THE BIBLE

in Plain Language

OLD TESTAMENT

THE BIBLE

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

VOLUME 1

Genesis to 1 Samuel

With an explanation for every section

EDITED BY ANDREAS RUPP

The Bible in Plain Language
Volume 1: Genesis to 1 Samuel

Edited by Andreas Rupp.

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The volumes of this edition:
Volume 1: Genesis to 1 Samuel
Volume 2: 2 Samuel to Psalms
Volume 3: Proverbs to Malachi
Volume 4: Matthew to Revelation

How to read this book

The Bible is the most important book in the world.

It is old. But its message is still true today.

This series tells the whole Bible in plain language, in 4 volumes.

No verse is left out. No name and no number.

Short sentences

Every line is one short thought.

So you can read in peace.

The numbers

[1] The small numbers are the verse numbers.
With them you can find every passage.
Just like in every other Bible.

The boxes

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
> After every section there is a box like this.
> It explains what you have read.
> And what it can mean for us today.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Some passages in the Bible are hard.
They have also been misused, for example against Jews, against women, or to justify violence.
At such passages you will find a note like this.

The Psalms

Some Bibles number the Psalms differently.

Then the other number is given in brackets.

Help

The Bible also tells of suffering and violence.

If something weighs on you: At the end of every volume you will find phone numbers where you can get help.

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GENESIS

50 CHAPTERS

GENESIS

CHAPTER 1

God creates the world

BEFORE WE BEGIN: WHAT IS THE BOOK OF GENESIS?

The Bible is really a collection of many books.

Genesis is the first book of the Bible.

It is also called "the First Book of Moses."

The name "Genesis" means "beginning" or "origin."

It tells how the world and people came to be.

And it tells how God starts a new path with one family: with Abraham and his descendants.

Jews and Christians have read this book for more than 2,500 years.

In the beginning VERSES 1–2

1 In the beginning, God created the heavens and the
earth.
2 The earth had no form yet.
It was empty.
Darkness was over the surface of the deep water.
And God's Spirit was hovering over the waters.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first sentence of the Bible says the most important thing: Everything that exists comes from God.

In the beginning, everything was empty, dark and without order.

But God was already there. His Spirit was very close, like a bird hovering over its nest.

This is still true today: God is there – even where a life feels empty and dark.

The first day: God makes light VERSES 3–5

3 God said, "Let there be light."
And there was light.
4 God looked at the light. He saw that it was good.
Then God separated the light from the darkness.
5 God called the light "day."
And he called the darkness "night."
There was evening, and there was morning.
That was the first day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God only has to speak – and it happens. His word has power.

The first thing God makes is light. Without light, you cannot see anything, and nothing can grow.

God looks at his work and is glad: It is good.

In the Bible, a day begins in the evening. That is why it always says "evening" first and then "morning." Jews still count days this way today.

The second day: God makes the sky VERSES 6–8

6 God said, "Let there be an expanse in the middle of the
waters.
Let it separate the waters from the waters."
7 God made the expanse.
An expanse is a wide, open space.
So he separated the waters under the expanse from the
waters above the expanse.
And so it happened.
8 God called the expanse "sky."
There was evening, and there was morning.
That was the second day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

People back then imagined the sky like a huge bell or dome. Above the dome, they thought, there is water. That is where the rain comes from.

The Bible speaks in the language of its time. It does not want to be a science textbook.

Its message is: God creates order. He makes room so that life can begin.

The third day: land, sea and plants VERSES 9–13

9 God said, "Let the waters under the sky gather in one
place.
Then let the dry land appear."
And so it happened.
10 God called the dry land "earth."
And he called the gathered waters "seas."
God saw that it was good.
11 God said, "Let the earth make green things grow:
grass and plants that make seeds,
and fruit trees that bear fruit.
Let the seeds be in the fruit.
Let every plant grow on the earth, each according to
its kind."
And so it happened.
12 The earth made green things grow:
grass and plants that make seeds, each according to its
kind,
and trees that bear fruit with seeds in it, each
according to its kind.
God saw that it was good.
13 There was evening, and there was morning.
That was the third day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now there is solid ground under our feet. And there is something to eat.

God thinks about the future: Every plant has seeds. So new life can always grow.

"Each according to its kind" means: An apple seed grows into an apple tree. God made the world with a good order.

The fourth day: sun, moon and stars VERSES 14–19

14 God said, "Let there be lights in the expanse of the sky.
Let them separate the day from the night.
Let them be signs.
Let them mark the seasons, the days and the years.

15 Let them be lights in the expanse of the sky and shine
on the earth."
And so it happened.
16 God made the two great lights:
the bigger light to rule over the day,
and the smaller light to rule over the night.
He also made the stars.
17 God put the lights in the expanse of the sky.
They were to shine on the earth.
18 They were to rule over the day and over the night.
And they were to separate the light from the darkness.
God saw that it was good.
19 There was evening, and there was morning.
That was the fourth day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "bigger light" is the sun. The "smaller light" is the moon.

The Bible does not call them by name on purpose. Back then, many peoples worshiped the sun and the moon as gods. The Bible says: These are not gods. God made them, like lamps on a ceiling.

The sun and the moon help us to divide time: into days, months, years and festivals.

The fifth day: animals in the water and birds VERSES 20–23

20 God said, "Let the waters be full of living creatures.
And let birds fly above the earth, across the open sky."
21 God created the large sea creatures
and every living creature that moves and swarms in
the water, each according to its kind.
And he created every bird with wings, each according
to its kind.
God saw that it was good.
22 God blessed the animals.
To bless means: God wishes something good and gives
the power for it.
He said, "Have many young, and become many!
Fill the waters in the seas.
And let the birds become many on the earth."
23 There was evening, and there was morning.
That was the fifth day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now there are the first living creatures. Things swim, fly and swarm.

For the first time, God blesses. He wants life to grow and spread out.

God loves variety. He wanted every kind – from the whale to the sparrow.

The sixth day: land animals and people VERSES 24–31

24 God said, "Let the earth bring out living creatures,
each according to its kind:
livestock, creeping animals and wild animals, each
according to its kind."
And so it happened.
25 God made the wild animals, each according to its kind,
the livestock, each according to its kind,
and every animal that creeps on the ground, each
according to its kind.
God saw that it was good.
26 Then God said, "Let us make man in our image, to be
like us.
Let them rule over the fish in the sea
and over the birds in the sky,
over the livestock and over the whole earth,
and over every animal that creeps on the earth."
27 So God created man in his own image.
Here, man means: the human being.
He created him in God's image.
He created them male and female.
28 God blessed them.
God said to them, "Have many children, and become
many!
Fill the earth and bring it under your control.
Rule over the fish in the sea, over the birds in the sky,
and over every living thing that moves on the earth."
29 God said, "Look! I have given you every plant on the
whole earth that makes seeds,
and every tree that bears fruit with seeds.
This will be your food.
30 And to every animal on the earth, to every bird in the
sky,
and to everything that creeps on the earth and has life
in it,
I have given all the green plants for food."
And so it happened.
31 God looked at everything he had made.
And look: It was very good.
There was evening, and there was morning.
That was the sixth day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The human being is an "image of God." That means: Every person reflects something of God. That is why every person has a dignity that no one may take away – no matter what they look like, where they come from, or what they can or cannot do.

Man and woman are **both** the image of God. They are worth the same.

"Rule" and "bring under control" do not mean here: use it up and exploit it. A king in the Bible is supposed to care for his land and protect it. In the same way, people are supposed to care for the earth and the animals.

God says, "Let **us**." Jews often understand it like this: God is talking with his angels, or he speaks the way a king does, saying "we." Many Christians see in it a hint of God as Father, Son and Holy Spirit.

Interesting: In the beginning, people and animals eat only plants. No one has to lose their life to be someone else's food. That is how peaceful God's world was meant to be.

Six times God saw that it was good. Now he sees that it is **very** good.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 2

The day of rest, the garden of Eden, man and woman

The seventh day: God rests VERSES 1–3

1 So the heavens and the earth were finished, with
everything in them.
2 On the seventh day, God had finished the work he had
done.
And on the seventh day he rested from all the work he
had done.
3 God blessed the seventh day.
And he made it holy.
Holy means: The day is very special. It belongs to God.
For on this day God rested from all his work of
creating, the work he had done.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is not tired. But he rests anyway. With this, he shows us: Rest is part of life.

The week has one day that is different from the others. For Jews, this became the Sabbath (Saturday), and for Christians, Sunday.

For today, this means: You are more than your work. You may take a break. That is God's gift.

God forms man from the earth VERSES 4–7

4 This is the history of the heavens and the earth, when
they were created.
It was on the day when the LORD God made the earth
and the heavens.
5 At that time, there were no plants of the field on the
earth yet.
And no green plant had sprung up in the field yet.
For the LORD God had not yet sent rain on the earth.
And there was no man to work the ground.
6 But a mist went up from the earth.
It watered the whole surface of the ground.
7 Then the LORD God formed man from the dust of the
ground.
He breathed the breath of life into his nose.
And the man became a living soul.
That means: a living being.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a second story of creation begins. It looks very closely at the human being.

Here God's name appears for the first time. In Hebrew, it has four letters: YHWH. It was probably pronounced "Yahweh." It means something like: "I am here." Out of deep respect, Jews do not say this name out loud. Instead, they say "the Lord." That is why many Bibles write: the LORD.

God forms the human being with his hands, like a potter shapes clay. Then he gives him his own breath.

This means: We are made from earth – a part of nature. But we live from God's breath.

The garden of Eden VERSES 8–14

8 The LORD God planted a garden in Eden, in the east.
He put the man he had formed there.
9 The LORD God made many trees grow out of the
ground.
They were beautiful to look at, and their fruit was
good to eat.
In the middle of the garden was the tree of life.
And there was also the tree of the knowledge of good
and evil.
10 A river flowed out of Eden.
It watered the garden.
From there it divided and became four rivers.
11 The name of the first river is Pishon.
It flows through the whole land of Havilah.
There is gold there.
12 The gold of that land is good.
There is also bdellium there, a sweet-smelling resin,
and the precious stone onyx.
13 The name of the second river is Gihon.
It flows through the whole land of Cush.
14 The name of the third river is Hiddekel.
It flows east of Assyria.
The fourth river is the Euphrates.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Eden" means "delight" or "joy." The garden is a place where people lack nothing.

Hiddekel is the old name of the Tigris. The Tigris and the Euphrates still exist today. They flow through Turkey, Syria and Iraq. No one knows exactly where the Pishon and the Gihon were. Cush is an old land south of Egypt.

The two trees in the middle of the garden are very important for the story. One stands for life. The other stands for the question: Who decides what is good and what is evil – God or people?

A task and a limit VERSES 15–17

15 The LORD God took the man and put him in the garden
of Eden.
The man was to work the garden and take care of it.
16 The LORD God gave the man a command.
He said, "You may eat from every tree in the garden, as
much as you want.
17 But you must not eat from the tree of the knowledge of
good and evil.
For on the day you eat from it, you will surely die."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The human being gets a task: to tend the garden and protect it. So work is something good from the very beginning.

God gives great freedom: **All** the trees are allowed. Only one is not.

This one limit says: Trust me. I know what is good for you. You do not have to decide everything yourself.

Being alone is not good VERSES 18–20

18 The LORD God said,
"It is not good for the man to be alone.
I will make him a helper who is right for him."
19 The LORD God formed every animal of the field and
every bird of the sky out of the ground.
He brought them to the man.
He wanted to see what the man would call them.
Whatever the man called each living creature, that
became its name.
20 The man gave names to all the livestock, to the birds of
the sky and to every animal of the field.
But for the man, no helper was found who was right
for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Until now, God always saw that it was good. Now he says for the first time: "It is **not** good" – being alone.

People need other people. God made us for community.

"Helper" does not mean "servant" or "assistant" here. In the Bible, even God himself is called a "helper." It means a partner who stands on the same level.

The man gives the animals names. This shows: He knows them and is responsible for them.

God makes the woman VERSES 21–25

21 Then the LORD God made the man fall into a deep sleep.
While the man was sleeping, God took one of his ribs.
And he closed up the flesh in its place.
22 From the rib he had taken from the man, the LORD God made a woman.
And he brought her to the man.
23 Then the man said,
"At last! This is bone of my bones
and flesh of my flesh.
She will be called 'woman,'
because she was taken out of Man."
24 That is why a man leaves his father and his mother.
He joins himself to his wife.
And the two become one flesh.
25 The man and his wife were both naked.
But they were not ashamed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Old Jewish and Christian teachers said: God did not make the woman from the man's head, so that she would stand above him. And not from his foot, so that she would stand below him. But from his side, so that she would stand at his side.

In Hebrew, man is "ish" and woman is "ishah." The words sound almost the same. They belong together.

"Becoming one flesh" means: Man and woman join together completely – with body, heart and life.

They are naked and not ashamed. That means: They have nothing to hide. They trust each other completely.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 3

People stop trusting God

The serpent and the woman VERSES 1–5

1 The serpent was more cunning than any animal of the field that the LORD God had made.
It said to the woman,
"Did God really say, 'You must not eat from any tree in the garden'?"
2 The woman answered the serpent,
"We may eat fruit from the trees in the garden.
3 But not the fruit of the tree in the middle of the garden.
God has said, 'You must not eat from it. You must not touch it. Or else you will die.'"
4 Then the serpent said to the woman,
"You will not really die.
5 For God knows: On the day you eat from it, your eyes will be opened.
Then you will be like God.
Then you will know what is good and what is evil."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The serpent begins with a question. And it twists what God said. God had allowed **all** the trees except one. The serpent acts as if God had forbidden everything.

This is how mistrust begins: "Does God really mean well with me? Or does he want to take something away from me?"

The woman also exaggerates a little: God had said nothing about touching.

Then the serpent lies openly: "You will not really die." And it tempts her: "You will be like God." This is the very first temptation: wanting to be God yourself and deciding for yourself what is good and evil.

In this chapter, it is only called "the serpent." Later, Jews and Christians connected it with the devil (for example in Revelation 12:9).

They eat VERSES 6–7

6 The woman looked at the tree.
She saw: The tree is good for food.
It is a delight to the eyes.
And it is attractive, because it makes a person wise.
So she took some of its fruit and ate.
She also gave some to her husband, who was with her.
And he ate it too.
7 Then the eyes of both of them were opened.
And they knew: We are naked.
They sewed fig leaves together
and made coverings for themselves.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The man was standing next to her the whole time. He said nothing and did nothing. Both of them are responsible.

Their eyes really are opened – but not the way the serpent promised. They do not become like God. They only see their own nakedness and weakness.

Before, they were not ashamed. Now they want to hide. Trust is broken.

God looks for the human beings VERSES 8–13

8 They heard the voice of the LORD God.
He was walking in the garden when the day was getting cool.
Then the man and his wife hid from the LORD God among the trees of the garden.
9 The LORD God called to the man.
He said to him, "Where are you?"
10 The man answered,
"I heard your voice in the garden.
I was afraid, because I was naked.
So I hid."

11 God said,
"Who told you that you were naked?
Have you eaten from the tree that I commanded you
not to eat from?"
12 The man said,
"The woman you gave to be with me –
she gave me fruit from the tree.
And I ate it."
13 The LORD God said to the woman,
"What have you done?"
The woman said,
"The serpent tricked me. And I ate."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people run away from God. But God goes after them. He looks for them.

"Where are you?" Of course God knows where they are. With this question, he gives them the chance to come out by themselves and be honest.

But both of them pass the blame on. The man says: "It was the woman – and really you, God, because you gave her to me." The woman says: "It was the serpent."

Everyone knows this: When we have done something wrong, we quickly look for someone else to blame.

What comes now VERSES 14–19

14 The LORD God said to the serpent,
"Because you have done this, you are cursed.
You are cursed more than all the livestock and more
than every animal of the field.
You will crawl on your belly.
You will eat dust all the days of your life.
15 I will put hostility between you and the woman,
and between your offspring and her offspring.
He will bruise your head.
And you will bruise his heel."
16 To the woman God said,
"I will make your pain in childbirth very great.
You will give birth to children in pain.
You will long for your husband.
And he will rule over you."
17 And to Adam God said,
"You listened to your wife's voice.
And you ate from the tree that I commanded you
about. I said: 'You must not eat from it.'
That is why the ground is cursed – because of you.
You will eat from it with hard work all the days of your
life.
18 It will grow thorns and thistles for you.
And you will eat the plants of the field.
19 You will eat bread by the sweat of your face
until you return to the ground.
For you were taken out of it.
Yes, you are dust,
and you will return to dust."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses explain why life is often so hard: pain in giving birth, hard work, conflict and power struggles between man and woman, and in the end, death.

Important: God curses the serpent and the ground. But he does not curse the people themselves.

That the man rules over the woman is **not** God's good plan. In Chapters 1 and 2, man and woman are of equal worth. Here the Bible describes how things, sadly, often are in a broken world.

Verse 15 is a first ray of hope: A descendant of the woman will bruise the serpent's head. Evil will be wounded, and in the end defeated. Christians see in this an early hint of Jesus.

"Adam" is the Hebrew word for "human being." It sounds like "adamah," which means "earth." So the human being is, so to speak, the "earthling."

God still takes care of them VERSES 20–24

20 The man called his wife Eve.
That name means "life."
For she would become the mother of all the living.
21 The LORD God made clothes from animal skins for
Adam and his wife.
And he dressed them.
22 The LORD God said,
"Look! The man has become like one of us.
He knows good and evil.
Now he must not also reach out his hand,
take from the tree of life, eat,
and live forever ..."
23 So the LORD God sent him out of the garden of Eden.
He was to work the ground he had been taken from.
24 So God drove the man out.
And at the east of the garden of Eden he placed the
cherubim.
Cherubim are mighty angel-like beings.
And he placed a flaming sword that turned in every
direction.
They were to guard the way to the tree of life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of this sad story, there are signs of hope:

The man calls his wife Eve, that is, "life." Death was just mentioned – but life goes on.

God himself makes clothes for the people. The leaves were not enough. God takes care of them, even though they did not trust him.

God's sentence in verse 22 stops in the middle. This shows how hard this moment is.

Having to leave the garden is a punishment. But it is also a protection: The people should not live forever in this broken state.

The whole rest of the Bible tells how God opens the way back. On the last page of the Bible (Revelation 22), the tree of life is there again – and the way to it is open.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 4

Cain and Abel

Two brothers VERSES 1–2

1 The man slept with his wife Eve.
She became pregnant and gave birth to Cain.
She said, "I have gotten a man with the LORD's help."
2 Then she gave birth again, to Cain's brother Abel.
Abel became a shepherd who kept sheep.
Cain became a farmer who worked the ground.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Outside the garden, life goes on. Children are born.

Eve knows: A child is a gift. God has helped.

"Abel" means "breath" or "a puff of wind." That is already a hint: His life will soon be over.

The brothers' offerings VERSES 3–7

3 After some time, Cain brought an offering to the LORD.
An offering is a gift for God.
Cain brought some of the fruit of the ground.
4 Abel also brought an offering.
He brought some of the firstborn animals of his flock and some of their fat.
The LORD looked kindly at Abel and his offering.
5 But he did not look kindly at Cain and his offering.
Then Cain became very angry.
His face fell, and he looked gloomy.
6 The LORD said to Cain,
"Why are you angry?
Why has your face fallen?
7 If you do what is good, will you not be able to lift up your face?
But if you do not do what is good, sin is crouching at the door.
It wants to have you.
But you are to rule over it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible does not say exactly why God accepts Abel's offering and not Cain's offering. There is a hint in the words: Abel brings "firstborn animals" and "their fat," that means, the best he has. For Cain, it does not say that he brought the first or the best. Maybe what matters is the heart with which a person gives.

"Sin" is what separates us from God and from other people.

God speaks with Cain like a father with his son. He warns him: Your anger is like a wild animal in front of your door. Be careful! But you can control it.

Cain has a choice. He is not helpless against sin.

The first murder VERSES 8–12

8 Cain said to his brother Abel, "Let's go out into the field."
While they were in the field, Cain attacked his brother Abel and killed him.
9 Then the LORD asked Cain,
"Where is your brother Abel?"
Cain answered,
"I don't know. Am I my brother's keeper?"
A keeper is someone who watches over another.
10 The LORD said,
"What have you done?
Listen: Your brother's blood is crying out to me from the ground!
11 So now you are cursed because of the ground.
The ground opened its mouth to take your brother's blood from your hand.
12 From now on, when you work the ground, it will not give you its strength.
You will be a fugitive and a wanderer on the earth."
A fugitive is someone who has to run away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Cain does not listen to God's warning. Anger turns into murder. It can happen that fast.

God asks again – just like with Adam: "Where …?" Again, God gives a chance to be honest.

Cain lies and becomes rude: "Am I my brother's keeper?" The whole Bible answers: **Yes.** We are responsible for one another.

No wrong stays hidden from God. The suffering of a victim "cries out" to him. God hears it.

"A fugitive and a wanderer" means: Cain will not feel at home anywhere anymore. He will wander around without rest.

God protects Cain VERSES 13–16

13 Cain said to the LORD,
"My punishment is too great. I cannot bear it.
14 Look: Today you are driving me away from the ground.
I will be hidden from your face.
I will be a fugitive and a wanderer on the earth.
And whoever finds me will kill me."
15 The LORD said to him,
"So whoever kills Cain will be punished seven times over."
And the LORD put a sign on Cain,
so that no one who found him would strike him down.
16 Then Cain went away from the presence of the LORD.
He lived in the land of Nod, east of Eden.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Cain carries great guilt. He has to bear the consequences.

But God does not drop him. He even protects the murderer from the revenge of others. So the "mark of Cain" is not a mark of shame. It is a sign of protection.

God does not want violence to keep causing new violence. Even a guilty person is still a person whom God cares about.

"Nod" means "flight" or "homelessness."

Cain's family VERSES 17–24

17 Cain slept with his wife.
She became pregnant and gave birth to Enoch.
Cain built a city.
He named the city after his son: Enoch.
18 Enoch had a son: Irad.
Irad became the father of Mehujael.
Mehujael became the father of Methushael.
And Methushael became the father of Lamech.
19 Lamech took two wives.
The first one was named Adah, and the second one was named Zillah.
20 Adah gave birth to Jabal.
He became the father of all who live in tents and keep

livestock.
21 His brother was named Jubal.
He became the father of all who play the harp and the pipe.
22 Zillah also had a son: Tubal Cain.
He was a smith who made all kinds of cutting tools out of bronze and iron.
Tubal Cain's sister was Naamah.
23 Lamech said to his wives,
"Adah and Zillah, hear my voice!
You wives of Lamech, listen to what I say:
I have killed a man because he wounded me.
I have killed a young man because he bruised me.
24 If Cain will be avenged 7 times,
then Lamech 77 times!"
To be avenged means: Someone pays back the harm that was done to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

People become inventive: They build cities, move around with herds, make music and forge tools. This is how culture begins.

But at the same time, violence grows. Lamech boasts: For a small wound, he killed a person.

God wanted to protect Cain with the number 7. Lamech turns it into a threat: 77!

Many centuries later, Jesus turns this saying around. He says: Do not take revenge again and again. Instead, **forgive** again and again – seventy times seven times (Matthew 18:22).

A new beginning VERSES 25–26

25 Adam slept with his wife again.
She gave birth to a son and named him Seth.
She said, "God has given me another child in place of Abel.
For Cain killed him."
26 Seth also had a son. He named him Enosh.
At that time, people began to call on the name of the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After all these terrible things, God gives a new beginning. In Hebrew, "Seth" sounds like "he has given."

"To call on the name of the LORD" means: to pray to God, to speak to him, to ask him for help.

The chapter shows two paths: With Lamech, violence grows. With Seth and Enosh, prayer grows.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 5

The family from Adam to Noah

God's image VERSES 1–2

1 This is the book of the family line of Adam.
When God created man, he made him like God.
2 He created them male and female.
He blessed them.
And on the day they were created, he gave them the name Adam.
Adam means: human being.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before the long family list begins, the Bible reminds us once more of Chapter 1: The human being is like God. Man and woman are blessed.

This is still true after the Garden of Eden, after Cain and Abel. Human dignity is not lost.

Adam, Seth and Enosh VERSES 3–11

3 Adam was 130 years old when he had a son.
The son was like him, in his own image.
He named him Seth.
4 After Seth was born, Adam lived another 800 years.
He had other sons and daughters.
5 Adam lived 930 years in all.
Then he died.
6 Seth was 105 years old when he had Enosh.
7 After Enosh was born, Seth lived another 807 years.
He had other sons and daughters.
8 Seth lived 912 years in all.
Then he died.
9 Enosh was 90 years old when he had Kenan.
10 After Kenan was born, Enosh lived another 815 years.
He had other sons and daughters.
11 Enosh lived 905 years in all.
Then he died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God made the human being as his image. In the same way, Adam has a son as his image. Life and dignity are passed on – from generation to generation.

Kenan, Mahalalel and Jared VERSES 12–20

12 Kenan was 70 years old when he had Mahalalel.
13 After Mahalalel was born, Kenan lived another 840 years.
He had other sons and daughters.
14 Kenan lived 910 years in all.
Then he died.
15 Mahalalel was 65 years old when he had Jared.
16 After Jared was born, Mahalalel lived another 830 years.
He had other sons and daughters.
17 Mahalalel lived 895 years in all.
Then he died.
18 Jared was 162 years old when he had Enoch.
19 After Enoch was born, Jared lived another 800 years.
He had other sons and daughters.
20 Jared lived 962 years in all.
Then he died.

Enoch walks with God VERSES 21–24

21 Enoch was 65 years old when he had Methuselah.

22 After Methuselah was born, Enoch walked with God
for 300 years.
He had more sons and daughters.
23 Enoch lived 365 years in all.
24 Enoch walked with God.
Then he could not be found anymore.
For God had taken him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For everyone else in this list, it says at the end: "Then he died." For Enoch, it does **not** say that.

Enoch lived as close to God as two friends who go for a walk together every day. And one day, God simply took him along.

In the middle of this list of the dead, this is a ray of light: Death does not have the last word.

365 years – as many years as a year has days. Some people see this as a sign of a "full" life.

Methuselah, Lamech and Noah VERSES 25–32

25 Methuselah was 187 years old when he had Lamech.
26 After Lamech was born, Methuselah lived another 782 years.
He had other sons and daughters.
27 Methuselah lived 969 years in all.
Then he died.
28 Lamech was 182 years old when he had a son.
29 He named him Noah.
He said, "This one will comfort us in our work
and in the hard labor of our hands,
because of the ground that the LORD has cursed."
30 After Noah was born, Lamech lived another 595 years.
He had other sons and daughters.
31 Lamech lived 777 years in all.
Then he died.
32 Noah was 500 years old.
Then Noah had three sons: Shem, Ham and Japheth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people in this list become unbelievably old. You can understand this in different ways. Some readers take the numbers literally. Others think: The numbers show that these people lived in a distant ancient time that was different from ours.

The sentence "Then he died" comes again and again. What God said in Chapter 3 has come true: Human beings must die.

Methuselah lives to be 969 years old – older than any other person in the Bible. In English, people say someone is "as old as Methuselah."

This Lamech is not the violent Lamech from Chapter 4. He is a different man. He sighs about the hard work and hopes for comfort.

In Hebrew, the name "Noah" sounds like "rest" and "comfort." Noah brings hope.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 6

Evil grows – God saves Noah

God's sons and the giants VERSES 1–4

1 People began to become many on the earth.
And daughters were born to them.
2 Then God's sons saw that the daughters of men were beautiful.
And they took any of them they wanted as their wives.
3 Then the LORD said,
"My Spirit will not struggle with man forever.
For he too is only flesh.
His days will be 120 years."
4 In those days, the Nephilim were on the earth.
They were giants.
They were also there later,
when God's sons came to the daughters of men and had children with them.
Those were the mighty men of long ago, the famous men.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This short passage is one of the most puzzling in the whole Bible. No one knows for sure who is meant by "God's sons."

There are three main explanations: Some say they are angels who crossed their limits. Others say they are powerful kings who acted like gods. Still others say they are the descendants of Seth.

But the message is clear: Limits that God has set are crossed. The strong take what they want.

"Flesh" here means: weak, easily hurt, and mortal.

God sets a limit: A human being is to live 120 years at the most. A human being is not God.

God is grieved in his heart VERSES 5–8

5 The LORD saw that the wickedness of people on the earth was great.
Everything their hearts thought and planned was only evil, all the time.
6 The LORD was sorry that he had made people on the earth.
And it hurt him in his heart.
7 The LORD said,
"I will wipe out the people I have created from the face of the ground.
The people, and also the animals, the creeping things and the birds of the sky.
For I am sorry that I have made them."
8 But Noah found favor in the eyes of the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the beginning, God looked at the world and saw that it was very good. Now he looks at the world, and it hurts him in his heart.

God is not cold and without feelings. Evil makes him sad – just as parents are sad when their child is on a bad path.

But then comes a big **but**: Noah. "To find favor" means: God looks kindly at him. In the middle of judgment, there is grace.

Noah, a righteous man VERSES 9–13

9 This is the story of Noah and his family.
Noah was a righteous man.
Among the people of his time, he was blameless.
Blameless means: No one could accuse him of anything wrong.
Noah walked with God.
10 Noah had three sons: Shem, Ham and Japheth.
11 But the earth was corrupt in God's eyes.
Corrupt means: rotten and ruined.
The earth was full of violence.
12 God looked at the earth.
And he saw: It was corrupt.
For all living beings on the earth had corrupted their way.
13 Then God said to Noah,
"I will bring an end to all living beings.
For because of them, the earth is full of violence.
Look: I will destroy them, together with the earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible, "righteous" means: to live in a way that pleases God, and to treat others fairly.

Noah "walked with God" – just like Enoch in Chapter 5. He lived differently from everyone around him. That takes courage.

In Hebrew, the same word appears here four times. It means "corrupt" and also "destroy." People have corrupted the good world. Now God will "destroy" it. That means: People reap what they have sown.

The word "violence" comes up twice. Since Cain and Lamech, violence has spread everywhere.

Build a ship! VERSES 14–16

14 "Make yourself a ship out of gopher wood.
Make rooms in the ship.
And cover it with pitch inside and outside.
15 This is how you are to make it:
about 450 feet long, about 75 feet wide and about 45 feet high.
16 Make a roof for the ship.
Finish it so that there is an opening about 18 inches high under the roof.
Put the door of the ship in its side.
And build it with three levels: a lower, a middle and an upper level."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: This ship is often called the ark. It is a huge ship shaped like a box.

In the Bible, the measurements are in cubits: 300 cubits long, 50 cubits wide, 30 cubits high, plus 1 cubit for the opening under the roof. A cubit is the length from the elbow to the tip of the middle finger, about 18 inches.

The ark is huge: as long as one and a half football fields. It is not a sailboat. It is a floating box.

Today no one knows exactly what "gopher wood" is. Maybe it was cypress wood.

Pitch is a black, sticky substance. It makes wood waterproof.

God's covenant with Noah VERSES 17–22

17 "For look: I will bring a flood, water over the earth.
I will destroy all life under the sky, everything that has the breath of life.
Everything that is on the earth will die.
18 "But I will make my covenant with you.
You are to go into the ship:
you, your sons, your wife and your sons' wives with you.
19 "And of every living thing, of all living beings,
you are to bring two of every kind into the ship,
to keep them alive with you.
They are to be a male and a female.
20 Of the birds, each according to its kind,
of the livestock, each according to its kind,
of every creeping thing on the ground, each according to its kind –
two of every kind will come to you, to keep them alive.
21 And you: Take some of every kind of food that people eat.
Gather it with you.
It will be food for you and for the animals."
22 And Noah did it.
He did everything exactly as God commanded him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: A covenant is a firm promise.

Here the word "covenant" appears for the first time in the Bible. God binds himself. He promises Noah: I will save you.

God does not want to end all life. He wants to start again with Noah, his family and the animals.

Noah does not ask questions. He trusts and does what God says. To the neighbors, it must have looked very strange: a huge ship in the middle of dry land.

Many ancient peoples knew stories about a great flood. The Bible tells it in its own way: God does not look away when the world is full of violence. But he saves those who trust him.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 7

The flood comes

Go into the ark VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD said to Noah,
"Go into the ship, you and your whole household.
For I have seen: Among the people of this time, you are righteous before me.
2 Take with you seven pairs of every clean animal, the male and his female.
And of the animals that are not clean, take two, the male and his female.
3 Also of the birds of the sky, take seven pairs, male and female.

That way, their young will stay alive on the whole earth.

4 For in 7 days, I will make it rain on the earth
for 40 days and 40 nights.
Then I will wipe out from the face of the ground every living thing that I have made."

5 And Noah did everything that the LORD commanded him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Clean" and "not clean": Later, the people of Israel were given rules about which animals they could eat and offer to God. These animals are called "clean," for example cattle, sheep, goats and doves. Other animals, for example pigs, are counted as "not clean."

Noah takes more of the clean animals with him. After the flood, he will offer some of them to God as a thank offering.

God gives seven more days. Even now, he is in no hurry to judge.

In the Bible, the number 40 often stands for a time of testing: Israel was in the wilderness for 40 years, and Jesus fasted for 40 days.

Noah goes into the ark VERSES 6–10

6 Noah was 600 years old when the flood came, the water over the earth.

7 Noah went into the ship to escape the waters of the flood.
His sons, his wife and his sons' wives went in with him.

8 Clean animals and animals that are not clean,
birds and everything that creeps on the ground

9 came to Noah into the ship in pairs, a male and a female,
just as God had commanded Noah.

10 After the seven days, the waters of the flood came over the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Noah does not have to catch the animals. They "come" to him. God takes care of it.

God said: in seven days. And that is exactly what happens. You can rely on God's word.

The sky opens VERSES 11–16

11 It was in the 600th year of Noah's life, in the second month, on the 17th day of the month.
On that day, all the springs of the great deep burst open.
And the windows of the sky opened.

12 The rain fell on the earth for 40 days and 40 nights.

13 On that very day, Noah went into the ship.
With him went Shem, Ham and Japheth, the sons of Noah,
and also Noah's wife and the three wives of his sons.

14 With them went every wild animal, each according to its kind,
all the livestock, each according to its kind,
every creeping thing that creeps on the earth, each according to its kind,
and every bird, each according to its kind – birds of every sort.

15 They came to Noah into the ship, in pairs from all living beings that have the breath of life.

16 Those that went in were male and female of all living beings,
just as God had commanded Noah.
Then the LORD shut him in.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible gives the exact date, like in a diary. That shows: This was a day that should never be forgotten.

The water comes from below (from the springs of the deep) and from above (from the windows of the sky). In Chapter 1, God separated the water above from the water below, to make room for life. Now everything comes crashing back together. It is as if creation were running backward.

A beautiful little sentence: "Then the LORD shut him in." God himself closes the door. Noah is safe in God's hand.

The water rises VERSES 17–24

17 The flood came over the earth for 40 days.
The waters rose and lifted up the ship.
So it was lifted high above the earth.

18 The waters became mighty and rose higher and higher on the earth.
And the ship floated on the surface of the waters.

19 The waters rose very high on the earth.
All the high mountains under the whole sky were covered.

20 The water rose about 22 feet higher than the mountains.
So the mountains were covered.

21 Then all living beings that moved on the earth died:
the birds, the livestock, the wild animals,
every creeping thing that creeps on the earth,
and every human being.

22 Everything on the dry land that had the breath of life in its nostrils died.

23 So every living thing on the face of the ground was wiped out:
people, livestock, creeping things and birds of the sky.
They were wiped out from the earth.
Only Noah was left, and those who were with him in the ship.

24 The waters flooded the earth for 150 days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says: 15 cubits above the mountains. That is about 22 feet.

This is a very serious, sad passage. The Bible does not make anything sound nicer than it is.

The message: Evil and violence have consequences. In the end, they destroy everything.

But in the middle of the destruction, the ark floats. It is a place of rescue. Later, Christians often saw the ark as a picture: With God, you are safe, even when everything around you is going under.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 8

The water goes down

God remembers Noah VERSES 1–5

1 Then God remembered Noah
and all the wild animals and all the livestock that were with him in the ship.
God made a wind blow over the earth.
Then the water went down.
2 The springs of the deep were closed, and the windows of the sky too.
And the rain from the sky stopped.
3 Little by little, the water went back from the earth.
After 150 days, the water had gone down.
4 In the seventh month, on the 17th day of the month, the ship came to rest
on the mountains of Ararat.
5 The water kept going down until the 10th month.
On the first day of the 10th month, the tops of the mountains could be seen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"God remembered Noah." This sentence is the turning point of the whole story. God has not forgotten Noah – and not the animals either.

A wind blows over the water. That is a reminder of Chapter 1, where God's Spirit was hovering over the waters. In Hebrew, "wind" and "spirit" are the same word. Now a new creation begins.

Ararat is a mountain range in the east of what is now Turkey, near Armenia.

The raven and the dove VERSES 6–12

6 After 40 days, Noah opened the window of the ship that he had made.
7 He sent out a raven.
The raven flew back and forth until the water on the earth had dried up.
8 Then Noah sent out a dove.
He wanted to see if the water on the ground had gone down.
9 But the dove found no place where her foot could rest.
For there was still water on the whole earth.
So she came back to him into the ship.
Noah reached out his hand, took her, and brought her back to himself into the ship.
10 Noah waited another seven days.
Then he sent the dove out of the ship again.
11 In the evening, the dove came back to him.
And look: In her beak was a freshly picked olive leaf.
Then Noah knew: The water on the earth has gone down.
12 Noah waited another seven days.
Then he sent the dove out again.
This time she did not come back to him anymore.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Noah has to be very patient. He waits and checks again and again whether the time has come.

It is described with love: Noah reaches out his hand and brings the tired dove inside.

To this day, the dove with the olive branch is a sign of **peace** and **hope** all over the world. It comes from this story.

The fresh green leaf shows: Things are growing again. Life is coming back.

Out of the ark VERSES 13–19

13 In the 601st year of Noah's life, in the first month, on the first day of the month, the water on the earth had dried up.
Noah took the covering off the ship and looked out.
He saw that the ground was dry.
14 In the second month, on the 27th day of the month, the earth was completely dry.
15 Then God spoke to Noah.
He said,
16 "Go out of the ship, you and your wife, your sons and your sons' wives with you.
17 Bring out with you every animal that is with you, of all living beings:
the birds, the livestock and every creeping thing that creeps on the earth.
Let them spread out on the earth.
They are to be fruitful and become many on the earth."
Fruitful means: having many young.
18 So Noah went out, with his sons, his wife and his sons' wives.
19 Every animal also went out of the ship,
every creeping thing and every bird, everything that moves on the earth,
family by family.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Noah was in the ark for more than a year. On New Year's Day, he sees dry land again. A new year, a new beginning for the world.

Noah does not simply go out when the ground is dry. He waits until God says: "Go out." He trusts God while waiting just as much as while acting.

God repeats the blessing from Chapter 1: The animals are to be fruitful and become many. It is like a second creation.

Noah's thanks and God's promise VERSES 20–22

20 Noah built an altar to the LORD.
An altar is a table of stones or earth on which people bring offerings to God.
He took some of every clean animal and of every clean bird.
And he offered them on the altar as burnt offerings.
That means: He burned them completely for God.
21 The LORD smelled the pleasant smell.
And the LORD said in his heart,
"I will never again curse the ground because of people.
For the human heart imagines evil from youth on.
And I will never again strike down every living thing, as I have done.
22 As long as the earth remains,
these will not stop:
seedtime and harvest,
cold and heat,

summer and winter,
day and night."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first thing Noah does: He says thank you. Before he builds a house, he builds an altar.

Amazing: People have not become better. God himself says: Their hearts imagine evil. And still he promises: I will never again destroy everything.

So God does not keep the world going because we are so good. He does it because **he** is so good. This is called grace.

Every sunrise, every winter and every summer, every harvest is a reminder of this promise.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 9

The rainbow

A new blessing VERSES 1–7

1 God blessed Noah and his sons.
He said to them,
"Be fruitful and become many! Fill the earth!
2 All the animals of the earth will fear you and be afraid of you,
and all the birds of the sky,
everything that moves along the ground,
and all the fish of the sea.
I put them into your hand.
3 "Every moving thing that lives will be food for you.
Just as I gave you the green plants, I now give you everything.
4 But you must not eat meat that still has its life in it –
that is, its blood.
5 "And for your own blood, for your life, I will surely demand an account.
I will demand it from every animal.
And I will demand it from every human being,
even from every person's brother.
I will demand an account for the life of a human being.
6 Whoever sheds human blood,
his blood will be shed by people.
For God made man in his own image.
7 "And you: Be fruitful and become many!
Spread out on the earth and become many on it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the flood, the world is different from the Garden of Eden. People and animals no longer live together in complete peace. The animals are afraid of people.

Now people may also eat meat. But with reverence: The life is in the blood. And life belongs to God. That is why, to this day, Jews only eat meat from which the blood has been removed.

"To demand an account" means: God asks about it. No one may simply take a human life.

The reason is in verse 6: Every person is an image of God. Whoever kills a person attacks God's image.

"His blood will be shed by people" – in ancient times, this was the basis for courts. Not everyone should take revenge for himself. The community should see to justice. This prevents endless blood feuds.

God's covenant and the sign VERSES 8–17

8 God spoke to Noah and to his sons who were with him.
He said,
9 "Look: I am making my covenant with you
and with your descendants after you,
10 and with every living creature that is with you:
with the birds, with the livestock and with every wild animal with you,
with all that came out of the ship,
with every animal of the earth.
11 I am making my covenant with you:
Never again will all living beings be wiped out by the waters of a flood.
Never again will there be a flood to destroy the earth."
12 And God said,
"This is the sign of the covenant
that I am making between me and you and every living creature with you,
for all generations, forever:
13 I set my rainbow in the clouds.
It will be the sign of the covenant between me and the earth.
14 When I bring clouds over the earth,
and the rainbow is seen in the clouds,
15 then I will remember my covenant
between me and you and every living creature of all living beings.
Never again will the water become a flood to destroy all life.
16 The rainbow will be in the clouds.
I will look at it.
Then I will remember the everlasting covenant
between God and every living creature on the earth."
17 God said to Noah,
"This is the sign of the covenant that I have made
between me and all living beings on the earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's covenant with Noah is a promise without conditions. People do not have to do anything to earn it.

It is for **all** people in the whole world – and even for the animals.

The Hebrew word for "bow" also means the bow for war, which shoots arrows. In a way, God hangs his weapon in the sky – with the open side pointing up, away from the earth. With this he says: I want peace with the world.

The rainbow is meant to remind not only us, but God himself. When you see a rainbow, you may think: God keeps his word.

The sons of Noah VERSES 18–19

18 The sons of Noah who went out of the ship were Shem,
Ham and Japheth.
Ham is the father of Canaan.
19 These three were the sons of Noah.
From them came all the people who spread out over
the whole earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

All the people in the world are one big family. We have the same ancestors.

Canaan is already mentioned here because he comes into the story right away. Later, the land where Israel lives is called "Canaan."

Noah and the wine VERSES 20–29

20 Noah became a farmer.
He planted a vineyard.
21 He drank some of the wine and got drunk.
Then he lay uncovered in his tent.
22 Ham, the father of Canaan, saw his father naked.
He went out and told his two brothers.
23 Then Shem and Japheth took a piece of clothing.
They both laid it on their shoulders.
Then they walked backward into the tent
and covered their father's naked body.
They kept their faces turned away.
So they did not see their father naked.
24 Noah woke up from his wine.
He found out what his youngest son had done to him.
25 Then he said,
"Canaan is cursed!
He will be the lowest servant of his brothers."
26 And he said,
"Praise be to the LORD, the God of Shem!
Let Canaan be his servant.
27 May God enlarge Japheth.
Let him live in the tents of Shem.
And let Canaan be his servant."
28 After the flood, Noah lived another 350 years.
29 Noah lived 950 years in all.
Then he died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even Noah, the righteous man, makes mistakes. The Bible tells the truth about its heroes – with all their weaknesses.

Ham sees his father in an embarrassing situation. Instead of protecting him, he tells others about it. Shem and Japheth act differently: They protect their father's dignity and cover him without looking. This is how we should deal with the weaknesses of others.

Verse 27: "Enlarge" means: give him much room.

In Hebrew, "Japheth" sounds like "to make room." That is why the blessing says: "May God enlarge Japheth."

Important: This curse was terribly misused in history. Some people used it to justify the slavery of people from Africa. That is **wrong**. The text does not curse Ham, and it certainly does not curse people with a certain skin color. It speaks about Canaan, the people who later lived in the land of Canaan. And the whole Bible says: Every person is an image of God.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 10

The nations of the earth

The sons of Noah VERSE 1

1 This is the story of the families of the sons of Noah:
Shem, Ham and Japheth.
After the flood, sons were born to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is a long list of names. It is called the "Table of Nations."

Many names are at the same time names of people, of peoples and of countries. In ancient times, people thought: Every people comes from one forefather and carries his name.

Names that end in "-ites" or "-im" are names of peoples – just as today we say "the Italians" or "the Texans."

The list is arranged in three parts: Japheth, Ham and Shem.

The descendants of Japheth VERSES 2–5

2 The sons of Japheth were:
Gomer, Magog, Madai, Javan, Tubal, Meshech and
Tiras.
3 The sons of Gomer were:
Ashkenaz, Riphath and Togarmah.
4 The sons of Javan were:
Elishah, Tarshish, Kittim and Dodanim.
5 From these, the peoples of the coasts and islands spread
out.
They live in their lands, each people with its own
language,
by their families and nations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The descendants of Japheth lived mostly in the north and west: Javan stands for the Greeks. Madai stands for the Medes in what is now Iran. The Kittim lived on the island of Cyprus. Tarshish was a port city far in the west, maybe in Spain.

Already here, it says as a matter of course: Every people has its own language. Variety is part of the world.

The descendants of Ham VERSES 6–20

6 The sons of Ham were:
Cush, Mizraim, Put and Canaan.
7 The sons of Cush were:
Seba, Havilah, Sabtah, Raamah and Sabteca.
The sons of Raamah were:
Sheba and Dedan.
8 Cush became the father of Nimrod.
Nimrod was the first to become a mighty ruler on the
earth.

9 He was a mighty hunter before the LORD.
That is why people say, "Like Nimrod, a mighty hunter before the LORD."
10 His kingdom began with Babel, Erech, Accad and Calneh in the land of Shinar.
11 From that land he went into Assyria.
There he built Nineveh, Rehoboth Ir, Calah,
12 and Resen between Nineveh and the great city Calah.
13 Mizraim became the father of the Ludim, Anamim, Lehabim, Naphtuhim,
14 Pathrusim, Casluhim – the Philistines came from them – and the Caphtorim.
15 Canaan became the father of Sidon, his firstborn, and of Heth,
16 and of the Jebusites, the Amorites and the Girgashites,
17 the Hivites, the Arkites and the Sinites,
18 the Arvadites, the Zemarites and the Hamathites.
Later, the families of the Canaanites spread out.
19 The land of the Canaanites reached from Sidon toward Gerar, as far as Gaza,
and toward Sodom, Gomorrah, Admah and Zeboiim, as far as Lasha.
20 These are the sons of Ham, by their families and languages,
in their lands and nations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The descendants of Ham lived mostly in the south: Cush is the land south of Egypt (what is now Sudan). Mizraim is the Hebrew name for Egypt. Put is probably Libya.

Nimrod is the first great ruler. He founds Babel and Nineveh. Later in the Bible, both cities become great enemies of Israel. Where people gather a lot of power, it becomes dangerous.

The peoples of Canaan lived in the land that God will later promise to Abraham. That is why they are listed here so carefully.

Sodom and Gomorrah will play a sad part later, in Chapter 19.

The descendants of Shem VERSES 21–31

21 Children were also born to Shem.
He was the older brother of Japheth and the forefather of all the descendants of Eber.
22 The sons of Shem were:
Elam, Asshur, Arpachshad, Lud and Aram.
23 The sons of Aram were:
Uz, Hul, Gether and Mash.
24 Arpachshad became the father of Shelah.
And Shelah became the father of Eber.
25 Two sons were born to Eber.
One was named Peleg, which means "division."
For in his days the earth was divided.
His brother was named Joktan.
26 Joktan became the father of Almodad, Sheleph, Hazarmaveth, Jerah,
27 Hadoram, Uzal, Diklah,
28 Obal, Abimael, Sheba,
29 Ophir, Havilah and Jobab.
All these were sons of Joktan.
30 The land where they lived reached from Mesha toward Sephar, the mountain in the east.
31 These are the sons of Shem, by their families and languages,
in their lands and nations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "Semites" come from Shem, for example the Hebrews (who later became the people of Israel), the Arameans and the Assyrians (Asshur).

The word "Hebrew" probably comes from the name "Eber." Here the Bible is already preparing to tell where Abraham comes from.

"In his days the earth was divided" – this points to the story in the next chapter: the tower of Babel.

All the nations VERSE 32

32 These are the families of the sons of Noah, by their family lines, in their nations.
From them, the nations spread out over the earth after the flood.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

If you count all the names, you get about 70 peoples. In the Bible, the number 70 stands for "all" – the whole world.

The message: All the peoples of the earth belong to **one** human family. God cares about all of them, not just one people.

This is important for what comes next: When God later chooses Abraham, he does it so that through him **all** peoples will be blessed (Chapter 12).

GENESIS

CHAPTER 11

The tower of Babel

A city and a tower VERSES 1–4

1 The whole earth had one language and the same words.
2 As people traveled east, they found a plain in the land of Shinar.
They settled there.
3 They said to one another,
"Come, let's make bricks and bake them hard in the fire!"
So they used bricks instead of stones,
and tar instead of mortar.
Mortar is what holds the stones of a wall together.
4 Then they said,
"Come, let's build ourselves a city and a tower.
Its top will reach to the sky.
Let's make a name for ourselves.
Then we will not be scattered over the face of the whole earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

People have a new invention: baked bricks. With them, you can build high. Inventions in themselves are not bad.

The problem is their goal: "Let's make a name for ourselves." They want to be famous and powerful. They want to reach the sky – all the way to God.

And they want to stay together instead of spreading out over the earth. But God had said: "Fill the earth."

In ancient Babylon, there really were huge temple towers made of bricks, with levels like a staircase to the sky. They are called ziggurats.

God confuses the language VERSES 5–9

5 Then the LORD came down.
He wanted to see the city and the tower that the people were building.
6 The LORD said,
"Look: They are one people, and they all have one language.
And this is only the beginning of what they will do.
Now nothing they plan to do will be impossible for them.
7 Come, let's go down
and confuse their language there,
so that they do not understand one another's speech."
8 So the LORD scattered them from there over the face of all the earth.
And they stopped building the city.
9 That is why the city is called Babel.
For there the LORD confused the language of all the earth.
And from there the LORD scattered them over the face of all the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

There is a quiet joke in this: People want to build a tower up to the sky. But God first has to "come down" just to see it. That is how small the tower is from God's point of view.

God is not afraid of people. But he sees: When all people join together to be like God themselves, it becomes dangerous – most of all for themselves.

In Hebrew, "Babel" sounds like "balal." That means "to confuse, to mix up."

The many languages are a punishment. But they are also a new beginning: Now people do spread out over the earth, as God wanted.

In the New Testament there is a counterpart: At Pentecost (Acts 2), people from many countries hear the good news about Jesus – each one in their own language. God brings people together again without taking away their variety.

From Shem to Terah VERSES 10–26

10 This is the family history of Shem.
Shem was 100 years old when he had Arpachshad. That was 2 years after the flood.
11 After Arpachshad was born, Shem lived another 500 years.
He had more sons and daughters.
12 Arpachshad was 35 years old when he had Shelah.
13 After Shelah was born, Arpachshad lived another 403 years.
He had more sons and daughters.
14 Shelah was 30 years old when he had Eber.
15 After Eber was born, Shelah lived another 403 years.
He had more sons and daughters.
16 Eber was 34 years old when he had Peleg.
17 After Peleg was born, Eber lived another 430 years.
He had more sons and daughters.
18 Peleg was 30 years old when he had Reu.
19 After Reu was born, Peleg lived another 209 years.
He had more sons and daughters.
20 Reu was 32 years old when he had Serug.
21 After Serug was born, Reu lived another 207 years.
He had more sons and daughters.
22 Serug was 30 years old when he had Nahor.
23 After Nahor was born, Serug lived another 200 years.
He had more sons and daughters.
24 Nahor was 29 years old when he had Terah.
25 After Terah was born, Nahor lived another 119 years.
He had more sons and daughters.
26 Terah was 70 years old.
Then he had Abram, Nahor and Haran.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This list leads in 10 generations from Shem to Abram – just as the list in Chapter 5 led in 10 generations from Adam to Noah.

People no longer live as long as before. Shem still lives to be 600 years old, Nahor only 148. The ancient time is coming to an end.

After the confusion of Babel, the Bible turns its eyes to **one** family. With this family, God wants to begin a new path for all of humanity.

The family of Terah VERSES 27–32

27 This is the family history of Terah.
Terah became the father of Abram, Nahor and Haran.
And Haran became the father of Lot.
28 Haran died while his father Terah was still alive,
in the land where he was born: in Ur of the Chaldees.
29 Abram and Nahor took wives.
Abram's wife was named Sarai.
Nahor's wife was named Milcah.
She was the daughter of Haran.
Haran was the father of Milcah and of Iscah.
30 Sarai was barren.
Barren means: She could not have children.
She had no child.
31 Terah took his son Abram,
his grandson Lot, the son of Haran,
and his daughter-in-law Sarai, the wife of his son Abram.
Together they left Ur of the Chaldees.
They wanted to go to the land of Canaan.
They came as far as Haran and settled there.
32 Terah lived 205 years.
Then Terah died in Haran.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now we meet the main characters of the next chapters: Abram (later he is called Abraham), his wife Sarai (later Sarah), and Lot, Abram's nephew.

Ur was a large, rich city in the south of what is now Iraq. Haran is a city in the south of what is now Turkey. It has

almost the same name as Abram's brother Haran who died, but in Hebrew it is a different name.

The most important sentence is very short: "She had no child." In those days, that was a great sorrow. Without children, a family had no future.

But right here, where humanly speaking there is no future, God begins something completely new. The next chapter tells about it.

GENESIS

Chapter 12

God calls Abram

God's call and God's promise VERSES 1–3

1 The LORD said to Abram,
"Leave your country,
leave your relatives
and leave your father's house.
Go to the land that I will show you.
2 I will make you into a great nation.
I will bless you
and make your name great.
And you will be a blessing.
3 I will bless those who bless you.
And whoever treats you with contempt, I will curse.
Through you, all the families of the earth will be blessed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important passages in the whole Bible. Here God's new path with humanity begins.

Abram is to leave behind everything that gives him security: his homeland, his relatives, his father's house. And he does not even know where the journey is going. God only says: "I will show you."

Remember Babel: There people said, "Let's make a name for ourselves." Here God says: **I** will make your name great. What people wanted to grab for themselves, God gives as a gift.

Five times the word "bless," "blessing" or "blessed" appears here. After the many curses in Chapters 3 to 11, the story of blessing now begins.

And the blessing is not only for Abram. Through him, it is to come to **all** the families of the earth. To this day, Jews, Christians and Muslims see Abraham as their father in faith.

Abram sets out VERSES 4–9

4 So Abram went, just as the LORD had told him.
And Lot went with him.
Abram was 75 years old when he left Haran.
5 Abram took his wife Sarai,
and Lot, his brother's son,
and everything they owned,
and the people who had come to belong to them in Haran.
They set out to go to the land of Canaan.
And they came into the land of Canaan.
6 Abram traveled through the land as far as the place of Shechem, to the oak of Moreh.
At that time, the Canaanites lived in the land.
7 Then the LORD appeared to Abram.
He said, "I will give this land to your descendants."
Abram built an altar there to the LORD, who had appeared to him.
8 From there he moved on to the hill country east of Bethel.
He set up his tent so that Bethel was to the west and Ai was to the east.
There he built an altar to the LORD
and called on the name of the LORD.
9 Then Abram traveled on, farther and farther toward the South.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abram asks no questions. He simply goes. The Bible calls this faith: trusting God so much that you take the first step, even if you do not know the way yet.

Abram is 75 years old! For God, no one is too old for a new beginning.

The land still belongs to others, the Canaanites. Abram owns nothing there. He only has God's promise.

"The LORD appeared to Abram" means: God showed himself to him in a special way, so that Abram knew: God is here.

Wherever Abram goes, he builds an altar and prays. In this way he shows: I trust the God who has promised me this land.

Abram in Egypt VERSES 10–20

10 A famine came over the land.
A famine is a time when there is not enough food.
So Abram went down to Egypt.
He wanted to live there as a foreigner.
For the famine in the land was severe.
11 When he came near Egypt, he said to his wife Sarai,
"Listen: I know that you are a beautiful woman.
12 When the Egyptians see you, they will say, 'This is his wife.'
Then they will kill me.
But they will let you live.
13 Please say that you are my sister.
Then things will go well for me because of you.
And I will stay alive because of you."
14 When Abram came into Egypt, the Egyptians saw that the woman was very beautiful.
15 Pharaoh's officials also saw her.
Pharaoh is the king of Egypt.
They praised her to Pharaoh.
And the woman was taken into Pharaoh's house.
16 Pharaoh treated Abram well because of her.
Abram got sheep and cattle, male donkeys,
male and female servants, female donkeys and camels.

17 But the LORD struck Pharaoh and his household with terrible plagues
because of Sarai, Abram's wife.
Plagues are great troubles and illnesses.
18 Then Pharaoh called Abram.
He said, "What have you done to me?
Why did you not tell me that she was your wife?
19 Why did you say, 'She is my sister'?
So I took her to be my wife.
Now here is your wife. Take her and go!"
20 Pharaoh gave his men orders about Abram.
They sent him away, with his wife and everything he had.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Just a moment ago, Abram trusted God completely. Now he becomes afraid and turns to a lie. To protect himself, he puts his wife in great danger. The Bible shows honestly: Even great examples of faith make serious mistakes.

Sarai really was Abram's half-sister (we learn this in Chapter 20). But he kept quiet about the most important thing: that she was his wife. A half-truth can also be a lie.

God steps in and protects Sarai. He keeps his promise, even when Abram fails.

It is shameful: Of all people, the foreign king behaves more decently here than Abram and confronts him.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 13

Abram and Lot go separate ways

Back to the beginning VERSES 1–4

1 Abram went up out of Egypt into the South,
he and his wife and everything he had.
And Lot was with him.
2 Abram was very rich in livestock, in silver and in gold.
3 He traveled from camp to camp, from the South as far as Bethel,
to the place where his tent had been at the beginning,
between Bethel and Ai.
4 That was the place where he had built the altar before.
There Abram called on the name of the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After his mistake in Egypt, Abram goes back to the place where he first prayed. That is like a new beginning with God.

Whoever has gone astray may always come back again.

A quarrel between the herdsmen VERSES 5–9

5 Lot, who traveled with Abram, also had flocks and herds and tents.
6 The land was not big enough for both of them to live together.
For they owned so much that they could not stay together anymore.
7 There was a quarrel between the herdsmen of Abram's livestock and the herdsmen of Lot's livestock.
At that time, the Canaanites and the Perizzites also lived in the land.
8 So Abram said to Lot,
"Please, let there be no quarrel between you and me,
and between your herdsmen and my herdsmen.
For we are relatives!
9 Is not the whole land in front of you?
Please separate from me.
If you go to the left, I will go to the right.
And if you go to the right, I will go to the left."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Owning a lot can become a problem. Here it leads to a quarrel in the family.

Other peoples also live in the land, and that makes it even more crowded.

"We are relatives" means here: We are one family. Lot is actually Abram's nephew.

Abram is the older one. He would have the right to choose first. But he lets Lot go first. Peace matters more to him than the best place.

Abram can be generous because he trusts God: God will take care of me, no matter which land I get.

Lot chooses with his eyes VERSES 10–13

10 Lot looked up and saw the whole plain of the Jordan.
It had plenty of water everywhere,
like the garden of the LORD, like the land of Egypt, as far as Zoar.
That was before the LORD destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah.
11 So Lot chose the whole plain of the Jordan for himself.
Lot traveled east.
So they separated from each other.
12 Abram lived in the land of Canaan.
Lot lived in the cities of the plain.
He moved his tents as far as Sodom.
13 But the men of Sodom were very wicked.
They sinned greatly against the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Lot chooses by what he sees: the greenest, best land. It looks like paradise. He only thinks about his own advantage.

But step by step, he comes closer and closer to Sodom, a city full of wickedness.

What looks beautiful is not always good. The Bible is already hinting: This will not end well (see Chapter 19).

God renews his promise VERSES 14–18

14 After Lot had separated from Abram, the LORD said to Abram,
"Look up, and look from the place where you are standing,
to the north and to the south, to the east and to the west.

15 For all the land that you see
I will give to you and to your descendants forever.
16 I will make your descendants as many as the dust of the earth.
If anyone can count the dust of the earth,
then your descendants can be counted too.
17 Get up and walk through the land, through its length and through its width.
For I will give it to you."
18 So Abram moved his tents.
He came to the oaks of Mamre, which are in Hebron, and lived there.
And he built an altar there to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Lot looked up and chose for himself. Now God tells Abram to look up too – in **all** directions. And God will give **him** all of this land.

Whoever is generous does not lose out with God.

Abram does not even have a single child yet. And God promises him descendants as many as the specks of dust. That sounds impossible. But God means it.

Hebron is still an important city today. According to tradition, the tomb of Abraham and Sarah is there.

GENESIS

Chapter 14

Abram rescues Lot – Melchizedek blesses Abram

Four kings against five VERSES 1–12

1 It was in the days of Amraphel, king of Shinar,
Arioch, king of Ellasar,
Chedorlaomer, king of Elam,
and Tidal, king of Goiim.
2 These kings made war against
Bera, king of Sodom,
Birsha, king of Gomorrah,
Shinab, king of Admah,
Shemeber, king of Zeboiim,
and against the king of Bela – that is Zoar.
3 These five joined together in the valley of Siddim.
That is the Salt Sea.
4 For 12 years they had served Chedorlaomer.
In the 13th year they rebelled against him.
5 In the 14th year, Chedorlaomer and the kings who were with him came.
They defeated
the Rephaim in Ashteroth Karnaim,
the Zuzim in Ham,
the Emim in Shaveh Kiriathaim,
6 and the Horites in their hill country of Seir, as far as El Paran, which is at the edge of the wilderness.
7 Then they turned back and came to En Mishpat – that is Kadesh.
They attacked the whole country of the Amalekites.
And they also defeated the Amorites who lived in Hazazon Tamar.
8 Then the king of Sodom, the king of Gomorrah, the king of Admah, the king of Zeboiim and the king of Bela – that is Zoar – went out to fight.
They lined up for battle in the valley of Siddim
9 against Chedorlaomer, king of Elam,
Tidal, king of Goiim,
Amraphel, king of Shinar,
and Arioch, king of Ellasar.
Four kings against the five.
10 The valley of Siddim was full of tar pits.
The kings of Sodom and Gomorrah ran away, and some fell there.
The others ran away to the hills.
11 The winners took all the goods of Sodom and Gomorrah and all their food.
Then they went away.
12 They also took Lot, the son of Abram's brother, and his goods.
For Lot lived in Sodom.
Then they left.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the first war story in the Bible. Powerful kings from the east – from the region of what is now Iraq and Iran – ruled over small city kings near the Jordan. These had to pay them taxes. When they fight back, war breaks out.

The peoples in verses 5 and 6 are very ancient peoples about whom we know little today. Some of them were thought to be especially tall.

The Salt Sea is the Dead Sea. It is so salty that no fish can live in it. To this day, there is tar (asphalt) in the ground in that area.

Lot wanted the most beautiful land. Now he ends up in the middle of a war and is carried off as a prisoner.

Abram steps in VERSES 13–16

13 Someone who had escaped came and told Abram the Hebrew.
At that time, Abram lived by the oaks of Mamre the Amorite.
Mamre was the brother of Eshcol and of Aner.
They were Abram's allies.
Allies are people who have promised to help each other.
14 When Abram heard that his relative had been taken prisoner,
he called out his trained men, who had been born in his household.
There were 318 men.
He chased the enemies as far as Dan.
15 At night he divided his men against them, he and his servants, and attacked them.
He defeated them and chased them as far as Hobah, which is on the left of Damascus.
16 He brought back all the goods.
He also brought back his relative Lot and his goods, and the women and the other people too.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Abram is called "the Hebrew" for the first time. That is the old name for the people that later becomes Israel.

Lot had separated from Abram and taken the better land for himself. Still, Abram does not leave him on his own. He risks his life for him.

"On the left of Damascus": When people back then gave directions, they faced east. Then left is north. So Hobah is north of Damascus.

With only 318 men, Abram defeats the armies of four kings. This shows: God is with him.

Melchizedek VERSES 17–20

17 Abram came back after he had defeated Chedorlaomer
and the kings who were with him.
Then the king of Sodom came out to meet him
in the valley of Shaveh. That is the King's Valley.
18 And Melchizedek, king of Salem, brought out bread
and wine.
He was a priest of God Most High.
19 He blessed Abram and said,
"Blessed be Abram by God Most High,
owner of heaven and earth.
20 And blessed be God Most High,
who has put your enemies into your hand."
And Abram gave him a tenth of everything.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Melchizedek is a mysterious figure. He suddenly appears and disappears again. His name means "king of righteousness." "Salem" means "peace." Salem is probably the city that is later called Jerusalem.

A priest is a person who stands between God and people: He prays for others and brings offerings to God. Melchizedek does not belong to Abram's family – and still he knows the one true God.

"A tenth" is one part out of 10. Abram gives a tenth of what he won in battle as thanks to God. Later, this became the custom of giving part of what you own to God.

Bread and wine: Christians think of the Lord's Supper. In the New Testament (Hebrews 7), Jesus is compared with Melchizedek.

Abram wants nothing from Sodom VERSES 21–24

21 The king of Sodom said to Abram,
"Give me the people.
Keep the goods for yourself."
22 But Abram said to the king of Sodom,
"I have lifted up my hand to the LORD, God Most High,
owner of heaven and earth,
and I have sworn:
23 I will not take a thread or a sandal strap,
or anything that is yours.
Then you cannot say, 'I have made Abram rich.'
24 I will take nothing from you,
except what the young men have eaten
and the share of the men who went with me: Aner,
Eshcol and Mamre.
Let them take their share."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Two kings come to Abram. Melchizedek brings a blessing. The king of Sodom offers riches.

Abram accepts the blessing from God. But he takes nothing from the king of the wicked city of Sodom – not even a thread.

"To lift up your hand to the LORD" means: to make a solemn promise, an oath.

Abram does not want anyone to be able to say: Abram became rich through Sodom. He knows: What I have comes from God.

But he is fair to his allies. They are to get what belongs to them.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 15

God makes a covenant with Abram

Look at the stars VERSES 1–6

1 After these things, the word of the LORD came to
Abram in a vision.
A vision is a picture that God shows a person, like a
dream while awake.
God said,
"Do not be afraid, Abram.
I am your shield.
I am your very great reward."
2 Abram said,
"Lord GOD, what will you give me?
I have no children.
The one who will inherit everything I own is Eliezer of
Damascus."
3 And Abram said,
"Look, you have given me no children.
So a servant born in my household will be my heir."
An heir is someone who gets everything when the
owner dies.
4 Then the word of the LORD came to him:
"This man will not be your heir.
Instead, a son from your own body will be your heir."
5 The LORD brought Abram outside and said,
"Look up at the sky and count the stars, if you can
count them."
And he said to him,
"That is how many your descendants will be."
6 Abram believed the LORD.
And the LORD counted it to him as righteousness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abram is afraid. He is old, and God's promise has not come true yet. He still has no child. Back then, in such a case, a faithful servant inherited everything.

Abram tells God honestly what is troubling him. That is allowed. God is not offended when we doubt and ask questions.

God answers with a picture: Look at the night sky. As many stars as there are – that is how many descendants you will have.

Verse 6 is one of the most famous sentences in the Bible: Abram trusts God. And God says: That is enough. That makes you righteous before me. Not what we achieve, but trust brings us into the right relationship with God. The apostle Paul quotes this sentence in the New Testament (Romans 4).

A strange sign VERSES 7–11

7 God said to Abram,
"I am the LORD.
I brought you out of Ur of the Chaldees
to give you this land to own."
8 Abram asked,
"Lord GOD, how will I know that I will own it?"
9 The LORD said to him,
"Bring me a young cow three years old,
a female goat three years old,
a ram three years old,
a turtledove and a young pigeon."
A ram is a male sheep.
10 Abram brought him all these animals.
He cut them in half down the middle.
And he laid the halves opposite each other.
But he did not cut the birds in half.
11 Then birds of prey swooped down on the dead animals.
But Abram drove them away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abram asks for a sign. That is allowed too. God answers with a solemn ceremony.

Cutting the animals in half sounds strange to us today. But that is how people made an agreement back then: They laid the halves in two rows. The partners walked between the halves. That meant: If I break my promise, may it happen to me as it happened to these animals.

In Hebrew, "to make a covenant" literally means: "to cut a covenant."

God tells about the future VERSES 12–16

12 When the sun was going down, Abram fell into a deep sleep.
Then terror and great darkness came over him.
13 Then God said to Abram,
"You must know for sure:
Your descendants will live as foreigners in a land that does not belong to them.
There they will be made slaves and treated cruelly for 400 years.
14 But I will also judge the nation they will have to serve.
Afterward, they will leave with great wealth.
15 But you will go to your ancestors in peace.
You will be buried at a good old age.
16 In the fourth generation, your descendants will come back here.
For the guilt of the Amorites is not yet full."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God tells what will happen much later: Abram's descendants will be slaves in Egypt. After that, God will lead them to freedom. The book of Exodus tells about this.

"To go to your ancestors" is a beautiful old way of saying: to die.

"The guilt of the Amorites is not yet full": The peoples in Canaan still get a lot of time. God does not simply take the land away from them. He waits patiently. Only when their wickedness is too great does he step in.

"Amorites" stands here for all the peoples who lived in Canaan at that time.

God alone passes between the animals VERSES 17–21

17 The sun had gone down, and it was dark.
And look: A smoking fire pot and a burning torch passed between the halves of the animals.
18 On that day, the LORD made a covenant with Abram.
He said,
"I have given this land to your descendants,
from the river of Egypt to the great river, the Euphrates River:
19 the land of the Kenites, the Kenizzites, the Kadmonites,
20 the Hittites, the Perizzites, the Rephaim,
21 the Amorites, the Canaanites, the Girgashites and the Jebusites."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The smoking fire pot and the torch are signs of God himself. In the Bible, God often shows himself in fire and smoke, for example later at Mount Sinai.

What is special: Only God passes between the halves of the animals. Abram is asleep. God alone binds himself. In this way he says: I stand behind this promise with my own life. Abram does not have to add anything.

The "river of Egypt" is probably a stream at the border between Canaan and Egypt. The Euphrates flows through what is now Syria and Iraq. That is a huge area.

The list of 10 peoples shows: The land is already inhabited. God's promise will only come true in the distant future.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 16

Hagar and Ishmael

Sarai's plan VERSES 1–6

1 Sarai, Abram's wife, had not given him any children.
She had a servant woman from Egypt.
Her name was Hagar.
2 Sarai said to Abram,
"Listen: The LORD has kept me from having children.
Please sleep with my servant.
Maybe I can have children through her."
And Abram listened to Sarai.

3 So Sarai, Abram's wife, took her Egyptian servant Hagar
and gave her to her husband Abram to be his wife.
That was after Abram had lived in the land of Canaan for 10 years.
4 Abram slept with Hagar, and she became pregnant.
When Hagar saw that she was pregnant, she looked down on her mistress.
Her mistress was the woman she served.
5 Then Sarai said to Abram,
"The wrong that is being done to me is your fault!
I put my servant into your arms.
And now that she sees that she is pregnant, she looks down on me.
May the LORD judge between me and you!"
6 But Abram said to Sarai,
"Look, your servant is in your hands.
Do with her whatever you think is right."
Then Sarai treated her harshly.
And Hagar ran away from her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abram and Sarai have been waiting for 10 years. God's promise is not coming true. So Sarai takes matters into her own hands.

Back then, it was common: If a woman could not have children, she could give her servant to her husband. The servant's child then counted as her own child. For us today, that is hard to understand. Hagar is not asked. She is a slave.

Their own plan only brings conflict: Hagar becomes proud, Sarai becomes jealous and harsh, and Abram avoids his responsibility.

The Bible tells this honestly. It shows: When we try to force God's promises with our own means, suffering often follows.

The God who sees me VERSES 7–14

7 The angel of the LORD found Hagar by a spring of water in the wilderness,
by the spring on the road to Shur.
8 He said,
"Hagar, Sarai's servant, where have you come from?
And where are you going?"
She answered,
"I am running away from my mistress Sarai."
9 The angel of the LORD said to her,
"Go back to your mistress and put yourself under her authority."
10 And the angel of the LORD said to her,
"I will make your descendants very many.
There will be so many that no one will be able to count them."
11 And the angel of the LORD said to her,
"Look, you are pregnant.
You will have a son.
You are to name him Ishmael.
For the LORD has heard your misery.
12 He will be like a wild donkey among people.
His hand will be against everyone, and everyone's hand against him.
He will live in conflict with all his brothers."
13 Then Hagar gave a name to the LORD who had spoken to her:
"You are a God who sees."
For she said,
"Have I really stayed alive after seeing him?"
14 That is why the well is called Beer Lahai Roi.
That means: "well of the Living One who sees me."
It is between Kadesh and Bered.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hagar is a slave, a foreigner, pregnant and alone in the wilderness. No one cares about her. But God looks for her and finds her.

The "angel of the LORD" is a messenger of God. Often God himself speaks through him. That is why Hagar says afterward: I have seen God.

The angel calls her by her name. He asks about her story: Where have you come from? Where are you going?

"Ishmael" means "God hears." The child's name is a reminder forever: God has heard Hagar's misery.

Back then, a "wild donkey" was not an insult. It means: free, strong, independent, not to be tamed – like someone who lives in the desert.

Hagar is the first person in the Bible to give God a name: "You are a God who sees." That is a great comfort for everyone who feels overlooked.

Ishmael is born VERSES 15–16

15 Hagar had a son by Abram.
Abram named his son, whom Hagar gave birth to, Ishmael.
16 Abram was 86 years old when Hagar gave birth to Ishmael for Abram.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abram gives the child exactly the name the angel said. So Hagar told him about the meeting, and Abram believes her.

Many Arabs and Muslims see Ishmael as their forefather.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 17

New names and the sign of the covenant

God Almighty VERSES 1–2

1 Abram was 99 years old.
Then the LORD appeared to Abram and said to him,
"I am God Almighty.
Walk before me and be blameless.
2 I will make my covenant between me and you.
And I will make you very, very many."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

13 years have passed since Ishmael was born. During this time, God was silent. Now he speaks again.

In Hebrew, "God Almighty" is "El Shaddai." With this, God says: Nothing is impossible for me – not even a child for a 99-year-old man.
"Walk before me" means: live as if God is always watching – not out of fear, but out of trust.

Abram becomes Abraham VERSES 3–8

3 Then Abram bowed down with his face to the ground.
And God talked with him.
He said,
4 "Look, this is my covenant with you:
You will be the father of many nations.
5 So your name will no longer be Abram.
Your name will be Abraham.
For I have made you the father of many nations.
6 I will make you very, very fruitful.
I will make nations from you.
And kings will come from you.
7 "I will make my covenant between me and you and your descendants after you,
from generation to generation, as an everlasting covenant.
I will be your God and the God of your descendants after you.
8 I will give to you and to your descendants after you the land where you now live as a foreigner:
the whole land of Canaan, to own forever.
And I will be their God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

To bow down with your face to the ground is a sign of deep reverence.
"Abram" means "great father." "Abraham" sounds like "father of many." God gives him a new name that fits his promise – even before it has come true.
In the Bible, a new name often means: a new stage of life, a new task.
The most important sentence is: "I will be your God." That is the heart of the covenant. God binds himself to people – forever.

The sign of circumcision VERSES 9–14

9 And God said to Abraham,
"As for you, you are to keep my covenant,
you and your descendants after you, from generation to generation.
10 This is my covenant between me and you and your descendants after you, which you are to keep:
Every male among you is to be circumcised.
11 You are to be circumcised in the foreskin of your penis.
That will be the sign of the covenant between me and you.
12 "Every boy among you is to be circumcised when he is eight days old, from generation to generation.
This is true for the boys who are born in your household,
and for those you have bought with money from foreigners and who are not your descendants.
13 Whoever is born in your household and whoever is bought with your money
must be circumcised.
So my covenant will be in your body, as an everlasting covenant.
14 A male who is not circumcised,
who has not been circumcised in the foreskin of his penis,
is to be cut off from his people.
For he has broken my covenant."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Circumcision is a small operation: The foreskin of the male organ is removed. It is carried as a sign on one's own body – for a lifetime.
Just as the rainbow is the sign of the covenant with Noah, circumcision is the sign of the covenant with Abraham and his descendants.
To this day, Jews celebrate circumcision on the eighth day of a boy's life. The celebration is called "Brit Milah" – "covenant of circumcision." Muslims also circumcise boys.
Servants and slaves who do not belong to the family are also part of the covenant. God's covenant is not only for blood relatives.
In the New Testament, there is a lot of discussion about whether Christians who are not Jews must be circumcised. The apostles decided: No (Acts 15). Paul speaks of a circumcision of the heart (Romans 2:29).

Sarai becomes Sarah VERSES 15–22

15 God said to Abraham,
"As for your wife Sarai, you are no longer to call her Sarai.
Her name will be Sarah.
16 I will bless her.
And I will also give you a son by her.
Yes, I will bless her.
She will be the mother of nations.
Kings of peoples will come from her."
17 Then Abraham bowed down with his face to the ground, and he laughed.
He said in his heart,
"Will a child be born to a man who is 100 years old?
And will Sarah, who is 90 years old, give birth?"
18 And Abraham said to God,
"Oh, if only Ishmael could live before you!"
19 God said,
"No, but your wife Sarah will give birth to a son for you.
You are to name him Isaac.
I will make my covenant with him, as an everlasting covenant for his descendants after him.
20 And about Ishmael, I have heard you.
Look: I have blessed him.
I will make him fruitful and very, very many.
He will become the father of 12 princes.
And I will make him into a great nation.
21 But I will make my covenant with Isaac.
Sarah will give birth to him for you at this time next year."
22 When God had finished talking with him, God went up from Abraham.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sarah also gets a new name. "Sarai" and "Sarah" both mean "princess." The new name shows: She is not just a side

character. God's promise is clearly for her too.

Abraham laughs. It just sounds too unbelievable: A man of 100 and a woman of 90 are going to have a baby?

God is not angry about the laughter. He even turns it into the child's name: "Isaac" means "he laughs."

Abraham loves Ishmael and prays for him. God hears this prayer too: Ishmael will be blessed and become a great nation. But the covenant is to go on through Isaac.

Abraham obeys at once VERSES 23–27

23 Abraham took his son Ishmael,
and all who were born in his household,
and all whom he had bought with his money –
every male among the men of Abraham's household.
And he circumcised them in their foreskin on that very same day, just as God had told him.

24 Abraham was 99 years old when he was circumcised in his foreskin.

25 His son Ishmael was 13 years old when he was circumcised in his foreskin.

26 On the same day, Abraham and his son Ishmael were circumcised.

27 And all the men of his household,
those born in the household and those bought with money from foreigners,
were circumcised with him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abraham does not hesitate. "On that very same day" he does what God said.

Ishmael is also circumcised. Even though the covenant goes on through Isaac, Ishmael belongs to Abraham's family and is not left out.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 18

Three guests visit Abraham – Abraham prays for Sodom

Abraham welcomes guests VERSES 1–8

1 The LORD appeared to Abraham by the oaks of Mamre.
Abraham was sitting at the entrance of his tent.
It was the hottest time of the day.

2 Abraham looked up.
Then he saw: Three men were standing near him.
When he saw them, he ran from the tent entrance to meet them.
He bowed down to the ground

3 and said,
"My lord, if I have found favor in your eyes,
please do not pass by your servant.

4 Let someone bring a little water.
Then you can wash your feet
and rest under the tree.

5 I will get a piece of bread, so that you can strengthen yourselves.
After that, you may go on your way.
After all, you have come to your servant."
They answered,
"Very well, do as you have said."

6 Abraham hurried into the tent to Sarah.
He said,
"Quick! Take about 6 gallons of fine flour.
Knead the dough and bake flat loaves of bread!"

7 Then Abraham ran to the herd.
He got a tender, good calf and gave it to the servant.
The servant hurried to prepare it.

8 Abraham took butter, milk and the calf that had been prepared,
and he set it in front of the men.
He himself stood by them under the tree while they ate.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

It is the heat of midday. No one likes to travel then. Still, old Abraham runs to meet the strangers. In the desert, hospitality was vital for life – and in the Middle East, it is still a great honor today.

Abraham modestly says: "a piece of bread." Then he serves a feast: fresh bread, a calf, butter and milk.

"About 6 gallons" of flour – the Bible says "three seahs." A seah is about 2 gallons. That is enough for very many people.

At first, Abraham may not know whom he is serving. The New Testament says: Do not forget to welcome strangers, for in this way some have welcomed angels without knowing it (Hebrews 13:2). This refers to this story.

Sarah laughs VERSES 9–15

9 The men asked him,
"Where is your wife Sarah?"
He answered,
"There, in the tent."

10 Then one of them said,
"I will surely come back to you at about this time next year.
And look: Your wife Sarah will have a son."
Sarah was listening at the entrance of the tent, which was behind him.

11 Abraham and Sarah were old, very far along in years.
Sarah had long been past the age when women can have children.

12 So Sarah laughed quietly to herself.
She thought,
"Now that I am old, will I still have the joy of love?
And my lord is old too!"

13 Then the LORD said to Abraham,
"Why did Sarah laugh and say,
'Will I really have a child, now that I am old?'

14 Is anything too hard for the LORD?
At the set time I will come back to you, at this time next year.
And Sarah will have a son."

15 Then Sarah denied it.
She said, "I did not laugh."

For she was afraid.
But he said, "No, you did laugh."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now it becomes clear: One of the three guests is the LORD himself. He even knows what Sarah is secretly thinking.

Sarah laughs – like Abraham in Chapter 17. It is a laugh of disbelief: That is impossible!

The big question in verse 14 is still true today: "Is anything too hard for the LORD?" Or in other words: Is anything impossible for God?

God does not embarrass Sarah. He only says calmly: "No, you did laugh." God accepts us with our doubts too. And soon Sarah will laugh for joy.

God lets Abraham in on his plan VERSES 16–21

16 The men got up and set out.
They looked toward Sodom.
Abraham went with them to walk with them part of the way.
17 Then the LORD said,
"Should I hide from Abraham what I am about to do?
18 Abraham will surely become a great and mighty nation.
And all the nations of the earth will be blessed through him.
19 For I know him.
He is to command his children and his household after him
to keep the way of the LORD
and to do what is right and just.
Then the LORD can bring about for Abraham what he has promised him."
20 And the LORD said,
"The cry of Sodom and Gomorrah is loud.
And their sin is very serious.
21 I will go down now and see
whether what they have done is as bad as the reports that have come to me.
If not, I will know."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God treats Abraham like a friend. He tells him what he is planning. Later in the Bible, Abraham is called "God's friend" (Isaiah 41:8; James 2:23).

"To do what is right and just" – that is the task for Abraham's family. It is to be an example for the whole world.

The "cry" of Sodom is the crying of the victims. Great wrongs are happening in Sodom. The weak cry for help – and God hears it.

God does not judge too quickly: "I will go down now and see." He checks carefully before he judges.

Abraham bargains with God VERSES 22–33

22 The men turned away and went toward Sodom.
But Abraham kept standing before the LORD.
23 Abraham came closer and said,
"Will you really destroy the righteous together with the wicked?
24 Maybe there are 50 righteous people in the city.
Will you still destroy it?
Will you not spare the place for the sake of the 50 righteous people in it?
25 Far be it from you to do such a thing!
You cannot kill the righteous together with the wicked,
so that the righteous are treated just like the wicked.
Far be it from you!
Shouldn't the Judge of all the earth do what is right?"
26 The LORD said,
"If I find 50 righteous people in the city of Sodom,
then I will spare the whole place for their sake."
27 Abraham answered,
"Look, I have dared to speak to the Lord,
although I am only dust and ashes.
28 Maybe 5 of the 50 righteous people are missing.
Will you destroy the whole city because 5 are missing?"
He said,
"I will not destroy it if I find 45 there."
29 Abraham spoke to him again and said,
"Maybe 40 will be found there."
He said,
"I will not do it, for the sake of the 40."
30 Abraham said,
"Please do not let the Lord be angry, and I will speak.
Maybe 30 will be found there."
He said,
"I will not do it if I find 30 there."
31 Abraham said,
"Look, I have dared to speak to the Lord.
Maybe 20 will be found there."
He said,
"I will not destroy it, for the sake of the 20."
32 Abraham said,
"Please do not let the Lord be angry, and I will speak just once more.
Maybe 10 will be found there."
He said,
"I will not destroy it, for the sake of the 10."
33 When the LORD had finished speaking with Abraham, he went on his way.
And Abraham went back to his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most amazing prayers in the Bible. Abraham does not pray for himself, but for a foreign, wicked city. But his nephew Lot also lives there.

Abraham is brave. He reminds God of his own justice: "Shouldn't the Judge of all the earth do what is right?" And yet he stays humble: "I am only dust and ashes."

God does not get angry. Each time, he agrees to Abraham's request. God wants to save, not to destroy. Even for the sake of 10 righteous people, he would spare a whole city.

The story shows: We may wrestle with God, bargain with him and pray for others. Prayer changes things.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 19

The destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah

Lot welcomes the guests VERSES 1–3

1 The two angels came to Sodom in the evening.
Lot was sitting in the gate of Sodom.
When Lot saw them, he got up to meet them.
He bowed down with his face to the ground
2 and said,
"Please listen, my lords:
Please come into your servant's house.
Stay overnight and wash your feet.
Then you can get up early and go on your way."
They said,
"No, we will spend the night in the town square."
3 But Lot urged them strongly.
So they went with him and came into his house.
He made them a feast.
He baked bread without yeast, and they ate.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Two of the three men from Chapter 18 come to Sodom. Now it is said clearly: They are angels, that is, messengers of God.

Back then, the city gate was the most important place in a city. The respected men met there and settled legal cases. Lot sits there – so he has become a respected man in Sodom.

Lot is hospitable like Abraham. He urges the strangers not to stay outside. He probably knows how dangerous the night in Sodom is for strangers.

Bread without yeast does not have to rise. It is quick to bake.

The men of Sodom VERSES 4–11

4 The guests had not yet lain down to sleep.
Then the men of the city surrounded the house – the men of Sodom, young and old,
all the people from every part of the city.
5 They called to Lot and said to him,
"Where are the men who came to you tonight?
Bring them out to us!
We want to have sex with them."
6 Lot went out to them through the door.
He shut the door behind him.
7 He said,
"Please, my brothers, do not do such an evil thing!
8 Listen: I have two daughters who have never slept with a man.
Let me bring them out to you.
Do with them whatever you like.
Only do nothing to these men.
For they have come under the protection of my roof."
9 But they said, "Get out of the way!"
And they said,
"This one fellow came here as a foreigner, and now he wants to play the judge!
Now we will treat you worse than them!"
They pushed hard against Lot
and came close to breaking down the door.
10 Then the men inside reached out their hands.
They pulled Lot into the house with them
and shut the door.
11 They struck the people outside the door with blindness, young and old.
So they wore themselves out trying to find the door.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a very dark scene. The whole city wants to sexually abuse the strangers by force. This is the "cry" that has come to God: violence against the weak and against strangers, contempt for every rule of hospitality.

Lot tries to protect his guests. But his offer to hand over his own daughters is horrible. The Bible does not praise this. It simply tells it as it was. It shows how much Sodom has already corrupted Lot too.

Later the Bible says about the guilt of Sodom: They were proud and had more than enough food, but they did not help the poor and needy (Ezekiel 16:49). The story shows a city without any compassion.

In the end, Lot does not save the guests – the guests save Lot.

The warning VERSES 12–14

12 The men said to Lot,
"Do you have anyone else here?
Sons-in-law, sons, daughters or anyone else in the city?
Bring them out of this place!
13 For we are going to destroy this place.
The cry against its people has become so great before the LORD
that the LORD has sent us to destroy it."
14 So Lot went out.
He spoke to his future sons-in-law, who were going to marry his daughters.
He said,
"Get up! Get out of this place!
For the LORD is going to destroy the city."
But his sons-in-law thought he was joking.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God gives Lot's family a chance to be saved. But the future sons-in-law do not take the warning seriously. They laugh about it.

Lot has lived in Sodom for so long that no one believes he could speak about God anymore.

The escape from Sodom VERSES 15–23

15 When morning came, the angels urged Lot to hurry.
They said,
"Get up! Take your wife and your two daughters who are here.
Or else you will be swept away when the city is punished for its guilt."
16 But Lot hesitated.
So the men grabbed his hand,
and the hands of his wife and his two daughters.
For the LORD was merciful to him.
They brought him out and only let go of him outside the city.
17 When they had brought them out, one of them said,
"Run for your life!
Do not look behind you!
Do not stop anywhere in the whole plain!

Escape to the mountains, or else you will be swept
away!"
18 Lot said to them,
"Oh no, my lord!
19 Look: Your servant has found favor in your eyes.
You have been very kind to me and saved my life.
But I cannot escape to the mountains.
Disaster might catch up with me, and then I will die.
20 Look, there is a city nearby.
I can escape there. It is a little one.
Please let me escape there – it is only a little one, isn't
it?
Then I will stay alive."
21 He said to him,
"All right, I will grant you this request too.
I will not destroy the city you are talking about.
22 Hurry, escape there!
For I cannot do anything until you get there."
That is why the city is called Zoar.
23 The sun had risen over the earth when Lot came to
Zoar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Lot hesitates. He clings to his belongings and his life in Sodom. The angels literally have to pull him out by the hand.

The most important sentence: "For the LORD was merciful to him." Lot is not saved because he is so good, but because God is merciful – and because Abraham prayed for him.

Even now, Lot is still bargaining. And God even grants him this request.

"Zoar" means "little." After all, Lot kept saying: "It is a little one."

Fire from the sky VERSES 24–29

24 Then the LORD rained sulfur and fire on Sodom and
Gomorrah.
It came from the LORD, out of the sky.
Sulfur is a yellow substance that burns with a terrible
smell.
25 He destroyed those cities and the whole plain,
all the people who lived in the cities
and everything that grew on the ground.
26 But Lot's wife, who was behind him, looked back.
And she became a pillar of salt.
27 Abraham got up early in the morning.
He went to the place where he had stood before the
LORD.
28 He looked down toward Sodom and Gomorrah and
toward the whole land of the plain.
Then he saw: Smoke was rising from the land, like the
smoke from a furnace.
29 This is what happened:
When God destroyed the cities of the plain, God
remembered Abraham.
So he brought Lot out of the middle of the
destruction,
when he destroyed the cities where Lot had lived.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sodom and Gomorrah were probably in the area south of the Dead Sea. To this day, there is a lot of salt, sulfur and tar there. Some researchers think there was an earthquake or a natural disaster. The Bible says: It was God's judgment.

Lot's wife looks back, even though this was forbidden. In her heart, she still clings to Sodom. Later, Jesus reminds people: Remember Lot's wife! (Luke 17:32). This means: Whoever is saved should not hold on to the old, evil life.

Abraham stands at the same place where he prayed for Sodom. He only sees smoke. There were not even 10 righteous people.

But verse 29 says: "God remembered Abraham." Abraham's prayer was not in vain. Lot was saved.

Lot and his daughters VERSES 30–38

30 Lot went up from Zoar into the mountains and lived
there with his two daughters.
For he was afraid to stay in Zoar.
He lived in a cave with his two daughters.
31 The older daughter said to the younger one,
"Our father is old.
And there is no man left on the earth to sleep with us,
as is the custom all over the earth.
32 Come, let's give our father wine to drink.
Then we will sleep with him.
That way we can keep our father's family line alive."
33 That night they gave their father wine to drink.
Then the older one went in and slept with her father.
He did not notice when she lay down or when she got
up.
34 The next day, the older one said to the younger one,
"Look, last night I slept with my father.
Let's give him wine to drink again tonight.
Then you go in and sleep with him.
That way we can keep our father's family line alive."
35 That night too they gave their father wine to drink.
Then the younger one went and slept with him.
He did not notice when she lay down or when she got
up.
36 So both of Lot's daughters became pregnant by their
father.
37 The older one had a son and named him Moab.
He is the father of the Moabites to this day.
38 The younger one also had a son and named him Ben
Ammi.
He is the father of the people of Ammon to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a sad ending for Lot. He chose the most beautiful land – and in the end he lost everything: his belongings, his wife, his good name. Now he lives in a cave.

The daughters believe they are the last people far and wide. In Sodom, they learned that you take what you want. What they do is incest – sex between a father and his daughters. Later, the Bible clearly forbids this (Leviticus 18).

The Bible tells this without approving of it. It shows plainly where the path has led.

Moab and Ammon later became neighboring peoples of Israel, east of the Jordan. Still, they are not lost: Ruth, a woman from Moab, becomes an ancestor of King David and of Jesus (Ruth 4; Matthew 1:5).

GENESIS

CHAPTER 20

Abraham and King Abimelech

The same lie again VERSES 1–2

1 Abraham traveled from there toward the land of the South.
He lived between Kadesh and Shur.
For a time, he lived as a foreigner in Gerar.
2 Abraham said about his wife Sarah, "She is my sister."
Then Abimelech, king of Gerar, sent men and took Sarah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Unbelievable: Abraham makes the same mistake as in Egypt (Chapter 12). Again he says his wife is his sister, to protect himself.

And this happens right now – shortly before Sarah is to have the promised son. God's whole promise is at stake.

Gerar is in the south of the land, near what is now the Gaza Strip.

God warns the king in a dream VERSES 3–8

3 But God came to Abimelech in a dream at night.
He said to him,
"Look, you are a dead man because of the woman you have taken.
For she is married to a man."
4 But Abimelech had not come near her.
He said,
"Lord, will you kill even a nation that is innocent?
5 Did he not tell me himself, 'She is my sister'?
And she herself also said, 'He is my brother.'
I did this with an honest heart and with clean hands."
6 God said to him in the dream,
"Yes, I know that you did this with an honest heart.
And I also kept you from sinning against me.
That is why I did not let you touch her.
7 So now give the man his wife back.
For he is a prophet.
He will pray for you, and you will live.
But if you do not give her back, then know for sure:
You will die, you and everyone who belongs to you."
8 Abimelech got up early in the morning.
He called all his servants together and told them all these things.
Then the men became very afraid.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God steps in again to protect Sarah. He even speaks to a foreign king who does not belong to Abraham's family.

Abimelech is honest and decent. He did not know he was doing anything wrong. God recognizes this.

A "prophet" is a person through whom God speaks and who is especially close to God. Here, for the first time in the Bible, someone is called a prophet – of all people Abraham, who has just lied. God holds on to Abraham, in spite of his mistakes.

The king confronts Abraham VERSES 9–13

9 Then Abimelech called Abraham.
He said to him,
"What have you done to us?
How have I wronged you,
that you have brought such great guilt on me and my kingdom?
You have done things to me that should not be done!"
10 And Abimelech said to Abraham,
"What were you thinking when you did this?"
11 Abraham answered,
"I thought: Surely there is no fear of God in this place.
They will kill me to get my wife.
12 Besides, she really is my sister.
She is the daughter of my father, but not the daughter of my mother.
And she became my wife.
13 When God made me wander away from my father's house, I said to her,
'Do me this kindness:
Everywhere we go, say about me, "He is my brother."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abraham thought: There is no fear of God here. But he was wrong. The foreign king showed more reverence for God than Abraham himself.

We should not judge others too quickly just because they are foreign.

Abraham excuses himself with a half-truth: Sarah is his half-sister. Back then, such a marriage was still allowed. Later, God forbade it (Leviticus 18:9).

Abimelech makes everything right VERSES 14–18

14 Then Abimelech took sheep and cattle, male and female servants.
He gave them to Abraham.
And he gave his wife Sarah back to him.
15 Abimelech said,
"Look, my land is open to you.
Live wherever you like."
16 And to Sarah he said,
"Look, I have given your brother 1,000 pieces of silver.
It is a covering of the eyes for all who are with you.
So in front of everyone, your honor is restored."
17 Abraham prayed to God.
Then God healed Abimelech, and his wife and his female servants too.
They were able to have children again.
18 For the LORD had made every woman in Abimelech's household unable to have children,
because of Sarah, Abraham's wife.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abimelech is generous. He gives Sarah back, gives Abraham gifts and pays a lot of silver so that no one will speak badly about Sarah. Word for word it says: It is to be "a

covering of the eyes" – that means, everyone is to look away and forget the matter.

Abraham, the guilty one, prays for the king, who was innocent. And God answers this prayer.

Strange and beautiful: Abimelech's household has children again. And in the next chapter, Sarah finally has her child too.

GENESIS

Chapter 21

Isaac is born – Hagar and Ishmael in the wilderness

At last: Isaac VERSES 1–7

1 The LORD visited Sarah, as he had said.
The LORD did for Sarah what he had promised.
2 Sarah became pregnant.
She gave birth to a son for Abraham in his old age,
at exactly the time God had told him.
3 Abraham named the son whom Sarah had given birth to Isaac.
4 Abraham circumcised his son Isaac when he was eight days old,
just as God had commanded him.
5 Abraham was 100 years old when his son Isaac was born to him.
6 Sarah said,
"God has made me laugh.
Everyone who hears about it will laugh with me."
7 And she said,
"Who would ever have said to Abraham that Sarah would nurse children?
And yet I have given birth to a son for him in his old age!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abraham has waited 25 years since God called him in Haran. Now the time has finally come. God keeps his promise – at exactly the time he said.

Do you remember? Abraham and Sarah both laughed in disbelief (Chapters 17 and 18). Now Sarah laughs again – but this time for joy. The laughter of doubt turns into the laughter of happiness.

That is why the child is called "Isaac," which means: "He laughs."

Trouble at the feast VERSES 8–13

8 The child grew and was weaned.
That means: He no longer drank at his mother's breast.
On the day Isaac was weaned, Abraham gave a great feast.
9 Then Sarah saw the son of Hagar the Egyptian, whom Hagar had given birth to for Abraham, mocking.
Mocking means: making fun of someone.
10 She said to Abraham,
"Drive out this servant woman and her son!
The son of this servant woman will not inherit together with my son Isaac."
11 This was very hard for Abraham, because of his son.
12 But God said to Abraham,
"Do not let it be so hard for you because of the boy and because of your servant woman.
Listen to everything Sarah tells you.
For your descendants will be named through Isaac.
13 But I will also make the son of the servant woman into a nation,
because he is your child."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, children were not weaned until they were about 2 or 3 years old. A feast for it was common, because many children died young.

Ishmael is now a teenager, about 16 years old. He is "mocking" – in Hebrew, this sounds like "playing Isaac," a play on the name Isaac. It is not quite clear what exactly he does. Sarah feels it is a threat to her son.

Abraham loves Ishmael. It breaks his heart.

God comforts Abraham: I will take care of Ishmael too. He is your child too, and I will not forget him.

Hagar and Ishmael in the wilderness VERSES 14–21

14 Abraham got up early the next morning.
He took bread and a skin bag of water.
He gave them to Hagar and put them on her shoulder.
He also gave her the boy and sent her away.
She left and wandered around in the wilderness of Beersheba.
15 When the water in the skin bag was used up,
she put the boy under one of the bushes.
16 Then she went and sat down across from him, a good distance away, about as far as an arrow flies from a bow.
For she said, "I cannot watch the child die."
So she sat across from him.
And she cried out loud.
17 But God heard the voice of the boy.
The angel of God called to Hagar from the sky:
"What is wrong, Hagar?
Do not be afraid!
For God has heard the voice of the boy, there where he is lying.
18 Get up, lift up the boy and hold him firmly by the hand.
For I will make him into a great nation."
19 Then God opened her eyes.
And she saw a well of water.
She went, filled the skin bag with water and gave the boy a drink.
20 God was with the boy.
He grew up and lived in the wilderness.
He became an archer.
An archer is someone who shoots with a bow and arrows.
21 He lived in the wilderness of Paran.
His mother got a wife for him from the land of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a heartbreaking scene. A mother sits in the wilderness and cannot bear to watch her child die of thirst.

But for the second time, God meets Hagar in the wilderness (the first time was in Chapter 16). Again he sees her. Again he hears.

The name "Ishmael" means "God hears." That is exactly what happens here: "God heard the voice of the boy."

Maybe the well was there the whole time. God "opened her eyes." Sometimes help is closer than we can see in our despair.

The distance an arrow flies from a bow is about 100 yards.

An agreement at the well VERSES 22–34

22 At that time, Abimelech and Phicol, the commander of
his army, came to Abraham.
Abimelech said,
"God is with you in everything you do.
23 So swear to me here by God
that you will not deceive me –
not me, not my children and not my grandchildren.
I have been kind to you.
So you are to be kind to me and to the land where you
live as a foreigner."
24 Abraham said,
"I will swear it."
25 But Abraham complained to Abimelech about a well of
water.
Abimelech's servants had taken it away by force.
26 Abimelech said,
"I do not know who did this.
You did not tell me.
I have not heard about it until today."
27 Then Abraham took sheep and cattle and gave them to
Abimelech.
And the two of them made a covenant.
Here a covenant is a firm agreement between two
people.
28 Abraham set apart seven female lambs from the flock.
29 Abimelech asked Abraham,
"What do these seven female lambs mean that you
have set apart?"
30 Abraham answered,
"You are to take these seven female lambs from my
hand.
They are to be proof that I dug this well."
31 That is why this place is called Beersheba.
For there the two of them swore an oath to each other.
32 So they made a covenant at Beersheba.
Then Abimelech and Phicol, the commander of his
army, set out
and went back to the land of the Philistines.
33 Abraham planted a tamarisk tree in Beersheba.
There he called on the name of the LORD, the
Everlasting God.
34 Abraham lived as a foreigner in the land of the
Philistines for a long time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the dry land, a well is vital for life. Quarrels about water were common.

Abraham and Abimelech settle the quarrel peacefully with an agreement. The seven lambs are like a receipt: Whoever accepts them recognizes that Abraham dug the well.

"Beersheba" means "well of the oath" or "well of seven." In Hebrew, "seven" and "swear" sound almost the same. Beersheba is still a large city in the south of Israel today.

A tamarisk is a tree that grows in the desert and gives shade for a long time. Whoever plants a tree is planning for the future. Abraham is beginning to put down roots in the promised land.

"The Everlasting God" – Abraham gets to know God better and better. He gives him a new name: God is the one who is always there and always stays.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 22

Abraham and Isaac on Mount Moriah

God tests Abraham VERSES 1–2

1 After these things, God tested Abraham.
He said to him, "Abraham!"
Abraham answered, "Here I am."
2 God said,
"Take your son, your only son, Isaac, whom you love.
Go to the land of Moriah.
Offer him there as a burnt offering, on one of the
mountains that I will tell you about."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the hardest and darkest stories in the Bible. Jews call it "the Binding of Isaac."

The reader learns right at the beginning: It is a **test**. God does not really want Isaac to be killed. But Abraham does not know that.

God asks for the unthinkable: the son for whom Abraham waited 25 years. The son through whom all of God's promises are to come true.

Notice how God describes Isaac: "your son, your only son, Isaac, whom you love." Every word makes it harder. God knows exactly how much he is asking.

A burnt offering is an animal that is burned completely on an altar for God.

According to Jewish tradition, Moriah is the mountain in Jerusalem where the temple was later built (2 Chronicles 3:1).

The hard road VERSES 3–8

3 Abraham got up early in the morning.
He saddled his donkey.
He took two of his young servants with him, and his
son Isaac.

He split wood for the burnt offering.
Then he set out for the place God had told him about.
4 On the third day, Abraham looked up.
Then he saw the place far away.
5 Abraham said to his young servants,
"Stay here with the donkey.
The boy and I will go over there.
We will worship God.
Then we will come back to you."
6 Abraham took the wood for the burnt offering and laid it on his son Isaac.
He himself took the fire and the knife in his hand.
So the two of them went on together.
7 Then Isaac said to his father Abraham,
"My father?"
Abraham answered, "Here I am, my son."
Isaac said,
"Here are the fire and the wood.
But where is the lamb for the burnt offering?"
8 Abraham said,
"God himself will provide the lamb for the burnt offering, my son."
So the two of them went on together.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abraham says nothing. He does not argue. He gets up early and sets out. For three days he is on the way – three days in which he could turn back at any time.

He says to the servants: "Then **we** will come back to you." Does Abraham hope that God will step in? The New Testament says: Abraham trusted that God can even bring the dead back to life (Hebrews 11:19).

Isaac carries the wood himself. Here Christians think of Jesus, who had to carry his cross himself.

Isaac's question is heartbreaking: "Where is the lamb?" Abraham's answer is a sentence full of trust: "God himself will provide the lamb."

Twice it says: "So the two of them went on together." Father and son walk the hard road together.

Stop! VERSES 9–14

9 They came to the place God had told him about.
There Abraham built the altar.
He laid the wood on it in order.
He tied up his son Isaac and laid him on the altar, on top of the wood.
10 Then Abraham reached out his hand and took the knife to kill his son.
11 Then the angel of the LORD called to him from the sky:
"Abraham! Abraham!"
He answered, "Here I am."
12 The angel said,
"Do not lay your hand on the boy!
Do not do anything to him!
For now I know that you fear God.
You have not held back your son, your only son, from me."
13 Abraham looked up.
Then he saw: Behind him was a ram caught by its horns in the bushes.
Abraham went, took the ram
and offered it as a burnt offering instead of his son.
14 Abraham named that place "The LORD Will Provide."
That is why people say to this day,
"On the LORD's mountain, it will be provided."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the last moment, God steps in. God does **not** want human sacrifices. Many peoples back then sacrificed children to their gods. Here the Bible says very clearly: The God of Israel does not want that. Later he forbids it clearly (Leviticus 18:21; Deuteronomy 12:31).

"To fear God" does not mean: to be afraid of God. It means: to take God so seriously and to trust him so much that he comes first – even before the dearest thing you have.

An animal dies "instead of" Isaac. God himself has provided, just as Abraham said.

In Hebrew, the name of the place is "Adonai Yireh." It means "The LORD sees" and at the same time "The LORD provides." When God sees, he also provides.

Christians see in this story a picture of Jesus: What God spared Abraham, God did himself. He gave his own beloved Son (John 3:16; Romans 8:32). In the New Testament, Jesus is called the Lamb of God (John 1:29).

To this day, many people find this story hard to bear. That is understandable. Jews and Christians, too, have wrestled with it a great deal over the centuries.

God's oath VERSES 15–19

15 The angel of the LORD called to Abraham a second time from the sky.
16 He said,
"'I have sworn by myself,' says the LORD,
'because you have done this
and have not held back your son, your only son,
17 I will bless you greatly.
I will make your descendants very many,
as many as the stars in the sky
and as the sand on the seashore.
Your descendants will take over the gates of their enemies.
18 Through your descendants, all the nations of the earth will be blessed.
For you have obeyed my voice.'"
19 Then Abraham went back to his young servants.
They set out and went together to Beersheba.
And Abraham lived in Beersheba.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God swears "by myself." There is no one greater by whom he could swear. That is the strongest oath there is.

God repeats all his promises – and makes them even bigger: as many as the stars in the sky **and** as the sand on the seashore.

"To take over the gates of their enemies" means: The descendants will be strong and will stand firm against their enemies.

Abraham goes back. And Isaac? He is not mentioned here. But we know from the next chapters: He is alive.

News from the family VERSES 20–24

20 After these things, Abraham was told,
"Look, Milcah has also had children for your brother Nahor:

21 Uz, the firstborn, and Buz, his brother,
Kemuel, the father of Aram,
22 Chesed, Hazo, Pildash, Jidlaph and Bethuel."
23 Bethuel became the father of Rebekah.
Milcah gave birth to these eight sons for Nahor,
Abraham's brother.
24 His concubine also had children.
Her name was Reumah.
She gave birth to Tebah, Gaham, Tahash and Maacah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the dramatic story comes another list of names. It seems unimportant, but one name is very important: **Rebekah**. She will later become Isaac's wife (Chapter 24).

Back then, a "concubine" was a woman who lived with a man and had children by him, but had fewer rights than the main wife.

Nahor has 12 sons – just like Ishmael and Jacob later. In the Bible, the number 12 often stands for a complete people.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 23

Sarah dies – Abraham buys a grave

Abraham mourns for Sarah VERSES 1–2

1 Sarah lived to be 127 years old.
That was how long Sarah lived.
2 Sarah died in Kiriath Arba – that is Hebron – in the land of Canaan.
Abraham came to mourn for Sarah and to weep for her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sarah is the only woman in the Bible whose age at death is given. This shows how important she is. She is the mother of the people of Israel.

Abraham weeps for his wife. A man of faith may grieve and weep too. Faith and grief belong together.

Mourning for the dead was a fixed custom back then: People grieved loudly and in public for someone who had died.

Abraham asks for a burial place VERSES 3–9

3 Then Abraham got up and left his dead wife.
He spoke to the people of Heth.
He said,
4 "I am a stranger and a foreigner living among you.
Give me a piece of land among you as my own, so that I can have a grave.
Then I can bury my dead there."
5 The people of Heth answered Abraham.
They said to him,
6 "Listen to us, my lord!
You are a prince of God among us.
Bury your dead in the best of our tombs.
None of us will refuse you his tomb.
Bury your dead."
7 Then Abraham got up and bowed down to the people of the land, to the people of Heth.
8 He said to them,
"If you agree that I may bury my dead,
then listen to me and speak for me to Ephron, the son of Zohar.
9 Let him sell me the cave of Machpelah, which belongs to him.
It is at the end of his field.
Let him sell it to me for the full price, here in front of all of you.
Then it will be my own, as a burial place."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God has promised Abraham the whole land. But until now he does not own a single square foot of it. He lives there as a foreigner.

The people of Heth, the Hittites, are a people who lived in the land at that time.

They treat Abraham with great respect: "a prince of God."

But Abraham does not want the grave as a gift, and he does not just want to borrow it. He wants to buy it – as his own, for good.

The bargaining VERSES 10–16

10 Ephron was sitting among the people of Heth.
Ephron the Hittite answered Abraham so that all the people of Heth could hear,
all who had come to the gate of his city.
He said,
11 "No, my lord, listen to me!
I give you the field.
And I also give you the cave that is in it.
In front of my people, I give it to you.
Bury your dead."
12 Then Abraham bowed down before the people of the land.
13 He spoke to Ephron so that the people of the land could hear:
"Please listen to me!
I will pay you the price of the field.
Take the money from me.
Then I will bury my dead there."
14 Ephron answered Abraham.
He said to him,
15 "My lord, listen to me!
A piece of land worth 400 shekels of silver –
what is that between me and you?
Bury your dead."
16 Abraham agreed with Ephron.
He weighed out for Ephron the silver he had named in front of the people of Heth:
400 shekels of silver (about 10 pounds), by the weight the traders used.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is how people bargained in the Middle East back then: First the seller acts as if he wants to give everything away. Then he mentions a price "by the way." And it is high.

Back then, a shekel was not a coin. It was a weight, about 0.4 ounces. 400 shekels are about 10 pounds of silver. That was a lot of money.

Abraham does not haggle. He pays the full price, in public and in front of witnesses. No one is ever to be able to say later that the grave does not belong to him.

The first piece of the promised land VERSES 17–20

17 So the field of Ephron in Machpelah, near Mamre,
became Abraham's:
the field, the cave in it
and all the trees in the field, all around, as far as its borders.
18 It became Abraham's own in front of the people of Heth,
in front of all who had come to the gate of his city.
19 After this, Abraham buried his wife Sarah in the cave of the field of Machpelah,
near Mamre – that is Hebron – in the land of Canaan.
20 So the field and the cave in it were given over to Abraham by the people of Heth as a burial place of his own.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first piece of land that Abraham owns in the promised land is a grave. That sounds sad. But it is also a sign of hope: Abraham firmly believes that his descendants will live here one day.

Later, Abraham himself, Isaac, Rebekah, Jacob and Leah will also be buried in this cave.

To this day, the cave of Machpelah in Hebron is a holy place for Jews, Christians and Muslims.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 24

A wife for Isaac

Abraham's task for his servant VERSES 1–9

1 Abraham was old, very far along in years.
The LORD had blessed Abraham in everything.
2 Abraham spoke to his servant, the oldest servant of his household.
He was in charge of everything Abraham owned.
Abraham said,
"Please put your hand under my thigh.
3 I want you to swear by the LORD, the God of heaven and the God of the earth:
You must not take a wife for my son from the daughters of the Canaanites, among whom I live.
4 Instead, you are to go to my country, to my relatives.
There you are to get a wife for my son Isaac."
5 The servant said to him,
"What if the woman does not want to follow me to this land?
Should I then take your son back to the land you came from?"
6 Abraham said to him,
"Be careful not to take my son back there!
7 The LORD, the God of heaven, took me from my father's house and from the land where I was born.
He spoke to me and swore to me,
'I will give this land to your descendants.'
He will send his angel ahead of you.
And you will get a wife for my son from there.
8 But if the woman does not want to follow you,
then you are free from this oath to me.
Only you must not take my son back there."
9 So the servant put his hand under the thigh of his master Abraham
and swore to him about this matter.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abraham is old and thinks about the future. Isaac is to marry a woman from his own relatives, not from the peoples in Canaan who worship other gods.

"To put your hand under the thigh" was a very solemn way of swearing back then. The thigh stood for one's descendants and for life.

Isaac must not go back to Mesopotamia under any circumstances. The land of Canaan is the land of God's promise. The path leads forward, not back.

Abraham trusts: God will send his angel ahead.

The prayer at the well VERSES 10–14

10 The servant took 10 of his master's camels.
He also took many valuable gifts from his master with him.
Then he set out for Mesopotamia, to the city of Nahor.
11 Outside the city, he made the camels kneel down by the well of water.
It was evening, the time when the women come out to draw water.
12 He prayed,
"LORD, God of my master Abraham,
please let me succeed today.
Show kindness to my master Abraham.
13 Look, I am standing here by the spring of water.
The daughters of the people of the city are coming out to draw water.
14 I will say to a young woman,
'Please tip your jar so that I can drink.'
If she then says,
'Drink, and I will also give your camels a drink' –
let her be the one you have chosen for your servant Isaac.
By this I will know that you have shown kindness to my master."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mesopotamia is the land between the Euphrates and Tigris rivers, in what is now Syria and Iraq. The journey there was many hundreds of miles long.

The servant prays. He does not leave the important decision to chance. He leaves it to God.

His sign is wisely chosen: After a long journey, a camel can drink up to about 25 gallons of water. Giving water to 10 camels is hard work. A woman who offers to do that on her own is helpful, hardworking and generous.

Rebekah VERSES 15–27

15 He had not yet finished praying when Rebekah came
out with her jar on her shoulder.
She was the daughter of Bethuel.
Bethuel was the son of Milcah, the wife of Nahor,
Abraham's brother.
16 The young woman was very beautiful.
She was a virgin. No man had slept with her.
She went down to the spring, filled her jar and came
back up.
17 Then the servant ran to meet her and said,
"Please let me drink a little water from your jar."
18 She said, "Drink, my lord!"
Quickly she lowered her jar onto her hand and gave
him a drink.
19 When she had given him enough to drink, she said,
"I will also draw water for your camels, until they
have had enough to drink."
20 Quickly she emptied her jar into the trough.
A trough is a long, open container for animals to drink
from.
Then she ran back to the well to draw water.
She drew water for all his camels.
21 The man watched her in silence.
He wanted to know whether the LORD had made his
journey successful or not.
22 When the camels had finished drinking, the man took a
gold ring.
It weighed half a shekel (about 0.2 ounces).
And he took two gold bracelets for her arms.
They weighed 10 shekels (about 4 ounces).
23 He said,
"Whose daughter are you? Please tell me.
Is there room in your father's house for us to spend
the night?"
24 She answered him,
"I am the daughter of Bethuel, the son whom Milcah
gave birth to for Nahor."
25 And she said,
"We have plenty of straw and feed.
And we also have room for you to spend the night."
26 Then the man bowed his head and worshiped the
LORD.
27 He said,
"Blessed be the LORD, the God of my master Abraham!
He has not stopped showing his loving kindness and
his faithfulness to my master.
As for me, the LORD has led me on the way to the
house of my master's relatives."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God answers even before the servant has finished praying.

Rebekah does exactly what the servant said in his prayer – and even more. She runs and draws water until all 10 camels have had enough.

And she belongs to exactly the family from which Isaac's wife is to come: She is the granddaughter of Abraham's brother Nahor (see Chapter 22).

A shekel is a weight of about 0.4 ounces.

The servant does not forget to thank God. He praises God for "his loving kindness and his faithfulness" – that means: God means well and keeps what he promises.

Laban welcomes the servant VERSES 28–33

28 The young woman ran home and told her mother's
household what had happened.
29 Rebekah had a brother. His name was Laban.
Laban ran out to the man at the spring.
30 For he had seen the ring and the bracelets on his sister's
arms.
And he had heard his sister Rebekah say, "This is what
the man said to me."
So he went to the man.
And look: He was still standing by the camels at the
spring.
31 Laban said,
"Come in, you who are blessed by the LORD!
Why are you standing out here?
I have made the house ready, and there is room for the
camels."
32 So the man came into the house.
The camels were unloaded and given straw and feed.
And water was brought so that he and the men who
were with him could wash their feet.
33 Then food was set in front of him.
But he said,
"I will not eat until I have said what I have to say."
Laban said, "Speak."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Laban will become important later (in the story of Jacob). Already here you can see: He looks very closely at the gold. He is a man to whom riches mean a lot.

The servant is completely focused on his task. He will not eat before he has given his message.

The servant tells everything VERSES 34–49

34 He said,
"I am Abraham's servant.
35 The LORD has blessed my master greatly.
He has become very rich.
The LORD has given him flocks and herds, silver and
gold,
male and female servants, camels and donkeys.
36 Sarah, my master's wife, gave birth to a son for my
master when she was old.
My master has given him everything he owns.
37 "My master made me swear. He said,
'You must not take a wife for my son from the
daughters of the Canaanites, in whose land I live.
38 Instead, go to my father's house and to my relatives.
There you are to get a wife for my son.'
39 I said to my master,
'What if the woman will not follow me?'
40 He said to me,
'The LORD, before whom I walk, will send his angel
with you.
He will make your journey successful.

You are to get a wife for my son from my relatives,
from my father's house.
41 Then you will be free from my oath, when you come to
my relatives.
If they do not give her to you, you will be free from my
oath.'
42 "Today I came to the spring.
And I prayed,
'LORD, God of my master Abraham, if you will make
the journey I am on successful –
43 look, I am standing here by the spring of water.
I will say to the young woman who comes out to draw
water,
"Please give me a little water from your jar to drink."
44 If she then says to me,
"Drink, and I will also draw water for your camels" –
let her be the woman the LORD has chosen for my
master's son.'
45 "Before I had finished praying in my heart,
Rebekah came out with her jar on her shoulder.
She went down to the spring and drew water.
I said to her, 'Please let me drink.'
46 Quickly she lowered her jar from her shoulder and
said,
'Drink, and I will also give your camels a drink.'
So I drank, and she also gave the camels a drink.
47 I asked her,
'Whose daughter are you?'
She said,
'The daughter of Bethuel, Nahor's son, whom Milcah
gave birth to for him.'
Then I put the ring in her nose and the bracelets on her
arms.
48 I bowed my head and worshiped the LORD.
I praised the LORD, the God of my master Abraham.
He has led me on the right way to get my master's
brother's daughter for his son.
49 "Now tell me:
Will you show kindness and faithfulness to my
master?
Then tell me.
If not, tell me that too.
Then I will know whether to turn to the right or to the
left."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The servant tells the whole story once more. The Bible repeats it in detail on purpose. This makes it clear: It was not chance at work here, but God.

"To turn to the right or to the left" means: Then I will know how things will go on, and I can look somewhere else.

Rebekah says yes VERSES 50–61

50 Laban and Bethuel answered,
"This comes from the LORD.
We cannot say anything to you, either bad or good.
51 Look, here is Rebekah.
Take her and go.
Let her be the wife of your master's son, as the LORD
has said."
52 When Abraham's servant heard their words, he bowed
down to the ground before the LORD.
53 Then the servant brought out jewelry of silver and
gold, and clothes.
He gave them to Rebekah.
He also gave valuable gifts to her brother and her
mother.
54 Then they ate and drank, he and the men who were
with him.
They stayed overnight.
In the morning they got up, and he said,
"Send me back to my master."
55 Her brother and her mother said,
"Let the young woman stay with us a few days, at least
10.
After that she may go."
56 But he said to them,
"Do not hold me back!
The LORD has made my journey successful.
Send me away, so that I may go to my master."
57 They said,
"We will call the young woman and ask her."
58 They called Rebekah and asked her,
"Will you go with this man?"
She answered,
"I will go."
59 So they sent their sister Rebekah away,
together with her nurse, and with Abraham's servant
and his men.
60 They blessed Rebekah and said to her,
"Our sister, may you become the mother of thousands
upon thousands!
May your descendants take over the gate of those who
hate them."
61 Rebekah set out with her servant women.
They rode on the camels and followed the man.
So the servant took Rebekah and went on his way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even Laban and Bethuel recognize: God has acted here.

Important: Rebekah is asked. She decides for herself. And she says bravely: "I will go."

In this she does the same as Abraham: She leaves her homeland and her family and goes to a foreign land, trusting in God.

A "nurse" here is a woman who has taken care of a child since she was little, like a nanny.

Her family's blessing sounds almost exactly like God's blessing for Abraham in Chapter 22.

Isaac and Rebekah VERSES 62–67

62 Meanwhile, Isaac had come back from the well Beer
Lahai Roi.
He lived in the land of the South.
63 In the evening, Isaac went out into the field to think
and pray quietly.
He looked up.
And look: Camels were coming.
64 Rebekah also looked up.
When she saw Isaac, she quickly got down from the
camel.
65 She asked the servant,
"Who is that man walking in the field to meet us?"
The servant said,

"It is my master."
Then she took her veil and covered herself.
66 The servant told Isaac everything he had done.
67 Isaac brought Rebekah into the tent of his mother Sarah.
He took Rebekah, and she became his wife.
And he loved her.
So Isaac was comforted after his mother's death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Beer Lahai Roi is the well where God met Hagar: "You are a God who sees" (Chapter 16).

Isaac is a quiet, thoughtful person. He goes out in the evening to be alone and to pray.

When Rebekah takes her veil, that was a custom back then: The bride covered herself before the bridegroom until the wedding.

The last sentence is very moving: "He loved her." It is the first time in the Bible that it says clearly that a man loves his wife.

Isaac grieved for his mother for a long time. Now he finds comfort in his love for Rebekah.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 25

Abraham dies – Esau and Jacob are born

Abraham's other children VERSES 1–6

1 Abraham took another wife. Her name was Keturah.
2 She had these sons with him: Zimran, Jokshan, Medan, Midian, Ishbak and Shuah.
3 Jokshan became the father of Sheba and Dedan.
The sons of Dedan were Asshurim, Letushim and Leummim.
4 The sons of Midian were Ephah, Epher, Hanoch, Abida and Eldaah.
All these were the descendants of Keturah.
5 Abraham gave everything he owned to Isaac.
6 But to the sons of his concubines, Abraham gave gifts.
A concubine is a wife of lower rank.
While Abraham was still alive, he sent these sons away from his son Isaac.
He sent them east, to the land of the east.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abraham has many more children even after Sarah's death. God's promise to make him the "father of many nations" comes true in this way too.

The Midianites come from Midian. They appear often later on, for example in the story of Moses.

Isaac is the main heir. But the other sons are not forgotten: Abraham takes care of them with gifts. Then he sends them away, so that there will be no fight about the inheritance later.

Abraham dies VERSES 7–11

7 Abraham lived to be 175 years old.
That is how long Abraham lived.
8 Then he breathed his last and died at a good old age.
He was an old man and had lived a full life.
And he was gathered to his people.
9 His sons Isaac and Ishmael buried him in the cave of Machpelah.
It is in the field of Ephron, the son of Zohar the Hittite, near Mamre.
10 That was the field that Abraham had bought from the people of Heth.
Abraham was buried there with his wife Sarah.
11 After Abraham's death, God blessed his son Isaac.
Isaac lived near the well Beer Lahai Roi.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Had lived a full life" – Abraham had a rich, complete life. He has lived enough and can go in peace, just as God had promised him: "You will be buried at a good old age" (Genesis 15:15).

"To be gathered to his people" is an old way of saying: to die and to go to those who have already died. It sounds like hope: death is not simply the end.

A beautiful detail: Isaac and Ishmael bury their father **together**. At their father's grave, the brothers come together again.

God's blessing now passes on to Isaac.

The family of Ishmael VERSES 12–18

12 This is the family history of Ishmael, Abraham's son.
Hagar the Egyptian, Sarah's servant, had given birth to him for Abraham.
13 These are the names of the sons of Ishmael, in the order they were born:
The firstborn of Ishmael was Nebaioth, then came Kedar, Adbeel, Mibsam,
14 Mishma, Dumah, Massa,
15 Hadad, Tema, Jetur, Naphish and Kedemah.
16 These are the sons of Ishmael, and these are their names.
Their villages and their camps are named after them.
They are 12 princes, each with his own people.
17 Ishmael lived to be 137 years old.
Then he breathed his last and died.
And he was gathered to his people.
18 His descendants lived from Havilah to Shur.
Shur is near Egypt, on the way toward Assyria.
Ishmael lived opposite all his relatives.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God keeps his promise to Hagar and Abraham: Ishmael becomes a great people. "He will become the father of 12 princes" (Genesis 17:20).

Kedar and Nebaioth later were well-known Arab tribes in the desert.

"Opposite all his relatives" reminds us of the angel's words to Hagar (Genesis 16:12). Ishmael's descendants live on their own, apart from the others.

Two nations in one womb VERSES 19–26

19 This is the family history of Isaac, Abraham's son.
Abraham became the father of Isaac.
20 Isaac was 40 years old when he married Rebekah.
She was the daughter of Bethuel the Syrian from Paddan Aram.
And she was the sister of Laban the Syrian.
21 Isaac prayed to the LORD for his wife,
because she could not have children.
The LORD answered his prayer.
And his wife Rebekah became pregnant.
22 The children pushed against each other inside her.
She said,
"If it is like this, why am I even alive?"
And she went to ask the LORD.
23 The LORD said to her,
"Two nations are in your womb.
Two peoples will come from your body and go separate ways.
One people will be stronger than the other.
And the older will serve the younger."
24 When the time came for her to give birth –
look: there were twins in her womb.
25 The first one came out.
He was red all over and hairy, like a coat of fur.
They named him Esau.
26 After that, his brother came out.
His hand was holding on to Esau's heel.
He was named Jacob.
Isaac was 60 years old when she gave birth to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Paddan Aram is the area around the city of Haran in Mesopotamia. Abraham's relatives lived there.

Rebekah, too, cannot have children at first – just like Sarah. Isaac and Rebekah wait 20 years. Isaac prays, and God hears.

The pregnancy is hard. Rebekah brings her distress to God. The answer: the two children will become two nations. And against all the rules of that time, the younger will stand above the older.

"Esau" sounds like "hairy." Esau also has a second name: Edom, which means "red."

In Hebrew, "Jacob" sounds like "heel." It can also mean "one who holds on" or "one who cheats." That fits his story.

Two very different brothers VERSES 27–28

27 The boys grew up.
Esau became a skillful hunter, a man who lived out in the open country.
Jacob was a quiet man who stayed in the tents.
28 Isaac loved Esau, because he liked to eat the wild game Esau hunted.
But Rebekah loved Jacob.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The twins are completely different: Esau is the wild, strong outdoors type. Jacob is the quiet, clever type who prefers to stay at home.

A big problem: each parent has a favorite son. Later this will lead to much conflict and pain. Parents should not love their children differently.

The lentil stew VERSES 29–34

29 One day Jacob was cooking stew.
Esau came in from the field.
He was starving.
30 Esau said to Jacob,
"Please let me eat some of that red stew, because I am starving."
That is why he was called Edom.
Edom means "red."
31 Jacob said,
"First sell me your birthright."
32 Esau said,
"Look, I am about to die.
What good is the birthright to me?"
33 Jacob said,
"Swear it to me first."
So Esau swore it to him.
And so he sold his birthright to Jacob.
34 Jacob gave Esau bread and lentil stew.
Esau ate and drank.
Then he got up and went on his way.
So Esau treated his birthright as worthless.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, the "birthright" belonged to the oldest son. He received a double share of the inheritance. After his father, he became the head of the family. In this family it meant even more: whoever had it carried on God's promise to Abraham.

Esau sells this great gift for a bowl of lentil soup. He thinks only of his hunger in the moment. He does not see what he is losing forever.

But Jacob is not a good example either. He coldly takes advantage of his brother's weakness.

In the end, the Bible judges Esau: he treated his birthright as worthless. In the New Testament, he is named as a warning (Hebrews 12:16).

In German there is a saying to this day: "to sell something for a dish of lentils." It means: to give away something very valuable for almost nothing.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 26

Isaac in Gerar – fighting over wells

God renews his promise to Isaac VERSES 1–6

1 There was a famine in the land.
It was another famine, besides the first famine in the time of Abraham.
Isaac went to Abimelech, the king of the Philistines, in Gerar.

2 The LORD appeared to him and said,
"Do not go down to Egypt.
Live in the land that I will tell you about.
3 Live in this land, and I will be with you and bless you.
For I will give all these lands to you and to your descendants.
And I will keep the oath that I swore to your father Abraham.
4 I will make your descendants as many as the stars in the sky.
I will give all these lands to your descendants.
And through your descendants all the nations of the earth will be blessed.
5 For Abraham listened to my voice.
He kept what I required of him: my commandments, my rules and my laws."
6 So Isaac lived in Gerar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Isaac goes through the same thing as his father: a famine. But God tells him: Stay in the land. I am with you.

God gives Isaac the same promises that he gave to Abraham: land, many descendants and blessing for all nations. The covenant goes on, from generation to generation.

Isaac obeys and stays.

Isaac repeats Abraham's mistake VERSES 7–11

7 The men of the place asked him about his wife.
He said, "She is my sister."
For he was afraid to say, "She is my wife."
He thought,
"The men of this place might kill me to get Rebekah, because she is very beautiful."
8 When he had been there for a long time,
Abimelech, the king of the Philistines, looked out of a window.
He saw Isaac caressing his wife Rebekah.
9 Abimelech called Isaac and said,
"Look, she really is your wife!
Why did you say, 'She is my sister'?"
Isaac said to him,
"Because I thought, 'I might die because of her.'"
10 Abimelech said,
"What have you done to us?
One of the people could easily have slept with your wife.
Then you would have brought guilt on us!"
11 Abimelech gave an order to all the people:
"Anyone who touches this man or his wife will surely be put to death."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Like father, like son: Isaac makes exactly the same mistake as Abraham (Chapters 12 and 20). Weaknesses and fears are often passed on in families.

The Abimelech here is probably not the same king as in Abraham's time. "Abimelech" was probably a title of the kings of Gerar, like "Pharaoh" in Egypt.

Once again, the foreign king acts more decently than the man of God. And once again, God protects the woman.

Isaac becomes rich – and envied VERSES 12–17

12 Isaac planted seed in that land.
In the same year he harvested 100 times as much as he had planted.
The LORD blessed him.
13 The man became rich.
He became richer and richer, until he was very rich.
14 He owned flocks of sheep and goats, herds of cattle and a large household.
The Philistines became jealous of him.
15 The servants of his father Abraham had dug wells in Abraham's lifetime.
The Philistines had blocked all these wells and filled them with earth.
16 Abimelech said to Isaac,
"Go away from us!
You have become much more powerful than we are."
17 So Isaac left that place.
He set up camp in the valley of Gerar and lived there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

To harvest 100 times as much – that is a huge harvest, in the middle of a time of famine. That is God's blessing.

But success makes others jealous. The Philistines destroy the wells. In the desert, that is a terrible attack, because nobody can live without water.

Isaac does not fight back with violence. He goes away.

Fighting over the wells VERSES 18–22

18 Isaac dug out again the wells of water that had been dug in the time of his father Abraham.
For the Philistines had blocked them after Abraham's death.
He gave them the same names that his father had given them.
19 Isaac's servants dug in the valley.
There they found a well of fresh, flowing water.
20 But the herdsmen of Gerar argued with Isaac's herdsmen.
They said, "The water is ours!"
So Isaac named the well Esek.
Esek means "quarrel."
For they had quarreled with him.
21 Then they dug another well.
They argued over that one too.
So he named it Sitnah.
Sitnah means "hostility."
22 He moved on from there and dug another well.
They did not argue over this one.
So he named it Rehoboth.
Rehoboth means "wide spaces."
He said,
"Now the LORD has made room for us.
Now we will grow in the land."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Isaac is a peaceful man. Twice his well is taken away from him. He does not fight. Instead, he moves on and digs a new one.

In the end, he finds a place without conflict: "Rehoboth" – wide spaces. He sees God's gift in this.

Whoever gives in does not necessarily lose. Sometimes it is exactly then that God opens up a new, wide space.

God appears to Isaac in Beersheba VERSES 23–25

23 From there Isaac went up to Beersheba.
24 That same night the LORD appeared to him and said,
"I am the God of your father Abraham.
Do not be afraid, for I am with you.
I will bless you and give you many descendants,
for the sake of my servant Abraham."
25 Isaac built an altar there and called on the name of the LORD.
He set up his tent there.
And there Isaac's servants dug a well.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Do not be afraid, for I am with you" – this is one of the most frequent sentences in the Bible. God says it again and again to people who feel unsure.

Isaac does what his father Abraham did: he builds an altar and prays. He has taken on his father's faith.

Peace with Abimelech VERSES 26–33

26 Then Abimelech came to him from Gerar.
With him came his friend Ahuzzath and Phicol, the commander of his army.
27 Isaac said to them,
"Why have you come to me?
You hate me, and you sent me away from you."
28 They said,
"We have seen clearly that the LORD is with you.
So we said,
'Let there be an oath between us and you.
Let us make a covenant with you:
29 You will do us no harm,
just as we have not touched you.
We have done nothing but good to you,
and we have let you go in peace.'
You are now the one the LORD has blessed."
30 Isaac made a feast for them, and they ate and drank.
31 Early in the morning they got up and swore an oath to each other.
Then Isaac sent them on their way.
And they left him in peace.
32 That same day, Isaac's servants came.
They told him about the well they had dug.
They said to him, "We have found water!"
33 Isaac named it Shibah.
Shibah means "oath."
That is why the city is called Beersheba to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Philistines had driven Isaac away. Now they come to him themselves and want peace. They have seen: God is with this man.

Isaac does not hold a grudge. Even though they treated him badly, he invites them to a meal.

And on the very day of the peace treaty, his servants find water. Peace and blessing belong together.

Abraham had already given Beersheba this name (Chapter 21). Isaac confirms the old name: "well of the oath."

Esau's wives VERSES 34–35

34 When Esau was 40 years old, he married Judith, the daughter of Beeri the Hittite,
and Basemath, the daughter of Elon the Hittite.
35 These two women made life hard and bitter for Isaac and Rebekah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abraham very much wanted Isaac not to marry a woman from the peoples of Canaan (Chapter 24). Esau does not care about that. He marries two Hittite women at once.

This shows again: Esau does not value the heritage of Abraham and God's promise.

For his parents this is a great sorrow. It prepares the way for the next story.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 27

Jacob gets the blessing by a trick

Isaac wants to bless Esau VERSES 1–4

1 Isaac had grown old.
His eyes were so weak that he could no longer see.
He called Esau, his older son, and said to him,
"My son?"
Esau said to him, "Here I am."
2 Isaac said,
"Look, I am old.
I do not know the day I will die.
3 So please take your weapons, your quiver and your bow.
Go out into the field and hunt some wild game for me.
4 Make me a tasty meal, the kind I love.
Bring it to me so that I may eat.
Then I will bless you with all my heart before I die."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, a father's blessing was very important. People believed: what a father promises in a blessing before his death is valid. It cannot be taken back. It shapes the future.

Isaac wants to give the blessing to Esau, his favorite son. But before the birth, God had said: "The older will serve the younger" (Genesis 25:23). Isaac does not keep to that.

A quiver is a case for arrows.

Rebekah's plan VERSES 5–17

5 Rebekah heard Isaac speaking to his son Esau.
Esau went out into the field to hunt wild game and bring it home.
6 Then Rebekah said to her son Jacob,
"Listen! I heard your father say to your brother Esau,

7 'Bring me wild game and make me a tasty meal, so that I may eat.
Then I will bless you in the presence of the LORD before I die.'
8 So now, my son, listen to me and do what I tell you.
9 Go to the flock and get me two good young goats.
I will make a tasty meal from them for your father, the kind he loves.
10 You will bring it to your father so that he may eat.
Then he will bless you before he dies."
11 Jacob said to his mother Rebekah,
"Look, my brother Esau is a hairy man,
and my skin is smooth.
12 What if my father touches me?
Then he will see me as a cheat.
And I would bring a curse on myself, not a blessing."
13 His mother said to him,
"Let your curse fall on me, my son.
Just listen to me. Go and get the goats for me."
14 So Jacob went, got the goats and brought them to his mother.
His mother made a tasty meal, the kind his father loved.
15 Then Rebekah took the good clothes of Esau, her older son.
She had them with her in the house.
She put them on Jacob, her younger son.
16 She put the skins of the young goats on his hands and on the smooth part of his neck.
17 Then she handed her son Jacob the tasty meal and the bread she had made.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rebekah knows God's word that Jacob is to come first. But instead of trusting God, she takes matters into her own hands – with a trick.

Jacob has no worries that it is wrong. He is only afraid of getting caught.

The whole family is torn apart: each parent fights for their favorite child. No one talks openly with anyone else.

Jacob before his father VERSES 18–29

18 Jacob went in to his father and said,
"My father?"
Isaac said,
"Here I am. Who are you, my son?"
19 Jacob said to his father,
"I am Esau, your firstborn.
I have done what you asked me to do.
Please get up, sit down and eat some of my wild game.
Then you can bless me with all your heart."
20 Isaac said to his son,
"How did you find it so quickly, my son?"
Jacob said,
"Because the LORD your God gave me success."
21 Isaac said to Jacob,
"Please come closer, my son.
I want to touch you and find out whether you are really my son Esau or not."
22 Jacob went close to his father Isaac.
Isaac touched him and said,
"The voice is Jacob's voice,
but the hands are the hands of Esau."
23 He did not recognize him,
because his hands were hairy, like the hands of his brother Esau.
So he blessed him.
24 He asked,
"Are you really my son Esau?"
Jacob said,
"I am."
25 Isaac said,
"Bring it to me, and I will eat some of my son's wild game.
Then I will bless you with all my heart."
Jacob brought it to him, and he ate.
He also brought him wine, and he drank.
26 Then his father Isaac said to him,
"Come here now and kiss me, my son."
27 Jacob came close and kissed him.
Isaac smelled the smell of his clothes.
He blessed him and said,
"Look, the smell of my son
is like the smell of a field that the LORD has blessed.
28 May God give you the dew of the sky
and the rich soil of the earth,
plenty of grain and new wine.
29 Let peoples serve you,
and let nations bow down to you.
Be lord over your brothers.
Let your mother's sons bow down to you.
Cursed be everyone who curses you.
Blessed be everyone who blesses you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob lies right to the face of his blind father three times. He even uses God's name for his lie: "Because the LORD your God gave me success."

Isaac is suspicious. He listens to the voice, he touches, he asks once more. But he lets himself be fooled by the smell and the skins.

The blessing is a blessing for a fertile land and for power. And it repeats what God had said to Abraham: "Blessed be everyone who blesses you."

Dew was very important in the dry land. At night it makes the plants wet, even when it has not rained for a long time.

Esau comes back VERSES 30–40

30 Isaac had just finished blessing Jacob.
Jacob had barely left his father Isaac.
Then his brother Esau came back from hunting.
31 He also made a tasty meal and brought it to his father.
He said to his father,
"Let my father get up and eat some of his son's wild game.
Then you can bless me with all your heart."
32 His father Isaac asked him,
"Who are you?"
He said,
"I am your son, your firstborn, Esau."
33 Isaac began to tremble violently.
He said,
"Then who was it that hunted wild game and brought

it to me?
I ate all of it before you came.
And I have blessed him.
Yes, he will stay blessed."
34 When Esau heard his father's words, he cried out loudly.
It was a very great and bitter cry.
He said to his father,
"Bless me too, my father!"
35 Isaac said,
"Your brother came with a trick.
He has taken away your blessing."
36 Esau said,
"He is rightly named Jacob!
He has cheated me two times now.
He took away my birthright.
And look, now he has taken away my blessing."
And he said,
"Have you not saved a blessing for me?"
37 Isaac answered Esau,
"Look, I have made him your lord.
I have given him all his brothers as servants.
I have supplied him with grain and new wine.
So what can I still do for you, my son?"
38 Esau said to his father,
"Do you have only one blessing, my father?
Bless me too, my father!"
And Esau began to weep loudly.
39 His father Isaac answered him,
"Look, your home will have a share in the rich soil of the earth
and in the dew of the sky above.
40 You will live by your sword,
and you will serve your brother.
But this will happen: when you break free,
you will shake his yoke off your neck."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Isaac trembles all over. He realizes: I wanted to act against God's word, and God still guided it the way he had said. That is why he says: "Yes, he will stay blessed."

Esau's cry and his tears are heartbreaking. The Bible shows his pain with much compassion. He is not just the villain.

"Jacob" sounds like "heel-holder" or "cheat." Esau says bitterly: the name fits!

In Hebrew, verse 39 can be read in two ways: Esau's home will have a share in the rich soil, or it will be far away from the rich soil. Our text follows the first reading. Many Bibles translate it the second way, because Esau's descendants, the Edomites, later lived in a poor, mountainous land southeast of the Dead Sea.

A "yoke" is a wooden beam used to hitch oxen to a plow. It is a picture of oppression. Isaac foretells: Edom will serve Israel, but one day it will break free. That is what happened later (2 Kings 8:20–22).

Esau wants to kill Jacob VERSES 41–46

41 Esau hated Jacob because of the blessing his father had given him.
Esau said to himself,
"The days of mourning for my father are near.
Then I will kill my brother Jacob."
42 Someone told Rebekah what her older son Esau had said.
She sent for her younger son Jacob.
She said to him,
"Listen: your brother Esau is comforting himself with the plan to kill you.
43 So now, my son, listen to me.
Get up and flee to my brother Laban in Haran.
44 Stay with him for a while,
until your brother's rage has calmed down –
45 until your brother's anger turns away from you
and he forgets what you have done to him.
Then I will send for you and bring you back from there.
Why should I lose you both in one day?"
46 Rebekah said to Isaac,
"I am sick of my life because of the daughters of Heth.
If Jacob marries one of the daughters of Heth like these,
one of the daughters of this land,
what good will my life be to me?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The trick has terrible results. The quarreling brothers almost become a second Cain and Abel.

"Why should I lose you both in one day?" – Rebekah is afraid: if Esau kills Jacob, she loses Jacob. And Esau would have to flee as a murderer or would be killed himself.

Rebekah says that Jacob is to be away only "for a while." In reality, he will stay away for 20 years. And Rebekah will never see her favorite son again. The Bible tells nothing more about her, except about her grave (Genesis 49:31).

With verse 46, Rebekah cleverly gets Isaac to send Jacob away – without telling him about Esau's plans to murder him.

The whole story shows: God reaches his goal, even through people's mistakes. But that does not make the trick good. Everyone in this family has to pay dearly for it.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 28

Jacob's dream of the stairway to heaven

Isaac blesses Jacob and sends him away VERSES 1–5

1 Isaac called Jacob to him.
He blessed him and gave him a command.
He said to him,
"Do not take a wife from the daughters of Canaan.
2 Get up and go to Paddan Aram,
to the house of Bethuel, your mother's father.

Take a wife there from the daughters of Laban, your mother's brother.

3 May God Almighty bless you.
May he make you fruitful and give you many descendants,
so that you become a great community of peoples.

4 May he give you the blessing of Abraham, to you and to your descendants with you.
Then you will own the land where you now live as a stranger.
God gave this land to Abraham."

5 So Isaac sent Jacob away.
Jacob went to Paddan Aram, to Laban.
Laban was the son of Bethuel the Syrian.
He was the brother of Rebekah, the mother of Jacob and Esau.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Isaac blesses Jacob once more – this time with open eyes. He knows whom he is blessing. And he clearly passes on to him the "blessing of Abraham": land, descendants and God's closeness.

Paddan Aram is the area around the city of Haran, the old home of Abraham's family. Jacob goes the same way as Abraham's servant in Chapter 24 – only the other way around, and as someone running away.

Esau marries one more wife VERSES 6–9

6 Esau saw that Isaac had blessed Jacob.
He saw that Isaac had sent him away to Paddan Aram to take a wife from there.
And he saw that Isaac had given him a command when he blessed him.
Isaac had said, "Do not take a wife from the daughters of Canaan."

7 Esau also saw that Jacob had obeyed his father and his mother
and had gone to Paddan Aram.

8 So Esau saw that his father Isaac did not like the daughters of Canaan.

9 That is why Esau went to Ishmael.
He already had wives.
But in addition to them, he took Mahalath as his wife.
She was the daughter of Ishmael, Abraham's son.
And she was the sister of Nebaioth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only now does Esau notice that his wives cause his parents grief. He tries to make it right and marries a woman from Abraham's family.

Esau wants to please his father. That is somehow touching. But he does not really understand what it is about. He simply adds one more wife.

The stairway to heaven VERSES 10–15

10 Jacob left Beersheba and went toward Haran.

11 He came to a certain place.
He stayed there for the night, because the sun had set.
He took one of the stones of that place and put it under his head.
Then he lay down in that place to sleep.

12 He had a dream:
He saw a stairway that stood on the earth.
Its top reached to heaven.
Look! The angels of God were going up and coming down on it.

13 Look! The LORD stood above it and said,
"I am the LORD, the God of your father Abraham, and the God of Isaac.
I will give the land you are lying on to you and to your descendants.

14 Your descendants will be as many as the dust of the earth.
You will spread out to the west and to the east, to the north and to the south.
Through you and through your descendants, all the families of the earth will be blessed.

15 Look! I am with you.
I will protect you wherever you go.
And I will bring you back into this land.
For I will not leave you until I have done what I have promised you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob is alone and on the run. He has cheated his brother and lost his family. He sleeps under the open sky, with a stone as a pillow. He is at the very bottom.

And exactly there, God meets him. Not in the temple, not in a holy moment, but on the run, after a serious mistake.

The stairway (often also called "Jacob's ladder") connects heaven and earth. The picture says: God is not far away. There is a connection between him and us.

God does not blame Jacob. He gives him promises: "I am with you. I will protect you wherever you go. I will not leave you."

In the New Testament, Jesus refers to this story. He says that he himself is this connection between heaven and earth (John 1:51).

Jacob wakes up VERSES 16–22

16 Then Jacob woke up from his sleep and said,
"Truly, the LORD is in this place, and I did not know it!"

17 He was afraid and said,
"How awesome this place is!
This is none other than God's house.
And this is the gate of heaven."

18 Jacob got up early in the morning.
He took the stone that he had put under his head and set it up as a pillar.
A pillar is a tall stone that stands upright as a sign.
Then he poured oil on its top.

19 He named that place Bethel.
But at first, the name of the city was Luz.

20 Then Jacob made a vow.
A vow is a solemn promise to God.
He said,
"If God will be with me,
and if he will protect me on this way that I am going,
and if he will give me bread to eat and clothes to wear,

21 so that I come back to my father's house in peace,
and if the LORD will be my God,

22 then this stone that I have set up as a pillar will be God's house.

And of everything you give me, I will surely give a tenth to you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The LORD is in this place, and I did not know it!" That is a wonderful sentence. God is often closer than we notice – especially in places where we do not expect him at all.

"Bethel" means "house of God."

With the oil, Jacob sets the stone apart for God. He makes it a reminder: God met me here.

Jacob is still careful. He says: "**If** God will be with me …, **then** …" He is not as far along as Abraham yet. For now, he is only trying out faith. But God meets him where he is. God is patient with people whose faith is still small.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 29

Jacob, Rachel and Leah

At the well VERSES 1–8

1 Jacob went on with his journey.
He came to the land of the people of the east.
2 There he saw a well in the field.
Three flocks of sheep were lying there beside it.
For people watered the flocks from this well.
The stone on the opening of the well was large.
3 All the flocks were gathered there.
Then the shepherds rolled the stone away from the opening of the well.
They watered the sheep.
After that, they put the stone back in its place on the opening of the well.
4 Jacob said to the shepherds,
"My relatives, where are you from?"
They said,
"We are from Haran."
5 He asked them,
"Do you know Laban, the son of Nahor?"
They said,
"We know him."
6 He asked them,
"Is he doing well?"
They said,
"He is doing well.
Look, his daughter Rachel is coming with the sheep."
7 Jacob said,
"Look, it is still the middle of the day.
It is not yet time to gather the livestock together.
Water the sheep, and go and let them eat."
8 They said,
"We can't do that.
First all the flocks must be gathered together.
Then the stone is rolled away from the opening of the well.
Then we water the sheep."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Once again there is a meeting at a well – like with Abraham's servant and Rebekah (Chapter 24). Back then, wells were meeting places. That is where people got to know each other.

The stone on the well protected the water. It was so heavy that people could only move it together. So no one could secretly steal water.

"Laban, the son of Nahor" – here "son" means: descendant. To be exact, Laban was Nahor's grandson (see Genesis 24:24 and 24:29).

Jacob meets Rachel VERSES 9–14

9 Jacob was still talking with them.
Then Rachel came with her father's sheep.
For she took care of them.
10 Jacob saw Rachel, the daughter of Laban, his mother's brother.
And he saw the sheep of Laban, his mother's brother.
Then Jacob went near.
He rolled the stone away from the opening of the well and watered the flock of Laban, his mother's brother.
11 Jacob kissed Rachel.
And he began to cry out loud.
12 Jacob told Rachel that he was her father's relative.
He told her that he was Rebekah's son.
She ran and told her father.
13 Laban heard the news about Jacob, his sister's son.
Then he ran to meet Jacob.
He hugged him, kissed him and brought him to his house.
Jacob told Laban all these things.
14 Laban said to him,
"Truly, you are my bone and my flesh."
Jacob stayed with him for a month.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob rolls the heavy stone away all by himself. Love gives him strength.

He cries for joy and relief. After his long, lonely flight, he has finally found his family.

Back then, a kiss was a normal greeting between relatives.

"My bone and my flesh" means: You belong to the family.

Seven years for Rachel VERSES 15–20

15 Then Laban said to Jacob,
"Should you work for me for nothing, just because you are my relative?
Tell me what your pay should be."
16 Laban had two daughters.
The older one was named Leah.
The younger one was named Rachel.
17 Leah's eyes were weak.
But Rachel had a beautiful figure and was lovely to look at.
18 Jacob loved Rachel.
He said,
"I will work for you seven years for Rachel, your younger daughter."

19 Laban said,
"It is better that I give her to you than to another man.
Stay with me."
20 So Jacob worked seven years for Rachel.
They seemed to him like only a few days, because he loved her so much.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, a bridegroom had to pay a bride price to the bride's family. Jacob has no money. He has run away. That is why he offers his work: seven years.

It is not clear what Leah's "weak" eyes mean exactly. Maybe she had soft, gentle eyes. Maybe her eyes were weak. In any case, she is less strikingly beautiful than her sister.

Verse 20 is one of the most beautiful love sentences in the Bible: Seven years seem to Jacob like a few days, because he loves Rachel so much.

The cheater is cheated VERSES 21–30

21 Then Jacob said to Laban,
"Give me my wife.
My time of work is over.
I want to sleep with her."
22 Laban gathered together all the men of the place and made a feast.
23 But in the evening, he took his daughter Leah and brought her to Jacob.
And Jacob slept with her.
24 Laban gave his servant Zilpah to his daughter Leah to be her servant.
25 In the morning – look! It was Leah!
Jacob said to Laban,
"What have you done to me?
Didn't I work for you for Rachel?
Why did you trick me?"
26 Laban said,
"In our place, it is not done to give the younger daughter before the firstborn.
27 Finish the wedding week of this one.
Then we will give you the other one too.
For her, you will work for me seven more years."
28 Jacob did so.
He finished Leah's wedding week.
Then Laban gave him his daughter Rachel as his wife.
29 Laban gave his servant Bilhah to his daughter Rachel to be her servant.
30 Jacob slept with Rachel too.
And he loved Rachel more than Leah.
And he worked for Laban seven more years.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

How could Jacob not notice? Back then, the bride wore a veil, it was dark, and there was a lot of wine at the feast.

Now Jacob finds out for himself what it is like to be tricked. He fooled his blind father by pretending to be the older son. Now he is fooled because the older daughter pretends to be the younger one.

Laban's answer hits the mark: "In our place, it is not done to give the younger daughter before the firstborn." That must have hit Jacob hard – he had done exactly that: as the younger one, he pushed himself ahead of the firstborn.

The Bible does not say this directly. But it shows: What you do to others often comes back to you.

Back then, a wedding lasted a whole week.

Later, the law forbids a man to marry two sisters at the same time (Leviticus 18:18). In this chapter, you can see why: It brings a lot of suffering.

Leah has sons VERSES 31–35

31 The LORD saw that Leah was hated.
That means: She was loved less.
So he let her have children.
But Rachel could not have children.
32 Leah became pregnant and gave birth to a son.
She named him Reuben.
For she said,
"The LORD has looked at my misery.
Now my husband will love me."
33 She became pregnant again and gave birth to a son.
She said,
"The LORD has heard that I am hated.
That is why he has given me this son too."
She named him Simeon.
34 She became pregnant again and gave birth to a son.
She said,
"Now this time my husband will be joined to me,
because I have given birth to three sons for him."
That is why he was named Levi.
35 She became pregnant again and gave birth to a son.
She said,
"This time I will praise the LORD."
That is why she named him Judah.
Then she stopped having children.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Leah suffers very much. She is not loved. The text even says: She was "hated." It means: pushed aside, loved less.

But God sees her. Just as he saw Hagar. God is on the side of those who are overlooked.

The names of the children tell Leah's feelings:

Reuben sounds like "Look, a son!" and "He has seen my misery."

Simeon sounds like "He has heard."

Levi sounds like "joined, connected."

Judah sounds like "praise."

With the first three sons, Leah still hopes that Jacob will finally love her. With the fourth, she turns to God: "This time I will praise the LORD." She no longer finds her worth only in Jacob's love, but with God.

Later the priests of Israel will come from Levi. From Judah come King David and – according to Christian faith – Jesus. Leah, who was not loved, becomes the mother of the most important tribes.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 30

Jacob's children – and Jacob becomes rich

Rachel and her servant Bilhah VERSES 1–8

1 Rachel saw that she did not give birth to any children for Jacob.
So she became jealous of her sister.
She said to Jacob,
"Give me children, or else I will die!"
2 Then Jacob became very angry with Rachel.
He said,
"Am I in God's place?
He is the one who has kept you from having children."
3 Rachel said,
"Look, here is my servant Bilhah.
Sleep with her.
She can give birth on my knees.
Then I too can have children through her."
4 So she gave him her servant Bilhah as a wife.
And Jacob slept with her.
5 Bilhah became pregnant and gave birth to a son for Jacob.
6 Rachel said,
"God has judged in my favor.
He has also heard my voice and has given me a son."
That is why she named him Dan.
7 Bilhah, Rachel's servant, became pregnant again.
She gave birth to a second son for Jacob.
8 Rachel said,
"I have wrestled with my sister in a mighty struggle.
And I have won."
She named him Naphtali.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rachel is loved, but she has no children. Leah has children, but she is not loved. Both sisters suffer – and they are jealous of each other.

Jacob's answer is harsh, but true: Children are a gift from God. No person can "make" them.

Rachel does the same thing as Sarah with Hagar: She gives her servant to her husband. "Give birth on my knees" was a custom: After the birth, the mistress took the child on her lap. That showed: This is my child.

Dan means "He has judged in my favor." Naphtali means "my struggle."

Leah and her servant Zilpah VERSES 9–13

9 Leah saw that she had stopped having children.
So she took her servant Zilpah and gave her to Jacob as a wife.
10 Zilpah, Leah's servant, gave birth to a son for Jacob.
11 Leah said,
"How lucky!"
She named him Gad.
12 Zilpah, Leah's servant, gave birth to a second son for Jacob.
13 Leah said,
"How happy I am!
The women will call me happy."
She named him Asher.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Leah copies her sister. It is a real contest between the sisters for children.

Gad means "luck." Asher means "happy."

The mandrakes VERSES 14–21

14 At the time of the wheat harvest, Reuben went out into the field.
There he found mandrakes.
He brought them to his mother Leah.
Then Rachel said to Leah,
"Please give me some of your son's mandrakes."
15 Leah said to her,
"Isn't it enough that you have taken my husband away from me?
Do you want to take my son's mandrakes too?"
Rachel said,
"All right. Then Jacob will sleep with you tonight.
In return, I get your son's mandrakes."
16 In the evening, Jacob came home from the field.
Leah went out to meet him and said,
"You must sleep with me tonight.
For I have paid for you with my son's mandrakes."
And he slept with her that night.
17 God listened to Leah.
She became pregnant and gave birth to a fifth son for Jacob.
18 Leah said,
"God has paid me back, because I gave my servant to my husband."
She named him Issachar.
19 Leah became pregnant again.
She gave birth to a sixth son for Jacob.
20 Leah said,
"God has given me a good gift.
Now my husband will live with me,
because I have given birth to six sons for him."
She named him Zebulun.
21 After that, she gave birth to a daughter.
She named her Dinah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mandrakes are the fruits of a plant. Back then, people believed they helped a woman to become pregnant.

The scene is sad: Two sisters trade their husband like goods. Leah has to "buy" her own husband so that he spends a night with her.

But it is not the mandrakes that help. It is God: Rachel has the mandrakes – and Leah gets the children.

Issachar sounds like "pay." Zebulun sounds like "gift" and "live with."

Dinah is the only daughter of Jacob who is named. She becomes important in Chapter 34.

At last: Joseph VERSES 22–24

22 Then God remembered Rachel.
God listened to her and let her have children.
23 She became pregnant and gave birth to a son.
She said,
"God has taken away my shame."
24 She named him Joseph and said,
"May the LORD give me another son!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"God remembered Rachel" – just like "God remembered Noah." After long years of waiting, God turns to her.

Back then, having no children was seen as a shame. At last, Rachel is free of this burden.

Joseph means "May he take away" and "May he add." Rachel wishes for another son. This wish will come true – but it will cost her her life (Chapter 35).

Later, Joseph becomes one of the most important people in the whole book of Genesis.

Jacob wants to go home VERSES 25–34

25 After Rachel had given birth to Joseph, Jacob said to Laban,
"Let me go.
I want to go back to my own place and to my own country.
26 Give me my wives and my children.
I have worked for you for them.
Let me go.
For you know how hard I have worked for you."
27 Laban said to him,
"If you are pleased with me, please stay here.
I have learned by signs that the LORD has blessed me because of you."
28 He said,
"Tell me what pay you want, and I will give it."
29 Jacob said to him,
"You know how I have worked for you,
and how your livestock have done in my care.
30 You had only a little before I came.
Now it has grown into very much.
The LORD has blessed you wherever I went.
But when will I take care of my own family too?"
31 Laban asked,
"What should I give you?"
Jacob said,
"You don't need to give me anything.
If you will do this one thing for me, then I will again feed your flock and take care of it.
32 Today I will go through your whole flock.
I will take out every speckled and spotted animal,
every black one among the sheep,
and the spotted and speckled ones among the goats.
That will be my pay.
33 So later my honesty will speak for me,
when you come to check my pay.
Every goat with me that is not speckled and spotted,
and every sheep with me that is not black,
will count as stolen."
34 Laban said,
"Good! Let it be as you have said."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob has now worked 14 years for his wives. He wants to go home.

Laban does not want to let him go. He has noticed: Since Jacob came, he keeps getting richer. God blesses him because of Jacob. "Learned by signs" means: Laban used fortune-telling.

Jacob makes an offer that looks very good for Laban: Sheep were mostly white, goats mostly black or brown. There were only a few spotted animals. So Jacob asks only for the rare animals.

Laban cheats – Jacob becomes rich anyway VERSES 35–43

35 But that same day, Laban took out the male goats that were striped and spotted,
all the female goats that were speckled and spotted,
every one that had white on it,
and all the black ones among the sheep.
He gave them to his sons.
36 He put a distance of three days' journey between himself and Jacob.
And Jacob fed the rest of Laban's flocks.
37 Then Jacob took fresh sticks from poplar, almond and plane trees.
He peeled white stripes into them.
So the white wood inside the sticks could be seen.
38 He set the peeled sticks in front of the flocks, in the water troughs
where the flocks came to drink.
The animals mated when they came to drink.
39 So the flocks mated in front of the sticks.
And the flocks had young ones that were striped, speckled and spotted.
40 Jacob separated the lambs.
He turned the faces of the flock toward the striped and all the black animals in Laban's flock.
He kept his own herds apart.
He did not put them with Laban's flock.
41 Whenever the stronger animals of the flock mated,
Jacob laid the sticks in front of their eyes in the water troughs,
so that they would mate among the sticks.
42 But when the animals were weak, he did not put the sticks there.
So the weaker animals were Laban's, and the stronger ones were Jacob's.
43 So the man became very, very rich.
He had large flocks, female servants and male servants, camels and donkeys.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Laban cheats right away: He takes away all the spotted animals before Jacob can get them. Then he takes them three days' journey away.

Jacob tries a trick: Back then, people believed that what an animal sees while mating affects how its young look. Today we know that this is not true. Color is passed on from the parents.

In the next chapter, Jacob himself explains what really happened: God took care of it, as Jacob saw in a dream (Genesis 31:10–12). It was not the sticks that made Jacob rich. It was God.

Jacob is clever and skillful. But he is still a man who works with tricks. Two tricksters meet here: Laban and Jacob.

Chapter 31

Jacob runs away from Laban

Time to go VERSES 1–3

1 Jacob heard what Laban's sons were saying:
"Jacob has taken everything that belonged to our father.
He has become rich from what belonged to our father."
2 Jacob looked at Laban's face.
He saw: Laban was not as friendly toward him as before.
3 Then the LORD said to Jacob,
"Go back to the land of your ancestors, to your relatives.
I will be with you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The mood at Laban's house has turned. Envy and distrust make living together impossible.

Exactly now, God speaks. He reminds Jacob of his promise at Bethel: "I will bring you back into this land" (Genesis 28:15).

Jacob talks with Rachel and Leah VERSES 4–16

4 Jacob sent for Rachel and Leah.
He called them to the field where his flock was.
5 He said to them,
"I see in your father's face that he is not as friendly toward me as before.
But the God of my father has been with me.
6 You know that I have worked for your father with all my strength.
7 But your father has tricked me.
He has changed my pay 10 times.
But God did not let him hurt me.
8 If he said, 'The speckled animals will be your pay,'
then the whole flock gave birth to speckled young.
If he said, 'The striped animals will be your pay,'
then the whole flock gave birth to striped young.
9 So God has taken away your father's livestock and given them to me.
10 At the time when the animals mated, I had a dream.
I looked up and saw:
The male goats that were mating with the flock were striped, speckled and gray-spotted.
11 The angel of God said to me in the dream, 'Jacob!'
I said, 'Here I am.'
12 He said,
'Look up and see:
All the male goats that are mating with the flock are striped, speckled and gray-spotted.
For I have seen everything that Laban is doing to you.
13 I am the God of Bethel.
There you poured oil on a pillar.
There you made a vow to me.
Now get up, leave this land,
and go back to the land where you were born.'"
14 Rachel and Leah answered him,
"Do we still have any share or inheritance in our father's house?
15 Doesn't he treat us like foreigners?
For he has sold us.
And he has also used up the money he got for us.
16 All the riches that God has taken away from our father belong to us and to our children.
So now do whatever God has told you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob tells his wives the whole truth: It was not his sticks that made him rich. It was God. God saw how unfair Laban is, and he made sure that justice was done.

"Changed my pay 10 times" means: again and again, very often.

For the first time, Rachel and Leah agree! Both are disappointed in their father. He treated them like goods. He kept the bride price – Jacob's 14 years of work – for himself, instead of giving some of it to his daughters, as was the custom.

The secret escape VERSES 17–21

17 Then Jacob got up.
He put his sons and his wives on the camels.
18 He drove away all his livestock
and took all the things he had gathered,
the livestock he had gained in Paddan Aram.
He wanted to go to his father Isaac, to the land of Canaan.
19 Laban had gone away to shear his sheep.
Then Rachel stole the teraphim that belonged to her father.
Teraphim are small statues of household gods.
20 Jacob tricked Laban the Syrian.
He did not tell him that he was running away.
21 So he ran away with everything he had.
He got up and crossed the River.
That is the Euphrates River.
And he headed toward the mountains of Gilead.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shearing the sheep was a big event. Laban was busy and far away. It was a good chance to escape.

The household gods (in Hebrew: teraphim) were small statues. People believed they brought luck and protection. Maybe they were also important for the inheritance: Whoever had them counted as the heir of the house.

The Bible does not say why Rachel steals them. Maybe she wanted to take revenge on her father. Maybe she herself was still attached to these gods.

Gilead is a hill country east of the Jordan River.

Laban catches up with Jacob VERSES 22–30

22 On the third day, Laban was told that Jacob had run away.
23 He took his relatives with him and chased after him for seven days.

He caught up with him in the mountains of Gilead.
24 But God came to Laban the Syrian in a dream at night.
He said to him,
"Be careful! Don't say anything to Jacob, either good or bad."
25 Laban caught up with Jacob.
Jacob had set up his tent in the mountains.
Laban and his relatives also set up camp in the mountains of Gilead.
26 Laban said to Jacob,
"What have you done?
You have tricked me.
You have carried away my daughters like prisoners of war!
27 Why did you run away secretly?
Why did you trick me and not tell me?
Then I could have sent you away with joy and with songs,
with tambourine and harp.
28 You did not even let me kiss my grandchildren and my daughters goodbye.
You have acted foolishly.
29 I have the power to hurt you.
But the God of your father spoke to me last night.
He said, 'Be careful! Don't say anything to Jacob, either good or bad.'
30 Now, you wanted to leave, because you longed so much for your father's house.
But why have you stolen my gods?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For seven days, Laban chases after Jacob. He is angry and probably wants to take everything away from Jacob again.

But God steps in and warns Laban in a dream. God protects Jacob, as he promised at Bethel.

"Either good or bad" means: Do not try to make him turn back, neither with threats nor with nice words.

Laban plays the sad, loving father. But you can tell: He thinks mainly about his possessions and his gods.

The search for the household gods VERSES 31–35

31 Jacob answered Laban,
"I was afraid.
I thought you would take your daughters away from me by force.
32 Whoever you find your gods with will not stay alive.
Here, in front of our relatives, look for whatever of yours is with me, and take it."
For Jacob did not know that Rachel had stolen them.
33 Laban went into Jacob's tent,
into Leah's tent,
and into the tent of the two female servants.
But he did not find them.
He came out of Leah's tent and went into Rachel's tent.
34 Now Rachel had taken the teraphim and put them in the camel's saddle.
She sat on them.
Laban felt around the whole tent, but he did not find them.
35 Rachel said to her father,
"Don't be angry, my lord, that I can't stand up in front of you.
For I am having my period."
He searched, but he did not find the teraphim.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob has no idea that Rachel has the gods. With his oath, he puts her life in danger.

Rachel is as sly as her father and her husband. She sits on the gods and says she is having her monthly bleeding. Back then, a woman counted as "unclean" during this time. Then no one wanted to touch her.

The scene is also meant to mock: What kind of gods are these, when a woman sits on them and they cannot help themselves? Here the Bible makes fun of the dead idols.

Jacob lets out his anger VERSES 36–42

36 Then Jacob became angry and argued with Laban.
Jacob said to Laban,
"What have I done wrong?
What is my sin, that you have chased me so angrily?
37 You have felt around in all my things.
What have you found that belongs to your house?
Put it here in front of my relatives and your relatives.
Let them judge between the two of us.
38 I have been with you for 20 years now.
Your sheep and your goats have never lost their young before birth.
And I have never eaten the rams of your flocks.
39 When an animal was torn apart by wild animals, I did not bring it to you.
I paid for the loss myself.
You made me pay for it, whether it was stolen by day or stolen by night.
40 This is how it was for me:
In the day, the heat wore me out, and at night, the frost.
And I could not sleep.
41 I have been in your house for 20 years now.
I worked for you 14 years for your 2 daughters
and 6 years for your flock.
And you have changed my pay 10 times.
42 If the God of my father had not been with me,
the God of Abraham, whom Isaac fears,
then you would surely have sent me away now with empty hands.
But God has seen my misery and the hard work of my hands.
And last night he scolded you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now everything that has built up in Jacob for 20 years bursts out of him.

He was a faithful, honest shepherd. Normally, a shepherd did not have to pay for animals that were torn apart, if he could prove that a wild animal had killed them. Laban still made him pay.

"The God whom Isaac fears" (literally: "the fear of Isaac") is a special, old name for God. Maybe it reminds us of how Isaac experienced God's power on a mountain in the land of Moriah (Chapter 22).

An agreement made of stones VERSES 43–55

43 Laban answered Jacob,
"The daughters are my daughters.

The children are my children.
The flocks are my flocks.
Everything you see is mine!
But what can I do today to these daughters of mine, or to the children they have given birth to?
44 Come, let us make a covenant, you and I.
Let it be a witness between me and you."
A covenant is a binding agreement.
45 Then Jacob took a stone and set it up as a pillar.
46 Jacob said to his relatives,
"Gather stones!"
They took stones and made a heap.
Then they ate there by the heap.
47 Laban called it Jegar Sahadutha.
But Jacob called it Galeed.
48 Laban said,
"This heap is a witness between me and you today."
That is why it was named Galeed,
49 and also Mizpah, because he said,
"May the LORD watch between me and you,
when we are away from each other.
50 If you treat my daughters badly,
or if you take other wives in addition to my daughters –
even if no one is with us: Look, God is a witness between me and you."
51 Laban said to Jacob,
"Look at this heap, and look at the pillar that I have set up between me and you.
52 May this heap be a witness, and may the pillar be a witness:
I will not go past this heap to you,
and you will not go past this heap and this pillar to me,
to do harm.
53 May the God of Abraham and the God of Nahor, the God of their father, judge between us."
Then Jacob swore an oath by the God whom his father Isaac feared.
54 Jacob offered a sacrifice on the mountain.
He invited his relatives to eat a meal.
They ate and stayed the whole night on the mountain.
55 Early in the morning, Laban got up.
He kissed his grandchildren and his daughters and blessed them.
Then Laban left and went back home.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Laban does not admit that he is in the wrong. He even claims: Everything is mine. But he notices: He cannot win against Jacob's God. That is why he suggests a peace agreement.

The heap of stones is a border. Neither of them is to cross it to harm the other.

"Jegar Sahadutha" is Aramaic, Laban's language. "Galeed" is Hebrew, Jacob's language. Both names mean the same: "heap of witness." Already here you can see: Two peoples with two languages part ways.

"Mizpah" means "watchtower." The sentence "May the LORD watch between me and you, when we are away from each other" (verse 49) is often used today as a friendly blessing when people say goodbye. But really it is a warning between two men who do not trust each other.

In the end, they part in peace. At least Laban can say goodbye to his daughters and grandchildren.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 32

Jacob wrestles with God and gets the name Israel

God's army VERSES 1–2

1 Jacob went on his way.
Then the angels of God met him.
2 When Jacob saw them, he said,
"This is God's army."
He named that place Mahanaim.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When Jacob ran away, he saw angels at Bethel (Chapter 28). Now, on the way back, he sees angels again. God has been with him the whole time – on the way there and on the way back.

"Mahanaim" means "two camps": Jacob's camp and God's camp. Jacob is not traveling alone.

Jacob is afraid of Esau VERSES 3–8

3 Jacob sent messengers ahead of him to his brother Esau,
to the land of Seir, the country of Edom.
4 He gave them this command:
"This is what you must say to my lord Esau:
'This is what your servant Jacob says:
I have lived as a foreigner with Laban, and I have stayed there until now.
5 I have cattle, donkeys, flocks, male servants and female servants.
I have sent messengers to tell this to my lord.
I hope that you will be kind to me.'"
6 The messengers came back to Jacob and said,
"We came to your brother Esau.
He is coming to meet you.
And 400 men are with him."
7 Then Jacob was very afraid and very upset.
He divided the people who were with him into two groups.
He also divided the flocks, the herds and the camels.
8 He said,
"If Esau comes to the one group and attacks it,
then the group that is left can escape."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

20 years have passed. Back then, Esau wanted to kill Jacob. Jacob does not know whether his brother has forgiven him.

Jacob calls Esau "my lord" and himself "your servant." In a way, he turns the stolen blessing around: The blessing said

that Esau would serve Jacob. Now Jacob makes himself small.

400 men – that is a small army. Jacob fears the worst.

His plan is typical of Jacob: clever and careful. He divides everything into two groups, so that at least half survive.

Jacob prays VERSES 9–12

9 Then Jacob prayed:
"God of my father Abraham, and God of my father Isaac!
LORD, you said to me,
'Go back to your country and to your relatives, and I will do good to you.'
10 I am not worthy of even the smallest of all the kindness and faithfulness
that you have shown to me, your servant.
For I crossed this Jordan with only my walking stick.
And now I have become two groups.
11 Please save me from the hand of my brother, from the hand of Esau!
For I am afraid of him.
He might come and attack me, and the mothers together with the children.
12 You said,
'I will surely do good to you.
I will make your descendants as many as the sand of the sea,
which can't be counted because there is so much of it.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is Jacob's first real prayer in the Bible. And it is a beautiful prayer.

Jacob has become humble: "I am not worthy." He knows: Everything he has is a gift.

He honestly tells God: "I am afraid of him."

And he reminds God of his own promises. You may do that in prayer: hold God to his word.

Gifts for Esau VERSES 13–21

13 Jacob stayed there that night.
Then he took a gift for his brother Esau from the things he had with him:
14 200 female goats and 20 male goats,
200 female sheep and 20 rams,
15 30 camels that were nursing their young, together with their young,
40 cows and 10 bulls,
20 female donkeys and 10 young donkeys.
16 He gave them to his servants, each herd by itself.
He said to his servants,
"Go on ahead of me.
Leave a space between one herd and the next."
17 He gave a command to the first servant:
"When my brother Esau meets you and asks you,
'Whose servant are you? Where are you going? And whose animals are these in front of you?'
18 Then you must say,
'They belong to your servant Jacob.
They are a gift sent to my lord Esau.
And look, he himself is coming behind us.'"
19 He gave the same command to the second servant and to the third,
and to all who followed the herds.
He said,
"This is how you must speak to Esau when you find him.
20 And you must say,
'Not only that, but look, your servant Jacob is coming behind us.'"
For Jacob thought,
"I will calm him with the gift that goes ahead of me.
After that, I will see his face.
Maybe he will accept me."
21 So the gift went on ahead of him.
But he himself stayed in the camp that night.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

All together these are 550 animals – a huge gift. Jacob wants to put his brother in a kind mood.

The herds go one after the other, with space between them. So Esau is surprised again and again, and his anger can calm down step by step.

Jacob prays – and at the same time he makes clever plans. Both belong together: trusting God and doing the right thing yourself.

The fight at night VERSES 22–32

22 That same night, Jacob got up.
He took his 2 wives, his 2 female servants and his 11 sons.
He crossed the river Jabbok at a shallow place.
23 He took them and sent them across the stream.
He also sent across everything he had.
24 Jacob was left alone.
A man wrestled with him there until the day began to dawn.
25 The man saw that he could not win against Jacob.
So he struck the socket of Jacob's hip.
And Jacob's hip was pulled out of joint while he wrestled with him.
26 The man said,
"Let me go, for the day is dawning."
Jacob said,
"I won't let you go unless you bless me."
27 The man asked him,
"What is your name?"
He said,
"Jacob."
28 The man said,
"Your name will no longer be Jacob, but Israel.
For you have fought with God and with people, and you have won."
29 Jacob asked him,
"Please tell me your name."
He said,
"Why do you ask what my name is?"
And he blessed him there.
30 Jacob named the place Peniel.
For he said,
"I have seen God face to face,
and yet my life was spared."

31 The sun rose on him as he passed Peniel.
He was limping because of his hip.
32 That is why the people of Israel do not eat the sinew of the hip, which lies on the hip socket, to this very day.
For the man struck Jacob's hip socket at this sinew.
A sinew is a tough cord in the body.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most mysterious stories in the Bible. Jacob is alone at night, full of fear of the next day. Suddenly a stranger wrestles with him.

In the end Jacob realizes: This "man" was God himself. Some interpreters say: It was an angel. Jacob himself says: "I have seen God face to face."

All his life Jacob has fought: with Esau even in their mother's womb, with his father, with Laban. Now he fights with God.

Jacob is hurt, but he does not give up. He holds on: "I won't let you go unless you bless me." Earlier he got the blessing by trickery. Now he honestly asks for it – from God himself.

The question "What is your name?" is important. When his father asked him that, Jacob lied and said "Esau." Now he tells the truth: "Jacob" – "cheater." He admits who he is.

Then he gets a new name: **Israel**. That means "God fights" or "He fought with God." From now on, the whole people is named after him: Israel.

"Peniel" (also Penuel) means "face of God." People believed: Whoever sees God must die. Jacob is amazed that he is alive.

Jacob comes out of the fight as the winner, but he limps. Whoever truly meets God does not stay the same. His strength no longer lies in his tricks, but in God's blessing.

To this day, many Jews do not eat this sinew (the sciatic nerve) of cattle or sheep. This reminds them of this fight.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 33

Jacob and Esau make peace

Meeting again VERSES 1–7

1 Jacob looked up.
Look! Esau was coming, and 400 men were with him.
Jacob divided the children among Leah, Rachel and the 2 female servants.
2 He put the servants and their children in front.
Behind them he put Leah and her children.
And at the very back he put Rachel and Joseph.
3 He himself went ahead of them.
He bowed down to the ground seven times, until he came near to his brother.
4 Esau ran to meet him.
He hugged him, threw his arms around his neck and kissed him.
And they both cried.
5 Esau looked up and saw the women and the children.
He asked,
"Who are these with you?"
Jacob said,
"They are the children whom God has kindly given to your servant."
6 Then the servants came near with their children, and they bowed down.
7 Leah also came near with her children, and they bowed down.
After them, Joseph and Rachel came near, and they bowed down.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob is still afraid. He puts the people he loves most – Rachel and Joseph – at the very back, where they are safest. That shows how unequally he loves his family. The others surely feel that.

But then Jacob himself goes to the front. He no longer hides behind gifts and messengers. He faces his brother.

Bowing seven times was how people bowed before a king back then. Jacob shows: I bow to you.

And then the miracle: Esau runs, hugs, kisses – and both of them cry. No anger, no revenge. 20 years of hatred are gone. God has answered Jacob's prayer.

Later Jesus tells the parable of the lost son. There it says, in almost the same words, that the father ran to his son, threw his arms around his neck and kissed him (Luke 15:20).

The gift VERSES 8–11

8 Esau asked,
"What do you mean by all these herds that I met?"
Jacob said,
"I wanted my lord to be kind to me."
9 Esau said,
"I have enough, my brother.
Keep what you have for yourself."
10 Jacob said,
"No, please!
If you are kind to me, then accept my gift from me.
For I have seen your face, as one sees the face of God.
And you have welcomed me kindly.
11 Please take the gift that I have brought to you.
For God has been kind to me, and I have enough."
Jacob kept urging him until he took it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Esau calls Jacob "my brother." Jacob still says "my lord." Esau has already forgiven. Jacob can hardly believe it yet.

"I have seen your face, as one sees the face of God." Jacob has just seen God at Peniel. Now, in the face of his brother who has made peace with him, he sees something of God's grace.

In Hebrew, the word for "gift" in verse 11 is actually "blessing." In a way, Jacob gives back the stolen blessing. He makes up for what he can.

Separate ways VERSES 12–17

12 Esau said,
"Let us set out and go on our way.
I will go ahead of you."

13 Jacob said to him,
"My lord knows that the children are still small and weak.
And the flocks and herds with me are nursing their young.
If they are driven too hard for even one day, all the flocks will die.
14 Please let my lord go on ahead of his servant.
I will follow slowly,
at the pace of the livestock in front of me and at the pace of the children,
until I come to my lord in Seir."
15 Esau said,
"Then let me leave some of my people with you."
Jacob said,
"Why do that?
It is enough for me that my lord is kind to me."
16 So that day Esau went back on his way to Seir.
17 But Jacob traveled to Succoth.
There he built himself a house.
And he made shelters for his livestock.
That is why the place is called Succoth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob is a caring shepherd: He thinks of the small and weak ones in his flock.

But he does not go to Esau in Seir, as he said he would. He goes in another direction. Maybe he does not fully trust the peace yet. Maybe he also knows: God has called him into the land of Canaan, not to Seir.

The brothers have made peace, but they live apart. Sometimes that is the best way to keep peace.

"Succoth" means "shelters" or "booths." Later the Jews celebrate a festival with this name: the Feast of Booths.

Jacob comes to Shechem VERSES 18–20

18 On his way from Paddan Aram, Jacob arrived safely at the city of Shechem in the land of Canaan.
He set up his camp in front of the city.
19 He bought the piece of land where he had set up his tent.
He bought it from the sons of Hamor, Shechem's father.
He paid 100 pieces of money for it.
20 He built an altar there.
He called it El Elohe Israel.
That means: "God, the God of Israel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Safely" – in Hebrew there is a word here that is related to "shalom": peace, whole, unharmed. God has kept his promise from Bethel: Jacob has come back safe and sound (Genesis 28:21).

Like Abraham, Jacob also buys a piece of land in the promised land.

"El" is an old word for God. With the name of the altar, Jacob says: This God is **my** God. He already uses his new name, Israel. At Bethel he had promised that the LORD would be his God. Now he keeps his promise.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 34

The wrong done to Dinah and her brothers' revenge

Dinah is raped VERSES 1–5

1 Dinah was the daughter whom Leah had given birth to for Jacob.
She went out to visit the young women of the land.
2 Shechem saw her.
He was the son of Hamor the Hivite.
Hamor was the prince of the land.
Shechem took her, slept with her and forced her.
3 After that, his heart was attached to Dinah, Jacob's daughter.
He loved the young woman and spoke kindly to her.
4 Shechem said to his father Hamor,
"Get me this young woman as my wife!"
5 Jacob heard that Shechem had dishonored his daughter Dinah.
But his sons were with his livestock in the field.
So Jacob kept silent until they came home.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter tells of a terrible crime: Dinah is raped. The Bible does not keep quiet about such things. It calls wrong by its name.

Dinah herself never speaks in the whole chapter. No one asks her how she is. That stands out, and it is sad. All the men talk about her, none of them with her.

Afterwards Shechem claims that he loves her. But he does not say he is sorry, and he does not let her go home. She stays in his house (see verse 26).

Jacob keeps silent. He does nothing for his daughter. Maybe because she is Leah's daughter, not Rachel's.

Hamor's offer VERSES 6–12

6 Hamor, Shechem's father, went out to Jacob to talk with him.
7 Jacob's sons came in from the field when they heard it.
The men were deeply hurt and very angry.
For Shechem had done a shameful thing in Israel.
He had slept with Jacob's daughter.
Such a thing must not be done.
8 Hamor talked with them and said,
"My son Shechem longs with all his heart for your daughter.
Please give her to him as his wife.
9 Join with us through marriage.
Give your daughters to us, and take our daughters for yourselves.
10 You can live with us.
The land is open to you.
Live here, trade here and get property in the land."
11 Shechem said to Dinah's father and to her brothers,
"Please be kind to me!

Whatever you tell me, I will give.
12 Ask me for a very high bride price.
I will give whatever you ask of me.
Only give me the young woman as my wife."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here, for the first time in the Bible, the words "in Israel" appear. Jacob's family is now "Israel," a people with its own values.

Hamor talks as if nothing bad had happened. He talks only about marriage and business. He does not say he is sorry for what his son has done.

Shechem wants to make everything right with money. But a wrong like this cannot simply be paid for.

The brothers' trick VERSES 13–24

13 Jacob's sons answered Shechem and his father Hamor with a trick.
For Shechem had dishonored their sister Dinah.
14 They said to them,
"We can't do this.
We can't give our sister to a man who is not circumcised.
That would be a disgrace for us.
15 We will agree only on one condition:
You must become like us.
Every male among you must be circumcised.
16 Then we will give our daughters to you,
and we will take your daughters for ourselves.
Then we will live with you and become one people.
17 But if you do not listen to us and are not circumcised,
then we will take our sister and leave."
To be circumcised means: The foreskin is cut off. It is a sign of belonging to God.
18 Their words pleased Hamor and his son Shechem.
19 The young man did not wait to do it.
For he was delighted with Jacob's daughter.
And he was the most respected person in his father's whole family.
20 Hamor and his son Shechem came to the gate of their city.
There they talked with the men of their city.
They said,
21 "These men are peaceful toward us.
So let them live in the land and trade in it.
Look, the land is large enough for them.
Let us take their daughters as our wives, and let us give them our daughters.
22 But the men will agree to live with us and become one people only on one condition:
Every male among us must be circumcised, just as they are circumcised.
23 Then won't their livestock, their property and all their animals be ours?
Let us just agree with them.
Then they will live with us."
24 All the men who went out of the gate of his city listened to Hamor and to his son Shechem.
And every male was circumcised, all who went out of the gate of his city.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The brothers misuse circumcision, the holy sign of the covenant with God, for a sneaky plan.

But Hamor and Shechem are not honest either. To their own people they say: Soon all their property will be ours! Each side wants to take advantage of the other.

Back then, important matters were discussed and decided in the gate of the city.

The bloodbath VERSES 25–31

25 On the third day, the men were in great pain.
Then two of Jacob's sons, Simeon and Levi, Dinah's brothers, each took his sword.
They attacked the city, which did not expect anything, and killed all the males.
26 They also killed Hamor and his son Shechem with the sword.
They took Dinah out of Shechem's house and went away.
27 Then Jacob's sons came upon the dead and robbed the city.
For the people there had dishonored their sister.
28 They took their flocks, their herds and their donkeys, everything that was in the city and in the field.
29 They took all their wealth.
They took all their little children and their wives as prisoners.
And they robbed everything that was in the houses.
30 Then Jacob said to Simeon and Levi,
"You have brought trouble on me.
Now the people who live in the land, the Canaanites and the Perizzites, hate me.
I have only a few people.
They will gather together against me and attack me.
Then I will be destroyed, I and my whole family."
31 But they said,
"Should he treat our sister like a prostitute?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Simeon and Levi are Dinah's full brothers – both are sons of Leah. They take revenge.

But their revenge goes far beyond any limit. For the crime of one man, they kill a whole city. The other brothers rob everything and take women and children as prisoners. Innocent people suffer for the deed of one person.

That reminds us of Lamech in Chapter 4: Violence creates more and more violence.

Jacob thinks only of his own safety. He says no word about Dinah and no word about the people who were killed.

The brothers are not completely wrong with their question: The wrong done to Dinah was terrible. But their answer to it was also wrong.

The Bible ends the chapter without a verdict. But at the end of his life, Jacob will sharply blame Simeon and Levi for this deed: "Their anger is cursed, because it was fierce" (Genesis 49:7).

GENESIS

CHAPTER 35

Back to Bethel – Rachel and Isaac die

Away with the foreign gods VERSES 1–5

1 God said to Jacob,
"Get up, go up to Bethel and live there.
Build an altar there to the God who appeared to you
when you ran away from your brother Esau."
2 Then Jacob said to his household and to all who were
with him,
"Get rid of the foreign gods that you have with you.
Make yourselves clean and change your clothes.
3 Let us get up and go up to Bethel.
There I will build an altar to the God who answered me
when I was in trouble.
He was with me on the way that I went."
4 So they gave Jacob all the foreign gods that they had,
and the rings that were in their ears.
Jacob hid them under the oak tree near Shechem.
5 Then they traveled on.
A terror from God came over the cities all around
them.
So they did not chase the sons of Jacob.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the terrible events in Shechem, God calls Jacob back to the beginning: to Bethel, where God met him for the first time.

Jacob notices: His family still has foreign gods with them, for example the household gods that Rachel stole. Now he cleans up. Whoever truly wants to meet God must let go of what separates them from God.

Back then, people often wore earrings as lucky charms, connected with foreign gods.

Putting on fresh clothes is a sign of a new beginning.

Jacob was afraid of revenge because of Shechem. But God protects him.

Back at Bethel VERSES 6–8

6 So Jacob came to Luz (that is, Bethel) in the land of
Canaan,
he and all the people who were with him.
7 He built an altar there
and named the place El Beth El.
For there God had shown himself to him when he ran
away from his brother.
8 Deborah, Rebekah's nurse, died there.
She was buried below Bethel under the oak tree.
That is why it was named Allon Bacuth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"El Beth El" means "God of Bethel." Now Jacob no longer honors only the place, but the God who met him there.

Deborah was Rebekah's nurse. She had come with Rebekah from Haran (Genesis 24:59). She probably moved to Jacob later. Her death is mentioned on purpose – she was a loved person.

"Allon Bacuth" means "oak of weeping."

God blesses Jacob once more VERSES 9–15

9 When Jacob had come from Paddan Aram, God
appeared to him again and blessed him.
10 God said to him,
"Your name is Jacob.
But your name will not be Jacob any more. Your name
will be Israel."
So he named him Israel.
11 God said to him,
"I am God Almighty.
Have many children and become many.
A nation, and a whole community of nations, will
come from you.
And kings will come from your own body.
12 The land that I gave to Abraham and Isaac, I will give to
you.
And I will give the land to your descendants after you."
13 Then God went up from him, at the place where he had
spoken with him.
14 Jacob set up a pillar at the place where God had spoken
with him, a pillar of stone.
He poured out a drink offering on it, and he poured oil
on it.
15 Jacob named the place where God had spoken with him
"Bethel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God confirms the new name Israel and the blessing. They are the same promises that Abraham and Isaac received.

A "drink offering" is a drink, mostly wine, that is poured out for God. It is a sign of thankfulness.

Jacob's path in life is like a circle: It began at Bethel, when he was on the run. Now he comes back to Bethel as a changed man.

Benjamin is born – Rachel dies VERSES 16–20

16 They traveled on from Bethel.
There was still some distance to go to Ephrath.
Then Rachel began to give birth.
The birth was very hard.
17 When the birth was so hard, the midwife said to her,
"Don't be afraid!
Now you will have another son."
18 Rachel was dying.
As her life was leaving her, she named her son Benoni.
But his father named him Benjamin.
19 So Rachel died.
She was buried on the way to Ephrath. Ephrath is also
called Bethlehem.
20 Jacob set up a pillar on her grave.
It is the pillar of Rachel's grave to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At Joseph's birth, Rachel had wished for another son (Genesis 30:24). Her wish comes true – but she dies giving birth.

"Benoni" means "son of my pain." Jacob does not want his son to carry this sad name all his life. He names him "Benjamin." That means "son of the right hand" or "son of good fortune."

Benjamin is the only son of Jacob who is born in the land of Canaan.

This is the first time Bethlehem is mentioned in the Bible. Later, King David is born there – and Jesus.

Rachel's grave near Bethlehem is still a place today where many people pray.

Reuben and the 12 sons of Jacob VERSES 21–26

21 Israel traveled on.
He set up his tent beyond the tower of Eder.
22 While Israel was living in that land, Reuben went and slept with Bilhah, his father's concubine.
A concubine is a wife of lower rank.
And Israel heard about it.

Jacob had 12 sons.

23 The sons of Leah were:
Reuben, Jacob's firstborn, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar and Zebulun.
24 The sons of Rachel were:
Joseph and Benjamin.
25 The sons of Bilhah, Rachel's servant, were:
Dan and Naphtali.
26 The sons of Zilpah, Leah's servant, were:
Gad and Asher.
These are the sons of Jacob who were born to him in Paddan Aram.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Tower of Eder" means "tower of the flock."

Reuben sleeps with Bilhah, his father's concubine. That is a serious wrong. Back then, such a thing also meant: I want to take over my father's power. Because of this, Reuben later loses his rights as the firstborn (Genesis 49:3–4).

Jacob hears about it – and keeps silent again. Just as he kept silent about Dinah.

The list of the 12 sons is very important: The 12 tribes of Israel come from them.

Actually, Benjamin was not born in Paddan Aram, but near Bethlehem. The list simply counts them all together.

Isaac dies VERSES 27–29

27 Jacob came to his father Isaac at Mamre, near Kiriath Arba (that is, Hebron),
where Abraham and Isaac had lived as foreigners.
28 Isaac lived to be 180 years old.
29 Then Isaac breathed his last and died.
He was gathered to his people, old and full of days.
That means: He had lived a long and full life.
His sons Esau and Jacob buried him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob sees his father again. His mother Rebekah is not mentioned. She has probably already died, without seeing her favorite son one more time.

Just as with Abraham, when Isaac and Ishmael buried their father together, Esau and Jacob also bury their father together. At their father's grave, the brothers who have made peace stand side by side.

Isaac lives to be 180 years old – older than Abraham.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 36

Esau's family – the people of Edom

Esau's wives and sons VERSES 1–5

1 This is the family history of Esau. Esau is Edom.
2 Esau took his wives from the daughters of Canaan:
Adah, the daughter of Elon the Hittite,
and Oholibamah, the daughter of Anah and granddaughter of Zibeon the Hivite,
3 and Basemath, Ishmael's daughter and the sister of Nebaioth.
4 Adah gave birth to Eliphaz for Esau.
Basemath gave birth to Reuel.
5 Oholibamah gave birth to Jeush, Jalam and Korah.
These are the sons of Esau who were born to him in the land of Canaan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible also tells about Esau and his descendants. Esau is not forgotten. A people comes from him too, just as Isaac had blessed him.

The names of the wives do not quite match Chapters 26 and 28. There they are called Judith, Basemath and Mahalath. Probably some women had two names. That was common back then. Scholars also explain it this way: Different old traditions come together here.

Esau moves away VERSES 6–8

6 Esau took his wives, his sons and his daughters,
and all the people of his household,
his livestock and all his animals,
and all the things he had gathered in the land of Canaan.
And he went into another land, away from his brother Jacob.
7 For they owned too much to live together.
The land where they lived as foreigners could not feed them, because of their livestock.
8 So Esau lived in the hill country of Seir.
Esau is Edom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

It is like with Abraham and Lot (Chapter 13): too many possessions, too little room. The brothers part ways – this time in peace.

The land of Canaan remains for Jacob. Esau moves to the hill country of Seir, southeast of the Dead Sea, in today's Jordan.

Esau's sons and grandsons VERSES 9–14

9 This is the family history of Esau, the father of the Edomites in the hill country of Seir.

10 These are the names of Esau's sons:
Eliphaz, the son of Adah, Esau's wife,
and Reuel, the son of Basemath, Esau's wife.
11 The sons of Eliphaz were:
Teman, Omar, Zepho, Gatam and Kenaz.
12 Timna was a concubine of Eliphaz, Esau's son.
A concubine is a wife of lower rank.
She gave birth to Amalek for Eliphaz.
These are the descendants of Adah, Esau's wife.
13 These are the sons of Reuel:
Nahath, Zerah, Shammah and Mizzah.
These were the descendants of Basemath, Esau's wife.
14 These were the sons of Oholibamah, Esau's wife.
She was the daughter of Anah and granddaughter of Zibeon.
She gave birth to Jeush, Jalam and Korah for Esau.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Amalek becomes important later. His descendants, the Amalekites, become great enemies of Israel (Exodus 17).

Later, Teman became the name of an area in Edom. According to tradition, Eliphaz, one of Job's friends, also lived there (Job 2:11).

The chiefs of Esau VERSES 15–19

15 These are the chiefs among the sons of Esau.
A chief is the leader of a tribe.
The sons of Eliphaz, Esau's firstborn, were:
chief Teman, chief Omar, chief Zepho, chief Kenaz,
16 chief Korah, chief Gatam and chief Amalek.
These are the chiefs who came from Eliphaz in the land of Edom.
These are the sons of Adah.
17 These are the sons of Reuel, Esau's son:
chief Nahath, chief Zerah, chief Shammah and chief Mizzah.
These are the chiefs who came from Reuel in the land of Edom.
These are the sons of Basemath, Esau's wife.
18 These are the sons of Oholibamah, Esau's wife:
chief Jeush, chief Jalam and chief Korah.
These are the chiefs who came from Oholibamah, the daughter of Anah, Esau's wife.
19 These are the sons of Esau (that is, Edom), and these are their chiefs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A "chief" is the head of a tribe or a large clan. In the beginning, Edom was not a kingdom, but a group of tribes with their own leaders.

The first people of Seir VERSES 20–30

20 These are the sons of Seir the Horite, who already lived in the land:
Lotan, Shobal, Zibeon, Anah,
21 Dishon, Ezer and Dishan.
These are the chiefs of the Horites, the descendants of Seir, in the land of Edom.
22 The children of Lotan were Hori and Heman.
Lotan's sister was Timna.
23 These are the children of Shobal:
Alvan, Manahath, Ebal, Shepho and Onam.
24 These are the children of Zibeon:
Aiah and Anah.
This is the Anah who found the hot springs in the wilderness,
while he was feeding the donkeys of his father Zibeon.
25 These are the children of Anah:
Dishon and Oholibamah, the daughter of Anah.
26 These are the children of Dishon:
Hemdan, Eshban, Ithran and Cheran.
27 These are the children of Ezer:
Bilhan, Zaavan and Akan.
28 These are the children of Dishan:
Uz and Aran.
29 These are the chiefs of the Horites:
chief Lotan, chief Shobal, chief Zibeon, chief Anah,
30 chief Dishon, chief Ezer and chief Dishan.
These are the chiefs of the Horites, by their chiefs, in the land of Seir.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before Esau came, the Horites lived in Seir. Esau's family mixed with them: His wife Oholibamah and the concubine Timna come from this family.

The little story of Anah and the hot springs shows: These lists are not dry lists. Behind every name there is a person with a story. To this day, there are hot springs in the area of Edom.

The kings of Edom VERSES 31–39

31 These are the kings who ruled in the land of Edom,
before any king ruled over the people of Israel:
32 Bela, the son of Beor, was king in Edom.
His city was named Dinhabah.
33 Bela died.
Then Jobab became king in his place. He was the son of Zerah from Bozrah.
34 Jobab died.
Then Husham became king in his place. He came from the land of the Temanites.
35 Husham died.
Then Hadad became king in his place. He was the son of Bedad.
He had defeated Midian in the country of Moab.
His city was named Avith.
36 Hadad died.
Then Samlah became king in his place. He came from Masrekah.
37 Samlah died.
Then Shaul became king in his place. He came from Rehoboth by the river.
38 Shaul died.
Then Baal Hanan became king in his place. He was the son of Achbor.
39 Baal Hanan, the son of Achbor, died.
Then Hadar became king in his place.
His city was named Pau.
His wife was named Mehetabel. She was the daughter of Matred and the granddaughter of Mezahab.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Edom already had kings when there were none in Israel yet. Israel's first king, Saul, came much later.

Notice: No king is the son of the king before him. Each comes from a different city. So there was no fixed royal family.

God had promised Abraham that kings would come from him (Genesis 17:6). With Esau, this comes true early. With Jacob, it still takes a long time.

The chiefs of Esau once more VERSES 40–43

40 These are the names of the chiefs who came from Esau,
by their families and their places, by their names:
chief Timna, chief Alvah, chief Jetheth,
41 chief Oholibamah, chief Elah, chief Pinon,
42 chief Kenaz, chief Teman, chief Mibzar,
43 chief Magdiel and chief Iram.
These are the chiefs of Edom, by the places where they lived in the land they owned.
This is Esau, the father of the Edomites.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This second list names the chiefs by the places where they lived. Some names are probably names of areas or cities.

With this chapter, the Bible says goodbye to Esau. From now on, it is about Jacob and his sons – above all about Joseph.

The Edomites and the Israelites remain neighbors and brother peoples. Their history is often difficult. But the book of Deuteronomy says: Do not hate an Edomite, for he is your brother (Deuteronomy 23:7; in some Bibles 23:8).

GENESIS

CHAPTER 37

Joseph is sold by his brothers

The favorite son VERSES 1–4

1 Jacob lived in the land of Canaan, where his father had lived as a foreigner.
2 This is the family history of Jacob.
Joseph was 17 years old.
He was feeding the flock with his brothers.
He was a young helper with the sons of Bilhah and Zilpah, his father's wives.
Joseph brought a bad report about them to their father.
3 Israel loved Joseph more than all his other children.
For Joseph was the son of his old age.
He made him a robe of many colors.
4 His brothers saw that their father loved him more than all his brothers.
So they hated him.
They could not speak a friendly word to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the long story of Joseph begins. It goes on until the end of the book of Genesis.

Jacob makes the same mistake as his parents: He has a favorite son. And he shows it openly to everyone. Joseph is the first son of his beloved Rachel.

The colorful robe was a precious piece of clothing. It showed: This son is something special. Maybe he was meant to be the heir one day. Shepherds who do dirty work did not wear such things.

Joseph tells on his brothers to his father. That does not make him more popular with them either.

Joseph's dreams VERSES 5–11

5 Joseph had a dream.
He told it to his brothers.
Then they hated him even more.
6 He said to them,
"Please listen to this dream that I had:
7 Look, we were tying up sheaves in the field.
And look: My sheaf got up and stood upright.
And look: Your sheaves gathered around and bowed down to my sheaf."
8 His brothers said to him,
"Do you really want to be king over us?
Do you really want to rule over us?"
And they hated him even more because of his dreams and because of his words.
9 Then he had yet another dream.
He told this one to his brothers too.
He said,
"Look, I have had another dream:
Look, the sun and the moon and 11 stars bowed down to me."
10 He told it to his father and to his brothers.
His father scolded him.
He said to him,
"What is this dream that you have had?
Will I and your mother and your brothers really come and bow down to the ground before you?"
11 His brothers were jealous of him.
But his father kept these words in mind.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sheaves are bundles of grain stalks that are tied together at harvest time.

Joseph's dreams say: One day the whole family will bow down before him. That will really happen – but very differently from what everyone thinks.

Joseph is young and tells his dreams without thinking of others. He does not notice how much he hurts his brothers with them.

The sun and the moon stand for father and mother, the 11 stars for the 11 brothers. Actually, Rachel has already died. Maybe Leah is meant here, or the dream simply speaks of "the parents."

Jacob scolds him, but he does not forget the dreams. He suspects: Maybe God is behind them.

Joseph looks for his brothers VERSES 12–17

12 His brothers had gone to Shechem to feed their father's flock.
13 Israel said to Joseph,
"Your brothers are feeding the flock at Shechem, aren't they?
Come, I will send you to them."

Joseph said to him,
"Here I am."
14 Israel said to him,
"Go now and see whether your brothers are doing well, and the flock too.
Then come back and tell me."
So he sent him away from the valley of Hebron.
And Joseph came to Shechem.
15 A man found him.
And look: Joseph was wandering around in the field.
The man asked him,
"What are you looking for?"
16 Joseph said,
"I am looking for my brothers.
Please tell me where they are feeding the flock."
17 The man said,
"They have left here.
I heard them say, 'Let's go to Dothan.'"
So Joseph went after his brothers.
And he found them in Dothan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shechem lies about 50 miles north of Hebron. Dothan lies about 12 miles farther. That is a long journey for a young man alone.

Of all places, Shechem – where the brothers had attacked the city (Chapter 34). Maybe that is why Jacob is worried.

The unknown man in the field seems to be a coincidence. But without him, Joseph would not have found his brothers. God's way often goes through such small "coincidences."

The brothers' plan VERSES 18–24

18 The brothers saw him from far away.
Even before he came near them, they made a plan to kill him.
19 They said to one another,
"Look, here comes this dreamer!
20 Come on, let's kill him and throw him into one of the pits.
Then we will say, 'A wild animal has eaten him.'
Then we will see what becomes of his dreams!"
21 Reuben heard it.
He saved him from their hands.
He said,
"Let's not kill him."
22 Reuben said to them,
"Do not shed any blood!
Throw him into this pit here in the wilderness.
But do not lay a hand on him."
For he wanted to save him from their hands and bring him back to his father.
23 When Joseph came to his brothers, they tore his robe off him,
the robe of many colors that he was wearing.
24 They took him and threw him into the pit.
The pit was empty. There was no water in it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A pit like this is a deep hole in the rock where people collected rainwater. When it is empty, you cannot get out by yourself.

Envy has turned into hatred, and hatred into a plan to murder. Just like with Cain and Abel.

Reuben is the oldest brother. He feels responsible and wants to save Joseph. But he does not dare to stand up openly against the others.

The first thing the brothers do: They tear off his colorful robe – the sign that their father prefers him.

Joseph is sold VERSES 25–28

25 Then they sat down to eat a meal.
They looked up and saw a caravan of Ishmaelites coming from Gilead.
A caravan is a group of traders traveling together.
Their camels were carrying spices, balm and myrrh.
They were on their way down to Egypt to take it there.
26 Judah said to his brothers,
"What do we gain if we kill our brother and hide his blood?
27 Come, let's sell him to the Ishmaelites.
Then we do not have to lay our hands on him.
For he is our brother, our own flesh."
His brothers listened to him.
28 Midianite traders passed by.
They pulled Joseph up out of the pit.
They sold Joseph to the Ishmaelites for 20 pieces of silver.
And the traders brought Joseph to Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The brothers calmly sit down to eat, while their brother cries for help in the pit (see Genesis 42:21). That shows how hard their hearts have become.

Balm and myrrh are valuable, sweet-smelling resins from plants. People used them as medicine and for perfume.

Judah does not want to kill Joseph – but only because you can make money with a living slave. That is hardly better.

Here both "Ishmaelites" and "Midianites" are named. Maybe it was a mixed caravan. Maybe "Ishmaelites" was a general word for traveling traders. Scholars also explain it this way: Two old stories have been joined together here.

Back then, 20 pieces of silver was the usual price for a young slave.

Christians think here of Jesus, who was betrayed by Judas for 30 pieces of silver.

The father is deceived VERSES 29–36

29 Reuben came back to the pit.
He saw that Joseph was not in the pit.
Then he tore his clothes.
30 He went back to his brothers and said,
"The boy is gone!
And I – where can I go now?"
31 Then they took Joseph's robe.
They killed a male goat and dipped the robe in the blood.
32 They took the robe of many colors and brought it to their father.
They said,
"We found this.
Please look at it and see whether it is your son's robe or not."
33 Jacob recognized it and said,
"It is my son's robe!

A wild animal has eaten him.
Joseph has surely been torn to pieces!"
34 Jacob tore his clothes.
He put sackcloth around his waist.
And he mourned for his son for many days.
35 All his sons and all his daughters came to comfort him.
But he refused to be comforted.
He said,
"No, I will go down to my son in Sheol (the world of the dead), still mourning."
So his father cried for him.
36 But the Midianites sold Joseph in Egypt to Potiphar.
Potiphar was an officer of Pharaoh, the captain of the guard.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, tearing your clothes was a sign of great pain and sorrow. People wore "sackcloth" in times of mourning: rough, scratchy clothing made of goat hair.

Jacob once tricked his father with a goatskin and Esau's clothes (Chapter 27). Now he himself is tricked with a male goat and his son's robe. And again the sons say, "Please look at it and see ..." – almost the same words.

The brothers do not lie directly. They let their father come to the wrong conclusion himself. That is especially cruel.

People imagined "Sheol," the world of the dead, as a dark place under the earth where all the dead go.

The last sentence is like a ray of light: Joseph is alive. He is in Egypt. The story is not over yet.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 38

Judah and Tamar

Judah's family VERSES 1–5

1 At that time, Judah left his brothers and went down.
He stayed with a man from Adullam whose name was Hirah.
2 There Judah saw the daughter of a Canaanite man named Shua.
He took her as his wife and slept with her.
3 She became pregnant and gave birth to a son.
Judah named him Er.
4 She became pregnant again and gave birth to a son.
She named him Onan.
5 Then she had one more son.
She named him Shelah.
Judah was at Chezib when she gave birth to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the Joseph story, a very different story suddenly comes. It is about Judah – the brother who suggested selling Joseph.

Judah leaves his brothers and marries a Canaanite woman. Abraham and Isaac did not want that for their sons.

The story shows how Judah changes. That will become very important later in the Joseph story.

Tamar becomes a widow twice VERSES 6–11

6 Judah took a wife for Er, his firstborn.
Her name was Tamar.
7 But Er, Judah's firstborn, was wicked in the LORD's eyes.
So the LORD put him to death.
8 Then Judah said to Onan,
"Sleep with your brother's wife.
Do your duty to her as the brother of her husband.
Give your brother descendants."
9 But Onan knew that the children would not count as his own.
So whenever he slept with his brother's wife, he let his seed fall on the ground.
He did this so that he would not give his brother descendants.
10 What he did was evil in the LORD's eyes.
So the LORD put him to death too.
11 Then Judah said to Tamar, his daughter-in-law,
"Stay as a widow in your father's house,
until my son Shelah is grown up."
For he thought, "Otherwise he might die too, like his brothers."
So Tamar went and lived in her father's house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then there was an important rule: If a man died without children, his brother was to marry the widow. The first child then counted as the child of the man who had died. So his name lived on, and the widow was taken care of. This is called "levirate marriage" (written down later in Deuteronomy 25).

Onan uses Tamar: He sleeps with her, but he does not want to give her a child. For then he himself would get a bigger inheritance. He is selfish and leaves the widow without a future.

Judah blames Tamar for the death of his sons. He sends her home and does not plan ever to give her Shelah. Tamar is stuck: She may not marry another man, but she does not get Shelah either.

Tamar's plan VERSES 12–19

12 Many days later, Judah's wife, the daughter of Shua, died.
When Judah had been comforted, he went up to Timnah to the men who were shearing his sheep.
He went with his friend Hirah from Adullam.
13 Tamar was told,
"Look, your father-in-law is going up to Timnah to shear his sheep."
14 So she took off her widow's clothes.
She covered herself with a veil and wrapped herself up.
She sat down at the gate of Enaim, which is on the way to Timnah.
For she saw that Shelah was grown up by now,
and she had not been given to him as his wife.
15 When Judah saw her, he thought she was a prostitute.
For she had covered her face.

16 He turned off the road, went over to her and said,
"Please come, let me sleep with you."
For he did not know that she was his daughter-in-law.
She asked,
"What will you give me if you sleep with me?"
17 He said,
"I will send you a young goat from the flock."
She said,
"Will you give me a pledge until you send it?"
18 He asked,
"What pledge should I give you?"
She said,
"Your seal and your cord, and the staff in your hand."
He gave them to her and slept with her.
And she became pregnant by him.
19 Then she got up and went away.
She took off her veil and put her widow's clothes back on.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tamar waits a long time. Then she realizes: Judah is not keeping his promise. She takes her future into her own hands.

Her plan is bold. She risks her life with it. But it is her only way to get what is rightfully hers: a child from the family of her husband who died.

A "pledge" is something you hand over as a security until you have paid.

The seal (often on a cord) and the staff were like an ID card and a signature today. Everyone could tell by them: This belongs to Judah.

Judah goes to a prostitute without thinking twice. The Bible does not show him here as a good example.

Judah looks for the woman VERSES 20–23

20 Judah sent the young goat with his friend from Adullam.
He was to get the pledge back from the woman.
But he did not find her.
21 He asked the men of that place,
"Where is the prostitute who was at Enaim by the road?"
They said,
"There has been no prostitute here."
22 He went back to Judah and said,
"I did not find her.
And the men of the place also said, 'There has been no prostitute here.'"
23 Judah said,
"Let her keep the things.
Otherwise people will laugh at us.
Look, I sent this young goat, but you did not find her."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Hebrew original, Hirah uses a different word here than in verse 15. It means a woman who worked as a prostitute at a foreign temple. Hirah probably wants to make the matter sound less embarrassing.

Judah wants one thing above all: that no one finds out. His reputation matters more to him than anything else.

"She is more righteous than I" VERSES 24–26

24 About three months later, Judah was told,
"Your daughter-in-law Tamar has acted like a prostitute.
And look: Because of it, she is pregnant."
Judah said,
"Bring her out! Let her be burned."
25 As she was being brought out, she sent a message to her father-in-law.
She said,
"I am pregnant by the man who owns these things."
And she said,
"Please look at these and see whose they are:
the seal, the cords and the staff."
26 Judah recognized them.
He said,
"She is more righteous than I.
For I did not give her to my son Shelah."
Righteous means: doing what is right.
After that, he did not sleep with her again.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Judah condemns Tamar to death right away. He sees no problem with himself, but for her he wants the harshest punishment. That is hypocrisy.

Tamar is wise. She does not shame Judah in public. She sends him the things secretly and gives him the chance to tell the truth himself.

"Please look ... and see" – these words again! With exactly these words, Judah and his brothers had shown their father Joseph's bloody robe (Genesis 37:32). Now Judah himself is proven guilty with these words.

And then the miracle: Judah admits his guilt. In public. "She is more righteous than I." For the first time in this family, someone honestly admits a wrong. This is the turning point in Judah's life.

Twins VERSES 27–30

27 When the time came for her to give birth – look: There were twins in her womb.
28 While she was giving birth, one of them put out a hand.
The midwife took a scarlet thread and tied it on his hand.
Scarlet is a bright red color.
She said,
"This one came out first."
29 But he pulled his hand back.
And look: His brother came out.
The midwife said,
"Why have you broken out like this?"
That is why he was named Perez.
30 After that, his brother came out, who had the scarlet thread on his hand.
He was named Zerah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Twins again, and again a struggle over who is first – just like with Esau and Jacob.

Perez means "breaking out." Zerah means "shining," maybe because of the red thread.

Tamar even gets two sons – in place of the two sons of Judah who died.

Tamar, a foreign woman who had to fight for her rights, becomes an ancestor of King David. Her son Perez is part of David's family line (Ruth 4:18–22). In the New Testament, Tamar is in the family tree of Jesus – as one of only four women who are named there (Matthew 1:3).

GENESIS

CHAPTER 39

Joseph with Potiphar – and in prison

God is with Joseph VERSES 1–6

1 Joseph had been brought down to Egypt.
Potiphar, an Egyptian, bought him from the
Ishmaelites who had brought him there.
Potiphar was an officer of Pharaoh, the captain of the
guard.
2 The LORD was with Joseph.
So everything went well for him.
He lived in the house of his master, the Egyptian.
3 His master saw that the LORD was with him.
He saw that the LORD made everything Joseph did go
well.
4 So Joseph won his master's favor.
He served him personally.
Potiphar put him in charge of his house.
He put everything he owned into Joseph's hands.
5 From the time when he put him in charge of his house
and of everything he owned,
the LORD blessed the Egyptian's house because of
Joseph.
The LORD's blessing was on everything Potiphar
owned, in the house and in the field.
6 Potiphar left everything he had in Joseph's hands.
He did not worry about anything himself, except the
food he ate.
Joseph had a fine build and was handsome.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph is a slave in a foreign land. He has lost everything: his family, his home, his freedom.

But one sentence comes up again and again in this chapter: "The LORD was with Joseph." God has not left him – not even in slavery.

God even blesses the house of an Egyptian because of Joseph. That reminds us of God's promise to Abraham: Through you all peoples will be blessed.

Potiphar trusts Joseph so much that he does not worry about anything anymore. "Except the food" may mean: Back then, Egyptians were not allowed to eat with foreigners (see Genesis 43:32).

Potiphar's wife VERSES 7–12

7 After some time, his master's wife set her eyes on
Joseph.
She said to him,
"Sleep with me!"
8 But he refused.
He said to his master's wife,
"Look, my master does not worry about anything in
the house, because I am here.
He has put everything he owns into my hands.
9 No one in this house is greater than I am.
He has kept nothing back from me except you,
because you are his wife.
How could I do such a great evil and sin against God?"
10 She spoke to Joseph day after day.
But he did not listen to her.
He would not sleep with her, or even be near her.
11 One day, Joseph went into the house to do his work.
None of the men of the house were inside.
12 She grabbed him by his clothes and said,
"Sleep with me!"
But he left his clothes in her hand and ran outside.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph is young, alone and in a foreign land. No one would find out. The temptation is great – and it comes every day.

But Joseph stays firm. He thinks of two things: He does not want to cheat his master, who trusts him. And he does not want to sin against God.

For Joseph it is clear: Every wrong against a person is also a wrong before God.

Joseph stays out of her way. And when it gets serious, he runs away. Sometimes running away is the best decision.

Once again a piece of clothing plays a part: For the second time, Joseph loses his clothes, and again they are used to tell a lie.

The false accusation VERSES 13–20

13 She saw that he had left his clothes in her hand and had
run outside.
14 Then she called the men of her house and said to them,
"Look at this!
My husband has brought a Hebrew into our house to
make fun of us.
He came in to me and wanted to sleep with me.
And I screamed loudly.
15 When he heard me scream out loud, he left his clothes
beside me and ran outside."
16 She kept his clothes beside her until his master came
home.
17 Then she told him the same story.
She said,
"The Hebrew servant whom you have brought to us
came in to me to make fun of me.
18 When I screamed out loud, he left his clothes beside me
and ran outside."
19 His master heard the words his wife spoke to him:
"This is what your servant did to me!"
Then he became very angry.
20 Joseph's master took him and put him into the prison,
the place where the king's prisoners were kept.
Joseph stayed there in prison.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The woman turns everything around. She makes the victim into the guilty one. And she presents Joseph as a foreigner: "a Hebrew," "the Hebrew servant." She uses prejudice against strangers.

She also blames her husband: "whom **you** have brought to us."

Joseph did the right thing – and still he is punished. Life is not always fair. The Bible does not keep quiet about that.

Back then, the punishment for such a crime was actually death. That Potiphar "only" throws Joseph into prison may show: He did not fully believe his wife.

God is with Joseph in prison too VERSES 21–23

21 But the LORD was with Joseph.
He was kind to him.
He made the keeper of the prison like him.
22 The keeper of the prison put all the prisoners in the prison into Joseph's hands.
Whatever was done there, Joseph was in charge of it.
23 The keeper of the prison did not worry about anything that was in Joseph's hands.
For the LORD was with him.
And whatever he did, the LORD made it go well.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph has hit the very bottom: from favorite son to slave, from slave to prisoner.

But here too it is true: "The LORD was with Joseph." God is not only with us when everything goes well. He is also there in prison, in misfortune, in injustice.

Joseph does not become bitter. He makes the best of his situation. And once again he is given responsibility.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 40

Joseph explains the dreams of two prisoners

Two new prisoners VERSES 1–4

1 After these things, the cup bearer of the king of Egypt and his baker did wrong against their lord, the king of Egypt.
2 Pharaoh was angry with his two officers, the chief cup bearer and the chief baker.
3 He put them under guard in the house of the captain of the guard,
in the prison, the place where Joseph was locked up.
4 The captain of the guard put Joseph in charge of them.
Joseph took care of them.
They stayed in prison for many days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A cup bearer handed the king his drinks. He had to make sure that no one poisoned the king. It was a job of great trust.

The chief baker took care of the bread and baked goods at the royal court.

The Bible does not say what the two did wrong.

Two dreams VERSES 5–8

5 One night, the cup bearer and the baker of the king of Egypt,
who were locked up in the prison, both had a dream.
Each man had his own dream.
Each dream had its own meaning.
6 In the morning, Joseph came in to them.
He looked at them and saw that they were sad.
7 He asked Pharaoh's officers, who were under guard with him in his master's house,
"Why do you look so sad today?"
8 They said to him,
"We have had a dream.
But there is no one who can explain it."
Joseph said to them,
"Don't explanations of dreams belong to God?
Please tell me your dreams."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Egypt, people firmly believed that dreams were messages from the gods. There were experts who explained dreams. In the prison, there was no one like that.

Joseph pays attention to others. He sees that the two are not doing well, and he asks about it. He himself is in prison, even though he is innocent. Still, he cares for others.

Joseph says clearly: It is not I who can explain dreams. It is God. He does not take the honor for himself.

The cup bearer's dream VERSES 9–15

9 The chief cup bearer told his dream to Joseph.
He said to him,
"In my dream – look: There was a grapevine in front of me.
10 There were three branches on the vine.
It was as if it was budding.
It blossomed, and its clusters became ripe grapes.
11 Pharaoh's cup was in my hand.
I took the grapes and pressed them into Pharaoh's cup.
Then I gave the cup into Pharaoh's hand."
12 Joseph said to him,
"This is what it means:
The three branches are three days.
13 Within three days, Pharaoh will lift up your head.
He will give you back your job.
You will give Pharaoh's cup into his hand again, the way you did before, when you were his cup bearer.
14 But remember me when things go well for you.
Please be kind to me and tell Pharaoh about me.
Help me get out of this house.
15 For I was really stolen away from the land of the Hebrews.
And here too I have done nothing for which they should put me into the dungeon."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Lift up your head" means: honor someone again, give them a high position again.

Joseph asks the cup bearer for help. It is the only time that Joseph speaks of his suffering. He does not say that his brothers sold him. He only says: "I was really stolen away" and "I have done nothing."

In Hebrew, "dungeon" is the same word as "pit" in Chapter 37. This is the second time Joseph has ended up in a pit.

The baker's dream VERSES 16–19

16 The chief baker saw that Joseph had given a good explanation.
So he said to Joseph,
"I also had a dream.
Look: There were three baskets of white bread on my head.
17 In the top basket there were all kinds of baked goods for Pharaoh.
But the birds were eating them out of the basket on my head."
18 Joseph answered,
"This is what it means:
The three baskets are three days.
19 Within three days, Pharaoh will lift up your head from your body.
He will hang you on a tree.
And the birds will eat the flesh from your body."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The baker hopes for good news. But Joseph has to tell him the terrible truth. Joseph is honest, even when it is hard.

Joseph uses the same words, "lift up your head" – but this time with a terrible meaning: The baker will be put to death.

Back then, it was especially terrible that the birds would eat the flesh. For the Egyptians, a proper burial was very important for life after death.

It happens as Joseph said VERSES 20–23

20 The third day was Pharaoh's birthday.
He made a feast for all his servants.
In front of all his servants, he lifted up the head of the chief cup bearer and the head of the chief baker.
21 He gave the chief cup bearer back his job.
And he gave the cup into Pharaoh's hand again.
22 But he hanged the chief baker,
just as Joseph had explained it to them.
23 But the chief cup bearer did not remember Joseph.
He forgot him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Everything happens exactly as Joseph said. God has spoken through him.

The last sentence is bitter: The cup bearer forgets Joseph. Joseph has to stay in prison for two more years (see Genesis 41:1).

People forget. But God does not forget. And sometimes God's timetable is different from ours. In the next chapter it becomes clear why Joseph still had to wait.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 41

Joseph explains Pharaoh's dreams and becomes ruler over Egypt

Pharaoh's dreams VERSES 1–8

1 At the end of two full years, Pharaoh had a dream.
Look: He was standing by the river.
2 And look: Seven cows came up out of the river.
They were sleek and fat, and they were eating in the marsh grass.
3 And look: Seven other cows came up out of the river after them.
They were ugly and thin.
They stood beside the other cows on the bank of the river.
4 The ugly and thin cows ate up the seven sleek and fat cows.
Then Pharaoh woke up.
5 He fell asleep and dreamed a second time.
Look: Seven heads of grain grew on one stalk, healthy and good.
6 And look: After them, seven heads of grain sprang up, thin and dried out by the east wind.
7 The thin heads of grain swallowed up the seven healthy and full heads.
Then Pharaoh woke up.
And look: It was a dream.
8 In the morning, Pharaoh was troubled.
He sent for all the magicians and all the wise men of Egypt.
Pharaoh told them his dreams.
But no one could explain them to Pharaoh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph has to wait two more years after the cup bearer forgot him.

The river is the Nile, the great river of Egypt. Without it, Egypt would be only desert. Every year it flooded its banks and made the land fertile. When that did not happen, hunger came.

The east wind is a hot, dry desert wind. It makes the grain dry up.

The magicians of Egypt were famous. But here they do not know what to do. Only those to whom God explains his message can understand it.

The cup bearer remembers VERSES 9–13

9 Then the chief cup bearer said to Pharaoh,
"Today I remember my faults.
10 Pharaoh was angry with his servants.
He put me under guard in the house of the captain of the guard, me and the chief baker.
11 We both had a dream in one night, he and I.
Each dream had its own meaning.
12 There was a young man with us there, a Hebrew, a servant of the captain of the guard.

We told him our dreams.
He explained them to us.
He explained to each man his own dream.
13 And it happened exactly as he explained it to us:
Pharaoh gave me back my job, and he hanged the baker."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At last the cup bearer remembers. Now, at exactly the right moment.

If Joseph had been set free two years earlier, maybe he would simply have gone home. Then he could not have saved Egypt and his family from hunger. God's timing is sometimes hard to understand – but it has a purpose.

Joseph before Pharaoh VERSES 14–24

14 Then Pharaoh sent for Joseph.
They quickly brought him out of the dungeon.
Joseph shaved, changed his clothes and came in to Pharaoh.
15 Pharaoh said to Joseph,
"I have had a dream, and no one can explain it.
I have heard people say about you: When you hear a dream, you can explain it."
16 Joseph answered Pharaoh,
"It is not in me.
God will give Pharaoh an answer that brings peace."
17 Pharaoh said to Joseph,
"In my dream – look: I was standing on the bank of the river.
18 And look: Seven fat and sleek cows came up out of the river.
They were eating in the marsh grass.
19 And look: Seven other cows came up after them, weak, very ugly and thin.
I have never seen such ugly cows in all the land of Egypt.
20 The thin and ugly cows ate up the first seven fat cows.
21 And when they had eaten them up, no one could tell that they had eaten them.
They were still as ugly as at the beginning.
Then I woke up.
22 Then I saw in my dream – look:
Seven heads of grain grew on one stalk, full and good.
23 And look: After them, seven heads of grain sprang up, withered, thin and dried out by the east wind.
24 The thin heads of grain swallowed up the seven good heads of grain.
I told it to the magicians.
But no one could explain it to me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph shaves, because the Egyptians – unlike the Hebrews – were clean-shaven. He fits in, so that he can appear before the king.

Joseph is now a grown-up man. Earlier he proudly told about his dreams. Now he says humbly: "It is not in me. God will give Pharaoh an answer that brings peace."

Pharaoh tells the dream once more and adds something: The thin cows stay thin, even though they have eaten the fat ones. That makes the message even clearer.

Joseph explains the dreams VERSES 25–32

25 Joseph said to Pharaoh,
"Pharaoh's dreams are one and the same.
God has told Pharaoh what he is about to do.
26 The seven good cows are seven years.
And the seven good heads of grain are seven years.
It is one and the same dream.
27 The seven thin and ugly cows that came up after them are seven years.
And the seven empty heads of grain, dried out by the east wind, are also seven years.
They will be seven years of famine.
28 That is what I have said to Pharaoh:
God has shown Pharaoh what he is about to do.
29 Look: Seven years of great plenty are coming in all the land of Egypt.
30 After them, seven years of famine will come.
Then all the plenty in the land of Egypt will be forgotten.
The famine will use up the land.
31 No one will notice the plenty in the land anymore, because of the famine that follows.
For it will be very severe.
32 Pharaoh had the dream twice.
This is because God has firmly decided it.
And God will soon make it happen."
A famine is a time when there is not enough food.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Five times in this conversation Joseph says "God." In front of the most powerful king in the world, he speaks openly about his God.

The dream comes twice – that means: It is completely certain. It was the same with Joseph's own dreams (Chapter 37): They came twice too.

Joseph's advice VERSES 33–36

33 "So now let Pharaoh look for a man who is wise and understanding.
Let him put this man in charge of the land of Egypt.
34 Let Pharaoh do this.
Let him appoint officials over the land.
In the seven years of plenty, let him collect a fifth of the harvest of the land of Egypt.
35 Let them gather all the food of these good years that are coming.
Let them store the grain under Pharaoh's control as food in the cities, and let them keep it safe.
36 This food will be a supply for the land, for the seven years of famine that will come in the land of Egypt.
Then the land will not be ruined by the famine."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph does not only explain the dream. He also has a wise plan right away: In good times, prepare for bad times.

A fifth is 20 percent of the harvest. That was a high tax, but people could manage it.

God's message is not a threat without a way out. It is a warning, so that people can act in time and save lives.

Joseph becomes the second man in Egypt VERSES 37–46

37 The plan pleased Pharaoh and all his servants.

38 Pharaoh said to his servants,
"Can we find anyone like this man, a man in whom is the Spirit of God?"
39 Pharaoh said to Joseph,
"God has shown you all of this.
So there is no one as wise and understanding as you.
40 You will be in charge of my house.
All my people will follow your orders.
Only my throne will make me greater than you."
41 Pharaoh said to Joseph,
"Look, I have put you in charge of all the land of Egypt."
42 Pharaoh took his signet ring off his hand and put it on Joseph's hand.
A signet ring is a ring with a seal.
He dressed him in robes of fine linen.
And he put a gold chain around his neck.
43 He let him ride in his second chariot.
And people shouted in front of him, "Bow the knee!"
So he put him in charge of all the land of Egypt.
44 Pharaoh said to Joseph,
"I am Pharaoh.
But without your permission, no one in all the land of Egypt will lift a hand or a foot."
45 Pharaoh gave Joseph the name Zaphenath-Paneah.
And he gave him Asenath as his wife.
She was the daughter of Potiphera, the priest of On.
And Joseph went out over the land of Egypt.
46 Joseph was 30 years old when he stood before Pharaoh, the king of Egypt.
Joseph went out from Pharaoh and traveled through all the land of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In a single day: from prison to the second most powerful man in the world. That is how fast God can turn a life around.

Even Pharaoh, who believed in many gods, recognizes: The Spirit of God is in this man.

The signet ring was like the king's signature. Whoever wore it could give orders in Pharaoh's name.

Once again clothing plays a part: The brothers took away the colorful robe. He lost his clothes at Potiphar's house when he ran away. Now he gets royal robes.

Zaphenath-Paneah is an Egyptian name. Its meaning is not quite certain. Maybe it means "God speaks, and he lives."

On is the city of Heliopolis, a center of the sun god, near today's Cairo.

It has been 13 years since Joseph was sold at the age of 17. 13 years of slavery and prison. Now he is 30.

The seven good years VERSES 47–52

47 In the seven years of plenty, the land produced huge harvests.
48 Joseph gathered all the food of the seven years in the land of Egypt.
He stored the food in the cities.
In each city he stored the food from the fields around that city.
49 So Joseph stored up grain like the sand of the sea, very much,
until he stopped counting.
For it could not be counted.
50 Before the years of famine came, two sons were born to Joseph.
Asenath, the daughter of Potiphera, the priest of On, gave birth to them.
51 Joseph named the firstborn Manasseh.
For he said,
"God has made me forget all my hardship and all my father's house."
52 He named the second one Ephraim.
For he said,
"God has made me fruitful in the land of my suffering."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Like the sand of the sea" – that is how many descendants God had promised Abraham. Now there is that much grain.

Manasseh sounds like "make forget." Ephraim sounds like "doubly fruitful."

Joseph has accepted his new life. The pain over what his family did to him is healed. But he has not completely forgotten it – the next chapter shows that.

Later, Manasseh and Ephraim become two separate tribes of Israel.

The famine comes VERSES 53–57

53 The seven years of plenty in the land of Egypt came to an end.
54 Then the seven years of famine began, just as Joseph had said.
There was famine in all the lands.
But in all the land of Egypt there was bread.
55 Then all the land of Egypt became hungry too.
The people cried out to Pharaoh for bread.
Pharaoh said to all the Egyptians,
"Go to Joseph!
Do what he tells you."
56 The famine was over the whole earth.
Joseph opened all the storehouses and sold grain to the Egyptians.
For the famine was severe in the land of Egypt.
57 And all the countries came to Egypt, to Joseph, to buy grain.
For the famine was severe in the whole earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Everything happens as God showed. Because Joseph planned ahead, people have food – not only in Egypt, but in the whole region.

"Do what he tells you" – here Christians remember the wedding at Cana. There Mary says about Jesus: Do whatever he tells you (John 2:5).

The last verse prepares for what is coming: If all the countries come to Egypt, then Jacob's family from Canaan will come too.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 42

Joseph's brothers come to Egypt

Jacob sends his sons VERSES 1–5

1 Jacob found out that there was grain in Egypt.
So Jacob said to his sons,
"Why do you just look at one another?"
2 He said,
"Look, I have heard that there is grain in Egypt.
Go down there and buy grain for us from there.
Then we will live and not die."
3 So Joseph's 10 brothers went down to buy grain from Egypt.
4 But Jacob did not send Benjamin, Joseph's brother, with his brothers.
For he said, "Something bad might happen to him."
5 So the sons of Israel came to buy grain, together with the others who came.
For there was famine in the land of Canaan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The brothers sit around and do not know what to do. Their father has to push them.

Jacob leaves Benjamin at home. Benjamin is now his favorite son – the only son of Rachel he still has. He is afraid of losing him too. You can feel it: Jacob does not fully trust his other sons.

The brothers bow down before Joseph VERSES 6–8

6 Joseph was the governor over the land.
He was the one who sold grain to all the people of the land.
Joseph's brothers came.
They bowed down before him with their faces to the ground.
7 Joseph saw his brothers and recognized them.
But he acted like a stranger to them.
He spoke harshly with them.
He asked them,
"Where do you come from?"
They said,
"From the land of Canaan, to buy food."
8 Joseph recognized his brothers.
But they did not recognize him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now what Joseph dreamed as a boy comes true: His brothers' sheaves bow down before him (Chapter 37). They bow down to the ground – without knowing to whom.

More than 20 years have passed. Joseph was 17 back then; now he is almost 40. He wears Egyptian clothes, is clean-shaven and speaks Egyptian. No wonder the brothers do not recognize him.

"You are spies!" VERSES 9–17

9 Joseph remembered the dreams that he had dreamed about them.
He said to them,
"You are spies!
You have come to find out where the land is weak and unprotected."
10 They said to him,
"No, my lord!
Your servants have come to buy food.
11 We are all sons of one man.
We are honest men.
Your servants are not spies."
12 He said to them,
"No!
You have come to find out where the land is weak and unprotected!"
13 They said,
"We, your servants, are 12 brothers,
the sons of one man in the land of Canaan.
Look: The youngest is with our father today.
And one is no more."
14 Joseph said to them,
"It is as I told you: You are spies!
15 This is how you will be tested:
As surely as Pharaoh lives, you will not leave this place unless your youngest brother comes here.
16 Send one of you.
Let him get your brother.
The rest of you will stay locked up.
That way your words will be tested, whether you are telling the truth.
If not, then as surely as Pharaoh lives, you are spies."
17 He put them all together in prison for three days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Why is Joseph so harsh? He wants to find out whether his brothers have changed. Are they still the same men who would sell a brother? How do they treat Benjamin, Rachel's other son?

"One is no more" – that is how the brothers talk about Joseph. They do not know that he is standing in front of them.

Joseph locks them up in prison for three days. Now the brothers experience a little of what Joseph went through.

The brothers see their guilt VERSES 18–24

18 On the third day, Joseph said to them,
"Do this, and you will live.
For I fear God.
19 If you are honest men, then let one of your brothers stay locked up in your prison.
The rest of you, go and take grain home to your hungry families.
20 But bring your youngest brother to me.
Then it will be proven that your words are true.
And you will not die."
They agreed to do it.
21 They said to one another,
"We really are guilty because of our brother.
We saw how afraid he was when he begged us.
But we would not listen.
That is why this trouble has come upon us."
22 Reuben answered them,
"Didn't I tell you, 'Don't sin against the boy'?

But you would not listen.
Now we must pay for his blood."
23 They did not know that Joseph understood them.
For there was an interpreter between them.
24 Joseph turned away from them and cried.
Then he came back to them and talked with them.
He took Simeon from among them and tied him up in front of their eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"I fear God" – Joseph lets them know that he believes in God. The brothers probably think he means the Egyptian gods.

After more than 20 years, the brothers talk openly about their guilt for the first time. They remember how Joseph cried for help from the pit. Their bad conscience has not let go of them all these years.

Joseph hears everything. And he cries. He is not harsh out of revenge. It breaks his heart.

An interpreter puts the words of one language into another.

Why Simeon? Maybe because he was the oldest after Reuben – and Reuben had wanted to save Joseph.

Money in the sacks VERSES 25–28

25 Then Joseph gave orders to fill their bags with grain.
Each man's money was to be put back into his sack.
And they were to be given food for the journey.
So it was done for them.
26 They loaded their grain onto their donkeys and left.
27 At the place where they stopped for the night, one of them opened his sack to give his donkey food.
Then he saw his money.
Look: It was at the top of his sack.
28 He said to his brothers,
"My money has been given back!
Look, it is in my sack!"
Their hearts sank.
Trembling, they turned to one another and said,
"What is this that God has done to us?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph secretly gives them the grain as a gift. But the brothers are not happy. They are afraid that people will now think they are thieves.

For the first time, the brothers speak of God. They sense: God has something to do with what is happening. Their conscience has woken up.

The report to their father VERSES 29–38

29 They came to their father Jacob in the land of Canaan.
They told him everything that had happened to them.
They said,
30 "The man, the lord of the land, spoke harshly with us.
He thought we were spies who wanted to explore the country.
31 We said to him,
'We are honest men. We are not spies.
32 We are 12 brothers, sons of our father.
One is no more.
And the youngest is with our father today in the land of Canaan.'
33 Then the man, the lord of the land, said to us,
'This is how I will know that you are honest men:
Leave one of your brothers with me.
Take grain for your hungry families and go.
34 Bring your youngest brother to me.
Then I will know that you are not spies, but honest men.
Then I will give your brother back to you.
And you may trade in the land.'"
35 Then they emptied their sacks.
And look: Each man's bag of money was in his sack.
When they and their father saw their bags of money, they were afraid.
36 Their father Jacob said to them,
"You have taken my children from me!
Joseph is no more.
Simeon is no more.
And now you want to take Benjamin away.
All these things are against me!"
37 Reuben said to his father,
"You may kill my two sons if I do not bring him back to you.
Put him in my care.
I will bring him back to you."
38 But Jacob said,
"My son will not go down with you.
For his brother is dead, and he is the only one left.
If something bad happens to him on the way you are going,
then you will bring my gray hairs down to Sheol (the world of the dead) in sorrow."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob is bitter. He blames his sons – more than he knows. For in fact, they did take Joseph away from him.

"He is the only one left" – for Jacob, only Rachel's sons count. The other 10 sons have to listen to that. That hurts.

Reuben's offer is well meant, but not thought through: What good would it do Jacob to kill his own grandsons?

"Sheol" is the world of the dead again, as in Chapter 37. "Bring my gray hairs down to Sheol" means: You will make me, an old man, die of grief.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 43

The second journey to Egypt – with Benjamin

Judah guarantees Benjamin's safety VERSES 1–10

1 The famine in the land was severe.
2 They had eaten up all the grain they had brought from Egypt.
Then their father said to them,
"Go again and buy us a little more food."

3 Judah said to him,
"The man warned us very seriously.
He said,
'You will not see my face again unless your brother is with you.'
4 If you send our brother with us,
we will go down and buy food for you.
5 But if you do not send him, we will not go down.
For the man said to us,
'You will not see my face again unless your brother is with you.'"
6 Israel said,
"Why did you treat me so badly?
Why did you tell the man that you had another brother?"
7 They said,
"The man asked us directly about ourselves and about our family.
He asked,
'Is your father still alive? Do you have another brother?'
We just answered his questions.
How could we know that he would say, 'Bring your brother down here'?"
8 Judah said to his father Israel,
"Send the boy with me.
Then we will get up and go,
so that we may live and not die –
we and you and our little children too.
9 I will guarantee his safety.
You can hold me responsible for him.
If I do not bring him back to you and set him before you,
then let me carry the blame before you forever.
10 For if we had not waited so long,
we could have been there and back twice by now."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hunger forces the family to act.

Judah now takes the lead. He is the one who once suggested selling Joseph. Now he wants to stand up for Benjamin with his own life.

"To guarantee" means: I will answer for it. If something goes wrong, I carry the responsibility.

You can tell: Judah has changed. Since the story with Tamar (Chapter 38), he has become a different person.

Jacob lets Benjamin go VERSES 11–15

11 Their father Israel said to them,
"If it must be so, then do this:
Take some of the best products of the land in your bags.
Take them down to the man as a gift:
a little balm and a little honey, spices and myrrh, nuts and almonds.
12 Take twice as much money with you.
And take back the money that was put back in the top of your sacks.
Maybe it was a mistake.
13 Take your brother too.
Get up and go back to the man.
14 May God Almighty let the man show you mercy,
so that he will let your other brother and Benjamin go free.
As for me – if I lose my children, then I lose them."
15 So the men took the gift.
They took twice as much money with them, and they took Benjamin.
They got up, went down to Egypt and stood before Joseph.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob gives in. He does what he did back when he met Esau: he sends a gift ahead (Chapter 32).

Balm, honey, spices and myrrh – these are goods like the ones carried by the traders who brought Joseph to Egypt (Genesis 37:25).

"If I lose my children, then I lose them." Jacob hands his worry over to God. He can no longer control anything. He has to trust.

Afraid of Joseph's house VERSES 16–25

16 When Joseph saw Benjamin with them, he said to the manager of his house,
"Bring the men into my house.
Slaughter an animal and prepare a meal.
For the men will eat with me at noon."
17 The man did what Joseph had told him.
He brought the men to Joseph's house.
18 The men were afraid because they were brought to Joseph's house.
They said,
"We are brought here because of the money that was put back in our sacks the first time.
He wants an excuse to act against us.
He wants to attack us and take us as slaves, along with our donkeys."
19 They went up to the manager of Joseph's house.
They spoke to him at the door of the house.
20 They said,
"Please, my lord!
We really did come down the first time to buy food.
21 When we got to the place where we stayed for the night, we opened our sacks.
Look: Each man's money was in the top of his sack.
It was our money, the full weight.
We have brought it back with us.
22 We have also brought other money with us to buy food.
We do not know who put our money in our sacks."
23 He said,
"Peace be with you. Do not be afraid.
Your God, the God of your father, has put treasure in your sacks for you.
I received your money."
Then he brought Simeon out to them.
24 The man brought the men into Joseph's house.
He gave them water, and they washed their feet.
He gave their donkeys food.
25 They got the gift ready for when Joseph came at noon.
For they had heard that they were to eat a meal there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The brothers have a guilty conscience. That is why they expect punishment everywhere – even where good things

happen to them.

This time they are honest and tell about the money before anyone asks them. That too is a sign that they have changed.

The manager speaks like someone who believes in the God of Israel. Maybe Joseph told him about his God.

"Peace be with you" in Hebrew is "Shalom." People in Israel still greet each other this way today.

The feast VERSES 26–34

26 When Joseph came home, they brought him the gift
they had with them into the house.
They bowed down to the ground before him.
27 He asked them how they were.
And he asked,
"Is your father well, the old man you told me about?
Is he still alive?"
28 They said,
"Your servant, our father, is well. He is still alive."
And they bowed down low.
29 Joseph looked up and saw his brother Benjamin, his
mother's son.
He asked,
"Is this your youngest brother, the one you told me
about?"
And he said,
"May God be kind to you, my son."
30 Then Joseph hurried out,
because he was deeply moved by his brother.
He looked for a place to cry.
He went into his room and cried there.
31 Then he washed his face and came out.
He controlled himself and said,
"Serve the meal."
32 They served Joseph by himself,
the brothers by themselves,
and the Egyptians who ate with him by themselves.
For the Egyptians do not eat with the Hebrews.
The Egyptians find that disgusting.
33 The brothers sat before him, the firstborn according to
his rank as the oldest, and the youngest according to
his youth.
The men looked at each other in amazement.
34 Joseph had portions brought to them from his own
table.
But Benjamin's portion was five times as big as anyone
else's.
They drank with him and had a good time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Once again the brothers bow down before Joseph – this time all 11. Now the second dream has come true as well.

When Joseph sees his little brother Benjamin, the only other son of his mother, he cannot hold back the tears. Benjamin was a small child when Joseph was sold.

The Egyptians did not eat with foreigners. They thought they were better. That is why there are three separate tables.

The brothers are seated exactly in the order of their age. How does this Egyptian know that? They are amazed.

Benjamin gets five times as much. This is a test: will the brothers become jealous of the new favorite son – as they once did with Joseph? They stay cheerful. No jealousy.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 44

The silver cup – Judah stands up for Benjamin

Joseph's last test VERSES 1–6

1 Joseph gave an order to the manager of his house:
"Fill the men's sacks with food, as much as they can
carry.
And put each man's money in the top of his sack.
2 Put my cup, the silver cup,
in the top of the youngest one's sack, together with his
money for the grain."
The manager did what Joseph had told him.
3 As soon as it was light in the morning, the men were
sent away with their donkeys.
4 They had just left the city and had not gone far.
Then Joseph said to his manager,
"Get up! Go after the men!
When you catch up with them, say to them,
'Why have you paid back good with evil?
5 Is this not the cup my lord drinks from?
Is it not the cup he uses to see the future?
You have done something evil!'"
6 The manager caught up with them and said these words
to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph tests his brothers one last time. It is the most important test of all.

He puts Benjamin in a position where he looks like a thief. The question is: will the brothers abandon Benjamin, the way they once abandoned Joseph? Or will they stand by him?

Back then, people tried to see the future with certain cups. They poured oil into water and explained the shapes. The Bible does not say whether Joseph really did this. Here he is playing the role of an Egyptian ruler.

The cup is found VERSES 7–13

7 They said to him,
"Why does my lord say such things?
Your servants would never do such a thing!
8 Look: we even brought back to you from the land of
Canaan
the money we found in the top of our sacks.
So why would we steal silver or gold from your lord's
house?
9 If it is found with any of your servants, he must die.
And the rest of us will be my lord's slaves."
10 He said,
"All right, let it be as you say.

But only the one it is found with will be my slave.
The rest of you will go free and be without blame."
11 Each man quickly lowered his sack to the ground, and
each man opened his sack.
12 The manager searched.
He started with the oldest and ended with the
youngest.
And the cup was found in Benjamin's sack.
13 Then they tore their clothes.
Each man loaded his donkey again.
And they went back to the city.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The brothers are so sure that they are innocent. They even swear: whoever has the cup must die.

The tension keeps rising: the manager starts with the oldest. Sack by sack. And only at the very end, with the youngest, is the cup found.

Now the brothers could simply have gone home. After all, they were free. Only Benjamin was to stay.

But they tear their clothes in grief – and all of them turn back. No one leaves Benjamin alone. Back then, they tore Joseph's robe. Now they tear their own clothes.

Before Joseph VERSES 14–17

14 Judah and his brothers came to Joseph's house.
Joseph was still there.
They threw themselves to the ground before him.
15 Joseph said to them,
"What is this you have done?
Do you not know that a man like me can see the
future?"
16 Judah said,
"What can we say to my lord?
What can we say?
How can we prove our innocence?
God has uncovered the guilt of your servants.
Look: we are my lord's slaves,
all of us and also the one the cup was found with."
17 But Joseph said,
"I would never do that.
The man the cup was found with will be my slave.
But as for the rest of you, go back in peace to your
father."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"God has uncovered the guilt of your servants." Judah does not mean the cup – they did not steal it. He means the old guilt: what they did to Joseph. He believes God is now punishing them for it.

Joseph offers them the easy way out: go home. Leave Benjamin here. Exactly the way they once left Joseph behind.

Now everything depends on what they do.

Judah's speech VERSES 18–34

18 Then Judah came up to him and said,
"Please, my lord!
Let your servant say a word to my lord.
Do not be angry with your servant.
For you are as powerful as Pharaoh.
19 My lord asked his servants,
'Do you have a father or a brother?'
20 We said to my lord,
'We have an old father.
And we have a young brother, born to him in his old
age.
His brother is dead.
He is the only one left of his mother's sons.
And his father loves him.'
21 Then you said to your servants,
'Bring him down to me, so that I can see him with my
own eyes.'
22 We said to my lord,
'The boy cannot leave his father.
If he leaves his father, his father will die.'
23 But you said to your servants,
'Unless your youngest brother comes down with you,
you will not see my face again.'
24 When we went back up to your servant, my father,
we told him what my lord had said.
25 Then our father said,
'Go again and buy us a little food.'
26 We said,
'We cannot go down.
We will go down only if our youngest brother is with
us.
For we cannot see the man's face unless our youngest
brother is with us.'
27 Your servant, my father, said to us,
'You know that my wife gave me two sons.
28 One of them went away from me.
And I said, "He must have been torn to pieces."
I have not seen him since.
29 If you take this one from me too, and something bad
happens to him,
you will bring my gray hairs down to Sheol (the world
of the dead) in sorrow.'
30 So now, when I come to your servant, my father,
and the boy is not with us –
his life is bound up with the boy's life –
31 when he sees that the boy is not there, he will die.
Then your servants will bring the gray hairs of your
servant, our father, down to Sheol in sorrow.
32 For your servant guaranteed the boy's safety to my
father.
I said,
'If I do not bring him back to you, then I will carry the
blame before my father forever.'
33 So now, please let your servant stay here as my lord's
slave instead of the boy.
And let the boy go back with his brothers.
34 For how can I go back to my father if the boy is not with
me?
I could not bear to see the misery that would come
over my father."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the longest speech in the whole book of Genesis. And one of the most moving.

Judah tells everything once more. He does not even hide that his father loves Benjamin more than him. He says it without bitterness. In the past, the favoring of one brother drove the brothers to hatred. Now Judah simply accepts it, out of love for his father.

And then comes the unbelievable part: Judah offers himself as a slave so that Benjamin can go free.

Judah, who once suggested selling Joseph as a slave, now wants to become a slave himself to save his brother. The brothers have truly changed.

Christians see here a picture of Jesus, who comes from the tribe of Judah: he gives himself up so that others can be free.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 45

"I am Joseph!"

Joseph tells them who he is VERSES 1–4

1 Then Joseph could no longer control himself in front
of all the people standing around him.
He called out,
"Send everyone out from me!"
So no one else was with him when Joseph told his
brothers who he was.
2 He wept loudly.
The Egyptians heard it.
The household of Pharaoh heard it too.
3 Joseph said to his brothers,
"I am Joseph!
Is my father still alive?"
But his brothers could not answer him.
They were terrified in front of him.
4 Joseph said to his brothers,
"Please come closer to me."
And they came closer.
He said,
"I am Joseph, your brother,
whom you sold into Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Judah's speech has touched Joseph deeply. He sees: my brothers are not the same anymore. Now he can no longer pretend.

He sends all the Egyptians out. What comes now belongs to the family alone.

"I am Joseph!" – three words that change everything. The brothers are frozen with fear. The powerful ruler they trembled before is their brother. The brother they sold.

Joseph tells the truth quite openly: "whom you sold into Egypt." He hides nothing. But he says it without blaming them.

God turned it to good VERSES 5–8

5 Now do not be upset, and do not be angry with
yourselves that you sold me here.
For God sent me ahead of you to save lives.
6 The famine has been in the land for two years now.
And there are still five more years in which there will
be no plowing and no harvest.
7 God sent me ahead of you,
so that some of you would be left alive on the earth,
and to keep you alive by a great rescue.
8 So it was not you who sent me here, but God.
He has made me a father to Pharaoh,
lord of his whole household
and ruler over the whole land of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the heart of the whole story of Joseph. Joseph sees his life with new eyes: behind all the suffering, behind the pit, the slavery and the prison, God was following a plan.

The brothers did evil. Joseph says that very clearly. But God made something good out of it: the rescue of many people.

Joseph forgives his brothers. He does not want them to go on tormenting themselves.

It says: God has made me a "father to Pharaoh." That was a title for the king's most important adviser.

Bring my father! VERSES 9–15

9 Hurry and go up to my father and tell him,
'This is what your son Joseph says:
"God has made me lord of all Egypt.
Come down to me. Do not wait.
10 You will live in the land of Goshen.
Then you will be near me,
you and your children and your grandchildren,
your flocks, your herds and everything you have.
11 I will take care of you there.
For there are still five years of famine to come.
Otherwise you would become poor, you and your
household and everything you have."'
12 Look, you can see it with your own eyes, and so can my
brother Benjamin:
it is really I who am speaking to you.
13 Tell my father about all my glory in Egypt
and about everything you have seen.
Hurry and bring my father down here."
14 Then Joseph hugged his brother Benjamin around the
neck and wept.
And Benjamin wept on his neck.
15 He kissed all his brothers and wept as he held them.
After that, his brothers talked with him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Goshen is a fertile area in the northeast of Egypt, in the Nile Delta. There was good pasture there for the herds.

Joseph wants to see his father again as quickly as possible.

Joseph first hugs Benjamin, then all his brothers. He weeps with each one.

The last sentence is very simple, but beautiful: "After that, his brothers talked with him." Earlier, "they could not speak a friendly word to him" (Genesis 37:4). Now they talk with each other again. The family is reconciled.

Pharaoh invites the family VERSES 16–20

16 The news reached Pharaoh's household:
"Joseph's brothers have come!"
This pleased Pharaoh and his officials very much.

17 Pharaoh said to Joseph,
"Tell your brothers,
'Do this: load your animals and travel to the land of Canaan.
18 Get your father and your households and come to me.
I will give you the best of the land of Egypt.
You will eat the richest food of the land.'
19 You are also to give them this order:
'Do this: take wagons from the land of Egypt
for your little children and for your wives.
Bring your father and come.
20 And do not worry about your belongings.
For the best of all the land of Egypt is yours.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Pharaoh is generous. He knows: Joseph has saved Egypt. Now he wants to do something good for Joseph's family.

Back then, wagons were something special. There were hardly any in the land of Canaan. People traveled on foot or on donkeys.

The brothers go home VERSES 21–28

21 The sons of Israel did this.
Joseph gave them wagons, as Pharaoh had ordered.
And he gave them food for the journey.
22 He gave each of them a change of clothes.
But to Benjamin he gave 300 pieces of silver and 5 changes of clothes.
23 He sent this to his father:
10 donkeys loaded with the best things of Egypt,
and 10 female donkeys loaded with grain, bread and food for his father's journey.
24 Then he sent his brothers on their way, and they left.
He said to them,
"Do not quarrel on the way!"
25 So they went up out of Egypt and came to their father Jacob in the land of Canaan.
26 They told him,
"Joseph is still alive!
And he is ruler over the whole land of Egypt!"
But Jacob's heart went numb,
for he did not believe them.
27 Then they told him everything Joseph had said to them.
And he saw the wagons Joseph had sent to carry him.
Then the spirit of their father Jacob came back to life.
28 Israel said,
"It is enough! My son Joseph is still alive!
I will go and see him before I die."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph once received a special robe, and that caused jealousy. Now he gives clothes to all his brothers.

Benjamin again gets more. But this time the brothers do not become jealous.

"Do not quarrel on the way!" – maybe Joseph is winking a little. He knows his brothers. Maybe he also means: do not blame each other now for what happened back then.

At first Jacob cannot believe it. He has mourned for Joseph for 22 years. Only when he sees the wagons does it become real.

The brothers probably also have to tell their father the truth now: that Joseph was not eaten by a wild animal. The Bible does not say how this conversation went.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 46

Jacob moves to Egypt with his whole family

God encourages Jacob VERSES 1–4

1 Israel set out with everything he had.
He came to Beersheba.
There he offered sacrifices to the God of his father Isaac.
2 At night God spoke to Israel in visions.
He said, "Jacob, Jacob!"
He said, "Here I am."
3 God said,
"I am God, the God of your father.
Do not be afraid to go down to Egypt.
For there I will make you into a great nation.
4 I will go down with you to Egypt.
And I will surely bring you up again.
Joseph's hand will close your eyes."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Beersheba is the last place in the south of the land of Canaan. Jacob stops here before he leaves the promised land. Abraham and Isaac prayed here.

Jacob is probably afraid: may he leave the land that God promised? Back then, Isaac was not allowed to go to Egypt (Genesis 26:2).

God calms him: this time it is right. And: I am going with you. God is not tied to one land.

"I will surely bring you up again" – this means Jacob's descendants. The book of Exodus tells about that.

"Joseph's hand will close your eyes" means: Joseph will be with you when you die. That is a great comfort for the old father.

Setting out VERSES 5–7

5 Then Jacob set out from Beersheba.
The sons of Israel put their father Jacob, their little children and their wives
on the wagons that Pharaoh had sent to carry him.
6 They took their livestock and the goods they had gained in the land of Canaan.
So they came to Egypt,
Jacob and all his descendants with him:
7 his sons and his grandsons,
his daughters and his granddaughters.
He brought all his descendants with him to Egypt.

Jacob's family: the descendants of Leah VERSES 8–15

8 These are the names of the people of Israel who came to Egypt, Jacob and his sons:

Reuben, Jacob's firstborn.
9 The sons of Reuben:
Hanoch, Pallu, Hezron and Carmi.
10 The sons of Simeon:
Jemuel, Jamin, Ohad, Jachin, Zohar,
and Shaul, the son of a Canaanite woman.
11 The sons of Levi:
Gershon, Kohath and Merari.
12 The sons of Judah:
Er, Onan, Shelah, Perez and Zerah.
But Er and Onan had died in the land of Canaan.
The sons of Perez were Hezron and Hamul.
13 The sons of Issachar:
Tola, Puvah, Iob and Shimron.
14 The sons of Zebulun:
Sered, Elon and Jahleel.
15 These are the sons of Leah, whom she had given birth to
for Jacob in Paddan Aram,
together with his daughter Dinah.
All together, his sons and daughters were 33 people.

The descendants of Zilpah VERSES 16–18

16 The sons of Gad:
Ziphion, Haggi, Shuni, Ezbon, Eri, Arodi and Areli.
17 The sons of Asher:
Imnah, Ishvah, Ishvi and Beriah,
and their sister Serah.
The sons of Beriah were Heber and Malchiel.
18 These are the descendants of Zilpah.
Laban had given her to his daughter Leah as a servant.
She gave birth to these for Jacob, 16 people.

The descendants of Rachel VERSES 19–22

19 The sons of Rachel, Jacob's wife:
Joseph and Benjamin.
20 In the land of Egypt, Manasseh and Ephraim were born
to Joseph.
Asenath, the daughter of Potiphera, the priest of On,
gave birth to them for him.
21 The sons of Benjamin:
Bela, Becher, Ashbel, Gera, Naaman, Ehi, Rosh,
Muppim, Huppim and Ard.
22 These are the descendants of Rachel who were born to
Jacob.
All together they were 14 people.

The descendants of Bilhah VERSES 23–25

23 The son of Dan:
Hushim.
24 The sons of Naphtali:
Jahzeel, Guni, Jezer and Shillem.
25 These are the descendants of Bilhah.
Laban had given her to his daughter Rachel as a
servant.
She gave birth to these for Jacob, all together 7 people.

70 people VERSES 26–27

26 All the people who came to Egypt with Jacob and were
his own descendants
were 66 – not counting the wives of Jacob's sons.
27 Then there were the 2 sons of Joseph, who were born to
him in Egypt.
So all the people of Jacob's family who came to Egypt
were 70.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> This long list is important: it names the families that later become the 12 tribes of Israel.
>
> The numbers are counted in a somewhat complicated way. For example, Jacob himself is counted among the 33 people of Leah, but Er and Onan are not. Joseph and his sons are counted among the 70, even though they were already in Egypt.
>
> The number 70 is important. It reminds us of the 70 nations in Chapter 10. Jacob's family is like a small world of its own. In Egypt, these 70 people will grow into a great nation.
>
> Women are named too: Dinah, and Serah, the daughter of Asher.

Meeting again VERSES 28–30

28 Jacob sent Judah ahead of him to Joseph,
to show him the way to Goshen.
So they came into the land of Goshen.
29 Joseph got his chariot ready.
He went up to Goshen to meet his father Israel.
When he came to him, he hugged him around the
neck.
And he wept on his neck for a long time.
30 Israel said to Joseph,
"Now I can die,
since I have seen your face and know that you are still
alive."

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> Judah goes ahead. He is now the leader among the brothers.
>
> After 22 years, father and son see each other again. The Bible describes it very simply. But everyone can feel how much emotion there is in this moment.
>
> Jacob has nothing left to wish for. His greatest pain is healed.

Joseph prepares his brothers to meet Pharaoh VERSES 31–34

31 Joseph said to his brothers and to his father's
household,
"I will go up and tell Pharaoh.
I will say to him,
'My brothers and my father's household, who were in
the land of Canaan, have come to me.
32 These men are shepherds.
They have always kept livestock.
They have brought their flocks, their herds and
everything they have.'
33 When Pharaoh calls you and asks,
'What is your work?'
34 then you are to say,
'Your servants have kept livestock from our youth
until now, both we and our ancestors.'
Then you will be allowed to live in the land of Goshen.
For the Egyptians find all shepherds disgusting."

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> Joseph is wise. He knows: the Egyptians want nothing to do with shepherds. That is exactly why they will leave his

family alone and give it its own area.

In this way, Israel stays a people of its own and does not mix with the Egyptians. It can keep its faith and its way of life.

GENESIS

Chapter 47

Jacob before Pharaoh – Joseph during the famine

The brothers before Pharaoh VERSES 1–6

1 Joseph went in to Pharaoh and told him,
"My father and my brothers have come from the land of Canaan,
with their flocks, their herds and everything they own.
Look, they are now in the land of Goshen."
2 He had taken five of his brothers with him.
He presented them to Pharaoh.
3 Pharaoh asked his brothers,
"What is your work?"
They said to Pharaoh,
"Your servants are shepherds, both we and our ancestors."
4 They also said to Pharaoh,
"We have come to live as foreigners in the land.
For there is no pasture for your servants' flocks.
The famine is severe in the land of Canaan.
So please let your servants live in the land of Goshen."
5 Pharaoh said to Joseph,
"Your father and your brothers have come to you.
6 The land of Egypt is open to you.
Let your father and your brothers live in the best part of the land.
Let them live in the land of Goshen.
And if you know any capable men among them,
put them in charge of my own livestock."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Everything goes the way Joseph planned it. The brothers are honest and modest.

Pharaoh is generous. He even gives Joseph's family work with his own herds.

Jacob blesses Pharaoh VERSES 7–12

7 Then Joseph brought in his father Jacob and presented him to Pharaoh.
And Jacob blessed Pharaoh.
8 Pharaoh asked Jacob,
"How old are you?"
9 Jacob said to Pharaoh,
"The years of my journey through life are 130 years.
The years of my life have been few and hard.
They have not reached the years of my ancestors' lives during their journeys."
10 Jacob blessed Pharaoh and went out from his presence.
11 Joseph gave his father and his brothers a place to live.
He gave them land of their own in Egypt, in the best part of the land, in the land of Rameses.
That is what Pharaoh had ordered.
12 Joseph supplied his father, his brothers and his father's whole household with bread,
as much as each family needed, according to its size.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An amazing scene: an old shepherd blesses the most powerful king in the world. Normally the greater person blesses the lesser one. But Jacob carries God's blessing. And so through Abraham's family, Egypt is blessed too.

Jacob calls his life a "journey." He was never really at home. And he is honest: they were hard years. He went through much suffering – and much of it was his own fault.

Rameses is an area in the Nile Delta. The name comes from a later Pharaoh. The storyteller uses the name his readers knew.

The famine gets worse and worse VERSES 13–17

13 There was no bread in the whole land,
for the famine was very severe.
The land of Egypt and the land of Canaan were worn out by the famine.
14 Joseph collected all the money there was in the land of Egypt and in the land of Canaan
in payment for the grain that people bought.
And Joseph brought the money into Pharaoh's palace.
15 When the money was all used up in the land of Egypt and in the land of Canaan,
all the Egyptians came to Joseph and said,
"Give us bread!
Why should we die in front of you?
Our money is gone."
16 Joseph said,
"Give me your livestock.
If your money is gone, I will give you food in exchange for your livestock."
17 So they brought their livestock to Joseph.
And Joseph gave them bread in exchange for their horses, their flocks, their herds and their donkeys.
That year he fed them with bread in exchange for all their livestock.

The Egyptians sell themselves and their land VERSES 18–26

18 When that year was over, they came to him in the second year and said to him,
"We will not hide it from my lord:
our money is all gone.
And our herds of livestock already belong to my lord.
Nothing is left for my lord except our bodies and our land.
19 Why should we die before your eyes, both we and our land?
Buy us and our land in exchange for bread.
Then we and our land will be servants to Pharaoh.
Give us seed, so that we may live and not die,
and so that the land will not become a wasteland."

20 So Joseph bought all the land of Egypt for Pharaoh.
For every Egyptian sold his field, because the famine was so severe for them.
So the land became Pharaoh's.
21 As for the people, he moved them into the cities,
from one end of Egypt to the other.
22 Only the land of the priests he did not buy.
For the priests received a fixed share from Pharaoh.
They lived on the share that Pharaoh gave them.
That is why they did not sell their land.
23 Joseph said to the people,
"Look, today I have bought you and your land for Pharaoh.
Here is seed for you. Plant it in the land.
24 At harvest time, you are to give one fifth to Pharaoh.
Four fifths will be your own:
as seed for the field and as food for you, your households and your little children."
25 They said,
"You have saved our lives!
May we find favor with my lord.
We will be Pharaoh's servants."
26 So Joseph made it a law for the land of Egypt, which still stands to this day:
one fifth belongs to Pharaoh.
Only the land of the priests did not become Pharaoh's.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This section is not easy for readers today. Joseph does save the Egyptians from starving to death. But in the end, all the money, all the livestock and all the land belong to Pharaoh. The people have become dependent on him.

The Egyptians themselves feel that they have been rescued: "You have saved our lives!" A tax of one fifth was rather mild back then. In other countries, rulers often demanded much more.

Some interpreters see Joseph here as a wise manager in a time of need. Others are critical that he made Pharaoh's power so much greater. Later, a Pharaoh will use exactly this power to make Joseph's descendants slaves (Exodus 1).

The Bible tells it without openly praising or blaming it.

Jacob wants to be buried in Canaan VERSES 27–31

27 So Israel lived in the land of Egypt, in the land of Goshen.
They got property there.
They had many children and became very many.
28 Jacob lived in the land of Egypt for 17 years.
So Jacob lived to be 147 years old in all.
29 When the time came near for Israel to die, he called his son Joseph.
He said to him,
"If I have found favor with you, please put your hand under my thigh.
Show me kindness and faithfulness:
please do not bury me in Egypt.
30 When I die and join my ancestors,
carry me out of Egypt
and bury me in their grave."
Joseph said,
"I will do as you have said."
31 Israel said,
"Swear it to me!"
And Joseph swore it to him.
Then Israel bowed down at the head of his bed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Egypt, God's promise comes true: the family becomes large and numerous.

Jacob had Joseph with him for 17 years at the beginning of Joseph's life. Now Jacob has 17 years with Joseph in Egypt. In this way, he gets the lost years back.

"To put your hand under the thigh" is a solemn oath, as with Abraham and his servant (Chapter 24).

Jacob does not want to stay in Egypt, not even after his death. His heart belongs to the land God promised. He wants to be buried with Abraham, Sarah, Isaac, Rebekah and Leah in the cave of Machpelah.

At the end, Jacob bows over his bed and worships God. He thanks God.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 48

Jacob blesses Ephraim and Manasseh

Joseph visits his sick father VERSES 1–7

1 Some time later, someone told Joseph,
"Look, your father is sick."
So he took his two sons Manasseh and Ephraim with him.
2 Someone told Jacob,
"Look, your son Joseph is coming to you."
Then Israel gathered all his strength and sat up in bed.
3 Jacob said to Joseph,
"God Almighty appeared to me at Luz in the land of Canaan and blessed me.
4 He said to me,
'Look, I will make you fruitful and give you many descendants.
I will make you into a community of peoples.
And I will give this land to your descendants after you, as their property forever.'
5 Your two sons were born to you in the land of Egypt, before I came to you in Egypt.
Now they are mine.
Ephraim and Manasseh will be mine, just as Reuben and Simeon are.
6 But the children you have after them will be yours.
They will be counted under the names of their brothers when the land is shared out.
7 When I was coming back from Paddan, Rachel died on the way, while I was with her in the land of Canaan.
There was still some distance to go to Ephrath.
I buried her there, by the road to Ephrath.
Ephrath is also called Bethlehem."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Luz is the old name of Bethel, where Jacob saw the stairway to heaven.

Jacob accepts Joseph's sons as his own sons. That means: Joseph receives a double share of the inheritance. Later, two tribes of Israel come from him: Ephraim and Manasseh.

The double share really belonged to the firstborn, that is, to Reuben. But Reuben lost this right (Genesis 35:22). Now Joseph receives it, the first son of Rachel.

Jacob thinks of Rachel. Even at the end of his life, he still grieves for his beloved wife. Maybe he is also explaining to Joseph: Rachel should have had more children. That is why I am taking your sons as my own.

The grandfather and the grandsons VERSES 8–12

8 Then Israel saw Joseph's sons and asked,
"Who are these?"
9 Joseph said to his father,
"They are my sons, whom God has given me here."
Jacob said,
"Please bring them to me, and I will bless them."
10 Israel's eyes had grown weak with age.
He could not see well.
Joseph brought them close to him.
And he kissed them and hugged them.
11 Israel said to Joseph,
"I did not think I would ever see your face again.
And look: God has even let me see your children."
12 Then Joseph took them from between his father's knees.
And he bowed down with his face to the ground.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Like his father Isaac, Jacob is almost blind in his old age. Do you remember? When Isaac was blind, Jacob tricked him (Chapter 27). Now Jacob himself is the blind father who gives the blessing.

Jacob is overwhelmed with thankfulness: he thought Joseph was dead. Now he even holds Joseph's children in his arms.

Taking the children on one's knees was a sign: I accept them as my own.

The younger before the older VERSES 13–20

13 Then Joseph took them both.
He held Ephraim with his right hand, toward Israel's left hand.
And he held Manasseh with his left hand, toward Israel's right hand.
So he brought them close to him.
14 But Israel stretched out his right hand and laid it on Ephraim's head, even though he was the younger.
And he laid his left hand on Manasseh's head.
He crossed his hands on purpose,
for Manasseh was the firstborn.
15 He blessed Joseph and said,
"The God whom my ancestors Abraham and Isaac followed,
the God who has fed me all my life long to this day,
16 the angel who has rescued me from all harm –
may he bless the boys.
May my name live on in them,
and the name of my ancestors Abraham and Isaac.
May they grow into a great crowd on the earth."
17 Joseph saw that his father laid his right hand on Ephraim's head.
He did not like that.
He took hold of his father's hand to move it from Ephraim's head to Manasseh's head.
18 Joseph said to his father,
"Not like that, my father!
This one is the firstborn.
Put your right hand on his head."
19 But his father refused.
He said,
"I know, my son, I know.
He too will become a people.
He too will be great.
But his younger brother will be greater than he is.
And his descendants will become a great number of nations."
20 So he blessed them that day and said,
"The people of Israel will use your name to bless others.
They will say, 'May God make you like Ephraim and Manasseh!'"
So he put Ephraim ahead of Manasseh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The right hand was seen as the more important one. It was meant for the firstborn.

Once again, the same thing happens as so often in the book of Genesis: the younger is put before the older. Abel before Cain, Isaac before Ishmael, Jacob before Esau, Joseph before his older brothers, Perez before Zerah. God does not keep to human rules. He often chooses the ones who are overlooked at first.

Jacob, who once got the blessing by a trick, now gives it very deliberately and openly. He knows what he is doing.

Jacob says that God has "fed" him. In Hebrew, this is the word for what a shepherd does. Jacob himself was a shepherd all his life. Now he sees: God has watched over me like a shepherd. This picture comes back later in the famous Psalm 23: "The LORD is my shepherd" (Psalm 23:1).

To this day, Jewish fathers bless their sons on Friday evening with the words: "May God make you like Ephraim and Manasseh."

A special gift for Joseph VERSES 21–22

21 Then Israel said to Joseph,
"Look, I am dying.
But God will be with you.
He will bring you back to the land of your ancestors.
22 And I give you one portion of land more than your brothers.
I took it from the Amorite with my sword and with my bow."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob is sure: God will keep his promise. The family will return to Canaan.

In Hebrew, the word for "portion" here is "Shechem." That is also the name of the city of Shechem. Probably this land is meant. Later, Joseph is in fact buried there (Joshua 24:32).

The Bible tells nothing else about a battle of Jacob against the Amorites. Maybe Jacob is thinking of his sons' attack on Shechem (Chapter 34) or of some other event.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 49

Jacob's blessing for his 12 sons – Jacob dies

Gather together! VERSES 1–2

1 Jacob called his sons and said,
"Gather together,
so that I can tell you what will happen to you in the days to come.
2 Come together and listen, you sons of Jacob.
Listen to Israel, your father.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end of his life, Jacob speaks to each of his sons. These words are like a poem. In many Bibles, this text is printed as poetry.

Jacob does not say only good things. He says openly what each one has done and what will become of him. The words are meant not only for the sons, but also for the tribes that will come from them.

Some pictures in this chapter are hard to understand. Even experts are not sure what exactly some verses mean.

Reuben VERSES 3–4

3 "Reuben, you are my firstborn,
my might and the first sign of my strength.
You were first in honor and first in power.
4 But you boiled over like water.
So you will not stay first.
For you climbed into your father's bed.
Then you dishonored it.
Yes, he climbed onto my bed!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

As the oldest, Reuben should have become the leader. But he slept with Bilhah, his father's concubine (Genesis 35:22). That is why he loses his special right.

"Boiling over like water" means: out of control, without self-control.

In fact, the tribe of Reuben did not play a big role in Israel later on.

Simeon and Levi VERSES 5–7

5 "Simeon and Levi are brothers.
Their swords are weapons of violence.
6 My soul, do not take part in their plans.
My honor, do not join their gathering.
For in their anger they killed men.
And in their stubborn pride they cut the leg tendons of cattle.
7 Their anger is cursed, because it was fierce,
and their rage, because it was cruel.
I will divide them up in Jacob
and scatter them in Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jacob is remembering the bloodbath in Shechem (Chapter 34). Back then, he thought only of himself. Now he clearly condemns the violence of his sons.

Important: Jacob does not curse his sons. He curses their anger and their violence.

"They will be scattered": later, the tribe of Simeon did not receive an area of its own, but lived in the middle of the area of Judah. The tribe of Levi did not receive its own land either. But the priests came from Levi, and they lived all over the land. So in the end, the curse became a blessing.

Judah VERSES 8–12

8 "Judah, your brothers will praise you.
Your hand will be on the neck of your enemies.
Your father's sons will bow down before you.
9 Judah is a young lion.
You have come up from the prey, my son.
He crouches down and lies down like a lion, like a lioness.
Who will wake him up?
10 The scepter will not leave Judah,
nor the ruler's staff from between his feet,
until he comes to whom it belongs.
The peoples will obey him.
11 He ties his young donkey to the vine,
his donkey's colt to the best vine.
He has washed his clothes in wine,
his robes in the blood of grapes.
12 His eyes will be red with wine,
his teeth white with milk.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Judah receives the greatest blessing. He has changed: he admitted his guilt with Tamar and offered himself for Benjamin. Now he becomes the leader among the brothers.

The lion is a picture of strength and royal dignity. To this day, the lion is the symbol on the coat of arms of Jerusalem.

A scepter is a staff that kings carry as a sign of their power. Later King David came from the tribe of Judah, and so did all the kings in Jerusalem.

"Until he comes to whom it belongs" – this sentence is hard to translate. Very early on, Jews and Christians related it to the Messiah, the coming king whom God will send. Christians see in it a pointer to Jesus. In the book of Revelation, Jesus is called "the Lion from the tribe of Judah" (Revelation 5:5).

Verses 11 and 12 paint a picture of unbelievable plenty: so much wine that people tie donkeys to fine vines and wash their clothes in it.

Zebulun and Issachar VERSES 13–15

13 "Zebulun will live by the shore of the sea.
He will be a harbor for ships.
His border will reach to Sidon.
14 Issachar is a strong donkey,
lying down between the saddlebags.

15 He saw that the resting place was good,
and that the land was pleasant.
So he bent his shoulder to carry the load
and became a servant doing forced labor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Later, Zebulun received an area toward the Mediterranean Sea, in the north of the land. Sidon is a port city in what is now Lebanon.

Issachar is compared to a strong donkey that carries loads. His land was very fertile. But because he wanted an easy life, he submitted to others and had to work for them.

Dan, Gad, Asher and Naphtali VERSES 16–21

16 "Dan will judge his people
as one of the tribes of Israel.
17 Dan will be a snake by the road,
a viper on the path,
that bites the horse's heels,
so that its rider falls backward.
18 LORD, I have waited for you to save me.
19 Gad – a band of raiders will attack him.
But he will attack them at their heels.
20 Asher's food will be rich.
He will produce fine food fit for a king.
21 Naphtali is a doe set free,
who gives birth to beautiful fawns.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Dan" means "judge." A small tribe, but cunning and dangerous like a snake. Later the judge Samson came from Dan.

In the middle of the words of blessing, Jacob suddenly sighs to God: "LORD, I have waited for you to save me." Maybe he realizes: my sons and their descendants will go through much fighting and trouble. In the end, only God can help.

"Gad" sounds like "band of raiders" and "attack." The tribe of Gad lived east of the Jordan and often had to defend itself against attackers.

"Asher" means "happy." He received a very fertile area on the coast.

With Naphtali, the Hebrew text is hard to understand. Some Bibles translate "beautiful fawns," others "beautiful words." What is clear: Naphtali is compared to a free, quick animal.

Joseph VERSES 22–26

22 "Joseph is a fruitful vine,
a fruitful vine by a spring.
His branches climb over the wall.
23 The archers have attacked him bitterly.
They shot at him and hunted him down.
24 But his bow stayed firm.
His arms were made strong
by the hands of the Mighty One of Jacob –
from there comes the shepherd, the stone of Israel –
25 by the God of your father, who will help you,
by the Almighty, who will bless you
with blessings from heaven above,
with blessings from the deep waters that lie below,
with blessings of the breasts and of the womb.
26 The blessings of your father are greater
than the blessings of my ancestors.
They reach beyond the borders of the ancient hills.
They will be on the head of Joseph,
on the top of the head of the one who was set apart
from his brothers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph receives the longest and warmest blessing.

The "archers" are a picture of all those who made Joseph suffer: his brothers, Potiphar's wife, the prison. But Joseph was not broken. God made him strong.

Jacob calls God by many beautiful names: the Mighty One of Jacob, the shepherd, the stone of Israel, the Almighty. A stone like this is a rock: firm and safe. You can build on it.

The blessing is complete: rain from heaven, water from the earth and many children.

Benjamin VERSE 27

27 "Benjamin is a hungry wolf.
In the morning he eats up the prey.
And in the evening he divides what he has captured."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Little Benjamin, who was so well protected, becomes a tribe of fighters. In fact, the people of Benjamin were later known as brave and dangerous warriors. Saul, the first king of Israel, came from Benjamin. And the apostle Paul also came from the tribe of Benjamin (Philippians 3:5).

Jacob dies VERSES 28–33

28 These are the 12 tribes of Israel.
And this is what their father said to them when he blessed them.
He blessed each one with the blessing that was meant for him.
29 Then he gave them instructions and said to them,
"I am about to be gathered to my people.
Bury me with my ancestors in the cave in the field of Ephron the Hittite,
30 in the cave in the field of Machpelah, near Mamre, in the land of Canaan.
Abraham bought it, together with the field, from Ephron the Hittite as a burial place.
31 There they buried Abraham and his wife Sarah.
There they buried Isaac and his wife Rebekah.
And there I buried Leah.
32 The field and the cave in it were bought from the people of Heth."
33 When Jacob had finished giving these instructions to his sons,
he drew his feet up into the bed.
He breathed his last.
And he was gathered to his people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here, for the first time in the Bible, we read: "the 12 tribes of Israel." A family has become a nation.

Jacob wants to be buried with Leah, not with Rachel. Leah, who fought so long for his love, lies at his side in the end – and with her, the great ancestors of faith.

Here we also learn that Rebekah and Leah have died. The Bible had not told this before.

Jacob's death is described as calm and peaceful. He has said everything he wanted to say. Then he lies down and dies.

GENESIS

CHAPTER 50

Jacob's burial – Joseph forgives his brothers – Joseph dies

Mourning for Jacob VERSES 1–3

1 Joseph threw himself on his father's face.
He wept over him and kissed him.
2 Then Joseph ordered his servants, the doctors, to
embalm his father.
And the doctors embalmed Israel.
3 It took 40 days,
for that is how long it takes to embalm.
The Egyptians mourned for Israel for 70 days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

To embalm means: to treat a dead body with special ointments and oils so that it does not decay. This is how the Egyptians made mummies. It was necessary because Jacob was still to be carried a long way to Canaan.

70 days of mourning – almost as long as the Egyptians mourned for a Pharaoh. Jacob is greatly honored in Egypt.

The great funeral procession to Canaan VERSES 4–14

4 When the days of mourning for him were over, Joseph
spoke to the people at Pharaoh's court.
He said,
"If I have found favor with you, please speak to
Pharaoh for me.
Tell him,
5 'My father made me swear an oath.
He said, "Look, I am dying.
Bury me in my grave that I dug for myself in the land
of Canaan."
So please let me go up and bury my father.
Then I will come back.'"
6 Pharaoh said,
"Go up and bury your father, just as he made you
swear."
7 So Joseph went up to bury his father.
With him went all of Pharaoh's officials,
the leaders of his household
and all the leaders of the land of Egypt,
8 and also Joseph's whole household, his brothers and his
father's household.
Only their little children, their flocks and their herds
stayed behind in the land of Goshen.
9 Chariots and horsemen also went up with him.
It was a very large crowd.
10 They came to the threshing floor of Atad, which is
beyond the Jordan.
There they mourned with very great and bitter
mourning.
Joseph mourned for his father for seven days.
11 The people who lived in the land, the Canaanites, saw
the mourning at the threshing floor of Atad.
They said,
"This is a time of deep mourning for the Egyptians."
That is why the place was named Abel Mizraim.
It is beyond the Jordan.
12 Jacob's sons did for him just what he had told them.
13 His sons carried him into the land of Canaan.
They buried him in the cave in the field of Machpelah,
near Mamre.
Abraham had bought it, together with the field, from
Ephron the Hittite as a burial place of his own.
14 After he had buried his father, Joseph went back to
Egypt,
he and his brothers and all who had gone up with him
to bury his father.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joseph keeps his promise to his father.

Joseph has to ask Pharaoh for permission. He promises to come back. He is powerful, but he is also a servant of Pharaoh.

A threshing floor is a hard, flat place where people beat the grain out of the plants.

"Abel Mizraim" means "mourning of the Egyptians" or "meadow of the Egyptians."

A huge Egyptian funeral procession goes into the promised land. It is almost like a foretaste of the exodus from Egypt many years later.

The brothers are afraid VERSES 15–18

15 Joseph's brothers saw that their father was dead.
Then they said,
"Maybe Joseph will hate us now.
Maybe he will pay us back in full for all the evil we did
to him."
16 So they sent a message to Joseph:
"Before he died, your father gave this order:
17 'This is what you are to say to Joseph:
"Please forgive your brothers for the wrong they did
and for their sin,
because they did evil to you."'
So now, please forgive the wrong done by the servants
of the God of your father."
When they spoke to him, Joseph wept.
18 Then his brothers came themselves.
They threw themselves down before him and said,
"Look, we are your slaves."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For 17 years, the brothers have lived in Egypt with Joseph. Still they are afraid. Maybe they thought: Joseph was only kind because of our father. Now that our father is dead, he will take revenge.

They send a message that is supposed to be from Jacob. We do not know whether Jacob really said that. Maybe the brothers made it up because they were so afraid.

Joseph weeps. It hurts him that his brothers still do not trust him.

For the last time, the brothers bow down before Joseph. They offer themselves to him as slaves. Back then, they sold him as a slave.

"You planned evil – God planned it for good" VERSES 19–21

19 But Joseph said to them,
"Do not be afraid.
Am I in the place of God?
20 You planned evil against me.
But God planned it for good.
He did it to keep many people alive, as is happening today.
21 So do not be afraid.
I will take care of you and your little children."
So he comforted them and spoke kindly to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important sentences in the whole Bible: "You planned evil against me. But God planned it for good."

Joseph does not gloss over anything. What the brothers did was evil. But God is greater than the evil people do. He can make something good even out of great wrong.

"Am I in the place of God?" means: it is not my task to punish you. Judgment belongs to God. And I forgive you.

Joseph does not forgive only with words. He takes care of his brothers and their children. Real forgiveness shows itself in actions.

The book of Genesis began with a family in which one brother killed the other (Cain and Abel). It ends with a family in which a brother forgives his brothers.

Joseph's last years and his death VERSES 22–26

22 Joseph stayed in Egypt, he and his father's household.
Joseph lived to be 110 years old.
23 Joseph saw Ephraim's children to the third generation.
The children of Machir, the son of Manasseh, were also born on Joseph's knees.
24 Joseph said to his brothers,
"I am dying.
But God will surely come to help you.
He will bring you up out of this land
to the land he promised with an oath to Abraham, to Isaac and to Jacob."
25 Joseph made the people of Israel swear an oath.
He said,
"God will surely come to help you.
Then you must carry my bones up from here."
26 So Joseph died at the age of 110.
They embalmed him, and he was put in a coffin in Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Egypt, 110 years was thought to be the ideal, perfect age.

"Born on Joseph's knees" means: Joseph accepted them as his own children, just as Jacob did with Ephraim and Manasseh.

Joseph lives in Egypt, but his heart belongs to the promised land. He firmly believes: one day God will lead his people out.

Then his bones are to be taken along. Many years later, at the exodus from Egypt, Moses will do exactly that (Exodus 13:19). And Joseph will be buried in Shechem (Joshua 24:32).

The book of Genesis ends with a coffin in Egypt. That sounds sad. But it also ends with a great hope: "God will surely come to help you." The story is not over yet. It goes on in the book of Exodus.

Looking back: the book of Genesis

The first book of the Bible tells a long story:

God creates a good world.

People do not trust God, and evil spreads.

But God does not give up.

He starts again with a single family: with Abraham and Sarah.

He promises them land, many descendants and blessing for all nations.

Through four generations – Abraham, Isaac, Jacob and Joseph – God keeps his promise,

even through mistakes, lies, quarrels and suffering.

In the end, a family has become a nation of 12 tribes: Israel.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 2 OF 66

EXODUS

40 CHAPTERS

EXODUS

Chapter 1

Israel is oppressed in Egypt

Before we begin: What is the book of Exodus?

The book of Exodus is also called "the Second Book of Moses."

The name "Exodus" means "going out."

It tells how God frees his people Israel from slavery in Egypt.

The main person is Moses.

God leads the people through the sea and through the desert to Mount Sinai.

There God makes a covenant with his people and gives them the Ten Commandments.

At the end, the people build a holy tent, where God lives among them.

For Jews, the going out from Egypt is still the most important event in their history. They celebrate it every year at the Passover festival.

A family becomes a people VERSES 1–7

1 These are the names of the sons of Israel who came to Egypt.
Each man came with Jacob, together with his household:
2 Reuben, Simeon, Levi, and Judah,
3 Issachar, Zebulun, and Benjamin,
4 Dan and Naphtali, Gad and Asher.
5 All the people who came from Jacob were 70 people.
Joseph was already in Egypt.
6 Then Joseph died.
All his brothers died too, and all the people of that generation.
7 But the people of Israel had many children.
They grew in number very much.
They became very many and very strong.
The land was full of them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Exodus goes on right where the book of Genesis ends. Again the sons of Jacob are named.

God had promised Abraham: Your descendants will be as many as the stars. In Egypt this comes true. 70 people become a great people.

The words here remind us of God's blessing at creation: "Have many children, and become many!" (Genesis 1:28). God's blessing is at work – even in a foreign land.

A new king VERSES 8–14

8 Then a new king came to power over Egypt.
He did not know about Joseph.
9 He said to his people,
"Look! The people of Israel are more in number and stronger than we are.
10 Come, let's be clever with them.
Otherwise they will become even more.
And when a war breaks out, they will join our enemies.
Then they will fight against us and leave the land."
11 So the Egyptians put slave drivers over them.
They were to oppress them with heavy work.
The Israelites built storage cities for Pharaoh: Pithom and Raamses.
12 But the more the Egyptians oppressed them, the more they grew in number.
And the more they spread out.
The Egyptians began to dread the people of Israel.
13 The Egyptians forced the people of Israel to work without mercy.
14 They made their lives bitter with hard work:
with mortar and with bricks,
and with all kinds of work in the field.
In all this work, they forced them without mercy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many years have passed. The new Pharaoh "did not know about Joseph." That means: He no longer remembers that an Israelite once saved Egypt from hunger. Or he does not care.

Pharaoh is afraid of the foreigners in his land. Fear turns into oppression. Sadly, this is still a well-known pattern today: People make a minority into a scapegoat.

The Israelites become slaves. They have to make bricks out of clay and build cities with them.

But God still lets his people grow. The oppression brings about the opposite of what Pharaoh wants.

The brave midwives VERSES 15–21

15 The king of Egypt spoke to the Hebrew midwives.
The name of one was Shiphrah.
The name of the other was Puah.
16 He said,
"When you help the Hebrew women give birth, watch them on the birth stool.
If it is a son, kill him.
But if it is a daughter, she may live."
17 But the midwives feared God.
They did not do what the king of Egypt had commanded them.
They let the baby boys live.
18 Then the king of Egypt called for the midwives.
He said to them,
"Why have you done this? Why have you let the boys live?"
19 The midwives said to Pharaoh,
"The Hebrew women are not like the Egyptian women.
They are strong.
They give birth before the midwife comes to them."

20 God was good to the midwives.
And the people grew in number and became very strong.
21 Because the midwives feared God, he gave them families of their own.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A midwife is a woman who helps at a birth.

Pharaoh orders a cruel mass murder of babies. But two women refuse – in the middle of the most powerful kingdom in the world.

They have more respect for God than for the king. This is the first act of nonviolent resistance in the Bible.

Shiphrah and Puah are named. The name of the Pharaoh is not given. For the Bible, these brave women are more important than the powerful king.

It is not quite clear whether they are lying or telling the truth. What is clear: God is on their side, because they save lives.

Pharaoh's command VERSE 22

22 Then Pharaoh commanded all his people,
"Throw every son who is born into the river.
But let every daughter live."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now it gets even worse. Pharaoh orders all Egyptians to kill the Hebrew boys.

The river is the Nile. For the Egyptians, the Nile was a god who gives life. Now it is to become a place of death.

But it is in the Nile that God will save a child: Moses. The next chapter tells about it.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 2

Moses is born and saved

The child in the basket VERSES 1–10

1 A man from the family of Levi married a woman.
She was a daughter of Levi too.
2 The woman became pregnant and gave birth to a son.
She saw that he was a fine child.
So she hid him for three months.
3 When she could not hide him any longer, she took a basket made of papyrus.
She coated it with tar and with pitch.
Then she put the child in it.
And she laid the basket in the reeds at the bank of the river.
4 His sister stood a little way off.
She wanted to see what would happen to him.
5 Then Pharaoh's daughter came down to the river to bathe.
Her young women walked along the riverbank.
She saw the basket among the reeds.
She sent her servant to get it.
6 She opened it and saw the child.
The baby was crying.
She felt sorry for him.
She said,
"This is one of the Hebrews' children."
7 Then his sister said to Pharaoh's daughter,
"Should I go and call a nurse for you from the Hebrew women?
She can nurse the child for you."
A nurse is a woman who breastfeeds a baby.
8 Pharaoh's daughter said to her,
"Go."
So the girl went and called the child's mother.
9 Pharaoh's daughter said to her,
"Take this child away and nurse him for me.
I will pay you for it."
So the woman took the child and nursed him.
10 The child grew.
Then she brought him to Pharaoh's daughter.
And he became her son.
She named him Moses.
She said,
"Because I drew him out of the water."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses comes from the family of Levi. Later we learn the names of his parents: Amram and Jochebed (Exodus 6:20). His sister is called Miriam.

In Hebrew, the word for "basket" is the same word as "ark" in the story of Noah. Like Noah in his ark, Moses is saved from death in the water in his little "box."

Papyrus is a reed plant that grows by the Nile. People also made paper from it.

Again it is women who save a life: the mother, the sister – and even Pharaoh's daughter, who does not obey her own father.

What a turn: The mother gets her own child back – and is even paid for it!

The name "Moses" probably comes from Egyptian and means "son" or "born." In Hebrew it sounds like "to draw out." Later Moses himself will "draw" his people out of Egypt.

Moses kills an Egyptian VERSES 11–15

11 In those days, when Moses had grown up, he went out to his brothers.
He saw how hard they had to work.
He saw an Egyptian beating a Hebrew, one of his brothers.
12 He looked this way and that way.
When he saw that no one was there, he killed the Egyptian.
And he hid him in the sand.
13 On the next day he went out again.
Two Hebrew men were fighting with each other.
He said to the one who was in the wrong,
"Why are you hitting your neighbor?"
14 The man said,
"Who made you a ruler and a judge over us?
Do you plan to kill me, the way you killed the

Egyptian?"
Then Moses was afraid.
He said, "So people know about this."
15 When Pharaoh heard about it, he tried to kill Moses.
But Moses fled from Pharaoh.
He went to live in the land of Midian.
There he sat down by a well.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses grew up at Pharaoh's court. But he knows that he is a Hebrew. He calls the slaves "his brothers."

He sees injustice and wants to help. But he does it on his own and with violence. He kills a person and hides the body.

The Bible does not praise this. Moses wants justice, but he goes the wrong way. He first has to learn to listen to God.

Midian is a desert region east of Egypt, probably in the northwest of today's Saudi Arabia. The Midianites came from Abraham and Keturah (Genesis 25:2).

Moses in Midian VERSES 16–22

16 The priest of Midian had seven daughters.
They came to the well and drew water.
They filled the troughs to give water to their father's flock.
A trough is a long, open box for water.
17 Then shepherds came and drove them away.
But Moses stood up and helped them.
He gave water to their flock.
18 When they came to Reuel, their father, he asked,
"Why have you come back so early today?"
19 They said,
"An Egyptian saved us from the shepherds.
He even drew water for us and gave water to the flock."
20 He said to his daughters,
"Where is he?
Why did you leave the man there?
Call him, so that he can eat with us."
21 Moses was glad to stay with the man.
And the man gave Moses his daughter Zipporah as his wife.
22 She gave birth to a son.
Moses named him Gershom.
He said,
"I have lived as a foreigner in a foreign land."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again there is a meeting at a well, like with Rebekah and with Rachel. And again it leads to a wedding.

Moses stands up for the weak again. This time without violence.

The women think Moses is an Egyptian, because he is dressed like one.

The priest of Midian has two names: Reuel and Jethro (Exodus 3:1).

"Gershom" sounds like "a foreigner there." Moses feels he has no home: In Egypt he was a Hebrew, in Midian he is a foreigner.

God hears his people cry VERSES 23–25

23 Many years went by.
Then the king of Egypt died.
The people of Israel groaned because of their slavery.
They cried out for help.
And their cry because of the slavery went up to God.
24 God heard their groaning.
And God remembered his covenant with Abraham, with Isaac, and with Jacob.
A covenant is a binding agreement.
25 God saw the people of Israel.
And God understood.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These three verses are the turning point. Here it says "God" four times: God hears. God remembers his covenant. God sees. God understands.

The people suffered for a long time. It seemed as if God was far away. But God has not forgotten anything. He has heard every cry.

"God understood" means more than: He had information. It means: He knows their suffering from the inside. He feels with them.

This message is still true today for all who are oppressed: God hears your cry.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 3

The burning bush

A bush that burns but does not burn up VERSES 1–6

1 Moses was taking care of the flock of Jethro, his father-in-law.
Jethro was the priest of Midian.
Moses led the flock to the far side of the wilderness.
The wilderness is a dry, empty land.
So he came to God's mountain, to Horeb.
2 There the angel of the LORD appeared to him in a flame of fire out of the middle of a bush.
Moses looked.
The bush was burning with fire.
But the bush did not burn up.
3 Moses said,
"I will go over now and see this great sight.
Why does the bush not burn up?"
4 The LORD saw that Moses came over to look.
Then God called to him out of the middle of the bush,
"Moses! Moses!"
Moses said, "Here I am."
5 God said,
"Do not come closer.
Take off your sandals.
For the place where you are standing is holy ground."
6 He also said,
"I am the God of your father,

the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob."
Then Moses hid his face.
For he was afraid to look at God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses is now a simple shepherd in the desert. He is about 80 years old (see Exodus 7:7). He probably did not expect anything great to happen in his life anymore.

Horeb is another name for Mount Sinai.

A fire that burns but does not burn up – a sign that God is present. God is like a fire: full of power, but he does not destroy.

Moses is curious. God calls him by his name, twice – just as with Abraham and Jacob.

"Holy ground": Where God is, an ordinary place becomes special. Taking off your shoes is a sign of deep respect. In many cultures, people still take off their shoes today when they enter a holy place.

God has seen the misery VERSES 7–10

7 The LORD said,
"I have surely seen the misery of my people who are in Egypt.
I have heard them cry out because of their slave drivers.
Yes, I know their pain.
8 So I have come down to save them from the hand of the Egyptians.
I will bring them up out of that land to a good and wide land,
to a land flowing with milk and honey:
to the place of the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Amorite, the Perizzite, the Hivite, and the Jebusite.
9 "Now the cry of the people of Israel has come to me.
I have also seen how the Egyptians oppress them.
10 So come now.
I will send you to Pharaoh.
Bring my people, the people of Israel, out of Egypt."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God says: I have seen, I have heard, I know the pain, I have come down, I will save. God does not stay in heaven. He comes down to those who suffer.

"A land flowing with milk and honey" – that means: a rich, fertile land where there is plenty of everything. Milk from the herds, honey from the bees or from dates.

And then the surprise: God wants to save – and for this he sends Moses. God often acts through people.

"Who am I?" VERSES 11–12

11 Moses said to God,
"Who am I, that I should go to Pharaoh?
And that I should bring the people of Israel out of Egypt?"
12 God said,
"I will certainly be with you.
This will be the sign for you that I have sent you:
When you have brought the people out of Egypt,
you will serve God on this mountain."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Earlier, Moses wanted to help his people by his own strength. Now that God calls him, he feels too small.

God does not answer, "You can do it." He says, "**I** will certainly be with you." What matters is not who Moses is, but who goes with him.

The sign is strange: It comes only when everything is done. Moses first has to trust and set out.

God's name VERSES 13–15

13 Moses said to God,
"Look, I will come to the people of Israel and tell them,
'The God of your ancestors has sent me to you.'
Then they will ask me, 'What is his name?'
What should I tell them?"
14 God said to Moses,
"I AM WHO I AM."
And he said,
"Tell the people of Israel this:
'I AM has sent me to you.'"
15 God also said to Moses,
"Tell the people of Israel this:
'The LORD, the God of your ancestors,
the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob,
has sent me to you.'
This is my name forever.
By this name I am to be remembered in all generations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important passages in the whole Bible: God tells his name.

"I AM WHO I AM" can also be translated: "I will be who I will be" or "I am there as the one who I am there." The name means: God is always there. He is there for his people. But he cannot be pinned down or locked in. He remains a mystery.

From this "I AM" comes God's name "YHWH" (probably pronounced "Yahweh"). In this Bible it is written as "the LORD."

Out of deep respect, Jews do not say this name out loud. Instead they say "Adonai" (my Lord) or "HaShem" (the Name).

In the Gospel of John, Jesus says "I am" several times: "I am the light of the world," "I am the good shepherd." Christians see in this a hint of this name of God.

God's plan VERSES 16–22

16 "Go and gather the elders of Israel.
Tell them,
'The LORD, the God of your ancestors, the God of Abraham, of Isaac, and of Jacob, has appeared to me.
He said,
"I have surely come to look after you.
I have seen what is being done to you in Egypt.
17 And I have said:
I will bring you up out of the misery of Egypt
to the land of the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Amorite, the Perizzite, the Hivite, and the Jebusite,
to a land flowing with milk and honey."'
18 "They will listen to you.
Then you and the elders of Israel will go to the king of Egypt.
You will tell him,
'The LORD, the God of the Hebrews, has met with us.

Now please let us go on a journey of three days into the wilderness.
There we want to offer sacrifices to the LORD, our God.'
19 "But I know that the king of Egypt will not let you go,
not even when a strong hand forces him.
20 So I will reach out my hand.
I will strike Egypt with all my wonders that I will do there.
After that he will let you go.
21 "I will make the Egyptians kind toward this people.
When you go, you will not go with empty hands.
22 Every woman will ask her neighbor, and the woman who visits her house,
for jewelry of silver, jewelry of gold, and clothing.
You will put them on your sons and on your daughters.
So you will take the riches of the Egyptians."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elders were the experienced, respected men who led a people or a town.

God honestly tells Moses ahead of time: It will not be easy. Pharaoh will refuse.

The first request is modest: only three days into the desert to worship God. Pharaoh will refuse even that. This shows how hard he is.

The Israelites are not to leave with empty hands. After so many years of unpaid slave labor, this is like late wages. God had already promised this to Abraham: After this, they will leave that land with great riches (Genesis 15:14).

EXODUS

CHAPTER 4

God gives Moses signs – Moses goes back to Egypt

Three signs VERSES 1–9

1 Moses answered,
"But they will not believe me.
They will not listen to me.
They will say, 'The LORD has not appeared to you.'"
2 The LORD said to him,
"What is that in your hand?"
Moses said,
"A staff."
3 The LORD said,
"Throw it on the ground."
Moses threw it on the ground.
Then it became a snake.
And Moses ran away from it.
4 The LORD said to Moses,
"Reach out your hand and take it by the tail."
Moses reached out his hand and took hold of it.
Then it became a staff in his hand again.
5 "This is so that they may believe that the LORD has appeared to you,
the God of their ancestors,
the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob."
6 The LORD also said to him,
"Now put your hand inside your cloak."
Moses put his hand inside his cloak.
When he took it out, his hand had leprosy.
It was as white as snow.
7 The LORD said,
"Put your hand inside your cloak again."
Moses put his hand inside his cloak again.
When he took it out of his cloak, it was healthy again, like the rest of his body.
8 "If they do not believe you and do not listen to the first sign,
they will believe the second sign.
9 And if they do not believe even these two signs and do not listen to you,
then take some water from the river and pour it on the dry land.
The water that you take from the river will become blood on the dry land."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses still has doubts. God is patient and gives him signs that he can show the Israelites.

The staff was a simple shepherd's staff – the tool of his daily work. God makes something special out of it. God uses what we already have in our hands.

In Egypt, the snake was a sign of Pharaoh's power. Moses grabs it by the tail. This shows: God is stronger than the power of Egypt.

Leprosy was a feared skin disease. God can make people sick and heal them.

The river is the Nile. For the Egyptians, the Nile was holy. When its water turns into blood, it shows: God is Lord over the gods of Egypt too.

"I am not good with words" VERSES 10–17

10 Moses said to the LORD,
"Oh, Lord, I am not good with words.
I was not good with words before,
and I am not good with words now, since you have spoken to your servant.
I speak slowly, and my tongue is slow."
11 The LORD said to him,
"Who made the human mouth?
Who makes a person mute or deaf, seeing or blind?
Is it not I, the LORD?
12 So go now.
I will be with your mouth.
I will teach you what to say."
13 But Moses said,
"Oh, Lord, please send someone else."
14 Then the LORD became very angry with Moses.
He said,
"What about your brother Aaron, the Levite?
I know that he can speak well.
And look: He is already coming out to meet you.
When he sees you, he will be glad in his heart.

15 You will speak to him and put the words in his mouth.
I will be with your mouth and with his mouth.
I will teach you what to do.
16 He will speak to the people for you.
He will be a mouth for you.
And you will be like God to him.
17 Take this staff in your hand.
With it you will do the signs."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses keeps finding new excuses. Maybe he stuttered. Maybe after 40 years in the desert he had forgotten the Egyptian language.

God's answer: I made you. I know your weaknesses. I will help you.

When Moses then simply says "Send someone else," God becomes angry. Behind the excuses is the fear of trusting God.

But God still gives in and sends help: Moses' brother Aaron. God takes our weaknesses into account.

"You will be like God to him" means: Moses receives the message from God and passes it on to Aaron, the way God speaks to a prophet.

Moses goes back to Egypt VERSES 18–23

18 Moses went back to Jethro, his father-in-law.
He said to him,
"Please let me go back to my brothers in Egypt.
I want to see whether they are still alive."
Jethro said to Moses,
"Go in peace."
19 The LORD said to Moses in Midian,
"Go back to Egypt.
For all the men who wanted to kill you are dead."
20 So Moses took his wife and his sons.
He put them on a donkey and went back to the land of Egypt.
Moses took God's staff in his hand.
21 The LORD said to Moses,
"When you go back to Egypt, do all the wonders before Pharaoh that I have put in your hand.
But I will make his heart hard.
Then he will not let the people go.
22 Tell Pharaoh,
'The LORD says:
Israel is my son, my firstborn.
23 I have told you,
"Let my son go, so that he may serve me."
But you have refused to let him go.
So I will kill your son, your firstborn.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses is respectful. He asks his father-in-law for permission.

The shepherd's staff is now called "God's staff." Through God's task, a simple object has become something special.

"I will make his heart hard" – for many readers this is a difficult passage. Does it mean that Pharaoh has no choice? In the next chapters, it often also says: Pharaoh made his heart hard **himself**. Many interpreters understand it like this: Pharaoh decides against God again and again. And God lets him stay with his decision and confirms it.

"Israel is my son, my firstborn" – God loves his people the way a father loves his child. Pharaoh will not set God's son free. So he will lose his own son. That is the last and worst of the 10 plagues (Chapter 12).

A mysterious night VERSES 24–26

24 On the way, at a place where they stayed for the night,
the LORD met Moses.
He wanted to kill him.
25 Then Zipporah took a sharp flint stone.
She cut off the foreskin of her son.
She threw it at his feet and said,
"You really are a bridegroom of blood to me."
26 So the LORD left him alone.
Then she said, "You are a bridegroom of blood."
She said this because of the circumcision.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most mysterious passages in the whole Bible. No one can explain it with complete certainty.

The most common explanation: Moses had not circumcised his son, even though circumcision was the sign of the covenant with God (Genesis 17). Whoever is to lead God's people must take God's covenant seriously himself.

Zipporah, a foreign woman, sees the danger and acts quickly. She saves Moses' life – just like the midwives, his mother, his sister and Pharaoh's daughter did before.

Whose feet she touches – those of Moses or those of the son – is not quite clear in the text. In Hebrew, "feet" can also be a modest word for the private parts.

"Bridegroom of blood" was perhaps an old expression that had to do with circumcision. Today no one knows exactly what it means.

Moses and Aaron with the people VERSES 27–31

27 The LORD said to Aaron,
"Go into the wilderness to meet Moses."
So Aaron went.
He met Moses at God's mountain and kissed him.
28 Moses told Aaron all the words of the LORD, who had sent him.
He also told him about all the signs the LORD had commanded him to do.
29 Then Moses and Aaron went.
They gathered all the elders of the people of Israel.
30 Aaron spoke all the words that the LORD had spoken to Moses.
And he did the signs before the eyes of the people.
31 The people believed.
They heard that the LORD had come to look after the people of Israel,
and that he had seen their misery.
Then they bowed their heads and worshiped.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The brothers meet at God's mountain, where God met Moses in the burning bush.

Moses was afraid that no one would believe him. But exactly the opposite happens: The people believe and worship God.

After long years of oppression, the people finally hear: God has not forgotten us. He has seen our suffering. That is the best news anyone could bring them.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 5

Moses before Pharaoh – the work gets even harder

"Let my people go!" VERSES 1–5

1 After that, Moses and Aaron went to Pharaoh and said,
"The LORD, the God of Israel, says this:
'Let my people go, so that they may hold a festival for me in the wilderness.'"
2 Pharaoh said,
"Who is the LORD, that I should listen to him and let Israel go?
I do not know the LORD.
And I will not let Israel go."
3 They said,
"The God of the Hebrews has met with us.
Please let us go on a journey of three days into the wilderness.
There we want to offer sacrifices to the LORD, our God.
Otherwise he may strike us with a deadly disease or with the sword."
4 The king of Egypt said to them,
"Moses and Aaron, why are you taking the people away from their work?
Get back to your work!"
5 Pharaoh said,
"Look, the people of the land are now many.
And you want them to rest from their work!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Let my people go!" – This sentence became famous. Later it became the cry of many oppressed people, for example enslaved Black people in America ("Let my people go").

Pharaoh thinks he himself is a god. For him, the God of the slaves is a nobody: "Who is the LORD … I do not know the LORD." In the next chapters he will get to know him.

Pharaoh thinks only about how much work the slaves can do. For him, they are not people, only workers.

Bricks without straw VERSES 6–14

6 That same day, Pharaoh gave a command to the slave drivers of the people and to their foremen.
He said,
7 "Do not give the people straw to make bricks anymore, as you did before.
Let them go and gather straw for themselves.
8 But they must still make the same number of bricks as before.
Do not let them make even one less.
For they are lazy.
That is why they cry out, 'Let's go and offer sacrifices to our God.'
9 Make the work heavier for the men.
Keep them busy with their work.
Then they will not pay attention to lies."
10 So the slave drivers of the people and their foremen went out.
They said to the people,
"Pharaoh says this:
'I will not give you straw.
11 Go yourselves and get straw wherever you can find it.
But your work will not become any less.'"
12 So the people spread out through the whole land of Egypt.
They gathered stubble to use as straw.
13 The slave drivers kept pushing them.
They said,
"Finish your work every day, just as when you had straw!"
14 Pharaoh's slave drivers had put Israelite foremen over the people.
These foremen of the people of Israel were beaten.
They were asked,
"Why have you not made as many bricks as before, yesterday and today?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bricks were made from clay, water and chopped straw. The straw made the bricks stronger.

Now the Israelites have to find the straw themselves – and still make just as many bricks. That is impossible. Pharaoh wants to wear them down on purpose.

"Stubble" is the short pieces of stalk that are left in the field after the harvest.

The foremen were Israelites who had to watch over their own people. They are caught in the middle – and they are beaten when their people cannot do the work.

The foremen complain VERSES 15–21

15 Then the foremen of the people of Israel went to Pharaoh.
They cried out to him,
"Why do you treat your servants like this?
16 Your servants are not given any straw.
And still they tell us, 'Make bricks!'
And look: Your servants are beaten.
But the fault is with your own people."
17 But Pharaoh said,
"You are lazy! You are lazy!
That is why you say, 'Let's go and offer sacrifices to the LORD.'
18 Now go and work!
You will not be given any straw.
But you must still deliver the same number of bricks!"
19 Then the foremen of the people of Israel saw that they were in trouble.
For they had been told,
"You must not make one brick less each day!"
20 When they came out from Pharaoh, they met Moses and Aaron.
Moses and Aaron were standing by the way.
21 The foremen said to them,
"May the LORD look at you and judge you!
You have made Pharaoh and his servants hate us.

It is as if we stink to them.
You have put a sword in their hand to kill us!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The foremen ask Pharaoh for justice. But Pharaoh only mocks them.

"Lazy" – this is how an oppressor talks about people he exploits.

Now the Israelites blame Moses and Aaron. Just a short time ago they were worshiping God. Now everything has become worse. Their hope is gone.

Many people know this: Sometimes things first get worse before they get better.

Moses complains to God VERSES 22–23

22 Then Moses turned to the LORD again and said,
"Lord, why have you brought trouble on this people?
Why did you send me at all?
23 Ever since I came to Pharaoh to speak in your name, he has treated this people even worse.
And you have not rescued your people at all!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses is in despair. He did what God wanted – and everything has become worse.

He brings his disappointment straight to God. He even accuses God: "Lord, why have you brought trouble on this people?"

This is allowed. In the Bible, people may tell God about their pain, their anger and their disappointment. An honest prayer of complaint is a prayer too.

In the next chapter, God answers him.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 6

God's promise – the family of Moses and Aaron

"I am the LORD" VERSES 1–8

1 The LORD said to Moses,
"Now you will see what I will do to Pharaoh.
A strong hand will force him to let them go.
Yes, a strong hand will force him to drive them out of his land."
2 God spoke to Moses.
He said to him,
"I am the LORD.
3 I appeared to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob as God Almighty.
But by my name, the LORD, I did not make myself known to them.
4 I also made my covenant with them.
I promised to give them the land of Canaan,
the land where they traveled and lived as foreigners.
5 I have also heard the groaning of the people of Israel,
whom the Egyptians keep as slaves.
And I have remembered my covenant.
6 "So tell the people of Israel,
'I am the LORD.
I will bring you out from under the heavy work of the Egyptians.
I will free you from their slavery.
I will rescue you with an outstretched arm and with great judgments.
7 I will take you as my own people.
I will be your God.
Then you will know that I am the LORD your God,
who brings you out from under the heavy work of the Egyptians.
8 I will bring you into the land that I swore to give to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob.
I will give it to you as your own.
I am the LORD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses had accused God (Chapter 5). God does not answer with an explanation, but with promises.

Verse 3 is hard to understand: The ancestors already used the name "the LORD" in the book of Genesis. Many interpreters understand it like this: The ancestors knew the name, but they had not yet experienced what it means. Only now, as he frees his people from Egypt, does God show who he really is: the God who is there and who saves.

At the beginning and at the end of this speech is the same sentence: "I am the LORD." Everything God promises stands on this foundation.

God promises seven things: to bring out, to free, to rescue, to take as his people, to be their God, to bring them into the land, to give them the land. To this day, Jews remember these promises at the Passover festival with four cups of wine.

In Hebrew, "swore" here is literally: "lifted up my hand." That means: made a solemn promise.

No one listens VERSES 9–13

9 Moses told all this to the people of Israel.
But they did not listen to Moses.
For they had lost all hope because of the cruel slavery.
10 Then the LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
11 "Go in and speak to Pharaoh, the king of Egypt.
Tell him to let the people of Israel go out of his land."
12 But Moses said to the LORD,
"Look, the people of Israel have not listened to me.
How then will Pharaoh listen to me,
when I have uncircumcised lips?"
13 Then the LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron.
He gave them a command for the people of Israel and for Pharaoh, the king of Egypt:
They were to bring the people of Israel out of the land of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Israelites can no longer hear the good news. They are too worn out and too full of despair. When someone suffers very much, sometimes they cannot accept hope anymore.

This is understandable. God does not blame them for it.

Moses literally says: "I have uncircumcised lips." This is an old picture and means: I am clumsy at speaking.

The families of Reuben, Simeon and Levi VERSES 14–25

14 These are the heads of their families:
The sons of Reuben, the firstborn of Israel:
Hanoch, Pallu, Hezron, and Carmi.
These are the families of Reuben.
15 The sons of Simeon:
Jemuel, Jamin, Ohad, Jachin, Zohar,
and Shaul, the son of a Canaanite woman.
These are the families of Simeon.
16 These are the names of the sons of Levi, by their generations:
Gershon, Kohath, and Merari.
Levi lived 137 years.
17 The sons of Gershon:
Libni and Shimei, by their families.
18 The sons of Kohath:
Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel.
Kohath lived 133 years.
19 The sons of Merari:
Mahli and Mushi.
These are the families of the Levites, by their generations.
20 Amram married Jochebed, his father's sister.
She gave birth to Aaron and Moses.
Amram lived 137 years.
21 The sons of Izhar:
Korah, Nepheg, and Zichri.
22 The sons of Uzziel:
Mishael, Elzaphan, and Sithri.
23 Aaron married Elisheba.
She was the daughter of Amminadab and the sister of Nahshon.
She gave birth to Nadab and Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar.
24 The sons of Korah:
Assir, Elkanah, and Abiasaph.
These are the families of the Korahites.
25 Eleazar, Aaron's son, married one of the daughters of Putiel.
She gave birth to Phinehas.
These are the heads of the families of the Levites, by their families.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the exciting story, there is suddenly a family list. It shows: Moses and Aaron are not just anyone. They have a family history. They come from Levi, a son of Jacob.

The list begins with Reuben and Simeon, the oldest sons of Jacob, and then comes to Levi. With Levi, it becomes detailed, because Moses and Aaron and later all the priests come from this tribe.

Moses' parents are Amram and Jochebed. Jochebed was Amram's aunt. Later God forbade such marriages (Leviticus 18:12).

Some names will become important later: Korah will lead a rebellion against Moses (Numbers 16). Nadab and Abihu die because they do not honor God (Leviticus 10). Phinehas will become a brave priest.

Nahshon later became the leader of the tribe of Judah and an ancestor of King David.

Moses and Aaron VERSES 26–30

26 These are the same Aaron and Moses to whom the LORD said,
"Bring the people of Israel out of the land of Egypt, in order, by their armies."
27 They are the ones who spoke to Pharaoh, the king of Egypt,
to bring the people of Israel out of Egypt.
These are the same Moses and Aaron.
28 On the day when the LORD spoke to Moses in the land of Egypt,
29 the LORD said to Moses,
"I am the LORD.
Tell Pharaoh, the king of Egypt, everything that I tell you."
30 But Moses said to the LORD,
"Look, I have uncircumcised lips.
How will Pharaoh listen to me?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the list, the story goes back exactly to where it stopped: to Moses' doubts.

"By their armies" means here: the people, in order like a great army. The slaves are not to leave as scattered refugees, but as God's people.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 7

Aaron's staff – the first plague: blood

Moses and Aaron get their task VERSES 1–7

1 The LORD said to Moses,
"Look, I have made you like God to Pharaoh.
And Aaron, your brother, will be your prophet.
2 You will speak everything that I command you.
And Aaron, your brother, will speak to Pharaoh,
so that he lets the people of Israel go out of his land.
3 "But I will make Pharaoh's heart hard.
And I will do many signs and wonders in the land of Egypt.
4 Pharaoh will not listen to you.
So I will lay my hand on Egypt.
I will bring my armies, my people, the people of Israel,

out of the land of Egypt
with great judgments.
5 Then the Egyptians will know that I am the LORD,
when I reach out my hand against Egypt
and bring the people of Israel out from among them."
6 Moses and Aaron did so.
They did just as the LORD had commanded them.
7 Moses was 80 years old, and Aaron was 83 years old,
when they spoke to Pharaoh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A prophet is someone who passes on God's words to others. Here Moses passes on God's words to Aaron, and Aaron tells them to Pharaoh.

Pharaoh thinks he himself is a god. Now an old shepherd stands before him and speaks with the power of the true God.

Again and again it says: The Egyptians will "know that I am the LORD." Remember: Pharaoh had said, "I do not know the LORD" (Exodus 5:2). Now he will get to know him.

Moses is 80 years old! For God, it is never too late to use someone.

The staff becomes a snake VERSES 8–13

8 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron.
He said,
9 "When Pharaoh says to you, 'Do a miracle!'
then tell Aaron,
'Take your staff and throw it down before Pharaoh,
and it will become a snake.'"
10 So Moses and Aaron went to Pharaoh.
They did as the LORD had commanded.
Aaron threw down his staff before Pharaoh and before his servants.
And it became a snake.
11 Then Pharaoh also called for his wise men and his sorcerers.
The magicians of Egypt did the same thing with their secret arts.
12 Each of them threw down his staff, and the staffs became snakes.
But Aaron's staff swallowed up their staffs.
13 But Pharaoh's heart stayed hard.
He did not listen to them, just as the LORD had said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Egyptian magicians can copy the trick. But Aaron's staff eats up their staffs. This shows: God's power is greater than all the magic of Egypt.

Still, Pharaoh is not impressed. A hard heart does not see even a miracle.

Later the magicians are called "Jannes and Jambres" (2 Timothy 3:8). But their names are not in this chapter.

The first plague: The water turns into blood VERSES 14–25

14 The LORD said to Moses,
"Pharaoh's heart is stubborn.
He refuses to let the people go.
15 Go to Pharaoh in the morning.
Look, he will be going out to the water.
Stand on the bank of the river to meet him.
Take in your hand the staff that turned into a snake.
16 Tell him,
'The LORD, the God of the Hebrews, has sent me to you.
He says, "Let my people go, so that they may serve me in the wilderness.
But until now you have not listened."
17 The LORD says, "By this you will know that I am the LORD:
Look, I will strike the water in the river with the staff that is in my hand.
Then it will turn into blood.
18 The fish in the river will die.
And the river will stink.
The Egyptians will not be able to stand drinking water from the river."'"
19 The LORD said to Moses,
"Tell Aaron,
'Take your staff and reach out your hand over the waters of Egypt:
over their rivers, over their streams, over their pools, and over all their ponds of water.
Then they will become blood.
There will be blood in the whole land of Egypt,
even in containers of wood and containers of stone.'"
20 Moses and Aaron did so, just as the LORD had commanded.
He lifted up the staff and struck the water in the river, before the eyes of Pharaoh and before the eyes of his servants.
Then all the water in the river turned into blood.
21 The fish in the river died.
The river stank.
The Egyptians could not drink water from the river.
There was blood in the whole land of Egypt.
22 But the magicians of Egypt did the same thing with their secret arts.
So Pharaoh's heart stayed hard.
He did not listen to them, just as the LORD had said.
23 Pharaoh turned and went into his house.
He did not take even this to heart.
24 All the Egyptians dug around the river for water to drink.
For they could not drink the water of the river.
25 Seven days went by after the LORD had struck the river.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the 10 plagues begin. A plague is a great disaster that comes over a land.

The river is the Nile. The Nile was the heart of Egypt. The Egyptians worshiped it as a god. God shows: The Nile is not a god. I am the Lord over it.

Remember: Pharaoh had ordered the Hebrew babies to be thrown into the Nile (Exodus 1:22). Now the Nile itself turns into blood.

Pharaoh simply goes home. He has enough to drink after all. He does not care about the suffering of his people.

Some researchers try to explain the plagues by natural events, for example red algae in the Nile. The Bible tells them as acts of God. What matters is not how it happened, but what it shows: God is mightier than Pharaoh and his gods.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 8

Frogs, lice and flies

The second plague: frogs VERSES 1–15

1 The LORD said to Moses,
"Go to Pharaoh and tell him,
'The LORD says this:
"Let my people go, so that they may serve me.
2 If you refuse to let them go,
look: I will strike your whole country with frogs.
3 The river will swarm with frogs.
They will come up and come into your house,
into your bedroom and onto your bed,
into the houses of your servants and onto your people,
into your ovens and into your bowls for making dough.
4 The frogs will come up onto you,
onto your people and onto all your servants."'"
5 The LORD said to Moses,
"Tell Aaron,
'Reach out your hand with your staff over the rivers,
over the streams, and over the pools.
Make frogs come up onto the land of Egypt.'"
6 So Aaron reached out his hand over the waters of Egypt.
And the frogs came up and covered the land of Egypt.
7 But the magicians did the same thing with their secret arts.
They too made frogs come up onto the land of Egypt.
8 Then Pharaoh called for Moses and Aaron.
He said,
"Pray to the LORD that he takes the frogs away from me and from my people.
Then I will let the people go, so that they can offer sacrifices to the LORD."
9 Moses said to Pharaoh,
"You may have the honor of choosing the time when I should pray for you, for your servants, and for your people.
Then the frogs will be gone from you and from your houses.
They will stay only in the river."
10 Pharaoh said,
"Tomorrow."
Moses said,
"Let it be as you say.
Then you will know that there is no one like the LORD, our God.
11 The frogs will leave you, your houses, your servants, and your people.
They will stay only in the river."
12 Moses and Aaron went out from Pharaoh.
And Moses cried out to the LORD about the frogs that he had brought on Pharaoh.
13 The LORD did what Moses asked.
The frogs died in the houses, in the courtyards, and in the fields.
14 People gathered them together in heaps.
And the land stank.
15 But when Pharaoh saw that he had some relief, he made his heart hard.
He did not listen to them, just as the LORD had said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles, the verses of this chapter have different numbers. There, the beginning (verses 1–4) is still part of Chapter 7. This Bible follows the numbering of the WEB, our English source text.

Frogs everywhere: in bed, in the oven, in the dough. A disgusting, annoying plague. The Egyptians worshiped a goddess with the head of a frog. She stood for having many children and good harvests. Now frogs become a plague.

The magicians can make even more frogs appear – but not one single frog goes away because of them. Only God can end the plague.

Moses lets Pharaoh choose the time. So no one can say it was by chance.

As soon as the trouble is over, Pharaoh forgets his promise. People today know this too: When they are in trouble, they pray. Afterward, everything is forgotten.

The third plague: lice VERSES 16–19

16 The LORD said to Moses,
"Tell Aaron,
'Reach out your staff and strike the dust of the earth.
Then it will become lice in the whole land of Egypt.'"
17 They did so.
Aaron reached out his hand with his staff and struck the dust of the earth.
Then there were lice on people and on animals.
All the dust of the earth became lice in the whole land of Egypt.
18 The magicians tried with their secret arts to make lice too.
But they could not.
There were lice on people and on animals.
19 Then the magicians said to Pharaoh,
"This is God's finger."
But Pharaoh's heart stayed hard.
He did not listen to them, just as the LORD had said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Hebrew word can mean lice, tiny biting gnats, or fleas. It means tiny pests that crawl and bite everywhere.

This plague comes without a warning.

Now the magicians are at their end. They admit: "This is God's finger." That means: Here a power is at work that is greater than all human skill.

Pharaoh's own advisers see it. Only Pharaoh does not want to see it.

The fourth plague: flies VERSES 20–32

20 The LORD said to Moses,
"Get up early in the morning and stand before

Pharaoh.
Look, he will be coming out to the water.
Tell him,
'The LORD says this:
"Let my people go, so that they may serve me.
21 If you do not let my people go,
look: I will send swarms of flies on you, on your servants, on your people, and into your houses.
The houses of the Egyptians will be full of swarms of flies,
and so will the ground they stand on.
22 But on that day I will set apart the land of Goshen,
where my people live.
There will be no swarms of flies there.
By this you will know that I am the LORD on the earth.
23 I will make a difference between my people and your people.
This sign will happen tomorrow."'"
24 The LORD did so.
Terrible swarms of flies came into the house of Pharaoh and into the houses of his servants.
In the whole land of Egypt, the land was ruined by the swarms of flies.
25 Then Pharaoh called for Moses and Aaron.
He said,
"Go and offer sacrifices to your God here in the land!"
26 Moses said,
"That would not be right.
For what we sacrifice to the LORD, our God, is disgusting to the Egyptians.
Look, if we sacrifice before their eyes what is disgusting to the Egyptians,
will they not throw stones at us until we die?
27 We will go on a journey of three days into the wilderness.
There we will sacrifice to the LORD, our God, as he will command us."
28 Pharaoh said,
"I will let you go, so that you may sacrifice to the LORD, your God, in the wilderness.
Only do not go very far away.
Pray for me."
29 Moses said,
"Look, I am leaving you now.
I will pray to the LORD that the swarms of flies leave Pharaoh, his servants, and his people tomorrow.
Only Pharaoh must not trick us again
by not letting the people go to sacrifice to the LORD."
30 Moses went out from Pharaoh and prayed to the LORD.
31 The LORD did what Moses asked.
He took the swarms of flies away from Pharaoh, from his servants, and from his people.
Not one fly was left.
32 But Pharaoh made his heart hard this time too.
He did not let the people go.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

New in this plague: God makes a difference. The land of Goshen, where the Israelites live, is spared. This shows: It is not by chance. God is on the side of his people.

Pharaoh begins to bargain: First "offer sacrifices to your God here in the land," then "only do not go very far away." He wants to give in a little, but not completely.

The Israelites sacrificed sheep, goats and cattle. Some of these animals were holy in Egypt. A sacrifice before the eyes of the Egyptians would have caused great anger.

"Pray for me." – The mighty Pharaoh needs the prayers of his slaves.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 9

Disease of the livestock, boils and hail

The fifth plague: the livestock die VERSES 1–7

1 Then the LORD said to Moses,
"Go to Pharaoh and tell him,
'The LORD, the God of the Hebrews, says this:
"Let my people go, so that they may serve me.
2 If you refuse to let them go and still hold on to them,
3 look: The hand of the LORD will come on your livestock in the field,
on the horses, on the donkeys, on the camels, on the herds of cattle, and on the flocks of sheep and goats.
A very terrible disease will come.
4 But the LORD will make a difference between the livestock of Israel and the livestock of Egypt.
Of everything that belongs to the people of Israel, not one animal will die."'"
5 The LORD set a time.
He said,
"Tomorrow the LORD will do this in the land."
6 On the next day the LORD did it.
All the livestock of Egypt died.
But of the livestock of the people of Israel, not one animal died.
7 Pharaoh sent people to check.
Not even one animal of the Israelites' livestock had died.
But Pharaoh's heart stayed stubborn.
He did not let the people go.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the livestock are struck. They were the wealth of Egypt. Here too, the Egyptians worshiped gods in the form of animals, for example a holy bull.

Again God makes a difference. Pharaoh even checks it himself – and it is true. Still he does not give in.

"All the livestock" here probably means: the livestock in the fields. For in the plague of hail, livestock are mentioned again.

The sixth plague: boils VERSES 8–12

8 The LORD said to Moses and to Aaron,
"Take handfuls of ashes from a furnace.
Let Moses throw them up toward the sky before
Pharaoh's eyes.
9 Then they will become fine dust over the whole land of
Egypt.
And on people and on animals they will become boils
that break open into blisters,
in the whole land of Egypt."
10 So they took ashes from a furnace and stood before
Pharaoh.
Moses threw them up toward the sky.
Then people and animals got boils that broke open into
blisters.
11 The magicians could not stand before Moses because of
the boils.
For the magicians had the boils, just like all the
Egyptians.
12 But the LORD made Pharaoh's heart hard.
He did not listen to them, just as the LORD had told
Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A boil is a swollen, painful spot on the skin that is full of pus.

Ashes from a furnace – perhaps from an oven where bricks were baked. The Israelites were tormented with bricks. Now the punishment comes out of this oven.

The magicians cannot even stand anymore. They are sick themselves.

For the first time, it says clearly here: "The LORD made Pharaoh's heart hard." Before this, Pharaoh did it himself, five times. Now God confirms his decision.

The seventh plague: hail VERSES 13–35

13 The LORD said to Moses,
"Get up early in the morning, stand before Pharaoh,
and tell him,
'The LORD, the God of the Hebrews, says this:
"Let my people go, so that they may serve me.
14 For this time I will send all my plagues against you
yourself, against your officials, and against your
people.
By this you will know that there is no one like me in all
the earth.
15 By now I could have reached out my hand
and struck you and your people with a deadly disease.
Then you would have been wiped off the earth.
16 But this is the very reason why I have let you stand:
to show you my power,
and so that my name may be made known in all the
earth.
17 You still set yourself up proudly against my people and
will not let them go.
18 Look: Tomorrow at about this time I will make a very
terrible hail fall.
There has never been hail like it in Egypt, from the day
Egypt was founded until now.
19 So now send word.
Bring your livestock and everything you have in the
field into a safe place.
The hail will fall on every person and every animal that
is in the field and is not brought home.
And they will die."'"
20 Some of Pharaoh's servants feared the word of the
LORD.
They quickly brought their servants and their
livestock into the houses.
21 But whoever did not respect the word of the LORD
left his servants and his livestock in the field.
22 The LORD said to Moses,
"Reach out your hand toward the sky.
Then there will be hail in the whole land of Egypt,
on people, on animals, and on every plant of the field,
in the whole land of Egypt."
23 Moses reached out his staff toward the sky.
And the LORD sent thunder and hail.
Lightning flashed down to the earth.
The LORD made hail rain on the land of Egypt.
24 So there was very heavy hail, and lightning flashed in
the middle of the hail.
There had never been anything like it in all the land of
Egypt since it became a nation.
25 In the whole land of Egypt, the hail struck down
everything that was in the field, both people and
animals.
The hail struck down every plant of the field.
And it broke every tree of the field.
26 Only in the land of Goshen, where the people of Israel
were, there was no hail.
27 Then Pharaoh sent for Moses and Aaron.
He said to them,
"This time I have sinned.
The LORD is in the right.
I and my people are in the wrong.
28 Pray to the LORD!
There has been enough of this mighty thunder and
hail.
I will let you go.
You do not have to stay any longer."
29 Moses said to him,
"As soon as I have gone out of the city, I will spread out
my hands to the LORD.
Then the thunder will stop, and there will be no more
hail.
By this you will know that the earth belongs to the
LORD.
30 But as for you and your servants, I know that you do
not yet fear the LORD God."
31 The flax and the barley were struck down.
For the barley was ripe, and the flax was in bloom.
32 But the wheat and the spelt were not struck down.
For they had not yet come up.
33 Moses left Pharaoh and went out of the city.
He spread out his hands to the LORD.
Then the thunder and the hail stopped.
And the rain no longer poured down on the earth.
34 When Pharaoh saw that the rain and the hail and the
thunder had stopped, he sinned even more.
He and his servants made their hearts hard.
35 Pharaoh's heart stayed hard.
He did not let the people of Israel go, just as the LORD
had said through Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This plague is special. God warns ahead of time and gives advice: Bring people and animals to a safe place. God does not want people to die.

And some Egyptians listen to him! In the middle of Egypt, there are people who take God's word seriously. God saves everyone who listens to him – no matter which people they come from.

For the first time, Pharaoh says: "I have sinned." But Moses sees through him: This is not real regret. Pharaoh is only afraid.

Flax is a plant that people make linen from. Barley and wheat are grains. Spelt is an old kind of wheat.

It is important that the wheat and the spelt are not struck down yet: So something is still left – for the next plague, the locusts.

The apostle Paul quotes verse 16 in the New Testament (Romans 9:17).

EXODUS

Chapter 10

Locusts and darkness

A warning about the locusts VERSES 1–6

1 The LORD said to Moses,
"Go to Pharaoh.
For I have made his heart hard, and the heart of his servants,
so that I may show these signs of mine among them.
2 And so that you may tell your son and your grandson
what I have done to Egypt,
and the signs that I have done among them.
Then you will know that I am the LORD."
3 So Moses and Aaron went to Pharaoh and said to him,
"The LORD, the God of the Hebrews, says this:
'How long will you refuse to humble yourself before me?
Let my people go, so that they may serve me.
4 If you refuse to let my people go,
look: Tomorrow I will bring locusts into your country.
5 They will cover the surface of the ground,
so that no one will be able to see the ground.
They will eat what is left over for you, what escaped the hail.
And they will eat every tree that grows for you in the field.
6 Your houses will be full of them,
and the houses of all your servants and the houses of all the Egyptians.
Neither your ancestors nor their ancestors have seen anything like it,
from the day they came onto the earth until today.'"
Then Moses turned and went out from Pharaoh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here God explains why he does all this: The story is to be told again and again, by parents to children and grandchildren. To this day, Jewish families tell this story to their children every year at the Passover festival.

Locusts are large insects. They fly in huge swarms with millions of animals and eat up everything green in a short time. To this day, swarms of locusts are a feared plague in Africa and in the Middle East.

"To humble yourself before me" means: to become humble, to admit that God is greater.

The officials grow impatient VERSES 7–11

7 Pharaoh's servants said to him,
"How long will this man be a trap for us?
Let the men go, so that they may serve the LORD, their God.
Do you still not understand that Egypt is ruined?"
8 So Moses and Aaron were brought back to Pharaoh.
He said to them,
"Go, serve the LORD, your God.
But who exactly will go?"
9 Moses said,
"We will go with our young and with our old.
We will go with our sons and with our daughters,
with our flocks and with our herds.
For we must hold a festival for the LORD."
10 Pharaoh said to them,
"The LORD will have to be with you if I ever let you go with your little children!
Look, you clearly have evil plans!
11 No, not like this!
You men go and serve the LORD.
That is what you want after all!"
Then they were driven out from Pharaoh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now even Pharaoh's own officials push him. They see: Egypt is being ruined. But Pharaoh stays stubborn.

Pharaoh wants to let only the men go. The women and children are to stay behind as a guarantee. Then the men would surely come back.

Moses insists: Everyone belongs. Young and old, men and women. A festival for God is a festival for the whole family.

Pharaoh means "The LORD will have to be with you" in a mocking way. He does not believe in it.

The eighth plague: locusts VERSES 12–20

12 The LORD said to Moses,
"Reach out your hand over the land of Egypt for the locusts,
so that they come up over the land of Egypt
and eat every plant in the land, everything that the hail has left."
13 So Moses reached out his staff over the land of Egypt.
And the LORD made an east wind blow over the land all that day and all night.

When it was morning, the east wind had brought the locusts.
14 The locusts came up over the whole land of Egypt.
They settled down in every part of Egypt.
It was a terrible swarm.
There had never been so many locusts before, and there will never be so many again.
15 They covered the surface of the whole ground, so that the land became dark.
They ate every plant in the land and all the fruit on the trees that the hail had left.
In the whole land of Egypt, nothing green was left, no tree and no plant of the field.
16 Then Pharaoh quickly called for Moses and Aaron.
He said,
"I have sinned against the LORD, your God, and against you.
17 Now please forgive my sin just this once more.
And pray to the LORD, your God, that he will at least take this deadly disaster away from me."
18 So Moses went out from Pharaoh and prayed to the LORD.
19 Then the LORD sent a very strong west wind.
It picked up the locusts and drove them into the Red Sea.
Not one locust was left in all of Egypt.
20 But the LORD made Pharaoh's heart hard.
He did not let the people of Israel go.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What the hail left behind, the locusts now eat. Egypt is bare. A famine is coming.

Pharaoh admits his guilt – again only because he is in trouble.

In the Hebrew original, the sea is called the "Sea of Reeds." Many Bibles say "Red Sea." Later the Israelites will go through this sea.

The ninth plague: darkness VERSES 21–29

21 The LORD said to Moses,
"Reach out your hand toward the sky.
Then darkness will come over the land of Egypt,
a darkness that people can feel."
22 So Moses reached out his hand toward the sky.
And there was thick darkness in the whole land of Egypt for three days.
23 People could not see one another.
For three days, no one got up from his place.
But all the people of Israel had light where they lived.
24 Then Pharaoh called for Moses.
He said,
"Go, serve the LORD.
Only your flocks and your herds must stay here.
Your little children may go with you too."
25 Moses said,
"You must also give us animals for sacrifices and burnt offerings,
so that we can sacrifice them to the LORD, our God.
26 Our livestock must also go with us.
Not one hoof may be left behind.
For we must take some of them to serve the LORD, our God.
And we do not know what we must use to serve the LORD until we get there."
A burnt offering is an animal that is completely burned on the altar for God.
27 But the LORD made Pharaoh's heart hard.
He would not let them go.
28 Pharaoh said to Moses,
"Get away from me!
Be careful never to see my face again!
For on the day you see my face, you will die!"
29 Moses said,
"You have spoken well.
I will never see your face again."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The highest god of the Egyptians was the sun god Ra. Pharaoh was thought to be his son. Now the sun is gone for three days. The sun god has no power.

But the Israelites have light. That is a strong picture: In the middle of darkness, God's people have light.

Again Pharaoh wants to bargain: Now all the people may go, but the livestock must stay. Without livestock they could not survive in the desert – and would have to come back.

"Not one hoof" means: not one single animal.

Pharaoh threatens Moses with death. Moses answers calmly: Fine, we will not see each other again. The conversation is over. Now the last plague comes.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 11

The last plague is announced

One more plague VERSES 1–3

1 The LORD said to Moses,
"I will bring one more plague on Pharaoh and on Egypt.
After that he will let you go from here.
When he lets you go, he will even drive you out completely.
2 Speak now to the people.
Let every man ask his neighbor, and every woman her neighbor,
for jewelry of silver and jewelry of gold."
3 The LORD made the Egyptians kind toward the people.
And the man Moses himself was very great in the land of Egypt,
in the eyes of Pharaoh's servants and in the eyes of the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God reminds them of his promise from Chapter 3: The Israelites are not to leave with empty hands.

Interesting: By now the Egyptians have great respect for Moses and the Israelites. They have seen who the true God is. Only Pharaoh does not want to admit it.

The announcement VERSES 4–8

4 Moses said,
"The LORD says this:
'At about midnight I will go out through the middle of Egypt.
5 Then every firstborn in the land of Egypt will die,
from the firstborn of Pharaoh, who sits on his throne,
to the firstborn of the female slave who works at the hand mill,
and all the firstborn of the livestock.
6 There will be a great cry in the whole land of Egypt.
There has never been such a cry, and there will never be one like it again.
7 But against the people of Israel, not even a dog will bark or move its tongue,
neither against people nor against animals.
By this you will know that the LORD makes a difference between the Egyptians and Israel.
8 All these servants of yours will come down to me.
They will bow down to me and say,
"Get out, you and all the people who follow you!"
And after that I will go out.'"
Then Moses went out from Pharaoh, burning with anger.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the most terrible plague. Many readers ask: How can God do something like this?

The Bible tells it like this: Pharaoh was the first to have the Hebrew babies killed (Chapter 1). God warned him: "Israel is my son, my firstborn. ... So I will kill your son, your firstborn" (Exodus 4:22–23). Pharaoh had the chance to turn around nine times. He did not use it.

The plague strikes everyone, from the king's family to the poorest slave woman at the mill. Through his stubbornness, Pharaoh brings endless suffering on his own people.

The Bible does not make this look nice. It shows: Whoever refuses God again and again and oppresses others brings death on himself and on others.

To this day, at the Passover festival, many Jews let a drop of wine fall from their cup for each plague as they tell the story. This shows: We are glad about our freedom – but we also grieve over the suffering of the Egyptians.

"Not even a dog will bark" means: The Israelites stay completely undisturbed.

Moses is angry – because of Pharaoh's stubbornness and because of the suffering that will now come.

Summary VERSES 9–10

9 The LORD said to Moses,
"Pharaoh will not listen to you.
So I will do even more wonders in the land of Egypt."
10 Moses and Aaron did all these wonders before Pharaoh.
But the LORD made Pharaoh's heart hard.
He did not let the people of Israel go out of his land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These two verses are like a look back at the nine plagues. Everything has happened just as God announced.

In the next chapter the last plague happens – and the people of Israel celebrate the Passover festival for the first time.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 12

The first Passover – the going out from Egypt

A new calendar VERSES 1–2

1 The LORD spoke to Moses and Aaron in the land of Egypt.
He said,
2 "This month will be the beginning of months for you.
It will be the first month of the year for you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Being set free is so important that a new year begins with it. The life of the people starts completely new.

This month is in the spring, in March or April. Later it was called "Nisan."

The Passover lamb VERSES 3–11

3 "Speak to the whole community of Israel.
Tell them this:
On the tenth day of this month, every man must take a lamb for his family,
one lamb for each household.
4 If a household is too small for a whole lamb,
then he must share one with his nearest neighbor.
Count by the number of people.
Figure out how much lamb you need by how much each person can eat.
5 Your lamb must be without any defect, a male, one year old.
You may take it from the sheep or from the goats.
6 Keep it until the fourteenth day of this month.
Then the whole gathered community of Israel must kill it in the evening.
7 "Take some of the blood.
Put it on the two doorposts and on the beam above the door of the houses where you eat it.
8 That night you must eat the meat, roasted over the fire.
Eat it with bread without yeast and with bitter herbs.
9 Do not eat it raw or boiled in water.
Eat it roasted over the fire, with its head, its legs and its inner parts.
10 Do not leave any of it until the morning.
Whatever is left until the morning, you must burn in the fire.
11 "This is how you must eat it:
with your belt around your waist, your sandals on your feet, and your staff in your hand.

Eat it in a hurry.
It is the LORD's Passover.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Passover" (in Hebrew "Pesach") means "passing over" or "sparing." God passes over the houses of the Israelites and spares them.

Every family is to join the celebration. Small and poor families too: They join together with their neighbors.

The blood on the door is a sign of protection.

Bread without yeast is made without sourdough or yeast. It is flat and quick to make. There is no time to wait for the dough to rise.

The bitter herbs are a reminder of the bitter life in slavery (Exodus 1:14).

People eat dressed and ready to travel, with shoes on their feet. Very soon they will set out into freedom.

God's judgment and the sign of the blood VERSES 12–14

12 "For on that night I will go through the land of Egypt.
I will strike every firstborn in the land of Egypt, both people and animals.
And I will bring judgment on all the gods of Egypt.
I am the LORD.
13 The blood will be a sign for you on the houses where you are.
When I see the blood, I will pass over you.
No plague will come on you to destroy you when I strike the land of Egypt.
14 "This day will be a day of remembering for you.
You must celebrate it as a festival for the LORD.
Celebrate it as a festival through all your generations.
This is a rule forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The plagues were also a judgment on the gods of Egypt. They showed: These gods cannot help.

The blood of the lamb saves. Death passes by the house with the blood.

To this day, Jews celebrate the Passover festival every year, for more than 3,000 years, generation after generation.

For Christians, this festival has a special meaning: Jesus died exactly at the time of the Passover festival. Before that, he celebrated the Passover meal with his disciples – the Last Supper. In the New Testament, Jesus is called "our Passover lamb" (1 Corinthians 5:7). Christians believe: His blood saves from death.

The Feast of Unleavened Bread VERSES 15–20

15 "For seven days you must eat bread without yeast.
On the very first day you must remove all yeast from your houses.
For whoever eats bread made with yeast from the first day to the seventh day
must be cut off from Israel.
16 On the first day you must have a holy gathering,
and on the seventh day a holy gathering too.
No kind of work may be done on these days.
You may only prepare the food that everyone must eat.
17 "Keep the Feast of Unleavened Bread.
For on this very day I brought your armies out of the land of Egypt.
So you must keep this day through all your generations.
This is a rule forever.
18 "In the first month, from the evening of the fourteenth day of the month,
you must eat bread without yeast until the evening of the twenty-first day of the month.
19 For seven days there must be no yeast in your houses.
For whoever eats anything made with yeast must be cut off from the community of Israel,
whether he is a foreigner or someone born in the land.
20 Eat nothing made with yeast.
In all the places where you live, you must eat bread without yeast."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Besides the Passover meal on the one night, there is a festival that lasts seven days. For a whole week, people eat only flat bread without yeast. Jews call it "matzah."

In the Bible, yeast often stands for something old that spreads everywhere. Before the new beginning comes, the old is cleared away. To this day, Jewish families clean the whole house before the Passover festival and look for every crumb of bread made with yeast.

"To be cut off" means: to no longer belong to the community of the people.

Moses passes on the instructions VERSES 21–28

21 Then Moses called all the elders of Israel.
He said to them,
"Go and pick out lambs for your families.
And kill the Passover lamb.
22 Take a bunch of hyssop.
Dip it in the blood that is in the bowl.
Then put some of the blood from the bowl on the beam above the door and on the two doorposts.
None of you may go out of the door of his house until the morning.
23 "For the LORD will go through the land to strike the Egyptians.
When he sees the blood on the beam above the door and on the two doorposts,
the LORD will pass over the door.
He will not let the destroyer come into your houses to strike you.
24 "You must keep this.
It is a rule for you and for your sons forever.
25 When you come to the land that the LORD will give you, as he has promised,
you must keep this service.
26 When your children ask you,
'What does this service mean to you?'
27 then you must say,
'It is the sacrifice of the LORD's Passover.
He passed over the houses of the people of Israel in Egypt
when he struck the Egyptians.
He spared our houses.'"
Then the people bowed their heads and worshiped.
28 The people of Israel went and did so.
They did just as the LORD had commanded Moses and Aaron.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hyssop is a small plant with many leaves. People could use it like a brush.

The "destroyer" is a picture for death that goes through the land.

The children are to ask. And the parents are to tell. To this day, at the Passover festival, the youngest child asks: "Why is this night different from all other nights?" Then the adults tell the story of how God set his people free.

Faith is passed on by telling what God has done.

The last plague VERSES 29–36

29 At midnight the LORD struck every firstborn in the land of Egypt,
from the firstborn of Pharaoh, who sat on his throne,
to the firstborn of the prisoner who was in the dungeon,
and all the firstborn of the livestock.
30 Pharaoh got up in the night, he and all his servants and all the Egyptians.
And there was a great cry in Egypt.
For there was not a house where no one was dead.
31 That same night Pharaoh called for Moses and Aaron.
He said,
"Get up! Get out from among my people, both you and the people of Israel!
Go, serve the LORD, as you have said!
32 Take your flocks and your herds too, as you have said.
Go!
And bless me too!"
33 The Egyptians pushed the people to leave the land quickly.
For they said,
"We will all be dead!"
34 So the people took their dough before yeast had made it rise.
They wrapped their bowls for making dough in their clothes and carried them on their shoulders.
35 The people of Israel did what Moses had said.
They asked the Egyptians for jewelry of silver, jewelry of gold, and clothing.
36 The LORD had made the Egyptians kind toward the people.
So the Egyptians gave them what they asked for.
In this way they took the riches of the Egyptians.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What God announced now happens. In every house in Egypt, people mourn – in the palace too. Pharaoh loses his own son.

Now Pharaoh finally gives in. He gives everything he refused before: Everyone may go, with all the livestock.

"And bless me too!" – The proud Pharaoh, who thought he was a god, asks the slaves for their blessing.

The Israelites must leave so quickly that the dough has no time to rise. The bread without yeast is a reminder of this.

Setting out VERSES 37–42

37 The people of Israel traveled from Rameses to Succoth.
There were about 600,000 men on foot, not counting the children.
38 A large mixed crowd of other people went up with them too.
There were also flocks and herds, a very large number of livestock.
39 From the dough that they had brought out of Egypt, they baked flat cakes without yeast.
For the dough had not risen.
They had been driven out of Egypt.
They could not wait, and they had not made any food for the journey.
40 The people of Israel had lived in Egypt for 430 years.
41 At the end of the 430 years, on that very day, all the armies of the LORD went out of the land of Egypt.
42 It is a night to be kept for the LORD, because he brought them out of the land of Egypt.
This is the LORD's night.
All the people of Israel must keep it through all their generations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

600,000 men – with women and children, that would be more than two million people. That is a huge number. Some experts think that the Hebrew word for "thousand" could also mean "family" or "group" here. Then there would have been fewer people. Others take the number literally.

A "large mixed crowd of other people" goes with them. They were probably Egyptians and other slaves who joined them. From the very beginning, God's people are open to people from other nations.

430 years – a long time. God had already told Abraham that his descendants would live in a foreign land for a long time (Genesis 15:13).

This night belongs to the LORD. That is why the Israelites are to keep it: They stay awake on this night and celebrate.

Who may celebrate the Passover? VERSES 43–51

43 The LORD said to Moses and Aaron,
"This is the rule for the Passover:
No foreigner may eat of it.
44 But every slave who was bought for money may eat of it once you have circumcised him.
45 A foreigner who is only staying with you and a hired worker may not eat of it.
46 The Passover lamb must be eaten in one house.
You must not carry any of the meat outside the house.
And you must not break any of its bones.
47 The whole community of Israel must keep it.
48 "A stranger may live with you as a foreigner and may want to keep the Passover for the LORD.
Then all the males in his family must be circumcised.
After that he may come and keep it.
He will be like someone born in the land.
But no one who is not circumcised may eat of it.
49 The same law is for the one who is born in the land and for the foreigner who lives among you."
50 All the people of Israel did so.
They did just as the LORD had commanded Moses and Aaron.
51 On that very day, the LORD brought the people of Israel out of the land of Egypt by their armies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Passover is a festival for the people of the covenant. Whoever wants to celebrate it belongs to the people – through circumcision, the sign of the covenant with Abraham.

But foreigners may join too. When they turn to the God of Israel, they are like people born in the land. "The same law is for the one who is born in the land and for the foreigner." These are great words: equal rights for all.

"Do not break any of its bones" – the Gospel of John remembers this when it tells about the death of Jesus: None of his bones were broken (John 19:36).

EXODUS

CHAPTER 13

The firstborn belong to God – the pillar of cloud and the pillar of fire

All the firstborn belong to God VERSES 1–2

1 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
2 "Set apart for me every firstborn.
Among the people of Israel, everything that comes
first out of its mother's womb belongs to me,
both people and animals.
It is mine."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Egypt, the firstborn died. The firstborn of Israel were spared. So now they are to belong to God in a special way.

"To set apart" means: to give something to God so that it belongs to him.

Remember this day VERSES 3–10

3 Moses said to the people,
"Remember this day,
the day you came out of Egypt, out of the house of slavery.
For the LORD brought you out from this place by the strength of his hand.
No bread made with yeast may be eaten.
4 Today you are going out, in the month of Abib.
5 "The LORD will bring you into the land of the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Amorite, the Hivite, and the Jebusite.
He swore to your ancestors that he would give it to you,
a land flowing with milk and honey.
Then you must keep this service in this month.
6 For seven days you must eat bread without yeast.
And on the seventh day there will be a festival for the LORD.
7 You must eat bread without yeast for all seven days.
No bread made with yeast may be seen among you.
No yeast may be seen among you anywhere in your land.
8 "On that day you must tell your son,
'It is because of what the LORD did for me when I came out of Egypt.'
9 It will be for you like a sign on your hand
and like a reminder between your eyes,
so that the law of the LORD may be in your mouth.
For the LORD brought you out of Egypt with a strong hand.
10 So you must keep this rule at its set time every year.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Abib" is the old name of the month. It means "young ears of grain." It is the time in the spring when the grain grows. Later the month was called "Nisan."

Important: The father does not say "what God did for our ancestors," but "what the LORD did for **me**." Every generation is to celebrate being set free as if they themselves had been there.

"A sign on your hand and between your eyes" means: You must always think of it, in everything you do and see. Devout Jews take this literally too, to this day. At morning prayer they tie small boxes with Bible verses to their arm and forehead. They are called "tefillin."

The firstborn are bought back VERSES 11–16

11 "The LORD will bring you into the land of the Canaanite,
as he swore to you and to your ancestors.
He will give it to you.
12 Then you must set apart for the LORD everything that comes first out of its mother's womb.
Every firstborn of your animals that is male belongs to the LORD.
13 You must buy back every firstborn donkey with a lamb.
If you do not buy it back, you must break its neck.
And you must buy back every firstborn among your sons.
14 "In the future your son will ask you, 'What does this mean?'
Then you must tell him,
'The LORD brought us out of Egypt by the strength of his hand, out of the house of slavery.
15 Pharaoh stubbornly refused to let us go.
Then the LORD killed every firstborn in the land of Egypt,
both the firstborn of people and the firstborn of livestock.
That is why I sacrifice to the LORD every male that comes first out of its mother's womb.
But I buy back every firstborn of my sons.'
16 It will be like a sign on your hand and like a reminder between your eyes.
For the LORD brought us out of Egypt by the strength of his hand."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"To buy back" means: to get something back by giving something else in its place.

A donkey was thought of as an "unclean" animal. People were not allowed to sacrifice it. So they give a lamb in its place.

Very important: People are **never** sacrificed. The firstborn sons are always bought back. God does not want human sacrifices (see also Genesis 22).

To this day, Jews have a celebration when a firstborn son is one month old. It is called "Pidyon HaBen," which means "buying back the son."

Jesus too, as a firstborn, was presented to God in the temple (Luke 2:22–23).

God chooses the way VERSES 17–22

17 Pharaoh had let the people go.
But God did not lead them on the road through the land of the Philistines, even though that way was near.
For God said,
"The people might change their minds when they see war.
Then they would go back to Egypt."
18 So God led the people around, on the road through the wilderness to the Red Sea.
The people of Israel went up out of the land of Egypt ready for battle.
19 Moses took the bones of Joseph with him.
For Joseph had made the people of Israel swear an oath.
He had said,
"God will surely come to help you.
Then you must carry my bones up from here with you."
20 They set out from Succoth.
They camped in Etham, at the edge of the wilderness.
21 The LORD went ahead of them:
by day in a pillar of cloud, to lead them on their way,
and by night in a pillar of fire, to give them light.
So they could travel by day and by night.
22 The pillar of cloud by day and the pillar of fire by night did not leave the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The shortest way to Canaan went along the coast. But there were Egyptian forts there and the warlike Philistines. God knows his people. After slavery, they are not yet ready for a fight. So he chooses a longer, but safer way.

Sometimes God's way is a detour. But he has a good reason.

Moses keeps the promise that Joseph was given more than 400 years before (Genesis 50:25). Joseph's faith that his people would return comes true.

The pillar of cloud and the pillar of fire show: God is among his people. He leads. He protects. He is always there, by day and by night.

EXODUS

Chapter 14

The way through the sea

Trapped between the sea and the desert VERSES 1–4

1 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
2 "Tell the people of Israel to turn back.
They must camp in front of Pihahiroth, between Migdol and the sea, in front of Baal Zephon.
You must camp across from it, by the sea.
3 Then Pharaoh will say about the people of Israel,
'They are lost in the land.
The wilderness has shut them in.'
4 I will make Pharaoh's heart hard, and he will chase after them.
Then I will show my glory through Pharaoh and through all his army.
And the Egyptians will know that I am the LORD."
They did so.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God lets the Israelites go into a dead end on purpose: the sea in front of them, the desert behind them. From a human point of view, a bad plan.

But God has a plan: Pharaoh is to think that it will be easy for him. Then God will show who is really mighty.

Today no one knows for sure exactly where the places Pihahiroth, Migdol and Baal Zephon were.

Pharaoh chases after them VERSES 5–9

5 The king of Egypt was told that the people had fled.
Then Pharaoh and his servants changed their minds about the people.
They said,
"What have we done?
We have let Israel go, and now they no longer serve us!"
6 Pharaoh got his chariot ready.
He took his army with him.
7 He took 600 chosen chariots
and all the other chariots of Egypt,
with officers over all of them.
8 The LORD made the heart of Pharaoh, the king of Egypt, hard.
And Pharaoh chased after the people of Israel.
But the people of Israel went out with a raised hand.
9 The Egyptians chased after them.
All of Pharaoh's horses and chariots, his horsemen, and his army caught up with them.
The Israelites were camping by the sea,
beside Pihahiroth, in front of Baal Zephon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

As soon as the slaves are gone, Pharaoh regrets it. He thinks only about the workers he has lost. Grief over his son has not changed him.

Back then, chariots were the strongest weapon. They were fast and dangerous. Against people on foot, they could hardly be beaten.

"With a raised hand" means: boldly, confidently, like winners.

"Do not be afraid!" VERSES 10–14

10 When Pharaoh came near, the people of Israel looked up.
They saw the Egyptians marching after them.
The people of Israel became very afraid.
They cried out to the LORD.
11 They said to Moses,
"Were there no graves in Egypt?
Is that why you have taken us away to die in the wilderness?
Why have you done this to us, bringing us out of Egypt?
12 Did we not tell you this in Egypt?
We said, 'Leave us alone, so that we can serve the Egyptians.'
It would have been better for us to serve the Egyptians than to die in the wilderness!"
13 Moses said to the people,
"Do not be afraid!
Stand still and see how the LORD will save you today.
For you will never again see the Egyptians whom you have seen today.
14 The LORD will fight for you.
And you must be still."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The fear is huge. In front of them is the sea, behind them the strongest army in the world. The people see no way out.

In their panic they even want to go back into slavery. Better to be unfree and alive than free and dead. This is human and understandable.

"Were there no graves in Egypt?" – a bitter mockery. Egypt was famous for its huge tombs, the pyramids.

Moses' answer is one of the best-known sentences in the Bible: "The LORD will fight for you. And you must be still." Sometimes you cannot do anything yourself. Then you may trust that God will act.

The sea divides VERSES 15–22

15 The LORD said to Moses,
"Why are you crying out to me?
Tell the people of Israel to go forward.
16 And you: Lift up your staff.
Reach out your hand over the sea and divide it.
Then the people of Israel will go through the middle of the sea on dry ground.
17 And look: I myself will make the hearts of the Egyptians hard, and they will go in after them.
Then I will show my glory through Pharaoh and through all his army,
through his chariots and through his horsemen.
18 Then the Egyptians will know that I am the LORD,
when I have shown my glory through Pharaoh,
through his chariots, and through his horsemen."
19 Then the angel of God, who went in front of the camp of Israel, moved and went behind them.
The pillar of cloud also moved from in front of them and stood behind them.
20 It came between the camp of Egypt and the camp of Israel.
There was the cloud and the darkness.
Yet it gave light in the night.
So the one camp did not come near the other all night.
21 Moses reached out his hand over the sea.
Then the LORD drove the sea back with a strong east wind all night.
He made the sea into dry land.
The waters were divided.
22 The people of Israel went into the middle of the sea on dry ground.
The waters were like a wall for them, on their right and on their left.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Why are you crying out to me? … go forward." – There is a time to pray and a time to act. Now the Israelites must take the first step.

The pillar of cloud becomes a shield. For the Egyptians it is dark, for the Israelites it is bright. The same presence of God means protection for some and a barrier for others.

God uses a wind, as at creation and after the flood (Genesis 1:2; 8:1). Again God makes dry land in the middle of the water. It is like a new creation: Slaves become a free people.

The Egyptians drown VERSES 23–31

23 The Egyptians chased after them.
All of Pharaoh's horses, his chariots, and his horsemen went in after them into the middle of the sea.
24 In the last watch of the night, just before morning, the LORD looked down on the Egyptian army from the pillar of fire and of cloud.
And he threw the Egyptian army into confusion.
25 He made the wheels come off their chariots,
so that they could only drive them with great trouble.
Then the Egyptians said,
"Let's flee from Israel!
For the LORD is fighting for them against the Egyptians!"
26 The LORD said to Moses,
"Reach out your hand over the sea.
Then the waters will come back over the Egyptians, over their chariots, and over their horsemen."
27 Moses reached out his hand over the sea.
When morning came, the sea went back to its full strength.
The Egyptians fled right into it.
The LORD threw the Egyptians down in the middle of the sea.
28 The waters came back and covered the chariots and the horsemen,
the whole army of Pharaoh that had gone in after them into the sea.
Not one of them was left.
29 But the people of Israel walked on dry land through the middle of the sea.
The waters were like a wall for them, on their right and on their left.
30 So on that day the LORD saved Israel from the hand of the Egyptians.
And Israel saw the Egyptians lying dead on the seashore.

31 Israel saw the great power that the LORD had used
against the Egyptians.
Then the people feared the LORD.
And they believed in the LORD and in his servant
Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, the night was divided into watches. The last watch of the night was just before sunrise.

Now even the Egyptians say: "The LORD is fighting for them." At last they see who the true God is – but too late.

Pharaoh wanted to drown the Israelites' babies in the water (Exodus 1:22). Now his own army drowns in the water.

The freedom is complete. The slaves are free. The oppressors can never chase them again.

The people see and believe. To this day, this crossing of the sea is the great sign for Israel that God saves.

Christians also see in it a picture of baptism: through the water into new life (1 Corinthians 10:1–2).

EXODUS

CHAPTER 15

The song by the sea – water in the desert

The song of Moses VERSES 1–5

1 Then Moses and the people of Israel sang this song to
the LORD.
They said,
"I will sing to the LORD,
for he has won a glorious victory.
He has thrown the horse and its rider into the sea.
2 Yah is my strength and my song.
He has become my salvation.
This is my God, and I will praise him.
He is my father's God, and I will honor him.
3 The LORD is a warrior.
The LORD is his name.
4 He has thrown Pharaoh's chariots and his army into the
sea.
His best officers have sunk in the Red Sea.
5 The deep waters cover them.
They went down into the depths like a stone.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After being saved, the people sing. This is one of the oldest songs in the Bible. In Hebrew it is written as poetry.

Whoever has been saved wants to give thanks and celebrate. Faith and music belong together.

In verse 2, the short form "Yah" stands for God. It is also in the word "Hallelujah" – that means: "Praise Yah! Praise the LORD!"

"The LORD is a warrior" means here: He fought for his people when they could not defend themselves (Exodus 14:14).

God's strong hand VERSES 6–12

6 "Your right hand, LORD, is glorious in power.
Your right hand, LORD, smashes the enemy to pieces.
7 In your great majesty, you throw down those who rise
up against you.
You send out your anger.
It burns them up like straw.
8 With the blast of your nostrils, the waters were piled
up.
The floods stood up like a wall.
The deep waters became solid in the heart of the sea.
9 "The enemy said,
'I will chase them. I will catch up with them.
I will divide the loot.
I will get all I want from them.
I will draw my sword.
My hand will destroy them.'
10 You blew with your wind.
The sea covered them.
They sank like lead in the mighty waters.
11 "Who is like you, LORD, among the gods?
Who is like you, glorious in holiness,
awesome in praises, doing wonders?
12 You reached out your right hand.
The earth swallowed them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The song paints big pictures: God's "blast of your nostrils" is the wind that divided the sea.

The enemy is full of greed and self-confidence: "I will chase them. I will catch up with them." Again and again he says "I" and "my." But one single breath from God is enough, and it is all over.

"Who is like you, LORD, among the gods?" – The gods of Egypt could do nothing. No other god is like the LORD. To this day, this sentence is spoken in Jewish prayer: "Mi chamocha."

God leads his people VERSES 13–18

13 "In your faithful love, you have led the people that you
have set free.
In your strength you have guided them to the holy
place where you live.
14 The peoples have heard it. They tremble.
Pain has taken hold of the people who live in Philistia.
15 Then the chiefs of Edom were terrified.
Trembling takes hold of the mighty men of Moab.
All the people who live in Canaan have lost their
courage.
16 Terror and dread fall on them.
Because of the greatness of your arm, they are as still
as a stone,
until your people pass by, LORD,
until the people you have bought for yourself pass by.
17 You will bring them in and plant them on the
mountain that belongs to you,
the place, LORD, that you have made for yourself to
live in,
the holy place, Lord, that your hands have built.

18 The LORD will reign forever and ever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the song looks ahead: God will lead his people through the desert and bring them into the promised land.

Philistia, Edom, Moab and Canaan are the peoples whose lands Israel will pass on the way.

The "mountain that belongs to you" is probably Mount Zion in Jerusalem, where the temple will later stand.

The song ends with the most important sentence: "The LORD will reign forever and ever." It is not Pharaoh who is king, but God.

Miriam dances VERSES 19–21

19 For Pharaoh's horses went into the sea with his chariots
and his horsemen.
And the LORD brought the waters of the sea back over them.
But the people of Israel walked on dry land through the middle of the sea.

20 Then Miriam the prophetess, the sister of Aaron, took a tambourine in her hand.
A tambourine is a small hand drum.
All the women went out after her with tambourines and with dancing.

21 Miriam sang to them,
"Sing to the LORD,
for he has won a glorious victory.
He has thrown the horse and its rider into the sea."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Miriam is the sister who once watched over her little brother by the Nile (Exodus 2:4). Now she is an old woman – and she dances.

She is called a "prophetess." She is one of the first women in the Bible with this title. God speaks through women too.

The women celebrate with drums and dancing. People may show their joy about God's rescue with their whole body.

Bitter water becomes sweet VERSES 22–27

22 Then Moses led Israel on from the Red Sea.
They went out into the wilderness of Shur.
For three days they walked through the wilderness and found no water.

23 Then they came to Marah.
But they could not drink the water of Marah, because it was bitter.
That is why the place was called Marah.
Marah means "bitter."

24 The people complained against Moses.
They said,
"What are we supposed to drink?"

25 Moses cried out to the LORD.
The LORD showed him a tree.
Moses threw it into the water.
Then the water became sweet.
There the LORD gave them a rule and a law.
And there he tested them.

26 He said,
"Listen carefully to the voice of the LORD your God.
Do what is right in his eyes.
Pay attention to his commandments, and keep all his rules.
If you do this, I will not put on you any of the diseases that I put on the Egyptians.
For I am the LORD who heals you."

27 Then they came to Elim.
There were 12 springs of water and 70 palm trees there.
They camped there by the water.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Just a short time ago, they were celebrating. Three days later they are already complaining. The desert is hard. Thirst is a real need.

In the Bible, "to complain" here means: to grumble and be unhappy.

Moses does the right thing: He brings the need to God.

"I am the LORD who heals you" – a beautiful name for God. God wants to heal, not to make people sick.

After the bitter water comes Elim: an oasis with 12 springs and 70 palm trees. 12 like the 12 tribes, 70 like the 70 descendants of Jacob. God provides enough for everyone.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 16

Manna and quail

The people are hungry VERSES 1–3

1 They set out from Elim.
The whole community of the people of Israel came to the wilderness of Sin, which is between Elim and Sinai.
That was on the fifteenth day of the second month after they had left the land of Egypt.

2 In the wilderness, the whole community of the people of Israel complained against Moses and against Aaron.

3 The people of Israel said to them,
"We wish we had died by the LORD's hand in the land of Egypt!
There we sat by the pots of meat.
There we ate as much bread as we wanted.
But you have brought us out into this wilderness to kill this whole crowd with hunger!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

One month after leaving Egypt, the food they brought is used up. The people are hungry.

And right away they remember Egypt only as the land of the "pots of meat." The slavery, the whips, the dead children – all forgotten.

There is still a saying in German about longing for "the meat pots of Egypt." It means: People long for a time that is past and forget how bad it really was.

God promises bread from heaven VERSES 4–12

4 Then the LORD said to Moses,
"Look, I will make bread rain down from the sky for you.
The people must go out every day and gather as much as they need for that day.
In this way I will test them, to see whether they will live by my law or not.
5 On the sixth day they must prepare what they bring in.
It will be twice as much as they gather on the other days."
6 Moses and Aaron said to all the people of Israel,
"This evening you will know that the LORD has brought you out of the land of Egypt.
7 And in the morning you will see the glory of the LORD.
For he has heard you complaining against the LORD.
Who are we, that you complain against us?"
8 Moses said,
"The LORD will give you meat to eat in the evening,
and in the morning bread, as much as you want.
For the LORD has heard you complaining against him.
Who are we?
You are not complaining against us, but against the LORD."
9 Moses said to Aaron,
"Tell the whole community of the people of Israel,
'Come close to the LORD, for he has heard your complaining.'"
10 While Aaron was speaking to the whole community of the people of Israel, they looked toward the wilderness.
And there the glory of the LORD appeared in the cloud.
11 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
12 "I have heard the complaining of the people of Israel.
Tell them,
'In the evening you will eat meat.
And in the morning you will be filled with bread.
Then you will know that I am the LORD your God.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God does not scold them. He answers their complaining with a gift.

But he also wants them to learn something: The people are to take only as much as they need each day. They are to learn to trust God anew every day.

"The glory of the LORD" is God's visible presence, here as a bright shining in the cloud.

Quail and manna VERSES 13–21

13 In the evening, quail came and covered the camp.
And in the morning there was dew all around the camp.
14 When the dew was gone,
there was something small and round on the surface of the wilderness,
as small as frost on the ground.
15 The people of Israel saw it.
They said to one another,
"What is it?"
For they did not know what it was.
Moses said to them,
"It is the bread that the LORD has given you to eat.
16 "This is what the LORD has commanded:
'Everyone must gather as much of it as he needs to eat.
Take an omer for each person,
by the number of people.
Everyone must gather for those who are in his tent.'"
17 The people of Israel did so.
Some gathered more, some less.
18 When they measured it with an omer,
the one who gathered much had nothing left over.
And the one who gathered little did not have too little.
Each one had gathered as much as he needed to eat.
19 Moses said to them,
"No one may leave any of it until the morning."
20 But they did not listen to Moses.
Some of them left some of it until the morning.
Then it was full of worms and stank.
And Moses was angry with them.
21 So they gathered it morning by morning, each one as much as he needed to eat.
When the sun grew hot, it melted.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Quail are small birds. To this day, they fly over the Sinai Peninsula in large flocks and land on the ground, worn out. Then they are easy to catch.

"What is it?" in Hebrew is "Man hu?" That is where the name "manna" comes from.

An omer is an old measure, about 2 quarts.

The miracle: Everyone has exactly as much as he needs. Whoever gathers much does not have too much. Whoever gathers little does not have too little. The apostle Paul quotes this sentence when he calls people to share with others (2 Corinthians 8:15).

Whoever stores food because he does not trust God finds out: It spoils. You cannot hoard God's care.

Later Jesus teaches people to pray to God for their daily bread. The manna is a reminder of this: new every day.

The manna and the Sabbath VERSES 22–30

22 On the sixth day they gathered twice as much bread, two omers for each person.
Then all the leaders of the community came and told Moses.
23 He said to them,
"This is what the LORD has said:
'Tomorrow is a day of rest, a holy Sabbath for the LORD.
Bake what you want to bake, and boil what you want to boil.
And put aside everything that is left over and keep it until the morning.'"
24 They put it aside until the morning, as Moses had ordered.
And it did not stink, and there were no worms in it.
25 Moses said,
"Eat it today.
For today is a Sabbath for the LORD.
Today you will not find any in the field.
26 For six days you must gather it.
But the seventh day is the Sabbath.

On that day there will be none."
27 On the seventh day, some of the people still went out to gather.
But they found none.
28 The LORD said to Moses,
"How long will you refuse to keep my commandments and my laws?
29 Look, the LORD has given you the Sabbath.
That is why on the sixth day he gives you bread for two days.
Everyone must stay in his place.
No one may leave his place on the seventh day."
30 So the people rested on the seventh day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the word "Sabbath" appears for the first time in the Bible. It means "rest" or "stopping."

God rested on the seventh day of creation (Genesis 2:2). Now he gives his people this day of rest.

For people who were slaves until recently and had to work hard every day, this is a huge gift: a day off, every week!

Before the Sabbath, the manna even keeps for two days. God makes sure that no one has to work on the day of rest.

But some people cannot let go. They go out to gather anyway. Even people who have been set free must first learn to rest.

A jar of manna to remember VERSES 31–36

31 The house of Israel called it "manna."
It was white, like coriander seed.
And it tasted like thin cakes made with honey.
32 Moses said,
"This is what the LORD has commanded:
'Fill an omer with it and keep it for your descendants through all generations.
They are to see the bread that I fed you with in the wilderness,
when I brought you out of the land of Egypt.'"
33 Moses said to Aaron,
"Take a jar and put a full omer of manna in it.
Put it before the LORD, so that it may be kept through all your generations."
34 Aaron put it in front of the Testimony, so that it would be kept,
just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
35 The people of Israel ate the manna for 40 years,
until they came to a land where people lived.
They ate the manna until they came to the border of the land of Canaan.
36 An omer is one tenth of an ephah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Coriander is a spice with small, round seeds.

The manna is not to be forgotten. A jar of it is kept, so that later generations can see: This is how God provided for us.

The "Testimony" is the stone tablets with the Ten Commandments, which are later kept in the ark of the covenant. So Moses writes this story with a later time in mind.

For 40 years, every day, God provides for his people – in spite of all their complaining.

An ephah is a larger dry measure, about 6 gallons.

In the New Testament, Jesus says that he is the bread of life. And he compares himself with the manna, the bread from heaven (John 6:31–35).

EXODUS

CHAPTER 17

Water from the rock – the fight against Amalek

No water in Rephidim VERSES 1–7

1 The whole community of the people of Israel set out from the wilderness of Sin.
They traveled from place to place, as the LORD commanded.
Then they camped in Rephidim.
But there was no water there for the people to drink.
2 So the people quarreled with Moses.
They said,
"Give us water to drink!"
Moses said to them,
"Why are you quarreling with me?
Why are you testing the LORD?"
3 But the people were very thirsty for water there.
So the people complained against Moses.
They said,
"Why have you brought us up out of Egypt?
Do you want to kill us, our children, and our livestock with thirst?"
4 Then Moses cried out to the LORD,
"What should I do with these people?
They are almost ready to throw stones at me!"
5 The LORD said to Moses,
"Walk on ahead of the people.
Take the elders of Israel with you.
Also take in your hand the staff that you struck the Nile with, and go.
6 Look, I will stand before you there on the rock at Horeb.
Strike the rock.
Then water will come out of it, so that the people can drink."
Moses did so before the eyes of the elders of Israel.
7 He named the place Massah and Meribah.
For the people of Israel had quarreled there.
And they had tested the LORD.
They had said,
"Is the LORD among us or not?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again there is no water. Again there is a quarrel. The situation becomes dangerous: The people even want to throw stones at Moses.

Thirst is a real need. But the people do not ask, "Help us, God!" They ask with distrust: "Is the LORD among us or not?" The Bible calls this: testing God.

Moses strikes with the same staff that he used to turn the Nile into blood. Now the staff brings life.

"Massah" means "testing." "Meribah" means "quarreling." The names remind people of what happened there.

The apostle Paul sees in the rock that gives water a picture of Christ (1 Corinthians 10:4).

The fight against Amalek VERSES 8–13

8 Then Amalek came and fought against Israel in
Rephidim.
9 Moses said to Joshua,
"Choose men for us, and go out to fight against
Amalek.
Tomorrow I will stand on the top of the hill
with God's staff in my hand."
10 So Joshua did as Moses had told him, and fought
against Amalek.
Moses, Aaron, and Hur went up to the top of the hill.
11 As long as Moses held up his hand, Israel was winning.
When he let his hand down, Amalek was winning.
12 But Moses' hands grew tired.
So they took a stone and put it under him.
He sat on it.
Aaron and Hur held up his hands, one on one side, and
the other on the other side.
So his hands stayed steady until the sun went down.
13 And Joshua defeated Amalek and his people with the
sword.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Amalekites were a desert people. They came from Esau (Genesis 36:12). They attack the worn-out people. Later we learn: They attacked on purpose the weak and tired people at the end of the line (Deuteronomy 25:18).

Here we meet Joshua for the first time. Later he will take Moses' place as leader.

Moses lifts his hands – probably in prayer. The victory does not come from the strength of the fighters, but from God.

A beautiful picture: Moses is tired. He cannot go on. Then Aaron and Hur help him and hold up his arms. Even a great leader needs people who support him. No one has to do everything alone.

Hur is a close friend of Moses. According to Jewish tradition, he was Miriam's husband.

An altar to remember VERSES 14–16

14 The LORD said to Moses,
"Write this in a book, so that it will be remembered.
And tell it clearly to Joshua:
I will completely wipe out the memory of Amalek
from under the sky."
15 Moses built an altar.
He named it "The LORD our Banner."
16 He said,
"Yah has sworn:
'The LORD will be at war with Amalek from
generation to generation.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here, for the first time in the Bible, it says that something is to be written down. God's acts are not to be forgotten.

A "banner" is a flag or a pole that soldiers gather around. Moses says: The place where we gather is God himself. He is our sign of victory.

Later, Amalek became a picture for the evil that attacks God's people again and again.

In Hebrew, verse 16 is very hard to understand. Literally, it speaks of something like a hand on the throne of Yah. Many Bibles understand it as a solemn oath, as here: "Yah has sworn." "Yah" is a short form of God's name.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 18

Jethro visits Moses and gives him good advice

A family visit in the desert VERSES 1–8

1 Jethro, the priest of Midian, Moses' father-in-law,
heard about everything God had done for Moses and
for Israel, his people.
He heard how the LORD had brought Israel out of
Egypt.
2 Moses had sent his wife Zipporah away before.
Jethro, Moses' father-in-law, took her in
3 with her two sons.
The name of one son was Gershom.
For Moses had said,
"I have lived as a foreigner in a foreign land."
4 The name of the other was Eliezer.
For Moses had said,
"My father's God was my help.
He saved me from Pharaoh's sword."
5 Jethro, Moses' father-in-law, came to Moses in the
wilderness with Moses' sons and his wife.
Moses was camped at the mountain of God.
6 Jethro said to Moses,
"I, your father-in-law Jethro, have come to you,
with your wife and her two sons."
7 Moses went out to meet his father-in-law.
He bowed down and kissed him.
They asked each other how they were.
Then they went into the tent.
8 Moses told his father-in-law everything the LORD had
done to Pharaoh and to the Egyptians for Israel's sake.
He told him about all the troubles they had met on the
way,
and how the LORD had saved them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At some point, Moses had sent his wife and his sons back to her father. Maybe to protect them during the dangerous time in Egypt.

Now Jethro brings the family back together.

"Eliezer" means "My God is help."

The two men meet each other with great respect and warmth. And Moses tells what God has done – the good

things and also the troubles.

Jethro praises God VERSES 9–12

9 Jethro was glad about all the good things the LORD had
done for Israel.
He was glad that the LORD had saved them from the
hand of the Egyptians.
10 Jethro said,
"Blessed be the LORD!
He has saved you from the hand of the Egyptians and
from the hand of Pharaoh.
He has freed the people from the power of the
Egyptians.
11 Now I know that the LORD is greater than all gods.
That became clear when they treated the people so
proudly."
12 Jethro, Moses' father-in-law, brought a burnt offering
and other sacrifices for God.
And Aaron came with all the elders of Israel to eat a
meal with Moses' father-in-law before God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jethro is not an Israelite. He is a priest from Midian. But when he hears what God has done, he praises the God of Israel.

"Now I know" – Jethro sees what Pharaoh did not want to see: The LORD is greater than all gods.

A foreigner brings the first sacrifice after leaving Egypt, and the elders of Israel eat with him. God's people are open to people from other nations who come to know God.

Moses works too much VERSES 13–18

13 On the next day, Moses sat down to judge the people.
And the people stood around Moses from morning
until evening.
14 Moses' father-in-law saw everything he was doing for
the people.
He said,
"What is this that you are doing for the people?
Why do you sit here all alone,
while all the people stand around you from morning
until evening?"
15 Moses said to his father-in-law,
"Because the people come to me to ask God for
guidance.
16 When they have a dispute, they come to me.
Then I decide between a man and his neighbor.
And I teach them God's rules and his laws."
17 Moses' father-in-law said to him,
"What you are doing is not good.
18 You will completely wear yourself out, both you and
the people who are with you.
For this task is too heavy for you.
You cannot do it alone."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses does everything alone. From morning until evening, he listens to disputes. And the people have to wait all day.

Jethro sees it from the outside and says honestly: "What you are doing is not good."

This sounds very modern: Whoever wants to do everything alone burns out. And the others suffer from it too.

Jethro's advice VERSES 19–23

19 "Now listen to me.
I will give you advice, and may God be with you.
You must stand for the people before God.
Bring their cases to God.
20 Teach them the rules and the laws.
Show them the way they must walk and the work they
must do.
21 "But choose capable men from all the people.
They must fear God.
They must be honest men who hate dishonest gain.
Put them over the people as leaders:
leaders of thousands, leaders of hundreds, leaders of
fifties, and leaders of tens.
22 Let them judge the people at all times.
They must bring every big case to you.
But they must decide every small case themselves.
So it will be easier for you.
And they will carry the load together with you.
23 If you do this, and God commands you to,
then you will be able to keep going.
And all these people will go home in peace."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jethro suggests: Share the work. Others decide the small cases. Only the hard ones come to Moses.

He also says what good leaders should be like: They must fear God, be honest and not take bribes. This is still true today for everyone who has responsibility.

"To fear God" means: to take God seriously and to answer to him.

Jethro is modest. He says: Do it like this – if God commands you to. God has the last word.

Moses listens to the advice VERSES 24–27

24 Moses listened to his father-in-law and did everything
he had said.
25 Moses chose capable men from all Israel.
He made them heads over the people:
leaders of thousands, leaders of hundreds, leaders of
fifties, and leaders of tens.
26 They judged the people at all times.
They brought the hard cases to Moses.
But they decided every small case themselves.
27 Then Moses let his father-in-law leave.
And Jethro went back to his own land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses is the great leader who speaks with God. Still, he is humble enough to listen to the advice of his father-in-law.

Good ideas may also come from the outside, from people of another nation and with a different background.

Before God gives the people his law at Sinai, an order for fair judges is already set up. Law and justice belong to the foundation of a people.

Chapter 19

At Mount Sinai

Arriving at the mountain of God VERSES 1–2

1 In the third month after the people of Israel had left the
land of Egypt,
on that very day, they came into the wilderness of
Sinai.
2 They had set out from Rephidim and had come to the
wilderness of Sinai.
They set up camp there in the wilderness.
Israel camped in front of the mountain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the people have reached the goal of the first stage: Mount Sinai. This is where God appeared to Moses in the burning bush. This is where God promised: "You will serve God on this mountain" (Exodus 3:12).

The people will stay at Sinai for almost a year. Everything told from here to the end of Exodus, in the whole book of Leviticus and at the beginning of Numbers happens here.

It is not certain exactly where Mount Sinai is. Many people think of a high mountain in the south of the Sinai Peninsula, the "Mountain of Moses" (Jebel Musa).

God's offer VERSES 3–8

3 Moses went up to God.
The LORD called to him from the mountain,
"This is what you are to say to the house of Jacob,
and what you are to tell the people of Israel:
4 'You have seen what I did to the Egyptians.
You have seen how I carried you on eagles' wings and
brought you to myself.
5 Now, if you will truly listen to my voice and keep my
covenant,
then you will be my very own treasure out of all the
peoples.
For the whole earth is mine.
6 You will be a kingdom of priests for me and a holy
nation.'
These are the words you are to speak to the people of
Israel."
7 Moses came and called together the elders of the
people.
He told them all these words that the LORD had
commanded him.
8 All the people answered together,
"We will do everything the LORD has said."
And Moses brought the people's answer back to the
LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

First God reminds them of what he has done. Only then does he say what he wishes from the people. With God, the gift always comes first, then the task.

"Carried on eagles' wings" – a beautiful picture. An eagle carries its young safely when they are learning to fly. In the same way, God has carried his people through all dangers.

God offers a covenant. Israel is to be his "very own treasure" – like a precious treasure. But not because the other peoples do not matter to God: "For the whole earth is mine."

"A kingdom of priests" means: the whole people is to stand between God and the world. It is to show the other peoples who God is. In the New Testament, this word is applied to all Christians: "a royal priesthood, a holy nation" (1 Peter 2:9).

The people say yes right away. Whether they will keep their promise will soon become clear.

Getting ready to meet God VERSES 9–15

9 The LORD said to Moses,
"Look, I am coming to you in a thick cloud.
The people are to hear when I speak with you.
Then they will believe you forever."
And Moses told the LORD what the people had said.
10 The LORD said to Moses,
"Go to the people.
Make them holy today and tomorrow.
They are to wash their clothes.
11 They are to be ready on the third day.
For on the third day the LORD will come down on
Mount Sinai in front of all the people.
12 Mark a boundary for the people all around the
mountain.
Tell them,
'Be careful not to go up the mountain or even touch its
edge.
Anyone who touches the mountain must be put to
death.
13 No hand is to touch that person.
He must be stoned or shot with arrows.
Whether animal or human, he must not live.'
Only when the trumpet sounds a long blast may they
come up to the mountain."
14 So Moses went down from the mountain to the people.
He made the people holy, and they washed their
clothes.
15 He said to the people,
"Be ready by the third day.
Do not have sex with a woman."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

You do not meet a king in dirty clothes. How much more is this true for God! The people are to get ready on the inside and on the outside.

"To make holy" or "to get ready" means: to prepare for meeting God.

The boundary around the mountain shows: God is near, but he is also holy and powerful. Nobody can just come near him however they like.

The "trumpet" here is a ram's horn (in Hebrew "shofar"). It is a wind instrument made from the horn of a male sheep. It is still blown on Jewish holidays today.

That men and women are not to sleep with each other during this time does not mean that sex is bad. Back then, it was a sign of special preparation and focus.

God comes down on the mountain VERSES 16–25

16 On the third day, when morning came, there was
thunder and lightning.
A thick cloud lay on the mountain.
And there was the sound of a very loud trumpet.
All the people in the camp trembled.
17 Moses led the people out of the camp to meet God.
They stood at the foot of the mountain.
18 All of Mount Sinai was covered in smoke,
because the LORD had come down on it in fire.
Its smoke went up like the smoke of a furnace.
And the whole mountain shook violently.
19 The sound of the trumpet grew louder and louder.
Moses spoke, and God answered him with a voice.
20 The LORD came down on Mount Sinai, on the top of
the mountain.
The LORD called Moses to the top of the mountain,
and Moses went up.
21 The LORD said to Moses,
"Go down and warn the people.
They must not push through to the LORD to stare at
him.
Otherwise many of them will die.
22 The priests who come near to the LORD must also make
themselves holy.
Otherwise the LORD will break out against them."
23 Moses said to the LORD,
"The people cannot come up Mount Sinai.
For you yourself warned us,
'Mark a boundary around the mountain and make it
holy.'"
24 The LORD said to him,
"Go down!
Then come back up, and bring Aaron with you.
But do not let the priests and the people push through
to come up to the LORD.
Otherwise he will break out against them."
25 So Moses went down to the people and told them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Thunder, lightning, fire, smoke, a shaking mountain and a trumpet sound that grows louder and louder: meeting God is overwhelming. The people tremble.

God is not a harmless buddy. He is holy and mighty, like a fire. And yet he comes down to speak with his people.

Moses is the go-between. He goes up and down again and again. He brings God's words to the people and the people's words to God.

The "priests" here probably means the firstborn or the elders who offered sacrifices back then. The actual priests from Aaron's family are appointed only later.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 20

The Ten Commandments

I am the LORD your God VERSES 1–2

1 Then God spoke all these words:
2 "I am the LORD your God.
I brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the
house of slavery.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now come the Ten Commandments. They are among the best-known words in the world. They are found here and once again in Deuteronomy 5.

Very important: the commandments do not begin with an order, but with a reminder: "I brought you out of the land of Egypt." God set them free. First comes God's rescue, then come the commandments. The commandments are not chains. They show how a free person can live well.

Jews count this sentence as the first of the "Ten Words." For in Hebrew, the Bible actually calls the commandments "the ten words" (Exodus 34:28).

The commandments speak to "you" – one person. God speaks to each person personally.

No other gods VERSES 3–6

3 You must have no other gods besides me.
4 You must not make an idol for yourself.
You must not make any image at all of anything
that is in the sky above, or on the earth below, or in the
water under the earth.
5 You must not bow down to them or serve them.
For I, the LORD your God, am a jealous God.
For those who hate me, I bring the guilt of the fathers
on the children,
to the third and fourth generation.
6 But to thousands of those who love me and keep my
commandments,
I show my loving kindness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first commandment: God alone is to be God. Nothing else is to be more important to us than he is – not money, not power, not success.

The ban on images: God cannot be locked up in a picture or a statue. He is greater than anything we can imagine. Back then, the peoples made statues of their gods and worshiped them.

Christians count the commandments in different ways. Catholics and Lutherans put verses 3–6 together as **one** commandment. Reformed churches, Orthodox churches and Jews count the ban on images as a separate commandment. That is why the commandments are numbered differently in different churches.

"Jealous" here means: God loves his people so much that he does not want to share them with other gods – just as a person in a marriage does not want to share their partner.

The comparison is important: the results of guilt reach four generations at most. But God's loving kindness reaches thousands. God's love is much greater than his anger.

Do not misuse God's name VERSE 7

7 You must not misuse the name of the LORD your God.
For the LORD will not let anyone go unpunished who

misuses his name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's name is holy. People should not use it carelessly, for example to curse, to swear falsely or to cheat others.

The worst is when people use God's name to justify wrong or to oppress others.

The Sabbath VERSES 8–11

8 Remember the Sabbath day and keep it holy.
9 You are to work for six days and do all your work.
10 But the seventh day is a Sabbath for the LORD your God.
On that day you must not do any work:
not you, not your son, not your daughter,
not your male servant, not your female servant, not your livestock,
and not the foreigner who lives in your towns.
11 For in six days the LORD made the sky and the earth,
the sea and everything in them.
And on the seventh day he rested.
That is why the LORD blessed the Sabbath day and made it holy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: A Sabbath is a day of rest.

The Sabbath is a gift: a free day every week.

What is special: it is for **everyone**. Not only for the head of the house, but also for children, servants, foreigners and even for the animals. No one may be exploited.

For people who had just been slaves and had to toil every day, this was revolutionary.

For Jews, the Sabbath is Saturday. Most Christians celebrate Sunday as their day of rest, because Jesus rose from the dead on a Sunday.

Honor father and mother VERSE 12

12 Honor your father and your mother.
Then you will live a long time in the land that the LORD your God is giving you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This commandment is mainly for grown-up children. They are to respect their old parents and take care of them when they become weak.

Father and mother are named equally. Both are to be honored.

This is the first commandment with a promise: a long life in the land.

Do not murder VERSE 13

13 You must not murder.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Every human life is holy, because every person is made in God's image (Genesis 1:27; 9:6).

The Hebrew word mainly means: to kill a person on purpose and unjustly.

Jesus made this commandment go even deeper: hatred and anger in the heart against another person are already the beginning of it (Matthew 5:21–22).

Do not break your marriage VERSE 14

14 You must not commit adultery.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: To commit adultery means: to have sex with someone else's husband or wife, or to be unfaithful to your own husband or wife.

Marriage is a covenant of faithfulness between husband and wife. Whoever breaks the marriage destroys this trust.

This commandment protects marriage, the family and the children.

Do not steal VERSE 15

15 You must not steal.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Every person has a right to what belongs to them.

Ancient Jewish teachers said: this commandment above all also forbids stealing a **person** – that is, kidnapping and slavery.

Do not lie VERSE 16

16 You must not give false testimony against your neighbor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

First of all, the commandment means: you must not lie in court. With false testimony, you can destroy another person's life.

But it also applies in everyday life: you should not speak badly about others, spread rumors or tell lies about them.

Do not covet VERSE 17

17 You must not covet your neighbor's house.
You must not covet your neighbor's wife,
or his male servant, or his female servant, or his ox, or his donkey,
or anything that belongs to your neighbor."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"To covet" means: to badly want to have something that belongs to someone else. Envy and greed.

This commandment goes deeper than all the others. It is not only against actions, but against what happens in the heart. For envy and greed in the heart later lead to stealing, adultery and even murder.

Catholics and Lutherans divide this verse into two commandments: the 9th and the 10th commandment. In this way, they also get to 10.

The people are afraid VERSES 18–21

18 All the people saw the thunder and the lightning,
heard the sound of the trumpet and saw the mountain smoking.
When the people saw it, they trembled and stayed far away.
19 They said to Moses,
"You speak with us, and we will listen.
But do not let God speak with us,
or we will die."
20 Moses said to the people,
"Do not be afraid.
God has come to test you,
so that you will have awe of him and not sin."

21 So the people stayed far away.
But Moses went near the thick darkness where God was.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's voice is so mighty that the people cannot bear it. They ask Moses to be the go-between for them and God.

"Do not be afraid" and "have awe" – both belong together. You do not need to be afraid of God, as if he were a tyrant. But you should take him seriously. Then you live in a way that does not harm others.

Instructions for the altar VERSES 22–26

22 The LORD said to Moses,
"Tell the people of Israel this:
'You yourselves have seen that I spoke with you from heaven.
23 You must not make gods of silver or gods of gold to set beside me.
You must never make such gods for yourselves.
24 Make an altar of earth for me.
On it you are to sacrifice your burnt offerings and your peace offerings,
your sheep and your cattle.
In every place where I cause my name to be remembered,
I will come to you and I will bless you.
25 If you make me an altar of stones,
do not build it from cut stones.
For if you use your tool on it, you make it unclean.
26 And do not go up to my altar by steps,
so that your private parts are not seen there.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God spoke, not through a picture. That is why the people need no statues of gods.

The altar is to be very simple: made of earth or of stones that have not been cut. No splendor, no artwork. Not people, but God is to be at the center.

"Peace offerings" were sacrifices in which one part was given to God and one part was eaten together, like a feast with God.

"In every place ... I will come to you and I will bless you" – God is not only at Sinai. He comes everywhere people honor him.

Back then, people wore long robes without underwear. Anyone who climbed steps could be seen from below. Worship is to be done with dignity.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 21

Laws for living together (1): slaves, violence and making up for damage

Introduction VERSE 1

1 "These are the laws that you are to set before them:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the Ten Commandments, Chapters 21 to 23 contain many individual laws. This part is called the "Book of the Covenant" (see Exodus 24:7).

These laws are more than 3,000 years old. They come from a world that was very different from ours: there was slavery, blood revenge and hardly any protection for the weak.

Some things in these laws sound harsh or unfair to us today. They need to be compared with the other laws of that time. Then you can see: the laws of the Bible often protect the weak much more than the laws of the neighboring peoples.

Jews and Christians read these laws differently today. Jews have explained them and developed them further over centuries. Christians see in them mainly the basic values behind them: protecting life, justice and care for the weak.

Hebrew slaves go free VERSES 2–6

2 "If you buy a Hebrew servant, he is to work for you for six years.
In the seventh year he is to go free without paying anything.
3 If he came alone, he is to leave alone.
If he was married, his wife is to leave with him.
4 If his master gives him a wife and she has sons or daughters with him,
then the wife and her children belong to her master.
And he is to leave alone.
5 "But the servant may say clearly,
'I love my master, my wife and my children.
I do not want to go free.'
6 Then his master is to bring him before God.
He is to bring him to the door or to the doorpost.
And his master is to pierce his ear with an awl.
Then he will serve his master for life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first law is about slaves. That fits: Israel itself had only just been a people of slaves.

Back then, an Israelite could become a slave if he could not pay his debts. But after six years he had to go free. So it was more like working off a debt for a set time, not slavery forever.

Verse 4 is hard for us to bear today: the family is separated. In the legal order of that time, the wife given by the master still belonged to the master's household.

Verse 6: An awl is a sharp, pointed tool.

Anyone who wanted to stay was allowed to stay. The hole in the ear was a sign: this person has made a free choice.

Protection for female slaves VERSES 7–11

7 "If a man sells his daughter as a female servant,
she is not to go free the way the male servants do.
8 Her master may have chosen her as a wife for himself.
If she does not please him, he must let her be bought back.
He has no right to sell her to a foreign people,
because he has treated her unfaithfully.
9 If he gives her to his son as a wife,
he must treat her like a daughter.
10 If he takes another wife for himself,
he must not take anything away from her:

not her food, not her clothing and not her rights as a wife.
11 If he does not do these three things for her,
she may go free without paying any money.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In great poverty, some families back then sold a daughter. Usually she was then to become the wife of the buyer or of his son.

These laws protect the young woman: she must not be sold on. She must be treated like a daughter or a wife. She has a right to food, clothing and love. If the man does not give these, she is free.

For that time, this was a great protection for women who would otherwise have had no rights at all.

Killing and murder VERSES 12–17

12 "Anyone who hits a person so that he dies must be put to death.
13 But if he did not do it on purpose, and God let it happen,
then I will choose a place for you where he can flee.
14 But if someone plans it and boldly attacks his neighbor to kill him,
then you must take him away even from my altar, so that he dies.
15 "Anyone who attacks his father or his mother must be put to death.
16 "Anyone who kidnaps a person must be put to death,
whether he has sold the person or the person is still found with him.
17 "Anyone who curses his father or his mother must be put to death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a difference is already made between murder (on purpose) and an accident (not on purpose). Anyone who killed someone by accident is to be able to flee to a safe place, to be protected from blood revenge. Later, special "cities of refuge" are set up for this (Numbers 35).

But a murderer cannot hide at the altar. Not even God's sanctuary protects a murderer.

Kidnapping is punished very severely. A people who were slaves themselves must never steal people and sell them.

The death penalty for hitting or cursing one's parents sounds very harsh. It shows how important respect for parents was back then. Later, Jewish scholars explained this punishment so narrowly that it was practically never carried out.

Bodily injury VERSES 18–27

18 "Men may quarrel,
and one may hit the other with a stone or with his fist.
The other man does not die, but he has to stay in bed.
19 If he gets up again and walks around outside with his walking stick,
then the one who hit him will not be punished.
But he must pay for the time the man lost from work and take care of his healing until he is completely well.
20 "If a man hits his male or female servant with a rod and the servant dies under his hand,
the man must surely be punished.
21 But if the servant gets up after a day or two,
the master is not to be punished,
for the servant is his property.
22 "Men may fight and hurt a pregnant woman,
so that she gives birth too early,
but no other harm follows.
Then the one who did it must pay a fine.
The woman's husband says how much, and the judges decide on it.
23 But if harm follows,
then you must give life for life,
24 eye for eye, tooth for tooth,
hand for hand, foot for foot,
25 burn for burn,
wound for wound, bruise for bruise.
26 "If a man hits the eye of his male or female servant and destroys it,
he must let the servant go free because of the eye.
27 If he knocks out a tooth of his male or female servant,
he must let the servant go free because of the tooth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Anyone who injures another person must pay for the damage: for the time lost from work and for the cost of the healing. Something similar still exists today.

Slaves are protected too. A man who beats his slave to death is punished. That was not a matter of course among the neighboring peoples. That the master is not punished if the slave dies later is hard for us to understand today. Back then, people assumed that in that case he had not meant to kill him.

Verse 22 can be understood in different ways. Some Bibles understand it like this: the woman loses her child. Others translate as here: "so that she gives birth too early." This decides whether the "harm" in verse 23 also includes the child.

"Eye for eye, tooth for tooth" – this famous sentence is often misunderstood. It does not mean: take revenge! On the contrary, it means: the punishment must **not be greater** than the damage. It puts a limit on revenge. Early on, Jewish judges understood it like this: the guilty person has to pay a fair amount of money to make up for the damage.

Jesus goes even further: he teaches people to give up paying back evil altogether (Matthew 5:38–39).

Anyone who injures a slave so badly that he loses an eye or a tooth must set him free. That is a strong protection against violence.

When a bull kills a person VERSES 28–32

28 "If a bull gores a man or a woman with its horns so that they die,
the bull must be stoned to death.
Its meat must not be eaten.
But the owner of the bull is not guilty.
29 But the bull may have been in the habit of goring in the past,
and its owner may have been warned,
and still he did not keep it locked up.
If it then kills a man or a woman,
the bull must be stoned.
And its owner must also be put to death.
30 But if a ransom is set for him,
he must pay whatever is set, to buy back his life.
31 If the bull gores a son or a daughter,
the same law applies to him.

32 If the bull gores a male or female servant,
the owner must give their master 30 shekels of silver (about 12 ounces).
And the bull must be stoned.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is about responsibility. Anyone who knows that his animal is dangerous and does nothing is guilty – like someone today who lets a dangerous dog run loose.

Instead of the death penalty, a ransom can be paid. For the owner did not kill anyone himself.

Important: children have the same rights as adults.

30 shekels of silver are about 12 ounces of silver. A shekel is a weight of silver. This was the price of a slave. For exactly this amount, Jesus was later betrayed (Matthew 26:15).

Damage to animals VERSES 33–36

33 "Someone may leave a pit open, or dig a pit and not cover it.
If a bull or a donkey falls into it,
34 the owner of the pit must make up for the loss.
He must give money to the owner of the animal.
But the dead animal will be his.
35 "If one man's bull injures another man's bull so that it dies,
they are to sell the live bull and share the money.
They are also to share the dead animal.
36 But it may be known that the bull was in the habit of goring in the past,
and its owner did not keep it locked up.
Then he must pay bull for bull.
And the dead animal will be his.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These laws sound very ordinary. But they show: God cares about the small things of living together too.

The rules are fair: whoever is careless has to make up for the damage. If no one is to blame, the loss is shared.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 22

Laws for living together (2): stealing, property and protecting the weak

Stealing VERSES 1–4

1 "If a man steals an ox or a sheep, and kills it or sells it,
he must pay back five oxen for one ox and four sheep for one sheep.
2 If a thief is caught breaking in,
and he is hit so that he dies,
then the one who killed him is not guilty of bloodshed.
3 But if the sun has already risen,
then he is guilty of bloodshed.
The thief must pay back what he stole.
If he has nothing, he is to be sold as a slave to pay for what he stole.
4 If the stolen animal is found alive with him, whether ox, donkey or sheep,
he must pay back double.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles, the verse numbering is different here: verse 1 is still Exodus 21:37 there.

Anyone who steals must give back more than he took. An ox is more valuable and important for work in the field, so it has to be paid back five times.

There were no prison sentences back then. Anyone who could not pay had to work off his debt.

The difference between night and day is interesting: in the dark, you do not know whether a burglar is dangerous. You may defend yourself. But in daylight, you can see that he is only a thief, and you may not simply kill him. Even a thief's life is protected.

Damage to fields VERSES 5–6

5 "Someone may let his animals graze in a field or a vineyard,
and they may eat in another man's field.
Then he must make up for it with the best of his own field and the best of his own vineyard.
6 "If a fire breaks out and spreads to thorn bushes,
so that stacked bundles of grain, standing grain or a whole field burn up,
then the one who started the fire must make up for the loss.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Anyone who causes damage to another person, even without meaning to, must pay for the damage. And not with the worst, but with the best.

Goods given for safekeeping VERSES 7–13

7 "Someone may give his neighbor money or goods to keep safe.
If they are stolen from the neighbor's house
and the thief is found, the thief must pay back double.
8 If the thief is not found,
the owner of the house must come before God.
There it will be found out whether he himself has taken his neighbor's goods.
9 In every quarrel about property –
whether it is about an ox, a donkey, a sheep, clothing or anything lost about which someone says, 'This is mine' –
the case of both people is to be brought before God.
The one whom God finds guilty must pay back double to his neighbor.
10 "Someone may give his neighbor a donkey, an ox, a sheep or any other animal to look after.
It may die, or be injured, or be driven away, without anyone seeing it.
11 Then both of them are to swear an oath by the LORD
that the neighbor has not taken the other man's goods.
The owner must accept this.
And the neighbor does not have to pay anything back.
12 But if it was stolen from him,
he must pay it back to the owner.

13 If it was torn to pieces by a wild animal,
he is to bring what is left as proof.
He does not have to pay for an animal that was torn to pieces.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

There were no banks back then. People gave valuables or animals to a neighbor to keep safe.

If something goes missing and no one knows who is to blame, the matter is brought "before God." This probably means: before the judges or priests at the sanctuary. There people have to tell the truth under a holy oath.

A shepherd cannot help it if a wild animal attacks. But he has to bring proof. Remember: Jacob complained to Laban that he even had to replace animals that were torn to pieces (Genesis 31:39). This law is fairer.

In some Bibles, the verse numbers in this chapter are often shifted by one.

Borrowed goods VERSES 14–15

14 "If someone borrows something from his neighbor,
and it is injured or dies while the owner is not there,
he must surely pay for it.
15 If the owner was there, he does not have to pay for it.
If it was rented, the loss is covered by the rent.

Seducing a young woman VERSES 16–17

16 "A man may talk a young woman into sleeping with him.
She is a virgin and not promised to anyone in marriage.
Then he must pay the bride price for her and marry her.
17 If her father firmly refuses to give her to him as a wife,
he must still pay as much money as the bride price for a virgin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: A bride price is money that the groom gives to the bride's family.

Back then, it was very hard for a woman who was no longer a virgin to find a husband. Without a husband, she had hardly any future in that society.

This law protects the young woman: the man may not simply leave her. He has to take responsibility.

But the father can also forbid the marriage, for example if the man is a bad person. Then the man still has to pay.

Deeds that deserve death VERSES 18–20

18 "You must not let a sorceress live.
19 Anyone who has sex with an animal must be put to death.
20 Anyone who sacrifices to any god other than the LORD
alone must be completely destroyed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These laws are very harsh for us today. They are aimed at things that were connected with faith in foreign gods back then: magic, sexual rituals with animals and sacrifices to other gods.

These verses have been terribly misused in history. In the Middle Ages and in early modern times, many thousands of women were burned as "witches" because of verse 18. That was a great injustice. These women were innocent.

Jews and Christians no longer use these death penalties today. Jesus showed that God does not want to destroy sinners, but to save them.

Protection for foreigners, widows and orphans VERSES 21–24

21 "You must not mistreat a foreigner or oppress him.
For you yourselves were foreigners in the land of Egypt.
22 "You must not take advantage of any widow or orphan.
23 If you do take advantage of them and they cry out to me,
I will surely hear their cry.
24 Then my anger will burn,
and I will kill you with the sword.
Then your own wives will become widows, and your children orphans.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important commandments in the Bible. It comes up again and again, more than 30 times.

Foreigners, widows and orphans were the weakest people in society. They had no one to protect them.

The reason given is moving: you know what it is like to be a foreigner. You yourselves were oppressed. So do not oppress anyone.

God himself takes the side of the weak. He hears their cry – just as he heard the cry of Israel in Egypt. Anyone who oppresses them will have to deal with God.

Protection for the poor VERSES 25–27

25 "If you lend money to one of my people, a poor person who lives among you,
do not treat him like a moneylender would.
You must not charge him interest.
26 If you take your neighbor's coat as a pledge that he will pay you back,
give it back to him before the sun goes down.
27 For it is his only covering.
It is the coat for his body.
What would he sleep in?
When he cries out to me, I will hear him.
For I am gracious.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Anyone who is poor and has to borrow money should not be taken advantage of on top of that. No interest for the poor!

A poor person often had nothing but his coat. During the day he wore it, at night he covered himself with it. Nobody may take this coat away from him overnight.

"What would he sleep in?" – God thinks very concretely about the suffering of the poor. He wants us to think about it too.

Respect for God and for the leaders VERSES 28–31

28 "You must not speak evil against God.
And you must not curse a leader of your people.
29 "Do not delay in giving me some of your harvest and of the juice from your presses.
You are to give me the firstborn of your sons.
30 Do the same with your cattle and your sheep.
The young animal is to stay with its mother for seven

days.
On the eighth day you are to give it to me.
31 "You are to be holy people for me.
So you must not eat any meat from an animal torn to pieces by wild animals in the field.
Throw it to the dogs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "presses" are the presses for wine and olive oil. From everything people harvest, they are to give something to God first, as thanks.

"To give the firstborn" does not mean to sacrifice him. Firstborn sons are bought back (see Exodus 13:13).

The young animal may stay with its mother for a week. Even with animals, people are to act with compassion.

"To be holy" means: to live differently from the others, to belong completely to God. This shows even in what you eat. Meat from animals torn to pieces had not been drained of blood and was therefore seen as unclean.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 23

Laws for living together (3): justice, times of rest and festivals

Justice in court VERSES 1–3

1 "You must not spread a false report.
Do not join forces with a guilty person by being a lying witness.
2 You must not follow a crowd to do evil.
When you speak as a witness in court, do not side with the majority and so twist justice.
3 You must also not favor a poor man in his case.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In court, only the truth counts. Not the majority, not the pressure of the crowd.

"Follow a crowd to do evil" – this is still a great danger today: people go along because everyone else is going along. The Bible says: stay with the truth, even if you are alone.

Surprisingly, a poor person is not to be favored either. Justice means that everyone is treated the same – poor and rich.

Help even your enemy VERSES 4–5

4 "If you come across your enemy's ox or donkey wandering off,
you must be sure to bring it back to him.
5 You may see the donkey of someone who hates you lying under its load.
Do not leave him alone with it.
You must be sure to help him with it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here we already find something of the command to love your enemies, which Jesus teaches later (Matthew 5:44). Even if you are enemies with someone: help him when he is in need. And the animal is not to blame for the quarrel.

Maybe helping each other with the donkey even leads to making peace.

No injustice in court VERSES 6–9

6 "You must not deny justice to the poor among you in their cases.
7 Stay far away from a false charge.
Do not put the innocent and the righteous to death.
For I will not declare the guilty innocent.
8 You must not take a bribe.
For a bribe makes those who can see blind,
and it twists the words of those who are in the right.
9 You must not oppress a foreigner.
You know how a foreigner feels,
for you yourselves were foreigners in the land of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The poor must not be favored (verse 3) – but they must not be treated unfairly either (verse 6). Equal justice for all.

Verse 7: Righteous means: living right before God.

A bribe makes people blind. Anyone who receives money no longer sees the truth. This is still true today in politics, business and the courts.

Once again the foreigner is protected: "You know how a foreigner feels." Literally it says: you know the heart of a foreigner. Anyone who was once a foreigner should have compassion.

A year of rest and a day of rest VERSES 10–13

10 "For six years you are to plant your land and bring in its harvest.
11 But in the seventh year you are to let it rest and not farm it.
Then the poor among your people can eat from it.
And what they leave, the wild animals may eat.
Do the same with your vineyard and your olive grove.
12 "For six days you are to do your work.
But on the seventh day you are to rest.
Then your ox and your donkey can rest too.
And the son of your female servant and the foreigner can catch their breath.
13 "Be careful to do everything I have told you.
Do not call on the names of other gods.
Do not even let their names be heard from your mouth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

It is not only people who need rest, but the land too. Every seven years a field is not to be farmed. This is called the "Sabbath year." Today we know: this is also good for the soil.

And what grows by itself belongs to the poor and even to the animals. God's care is for everyone.

For the day of rest, the weakest are especially kept in mind here: the animals, the children of servants, the foreigners. They are to be able to "catch their breath."

Three great festivals a year VERSES 14–19

14 "Three times a year you are to hold a festival for me.

15 Keep the Festival of Unleavened Bread.
For seven days you are to eat bread without yeast, as I commanded you.
Keep it at the set time in the month of Abib,
for in that month you came out of Egypt.
No one is to come before me with empty hands.
16 Also keep the Festival of Harvest,
when you harvest the first crops of what you planted in the field.
And keep the Festival of Ingathering at the end of the year,
when you gather in the crops of your work from the field.
17 Three times a year all your males are to come before the Lord GOD.
18 "You must not offer the blood of my sacrifice together with bread made with yeast.
And the fat of my festival sacrifice must not be left overnight until the morning.
19 Bring the very best of the first crops of your land to the house of the LORD your God.
You must not boil a young goat in its mother's milk.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel is to celebrate three great festivals. All three are connected with farming and with what God has done:

The Festival of Unleavened Bread (Passover) in spring reminds them of the exodus from Egypt.

The Festival of Harvest in early summer is the festival of the wheat harvest. Later it is called the "Festival of Weeks" (Shavuot). At this time of year, Christians celebrate Pentecost.

The Festival of Ingathering in the fall is the festival at the end of the harvest, when fruit and grapes are brought in. Later it is called the "Festival of Shelters" (Sukkot).

"Not to come with empty hands" means: whoever celebrates brings God a gift of thanks from what he has received.

The ban on boiling a young goat in its mother's milk may be aimed at a pagan custom. But it also shows compassion: the milk that is meant to give life is not to serve death. From this verse, Jews later developed the rule not to eat meat and milk together.

God promises his protection VERSES 20–26

20 "Look, I am sending an angel ahead of you.
He will protect you on the way
and bring you to the place I have prepared.
21 Pay attention to him and listen to his voice.
Do not rebel against him,
for he will not forgive your disobedience,
because my name is in him.
22 But if you truly listen to his voice and do everything I say,
then I will be an enemy to your enemies
and an opponent to your opponents.
23 "For my angel will go ahead of you.
He will bring you to the Amorite, the Hittite, the Perizzite, the Canaanite, the Hivite and the Jebusite.
And I will wipe them out.
24 You must not bow down to their gods or serve them.
Do not do what they do.
Instead, you must completely tear them down and smash their sacred pillars.
25 "You are to serve the LORD your God.
Then he will bless your bread and your water.
And I will take sickness away from among you.
26 In your land no woman will lose her baby before birth or be unable to have children.
I will let you live out the full number of your days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God promises to go with his people and protect them along the whole way. The angel is God's messenger. "My name is in him" means: God himself is present in him.

The "sacred pillars" were standing stones where the peoples in Canaan worshiped their gods.

The peoples in Canaan are to be wiped out. This is a very difficult passage. It becomes important in the books of Joshua and Judges. The Bible gives the reason that these peoples worshiped cruel gods – some even sacrificed children. Israel was not to be drawn into this idol worship. Many interpreters stress: this was a one-time task in a certain time. It never justifies violence against other peoples today.

God's blessing is very concrete: bread, water, health, children and a long life.

Little by little VERSES 27–33

27 "I will send terror of me ahead of you.
I will throw into confusion all the peoples you come to.
I will make all your enemies turn their backs and run from you.
28 I will send the hornet ahead of you.
It will drive out the Hivite, the Canaanite and the Hittite from in front of you.
29 But I will not drive them out from in front of you in a single year.
Otherwise the land would become a wasteland,
and the wild animals would become too many for you.
30 Little by little I will drive them out from in front of you,
until you have become many and can take the land as your own.
31 "I will set your borders from the Red Sea to the sea of the Philistines,
and from the wilderness to the River.
For I will hand over the people who live in the land to you,
and you will drive them out from in front of you.
32 You must not make a covenant with them or with their gods.
33 They must not live in your land,
or they will make you sin against me.
For if you serve their gods, it will surely become a trap for you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God promises to fight for his people himself. He sends terror and the hornet ahead. Hornets are large, dangerous wasps. Maybe this is also a picture of a panic that makes the peoples run away.

God is wise: if the land were suddenly empty, it would grow wild. That is why it happens step by step.

The "sea of the Philistines" is the Mediterranean Sea. The "River" means the Euphrates. The land was this large only for a short time later, in the time of King David and Solomon.

The greatest danger for Israel was not the weapons of the other peoples, but their gods. Whoever binds himself to them loses himself.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 24

The covenant is made

The invitation up the mountain VERSES 1–2

1 God said to Moses,
"Come up to the LORD, you and Aaron, Nadab and Abihu,
and 70 of the elders of Israel.
Worship from a distance.
2 Only Moses is to come near to the LORD.
The others are not to come near.
And the people are not to go up with him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nadab and Abihu are Aaron's oldest sons.

There are different levels of nearness to God: the people stay below. The leaders come part of the way up. Only Moses is allowed to come very close to God.

The people say yes VERSES 3–8

3 Moses came and told the people all the LORD's words and all the laws.
All the people answered with one voice,
"We will do everything the LORD has said."
4 Moses wrote down all the LORD's words.
Early the next morning he got up.
At the foot of the mountain he built an altar.
He also set up 12 pillars, for the 12 tribes of Israel.
5 Then he sent young men of the people of Israel.
They offered burnt offerings
and sacrificed cattle as peace offerings to the LORD.
6 Moses took half of the blood and put it in bowls.
The other half of the blood he sprinkled on the altar.
7 Then he took the Book of the Covenant and read it aloud to the people.
They said,
"We will do everything the LORD has said, and we will obey."
8 Then Moses took the blood and sprinkled it on the people.
He said,
"Look, this is the blood of the covenant
that the LORD has made with you, based on all these words."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the covenant between God and Israel is solemnly made.

First the people hear what God says. Then they say yes – even twice.

Moses writes everything down. This is how the "Book of the Covenant" comes about (Chapters 20–23).

The 12 pillars stand for the 12 tribes. The whole people takes part.

The blood connects both sides: one part goes on the altar (for God), one part on the people. Back then, a covenant was often sealed with blood. That meant: this covenant is a matter of life and death.

Jesus takes up these words at the Last Supper. He takes the cup and says: "This is my blood of the new covenant" (Mark 14:24). Christians believe: with Jesus a new covenant begins.

They see God VERSES 9–11

9 Then Moses, Aaron, Nadab, Abihu and 70 of the elders of Israel went up.
10 They saw the God of Israel.
Under his feet was something like a floor made of sapphire stone,
as clear as the sky itself.
11 But God did not lay a hand on the leaders of the people of Israel.
They saw God, and they ate and drank.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most mysterious passages in the Bible. The leaders see God – and stay alive.

The Bible does not describe exactly what they see. It only describes what is under his feet: something blue and clear, like a floor of precious stones. A sapphire is a blue precious stone.

Then they eat and drink. A feast with God. Back then, people celebrated an agreement like this: with a meal together.

Later it says: "No one can see me and live" (Exodus 33:20). Many understand it like this: they saw only a reflection of God's glory, not God himself.

Moses goes up into the cloud VERSES 12–18

12 The LORD said to Moses,
"Come up to me on the mountain and stay here.
I will give you the stone tablets
with the law and the commandments that I have written,
so that you can teach them to the people."
13 So Moses set out with his helper Joshua.
And Moses went up onto the mountain of God.
14 He said to the elders,
"Wait here for us until we come back to you.
Look, Aaron and Hur are with you.
Anyone who has a quarrel can go to them."
15 Moses went up the mountain.
And the cloud covered the mountain.
16 The glory of the LORD settled on Mount Sinai.
The cloud covered it for six days.
On the seventh day the LORD called to Moses from the middle of the cloud.

17 To the people of Israel, the glory of the LORD looked
like a fire that burns everything up, on the top of the
mountain.
18 Moses went into the middle of the cloud and went up
the mountain.
And Moses stayed on the mountain for 40 days and 40
nights.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God himself has written the commandments on stone tablets. Stone stands for something that lasts.

Joshua is allowed to come part of the way. He is being prepared for his later task.

Six days of waiting, and on the seventh day God calls – as at creation.

From below, the mountain looks like a fire. And Moses walks right into it. He has great trust in God.

40 days and 40 nights – a long time. During this time, God gives Moses the instructions for the holy tent (Chapters 25–31). Down in the camp, the people become impatient. Chapter 32 tells what happens then.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 25

God's home in the middle of his people: the ark, the table and the lamp stand

Gifts for the sanctuary VERSES 1–9

1 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel.
Tell them to collect an offering for me.
Take my offering from everyone whose heart makes
him willing to give.
3 This is the offering that you shall take from them:
gold, silver and bronze,
4 blue, purple and scarlet cloth,
fine linen and goats' hair,
5 rams' skins dyed red, sea cow hides and acacia wood,
6 oil for the light,
spices for the anointing oil and for the sweet incense,
7 onyx stones, and stones to be set
for the ephod and for the breastplate.
8 "Let them make me a sanctuary.
Then I will live among them.
9 You shall make it exactly like everything I show you:
the pattern of the tabernacle and the pattern of all its
furniture.
That is how you shall make it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now a long part begins (Chapters 25–31 and 35–40). It is about the "sanctuary." It is also called the "tabernacle" or the "Tent of Meeting." It is a large tent that can be carried. In it, God wants to live in the middle of his people.

This is the great goal of leaving Egypt: God does not want to stay far away on a mountain. He wants to be in the middle of his people and travel with them through the desert.

No one is forced to give anything. God only wants gifts that come from the heart.

The valuable things probably came from Egypt: When the Israelites left, the Egyptians had given them gold, silver and clothes (Exodus 12:35).

Purple and scarlet were very expensive dyes. Cloth for kings was dyed with them.

It is not certain what "sea cows" means here. Maybe the hides of dugongs, which live in the Red Sea. Other Bibles say "fine leather" or "dolphin skins."

Acacias are trees that grow in the desert. Their wood is very hard and lasts a long time.

The ephod and the breastplate are part of the high priest's clothes (Chapter 28).

The ark of the covenant VERSES 10–16

10 "They shall make an ark of acacia wood.
It shall be about 3 feet 9 inches long, about 2 feet 3
inches wide and about 2 feet 3 inches high.
11 Cover it with pure gold, inside and outside.
And make a gold molding all around it.
12 Cast four gold rings for it.
Put them on its four feet:
two rings on one side and two rings on the other side.
13 Make poles of acacia wood and cover them with gold.
14 Put the poles through the rings on the sides of the ark,
so that the ark can be carried with them.
15 The poles shall stay in the rings of the ark.
They shall never be taken out.
16 Put the covenant that I will give you into the ark.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible, the measurements are given in cubits: two and a half cubits long, one and a half cubits wide and high. A cubit is about 18 inches.

The ark (also called the "ark of the covenant") is a chest. It is the most important object in the sanctuary.

In the ark are the two stone tablets with the Ten Commandments. They are the written witness of the covenant. A covenant is a firm agreement.

The poles always stay in the rings. God's presence is always ready to move on with the people.

The cover with the cherubim VERSES 17–22

17 "Make a mercy seat of pure gold.
It shall be about 3 feet 9 inches long and about 2 feet 3
inches wide.
18 Make two cherubim of hammered gold.
Put them at the two ends of the mercy seat.
19 Make one cherub at one end and one cherub at the
other end.
The cherubim shall be one piece with the mercy seat.
20 The cherubim shall spread out their wings upward
and cover the mercy seat with their wings.
Their faces shall be turned toward each other.
They shall look toward the mercy seat.

21 "Put the mercy seat on top of the ark.
And put the covenant that I will give you inside the ark.
22 There I will meet with you.
From above the mercy seat, from between the two cherubim on the ark of the covenant,
I will tell you everything that I command you for the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The mercy seat is the cover of the ark. In Hebrew it is called "kapporet." The word is connected with "making peace" and "covering guilt." On the great Day of Atonement, blood is sprinkled here, so that the people's guilt is forgiven (Leviticus 16).

Cherubim (one is called a cherub) are mighty heavenly beings with wings. They also guard the way to the Garden of Eden (Genesis 3:24).

The space between the cherubim is like an empty throne. God himself sits on it, but no one can see him. There is no image of God – only an empty place for him.

"There I will meet with you" – this is the heart of the sanctuary. Here God speaks with Moses.

The table for the bread VERSES 23–30

23 "Make a table of acacia wood.
It shall be about 3 feet long, about 18 inches wide and about 2 feet 3 inches high.
24 Cover it with pure gold and make a gold molding all around it.
25 Make a rim all around it, about 3 inches wide.
And make a gold molding all around this rim.
26 Make four gold rings for the table.
Put the rings at the four corners, on its four legs.
27 The rings shall be close to the rim.
The poles for carrying the table shall go through them.
28 Make the poles of acacia wood and cover them with gold.
The table shall be carried with them.
29 Also make its dishes, its spoons, its ladles and its bowls for pouring out offerings.
Make them of pure gold.
30 Always put the bread of the presence on the table before me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: two cubits long, one cubit wide, one and a half cubits high. A hand width is about 3 inches.

The "bread of the presence" (word for word: "bread of the face") was 12 loaves, one for each tribe (Leviticus 24:5–9). They always lay before God. They show: The whole people always stands before God's face. And it is God who gives his people bread.

The golden lamp stand VERSES 31–40

31 "Make a lamp stand of pure gold.
The lamp stand shall be made of hammered gold.
Its base, its shaft, its cups, its buds and its flowers shall be one piece with it.
32 Six branches shall go out from its sides:
three branches on one side and three branches on the other side.
33 On one branch there shall be three cups shaped like almond blossoms, each with a bud and a flower.
And on the next branch there shall also be three cups shaped like almond blossoms, each with a bud and a flower.
It shall be like this for all six branches that go out from the lamp stand.
34 On the lamp stand itself there shall be four cups shaped like almond blossoms, with their buds and their flowers.
35 There shall be a bud under each pair of branches, one piece with the lamp stand:
a bud under the first two branches,
a bud under the next two branches
and a bud under the last two branches.
It shall be like this for the six branches that go out from the lamp stand.
36 The buds and the branches shall be one piece with it.
All of it shall be one piece of hammered, pure gold.
37 "Make seven lamps for it.
They shall light its lamps so that they give light to the space in front of it.
38 Its snuffers and its snuff dishes shall also be of pure gold.
39 The lamp stand and all these tools shall be made from a talent of pure gold (about 75 pounds).
40 Make sure that you make everything exactly like the pattern that was shown to you on the mountain."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The lamp stand has seven branches. In Hebrew it is called the "menorah." To this day, it is one of the most important signs of Judaism. It is even on the coat of arms of the State of Israel.

The lamp stand looks like an almond tree in bloom. In the land of Israel, the almond tree is the first tree to bloom each year, while it is still winter. Maybe the lamp stand is also a reminder of the tree of life in the Garden of Eden.

A talent is an old weight, about 75 pounds. That much pure gold for just one lamp stand!

"Hammered gold" means: The gold is beaten into shape with a hammer. The whole lamp stand is made of one single piece.

Snuffers are used to cut off the burned wicks of the lamps.

Again and again it says: exactly like the pattern that God showed. People did not invent the sanctuary themselves. It is a copy of something in heaven (Hebrews 8:5).

EXODUS

CHAPTER 26

God's home: curtains, boards and veil

The inner curtains of linen VERSES 1–6

1 "Make the tabernacle with 10 curtains.
They shall be made of fine twisted linen and of blue, purple and scarlet cloth.
Cherubim shall be woven into them by a skillful worker.
2 Each curtain shall be about 42 feet long and about 6 feet wide.
All the curtains shall be the same size.
3 Five curtains shall be joined to each other.
And the other five curtains shall be joined to each other.
4 Make loops of blue cloth on the edge of the last curtain of the first set.
And do the same on the edge of the last curtain of the second set.
5 Make 50 loops on the one curtain,
and make 50 loops on the edge of the curtain of the second set.
The loops shall be exactly opposite each other.
6 Make 50 clasps of gold.
Join the curtains to each other with the clasps.
So the tabernacle shall be one whole.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's home is a large tent. It is built in several layers.

The innermost layer is the most beautiful: colored linen with pictures of cherubim woven into it. Anyone who stands inside sees a sky full of cherubim above them.

In the Bible, the measurements are given in cubits: 28 cubits long, 4 cubits wide. A cubit is about 18 inches.

"Twisted" means: Several threads are twisted together to make one strong thread.

The curtains of goats' hair VERSES 7–13

7 "Also make curtains of goats' hair.
They shall be a covering over the tabernacle.
Make 11 of these curtains.
8 Each curtain shall be about 45 feet long and about 6 feet wide.
All 11 curtains shall be the same size.
9 Join five curtains together into one set,
and six curtains into another set.
Fold the sixth curtain double at the front of the tent.
10 "Make 50 loops on the edge of the last curtain of the first set,
and 50 loops on the edge of the last curtain of the second set.
11 Make 50 clasps of bronze.
Put the clasps into the loops and join the tent together, so that it becomes one whole.
12 There is a part of the tent curtains that is left over: the half curtain that remains.
It shall hang down over the back of the tabernacle.
13 On each side, the tent curtains are about 18 inches longer than needed.
This part shall hang down over the sides of the tabernacle, on this side and on that side, to cover it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: 30 cubits long, 4 cubits wide. The part that hangs over is one cubit.

Over the beautiful linen curtains comes a covering of goats' hair that protects them. Nomads in the desert still use coverings like this for their tents today. They keep out rain and sun.

This covering is a little larger than the inner one, so that it covers everything well.

The outer coverings VERSE 14

14 "Make a covering for the tent of rams' skins dyed red.
And above that, make a covering of sea cow hides.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

All together, there are four layers. From the outside, the sanctuary looked very plain, like a simple tent of leather. All the splendor was hidden inside.

The boards VERSES 15–25

15 "Make the boards for the tabernacle of acacia wood.
They shall stand upright.
16 Each board shall be about 15 feet long and about 2 feet 3 inches wide.
17 Each board shall have two tenons, joined to each other.
Do this for all the boards of the tabernacle.
18 Make 20 boards for the tabernacle for the south side.
19 Make 40 sockets of silver under the 20 boards:
2 sockets under each board for its 2 tenons.
20 "For the second side of the tabernacle, the north side, make 20 boards
21 and their 40 sockets of silver:
2 sockets under each board.
22 For the back of the tabernacle, toward the west, make six boards.
23 And make two boards for the corners of the tabernacle at the back.
24 They shall be double at the bottom, and they shall be joined together at the top, up to the first ring.
It shall be like this for both of them.
They shall form the two corners.
25 So there shall be 8 boards with their sockets of silver, 16 sockets:
2 sockets under each board.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: 10 cubits long, one and a half cubits wide.

Verse 17: A tenon is a peg at the end of a board that fits into a hole.

The boards form the walls of the sanctuary: 20 on the south side and 20 on the north side, 6 boards and 2 corner boards on the west side. The east side is open. The entrance is there.

The silver sockets stand on the ground. The tenons of the boards are put into them. So everything stands firm and can still be taken down quickly.

The sanctuary was about 45 feet long and about 15 feet wide.

The bars VERSES 26–30

26 "Make bars of acacia wood:
five for the boards on one side of the tabernacle,

27 five bars for the boards on the other side of the tabernacle,
and five bars for the boards at the back, toward the west.
28 The middle bar shall go through the middle of the boards from one end to the other.
29 Cover the boards with gold.
Make gold rings on them for the bars to go through.
And cover the bars with gold too.
30 Set up the tabernacle exactly the way it was shown to you on the mountain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The bars hold the boards together, so that the walls are strong.

Inside, everything was covered with gold. When the light of the lamp stand fell on it, everything shone like gold.

The veil in front of the Most Holy Place VERSES 31–35

31 "Make a veil of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted linen.
Cherubim shall be woven into it by a skillful worker.
32 Hang it on four pillars of acacia wood covered with gold.
Their hooks shall be of gold.
And they shall stand on four sockets of silver.
33 "Hang up the veil under the clasps.
Bring the ark of the covenant in there, behind the veil.
The veil shall separate the holy place from the most holy place for you.
34 Put the mercy seat on the ark of the covenant in the most holy place.
35 Put the table outside the veil.
And put the lamp stand across from the table, on the south side of the tabernacle.
Put the table on the north side.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The sanctuary has two rooms: the "Holy Place" and the "Most Holy Place." A precious veil hangs between them.

Verse 31: A veil is a large curtain.

Only the ark of the covenant stands in the Most Holy Place. God is present there in a special way. Only the high priest may go in, once a year (Leviticus 16).

In the Holy Place in front of it stand the table with the bread, the lamp stand and, later, the altar of incense.

The New Testament tells: When Jesus died on the cross, the veil in the temple was torn in two from top to bottom (Matthew 27:51). Christians understand it this way: Through Jesus, the way to God is open for everyone.

The screen at the entrance VERSES 36–37

36 "Make a screen for the door of the Tent.
Make it of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted linen,
the work of an embroiderer.
37 Make five pillars of acacia wood for the screen and cover them with gold.
Their hooks shall be of gold.
And cast five sockets of bronze for them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 36: A screen is a hanging curtain. An embroiderer sews colorful patterns into cloth.

The entrance is on the east side. It also has a colorful curtain, but without cherubim.

The closer you come to the Most Holy Place, the more precious the materials become: outside bronze, inside silver and gold. So the way it is built shows: The closer to God, the holier.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 27

The altar for burnt offerings, the courtyard and the oil for the lamp stand

The altar for burnt offerings VERSES 1–8

1 "Make the altar of acacia wood.
It shall be about 7 feet 6 inches long and about 7 feet 6 inches wide.
So the altar shall be square.
It shall be about 4 feet 6 inches high.
2 Make horns on its four corners.
The horns shall be one piece with the altar.
Cover it with bronze.
3 Also make its pots for taking away the ashes,
and its shovels, its basins, its meat hooks and its fire pans.
Make all its tools of bronze.
4 "Make a grating of bronze for the altar, like a net.
On the net, make four bronze rings at its four corners.
5 Put the grating under the ledge that goes around the altar, down below.
The net shall reach halfway up the altar.
6 Make poles for the altar, poles of acacia wood, and cover them with bronze.
7 The poles shall be put into the rings.
When the altar is carried, the poles shall be on its two sides.
8 Make the altar hollow, out of planks.
They shall make it just as it was shown to you on the mountain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: 5 cubits long and wide, 3 cubits high. A cubit is about 18 inches.

This altar stands outside in the courtyard, in front of the entrance of the sanctuary. The animal sacrifices are burned on it.

The "horns" are points on the four corners. People saw them as very holy. Someone who was being hunted could hold on to the horns of the altar and ask for protection (1 Kings 1:50).

The altar is hollow inside and has poles for carrying. So it can be taken along on the journey through the desert.

Here everything is made of bronze, not of gold. The farther away from the Most Holy Place, the simpler the materials become.

The courtyard VERSES 9–19

9 "Make the courtyard of the tabernacle.
For the south side, there shall be hangings of fine twisted linen for the courtyard, about 150 feet long for this one side.
10 Its pillars shall be 20, with 20 sockets of bronze.
The hooks of the pillars and their bands shall be of silver.
11 It shall be the same on the north side:
hangings about 150 feet long, with 20 pillars and 20 sockets of bronze.
The hooks of the pillars and their bands shall be of silver.
12 "For the width of the courtyard on the west side, there shall be hangings about 75 feet long,
with 10 pillars and 10 sockets.
13 On the east side, toward the sunrise, the courtyard shall also be about 75 feet wide.
14 On one side of the gate there shall be hangings about 22 feet 6 inches long,
with three pillars and three sockets.
15 And on the other side there shall be hangings, also about 22 feet 6 inches long,
with three pillars and three sockets.
16 For the gate of the courtyard there shall be a screen about 30 feet long.
It shall be made of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted linen, the work of an embroiderer.
It shall have four pillars and four sockets.
17 "All the pillars around the courtyard shall be joined with bands of silver.
Their hooks shall be of silver, and their sockets of bronze.
18 The courtyard shall be about 150 feet long and about 75 feet wide all along.
The hangings shall be about 7 feet 6 inches high, made of fine twisted linen.
And their sockets shall be of bronze.
19 All the tools of the tabernacle that are needed for its service,
all its tent pegs and all the tent pegs of the courtyard shall be of bronze.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: The courtyard is 100 cubits long and 50 cubits wide. The hangings are 5 cubits high. The gate is 20 cubits wide, and the parts on each side of it are 15 cubits each.

The courtyard is a large open space with a fence around the sanctuary. It is about as big as four tennis courts.

The white linen hangings were more than 7 feet high. No one could see in from the outside. So in the middle of the camp, there was a holy area that was set apart.

There is only one entrance, on the east side. It is especially colorful and beautiful.

The oil for the lamp stand VERSES 20–21

20 "Command the people of Israel to bring you pure olive oil.
It shall be made from beaten olives, for the light.
With it, a lamp shall burn all the time.
21 It shall be in the Tent of Meeting, outside the veil that is in front of the covenant.
There Aaron and his sons shall keep the lamp burning before the LORD from evening until morning.
This is a law forever, for all the generations of the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The best oil is used for the lamps: The olives are not pressed hard. They are only beaten lightly. So the oil is very pure and burns brightly, without much smoke.

"Tent of Meeting" is another name for the sanctuary. There God and people meet.

The light shall burn every night. To this day, an "eternal light" burns in every synagogue. An eternal light also burns in Catholic churches. It shows: God is present here.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 28

The clothes of the priests

Aaron and his sons become priests VERSES 1–5

1 "Bring your brother Aaron and his sons with him near to you, from among the people of Israel.
They shall serve me as priests:
Aaron and his sons Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar.
2 Make holy clothes for your brother Aaron,
to give him glory and beauty.
3 Speak to all who have a wise heart,
whom I have filled with the spirit of wisdom.
They shall make Aaron's clothes,
to make him holy, so that he can serve me as a priest.
4 "These are the clothes that they shall make:
a breastplate, an ephod, a robe, a fitted tunic, a turban and a sash.
They shall make holy clothes for your brother Aaron and his sons,
so that he can serve me as a priest.
5 They shall use the gold,
and the blue, purple and scarlet cloth, and the fine linen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A priest is a person who stands between God and people. He brings the people's offerings before God and speaks God's blessing over the people.

Aaron becomes the first high priest. His sons become priests. Later, only their descendants are allowed to be priests.

The clothes shall give "glory and beauty." Whoever serves before God should show it on the outside too.

Interesting: Here the skill of a craftsman is called a gift of God's Spirit. Art and craft are gifts from God.

The ephod VERSES 6–14

6 "They shall make the ephod of gold,
of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted linen, the work of a skillful worker.
7 It shall have two shoulder straps fastened to its two ends.
So it is held together.
8 The skillfully woven band on it shall be made the same way and be one piece with it,
of gold, of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted linen.
9 "Take two onyx stones.
Engrave the names of the people of Israel on them:
10 six of their names on the one stone,
and the names of the other six on the other stone,
in the order of their birth.
11 An engraver of stone shall engrave the names of the people of Israel on the two stones, the way a seal is engraved.
Put the stones in settings of gold.
12 Put the two stones on the shoulder straps of the ephod.
They shall be stones of remembrance for the people of Israel.
So Aaron shall carry their names before the LORD on his two shoulders, as a reminder.
13 "Make settings of gold,
14 and two chains of pure gold.
Make them like braided cords.
Fasten the braided chains to the settings.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The ephod is a kind of apron or vest. It is worn over the robe. It is held up by straps over the shoulders.

Verse 11: A seal is a stamp with a name on it.

On his shoulders, Aaron carries the names of the 12 tribes. This is a beautiful picture: The priest carries the whole people on his shoulders before God. He forgets no one.

The breastplate VERSES 15–30

15 "Make a breastplate of judgment, the work of a skillful worker.
Make it the same way as the ephod:
of gold, of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted linen.
16 It shall be square and folded double.
It shall be about 9 inches long and about 9 inches wide.
17 "Set stones in it, in four rows:
In the first row a ruby, a topaz and a beryl.
18 In the second row a turquoise, a sapphire and an emerald.
19 In the third row a jacinth, an agate and an amethyst.
20 In the fourth row a chrysolite, an onyx and a jasper.
They shall be set in gold settings.
21 There shall be 12 stones, one for each name of the people of Israel.
A name shall be engraved on each stone, the way a seal is engraved.
They shall be for the 12 tribes.
22 "Make chains for the breastplate like braided cords of pure gold.
23 Make two rings of gold for the breastplate.
Put the two rings on the two ends of the breastplate.
24 Put the two braided chains of gold through the two rings at the ends of the breastplate.
25 Fasten the other two ends of the two chains to the two settings.
Put them on the front of the shoulder straps of the ephod.
26 "Make two more rings of gold.
Put them on the two ends of the breastplate, on its inside edge, next to the ephod.
27 And make two more rings of gold.
Put them low on the front of the two shoulder straps of the ephod,
close to the place where they are joined, above the woven band of the ephod.
28 They shall tie the breastplate by its rings to the rings of the ephod with a blue cord.
So it stays on the woven band of the ephod,
and the breastplate cannot swing away from the ephod.
29 "So Aaron shall carry the names of the people of Israel on the breastplate of judgment, on his heart,
when he goes into the holy place.
It shall always be a reminder before the LORD.
30 Put the Urim and the Thummim into the breastplate of judgment.
They shall be on Aaron's heart when he goes in before the LORD.
So Aaron shall always carry the judgment of the people of Israel on his heart before the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible gives the size as "a span." A span is the distance from the thumb to the little finger when the hand is spread out. It is about 9 inches.

Today no one knows for sure which precious stones are meant. The names are translations of old Hebrew words. Different Bibles name different stones here.

There are 12 precious stones for the 12 tribes. Each tribe is precious and special, like a jewel.

The priest carries the names of the people on his shoulders (strength) and on his heart (love). He brings the people, with everything that moves them, before God.

No one knows exactly what the "Urim and Thummim" were. They were probably two lots or stones. With them, people could ask what God wanted in difficult questions. The words probably mean "lights and perfections."

The robe with bells VERSES 31–35

31 "Make the robe that is worn under the ephod all of blue cloth.
32 There shall be a hole for the head in the middle of it.
There shall be a woven edge around the hole,
like the neck hole of a coat of armor, so that it does not tear.
33 On its hem, make pomegranates
of blue, purple and scarlet cloth, all around the hem.

And put bells of gold between them, all around:
34 a golden bell and a pomegranate,
a golden bell and a pomegranate,
all around the hem of the robe.
35 Aaron shall wear it when he serves.
Its sound shall be heard when he goes into the holy place before the LORD, and when he comes out, so that he does not die.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The pomegranate is a fruit with many seeds. It was a sign of new life and of many children.

The bells ring with every step. So the people outside hear: The priest is inside and is doing his service. He is alive.

"So that he does not die" – that sounds hard. It shows how serious it is to meet the holy God. You do not simply go to God without being announced – just as you would not with a king.

The golden plate on the forehead VERSES 36–38

36 "Make a plate of pure gold.
Engrave on it, the way a seal is engraved:
'HOLY TO THE LORD.'
37 Fasten it with a blue cord to the turban.
It shall be on the front of the turban.
38 It shall be on Aaron's forehead.
So Aaron carries the guilt that may stick to the holy things,
which the people of Israel make holy in all their holy gifts.
It shall always be on his forehead,
so that the LORD accepts them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The WEB, our English source text, says "sash" in verse 37. But the Hebrew text means the turban, the covering for the head, because the plate sits on the forehead. That is why it says "turban" here.

"Holy to the LORD" – these words show: The priest belongs completely to God. And he stands in the place of the whole people, who are meant to belong to God.

People make mistakes, even when they want to give God a gift. The priest carries these mistakes before God, so that God still accepts the gifts with kindness.

The other clothes VERSES 39–43

39 "Weave the tunic of fine linen.
Make a turban of fine linen.
And make a sash, the work of an embroiderer.
40 "Make tunics for Aaron's sons too.
Make sashes for them, and make headbands for them.
They shall give them glory and beauty.
41 Put them on your brother Aaron and on his sons with him.
Anoint them, ordain them and make them holy,
so that they can serve me as priests.
42 "Make linen pants for them to cover their naked bodies.
They shall reach from the waist to the thighs.
43 Aaron and his sons shall wear them
when they go into the Tent of Meeting,
or when they come near the altar to serve in the holy place.
Otherwise they will carry guilt and die.
This shall be a law forever, for Aaron and for his descendants after him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Anoint" means: to pour sweet-smelling oil over someone. It is a sign that God has chosen someone for a special task. Later, kings were anointed too. The Hebrew word for "anointed one" is "Messiah." In Greek it is "Christ."

The priests shall be dressed with dignity and decency. In many other religions of that time, there were rituals with nakedness. Not in Israel.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 29

The priests are made holy – the daily offering

Getting ready VERSES 1–3

1 "This is what you shall do to them to make them holy, so that they can serve me as priests:
Take one young bull and two rams without any defect.
2 Also take bread without yeast,
cakes without yeast mixed with oil,
and wafers without yeast spread with oil.
Make them of fine wheat flour.
3 Put them into one basket.
Bring them in the basket, together with the bull and the two rams.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now it describes how Aaron and his sons are put into their office. The ceremony lasts seven days. Leviticus 8 tells how it really takes place.

"Consecrate" means: to set apart for God and make holy.

Washing, dressing and anointing VERSES 4–9

4 "Bring Aaron and his sons to the door of the Tent of Meeting.
Wash them with water.
5 Take the clothes.
Put the tunic on Aaron, and the robe of the ephod, the ephod and the breastplate.
And tie the skillfully woven band of the ephod around him.
6 Put the turban on his head.
And put the holy crown on the turban.
7 Then take the anointing oil.
Pour it on his head and anoint him.
8 "Bring his sons too.
Put tunics on them.
9 Tie belts around them, around Aaron and his sons.
And tie headbands on them.

The priesthood shall be theirs by a law forever.
In this way, you shall consecrate Aaron and his sons.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

First they are washed. Whoever wants to serve God must be clean – on the outside and on the inside.

The "holy crown" is the golden plate on the forehead with the words "Holy to the LORD" (Exodus 28:36).

Only Aaron has oil poured over him. It is a sign of his special office as high priest.

The sin offering: the bull VERSES 10–14

10 "Bring the bull in front of the Tent of Meeting.
Aaron and his sons shall lay their hands on the head of the bull.
11 Then kill the bull before the LORD, at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
12 Take some of the bull's blood and put it on the horns of the altar with your finger.
Pour out all the rest of the blood at the base of the altar.
13 Take all the fat that covers the inner organs,
the cover of the liver, the two kidneys and the fat on them.
Burn them on the altar.
14 But burn the meat of the bull, its skin and its dung with fire outside the camp.
It is a sin offering.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sacrifices seem strange to us today. Back then, they were the way people came before God.

When Aaron and his sons lay their hands on the animal's head, they show: This animal stands in our place. It carries our guilt.

The priests are also people who make mistakes. Before they stand before God for others, they need forgiveness themselves.

A "sin offering" is an offering through which guilt is forgiven.

The fat was seen as the best part of the animal. It belongs to God.

The New Testament reminds us that Jesus also died "outside the gate" (Hebrews 13:11–12).

The burnt offering: the first ram VERSES 15–18

15 "Also take the one ram.
Aaron and his sons shall lay their hands on its head.
16 Kill the ram.
Take its blood and sprinkle it all around on the altar.
17 Cut the ram into its pieces.
Wash its inner organs and its legs.
Put them with its other pieces and with its head.
18 Then burn the whole ram on the altar.
It is a burnt offering to the LORD.
It is a pleasant smell, an offering made by fire to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In a burnt offering, the whole animal is burned. Nothing is left for the people. It is a sign of giving oneself completely: We belong completely to you, God.

"A pleasant smell to the LORD" is a picture. It means that God gladly accepts the offering.

The offering of consecration: the second ram VERSES 19–28

19 "Take the other ram.
Aaron and his sons shall lay their hands on its head.
20 Then kill the ram.
Take some of its blood and put it
on the tip of Aaron's right ear and on the tip of his sons' right ear,
on the thumb of their right hand and on the big toe of their right foot.
Sprinkle the rest of the blood all around on the altar.
21 Take some of the blood that is on the altar, and some of the anointing oil.
Sprinkle it on Aaron and on his clothes,
and on his sons and on his sons' clothes with him.
Then he and his clothes, and his sons and his sons' clothes with him, will be holy.
22 "Also take some of the ram's fat:
the fat tail, the fat that covers the inner organs,
the cover of the liver, the two kidneys and the fat on them,
and the right thigh.
For it is a ram of consecration.
23 Also take one loaf of bread, one cake of bread made with oil and one wafer
out of the basket of bread without yeast that stands before the LORD.
24 Put all of this into Aaron's hands and into his sons' hands.
Wave them before the LORD as a wave offering.
25 Then take them from their hands.
Burn them on the altar, on top of the burnt offering,
as a pleasant smell before the LORD.
It is an offering made by fire to the LORD.
26 "Take the breast of Aaron's ram of consecration.
Wave it before the LORD as a wave offering.
It shall be your share.
27 Make holy the breast of the wave offering and the thigh of the wave offering,
which were waved and raised up from the ram of consecration,
from what is for Aaron and for his sons.
28 It shall be Aaron's and his sons' share forever from the people of Israel.
For it is a wave offering.
It shall be a wave offering from the people of Israel,
from the sacrifices of their peace offerings.
It is their wave offering to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The blood is put on the ear, the hand and the foot, each time on the right side. This means: The priest shall listen to God with his ear, do God's work with his hand, and walk in God's ways with his foot. The whole person belongs to God.

In a "wave offering," the gift is waved back and forth in front of the altar. This is a sign: We give it to God – and God gives it back to us.

Part of the offerings is food for the priests. In this way, God takes care of those who serve him.

The "fat tail" belongs to a special kind of sheep in the Middle East. This sheep stores a lot of fat in its tail.

The clothes for those who come after VERSES 29–30

29 "Aaron's holy clothes shall belong to his sons after him.
They shall be anointed and consecrated in them.
30 The son who becomes priest in his place shall wear
them for seven days,
when he comes into the Tent of Meeting to serve in the
holy place.

The holy meal VERSES 31–34

31 "Take the ram of consecration and boil its meat in a
holy place.
32 Aaron and his sons shall eat the meat of the ram and the
bread in the basket,
at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
33 They shall eat the things by which atonement was made
for them,
to consecrate them and make them holy.
But a stranger shall not eat any of it,
because these things are holy.
34 If any of the meat of consecration or any of the bread is
left over until the morning,
then burn what is left with fire.
It shall not be eaten,
because it is holy.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> At the end of the consecration, there is a meal together. It is like a feast with God.
>
> "Atonement" means: What separates God and people is taken away. The relationship is whole again.
>
> "A stranger" here means: someone who does not belong to the family of priests.

Seven days of consecration VERSES 35–37

35 "Do this to Aaron and to his sons, exactly as I have
commanded you.
Consecrate them for seven days.
36 Every day, offer a bull as a sin offering for atonement.
Cleanse the altar when you make atonement for it.
Anoint it to make it holy.
37 For seven days, make atonement for the altar and make
it holy.
Then the altar will be most holy.
Whatever touches the altar will be holy.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> Seven days – like the seven days of creation. With the sanctuary, something completely new begins.
>
> Even the altar is cleansed and made holy. Everything that serves God shall be holy.

The daily offering VERSES 38–42

38 "This is what you shall offer on the altar:
two lambs a year old, every day, all the time.
39 Offer one lamb in the morning,
and offer the other lamb in the evening.
40 With the one lamb, offer about 2 quarts of fine flour
mixed with about 1 quart of oil from beaten olives,
and about 1 quart of wine as a drink offering.
41 Offer the other lamb in the evening.
Do the same with it as with the grain offering and the
drink offering of the morning.
It is a pleasant smell, an offering made by fire to the
LORD.
42 It shall be a burnt offering all the time, through all
your generations,
at the door of the Tent of Meeting before the LORD.
There I will meet with you, to speak to you there.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> In the Bible, the amounts are given like this: a tenth of an ephah of flour, a fourth of a hin of oil and a fourth of a hin of wine. A hin is about 1 gallon.
>
> An offering every morning and every evening. The whole day begins with God and ends with God. To this day, Jews pray at these times. Many Christians also have a morning prayer and an evening prayer.

God lives in the middle of his people VERSES 43–46

43 "There I will meet with the people of Israel.
And the place will be made holy by my glory.
44 I will make the Tent of Meeting and the altar holy.
I will also make Aaron and his sons holy, so that they
can serve me as priests.
45 I will live among the people of Israel.
And I will be their God.
46 Then they will know that I am the LORD their God,
who brought them out of the land of Egypt,
so that I might live among them.
I am the LORD their God.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> These verses are the goal of everything: "I will live among the people of Israel. And I will be their God."
>
> God did not only free Israel from Egypt so that it would be free. He freed it so that he could live with it. Freedom leads to friendship with God.
>
> In the New Testament it says about Jesus that the Word became flesh and lived among us (John 1:14). Flesh here means: a human being. In Greek, the word for "lived" really means: to live in a tent. And at the very end of the Bible it says that God's home is with people, and that he will live with them (Revelation 21:3). There, too, the Greek uses the word for tent.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 30

Altar of incense, offering, basin, anointing oil and incense

The altar of incense VERSES 1–10

1 "Make an altar to burn incense on.
Make it of acacia wood.
2 It shall be about 18 inches long and about 18 inches
wide.

So it shall be square.
And it shall be about 3 feet high.
Its horns shall be one piece with it.
3 Cover it with pure gold:
its top, its sides all around and its horns.
And make a gold molding all around it.
4 Make two gold rings for it under its molding.
Make them on its two sides, across from each other.
They shall hold the poles for carrying it.
5 Make the poles of acacia wood and cover them with gold.
6 "Put the altar in front of the veil that is by the ark of the covenant,
in front of the mercy seat that is over the covenant.
There I will meet with you.
7 Aaron shall burn sweet-smelling incense on it every morning.
When he takes care of the lamps, he shall burn it.
8 And when Aaron lights the lamps in the evening, he shall burn it too.
So there shall always be incense before the LORD,
through all your generations.
9 Do not offer any strange incense on it,
no burnt offering and no grain offering.
And do not pour any drink offering on it.
10 Once a year, Aaron shall make atonement on its horns.
With the blood of the sin offering of atonement, he shall make atonement for it once a year, through all your generations.
It is most holy to the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: one cubit long and wide, two cubits high. A cubit is about 18 inches.

The altar of incense is small. It stands in the Holy Place, right in front of the veil to the Most Holy Place.

Incense is a mixture of resins and spices. When you sprinkle it on glowing coals, sweet-smelling smoke rises up.

In the Bible, rising smoke is a picture for prayer. In Psalm 141:2, someone asks God to let his prayer come before God like incense. In the morning and in the evening the sweet smell rises – just like the prayers of the people rise to God.

"Strange incense" is incense that God did not command. A story in Leviticus 10 shows how serious that is.

"Once a year" means the great Day of Atonement, Yom Kippur (Leviticus 16).

The offering at the census VERSES 11–16

11 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
12 "When you take a census of the people of Israel and count them,
each man shall give the LORD a ransom for his life.
Then no plague will come on them when you count them.
13 Everyone who passes over to those who are counted shall give this:
half a shekel (about 0.2 ounces), by the weight of the shekel of the sanctuary.
A shekel is 20 gerahs.
Half a shekel shall be an offering to the LORD.
14 Everyone who passes over to those who are counted, who is 20 years old or older, shall give the offering to the LORD.
15 The rich shall not give more, and the poor shall not give less, than the half shekel,
when you give the LORD's offering to make atonement for your lives.
16 Take the atonement money from the people of Israel.
Use it for the service of the Tent of Meeting.
It shall be a reminder of the people of Israel before the LORD,
to make atonement for your lives."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: A census means: counting the people. A ransom is a price paid to set a life free.

Half a shekel is about one fifth of an ounce of silver. A "gerah" is an even smaller weight, about one fiftieth of an ounce.

The men who were counted were 20 years old or older. They were the men who could go to war. Whoever was counted "passed over" to those who had already been counted.

Back then, people believed: Counting a people is dangerous. Life belongs to God, not to the king or the leader. That is why everyone shall give a small gift – as a sign: My life belongs to God. Later, the Bible tells how King David counts the people, and a plague comes because of it (2 Samuel 24).

Important: The rich and the poor pay exactly the same. Before God, every life is worth the same.

Later, part of the sanctuary was built with this money (Exodus 38:25–28). In the time of Jesus, Jews paid a temple tax like this every year (Matthew 17:24).

The basin VERSES 17–21

17 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
18 "Also make a basin of bronze with a base of bronze, for washing.
Put it between the Tent of Meeting and the altar.
And put water in it.
19 Aaron and his sons shall wash their hands and their feet in it.
20 When they go into the Tent of Meeting, they shall wash with water, so that they do not die.
They shall also wash when they come near the altar to serve, to burn an offering made by fire to the LORD.
21 So they shall wash their hands and their feet, so that they do not die.
This shall be a law forever for them,
for Aaron and for his descendants, through all their generations."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before the priests serve God, they wash. With their hands they do their work. With their feet they walk their way. Both shall be clean.

Washing is a sign: Whoever comes to God should not just come any way at all, but prepared and cleansed.

In the New Testament, Jesus washes his disciples' feet (John 13). And in baptism, washing with water becomes a sign of a new beginning with God.

The holy anointing oil VERSES 22–33

22 The LORD also spoke to Moses.
He said,
23 "Also take the finest spices:
liquid myrrh, 500 shekels (about 12 pounds);
sweet-smelling cinnamon, half as much, 250 shekels (about 6 pounds);
and sweet-smelling cane, 250 shekels (about 6 pounds);
24 and cassia, 500 shekels (about 12 pounds), by the weight of the shekel of the sanctuary.
Also take about 1 gallon of olive oil.
25 Make it into a holy anointing oil,
a perfume mixed with the skill of a perfume maker.
It shall be a holy anointing oil.
26 "Use it to anoint
the Tent of Meeting, the ark of the covenant,
27 the table and all its things, the lamp stand and its tools, the altar of incense,
28 the altar of burnt offering with all its tools, and the basin with its base.
29 Make them holy, so that they are most holy.
Whatever touches them will be holy.
30 Anoint Aaron and his sons too, and make them holy, so that they can serve me as priests.
31 "Speak to the people of Israel.
Say, 'This shall be a holy anointing oil for me, through all your generations.
32 It shall not be poured on the body of an ordinary person.
And do not make any oil like it with the same mixture.
It is holy. It shall be holy to you.
33 Whoever mixes any oil like it,
or whoever puts any of it on a stranger,
shall be cut off from his people.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible, the weights are given like this: 500 shekels of myrrh, 250 shekels of cinnamon, 250 shekels of cane, 500 shekels of cassia, and a hin of oil. A shekel is about 0.4 ounces. A hin is about 1 gallon.

Myrrh is a precious, sweet-smelling resin from a bush. Cassia is a kind of cinnamon. The cane is a sweet-smelling plant, maybe sweet flag.

This oil has a very special smell. No one may copy it for himself. It belongs only to God. So the people learn: There are things that are set apart completely for God.

"A stranger" here means: someone who is not a priest.

"Cut off from his people" – this is word for word what the Hebrew says. It is not completely clear what this meant. Maybe the person was thrown out of the community. Maybe it means that God himself punishes the person.

The holy incense VERSES 34–38

34 The LORD said to Moses,
"Take sweet spices: gum resin, onycha and galbanum.
Take these sweet spices with pure frankincense.
There shall be the same weight of each.
35 Make incense out of it, a perfume mixed with the skill of a perfume maker.
It shall be seasoned with salt, pure and holy.
36 Beat some of it into very fine powder.
Put some of it in front of the covenant in the Tent of Meeting, where I will meet with you.
It shall be most holy to you.
37 Do not make any incense with the same mixture for yourselves.
It shall be holy to you, for the LORD.
38 Whoever makes any like it, to enjoy its smell,
shall be cut off from his people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The incense is made of four ingredients. Frankincense is a sweet-smelling resin from a tree that grows in Arabia and Africa. Galbanum is a resin from a plant. "Onycha" is probably the shell lid of a sea snail, which smells sweet when it burns.

Here too: This smell is only for God. No one shall copy it at home for himself.

To this day, incense is burned in many churches. It is a reminder of this service in the sanctuary and of prayer that rises up to God.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 31

The craftsmen, the Sabbath and the two stone tablets

Bezalel and Oholiab VERSES 1–11

1 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
2 "Look, I have called Bezalel by name.
He is the son of Uri, the son of Hur, from the tribe of Judah.
3 I have filled him with the Spirit of God,
with wisdom, with understanding and with knowledge,
and with skill for every kind of work.
4 So he can plan works of art
and work with gold, with silver and with bronze.
5 He can cut stones and set them,
carve wood and do every kind of work.
6 And look, I myself have chosen Oholiab to work with him.
He is the son of Ahisamach, from the tribe of Dan.
And I have put wisdom into the hearts of all who have a wise heart.
So they can make everything that I have commanded you:
7 the Tent of Meeting, the ark of the covenant,
the mercy seat on it and all the furniture of the Tent,
8 the table and its things, the pure lamp stand with all its things, the altar of incense,
9 the altar of burnt offering with all its tools, the basin and its base,

10 the finely made clothes –
the holy clothes for Aaron the priest,
and the clothes of his sons for their service as priests –
11 the anointing oil and the sweet-smelling incense for the holy place.
They shall do everything exactly as I have commanded you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bezalel is the first person in the Bible of whom it says that he is filled with the Spirit of God. And for what? For art and craft!

This shows: Gifts for designing, building and decorating come from God. Not only priests and prophets serve God, but also craftsmen and artists.

Bezalel comes from Judah, a large and important tribe. Oholiab comes from Dan, a small tribe. The two of them work together.

Hur is probably the man who held up Moses' arms together with Aaron (Exodus 17:12).

The Sabbath as a sign VERSES 12–17

12 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
13 "Also speak to the people of Israel.
Say, 'You shall surely keep my Sabbaths.
For the Sabbath is a sign between me and you, through all your generations.
By it you shall know that I am the LORD who makes you holy.
14 So keep the Sabbath, because it is holy to you.
Everyone who treats it as unholy shall surely be put to death.
For whoever does any work on it shall be cut off from among his people.
15 Work shall be done for six days.
But the seventh day is a Sabbath, a day of complete rest, holy to the LORD.
Whoever does any work on the Sabbath day shall surely be put to death.
16 So the people of Israel shall keep the Sabbath.
They shall celebrate the Sabbath through all their generations, as a covenant forever.
17 It is a sign between me and the people of Israel forever.
For in six days the LORD made heaven and earth.
And on the seventh day he rested and was refreshed.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the instructions for the sanctuary comes the commandment about the Sabbath. That is no accident. It means: Even the holy work on the sanctuary must rest on the Sabbath. Resting with God is more important than any work, even more important than work for God.

The Sabbath is a "sign," like a wedding ring between God and his people. It shows: We belong together.

"Was refreshed" – in Hebrew, this word means: "caught his breath." That is a strong picture. God himself rests after his work. If even God rests, then people need rest all the more.

The death penalty for working on the Sabbath shocks us today. It shows how seriously the Sabbath was taken back then: It was the heart of the covenant. In later Judaism, the teachers set up very high hurdles, so that such punishments were hardly ever carried out. Jesus later said that the Sabbath was made for people, not people for the Sabbath (Mark 2:27).

To this day, Jews celebrate the Sabbath from Friday evening to Saturday evening. Most Christians celebrate Sunday as a day of rest, because Jesus rose from the dead on a Sunday.

The two stone tablets VERSE 18

18 God finished speaking with Moses on Mount Sinai.
Then he gave Moses the two tablets of the covenant.
They were tablets of stone, written with God's finger.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the many instructions end that God gave Moses on the mountain (since Chapter 25).

"Written with God's finger" means: These words come straight from God. Moses did not make them up.

But while Moses was up on the mountain, something terrible happened down in the camp. The next chapter tells about it.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 32

The golden calf

The people make a golden calf VERSES 1–6

1 The people saw that Moses was taking a long time to come down from the mountain.
So the people gathered around Aaron and said to him,
"Come, make us gods that will go in front of us!
For this Moses, the man who brought us up out of the land of Egypt –
we do not know what has happened to him."
2 Aaron said to them,
"Take off the gold rings that are in the ears of your wives, your sons and your daughters.
And bring them to me."
3 So all the people took off the gold rings that were in their ears and brought them to Aaron.
4 Aaron took what they handed him.
He shaped it with an engraving tool and made it into a calf of melted metal.
Then they said, "Israel, these are your gods, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt!"
5 When Aaron saw this, he built an altar in front of the calf.
And Aaron announced, "Tomorrow there shall be a feast to the LORD!"
6 The next day, they got up early.
They offered burnt offerings and brought peace offerings.
Then the people sat down to eat and to drink.
And after that they got up to play.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses has already been on the mountain for 40 days (Exodus 24:18). The people become impatient. They want something they can see and touch.

In Egypt and in Canaan, a calf or young bull was a sign of strength and of new life. Many peoples worshiped gods in the form of a bull.

Very shocking: They say that this calf freed them from Egypt. And Aaron calls the feast a "feast to the LORD." They do not want to leave God completely. But they make an image of him – exactly what God has just forbidden (Exodus 20:4).

Only a few weeks after they heard God's voice and promised to do everything he said (Exodus 24:3), they break the covenant.

"To play" – the Hebrew word can also mean wild partying and dancing.

God is angry – Moses prays for the people VERSES 7–14

7 The LORD said to Moses,
"Go, get down!
For your people, whom you brought up out of the land of Egypt, have done evil.
8 They have quickly turned away from the way that I commanded them.
They have made themselves a calf of melted metal.
They have bowed down to it and have offered sacrifices to it.
And they have said, 'Israel, these are your gods, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt.'"
9 The LORD also said to Moses,
"I have seen these people.
Look, they are a stiff-necked people.
10 So now leave me alone!
Let my anger burn hot against them, so that I can destroy them.
But I will make you into a great nation."
11 But Moses begged the LORD his God. He said,
"LORD, why does your anger burn hot against your people?
You brought them out of the land of Egypt with great power and with a mighty hand.
12 Why should the Egyptians say,
'He brought them out to do them harm.
He wanted to kill them in the mountains and wipe them off the face of the earth'?
Turn away from your burning anger.
Do not bring this harm on your people.
13 Remember Abraham, Isaac and Israel, your servants.
You swore to them by your own self and said to them,
'I will make your descendants as many as the stars of the sky.
And I will give all this land that I have spoken of to your descendants.
They shall own it forever.'"
14 So the LORD turned away from the harm that he had said he would do to his people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God says to Moses "your people," not "my people." It sounds as if God wants to separate himself from Israel.

"A stiff-necked people" is a picture from farming: a cow or ox that makes its neck stiff and will not be led. It means: stubborn and willful.

God offers Moses a new beginning with him – like back then with Abraham. But Moses says no. He stands up for the people.

Moses gives three reasons: They are your people. What will the Egyptians think of you? And remember your promises to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.

"So the LORD turned away from the harm" – this is an amazing passage. A person's prayer matters to God. It changes something. Here the Bible shows: God does not want to destroy. He waits for someone to stand up for the guilty.

Moses breaks the tablets VERSES 15–20

15 Moses turned and went down from the mountain.
He had the two tablets of the covenant in his hand.
The tablets were written on both sides, on the front and on the back.
16 The tablets were the work of God.
And the writing was God's writing, engraved on the tablets.
17 Joshua heard the noise of the people as they shouted.
He said to Moses, "There is the noise of war in the camp!"
18 Moses answered,
"It is not the sound of people shouting because they have won.
And it is not the sound of people crying because they have lost.
I hear the noise of people singing."
19 As soon as Moses came near the camp, he saw the calf and the dancing.
Then Moses became very angry.
He threw the tablets out of his hands and broke them at the foot of the mountain.
20 He took the calf that they had made and burned it with fire.
He ground it into powder, scattered it on the water, and made the people of Israel drink it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The tablets were God's own handwriting. Moses breaks them. This is a sign: The covenant is broken. The people have broken it already, even before the tablets arrive.

The calf is burned, ground up and scattered on the water. The people have to drink it. So they learn: This "god" is nothing. It can be destroyed and swallowed. And they themselves have to "swallow" what their deed brings.

Aaron's excuse VERSES 21–24

21 Moses said to Aaron,
"What did these people do to you, that you have brought such a great sin on them?"
22 Aaron answered,
"Do not let my lord become angry.
You know the people. They are set on doing evil.
23 They said to me,
'Make us gods that will go in front of us.
For this Moses, the man who brought us up out of the land of Egypt –
we do not know what has happened to him.'
24 So I said to them,
'Whoever has any gold, take it off.'

So they gave it to me.
I threw it into the fire, and out came this calf."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Aaron's excuse is almost silly: "I threw it into the fire, and out came this calf." As if it had made itself. But he shaped it himself (verse 4).

People often talk like this when they have made mistakes: The others are to blame, and it just happened. Here the Bible shows honestly: Aaron, the high priest, failed too.

The Levites and the punishment VERSES 25–29

25 Moses saw that the people were out of control.
For Aaron had let them lose control, so that their enemies could laugh at them.
26 Then Moses stood in the gate of the camp and called out,
"Whoever is on the LORD's side, come to me!"
And all the sons of Levi gathered around him.
27 He said to them,
"The LORD, the God of Israel, says,
'Every man is to put his sword at his side.
Go back and forth from gate to gate through the camp.
Every man is to kill his brother, his friend and his neighbor.'"
28 The sons of Levi did what Moses said.
That day about 3,000 men of the people died.
29 Moses said,
"Set yourselves apart for the LORD today.
For every man was against his son and against his brother.
So he will give you a blessing today."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the hardest passages in the Bible. 3,000 men are killed, by their own relatives.

We have to understand it from its own time. The covenant with God had only just been made. Worshiping idols put the life of the whole people in danger. The Bible sees it as betrayal, as bad as treason in a war. The punishment probably fell on those who did not want to stop.

Still, this story remains shocking. Jews and Christians have thought about it for a long time. It is not an instruction to use violence in God's name today. Jesus rejected violence in God's name (Matthew 26:52).

The tribe of Levi takes God's side completely. That is why the Levites later become the servants at the sanctuary (Numbers 3).

Moses wants to stand up for the people VERSES 30–35

30 The next day, Moses said to the people,
"You have committed a great sin.
Now I will go up to the LORD.
Maybe I can make atonement for your sin."
31 Moses went back to the LORD and said,
"Oh, these people have committed a great sin.
They have made themselves gods of gold.
32 But now, please, forgive their sin!
And if not, then please erase me from your book that you have written."
33 The LORD said to Moses,
"Whoever has sinned against me, I will erase him from my book.
34 Now go!
Lead the people to the place that I have told you about.
Look, my angel will go in front of you.
But on the day when I punish, I will punish them for their sin."
35 And the LORD struck the people,
because of what they did with the calf that Aaron made.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses is ready to give his own life for the people. "Erase me from your book" means: I would rather be lost myself than let my people be lost.

The "book" is a picture for the book of life. The names of the people who belong to God are written in it.

God does not accept the offer. Each person is responsible for his own guilt.

Christians see a pointer to Jesus here: He did what Moses offered. He gave his life for the guilt of others. Paul also said something similar to Moses about his own people (Romans 9:3).

It does not say how God "struck" the people. Maybe it was a disease.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 33

Will God still go with them? Moses wants to see God's glory

"I will not go up among you" VERSES 1–6

1 The LORD said to Moses,
"Leave. Go up from here,
you and the people that you brought up out of the land of Egypt.
Go to the land that I promised to Abraham, to Isaac and to Jacob with an oath.
I said, 'I will give it to your descendants.'
2 I will send an angel in front of you.
And I will drive out the Canaanite, the Amorite, the Hittite, the Perizzite, the Hivite and the Jebusite.
3 Go to a land flowing with milk and honey.
But I will not go up among you myself,
because you are a stiff-necked people.
Otherwise I might destroy you on the way."
4 When the people heard this bad news, they mourned.
And no one put on his jewelry.
5 For the LORD had said to Moses,
"Tell the people of Israel,
'You are a stiff-necked people.
If I went up among you for just one moment, I would destroy you.
So now take off your jewelry.
Then I will know what to do with you.'"

6 So the people of Israel took off their jewelry, from
Mount Horeb on.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God keeps his promise: The people will get the land. But God himself does not want to go with them. Only an angel shall lead them.

At first, that does not sound so bad. But the people understand: The land without God is worth nothing. That is why they mourn.

God says: Being close to me would be dangerous for you. A holy God and a people that turns against him – that does not fit together.

Taking off jewelry is a sign of sadness and of being sorry. After all, they had made the golden calf out of jewelry.

Horeb is another name for Mount Sinai.

The Tent of Meeting outside the camp VERSES 7–11

7 Moses used to take the tent and set it up outside the
camp, far away from the camp.
He called it "the Tent of Meeting."
Everyone who wanted to seek the LORD went out to
the Tent of Meeting, which was outside the camp.
8 Whenever Moses went out to the Tent, all the people
got up.
Each person stood at the door of his tent.
And they watched Moses until he had gone into the
Tent.
9 When Moses went into the Tent, the pillar of cloud
came down and stood at the door of the Tent.
And the LORD spoke with Moses.
10 All the people saw the pillar of cloud standing at the
door of the Tent.
Then all the people got up and worshiped, each person
at the door of his tent.
11 The LORD spoke to Moses face to face,
as a man speaks to his friend.
Then Moses went back into the camp.
But his servant Joshua, the son of Nun, a young man,
did not leave the Tent.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is not yet the large sanctuary that Chapters 25–31 describe. That one is built later. Here it is a simpler tent, where Moses meets God.

The tent now stands outside the camp. This shows: God has moved away. Whoever seeks him must go out.

"As a man speaks to his friend" – that is how close Moses is to God. "Face to face" here means: very directly and as close friends. Verse 20 says that Moses cannot really see God's face.

Joshua stays in the tent. Already now he is learning to be close to God. Later he will take Moses' place as leader.

Moses asks: Go with us! VERSES 12–17

12 Moses said to the LORD,
"Look, you tell me, 'Bring up these people.'
But you have not let me know whom you will send
with me.
Yet you have said, 'I know you by name,
and you have found favor in my eyes.'
13 So if I have found favor in your eyes,
then please show me your way now.
Then I can know you and find favor in your eyes.
And remember: These people are your people."
14 He answered, "My presence will go with you.
And I will give you rest."
15 Moses said to him,
"If your presence does not go with me, then do not
take us up from here.
16 For how else will people know that I and your people
have found favor in your eyes?
Is it not because you go with us?
That is what makes me and your people different from
all the peoples on the face of the earth."
17 The LORD said to Moses,
"I will also do this thing that you have asked.
For you have found favor in my eyes, and I know you
by name."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses does not give up. He reminds God: "These people are your people." In Chapter 32 God had said "your people," meaning: the people of Moses. Moses gives them back to God.

"My presence will go with you" means: I myself will go with you, not just an angel. Word for word, the Hebrew says: "My face will go with you."

Moses says: Without you, we do not even want to start out. What makes Israel special is not the land or power. What makes Israel special is that God goes with it.

And God lets himself be asked. Again the Bible shows: Moses' prayer changes something.

Moses wants to see God's glory VERSES 18–23

18 Moses said, "Please show me your glory!"
19 He answered,
"I will make all my goodness pass in front of you.
And I will call out the name of the LORD before you.
I will be kind to whom I will be kind.
And I will show mercy to whom I will show mercy."
20 He also said,
"You cannot see my face.
For no one can see me and live."
21 The LORD also said,
"Look, there is a place near me. Stand on the rock.
22 While my glory passes by, I will put you in a crack in the
rock.
And I will cover you with my hand until I have passed
by.
23 Then I will take my hand away.
And you will see my back.
But my face shall not be seen."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses wishes for the greatest thing a person can wish for: to see God himself.

God answers with his "goodness." This shows: God's glory is, above all, his goodness.

"I will be kind to whom I will be kind" means: God's kindness is a gift. No one can earn it or force it. God gives it freely.

No one can see God's face. God is too great and too holy for our eyes. But God protects Moses with his hand and shows him as much as he can bear.

"You will see my back" – maybe this means: Often we only recognize God afterward, by the traces he has left behind.

The New Testament says that no one has ever seen God, but that the only Son, who is very close to the Father, has made him known (John 1:18). Christians believe: In Jesus, you can see what God is like.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 34

New tablets – God says who he is – Moses' shining face

Two new tablets VERSES 1–4

1 The LORD said to Moses,
"Cut two stone tablets like the first ones.
I will write on the tablets the words that were on the first tablets, which you broke.
2 Be ready by the morning.
In the morning, come up Mount Sinai
and stand before me there on the top of the mountain.
3 No one shall come up with you.
No one shall be seen anywhere on the mountain.
And do not let the flocks or the herds graze in front of that mountain."
4 So Moses cut two tablets of stone like the first ones.
Moses got up early in the morning and went up Mount Sinai, as the LORD had commanded him.
And he took the two stone tablets in his hand.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God gives the people a second chance. The covenant is made new.

This time, Moses has to cut the stone tablets himself. But God writes the words again.

God says who he is VERSES 5–9

5 The LORD came down in the cloud.
He stood with him there and called out the name of the LORD.
6 The LORD passed by in front of him and called out,
"The LORD! The LORD!
A God who is full of mercy and kindness,
slow to become angry, and rich in loving kindness and faithfulness.
7 He keeps loving kindness for thousands.
He forgives wrongdoing, disobedience and sin.
But he will not simply let the guilty go free.
He brings the wrongdoing of the fathers on the children and on the grandchildren,
on the third and on the fourth generation."
8 Moses quickly bowed his head to the ground and worshiped.
9 He said,
"Lord, if I have now found favor in your eyes,
then please, Lord, go among us.
Yes, these are a stiff-necked people.
But forgive our wrongdoing and our sin.
And take us as your own."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important passages in the whole Old Testament. God himself says who he is. These words are repeated many times in the Bible (for example, Psalm 103:8; Jonah 4:2).

The first thing God says about himself is: full of mercy, kind, patient, full of love and faithfulness. And this comes right after the golden calf!

"Loving kindness for thousands" and punishment up to the "third and fourth generation" – the love is much, much greater than the punishment.

The punishment up to the third and fourth generation means: The results of guilt go on in families. Children often suffer because of what their parents did wrong. Back then, three or four generations often lived together in one house. Later the Bible says clearly: Each person is responsible only for his own guilt (Ezekiel 18:20).

"Loving kindness" stands for the Hebrew word "chesed." It means a faithful love that keeps its promise.

Now Moses no longer says "these people," but "us." He takes the side of the people completely.

God makes the covenant new VERSES 10–17

10 He said,
"Look, I am making a covenant.
In front of all your people I will do wonders,
such as have never been done in all the earth or in any nation.
All the people among whom you live shall see the work of the LORD.
For what I will do with you is an awesome thing.
11 "Keep what I command you today.
Look, I will drive out the Amorite, the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Perizzite, the Hivite and the Jebusite in front of you.
12 Be careful not to make a covenant with the people who live in the land where you are going.
Otherwise it will become a trap among you.
13 Instead, you shall break down their altars,
smash their sacred pillars
and cut down their Asherah poles.
14 For you shall worship no other god.
For the LORD, whose name is 'Jealous,' is a jealous God.
15 "Do not make a covenant with the people who live in the land.
Otherwise they will give themselves to their gods like prostitutes and offer sacrifices to their gods.
And someone will invite you, and you will eat from his sacrifice.
16 And you will take their daughters as wives for your sons.
Then their daughters will give themselves to their gods like prostitutes,

and they will make your sons give themselves to their gods like prostitutes too.
17 "Do not make any idols of melted metal for yourselves.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Asherah poles" were wooden poles that were set up for the goddess Asherah. Asherah was a goddess of fertility in Canaan.

Israel shall not get involved with the gods of the other peoples. God compares this to unfaithfulness in a marriage. That is why the hard picture of prostitution is used here. God and his people are like husband and wife. Whoever serves other gods breaks faith.

"Jealous" is even a name of God. God loves his people with all his passion and does not want to share them with anyone.

This is not about hating people from other nations. It is about faith: Israel shall stay faithful to the one God only. Later, for example, Ruth, a woman from Moab, marries into Israel, because she turns to Israel's God (Ruth 1:16).

"Idols of melted metal" – verse 17 is a direct reminder of the golden calf.

The feasts and the gifts VERSES 18–26

18 "Keep the Festival of Unleavened Bread.
For seven days you shall eat bread without yeast, as I commanded you,
at the set time in the month of Abib.
For in the month of Abib you came out of Egypt.
19 "Everything that is born first from its mother is mine.
That includes all the male firstborn of your livestock, of cattle and of sheep.
20 Buy back the firstborn of a donkey with a lamb.
If you will not buy it back, then break its neck.
Buy back all the firstborn of your sons.
No one shall come before me with empty hands.
21 "You shall work for six days, but on the seventh day you shall rest.
Even in the time of plowing and in the time of harvest you shall rest.
22 "Keep the Festival of Weeks, with the first fruits of the wheat harvest.
And keep the Festival of Harvest at the end of the year.
23 Three times a year all your men shall come before the Lord GOD, the God of Israel.
24 For I will drive out nations in front of you and make your land larger.
No one will want to take your land
when you go up three times a year to come before the LORD your God.
25 "Do not offer the blood of my sacrifice together with bread made with yeast.
And do not leave any of the sacrifice of the Passover feast until the morning.
26 "Bring the very first of the first fruits of your fields to the house of the LORD your God.
"Do not boil a young goat in its mother's milk."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

We already know these commandments from Chapters 13 and 23. They are repeated here, because the covenant is being made new.

"Buy back" means: You give something else in its place, for example a lamb for the donkey. A donkey could not be sacrificed. And people were never sacrificed. For every firstborn son, a gift was given instead.

The Sabbath rest also counts in the time of harvest, when there is the most work. Especially then, people should trust God.

"No one will want to take your land" – God promises: When all the men go to the feast, God watches over their land. No one will attack it.

You can read more about the feasts and the young goat in the explanations for Exodus 23.

40 days on the mountain VERSES 27–28

27 The LORD said to Moses,
"Write down these words.
For on the basis of these words I have made a covenant with you and with Israel."
28 Moses was there with the LORD for 40 days and 40 nights.
He did not eat any bread or drink any water.
And he wrote on the tablets the words of the covenant, the Ten Commandments.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For the second time, Moses is on the mountain for 40 days. He fasts completely, without food and drink. That is more than a person can normally stand. God himself keeps him alive.

Here it is not completely clear who writes on the tablets. In verse 1, God had said that he himself would write. Deuteronomy 10:4 also says: God wrote.

Later, Jesus also fasted for 40 days in the desert (Matthew 4:2).

Moses' face shines VERSES 29–35

29 Moses came down from Mount Sinai.
He had the two tablets of the covenant in his hand.
When he came down from the mountain, Moses did not know that the skin of his face was shining,
because he had been speaking with God.
30 Aaron and all the people of Israel saw Moses.
And look, the skin of his face was shining.
So they were afraid to come near him.
31 Moses called to them.
Then Aaron and all the leaders of the community came back to him,
and Moses spoke to them.
32 After that, all the people of Israel came near.
And he gave them all the commandments that the LORD had spoken with him on Mount Sinai.
33 When Moses had finished speaking with them, he put a veil over his face.
34 But whenever Moses went in before the LORD to speak with him, he took the veil off until he came out.
Then he came out and told the people of Israel what he had been commanded.
35 The people of Israel saw Moses' face, that the skin of Moses' face was shining.
Then Moses put the veil over his face again, until he went in to speak with God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses was so close to God that some of God's light stayed on him. He himself does not even notice it.

The Hebrew word for "shine" is related to the word for "horn." So an old Latin translation wrote that Moses had "horns." That is why some old pictures and statues show Moses with horns, for example the famous statue by Michelangelo in Rome. But what is meant is rays of light.

Moses does not wear the veil when he speaks with God or passes on God's words. He wears it afterward, in everyday life.

In the New Testament, Paul writes about this story (2 Corinthians 3:7–18). He says: Whoever turns to God has the veil taken away. And people who look at God are changed more and more themselves.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 35

The people bring their gifts

First the Sabbath VERSES 1–3

1 Moses gathered the whole community of the people of
Israel and said to them,
"These are the words that the LORD has commanded
you to do:
2 'Work shall be done for six days.
But the seventh day shall be a holy day for you,
a Sabbath, a day of complete rest to the LORD.
Whoever does any work on it shall be put to death.
3 Do not light a fire in any of your homes on the Sabbath
day.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the building of the sanctuary begins. Chapters 35 to 40 tell how everything is made exactly the way God commanded in Chapters 25 to 31. That is why many verses sound almost the same as there. The repetition shows: Now the people really do what God said.

At the very beginning, there is the Sabbath again. Even the work for the sanctuary shall rest on the Sabbath.

Do not light a fire – back then, making a fire was hard work. To this day, many Jews do not light a fire on the Sabbath. That is why, for example, there are lights that are lit before the Sabbath begins.

You can read more about the death penalty for work on the Sabbath in the explanation for Exodus 31.

Whoever is glad to give shall give VERSES 4–9

4 Moses said to the whole community of the people of
Israel,
"This is what the LORD has commanded:
5 'Collect an offering for the LORD from among you.
Whoever has a willing heart shall bring it as the
LORD's offering:
gold, silver and bronze,
6 blue, purple and scarlet cloth, fine linen, goats' hair,
7 rams' skins dyed red, sea cow hides, acacia wood,
8 oil for the light,
spices for the anointing oil and for the sweet incense,
9 onyx stones, and stones to be set for the ephod and for
the breastplate.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

No one is forced. Only those who have a "willing heart" shall give. God does not want gifts that are forced.

This list is the same as in Exodus 25:3–7.

Whoever has skill shall build VERSES 10–19

10 "'Let every man among you who has a wise heart come
and make everything that the LORD has commanded:
11 the tabernacle, its outer covering, its roof,
its clasps, its boards, its bars, its pillars and its sockets,
12 the ark and its poles, the mercy seat, and the veil that
hides it,
13 the table with its poles and all its things, and the bread
of the presence,
14 the lamp stand for the light with its things, its lamps
and the oil for the light,
15 the altar of incense with its poles, the anointing oil, the
sweet incense,
and the screen for the door, at the door of the
tabernacle,
16 the altar of burnt offering with its grating of bronze,
its poles and all its tools,
the basin and its base,
17 the hangings of the courtyard, its pillars and their
sockets,
and the screen for the gate of the courtyard,
18 the tent pegs of the tabernacle, the tent pegs of the
courtyard and their ropes,
19 the finely made clothes for serving in the holy place –
the holy clothes for Aaron the priest and the clothes of
his sons –
for their service as priests.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here everything that must be built is listed. It is a lot of work. One person alone cannot do it. Everyone who is able to do something shall help.

A "wise heart" here means: skill and ability in craft and art.

The people give more than enough VERSES 20–29

20 Then the whole community of the people of Israel left
Moses.
21 And they came back:
everyone whose heart moved him,
and everyone whose spirit made him willing.
They brought the LORD's offering
for the work on the Tent of Meeting, for all its service
and for the holy clothes.
22 They came, men and women, all who had a willing
heart.
They brought brooches, earrings, signet rings and
armbands, all kinds of gold jewelry.

Everyone who gave the LORD an offering of gold
brought it.
23 Everyone who had blue, purple or scarlet cloth,
fine linen, goats' hair, rams' skins dyed red or sea cow
hides brought them.
24 Everyone who wanted to give an offering of silver or
bronze brought it as the LORD's offering.
And everyone who had acacia wood for any of the work
brought it.
25 All the women who had a wise heart spun thread with
their hands.
They brought what they had spun:
the blue, the purple and the scarlet thread and the fine
linen.
26 And all the women whose heart moved them and who
had skill spun the goats' hair.
27 The leaders brought the onyx stones and the stones to
be set for the ephod and for the breastplate,
28 and the spices and the oil for the light, for the
anointing oil and for the sweet incense.
29 So the people of Israel brought a freewill offering to the
LORD.
Every man and woman whose heart made them
willing
brought something for all the work that the LORD
had commanded through Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What a difference from Chapter 32! There the people gave their gold for a golden calf. Now they give their gold for God's sanctuary.

Everyone takes part: men and women, leaders and ordinary people. Each person gives what he has and what he can do.

The women are named in a special way. They spin the threads for the cloth. Without their work there would be no curtains and no priests' clothes.

Where did the people get so much gold and jewelry in the desert? When they left, the Egyptians had given them jewelry (Exodus 12:35–36).

Bezalel and Oholiab VERSES 30–35

30 Moses said to the people of Israel,
"Look, the LORD has called Bezalel by name,
the son of Uri, the son of Hur, from the tribe of Judah.
31 He has filled him with the Spirit of God,
with wisdom, with understanding and with
knowledge,
and with skill for every kind of work,
32 so that he can plan works of art
and work with gold, with silver and with bronze,
33 cut stones and set them, carve wood,
and do every kind of skillful work.
34 And he has put it into his heart to teach others,
both him and Oholiab, the son of Ahisamach, from the
tribe of Dan.
35 He has filled them with wisdom of heart to do every
kind of work:
the work of the engraver, of the skillful worker, and of
the embroiderer
in blue, purple and scarlet thread and in fine linen,
and the work of the weaver.
They can do every kind of work and plan works of art."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What is new here: Bezalel and Oholiab can not only do good work themselves. God has also given them the gift of teaching others. So many people can work along with them.

Good teachers are a gift. Knowledge and skill should be passed on.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 36

The building begins: curtains, boards and veils

The people must be stopped VERSES 1–7

1 "Bezalel and Oholiab shall work
together with every man who has a wise heart,
in whom the LORD has put wisdom and
understanding.
So they know how to do all the work for the service of
the sanctuary,
exactly as the LORD has commanded."
2 Moses called Bezalel and Oholiab
and every man with a wise heart, in whose heart the
LORD had put wisdom,
everyone whose heart moved him to come to the work
and do it.
3 They received from Moses the whole offering
that the people of Israel had brought for the work of
the sanctuary, so that they could build it.
But the people kept bringing freewill offerings to him
every morning.
4 So all the skilled men who did all the work of the
sanctuary came.
Each one came from the work that he was doing.
5 They said to Moses,
"The people are bringing much more than enough for
the work that the LORD commanded us to do."
6 So Moses gave a command.
They had it announced through the whole camp:
"No man and no woman shall make anything more for
the offering for the sanctuary!"
So the people were stopped from bringing more.
7 For the materials they had were enough for all the
work.
They were even too much.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a wonderful passage: The people are so glad to give that they have to be stopped. It is probably one of the few collections in history that had to end because the gifts were too large.

When people give from the heart, there is more than enough.

The inner curtains of linen VERSES 8–13

8 All the men with a wise heart among the workers made
the tabernacle with 10 curtains.
They were made of fine twisted linen and of blue,
purple and scarlet cloth.
Cherubim were woven into them, the work of a
skillful worker.
9 Each curtain was about 42 feet long and about 6 feet
wide.
All the curtains were the same size.
10 He joined five curtains to each other,
and he joined the other five curtains to each other too.
11 He made loops of blue cloth on the edge of the last
curtain of the first set.
He did the same on the edge of the last curtain of the
second set.
12 He made 50 loops on the one curtain,
and 50 loops on the edge of the curtain of the second
set.
The loops were exactly opposite each other.
13 He made 50 clasps of gold.
He joined the curtains to each other with the clasps.
So the tabernacle became one whole.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: 28 cubits long, 4 cubits wide. A cubit is about 18 inches.

"He" here is probably Bezalel, the leader of the work. But it also means all those who worked with him.

From here on, everything is done exactly as it was commanded in Chapter 26.

The curtains of goats' hair and the skins VERSES 14–19

14 He made curtains of goats' hair as a covering over the
tabernacle.
He made 11 of these curtains.
15 Each curtain was about 45 feet long and about 6 feet
wide.
The 11 curtains were all the same size.
16 He joined five curtains together into one set,
and six curtains into another set.
17 He made 50 loops on the edge of the last curtain of the
first set,
and 50 loops on the edge of the last curtain of the
second set.
18 He made 50 clasps of bronze to join the tent together, so
that it became one whole.
19 He made a covering for the tent of rams' skins dyed red.
And above that, he made a covering of sea cow hides.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: 30 cubits long, 4 cubits wide.

As in Chapter 26: Over the beautiful linen curtains lie a covering of goats' hair and two coverings of skins and hides. They protect against sun and rain.

The boards VERSES 20–30

20 He made the boards for the tabernacle of acacia wood.
They stood upright.
21 Each board was about 15 feet long and about 2 feet 3
inches wide.
22 Each board had two tenons, joined to each other.
He made all the boards of the tabernacle this way.
23 He made the boards for the tabernacle: 20 boards for
the south side.
24 He made 40 sockets of silver under the 20 boards:
2 sockets under one board for its 2 tenons,
and 2 sockets under the next board for its 2 tenons.
25 For the second side of the tabernacle, the north side, he
made 20 boards
26 and their 40 sockets of silver:
2 sockets under one board and 2 sockets under the next
board.
27 For the back of the tabernacle, toward the west, he
made six boards.
28 And he made two boards for the corners of the
tabernacle at the back.
29 They were double at the bottom, and in the same way
they went all the way to the top, up to the first ring.
He did this with both of them, at the two corners.
30 So there were 8 boards with their sockets of silver, 16
sockets:
2 sockets under each board.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: 10 cubits long, one and a half cubits wide.

The boards form the walls of the sanctuary. You can read more about this in the explanation for Exodus 26.

The bars VERSES 31–34

31 He made bars of acacia wood:
five for the boards on one side of the tabernacle,
32 five bars for the boards on the other side of the
tabernacle,
and five bars for the boards at the back, toward the
west.
33 He made the middle bar so that it went through the
middle of the boards from one end to the other.
34 He covered the boards with gold.
He made gold rings on them for the bars to go
through.
And he covered the bars with gold.

The two veils VERSES 35–38

35 He made the veil of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of
fine twisted linen.
Cherubim were woven into it, the work of a skillful
worker.
36 He made four pillars of acacia wood for it and covered
them with gold.
Their hooks were of gold.
And he cast four sockets of silver for them.
37 He made a screen for the door of the tent
of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted
linen,
the work of an embroiderer.
38 He also made its five pillars with their hooks.
He covered their capitals and their bands with gold.
And their five sockets were of bronze.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first veil separates the Holy Place from the Most Holy Place. The second curtain hangs at the entrance of the tent.

A "capital" is the top part of a pillar. It is often decorated.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 37

The ark, the table, the lamp stand and the altar of incense

The ark of the covenant VERSES 1–5

1 Bezalel made the ark of acacia wood.
It was about 3 feet 9 inches long, about 2 feet 3 inches
wide and about 2 feet 3 inches high.
2 He covered it with pure gold, inside and outside.
And he made a gold molding all around it.
3 He cast four gold rings for it and put them on its four
feet:
two rings on one side and two rings on the other side.
4 He made poles of acacia wood and covered them with
gold.
5 He put the poles through the rings on the sides of the
ark, so that the ark could be carried.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: two and a half cubits long, one and a half cubits wide and high. A cubit is about 18 inches.

Bezalel makes the ark of the covenant himself. It is the most important piece in the whole sanctuary. You can read more about it in the explanation for Exodus 25.

The cover with the cherubim VERSES 6–9

6 He made a mercy seat of pure gold.
It is the cover of the ark.
It was about 3 feet 9 inches long and about 2 feet 3
inches wide.
7 He made two cherubim of gold.
He made them of hammered gold, at the two ends of
the mercy seat:
8 one cherub at one end and one cherub at the other end.
He made the cherubim one piece with the mercy seat,
at its two ends.
9 The cherubim spread out their wings upward
and covered the mercy seat with their wings.
Their faces were turned toward each other.
The faces of the cherubim looked toward the mercy
seat.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Cherubim are heavenly beings with wings. They guard the place where God is present.

"Hammered gold" means: The gold is not poured into a mold. It is beaten into shape with a hammer.

The table VERSES 10–16

10 He made the table of acacia wood.
It was about 3 feet long, about 18 inches wide and
about 2 feet 3 inches high.
11 He covered it with pure gold and made a gold molding
all around it.
12 He made a border all around it, about 3 inches wide.
And he made a gold molding all around this border.
13 He cast four gold rings for the table.
He put the rings at the four corners, on its four legs.
14 The rings were close to the border.
The poles for carrying the table went through them.
15 He made the poles of acacia wood and covered them
with gold, to carry the table.
16 He also made the things that belonged on the table:
its dishes, its spoons, its bowls and its pitchers for
pouring.
He made them of pure gold.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: two cubits long, one cubit wide, one and a half cubits high. A hand's width is about 3 inches.

The bread of the presence lay on this table: 12 loaves for the 12 tribes.

The golden lamp stand VERSES 17–24

17 He made the lamp stand of pure gold.
He made the lamp stand of hammered gold.
Its base, its shaft, its cups, its buds and its flowers were
one piece with it.
18 Six branches went out from its sides:
three branches on one side and three branches on the
other side.
19 On one branch there were three cups shaped like
almond blossoms, each with a bud and a flower.
And on the next branch there were also three cups
shaped like almond blossoms, each with a bud and a
flower.
It was like this for all six branches that went out from
the lamp stand.
20 On the lamp stand itself there were four cups shaped
like almond blossoms, with their buds and their
flowers.
21 There was a bud under each pair of branches, one piece
with the lamp stand:
a bud under the first two branches,
a bud under the next two branches
and a bud under the last two branches.
It was like this for the six branches that went out from
it.
22 The buds and the branches were one piece with it.
The whole thing was one piece of hammered, pure
gold.
23 He made its seven lamps,
and its snuffers and its snuff dishes, of pure gold.
24 He made the lamp stand and all its tools from a talent of
pure gold (about 75 pounds).

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A talent is about 75 pounds. That much gold went into the lamp stand and its tools.

The lamp stand with seven branches is called the "menorah" in Hebrew. To this day, it is an important sign of Judaism. It is on the coat of arms of the State of Israel.

The altar of incense, the anointing oil and the incense
VERSES 25–29

25 He made the altar of incense of acacia wood.
It was square: about 18 inches long and about 18 inches wide.
And it was about 3 feet high.
Its horns were one piece with it.
26 He covered it with pure gold:
its top, its sides all around and its horns.
And he made a gold molding all around it.
27 He made two gold rings for it under its molding,
on its two sides, across from each other.
They held the poles for carrying it.
28 He made the poles of acacia wood and covered them with gold.
29 He also made the holy anointing oil
and the pure, sweet-smelling incense,
with the skill of a perfume maker.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: one cubit long and wide, two cubits high.

Now all the objects for the inside of the sanctuary are finished: the ark of the covenant in the Most Holy Place, and the table, the lamp stand and the altar of incense in the Holy Place.

What was commanded in Chapters 25 and 30 is now done, piece by piece.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 38

Altar for burnt offerings, basin, courtyard – and what everything cost

The altar for burnt offerings VERSES 1–7

1 He made the altar of burnt offering of acacia wood.
It was square: about 7 feet 6 inches long and about 7 feet 6 inches wide.
And it was about 4 feet 6 inches high.
2 He made its horns on its four corners.
Its horns were one piece with it.
And he covered it with bronze.
3 He made all the tools of the altar:
the pots, the shovels, the basins, the forks and the fire pans.
He made all its tools of bronze.
4 He made a grating of bronze for the altar, like a net.
It was under the ledge that goes around the altar, down below.
It reached halfway up.
5 He cast four rings for the four corners of the bronze grating.
They were to hold the poles.
6 He made the poles of acacia wood and covered them with bronze.
7 He put the poles into the rings on the sides of the altar, to carry it with them.
He made it hollow, out of planks.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: 5 cubits long and wide, 3 cubits high. A cubit is about 18 inches.

All of this was commanded in Chapter 27. Now it is done exactly that way.

The basin made of mirrors VERSE 8

8 He made the basin of bronze and its base of bronze.
He made them from the mirrors of the women who served at the door of the Tent of Meeting.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, there were no mirrors made of glass. Mirrors were made of bronze. The bronze was polished so brightly that people could see themselves in it.

The women give away their mirrors. For them, this was something valuable and personal. It becomes the basin in which the priests wash.

Here it is mentioned in passing that women served at the entrance of the sanctuary. The Bible does not say what exactly their task was. They are also mentioned in 1 Samuel 2:22.

The courtyard VERSES 9–20

9 He made the courtyard.
On the south side, the hangings of the courtyard were made of fine twisted linen, about 150 feet long.
10 Their pillars were 20, and their sockets 20, of bronze.
The hooks of the pillars and their bands were of silver.
11 On the north side it was also about 150 feet,
with 20 pillars and 20 sockets of bronze.
The hooks of the pillars and their bands were of silver.
12 On the west side there were hangings about 75 feet long,
with 10 pillars and 10 sockets.
The hooks of the pillars and their bands were of silver.
13 On the east side, toward the sunrise, it was also about 75 feet.
14 The hangings for one side were about 22 feet 6 inches long,
with three pillars and three sockets.
15 And it was the same on the other side:
On both sides of the gate of the courtyard there were hangings about 22 feet 6 inches long,
with three pillars and three sockets.
16 All the hangings around the courtyard were of fine twisted linen.
17 The sockets for the pillars were of bronze.
The hooks of the pillars and their bands were of silver.
Their capitals were covered with silver.
All the pillars of the courtyard had silver bands.
18 The screen for the gate of the courtyard was the work of an embroiderer,

of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted linen.
It was about 30 feet long and about 7 feet 6 inches high, just as high as the hangings of the courtyard.
19 Their pillars were four, and their sockets four, of bronze.
Their hooks were of silver.
And the covering of their capitals and their bands were of silver.
20 All the tent pegs of the tabernacle and of the courtyard around it were of bronze.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In cubits: The courtyard is 100 cubits long and 50 cubits wide. The hangings next to the gate are 15 cubits long each. The gate is 20 cubits wide and 5 cubits high.

A "capital" is the top part of a pillar.

You can read more about the courtyard in the explanation for Exodus 27.

The accounts: gold, silver and bronze VERSES 21–31

21 This is the list of the materials for the tabernacle, the Tabernacle of the Testimony.
They were counted at the command of Moses,
for the service of the Levites, under the leadership of Ithamar, the son of Aaron the priest.
22 Bezalel the son of Uri, the son of Hur, from the tribe of Judah,
made everything that the LORD had commanded Moses.
23 With him was Oholiab, the son of Ahisamach, from the tribe of Dan.
He was an engraver and a skillful worker,
and an embroiderer in blue, purple and scarlet thread and in fine linen.
24 All the gold that was used for the work on the whole sanctuary, the gold of the offering,
was 29 talents and 730 shekels (about 2,200 pounds), by the weight of the shekel of the sanctuary.
25 The silver from those of the community who were counted was 100 talents and 1,775 shekels (about 7,540 pounds), by the weight of the shekel of the sanctuary.
26 That was a beka for each person, that is, half a shekel by the weight of the shekel of the sanctuary,
from everyone who passed over to those who were counted, 20 years old or older.
There were 603,550 men.
27 The 100 talents of silver (about 7,500 pounds) were used to cast the sockets of the sanctuary and the sockets of the veil:
100 sockets from the 100 talents, one talent (about 75 pounds) for each socket.
28 From the 1,775 shekels (about 44 pounds), he made the hooks for the pillars.
He covered their capitals and made bands for them.
29 The bronze of the offering was 70 talents and 2,400 shekels (about 5,300 pounds).
30 With it he made the sockets for the door of the Tent of Meeting,
the bronze altar, the bronze grating for it and all the tools of the altar,
31 the sockets around the courtyard, the sockets of the gate of the courtyard,
all the tent pegs of the tabernacle and all the tent pegs around the courtyard.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible, the weights are given in talents and shekels. A talent is about 75 pounds. A shekel is about 0.4 ounces.

Gold: 29 talents and 730 shekels. Silver: 100 talents and 1,775 shekels. Bronze: 70 talents and 2,400 shekels. 100 sockets from 100 talents, one talent for each socket. The other 1,775 shekels for hooks and bands.

A "beka" is half a shekel, about one fifth of an ounce of silver. This is the offering from Exodus 30:13. The numbers add up exactly: 603,550 half shekels are 100 talents and 1,775 shekels.

All together, about one ton of gold, more than three tons of silver and more than two tons of bronze. The sanctuary was a great and precious work.

Here the Bible gives an exact account. Money that was given for God should be handled honestly and openly.

The number 603,550 also appears in the great census in Numbers 1:46.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 39

The priests' clothes – and everything is finished

The ephod VERSES 1–7

1 From the blue, purple and scarlet cloth they made finely made clothes for serving in the holy place.
They made the holy clothes for Aaron, as the LORD commanded Moses.
2 He made the ephod of gold,
of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted linen.
3 They beat the gold into thin sheets and cut it into threads.
So they could weave it into the blue, purple and scarlet cloth and into the fine linen,
the work of a skillful worker.
4 They made shoulder straps for it, joined together.
It was held together at its two ends.
5 The skillfully woven band on it, used to tie it on, was one piece with it and made the same way:
of gold, of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted linen,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
6 They worked the onyx stones and set them in settings of gold.
They engraved the names of the people of Israel on them, the way a seal is engraved.

7 He put them on the shoulder straps of the ephod.
They were stones of remembrance for the people of Israel,
as the LORD commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here it shows how gold thread is made: The gold is beaten very thin and then cut into fine strips.

Again and again this chapter says: "as the LORD commanded Moses." This sentence comes seven times here. In the Bible, seven is the number of completeness. Everything is done exactly the way God wanted it.

You can read more about the clothes in the explanation for Exodus 28.

The breastplate VERSES 8–21

8 He made the breastplate, the work of a skillful worker,
the same way as the ephod:
of gold, of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of fine twisted linen.
9 It was square. They made the breastplate folded double.
It was about 9 inches long and about 9 inches wide, folded double.
10 They set four rows of stones in it:
In the first row a ruby, a topaz and a beryl.
11 In the second row a turquoise, a sapphire and an emerald.
12 In the third row a jacinth, an agate and an amethyst.
13 In the fourth row a chrysolite, an onyx and a jasper.
They were set in gold settings.
14 There were 12 stones, one for each name of the people of Israel.
A name was engraved on each stone, the way a seal is engraved, for the 12 tribes.
15 They made chains for the breastplate like braided cords of pure gold.
16 They made two settings of gold and two rings of gold.
They put the two rings on the two ends of the breastplate.
17 They put the two braided chains of gold through the two rings at the ends of the breastplate.
18 They fastened the other two ends of the two chains to the two settings.
And they put them on the front of the shoulder straps of the ephod.
19 They made two more rings of gold.
They put them on the two ends of the breastplate, on its inside edge, next to the ephod.
20 And they made two more rings of gold.
They put them low on the front of the two shoulder straps of the ephod,
close to the place where they are joined, above the woven band of the ephod.
21 They tied the breastplate by its rings to the rings of the ephod with a blue cord.
So it stayed on the woven band of the ephod, and the breastplate could not come loose from the ephod,
as the LORD commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible gives the size as "a span." A span is about 9 inches.

The 12 stones stand for the 12 tribes of Israel. The priest carries them on his heart before God.

The robe and the other clothes VERSES 22–31

22 He made the robe that is worn under the ephod, of woven work, all of blue cloth.
23 The robe had an opening in the middle, like the neck opening of a coat of armor.
There was an edge around the opening, so that it would not tear.
24 On the hem of the robe they made pomegranates of blue, purple and scarlet cloth and of twisted linen.
25 They made bells of pure gold.
They put the bells between the pomegranates, all around the hem of the robe, between the pomegranates:
26 a bell and a pomegranate, a bell and a pomegranate, all around the hem of the robe, for serving,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
27 They made the tunics of fine linen, of woven work, for Aaron and for his sons,
28 the turban of fine linen,
the linen headbands of fine linen,
the linen pants of fine twisted linen,
29 and the sash of fine twisted linen and of blue, purple and scarlet cloth,
the work of an embroiderer,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
30 They made the plate of the holy crown of pure gold.
They wrote words on it, the way a seal is engraved:
"HOLY TO THE LORD."
31 They tied a blue cord to it, to fasten it on the turban above,
as the LORD commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The bells on the hem, the golden plate on the forehead with "Holy to the LORD" – everything is finished now. You can read more about it in the explanation for Exodus 28.

The work is finished VERSES 32–43

32 So all the work on the tabernacle, the Tent of Meeting, was finished.
The people of Israel did everything as the LORD had told Moses. That is what they did.
33 They brought the tabernacle to Moses:
the tent with all its furniture,
its clasps, its boards, its bars, its pillars and its sockets,
34 the covering of rams' skins dyed red,
the covering of sea cow hides,
the veil that hangs as a screen,
35 the ark of the covenant with its poles, the mercy seat,
36 the table with all its things, and the bread of the presence,
37 the pure lamp stand with its lamps, the lamps set in a row,
with all its things and the oil for the light,
38 the golden altar, the anointing oil, the sweet incense,
the screen for the door of the Tent,
39 the bronze altar with its grating of bronze, its poles and all its tools,

the basin and its base,
40 the hangings of the courtyard, its pillars and its sockets,
the screen for the gate of the courtyard, its ropes and its tent pegs,
and all the tools for the service of the tabernacle, for the Tent of Meeting,
41 the finely made clothes for serving in the holy place,
the holy clothes for Aaron the priest and the clothes of his sons
for their service as priests.
42 The people of Israel did all the work exactly as the LORD had told Moses.
43 Moses looked at all the work.
And look: They had done it as the LORD had commanded. That is what they had done.
And Moses blessed them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are a reminder of the story of creation. There it says: "God looked at everything he had made. And look: It was very good" (Genesis 1:31). And God blessed the seventh day (Genesis 2:3).

Here Moses looks at all the work. It is done well. And Moses blesses the people.

Just as God made the world as a home for people, people have now made a home for God.

EXODUS

CHAPTER 40

The sanctuary is set up – God's glory fills it

God's instructions for setting it up VERSES 1–15

1 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
2 "On the first day of the first month, set up the tabernacle, the Tent of Meeting.
3 Put the ark of the covenant in it.
And hide the ark behind the veil.
4 Bring in the table and set out in order the things that belong on it.
Bring in the lamp stand and light its lamps.
5 Put the golden altar for incense in front of the ark of the covenant.
And hang the screen at the door of the tabernacle.
6 "Put the altar of burnt offering in front of the door of the tabernacle, the Tent of Meeting.
7 Put the basin between the Tent of Meeting and the altar.
And put water in it.
8 Set up the courtyard all around it.
And hang the screen at the gate of the courtyard.
9 "Take the anointing oil.
Anoint the tabernacle and everything in it.
Make it holy, with all its furniture. Then it will be holy.
10 Anoint the altar of burnt offering with all its tools.
Make the altar holy. Then the altar will be most holy.
11 Anoint the basin and its base, and make it holy.
12 "Bring Aaron and his sons to the door of the Tent of Meeting.
And wash them with water.
13 Put the holy clothes on Aaron.
Anoint him and make him holy, so that he can serve me as a priest.
14 Bring his sons and put tunics on them.
15 Anoint them, just as you anointed their father, so that they can serve me as priests.
Their anointing shall make them priests forever, through all their generations."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "first day of the first month" is New Year's Day, almost exactly one year after leaving Egypt. With the sanctuary, a new year and a new part of the story begin.

The consecration of the priests that is commanded here is told in detail in Leviticus 8.

Moses sets up the sanctuary VERSES 16–33

16 Moses did this.
He did everything exactly as the LORD had commanded him.
17 In the first month of the second year, on the first day of the month, the tabernacle was set up.
18 Moses set up the tabernacle.
He laid its sockets, set up its boards, put in its bars and set up its pillars.
19 He spread the covering over the tent.
And he put the roof of the tabernacle on top of it,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
20 He took the covenant and put it into the ark.
He put the poles on the ark.
And he put the mercy seat on top of the ark.
21 He brought the ark into the tabernacle.
He hung up the veil as a screen, and so he screened off the ark of the covenant,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
22 He put the table in the Tent of Meeting, on the north side of the tabernacle, outside the veil.
23 He set out the bread on it in order, before the LORD,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
24 He put the lamp stand in the Tent of Meeting, across from the table, on the south side of the tabernacle.
25 He lit the lamps before the LORD,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
26 He put the golden altar in the Tent of Meeting, in front of the veil.
27 And he burned sweet-smelling incense on it,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
28 He hung up the screen at the door of the tabernacle.

29 He put the altar of burnt offering at the door of the tabernacle, the Tent of Meeting.
And he offered the burnt offering and the grain offering on it,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
30 He put the basin between the Tent of Meeting and the altar.
And he put water in it for washing.
31 Moses, Aaron and his sons washed their hands and their feet in it.
32 Whenever they went into the Tent of Meeting, and whenever they came near the altar, they washed,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
33 He set up the courtyard around the tabernacle and the altar.
And he hung up the screen at the gate of the courtyard.
So Moses finished the work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses sets everything up from the inside to the outside: first the tabernacle and the ark of the covenant, then the table, the lamp stand and the altar of incense, then the altar and the basin outside, and last of all the courtyard.

Again it says seven times: "as the LORD commanded Moses."

"So Moses finished the work" – this is also a reminder of creation. There it says: "On the seventh day, God had finished the work he had done" (Genesis 2:2).

God's glory fills the sanctuary VERSES 34–38

34 Then the cloud covered the Tent of Meeting.
And the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle.
35 Moses was not able to go into the Tent of Meeting, because the cloud stayed on it,
and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle.
36 Whenever the cloud was lifted up from over the tabernacle, the people of Israel moved on.
It was like this on all their journeys.
37 But if the cloud was not lifted up, then they did not travel,
until the day when it was lifted up.
38 For the cloud of the LORD was over the tabernacle by day.
And at night there was fire in the cloud.
All the house of Israel could see it, on all their journeys.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the great goal of the whole book of Exodus. At the beginning, Israel was in Egypt, slaves of Pharaoh, far away from God. At the end, God lives in the middle of his people.

God has kept his promise: "I will live among the people of Israel" (Exodus 29:45).

And this after the golden calf! The people had broken the covenant. But God has forgiven them and comes anyway, to live with them.

God's glory is so great that not even Moses can go in. The next book, Leviticus, tells how people can still come near to the holy God.

The cloud shows the people the way through the desert. When it moves on, they move on. When it stays, they stay. God himself leads his people.

Here Christians also think of Pentecost: Then God's Spirit came on the people like fire (Acts 2:3). Paul writes: You yourselves are now the temple where God's Spirit lives (1 Corinthians 3:16).

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Exodus?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Exodus tells three large parts:

1. God frees his people from slavery in Egypt (Chapters 1–18).

2. At Mount Sinai, God makes a covenant with his people and gives them his commandments (Chapters 19–24).

3. God comes to live in the middle of his people. For this, the sanctuary is built (Chapters 25–40). In the middle of it stand the golden calf and God's forgiveness (Chapters 32–34).

The message of the book: God sees the suffering of people who are oppressed. He frees them. He gives them good rules for a life in freedom. And he does not want to be far away. He wants to live among people.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 3 OF 66

LEVITICUS

27 CHAPTERS

LEVITICUS

Chapter 1

The burnt offering

Before we begin: What is the book of Leviticus?

The third book of Moses is also called "Leviticus." That means: the book for the Levites, that is, for the priests and the helpers at the holy tent.

At the end of the book of Exodus, God moves into the holy tent, right in the middle of his people. But God is holy. How can people with faults and guilt live close to the holy God?

This book gives the answer. It explains the offerings, the work of the priests, the rules for clean and unclean, the great Day of Atonement and the festivals.

The most important sentence of the book is: "You shall be holy, because I, the LORD your God, am holy" (Leviticus 19:2).

Here we also find the commandment that Jesus later names as one of the two most important commandments: "Love your neighbor as yourself" (Leviticus 19:18).

Many things in this book seem strange to us today: animal offerings, blood, rules about food and illnesses. The explanations help us understand them.

The temple in Jerusalem was destroyed in AD 70. Since then, Jews no longer bring animal offerings. In their place have come prayer, learning the Torah and good deeds. Christians believe that Jesus, through his death, brought the last and perfect offering (Hebrews 10:10–14).

The burnt offering from cattle VERSES 1–9

1 The LORD called to Moses and spoke to him from the
Tent of Meeting. He said,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them,
'When any of you brings an offering to the LORD,
you shall bring your offering from the livestock, from
the cattle or from the sheep and goats.
3 "'If his offering is a burnt offering from the cattle,
he shall bring a male animal without any fault.
He shall bring it to the door of the Tent of Meeting,
so that he is accepted before the LORD.
4 He shall lay his hand on the head of the burnt offering.
Then it will be accepted for him, to make atonement
for him.
5 He shall kill the bull before the LORD.
Aaron's sons, the priests, shall bring the blood
and sprinkle the blood all around on the altar that
stands at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
6 He shall take the skin off the burnt offering and cut it
into pieces.
7 The sons of Aaron the priest shall put fire on the altar
and lay wood neatly on the fire.
8 And Aaron's sons, the priests, shall lay the pieces, the
head and the fat
neatly on the wood that is on the fire on the altar.
9 But he shall wash its inner parts and its legs with water.
The priest shall burn all of it on the altar.
It is a burnt offering, an offering made by fire, a
pleasant smell to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now God calls Moses from the Tent of Meeting, the holy tent that has just been finished.

The burnt offering is the first offering that is described. The whole animal is burned. None of it is eaten. It is a sign: I give myself completely to God.

The animal must be "without any fault," that is, healthy and without injury. You do not give God the worst. You give him the best.

The person who brings the offering lays his hand on the animal's head. That means: This animal stands for me.

Verse 4: To make atonement means: to take away guilt, so that a person can be at peace with God again.

Interesting: The person who brings the offering kills the animal himself. The priest takes care of the blood and the altar.

"A pleasant smell to the LORD" is a picture: God is glad to accept the offering.

The burnt offering from sheep and goats VERSES 10–13

10 "'If his offering for a burnt offering is from the sheep
or from the goats,
he shall bring a male animal without any fault.
11 He shall kill it on the north side of the altar before the
LORD.
Aaron's sons, the priests, shall sprinkle its blood all
around on the altar.
12 He shall cut it into its pieces, with its head and its fat.
The priest shall lay them neatly on the wood that is on
the fire on the altar.
13 But he shall wash the inner parts and the legs with
water.
The priest shall bring the whole animal and burn it on
the altar.
It is a burnt offering, an offering made by fire, a
pleasant smell to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Not everyone could afford a bull. So people could also bring a sheep or a goat. That offering counts just as much.

The burnt offering from birds VERSES 14–17

14 "'If his offering to the LORD is a burnt offering of
birds,
he shall bring his offering from the turtledoves or
from the young pigeons.
15 The priest shall bring it to the altar, twist off its head
and burn it on the altar.
Its blood shall be drained out on the side of the altar.
16 He shall take away its crop and its feathers.
He shall throw it beside the altar, on the east side, in
the place for the ashes.

17 He shall tear it open by its wings, but he shall not divide it completely.
The priest shall burn it on the altar, on the wood that is on the fire.
It is a burnt offering, an offering made by fire, a pleasant smell to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: The crop is a pouch in the bird's throat where food is stored.

People who were very poor could bring doves. So everyone could bring an offering, no matter how much money they had.

Three times the end is the same: "a pleasant smell to the LORD" – for the bull, for the sheep and for the dove. To God, the small dove of a poor person is worth just as much as the bull of a rich person.

Mary and Joseph were poor too. When Jesus was born, they brought two doves as an offering in the temple (Luke 2:24).

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 2

The grain offering

The grain offering of flour VERSES 1–3

1 "'When anyone brings a grain offering to the LORD as an offering,
his offering shall be of fine flour.
He shall pour oil on it and put frankincense on it.
2 He shall bring it to Aaron's sons, the priests.
He shall take a handful of its fine flour and of its oil, with all its frankincense.
And the priest shall burn this memorial part on the altar,
as an offering made by fire, a pleasant smell to the LORD.
3 What is left of the grain offering belongs to Aaron and his sons.
It is a most holy part of the LORD's offerings made by fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A grain offering is an offering of flour or grain. Frankincense is a sweet-smelling resin from a tree. It gives off a pleasant smoke when it burns.

The grain offering is an offering without an animal. People bring flour, oil and frankincense – things that come from work in the fields. It is a thank-you to God for our daily bread.

Only a handful is burned. This is called the "memorial part." It stands for the whole offering. It is meant to remind God of the person who brings it.

The rest is food for the priests. The priests had no land of their own. This is how God cared for them.

Baked, on a griddle or in a pan VERSES 4–10

4 "'When you bring a grain offering that is baked in the oven,
it shall be cakes of fine flour without yeast, mixed with oil,
or thin wafers without yeast, spread with oil.
5 If your offering is a grain offering made on a griddle,
it shall be of fine flour without yeast, mixed with oil.
6 Cut it in pieces and pour oil on it. It is a grain offering.
7 If your offering is a grain offering made in a pan,
it shall be made of fine flour with oil.
8 "'Bring the grain offering that is made of these things to the LORD.
It shall be given to the priest, and he shall bring it to the altar.
9 The priest shall take the memorial part from the grain offering and burn it on the altar,
as an offering made by fire, a pleasant smell to the LORD.
10 What is left of the grain offering belongs to Aaron and his sons.
It is a most holy part of the LORD's offerings made by fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: A griddle is a flat, hot iron plate for baking.

People could prepare the flour in different ways: baked in an oven, on a hot griddle or in a pan. Everyone could bring the offering the way he baked in his own kitchen.

No yeast, no honey – but always salt VERSES 11–13

11 "'No grain offering that you bring to the LORD may be made with yeast.
For you may not burn any yeast or any honey as an offering made by fire to the LORD.
12 You may bring them to the LORD as an offering of first fruits.
But they shall not go up on the altar as a pleasant smell.
13 You shall season every offering of your grain offering with salt.
Do not let the salt of the covenant of your God be missing from your grain offering.
You shall bring salt with all your offerings.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: A covenant is a firm agreement.

Yeast and honey ferment and spoil. That is why they do not belong on the altar. In the Bible, yeast is often a picture of something that spreads and spoils things (for example, 1 Corinthians 5:6–8).

Salt, on the other hand, keeps things fresh. It stops things from spoiling. That is why salt is a sign of a covenant that lasts forever. Back then, people ate bread and salt together when they became friends.

Jesus says to his disciples, "You are the salt of the earth" (Matthew 5:13).

The grain offering of first fruits VERSES 14–16

14 "'If you bring the LORD a grain offering of first fruits, you shall bring fresh heads of grain as the grain

offering of your first fruits,
roasted in the fire and crushed.
15 Put oil on it and lay frankincense on it. It is a grain offering.
16 The priest shall burn some of the crushed grain and some of the oil as its memorial part,
together with all its frankincense.
It is an offering made by fire to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "first fruits" are the first heads of grain from the new harvest. People give the first and best to God. In this way they say: The whole harvest is a gift from God.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 3

The peace offering

The peace offering from cattle VERSES 1–5

1 "'If his offering is a sacrifice of peace offerings,
and he brings it from the cattle, a male or a female animal,
he shall bring it before the LORD without any fault.
2 He shall lay his hand on the head of his offering
and kill it at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
Aaron's sons, the priests, shall sprinkle the blood all around on the altar.
3 From the sacrifice of peace offerings he shall bring an offering made by fire to the LORD:
the fat that covers the inner parts, and all the fat that is on the inner parts,
4 the two kidneys and the fat on them, which is by the lower back,
and the covering on the liver.
He shall take that away together with the kidneys.
5 Aaron's sons shall burn it on the altar, on top of the burnt offering
that is on the wood over the fire.
It is an offering made by fire, a pleasant smell to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A sacrifice is an animal that is killed and given to God as an offering.

The peace offering is also called the "fellowship offering." In Hebrew, its name contains the word "shalom": peace, well-being, being whole.

In this offering, only the fat and a few inner parts are burned. The people eat most of the meat themselves – at a feast with family and friends (Leviticus 7:15). One part belongs to the priests.

It is like a shared meal with God. People celebrate that they live in peace with God and with one another. People brought it, for example, to thank God, or when they had kept a promise.

Unlike the burnt offering, it may also be a female animal.

The peace offering from sheep VERSES 6–11

6 "'If his offering for a sacrifice of peace offerings to the LORD is from the flock,
a male or a female animal,
he shall bring it without any fault.
7 If he brings a lamb as his offering, he shall bring it before the LORD.
8 He shall lay his hand on the head of his offering
and kill it in front of the Tent of Meeting.
Aaron's sons shall sprinkle its blood all around on the altar.
9 From the sacrifice of peace offerings he shall bring an offering made by fire to the LORD:
its fat, the whole fat tail, which he shall cut off close to the backbone,
the fat that covers the inner parts, and all the fat that is on the inner parts,
10 the two kidneys and the fat on them, which is by the lower back,
and the covering on the liver.
He shall take that away together with the kidneys.
11 The priest shall burn it on the altar.
It is the food of the offering made by fire to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "fat tail" belongs to a kind of sheep in the Middle East that stores a lot of fat in its tail. It could weigh many pounds and was seen as an especially good piece.

"The food of the offering to the LORD" is a picture. God does not need food. But the offering is like an invitation: God sits at the table with us.

The peace offering from goats VERSES 12–17

12 "'If his offering is a goat, he shall bring it before the LORD.
13 He shall lay his hand on its head and kill it in front of the Tent of Meeting.
The sons of Aaron shall sprinkle its blood all around on the altar.
14 From it he shall bring his offering, an offering made by fire to the LORD:
the fat that covers the inner parts, and all the fat that is on the inner parts,
15 the two kidneys and the fat on them, which is by the lower back,
and the covering on the liver.
He shall take that away together with the kidneys.
16 The priest shall burn them on the altar.
It is the food of the offering made by fire, a pleasant smell.
All the fat belongs to the LORD.
17 "'This shall be a rule that lasts forever, for all your generations, everywhere you live:
You shall not eat any fat or any blood.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The fat was seen as the best part of the animal. That is why it belongs to God.

This means the fat around the inner organs, not the fat inside the meat.

People may not eat blood, because the life is in the blood (Leviticus 17:11). Life belongs to God. This rule already existed in the time of Noah (Genesis 9:4).

To this day, Jews make sure that kosher meat has had the blood drained out. The first Christians also kept the rule against blood (Acts 15:20).

LEVITICUS

Chapter 4

The sin offering

When the high priest sins VERSES 1–12

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and say,
'If anyone sins without meaning to,
and does any of the things that the LORD has commanded not to be done –
3 if the anointed priest sins and so brings guilt on the people,
then for the sin he has done, he shall bring the LORD a young bull without any fault as a sin offering.
4 He shall bring the bull to the door of the Tent of Meeting, before the LORD.
He shall lay his hand on the head of the bull and kill the bull before the LORD.
5 The anointed priest shall take some of the bull's blood and bring it into the Tent of Meeting.
6 The priest shall dip his finger in the blood and sprinkle some of the blood seven times before the LORD, in front of the veil of the sanctuary.
7 The priest shall put some of the blood on the horns of the altar for sweet incense,
which stands before the LORD in the Tent of Meeting.
He shall pour out all the rest of the bull's blood at the bottom of the altar for burnt offerings,
which stands at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
8 He shall take all the fat from the bull of the sin offering:
the fat that covers the inner parts, and all the fat that is on the inner parts,
9 the two kidneys and the fat on them, which is by the lower back,
and the covering on the liver. He shall take that away together with the kidneys,
10 just as it is taken away from the bull of the sacrifice of peace offerings.
The priest shall burn them on the altar for burnt offerings.
11 But the bull's skin and all its meat, with its head and its legs, its inner parts and its dung –
12 that is, all the rest of the bull –
he shall carry outside the camp, to a clean place where the ashes are poured out.
There he shall burn it on wood with fire.
It shall be burned where the ashes are poured out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: The anointed priest is the priest on whose head holy oil has been poured.

Verse 7: The horns are the raised corners of the altar.

Now it is about the "sin offering." It is for sins that someone did without meaning to: by accident, because he did not know, or because he was not careful.

Such mistakes count too. They harm the relationship with God and with other people. But God gives a way for them to be forgiven.

The chapter goes step by step: What does the high priest do? What does the whole people do? What does a leader do? What does an ordinary person do?

The "anointed priest" is the high priest. If he makes a mistake, it affects the whole people. For he stands before God for the people. That is why he must bring a big offering: a young bull.

The blood is even brought into the holy tent, right up to the veil in front of the Most Holy Place. The more important the person, the heavier his guilt.

Seven is the number of completeness. The atonement is meant to be whole and complete.

No one may eat the meat here. It is burned outside the camp. The high priest may not eat from his own sin offering.

When the whole people sins VERSES 13–21

13 "'If the whole community of Israel sins, and the assembly does not notice it,
and they do any of the things that the LORD has commanded not to be done, and so they become guilty,
14 and then the sin that they have done becomes known,
the assembly shall bring a young bull as a sin offering.
They shall bring it in front of the Tent of Meeting.
15 The elders of the community shall lay their hands on the head of the bull before the LORD.
And the bull shall be killed before the LORD.
16 The anointed priest shall bring some of the bull's blood into the Tent of Meeting.
17 The priest shall dip his finger in the blood and sprinkle it seven times before the LORD, in front of the veil.
18 He shall put some of the blood on the horns of the altar that stands before the LORD in the Tent of Meeting.
He shall pour out all the rest of the blood at the bottom of the altar for burnt offerings, which stands at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
19 He shall take all its fat from it and burn it on the altar.
20 This is what he shall do with the bull.
As he did with the bull of the sin offering, so he shall do with this one.
So the priest shall make atonement for them, and they will be forgiven.
21 He shall carry the bull outside the camp
and burn it, just as he burned the first bull.
It is the sin offering for the assembly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A whole people can also become guilty together without noticing it. For example, when everyone takes part in a

wrong, or when everyone looks away.
The elders lay their hands on the animal in place of everyone.
"They will be forgiven" – that is the goal of the offering. God wants to forgive.

When a leader sins VERSES 22–26

22 "'When a ruler sins,
and without meaning to does any of the things that the LORD his God has commanded not to be done, and so he becomes guilty,
23 and then the sin that he has done is made known to him,
he shall bring a male goat as his offering, a male animal without any fault.
24 He shall lay his hand on the head of the goat
and kill it in the place where the burnt offering is killed before the LORD.
It is a sin offering.
25 The priest shall take some of the blood of the sin offering with his finger
and put it on the horns of the altar for burnt offerings.
He shall pour out the rest of its blood at the bottom of the altar for burnt offerings.
26 He shall burn all its fat on the altar, like the fat of the sacrifice of peace offerings.
So the priest shall make atonement for him because of his sin, and he will be forgiven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A ruler is, for example, the head of a tribe. He brings a male goat, that is, a little less than the high priest.
Here the blood is only put on the altar outside. It is not sprinkled inside the holy tent.

When an ordinary person sins VERSES 27–35

27 "'If anyone of the ordinary people sins without meaning to,
by doing any of the things that the LORD has commanded not to be done, and so he becomes guilty,
28 and then the sin that he has done is made known to him,
he shall bring a goat as his offering for the sin he has done, a female animal without any fault.
29 He shall lay his hand on the head of the sin offering
and kill the sin offering in the place of the burnt offering.
30 The priest shall take some of its blood with his finger
and put it on the horns of the altar for burnt offerings.
He shall pour out all the rest of its blood at the bottom of the altar.
31 He shall take away all its fat, just as the fat is taken away from the sacrifice of peace offerings.
The priest shall burn it on the altar as a pleasant smell to the LORD.
So the priest shall make atonement for him, and he will be forgiven.
32 "'If he brings a lamb as his offering for a sin offering,
he shall bring a female animal without any fault.
33 He shall lay his hand on the head of the sin offering
and kill it as a sin offering in the place where the burnt offering is killed.
34 The priest shall take some of the blood of the sin offering with his finger
and put it on the horns of the altar for burnt offerings.
He shall pour out all the rest of its blood at the bottom of the altar.
35 He shall take away all its fat, just as the fat of the lamb is taken away from the sacrifice of peace offerings.
The priest shall burn them on the altar, on top of the LORD's offerings made by fire.
So the priest shall make atonement for him because of the sin he has done, and he will be forgiven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An ordinary person can also be forgiven. He brings a goat or a lamb.
Four times this chapter says: "and he will be forgiven" or "and they will be forgiven." Whether high priest, the whole people, a leader or an ordinary person – there is forgiveness for everyone.
Important: These offerings are for sins done "without meaning to." For sins that someone does knowingly and on purpose, other rules apply (Numbers 15:30). Later the prophets say clearly: God does not want only offerings. He wants an honest heart that is sorry (Psalm 51:16–17; Hosea 6:6).

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 5

Sin offerings for special cases – the guilt offering

Four cases VERSES 1–4

1 "'If anyone hears a public call to testify and sins in this way:
he is a witness, because he has seen something or knows something,
but he does not report it,
then he shall carry his guilt.
2 "'Or if anyone touches anything unclean,
whether it is the dead body of an unclean wild animal, or the dead body of unclean livestock,
or the dead body of an unclean creeping animal,
and he does not notice it, but he is unclean,
then he shall be guilty.
3 "'Or if he touches something unclean from a human being,
whatever the uncleanness is that makes a person unclean,
and he does not notice it,
then he shall be guilty as soon as he knows about it.
4 "'Or if anyone swears with his lips without thinking, to do something bad or something good –

whatever a person might swear without thinking –
and he does not notice it,
then he will be guilty in one of these cases as soon as he knows about it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here four cases are named:

1. Someone has seen something, but he stays silent in court. Whoever knows the truth and stays silent shares in the guilt.

2. and 3. Someone has touched something "unclean" without noticing it. Chapters 11 to 15 explain what "unclean" means. Unclean does not mean dirty or evil. It means: For a while, a person is not ready to come into the holy tent.

4. Someone has sworn something carelessly and then forgotten it. Words are important. Later Jesus says: "Let your 'Yes' be 'Yes' and your 'No' be 'No'" (Matthew 5:37).

Confessing and bringing an offering VERSES 5–6

5 "'When he is guilty in one of these cases,
he shall confess what he has sinned in.
6 And he shall bring his guilt offering to the LORD for the sin he has done:
a female animal from the flock, a lamb or a goat, as a sin offering.
So the priest shall make atonement for him because of his sin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is something very important: First a person should confess the sin, that is, say openly what he has done wrong. The offering alone is not enough. A person must also honestly face his guilt.

The New Testament says about God: "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and righteous. He forgives us our sins" (1 John 1:9).

For those who are poor VERSES 7–13

7 "'If he cannot afford a lamb,
he shall bring two turtledoves or two young pigeons to the LORD as his guilt offering for what he has sinned in:
one as a sin offering and the other as a burnt offering.
8 He shall bring them to the priest.
The priest shall first bring the bird for the sin offering.
He shall twist its head at the neck, but he shall not tear it off completely.
9 He shall sprinkle some of the blood of the sin offering on the side of the altar.
The rest of the blood shall be drained out at the bottom of the altar.
It is a sin offering.
10 He shall bring the second bird as a burnt offering, as the rule says.
So the priest shall make atonement for him because of the sin he has done, and he will be forgiven.
11 "'But if he cannot afford two turtledoves or two young pigeons either,
he shall bring as his offering for what he has sinned in about two quarts of fine flour as a sin offering.
He shall not pour any oil on it, and he shall not put any frankincense on it.
For it is a sin offering.
12 He shall bring it to the priest.
The priest shall take a handful of it as the memorial part
and burn it on the altar, on top of the LORD's offerings made by fire.
It is a sin offering.
13 So the priest shall make atonement for him because of the sin he has done in any of these cases, and he will be forgiven.
The rest shall belong to the priest, like the grain offering.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says: a tenth of an ephah of flour. An ephah is about 6 gallons.

This is a wonderful rule: No one is too poor for God's forgiveness. Whoever has no lamb brings doves. Whoever has no doves brings a handful of flour. Forgiveness does not depend on your wallet.

In the sin offering there is no oil and no frankincense. Oil and frankincense stand for joy and celebration. But the sin offering is about being sorry.

The guilt offering: when you owe God something VERSES 14–16

14 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
15 "If anyone is unfaithful and sins without meaning to against the LORD's holy things,
he shall bring his guilt offering to the LORD:
a ram without any fault from the flock.
You shall set its value in shekels of silver, by the shekel of the holy place, as a guilt offering.
16 He shall pay back what he did wrong with the holy thing.
He shall add a fifth to it and give it to the priest.
So the priest shall make atonement for him with the ram of the guilt offering, and he will be forgiven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: A ram is a male sheep.

The "guilt offering" is for cases where damage has been done that can be made good again. For example: Someone has eaten by mistake some of the gifts that belong to God or to the priests.

Then an offering is not enough. He must pay for the damage and add one fifth more, that is, 20 percent.

Forgiveness from God and making things good again belong together.

A shekel is about 0.4 ounces of silver.

When you did not know it VERSES 17–19

17 "If anyone sins and does any of the things that the LORD has commanded not to be done,
even if he did not know it,
he is still guilty and shall carry his guilt.
18 He shall bring a ram without any fault from the flock, by your estimate, to the priest as a guilt offering.
So the priest shall make atonement for him because of what he did wrong without knowing it, and he will be forgiven.
19 It is a guilt offering. He is truly guilty before the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even if you did not know something, you can do damage. We know this today too: If you damage someone else's car by accident, you still have to pay for it.

The Bible takes guilt seriously, even guilt that we are not aware of. But it always shows a way to forgiveness too.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 6

Making things right – instructions for the priests

When someone cheats his neighbor VERSES 1–7

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "If anyone sins and is unfaithful to the LORD
by cheating his neighbor:
in something that was given to him to keep safe,
in a business deal, or by robbery,
or if he has oppressed his neighbor,
3 or if he has found something that was lost and lied about it,
and has sworn a false oath –
in any of these things that a person does and so sins –
4 if he has sinned in this way and is guilty,
he shall give back
what he took by robbery,
or what he got by oppression,
or what was given to him to keep safe,
or the lost thing that he found,
5 or anything about which he swore falsely.
He shall pay it back in full and add a fifth more to it.
He shall give it back to the one it belongs to, on the day he is found guilty.
6 And he shall bring his guilt offering to the LORD:
a ram without any fault from the flock, by your estimate, as a guilt offering to the priest.
7 So the priest shall make atonement for him before the LORD.
And he will be forgiven for whatever he did that made him guilty."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles, verses 1–7 of this chapter come at the end of Chapter 5 (as 5:20–26). That is why the verse numbers in Chapter 6 are different there. Here we follow the numbering of the WEB.

Whoever cheats another person sins not only against that person, but also against God. That is why it says: He "is unfaithful to the LORD."

The order is important: First you give back to the person what you took from him, and you add a fifth. Only then do you bring the offering to God.

Jesus says something very similar: "So if you are bringing your gift to the altar and you remember there that your brother has something against you, then leave your gift there in front of the altar and go away. First make peace with your brother. Then come and offer your gift" (Matthew 5:23–24).

A good example is Zacchaeus in the New Testament. He even gave back four times as much (Luke 19:8).

The fire on the altar must never go out VERSES 8–13

8 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
9 "Command Aaron and his sons and say,
'This is the law for the burnt offering:
The burnt offering shall stay on the fireplace on the altar all night until morning.
And the fire of the altar shall be kept burning on it.
10 The priest shall put on his linen robe,
and he shall put on his linen underpants on his body.
He shall take away the ashes that are left when the fire has burned up the burnt offering on the altar.
And he shall put them beside the altar.
11 Then he shall take off his clothes and put on other clothes,
and carry the ashes outside the camp to a clean place.
12 The fire on the altar shall be kept burning on it. It shall not go out.
Every morning the priest shall burn wood on it.
He shall lay the burnt offering neatly on it
and burn the fat of the peace offerings on it.
13 Fire shall be kept burning on the altar all the time. It shall not go out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Linen is a fine cloth made from a plant called flax.

From here on, the instructions are for the priests: How should they handle the offerings?

The fire on the altar should never go out, day and night. This is said three times. It is a sign that the bond between God and his people should never be broken.

Even carrying away the ashes is a holy service. The priest wears special clothes for it.

Many Christians also see the fire that never goes out as a picture of faith: It should always burn in us and never go out.

The law for the grain offering VERSES 14–18

14 "'This is the law for the grain offering:
The sons of Aaron shall bring it before the LORD, in front of the altar.
15 He shall take from it a handful of the fine flour of the grain offering and of its oil,
and all the frankincense that is on the grain offering.
He shall burn it on the altar as a pleasant smell, as its memorial part for the LORD.
16 Aaron and his sons shall eat what is left of it.
It shall be eaten without yeast in a holy place.
They shall eat it in the courtyard of the Tent of Meeting.
17 It shall not be baked with yeast.
I have given it to them as their share of my offerings made by fire.
It is most holy, like the sin offering and the guilt offering.

18 Every male among the descendants of Aaron shall eat
from it.
This is their share forever, for all your generations,
from the LORD's offerings made by fire.
Whoever touches them shall be holy.'"

The grain offering of the priests VERSES 19–23

19 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
20 "This is the offering of Aaron and his sons,
which they shall bring to the LORD on the day when
he is anointed:
about 2 quarts of fine flour as a grain offering that is
always given,
half of it in the morning and half of it in the evening.
21 It shall be made with oil on a griddle.
When it is soaked through, you shall bring it in.
You shall bring the grain offering in baked pieces, as a
pleasant smell to the LORD.
22 The anointed priest from among his sons who takes his
place shall bring it.
It is a rule forever. It shall be burned completely for
the LORD.
23 Every grain offering of a priest shall be burned
completely.
It shall not be eaten."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says: a tenth of an ephah of flour, that is, about 2 quarts.

When an ordinary person brings a grain offering, the priests eat the rest. But when a priest brings a grain offering himself, he may not eat any of it. Otherwise he would be giving a present to himself.

The law for the sin offering VERSES 24–30

24 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
25 "Speak to Aaron and his sons and say,
'This is the law for the sin offering:
In the place where the burnt offering is killed, the sin
offering shall also be killed before the LORD.
It is most holy.
26 The priest who brings it for sin shall eat it.
It shall be eaten in a holy place, in the courtyard of the
Tent of Meeting.
27 Whatever touches its meat shall be holy.
If any of its blood is sprinkled on a piece of clothing,
you shall wash the thing it was sprinkled on in a holy
place.
28 But the clay pot in which it is boiled shall be broken.
And if it is boiled in a bronze pot, the pot shall be
scrubbed and rinsed with water.
29 Every male among the priests shall eat from it. It is
most holy.
30 But no sin offering shall be eaten if any of its blood is
brought into the Tent of Meeting
to make atonement in the Holy Place.
It shall be burned with fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For the smaller sin offerings (for leaders and ordinary people), the priests eat the meat. For the big sin offerings whose blood is brought into the holy tent (for the high priest and the whole people), everything is burned (see Leviticus 4).

A clay pot soaks up some of the meat. That is why it must be broken. A bronze pot can be cleaned completely.

What is holy should not be mixed with everyday things.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 7

More laws for the offerings – the share of the priests

The law for the guilt offering VERSES 1–6

1 "'This is the law for the guilt offering: It is most holy.
2 In the place where they kill the burnt offering, he shall
also kill the guilt offering.
And he shall sprinkle its blood all around on the altar.
3 He shall bring all its fat:
the fat tail and the fat that covers the inner parts,
4 and he shall take away the two kidneys and the fat on
them, which is by the lower back,
and the covering on the liver, together with the
kidneys.
5 The priest shall burn them on the altar as an offering
made by fire to the LORD.
It is a guilt offering.
6 Every male among the priests may eat from it.
It shall be eaten in a holy place. It is most holy.

What belongs to the priests VERSES 7–10

7 "'The guilt offering is like the sin offering.
There is one law for both.
It belongs to the priest who makes atonement with it.
8 When a priest brings someone's burnt offering,
the skin of the burnt offering that he has brought
belongs to him.
9 Every grain offering that is baked in the oven,
and everything that is prepared in a pan or on a
griddle,
belongs to the priest who brings it.
10 Every grain offering, whether mixed with oil or dry,
belongs to all the sons of Aaron, to one as much as to
another.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The priests had no land of their own where they could grow food. They lived from the offerings. That is why this tells exactly what belongs to them: meat, skins and bread.

In this way the whole people cared, through their offerings, for the priests who served for everyone.

The law for the peace offering VERSES 11–21

11 "'This is the law for the sacrifice of peace offerings that
someone brings to the LORD:

12 If he brings it to give thanks,
then together with the sacrifice of thanks he shall bring cakes without yeast, mixed with oil,
thin wafers without yeast, spread with oil,
and cakes mixed with oil.
13 Together with the sacrifice of his peace offerings for thanks,
he shall also bring cakes of bread made with yeast.
14 From these he shall bring one of each kind as a heave offering to the LORD.
It shall belong to the priest who sprinkles the blood of the peace offerings.
15 The meat of the sacrifice of his peace offerings for thanks
shall be eaten on the day he brings his offering.
He shall not leave any of it until the morning.
16 "'But if the sacrifice he brings is for a vow, or is a freewill offering,
it shall be eaten on the day he brings his sacrifice.
What is left of it may also be eaten on the next day.
17 But whatever is left of the meat of the sacrifice on the third day shall be burned with fire.
18 If any of the meat of the sacrifice of his peace offerings is eaten on the third day,
it will not be accepted.
It will not be counted for the one who brings it.
It will be something disgusting to God.
And the person who eats any of it will carry his guilt.
19 "'Meat that touches anything unclean shall not be eaten.
It shall be burned with fire.
As for the other meat, everyone who is clean may eat it.
20 But if a person eats from the meat of the sacrifice of peace offerings that belongs to the LORD
while he is unclean,
that person shall be cut off from his people.
21 When anyone touches anything unclean –
something unclean from a human being, or an unclean animal, or anything unclean and disgusting –
and then eats some of the meat of the sacrifice of peace offerings that belongs to the LORD,
that person shall be cut off from his people.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: A heave offering is a gift that is lifted up for God.

Verse 16: A vow is a solemn promise to God.

Verse 20: "Cut off from his people" means: He no longer belongs to the people of God.

People could bring the peace offering for three reasons: to thank God, to keep a promise they had made to God, or simply freely, out of joy.

With the thank offering there is a feast. The meat must be eaten on the same day. That means: You invite many guests – family, friends, poor people. You should share your joy about God's help.

Interesting: Bread made with yeast is part of it here too. It is not burned on the altar. It is eaten at the feast.

After three days, the meat has gone bad in the heat. That is why it may not be eaten then anymore.

There is more about "being cut off" in the explanation for Exodus 30:33.

No fat and no blood VERSES 22–27

22 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
23 "Speak to the people of Israel and say,
'You shall not eat any fat, whether of cattle, or sheep, or goats.
24 The fat of an animal that died by itself,
and the fat of an animal that was torn by wild animals,
may be used for anything else.
But you shall never eat it.
25 For whoever eats the fat of an animal that people bring to the LORD as an offering made by fire,
that person shall be cut off from his people.
26 And you shall not eat any blood, whether of birds or of other animals, anywhere you live.
27 Whoever eats any blood, that person shall be cut off from his people.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This means the fat around the inner organs, which is burned on the altar with the offerings. It belongs to God.

But people could use this fat for other things, for example for lamps or to care for leather.

People may not eat blood, because the life is in the blood (Leviticus 17:11).

The priests' share of the peace offering VERSES 28–36

28 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
29 "Speak to the people of Israel and say,
'Whoever brings the sacrifice of his peace offerings to the LORD
shall bring his gift to the LORD from the sacrifice of his peace offerings.
30 He shall bring the LORD's offerings made by fire with his own hands.
He shall bring the fat together with the breast.
The breast shall be waved before the LORD as a wave offering.
31 The priest shall burn the fat on the altar.
But the breast shall belong to Aaron and his sons.
32 You shall give the right thigh to the priest as a heave offering from the sacrifices of your peace offerings.
33 The one among the sons of Aaron who brings the blood of the peace offerings and the fat
shall have the right thigh as his share.
34 For I have taken the breast that is waved and the thigh that is lifted up
from the people of Israel, from the sacrifices of their peace offerings.
And I have given them to Aaron the priest and to his sons
as their share forever from the people of Israel.'"
35 This is the holy share of Aaron and the holy share of his sons
from the LORD's offerings made by fire,
on the day when he brought them near to serve the LORD as priests.
36 The LORD commanded that the people of Israel give this to them,
on the day that he anointed them.
It is their share forever, for all their generations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever brings an offering should bring the gift "with his own hands." He should not leave it to others. It is a personal present to God.

In the "wave offering," the gift is moved back and forth in front of the altar. In the "heave offering," it is lifted up. Both show: This gift is meant for God. God then passes it on to the priests.

Summary VERSES 37–38

37 This is the law for the burnt offering, the grain offering, the sin offering, the guilt offering, the consecration offering, and the sacrifice of peace offerings,

38 which the LORD commanded Moses on Mount Sinai, on the day when he commanded the people of Israel to bring their offerings to the LORD, in the wilderness of Sinai.

The consecration offering is the offering when the priests are set apart for their service.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the laws for the offerings end (Chapters 1–7). There are five kinds of offerings: the burnt offering, the grain offering, the sin offering, the guilt offering and the peace offering. In addition, there is the "consecration offering" when the priests are set apart. The next chapter tells about that.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 8

Aaron and his sons are made priests

The people gather VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Take Aaron and his sons with him,
and the clothes, the anointing oil, the bull for the sin offering, the two rams and the basket of bread without yeast.
3 And gather the whole community at the door of the Tent of Meeting."
4 Moses did as the LORD had commanded him.
And the community gathered at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
5 Moses said to the community,
"This is what the LORD has commanded to be done."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: Anointing oil is special holy oil. It is poured on people or things to set them apart for God.

Now what God commanded in Exodus 29 happens: Aaron and his sons are made priests.

The whole people is there. After all, the priests serve the whole people. That is why everyone should see how they are put into their office.

Again and again this chapter says: "as the LORD commanded Moses." Everything happens exactly according to God's word.

Washing, dressing and anointing VERSES 6–13

6 Moses brought Aaron and his sons and washed them with water.
7 He put the tunic on Aaron and tied the sash around him.
A tunic is a long shirt.
He dressed him in the robe and put the ephod on him.
The ephod is a special apron of the high priest.
He tied the skillfully woven band of the ephod around him and fastened the ephod to him with it.
8 He put the breastplate on him.
In the breastplate he put the Urim and Thummim.
The Urim and Thummim were holy objects. The priest used them to ask God for decisions.
9 He set the turban on his head.
And on the front of the turban he set the golden plate, the holy crown,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
10 Moses took the anointing oil.
He anointed the tabernacle and everything in it, and made them holy.
The tabernacle is the holy tent.
11 He sprinkled some of it on the altar seven times.
He anointed the altar and all its tools, and the basin and its stand, to make them holy.
12 He poured some of the anointing oil on Aaron's head and anointed him, to make him holy.
13 Moses brought Aaron's sons.
He dressed them in tunics, tied sashes around them and put headbands on them,
as the LORD commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The clothes and objects were described in Exodus 28.

Oil is poured over Aaron. Psalm 133:2 talks about this: "It is like the precious oil on the head, that ran down on the beard, Aaron's beard" (Psalm 133:2). There it is a picture of the joy when people live together in peace.

The sin offering VERSES 14–17

14 He brought the bull for the sin offering.
Aaron and his sons laid their hands on the head of the bull for the sin offering.
15 He killed it.
Moses took the blood and put it with his finger all around on the horns of the altar.
So he made the altar clean.
He poured out the rest of the blood at the bottom of the altar.
So he made it holy, to make atonement for it.
16 He took all the fat that was on the inner parts, the covering of the liver, and the two kidneys with their fat.
And Moses burned it on the altar.

17 But the bull, its skin, its meat and its dung he burned
with fire outside the camp,
as the LORD commanded Moses.

The burnt offering VERSES 18–21

18 He brought the ram for the burnt offering.
Aaron and his sons laid their hands on the head of the ram.
19 He killed it.
And Moses sprinkled the blood all around on the altar.
20 He cut the ram into its pieces.
And Moses burned the head, the pieces and the fat.
21 He washed the inner parts and the legs with water.
And Moses burned the whole ram on the altar.
It was a burnt offering, a pleasant smell, an offering made by fire to the LORD,
as the LORD commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At this ceremony, Moses acts as the priest. After all, Aaron and his sons have not been set apart yet. Only after the ceremony may they bring offerings themselves.

The consecration offering VERSES 22–30

22 He brought the other ram, the ram of consecration.
Consecration means: setting someone apart for God's service.
Aaron and his sons laid their hands on the head of the ram.
23 He killed it.
Moses took some of its blood and put it
on the tip of Aaron's right ear,
on the thumb of his right hand
and on the big toe of his right foot.
24 He brought Aaron's sons.
Moses put some of the blood on the tip of their right ear,
on the thumb of their right hand and on the big toe of their right foot.
And Moses sprinkled the rest of the blood all around on the altar.
25 He took the fat:
the fat tail, all the fat that was on the inner parts, the covering of the liver,
the two kidneys and their fat, and the right thigh.
26 And from the basket of bread without yeast that stood before the LORD,
he took one cake without yeast, one cake of bread made with oil, and one thin wafer.
He put them on the fat and on the right thigh.
27 He put all this in Aaron's hands and in his sons' hands.
And he waved it before the LORD as a wave offering.
28 Moses took it from their hands and burned it on the altar, on top of the burnt offering.
It was a consecration offering, a pleasant smell, an offering made by fire to the LORD.
29 Moses took the breast and waved it before the LORD as a wave offering.
It was Moses' share of the ram of consecration,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
30 Moses took some of the anointing oil and some of the blood that was on the altar.
He sprinkled it on Aaron and on his clothes,
and on his sons and on his sons' clothes with him.
So he made Aaron and his clothes holy, and his sons and his sons' clothes with him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The blood on the ear, the hand and the foot means: With his ear, the priest should listen to God. With his hand, he should do God's work. And with his foot, he should walk on God's paths. The whole person belongs to God.

Oil and blood are sprinkled on the priests together. The oil is a sign of God's Spirit and of God's choice. The blood is a sign of atonement and of being made clean.

Seven days at the door of the tent VERSES 31–36

31 Moses said to Aaron and his sons,
"Boil the meat at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
Eat it there, together with the bread that is in the basket of consecration.
That is what I commanded when I said, 'Aaron and his sons shall eat it.'
32 Whatever is left of the meat and of the bread you shall burn with fire.
33 For seven days you shall not go out from the door of the Tent of Meeting,
until the days of your consecration are over.
For he will consecrate you for seven days.
34 What has been done today is what the LORD has commanded to be done,
to make atonement for you.
35 You shall stay at the door of the Tent of Meeting day and night for seven days,
and keep the LORD's command, so that you do not die.
For that is what I have been commanded."
36 Aaron and his sons did all the things that the LORD commanded through Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The ceremony lasts seven days. Seven days – like the seven days of creation. A new life begins for the priests.

During these seven days they stay at the holy tent day and night. They should be completely with God before they begin their service.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 9

Aaron's first offering – God's glory appears

Today the LORD appears to you VERSES 1–7

1 On the eighth day, Moses called Aaron and his sons and the elders of Israel.
2 He said to Aaron,
"Take a calf from the cattle as a sin offering and a ram

as a burnt offering, both without any fault,
and bring them before the LORD.
3 And speak to the people of Israel and say,
'Take a male goat as a sin offering,
and a calf and a lamb, both one year old and without
any fault, as a burnt offering,
4 and a bull and a ram as peace offerings, to sacrifice
before the LORD,
and a grain offering mixed with oil.
For today the LORD appears to you.'"
5 They brought what Moses had commanded in front of
the Tent of Meeting.
The whole community came near and stood before the
LORD.
6 Moses said,
"This is what the LORD commanded you to do.
Then the LORD's glory will appear to you."
Glory means: the bright light of God's greatness.
7 Moses said to Aaron,
"Come near to the altar.
Bring your sin offering and your burnt offering.
Make atonement for yourself and for the people.
Then bring the offering of the people and make
atonement for them,
as the LORD commanded."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the seven days of the ceremony comes the eighth day. It is the first day of a new beginning. Now Aaron does his work as a priest himself for the first time.

First Aaron must bring an offering for himself. The high priest, too, is a person with faults. Only then can he come before God for the people.

Aaron has to offer a calf, of all things. Maybe this is meant to remind him of the golden calf he had made (Exodus 32). Now this guilt is forgiven.

Aaron's offering for himself VERSES 8–14

8 So Aaron came near to the altar and killed the calf for
the sin offering, which was for himself.
9 Aaron's sons brought the blood to him.
He dipped his finger in the blood and put it on the
horns of the altar.
He poured out the rest of the blood at the bottom of
the altar.
10 But he burned on the altar the fat, the kidneys and the
covering from the liver of the sin offering,
as the LORD commanded Moses.
11 He burned the meat and the skin with fire outside the
camp.
12 He killed the burnt offering.
Aaron's sons handed him the blood, and he sprinkled it
all around on the altar.
13 They handed him the burnt offering, piece by piece,
and the head.
He burned them on the altar.
14 He washed the inner parts and the legs, and burned
them on top of the burnt offering on the altar.

Aaron's offering for the people VERSES 15–21

15 Then he brought the people's offering.
He took the goat for the sin offering, which was for the
people, and killed it,
and offered it for sin, like the first one.
16 He brought the burnt offering and offered it as the rule
says.
17 He brought the grain offering.
He filled his hand with some of it and burned it on the
altar,
in addition to the burnt offering of the morning.
18 He also killed the bull and the ram, the sacrifice of peace
offerings for the people.
Aaron's sons handed him the blood, and he sprinkled it
all around on the altar.
19 And they handed him the fat of the bull and of the ram:
the fat tail, the fat that covers the inner parts, the
kidneys and the covering of the liver.
20 They put the fat on the breasts.
And he burned the fat on the altar.
21 Aaron waved the breasts and the right thigh before the
LORD as a wave offering,
as Moses commanded.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now all the kinds of offerings come together: the sin offering, the burnt offering, the grain offering and the peace offering.

The order has a meaning: First the guilt is forgiven (sin offering). Then you give yourself completely to God (burnt offering). Then you give thanks (grain offering). And last, you celebrate fellowship with God (peace offering).

The blessing and the fire from the LORD VERSES 22–24

22 Aaron lifted up his hands toward the people and blessed
them.
Then he came down, after he had brought the sin
offering, the burnt offering and the peace offerings.
23 Moses and Aaron went into the Tent of Meeting.
Then they came out and blessed the people.
And the LORD's glory appeared to all the people.
24 Fire came out from before the LORD and burned up the
burnt offering and the fat on the altar.
When all the people saw it, they shouted and fell down
on their faces.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a great high point. God accepts the offerings. Fire comes from God and burns up the offering. This is the sign: God is here, and he is at peace with his people.

Aaron lifts his hands and blesses the people. Numbers 6:24–26 shows how this blessing later sounds. It begins: "The LORD bless you and keep you ..." (Numbers 6:24). These words are still spoken today in synagogues and churches.

The people shout for joy and fall down. Joy and deep respect belong together.

But in the very next chapter, something terrible happens.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 10

Nadab and Abihu – strange fire

The death of Nadab and Abihu VERSES 1–7

1 Nadab and Abihu, the sons of Aaron, each took his censer.
A censer is a small pan for burning incense.
They put fire in it and laid incense on it.
So they brought strange fire before the LORD, which he had not commanded them.
2 Then fire came out from before the LORD and burned them up.
And they died before the LORD.
3 Then Moses said to Aaron,
"This is what the LORD spoke about when he said,
'I will show myself holy among those who come near me.
And before all the people I will be honored.'"
And Aaron was silent.
4 Moses called Mishael and Elzaphan, the sons of Uzziel, Aaron's uncle.
He said to them,
"Come here. Carry your brothers away from the holy place, out of the camp."
5 So they came and carried them in their tunics out of the camp, as Moses had said.
6 Moses said to Aaron and to his sons Eleazar and Ithamar,
"Do not let the hair of your heads hang loose, and do not tear your clothes.
Otherwise you will die, and he will be angry with the whole community.
But your brothers, the whole house of Israel, shall weep over the burning that the LORD has started.
7 Do not go out from the door of the Tent of Meeting, or you will die.
For the LORD's anointing oil is on you."
And they did what Moses said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most shocking stories in the Bible. On the day of great joy, right after God's fire accepted the offering (Chapter 9), two sons of Aaron die by this fire.

The Bible does not say very clearly what exactly their mistake was. They brought "strange fire," "which he had not commanded them." Maybe they took fire that did not come from the altar. Maybe they went into the holy place on their own and at the wrong time. Some Jewish teachers think that they were drunk, because right after this comes the rule against alcohol for priests (verse 9).

The message is serious: God is holy. You cannot serve him just the way you like. The closer you are to God, the more responsibility you carry.

"And Aaron was silent" – a father loses two sons in one day and says nothing. This silence shows deep pain, and maybe also that he accepts God's will.

As high priest, Aaron may not show the usual signs of mourning: letting his hair hang loose and tearing his clothes. He may not stop his service. Instead, the whole people is to mourn for him.

For us today, this story is hard to understand. It remains a warning not to come to God carelessly.

No wine in the holy place VERSES 8–11

8 The LORD spoke to Aaron. He said,
9 "You and your sons may not drink wine or strong drink when you go into the Tent of Meeting.
Otherwise you will die.
This is a rule forever, for all your generations.
10 You must tell the difference between what is holy and what is common,
and between what is unclean and what is clean.
11 And you must teach the people of Israel all the rules that the LORD has spoken to them through Moses."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the only time in Leviticus that God speaks directly to Aaron alone.

Whoever serves God needs a clear head. He must be able to tell what is holy and what is not.

The priests had two tasks: to serve at the holy tent and to teach the people. They were also the teachers of the people.

What the priests shall eat VERSES 12–15

12 Moses spoke to Aaron and to Eleazar and Ithamar, his sons who were left. He said,
"Take the grain offering that is left over from the LORD's offerings made by fire,
and eat it without yeast beside the altar.
For it is most holy.
13 You shall eat it in a holy place.
For it is your share and your sons' share of the LORD's offerings made by fire.
That is what I have been commanded.
14 The breast that is waved and the thigh that is lifted up you shall eat in a clean place,
you and your sons and your daughters with you.
For they are given as your share and your sons' share, from the sacrifices of the peace offerings of the people of Israel.
15 They shall bring the thigh that is lifted up and the breast that is waved
together with the fat of the offerings made by fire, to wave it before the LORD as a wave offering.
It shall belong to you and to your sons with you, as a share forever,
as the LORD has commanded."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even in the middle of the grief, the service goes on. The other priests are to eat what is theirs.

The family of the priest may also eat the breast and the thigh, the daughters too. The other part, the "most holy" part, may only be eaten by the priests themselves in the holy place.

Moses' anger and Aaron's answer VERSES 16–20

16 Moses asked carefully about the goat of the sin offering.
And look: It had been burned.
Then he was angry with Eleazar and Ithamar, the sons of Aaron who were left. He said,

17 "Why have you not eaten the sin offering in the holy place?
It is most holy, after all.
He has given it to you so that you carry the guilt of the community
and make atonement for them before the LORD.
18 Look: Its blood was not brought into the inner part of the holy place.
You certainly should have eaten it in the holy place, as I commanded."
19 Aaron answered Moses,
"Look: Today they brought their sin offering and their burnt offering before the LORD.
And things like these have happened to me.
If I had eaten the sin offering today,
would the LORD have been pleased with that?"
20 When Moses heard that, he was satisfied.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

According to the rules in Leviticus 6:26, the priests should have eaten the meat of the sin offering. Instead, they burned it. Moses is angry. After the death of Nadab and Abihu, he is afraid that another mistake will happen.

Aaron explains: How could I eat the holy offering meal on a day like this, full of grief? Would God have been pleased with that?

And Moses understands him. He agrees with Aaron.

This small story shows: God's rules are important. But they should not be followed without a heart. God sees what is going on inside a person. Grief and honesty have their place before him.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 11

Clean and unclean animals

Land animals VERSES 1–8

1 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron. He said to them,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and say,
'These are the living things that you may eat, of all the animals on the earth:
3 Any animal that has a split hoof, divided all the way through, and that chews the cud, you may eat.
4 "'But of those that chew the cud or have a split hoof, you shall not eat these:
the camel, because it chews the cud but does not have a split hoof. It is unclean to you.
5 The hyrax, because it chews the cud but does not have a split hoof. It is unclean to you.
6 The hare, because it chews the cud but does not have a split hoof. It is unclean to you.
7 The pig, because it has a split hoof, divided all the way through, but it does not chew the cud. It is unclean to you.
8 You shall not eat their meat, and you shall not touch their dead bodies.
They are unclean to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: To chew the cud means: The animal brings its food back up from its stomach and chews it again.

Now a big part of the book about "clean" and "unclean" begins (Chapters 11–15). First it is about food.

"Unclean" here does not mean dirty, disgusting or evil. It means: The Israelites should not eat these animals. All animals are created by God and are good (Genesis 1:31).

Land animals are allowed if they have two marks: a split hoof and chewing the cud. These include cattle, sheep, goats and deer.

A hyrax is a small animal that lives among rocks. It is about the size of a rabbit. The hyrax and the hare do not really chew the cud. But when they eat, they move their mouths as if they were chewing the cud. The Bible describes them the way people saw them back then.

Why these rules? Jews and Christians have thought about this a lot. Some say: for reasons of health. Others say: They are signs so that Israel is different from other peoples. The most important reason is at the end of the chapter: "Be holy, because I am holy."

To this day, many Jews eat "kosher," that is, by these rules. Muslims do not eat pork either. Most Christians do not keep these food rules. Jesus said that it is not food that makes a person unclean, but what comes out of his heart (Mark 7:18–23). Peter also had a vision about this (Acts 10).

Animals in the water VERSES 9–12

9 "'Of all the animals in the water, you may eat these:
Anything in the water that has fins and scales, in the seas and in the rivers, you may eat.
10 But anything that does not have fins and scales, in the seas and in the rivers,
anything that moves in the water, and all the living creatures in the water –
they are something disgusting to you.
11 They shall be disgusting to you.
You shall not eat their meat.
And you shall find their dead bodies disgusting.
12 Anything in the water that has no fins and no scales is something disgusting to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Fish with fins and scales are allowed, for example carp, salmon or herring. Not allowed are, for example, eels, mussels, crabs and squid.

Birds VERSES 13–19

13 "'You shall find these birds disgusting.
They shall not be eaten, because they are something disgusting:
the eagle, the vulture, the black vulture,
14 the red kite, every kind of black kite,
15 every kind of raven,
16 the horned owl, the screech owl, the gull, every kind of hawk,

17 the little owl, the cormorant, the great owl,
18 the white owl, the desert owl, the osprey,
19 the stork, every kind of heron, the hoopoe and the bat.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Today we no longer know for sure which birds are meant exactly. The old Hebrew names cannot always be translated exactly. That is why different Bibles have slightly different names.

It stands out that many of these birds are birds of prey or eat dead animals. They have to do with death and blood.

The bat is not a bird, of course. But back then, everything that flies was counted together.

Insects VERSES 20–23

20 "'All flying insects that walk on all fours are something disgusting to you.
21 But you may eat these:
of all the winged creeping animals that walk on all fours,
those that have long jointed legs for hopping on the ground.
22 Of these you may eat:
every kind of locust, every kind of katydid,
every kind of cricket and every kind of grasshopper.
23 But all other winged creeping animals that have four feet are something disgusting to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Walk on all fours" is a simple description. Insects actually have six legs. With grasshoppers, you see four legs for walking and two big legs for jumping.

In the Middle East, locusts were normal food, especially for poor people. John the Baptist also ate locusts and wild honey (Mark 1:6).

Whoever touches dead animals VERSES 24–28

24 "'You will become unclean by these:
Whoever touches their dead body shall be unclean until the evening.
25 Whoever carries any part of their dead body shall wash his clothes and be unclean until the evening.
26 "'Every animal that has a split hoof that is not divided all the way through,
or that does not chew the cud, is unclean to you.
Everyone who touches them shall be unclean.
27 All animals that walk on paws, of all the animals that walk on all fours, are unclean to you.
Whoever touches their dead body shall be unclean until the evening.
28 Whoever carries their dead body shall wash his clothes and be unclean until the evening.
They are unclean to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever touches a dead unclean animal becomes "unclean" himself. That means: For a while, he may not go into the holy tent or touch holy things.

But this lasts only "until the evening." Then, by the Jewish way of counting, a new day begins. Whoever washes his clothes is clean again afterward.

Animals that "walk on paws" are, for example, dogs, cats, lions and bears.

Small animals that creep on the ground VERSES 29–38

29 "'These are unclean to you among the small animals that creep on the ground:
the weasel, the rat, every kind of large lizard,
30 the gecko, the monitor lizard, the wall lizard, the skink and the chameleon.
31 These are unclean to you among all the creeping animals.
Whoever touches them when they are dead shall be unclean until the evening.
32 Anything that one of them falls on when it is dead shall be unclean:
any container made of wood, any clothing, any leather, any sack,
any object that is used for work.
It must be put into water.
It shall be unclean until the evening. Then it will be clean.
33 Every clay pot that one of them falls into, and everything in it, shall be unclean.
You shall break it.
34 All food that may be eaten and that is soaked in water shall be unclean.
And every drink in such a pot shall be unclean.
35 Everything that a part of their dead body falls on shall be unclean.
An oven or a stove for pots shall be broken in pieces.
They are unclean and shall be unclean to you.
36 But a spring or a cistern where water is gathered shall stay clean.
But whatever touches their dead body shall be unclean.
37 If a part of their dead body falls on seed that is to be planted, it is clean.
38 But if water has been put on the seed
and a part of their dead body falls on it,
it is unclean to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 36: A cistern is a large hole in the ground for storing water.

To us, these rules seem like rules for hygiene. Mice, rats and lizards often came into houses. If such an animal fell dead into a pot, everything had to be cleaned or thrown away.

Interesting: Flowing water in a spring or a cistern stays clean. And dry seed does too. But wet seed, or food made with water, becomes unclean. People thought that wetness passes on uncleanness.

Simple clay pots could not be cleaned well. That is why they had to be broken.

When an allowed animal dies by itself VERSES 39–40

39 "'If one of the animals that you may eat dies,
whoever touches its dead body shall be unclean until the evening.
40 Whoever eats from its dead body shall wash his clothes and be unclean until the evening.
Whoever carries its dead body shall also wash his clothes and be unclean until the evening.

You shall be holy VERSES 41–47

41 "'Every small animal that creeps on the ground is something disgusting.
It shall not be eaten.
42 Whatever crawls on its belly,
whatever walks on all fours,
and whatever has many feet,
all the small animals that creep on the ground –
you shall not eat them.
For they are something disgusting.
43 Do not make yourselves disgusting with any creeping animal.
Do not make yourselves unclean with them, so that you are not made impure by them.
44 For I am the LORD your God.
So make yourselves holy, and be holy, because I am holy.
Do not make yourselves unclean with any kind of creeping animal that moves on the ground.
45 For I am the LORD who brought you up out of the land of Egypt, to be your God.
So you shall be holy, because I am holy.
46 "'This is the law about the land animals, the birds, every living creature that moves in the water, and every creature that creeps on the ground,
47 so that you can tell the difference between the unclean and the clean,
between the animals that may be eaten and the animals that may not be eaten.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is the most important reason for all these rules: "Be holy, because I am holy." This sentence appears here for the first time. It is repeated often in Leviticus.

"Holy" means: belonging to God, set apart for God, being different. Even when they eat, that is, every day, Israel should remember: We belong to God.

This sentence is also quoted in the New Testament. Peter writes: "So you also are to be holy in all your way of life. For it is written, 'You shall be holy, for I am holy'" (1 Peter 1:15–16).

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 12

The cleansing of a mother after giving birth

After the birth of a son or a daughter VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and say,
'If a woman becomes pregnant and gives birth to a son, she shall be unclean for seven days.
She shall be unclean as in the days of her monthly period.
3 On the eighth day, the flesh of the boy's foreskin shall be circumcised.
4 Then she shall stay in the blood of her cleansing for 33 more days.
She shall not touch anything holy, and she shall not come into the holy place,
until the days of her cleansing are over.
5 But if she gives birth to a daughter,
she shall be unclean for 2 weeks, as in her period.
And then she shall stay in the blood of her cleansing for 66 more days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: To circumcise means: to cut off the foreskin of the penis.

After giving birth, a woman keeps bleeding for a few weeks. In the Bible, blood stands for life. That is why a person is seen as "unclean" when blood flows out of the body.

Important: "Unclean" does not mean dirty or sinful. Giving birth is not a sin. Children are a blessing from God (Psalm 127:3). It only means: For a while, the woman should not go into the holy tent.

This was also a protection. The mother had time to recover and did not have to do any religious duties.

Circumcision on the eighth day is the sign of the covenant that God made with Abraham (Genesis 17:10–12). Jesus was also circumcised on the eighth day (Luke 2:21).

The Bible does not say why the time after the birth of a daughter is twice as long. There are different guesses about this. Some Jewish teachers think: Because the girl herself will one day give life, her birth is honored in a special way. We do not know for sure. But it does not mean that a girl is worth less.

The offering after the cleansing VERSES 6–8

6 "'When the days of her cleansing for a son or for a daughter are over,
she shall bring to the priest at the door of the Tent of Meeting
a lamb one year old as a burnt offering,
and a young pigeon or a turtledove as a sin offering.
7 He shall bring it before the LORD and make atonement for her.
Then she will be clean from the flow of her blood.
"'This is the law for a woman who gives birth, whether to a boy or to a girl.
8 If she cannot afford a lamb,
she shall take two turtledoves or two young pigeons, one as a burnt offering and the other as a sin offering.
So the priest shall make atonement for her, and she will be clean.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "sin offering" here does not mean that the woman has sinned. It is an offering for cleansing. After it, she may come into the holy tent again and take part in worship.

The burnt offering is also a thank-you to God for the child.

Mary brought exactly this offering after Jesus was born. She and Joseph were poor. That is why they brought two doves (Luke 2:22–24).

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 13

Leprosy on the skin and on clothes

The priest examines the skin VERSES 1–8

1 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron. He said,
2 "When a person gets a swelling on his skin, or a scab, or a bright spot,
and it becomes the disease of leprosy on his skin,
he shall be brought to Aaron the priest, or to one of his sons, the priests.
3 The priest shall examine the sore on the skin.
If the hair in the sore has turned white,
and the sore looks deeper than the skin,
it is the disease of leprosy.
The priest shall examine him and declare him unclean.
4 If the bright spot on his skin is white,
but it does not look deeper than the skin,
and the hair on it has not turned white,
then the priest shall keep the sick person apart for seven days.
5 On the seventh day the priest shall examine him.
If, as far as he can see, the sore has stayed the same
and has not spread on the skin,
then the priest shall keep him apart for seven more days.
6 On the seventh day the priest shall examine him again.
If the sore has faded
and has not spread on the skin,
then the priest shall declare him clean.
It is only a scab.
He shall wash his clothes, and he will be clean.
7 But if the scab spreads on the skin
after he has shown himself to the priest to be declared clean,
he shall show himself to the priest again.
8 The priest shall examine him.
If the scab has spread on the skin,
then the priest shall declare him unclean.
It is leprosy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The WEB, our English source text, says "leprosy" here, like many Bibles. But this does not only mean the illness that we call leprosy today. The Hebrew word "tzaraat" means different skin diseases with spots, scales or open sores. Even mold on clothes and houses is called by this name (from verse 47 and in Chapter 14).

The priest is not a doctor here. He does not heal. He looks carefully and decides: May this person go on taking part in the community and in worship, or not?

He decides carefully and not too quickly. If he is not sure, he waits seven days and looks again. Sometimes another seven days. No one should be shut out unfairly.

"Keep apart" means: The sick person stays by himself for a while, as in a quarantine.

Old leprosy VERSES 9–17

9 "When a person has the disease of leprosy, he shall be brought to the priest.
10 The priest shall examine him.
If there is a white swelling on the skin,
and it has turned the hair white,
and there is raw flesh in the swelling,
11 it is an old leprosy on the skin of his body.
The priest shall declare him unclean.
He does not need to keep him apart, because he is already unclean.
12 "If the leprosy breaks out all over the skin,
and the leprosy covers all the skin of the sick person,
from his head to his feet,
as far as the priest can see,
13 then the priest shall examine him.
If the leprosy has covered his whole body,
he shall declare him clean from the disease.
It has all turned white: He is clean.
14 But whenever raw flesh can be seen on him, he shall be unclean.
15 The priest shall examine the raw flesh and declare him unclean.
The raw flesh is unclean. It is leprosy.
16 But if the raw flesh changes again and turns white,
he shall come to the priest.
17 The priest shall examine him.
If the sore has turned white,
then the priest shall declare him clean from the disease. He is clean.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This sounds strange: Whoever is completely white is clean. Whoever has raw flesh is unclean.

Probably it means: When the whole skin is white and peeling, the disease is healing. The new skin comes out underneath. But when open, raw flesh can be seen, the disease is still active.

After a boil VERSES 18–23

18 "When someone has a boil on his skin, and it has healed,
19 and in the place of the boil there is a white swelling,
or a bright spot, reddish-white,
then it shall be shown to the priest.
20 The priest shall examine it.
If it looks deeper than the skin, and the hair on it has turned white,
then the priest shall declare him unclean.
It is the disease of leprosy. It has broken out in the boil.
21 But if the priest examines it,
and there are no white hairs on it,
and it is not deeper than the skin, but it is pale,
then the priest shall keep him apart for seven days.
22 If it spreads on the skin,
then the priest shall declare him unclean. It is a

disease.
23 But if the bright spot stays in its place and has not spread,
it is the scar from the boil.
The priest shall declare him clean.

After a burn VERSES 24–28

24 "Or when someone has a burn from fire on his skin,
and the raw flesh of the burn becomes a bright spot,
reddish-white or white,
25 then the priest shall examine it.
If the hair on the bright spot has turned white,
and it looks deeper than the skin,
it is leprosy. It has broken out in the burn.
The priest shall declare him unclean. It is the disease of leprosy.
26 But if the priest examines it,
and there is no white hair on the bright spot,
and it is not deeper than the skin, but it has faded,
then the priest shall keep him apart for seven days.
27 On the seventh day the priest shall examine him.
If it has spread on the skin,
then the priest shall declare him unclean. It is the disease of leprosy.
28 If the bright spot stays in its place
and has not spread on the skin, but it is faded,
it is the swelling from the burn.
The priest shall declare him clean.
For it is the scar from the burn.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> Verse 18: A boil is a painful, swollen sore with pus.
>
> The priest looks very carefully: Is this only a scar that is healing well? Or is a disease spreading? The most important sign is always: Is it spreading or not?

On the head or in the beard VERSES 29–37

29 "When a man or a woman has a sore on the head or in the beard,
30 then the priest shall examine the sore.
If it looks deeper than the skin,
and the hair on it is yellow and thin,
then the priest shall declare him unclean.
It is an itch, a leprosy of the head or of the beard.
31 If the priest examines the sore with the itch,
and it does not look deeper than the skin,
and there is no black hair on it,
then the priest shall keep the person with the itch apart for seven days.
32 On the seventh day the priest shall examine the sore.
If the itch has not spread,
and there is no yellow hair on it,
and the itch does not look deeper than the skin,
33 then the person shall shave himself, but he shall not shave the place with the itch.
And the priest shall keep the person with the itch apart for seven more days.
34 On the seventh day the priest shall examine the itch.
If the itch has not spread on the skin,
and it does not look deeper than the skin,
then the priest shall declare him clean.
He shall wash his clothes, and he will be clean.
35 But if the itch spreads on the skin after he has been declared clean,
36 then the priest shall examine him.
If the itch has spread on the skin,
the priest does not need to look for the yellow hair. He is unclean.
37 But if, as far as he can see, the itch has stayed the same,
and black hair has grown on it,
then the itch is healed. He is clean.
The priest shall declare him clean.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> "Itch" here means an itching, scaly rash on the skin of the head.
>
> When normal, black hair grows again, it is a sign of healing.

Harmless spots and bald heads VERSES 38–44

38 "When a man or a woman has bright spots on the skin,
white bright spots,
39 then the priest shall examine them.
If the spots on the skin are a dull white,
it is a harmless rash that has broken out on the skin.
He is clean.
40 "If a man's hair has fallen out from his head, he is bald.
He is clean.
41 If his hair has fallen out from the front of his head, his forehead is bald. He is clean.
42 But if there is a reddish-white sore on the bald head or on the bald forehead,
it is leprosy breaking out on his bald head or on his bald forehead.
43 Then the priest shall examine him.
If the swelling of the sore on his bald head or on his bald forehead is reddish-white,
and it looks like leprosy on the skin,
44 he has leprosy. He is unclean.
The priest shall certainly declare him unclean.
The disease is on his head.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> Being bald is not a disease. Whoever is bald is clean. Here the Bible protects people from being shut out because of something harmless.

How a person with leprosy must live VERSES 45–46

45 "The person with leprosy who has the disease shall wear torn clothes.
He shall let the hair of his head hang loose.
He shall cover his upper lip and call out, 'Unclean! Unclean!'
46 As long as he has the disease, he shall be unclean.
He is unclean. He shall live alone.
He shall live outside the camp.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> This is very hard. The person with leprosy must wear the signs of mourning: torn clothes, loose hair, a covered mouth. He must warn others and live alone outside the camp.
>
> This protected the community from infection. But for the sick person, it meant loneliness and great suffering.
>
> That makes what Jesus does later all the more moving: He touches people with leprosy and heals them (Mark 1:40–42).

He is not afraid of them. He brings them back into the community.

Important: The Bible does not say that the disease is a punishment for sin. Today, too, we should not shut out or judge people who are sick.

Leprosy on clothes VERSES 47–59

47 "If the disease of leprosy is on a piece of clothing,
whether it is clothing of wool or clothing of linen,
48 in the threads that run lengthwise or in the threads
that run across, of linen or of wool,
or on leather, or on anything made of leather,
49 and if the spot is greenish or reddish,
on the clothing or on the leather, in the lengthwise
threads or in the crosswise threads,
or on anything made of leather,
it is the disease of leprosy.
It shall be shown to the priest.
50 The priest shall examine the spot
and keep the thing that has the spot apart for seven
days.
51 On the seventh day he shall examine the spot.
If the spot has spread,
on the clothing, in the lengthwise threads or in the
crosswise threads, or on the leather,
whatever the leather is used for,
then the spot is a destructive mildew. It is unclean.
52 He shall burn the clothing,
the lengthwise threads or the crosswise threads, of
wool or of linen,
or anything of leather that has the spot on it.
For it is a destructive mildew.
It shall be burned in the fire.
53 "If the priest examines it,
and the spot has not spread,
on the clothing, in the lengthwise threads or in the
crosswise threads, or on anything of leather,
54 then the priest shall command that they wash the
thing that has the spot on it.
And he shall keep it apart for seven more days.
55 Then the priest shall examine it after the spot has been
washed.
If the spot has not changed its color,
even if the spot has not spread,
it is unclean. You shall burn it in the fire.
It is a spot of mildew, whether the worn place is on the
inside or on the outside.
56 If the priest looks,
and the spot has faded after it was washed,
then he shall tear it out:
out of the clothing, or out of the leather, or out of the
lengthwise threads, or out of the crosswise threads.
57 If it then appears again on the clothing,
in the lengthwise threads or in the crosswise threads,
or on anything of leather,
it is spreading.
You shall burn the thing that has the spot on it with
fire.
58 But the clothing, the lengthwise threads or the
crosswise threads, or whatever is made of leather,
that you have washed, and the spot has gone away
from it,
shall be washed a second time. Then it will be clean."
59 This is the law about the disease of mildew
on clothing of wool or of linen,
in the lengthwise threads or in the crosswise threads,
or on anything of leather,
to declare it clean or to declare it unclean.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 51: Mildew is a kind of mold.

The "lengthwise threads" and the "crosswise threads" are the threads that cloth is woven from. Maybe this also means yarn that has not been woven yet.

This is about mold or fungus on cloth and leather. For this, too, the Bible uses the same word as for leprosy.

Here, too, everything is checked carefully: First the thing is washed, and they wait. Only if the mildew does not go away is the clothing burned. Clothes were very valuable back then. People did not throw them away carelessly.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 14

The cleansing after leprosy – mildew in houses

The healed person is cleansed: the two birds VERSES 1–7

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "This shall be the law for the person with leprosy on the
day he is cleansed:
He shall be brought to the priest.
3 The priest shall go out of the camp.
The priest shall examine him.
If the person with leprosy is healed from the disease of
leprosy,
4 then the priest shall command them to take for the one
who is to be cleansed
two living clean birds,
and cedar wood, scarlet cloth and hyssop.
5 The priest shall command them to kill one of the birds
in a clay pot over running water.
6 He shall take the living bird,
and the cedar wood, the scarlet cloth and the hyssop.
He shall dip them, together with the living bird, in the
blood of the bird
that was killed over the running water.
7 He shall sprinkle seven times on the one who is to be
cleansed from the leprosy,
and declare him clean.
And he shall let the living bird fly away into the open
field.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: Scarlet is a bright red color.

God heals. The priest only makes sure that the healing has happened. He goes out of the camp to the sick person. He does not wait until the sick person comes to him.

"Running water" is fresh, living water from a spring or a stream, not water that stands still.

Hyssop is a small plant with many branches. It was good for sprinkling. Cedar wood is a wood that does not rot. The red cloth is a reminder of blood, that is, of life.

One bird dies, the other flies away free. This is a strong picture: The disease and the uncleanness are carried away. The person is free and can live a new life.

Jesus said to people with leprosy whom he healed: "Go and show yourselves to the priests" (Luke 17:14). In this way, their healing was to be officially confirmed, following exactly this law.

Washing, shaving and waiting seven days VERSES 8–9

8 "The one who is to be cleansed shall wash his clothes,
shave off all his hair and bathe himself in water.
Then he will be clean.
After that he may come into the camp.
But for seven days he shall live outside his tent.
9 On the seventh day he shall shave off all his hair:
the hair on his head, his beard and his eyebrows.
He shall shave off all his hair.
He shall wash his clothes and bathe his body in water.
Then he will be clean.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The healed person starts completely new, almost like a newborn child without hair. He comes back step by step: first into the camp, and after seven days into his own tent.

The offerings on the eighth day VERSES 10–20

10 "On the eighth day he shall take two male lambs
without any fault,
one female lamb one year old without any fault,
about seven quarts of fine flour mixed with oil as a grain offering,
and about two-thirds of a pint of oil.
11 The priest who cleanses him shall set the man who is to be cleansed, and these things,
before the LORD, at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
12 "The priest shall take one of the male lambs
and bring it as a guilt offering, together with the oil.
He shall wave them before the LORD as a wave offering.
13 He shall kill the male lamb in the place where they kill the sin offering and the burnt offering, in the holy place.
For just as the sin offering belongs to the priest, so does the guilt offering.
It is most holy.
14 The priest shall take some of the blood of the guilt offering.
The priest shall put it on the tip of the right ear of the one who is to be cleansed,
on the thumb of his right hand and on the big toe of his right foot.
15 The priest shall take some of the oil
and pour it into the palm of his own left hand.
16 The priest shall dip his right finger in the oil that is in his left hand.
And with his finger he shall sprinkle some of the oil seven times before the LORD.
17 From the rest of the oil in his hand, the priest shall put some
on the tip of the right ear of the one who is to be cleansed,
on the thumb of his right hand and on the big toe of his right foot,
on top of the blood of the guilt offering.
18 The rest of the oil in the priest's hand he shall put on the head of the one who is to be cleansed.
So the priest shall make atonement for him before the LORD.
19 "The priest shall bring the sin offering
and make atonement for the one who is to be cleansed from his uncleanness.
After that he shall kill the burnt offering.
20 Then the priest shall bring the burnt offering and the grain offering on the altar.
So the priest shall make atonement for him, and he will be clean.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible gives the measures like this: three tenths of an ephah of flour and one log of oil. A log is about two-thirds of a pint.

Blood and oil on the ear, the hand and the foot – this is exactly how the priests were set apart too (Leviticus 8:23–24). The healed person is treated like a priest. That is a great honor. Whoever was shut out for a long time is now welcomed back with a ceremony. He fully belongs again, to God and to the people.

When the healed person is poor VERSES 21–32

21 "If he is poor and cannot afford so much,
he shall take one male lamb as a guilt offering, to be waved, to make atonement for him,
and about two quarts of fine flour mixed with oil as a grain offering,
and about two-thirds of a pint of oil,
22 and two turtledoves or two young pigeons, whatever he can afford.
One shall be a sin offering and the other a burnt offering.
23 "On the eighth day he shall bring them for his cleansing to the priest,
to the door of the Tent of Meeting, before the LORD.
24 The priest shall take the lamb of the guilt offering and the oil.
And the priest shall wave them before the LORD as a wave offering.
25 He shall kill the lamb of the guilt offering.
The priest shall take some of the blood of the guilt offering
and put it on the tip of the right ear of the one who is to be cleansed,
on the thumb of his right hand and on the big toe of his right foot.
26 The priest shall pour some of the oil into the palm of his own left hand.
27 And with his right finger the priest shall sprinkle some of the oil that is in his left hand

seven times before the LORD.
28 Then the priest shall put some of the oil that is in his hand
on the tip of the right ear of the one who is to be cleansed,
on the thumb of his right hand and on the big toe of his right foot,
on the place where the blood of the guilt offering is.
29 The rest of the oil in the priest's hand he shall put on the head of the one who is to be cleansed,
to make atonement for him before the LORD.
30 He shall bring one of the turtledoves or of the young pigeons, whichever he can afford,
31 of the kind he can afford:
the one as a sin offering and the other as a burnt offering, together with the grain offering.
So the priest shall make atonement before the LORD for the one who is to be cleansed."
32 This is the law for the person who had the disease of leprosy
and who cannot afford the offering for his cleansing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever was sick for a long time often could not work and was poor. That is why there is a rule for poor people: Instead of three lambs, one lamb and two doves are enough.

But the steps are exactly the same. The poor person is welcomed back with just as much honor as the rich person.

Mildew in houses VERSES 33–47

33 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron. He said,
34 "When you have come into the land of Canaan, which I give to you as your own,
and I put a spreading mildew in a house in the land you own,
35 then the owner of the house shall come and tell the priest,
'It seems to me that there is some kind of disease in the house.'
36 The priest shall command that they empty the house before the priest goes in to examine the disease.
That way nothing in the house will become unclean.
After that the priest shall go in to examine the house.
37 He shall examine the disease.
If the disease is in the walls of the house,
with hollow streaks, greenish or reddish,
and it looks deeper than the wall,
38 then the priest shall go out of the house to the door of the house
and shut up the house for seven days.
39 On the seventh day the priest shall come again and look.
If the disease has spread in the walls of the house,
40 then the priest shall command that they take out the stones that have the disease in them,
and throw them into an unclean place outside the city.
41 He shall have the inside of the house scraped all over.
They shall pour out the plaster that they scraped off into an unclean place outside the city.
42 They shall take other stones and put them in the place of those stones.
And he shall take other plaster and plaster the house.
43 "If the disease comes back and breaks out in the house after he has taken out the stones,
and after he has scraped the house, and after it was plastered,
44 then the priest shall come in and look.
If the disease has spread in the house,
it is a destructive mildew in the house. It is unclean.
45 He shall tear down the house, its stones, its wood and all the plaster of the house.
And he shall carry them out of the city into an unclean place.
46 "Also, whoever goes into the house while it is shut up shall be unclean until the evening.
47 Whoever lies down in the house shall wash his clothes.
And whoever eats in the house shall wash his clothes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This rule only applies to the time when Israel lives in solid houses in the land of Canaan. In the wilderness, they lived in tents.

"I put a spreading mildew in a house" – in the Bible, everything in the end comes from God's hand, even mildew. But this does not mean that the owner has done something evil.

The priest has the house emptied first. That way the owner does not have to lose his things. The Bible thinks very practically here.

Here, too, things are repaired first: Stones are replaced, and the walls are plastered again. Only if that does not help is the house torn down. This is still a good rule today for dangerous mold.

The cleansing of the house VERSES 48–53

48 "If the priest comes in and examines it,
and the disease has not spread in the house after the house was plastered,
then the priest shall declare the house clean.
For the disease is healed.
49 To cleanse the house, he shall take two birds, cedar wood, scarlet cloth and hyssop.
50 He shall kill one of the birds in a clay pot over running water.
51 He shall take the cedar wood, the hyssop, the scarlet cloth and the living bird.
He shall dip them in the blood of the bird that was killed, and in the running water.
And he shall sprinkle the house seven times.
52 So he shall cleanse the house
with the blood of the bird and with the running water, with the living bird, with the cedar wood, with the hyssop and with the scarlet cloth.
53 But he shall let the living bird fly away out of the city into the open field.
So he shall make atonement for the house, and it will be clean."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A house is cleansed in the same way as a person, with the two birds. A house, too, can get a new beginning.

Summary VERSES 54–57

54 This is the law for every disease of leprosy and for an itch,

55 for the destructive mildew on clothing and on a house,
56 for a swelling, for a scab and for a bright spot,
57 to teach when something is unclean and when it is clean.
This is the law about leprosy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapters 13 and 14 belong together. They show: God cares about the health of his people, about their bodies, their clothes and their homes.

And they show: Whoever had to be shut out should not stay shut out forever. There is a way back into the community.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 15

Uncleanness from fluids of the body

When a man has a discharge because of illness
VERSES 1–12

1 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron. He said,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them,
'When any man has a discharge from his body,
he is unclean because of his discharge.
3 This is his uncleanness because of his discharge:
Whether his body lets the discharge run, or his body holds it back,
it is his uncleanness.
4 "'Every bed that the man with the discharge lies on shall be unclean.
And everything he sits on shall be unclean.
5 Whoever touches his bed shall wash his clothes
and bathe himself in water, and he will be unclean until the evening.
6 Whoever sits on anything that the man with the discharge sat on
shall wash his clothes and bathe himself in water, and he will be unclean until the evening.
7 "'Whoever touches the body of the man with the discharge
shall wash his clothes and bathe himself in water, and he will be unclean until the evening.
8 "'If the man with the discharge spits on someone who is clean,
that person shall wash his clothes and bathe himself in water, and he will be unclean until the evening.
9 "'Every saddle that the man with the discharge rides on shall be unclean.
10 Whoever touches anything that was under him shall be unclean until the evening.
Whoever carries those things shall wash his clothes
and bathe himself in water, and he will be unclean until the evening.
11 "'If the man with the discharge touches someone without first rinsing his hands in water,
that person shall wash his clothes and bathe himself in water, and he will be unclean until the evening.
12 "'A clay pot that the man with the discharge touches shall be broken.
And every container made of wood shall be rinsed with water.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: A discharge is a fluid that flows out of the body.

This chapter is about fluids that come from the sexual organs. This is a very personal subject. The Bible speaks about it openly.

First it means a discharge in a man that comes from illness, for example from an infection.

Many of these rules protect against infection: The sick person's bed, saddle and dishes are cleaned. Whoever touches him washes himself. And the sick person should wash his hands before he touches others (verse 11). This is a very good rule of hygiene, thousands of years before people knew about bacteria.

Important: "Unclean" does not mean "sinful." It means: For a while, a person may not go into the holy tent.

When the man is healed VERSES 13–15

13 "'When the man with the discharge has become clean from his discharge,
he shall count seven days for his cleansing.
He shall wash his clothes and bathe his body in running water.
Then he will be clean.
14 "'On the eighth day he shall take two turtledoves or two young pigeons,
come before the LORD to the door of the Tent of Meeting,
and give them to the priest.
15 The priest shall bring them, the one as a sin offering and the other as a burnt offering.
So the priest shall make atonement for him before the LORD because of his discharge.

Release of semen and sexual relations VERSES 16–18

16 "'If a man has a release of semen,
he shall bathe his whole body in water, and he will be unclean until the evening.
17 Every piece of clothing and every piece of leather that has semen on it
shall be washed with water, and it will be unclean until the evening.
18 If a man sleeps with a woman and there is a release of semen,
they shall both bathe themselves in water, and they will be unclean until the evening.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: Semen is the fluid that comes out of a man's penis.

A release of semen is completely natural. Love between a man and a woman is good too. The Bible has a whole book that celebrates love: the Song of Songs.

Still, afterward a person counts as unclean until the evening. This only means: A person should not go into the holy tent right afterward. Sexuality and worship should be

kept apart. Among Israel's neighbors, there were religions in which sex played a part in the temple. That was not supposed to happen in Israel.
The uncleanness only lasts until the evening. You bathe, and then everything is fine again.

A woman's monthly bleeding VERSES 19–24

19 "'If a woman has a discharge, and the discharge from
her body is blood,
she shall be in her impurity for seven days.
Whoever touches her shall be unclean until the
evening.
20 "'Everything that she lies on in her impurity shall be
unclean.
And everything that she sits on shall be unclean.
21 Whoever touches her bed shall wash his clothes and
bathe himself in water, and he will be unclean until
the evening.
22 Whoever touches anything that she sits on
shall wash his clothes and bathe himself in water, and
he will be unclean until the evening.
23 If it is on the bed, or on anything she sits on, when he
touches it,
he will be unclean until the evening.
24 "'If any man sleeps with her, and some of her monthly
bleeding gets on him,
he will be unclean for seven days.
And every bed he lies on shall be unclean.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The monthly bleeding, the period, is something completely natural. God created a woman's body this way. It is not a sin and nothing dirty.

In the Bible, blood stands for life. That is why a person counts as unclean for a while when blood flows out of the body.

For the woman, this time could also be a time of rest, when she was free from some duties.

Sadly, these rules were sometimes used later to look down on women. That is not what this text means. Here very similar rules apply to men and women.

When a woman bleeds outside her normal time VERSES 25–30

25 "'If a woman has a flow of blood for many days, outside
the time of her period,
or if her bleeding lasts longer than her period,
then all the days of her unclean flow shall be as in the
days of her period. She is unclean.
26 Every bed that she lies on during all the days of her flow
shall be to her like the bed during her period.
And everything she sits on shall be unclean, like the
uncleanness of her period.
27 Whoever touches these things shall be unclean.
He shall wash his clothes and bathe himself in water,
and he will be unclean until the evening.
28 "'But if she has become clean from her flow,
she shall count seven days. After that she will be clean.
29 On the eighth day she shall take two turtledoves or two
young pigeons
and bring them to the priest, to the door of the Tent of
Meeting.
30 The priest shall bring the one as a sin offering and the
other as a burnt offering.
So the priest shall make atonement for her before the
LORD because of her unclean flow.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is about an illness: bleeding that does not stop.

The New Testament tells about a woman who suffered from bleeding like this for 12 years. The whole time she was "unclean" and shut out. Full of trust, she touched Jesus' clothes and was healed. Jesus did not scold her for touching him. He said lovingly to her: "Daughter, your faith has made you well. Go in peace" (Mark 5:25–34).

The purpose of these rules VERSES 31–33

31 "'This is how you shall keep the people of Israel away
from their uncleanness.
Otherwise they will die in their uncleanness when
they make my tabernacle unclean, which is among
them.'"
32 This is the law for the man who has a discharge,
and for the man who has a release of semen that makes
him unclean,
33 and for the woman who has her period,
and for a man or a woman who has a discharge,
and for the man who sleeps with a woman who is
unclean.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31 explains the reason for all these rules: God lives in the middle of the camp. His home is holy. That is why the people must take care to be clean.

These rules applied above all as long as the holy tent and the temple existed. In Judaism, some of them are still kept today, for example the woman's ritual bath (mikveh) after her period. Most Christians no longer keep these rules, because they believe that Jesus has made people completely clean.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 16

The great Day of Atonement – the scapegoat

Not at just any time into the Most Holy Place VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD spoke to Moses after the death of the two
sons of Aaron,
who came near before the LORD and died.
2 The LORD said to Moses,
"Tell your brother Aaron that he may not come at just
any time
into the Most Holy Place behind the curtain,
in front of the mercy seat that is on the ark.

Otherwise he will die.
For I will appear in the cloud above the mercy seat.
3 "This is how Aaron shall come into the holy place:
with a young bull as a sin offering and a ram as a burnt offering.
4 He shall put on the holy linen tunic.
He shall have the linen underpants on his body,
tie on the linen sash
and put on the linen turban.
These are the holy clothes.
He shall bathe his body in water and then put them on.
5 From the community of the people of Israel he shall take two male goats as a sin offering,
and one ram as a burnt offering.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: The ark is the holy chest with the Ten Commandments in it. The mercy seat is the golden lid on top of the ark.

This chapter is the heart of Leviticus. It describes the great Day of Atonement, in Hebrew "Yom Kippur." To this day it is the holiest day of the Jewish year.

It begins by remembering Nadab and Abihu (Chapter 10). You cannot simply come close to God however you like. But now God shows a way to do it.

On this day the high priest does not wear his splendid clothes of gold and precious stones. He wears simple white linen clothes. He comes before God humbly, like a simple servant.

The two goats VERSES 6–10

6 "Aaron shall bring the bull for the sin offering, which is for himself.
So he shall make atonement for himself and for his family.
7 He shall take the two goats
and set them before the LORD at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
8 Aaron shall cast lots for the two goats:
one lot for the LORD and the other lot for the scapegoat.
9 Aaron shall bring the goat on which the lot for the LORD falls, and offer it as a sin offering.
10 But the goat on which the lot for the scapegoat falls shall be set alive before the LORD, to make atonement with it.
He shall send it away into the wilderness as the scapegoat.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Casting lots is a way of choosing, a little like rolling dice.

In Hebrew it says here "for Azazel." We do not know for sure what this word means. Maybe it means "the goat that goes away." That is where the English translation "scapegoat" comes from. Maybe Azazel is also the name of a place in the wilderness, or of a desert demon.

We still use the word "scapegoat" today. Today it means someone who is unfairly blamed for something. Here in the Bible it is different: The goat carries the guilt of the people away, so that the people become free.

Aaron goes into the Most Holy Place VERSES 11–14

11 "Aaron shall bring the bull for the sin offering, which is for himself.
He shall make atonement for himself and for his family.
And he shall kill the bull for the sin offering, which is for himself.
12 He shall take a censer full of burning coals from the altar that stands before the LORD,
and two handfuls of sweet incense, crushed fine.
And he shall bring it behind the curtain.
13 He shall put the incense on the fire before the LORD.
The cloud of the incense shall cover the mercy seat that is on the covenant.
Then he will not die.
14 He shall take some of the bull's blood
and sprinkle it with his finger on the front of the mercy seat, toward the east.
And in front of the mercy seat he shall sprinkle some of the blood with his finger seven times.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only on this one day of the year may a person enter the Most Holy Place, and only the high priest.

The cloud of incense covers the mercy seat. So the high priest does not see God's presence directly. For no person can see God and stay alive (Exodus 33:20).

The blood is sprinkled on the mercy seat. Here, right above the Ten Commandments in the ark, the guilt is covered.

Atonement for the people and for the holy place VERSES 15–19

15 "Then he shall kill the goat for the sin offering, which is for the people.
He shall bring its blood behind the curtain.
He shall do with its blood just as he did with the bull's blood,
and sprinkle it on the mercy seat and in front of the mercy seat.
16 So he shall make atonement for the Holy Place,
because of the uncleanness of the people of Israel and because of their wrongdoings, all their sins.
He shall do the same for the Tent of Meeting,
which stands among them in the middle of their uncleanness.
17 No one shall be in the Tent of Meeting
when he goes in to make atonement in the Holy Place,
until he comes out and has made atonement
for himself, for his family and for the whole assembly of Israel.
18 "He shall go out to the altar that stands before the LORD and make atonement for it.
He shall take some of the bull's blood and some of the goat's blood
and put it all around on the horns of the altar.
19 He shall sprinkle some of the blood on it with his finger seven times.
So he shall make it clean and make it holy from the uncleanness of the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Not only the people are made clean, but also the holy place itself. All year long, the guilt of the people has piled up in

the holy place like dirt. Now everything is made clean. So God can go on living in the middle of his people.

"In the middle of their uncleanness" – God does not live with perfect people. He lives among people with faults. And he gives a way for this to stay possible.

The scapegoat carries the guilt away VERSES 20–22

20 "When he has finished making atonement for the Holy Place, the Tent of Meeting and the altar,
he shall bring the living goat.
21 Aaron shall lay both his hands on the head of the living goat.
Over it he shall confess all the guilt of the people of Israel,
all their wrongdoings, all their sins.
He shall put them on the head of the goat.
And he shall send it away into the wilderness with a man who is ready for this.
22 So the goat shall carry all their guilt on itself into a lonely land.
And the man shall let the goat go free in the wilderness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a very vivid picture. All the sins of the people are said out loud and laid on the goat. Then the goat is led far away, into the wilderness. The guilt is gone. It does not come back.

Psalm 103:12 says: "As far as the east is from the west, so far has he removed our sins from us" (Psalm 103:12).

Christians see here a picture of Jesus. John the Baptist said about him: "Look, there is the Lamb of God! He takes away the sin of the world!" (John 1:29). The letter to the Hebrews in the New Testament compares Jesus in detail with the high priest on the Day of Atonement (Hebrews 9).

After the service in the Most Holy Place VERSES 23–28

23 "Aaron shall go into the Tent of Meeting.
He shall take off the linen clothes that he put on when he went into the Holy Place,
and leave them there.
24 Then he shall bathe himself in water in a holy place and put on his clothes.
He shall come out and bring his burnt offering and the burnt offering of the people.
So he shall make atonement for himself and for the people.
25 He shall burn the fat of the sin offering on the altar.
26 "The man who let the goat go as the scapegoat
shall wash his clothes and bathe his body in water.
After that he may come into the camp.
27 The bull for the sin offering and the goat for the sin offering,
whose blood was brought into the Holy Place to make atonement,
shall be carried outside the camp.
They shall burn their skins, their meat and their dung with fire.
28 Whoever burns them shall wash his clothes and bathe his body in water.
After that he may come into the camp.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the service, Aaron puts on his splendid clothes again (his "clothes" in verse 24). He brings the burnt offerings. Now the people are at peace with God and can give themselves completely to him.

Yom Kippur – a day for all time VERSES 29–34

29 "This shall be a rule for you forever:
In the seventh month, on the tenth day of the month, you shall humble yourselves.
And you shall do no work at all.
This is for those who were born in the land and for the foreigner who lives among you.
30 For on this day atonement will be made for you, to make you clean.
You will be clean from all your sins before the LORD.
31 It is a Sabbath for you, a day of complete rest.
And you shall humble yourselves.
This is a rule forever.
32 The priest who is anointed and set apart to serve as priest in his father's place
shall make the atonement.
He shall put on the linen clothes, the holy clothes.
33 He shall make atonement for the Most Holy Place.
He shall make atonement for the Tent of Meeting and for the altar.
And he shall make atonement for the priests and for all the people of the assembly.
34 "This shall be a rule for you forever:
to make atonement for the people of Israel once a year because of all their sins."
And it was done as the LORD commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31: The Sabbath is the holy day of rest.

The seventh month is in the fall, in September or October.

"Humbling yourselves" means above all: fasting. To this day, Jews fast for 25 hours on Yom Kippur. They do not eat or drink anything. They pray in the synagogue, think about their lives and ask God and other people for forgiveness.

"You will be clean from all your sins" – that is the great promise of this day. Once a year, everyone may start completely new.

The foreigner who lives in Israel is also to rest on this day. God's atonement is for everyone.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 17

The blood is the life

Sacrifices only at the holy tent VERSES 1–9

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,

2 "Speak to Aaron, to his sons, and to all the people of Israel.
Tell them,
'This is what the LORD has commanded:
3 Someone from the house of Israel might kill a bull, a lamb, or a goat
in the camp or outside the camp.
4 If he does not bring it to the door of the Tent of Meeting
to give it as an offering to the LORD in front of the LORD's tabernacle,
then that man is guilty of blood.
He has shed blood.
That man shall be cut off from his people.
5 This rule is there so that the people of Israel bring their sacrifices to the LORD.
Until now they have sacrificed them out in the open field.
Now they shall bring them to the door of the Tent of Meeting, to the priest.
There they shall sacrifice them to the LORD as peace offerings.
6 The priest shall sprinkle the blood on the LORD's altar at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
He shall burn the fat as a pleasant smell for the LORD.
7 They shall no longer bring their sacrifices to the goat idols.
They have been unfaithful to God with them, like a prostitute.
This shall be a rule for them forever, for all their generations.'
8 "Tell them,
'Someone from the house of Israel,
or one of the foreigners who live among them,
might offer a burnt offering or another sacrifice.
9 If he does not bring it to the door of the Tent of Meeting to sacrifice it to the LORD,
then that man shall be cut off from his people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: "Cut off from his people" means: He no longer belongs to the people of God.

In the wilderness, everyone lived close to the holy tent. If someone wanted to kill a bull, a sheep, or a goat, he was to bring it to the holy tent as a peace offering. So every meal with meat became a meal with God.

Back then, many people believed in spirits in the wilderness that looked like male goats. Our English source text says "goat idols." That means idols in the shape of a goat. Some Israelites secretly made sacrifices to these spirits. That is to stop.

Later, when Israel lived in the whole land, people were also allowed to kill animals at home (Deuteronomy 12:15–16). But they were still not allowed to eat the blood.

Why no one may eat blood VERSES 10–14

10 "'Someone from the house of Israel,
or one of the foreigners who live among them,
might eat any kind of blood.
Then I will turn against that person who eats blood.
I will cut him off from his people.
11 For the life of the body is in the blood.
I have given it to you on the altar, to make atonement for your lives.
For it is the blood that makes atonement, because the life is in it.
12 That is why I have said to the people of Israel,
"No one among you may eat blood.
And no foreigner who lives among you may eat blood."
13 "'Someone from the people of Israel,
or one of the foreigners who live among them,
might hunt an animal or a bird that may be eaten.
Then he shall pour out its blood and cover it with dust.
14 For the life of every living body is in its blood.
Its blood is its life.
That is why I said to the people of Israel,
"You shall not eat the blood of any kind of living body.
For the life of every living body is its blood.
Whoever eats it shall be cut off."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Atonement means: The guilt is taken away, and there is peace with God again.

Verse 11 is one of the most important verses about the sacrifices: "For the life of the body is in the blood." The blood stands for life. And life belongs to God, not to people.

That is why the blood is so important in the sacrifices: One life is given for another life. That is how atonement happens.

Even someone who hunts an animal is to honor the blood. He is to cover it with dust, almost like a burial. That shows respect for the life of the animal.

Christians see a pointer to Jesus here. The New Testament says: "And without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness" (Hebrews 9:22). And at the Last Supper, Jesus says about the wine: "this is my blood of the new covenant, which is poured out for many for the forgiveness of sins" (Matthew 26:28).

Someone who eats an animal that died by itself VERSES 15–16

15 "'Someone might eat an animal that died by itself, or one that wild animals have torn.
It does not matter whether he was born in Israel or is a foreigner.
He shall wash his clothes and bathe in water.
He is unclean until the evening.
Then he is clean.
16 But if he does not wash his clothes or bathe his body, then he shall carry his guilt.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An animal that died by itself has not been drained of its blood. The blood is still in it. That is why it makes a person unclean.

Someone who ate it anyway, for example because of hunger, can wash and is clean again in the evening. The only bad thing is to simply ignore the cleansing.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 18

Rules for sexuality and family

Not like in Egypt and not like in Canaan VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD said to Moses,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them,
'I am the LORD your God.
3 You shall not do what people do in the land of Egypt,
where you lived.
And you shall not do what people do in the land of
Canaan, where I am bringing you.
You shall not live by their rules.
4 You shall do what my laws say.
You shall keep my rules and live by them.
I am the LORD your God.
5 So you shall keep my rules and my laws.
Whoever does them will live by them.
I am the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel is to live differently from the nations around it. God's commandments are not a burden. They are a way to life: "Whoever does them will live by them."

This chapter is about sexuality and family. The Bible speaks openly about these things. The goal is to protect the family, especially the weaker people in the family.

No sex with close relatives VERSES 6–18

6 "'None of you shall come near any close relative to have
sex with them.
I am the LORD.
7 "'You shall not have sex with your father.
And you shall not have sex with your mother.
She is your mother. You shall not have sex with her.
8 "'You shall not have sex with your father's wife.
She belongs to your father.
9 "'You shall not have sex with your sister,
the daughter of your father or the daughter of your
mother,
whether she was born at home or somewhere else.
10 "'You shall not have sex with your son's daughter or
your daughter's daughter.
For their body is your own body.
11 "'You shall not have sex with the daughter of your
father's wife, whom your father fathered.
She is your sister.
12 "'You shall not have sex with your father's sister.
She is a close relative of your father.
13 "'You shall not have sex with your mother's sister.
For she is a close relative of your mother.
14 "'You shall not have sex with your father's brother.
You shall not come near his wife. She is your aunt.
15 "'You shall not have sex with your daughter-in-law.
She is your son's wife. You shall not have sex with her.
16 "'You shall not have sex with your brother's wife.
She belongs to your brother.
17 "'You shall not have sex with a woman and her
daughter.
You shall not take her son's daughter or her daughter's
daughter to have sex with her.
They are close relatives. It is wicked.
18 "'You shall not marry your wife's sister as well,
so that they become rivals, and have sex with her while
your wife is still alive.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Our English source text says "uncover the nakedness." That is an old, discreet expression for sexual intercourse. It means: to sleep with someone.

These rules forbid sex between close relatives. This is called incest. To this day it is forbidden in almost all countries. It destroys families and hurts children and young people very badly.

Back then, many generations often lived together in one large family. These rules protected everyone, especially the women and girls, from abuse within the family.

Verse 18 is a reminder of Jacob. He married two sisters, Leah and Rachel. That led to a lot of jealousy and fighting (Genesis 29–30).

Verse 16 has an exception: If a brother died without children, his brother was to marry the widow (Deuteronomy 25:5–6).

Other forbidden acts VERSES 19–23

19 "'You shall not come near a woman to have sex with
her while she is unclean because of her monthly
period.
20 "'You shall not sleep with your neighbor's wife and
make yourself unclean with her.
21 "'You shall not give any of your children as a sacrifice to
Molech.
You shall not dishonor the name of your God. I am the
LORD.
22 "'You shall not sleep with a man the way one sleeps with
a woman.
That is disgusting.
23 "'You shall not sleep with any animal and make
yourself unclean with it.
And no woman may give herself to an animal to have
sex with it.
That is a perversion.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20 forbids adultery. That is also in the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:14).

Verse 21: Molech was a god of the neighboring nations. Children were sacrificed and burned for him. For Israel this is one of the worst crimes of all. The Bible condemns it sharply again and again (for example Jeremiah 7:31).

Verse 22 is about sex between men. Today people understand this passage in very different ways:

Many Jews and Christians, especially in traditional congregations, see it as a lasting commandment of God.

Other Jews and Christians say: This rule must be understood from its own time. Back then it may have been about certain practices, for example the worship of other nations, or violence and exploitation. Loving, faithful partnerships as we know them today were not in view back then.

What matters: This passage must never be used to justify hatred, mockery, or violence against people. The Bible also says: "You shall love your neighbor as yourself" (Leviticus 19:18). Every human being is created in God's image (Genesis 1:27).

The land vomits out its people VERSES 24–30

24 "'Do not make yourselves unclean by any of these things.
For the nations that I am driving out ahead of you made themselves unclean by all these things.
25 The land became unclean.
So I punished it for its guilt.
And the land vomited out the people who lived in it.
26 So you shall keep my rules and my laws.
You shall not do any of these disgusting things.
This is true for those born in Israel and for the foreigners who live among you.
27 For the people of the land who were there before you did all these disgusting things,
and the land became unclean.
28 Keep my rules, so that the land does not vomit you out too when you make it unclean,
just as it vomited out the nation that was there before you.
29 "'For whoever does any of these disgusting things shall be cut off from his people.
30 So you shall do what I require.
Do not live by any of these disgusting customs that people practiced before you.
And do not make yourselves unclean by them.
I am the LORD your God.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the land is almost like a living being. When the people in it do wrong, it feels "sick" and vomits them out.

This is a serious warning to Israel: You are not safe either if you live like this. The land is a gift. It is not something you simply own forever.

Later in Israel's history, the people really were taken away into exile. The prophets saw this as the result of Israel not keeping God's commandments.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 19

Be holy – love your neighbor as yourself

You shall be holy VERSES 1–4

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Speak to the whole community of the people of Israel and tell them,
'You shall be holy, because I, the LORD your God, am holy.
3 "'Each one of you shall respect his mother and his father.
And you shall keep my Sabbaths.
I am the LORD your God.
4 "'Do not turn to idols.
And do not make gods out of melted metal for yourselves.
I am the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chapter 19 is one of the most important chapters in the whole Bible. It shows what "being holy" means in everyday life.

Being holy does not only mean being devout at worship. It means doing what is good, fair, and loving in all of life: at work, in the field, in court, with neighbors, with foreigners, with old people, and with people with disabilities.

Many commandments here are a reminder of the Ten Commandments: honor your parents, keep the Sabbath, no idols.

Again and again it says: "I am the LORD." That is the reason: Because God is like this, we are to be like this too.

The peace offering VERSES 5–8

5 "'When you bring a peace offering to the LORD,
you shall offer it in the right way, so that you are accepted.
6 It shall be eaten on the day you offer it, and on the next day.
Whatever is left over until the third day shall be burned with fire.
7 If someone still eats some of it on the third day, it is disgusting.
It will not be accepted.
8 And everyone who eats it shall carry his guilt.
For he has dishonored what is holy to the LORD.
That person shall be cut off from his people.

Leave something for the poor VERSES 9–10

9 "'When you bring in the harvest of your land,
you shall not harvest your field all the way to the corners.
And you shall not pick up the grain that is left lying after the harvest.
10 You shall not go over your vineyard a second time.
And you shall not pick up the grapes that have fallen down.
You shall leave them for the poor and for the foreigner.
I am the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a social rule: The farmers are not to keep everything for themselves. The edges of the field and what is left lying belong to the poor and the foreigners. That way, people without land of their own could also find something to eat.

The poor do not just receive a handout. They work and gather for themselves. That way they keep their dignity.

The book of Ruth tells how Ruth, a poor foreign woman, gathers grain in the field of Boaz (Ruth 2). That is how a wonderful story begins.

Deal honestly and fairly with each other VERSES 11–16

11 "'You shall not steal.
"'You shall not lie.
"'You shall not cheat one another.
12 "'You shall not swear falsely by my name
and so dishonor the name of your God.
I am the LORD.
13 "'You shall not oppress your neighbor or rob him.
"'You shall not keep the pay of a hired worker with you
overnight until the morning.
14 "'You shall not curse a deaf person.
And you shall not put something in the way of a blind
person so that he trips.
But you shall fear your God.
I am the LORD.
15 "'You shall not be unfair when you judge.
You shall not favor the poor, and you shall not favor
the powerful.
You shall judge your neighbor fairly.
16 "'You shall not go around spreading lies about others
among your people.
"'You shall not put the life of your neighbor in danger.
I am the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A hired worker here is a worker who is hired for only one day. He needs his pay that same evening to buy food for his family. That is why he is to be paid right away.

A deaf person does not hear the curse. A blind person does not see what is in the way. You could think: Nobody will notice. But God sees it. That is why it says: "But you shall fear your God." Whoever mocks or harms weak people acts against God.

In court, everyone is to be treated the same. The rich are not to be favored. But the poor are not to be favored out of pity either. Justice applies to everyone.

"Put the life of your neighbor in danger" may also mean: to stand by and do nothing when someone is in danger. Jews understand this verse like this: You must help when another person's life is in danger.

Love your neighbor as yourself VERSES 17–18

17 "'You shall not hate your brother in your heart.
You shall openly correct your neighbor,
so that you do not carry guilt because of him.
18 "'You shall not take revenge.
And you shall not hold a grudge against the people of
your nation.
But you shall love your neighbor as yourself.
I am the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is one of the most famous sentences in the Bible: "You shall love your neighbor as yourself."

Jesus called it one of the two most important commandments, together with the commandment to love God with all your heart (Mark 12:29–31). The famous Jewish teacher Rabbi Akiva also said: This is the most important principle of the Torah.

The order is interesting: First it says: Do not hate your brother in your heart. Then it says: Speak openly with your neighbor. If someone has hurt you, you are to tell him, instead of holding a secret grudge. Honest words are better than silent hate.

"As yourself" – this assumes that you may also accept yourself.

Who is my neighbor? Jesus answered this with the story of the good Samaritan (Luke 10:25–37). And already in this chapter, in verse 34, the commandment is widened to include the foreigner.

Do not mix things VERSE 19

19 "'You shall keep my rules.
"'You shall not breed two different kinds of animals
with each other.
"'You shall not sow your field with two different kinds
of seed.
"'Do not wear clothes made of two different kinds of
material.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Why these rules? The Bible does not explain it. Maybe it is meant to remind people of creation, where God created everything "each according to its kind" (Genesis 1). The order of creation is to be respected.

Later it is explained that the two materials are wool and linen (Deuteronomy 22:11). Some Jews still pay attention to this today.

A case with a slave woman VERSES 20–22

20 "'A man might sleep with a woman who is a slave.
She is promised in marriage to another man,
but she has not yet been bought free or given her
freedom.
Then they shall be punished.
But they shall not be put to death, because she was not
free.
21 He shall bring his guilt offering to the LORD, to the
door of the Tent of Meeting.
It shall be a ram as a guilt offering.
22 With the ram of the guilt offering, the priest shall
make atonement for him before the LORD
for the sin he has committed.
Then the sin he has committed will be forgiven him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a difficult case from a time when there was slavery. If a free woman who was engaged slept with another man, it counted as adultery, and the punishment was death (Deuteronomy 22:23–24). With a slave woman the situation was different, because she could not freely decide for herself.

For us today it is hard to bear that people were slaves. Here the Bible describes the world as it was back then. It tries to give rules for justice in that world. Slavery itself is not an ideal of the Bible. Israel was always to remember that it had been a slave in Egypt itself.

The fruit of young trees VERSES 23–25

23 "'When you come into the land and plant all kinds of
fruit trees,
you shall treat their fruit as forbidden.
For three years it shall be forbidden to you. It shall not
be eaten.
24 But in the fourth year all its fruit shall be holy, to praise
the LORD.
25 In the fifth year you may eat its fruit.
So the trees will give you more and more fruit.

I am the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Young trees bear only a few small fruits in their first years. If you do not pick them, the trees grow stronger. That is also a good rule for growing fruit.

The first good fruit in the fourth year belongs to God, as a thank-you. Only after that may you eat from it yourself.

No pagan customs VERSES 26–31

26 "'You shall not eat any meat with the blood still in it.
You shall not use magic spells, and you shall not practice sorcery.
27 "'You shall not cut the hair on the sides of your head.
And you shall not trim the edge of your beard.
28 "'You shall not make any cuts in your skin for the dead.
And you shall not tattoo any marks on yourselves.
I am the LORD.
29 "'Do not dishonor your daughter by making her a prostitute.
Otherwise the land will turn to prostitution, and the land will become full of wickedness.
30 "'You shall keep my Sabbaths and honor my holy place.
I am the LORD.
31 "'Do not turn to people who call up the dead, or to fortune-tellers.
Do not go to them, so that you do not become unclean through them.
I am the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is about customs that the nations around Israel had. When they mourned, they cut their skin and cut their hair in a special way to honor the gods of the dead. Israel is not to do this.

Verse 27 is where some devout Jews get the custom of wearing long curls at the temples, called "payot."

Verse 28 also mentions tattoos. Back then they were often signs of foreign gods or marks for slaves. Jews and Christians think differently about whether this ban also applies to tattoos today.

Verse 29 protects daughters. Fathers in need sometimes sold their daughters into prostitution. This is strictly forbidden here.

Magic, fortune-telling, and calling up the dead are forbidden. Whoever trusts God does not need fortune-tellers to learn about the future.

Old people and foreigners VERSES 32–34

32 "'You shall stand up in front of a gray head, and you shall honor old people.
And you shall fear your God.
I am the LORD.
33 "'If a foreigner lives with you in your land, you shall not do him wrong.
34 The foreigner who lives with you shall be to you like someone born among you.
And you shall love him as yourself.
For you yourselves lived as foreigners in the land of Egypt.
I am the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Old people are to be honored. A "gray head" is a person with gray hair. When an old person comes into the room, you stand up. That is a sign of respect.

Verse 34 is very special: The commandment to love your neighbor also applies to the foreigner, the person from another country. "And you shall love him as yourself."

The reason: "For you yourselves lived as foreigners in the land of Egypt." Israel knows how it feels to be oppressed as a foreigner. That is why they are to treat foreigners well. This commandment, in these or similar words, is in the Torah more than 30 times.

Honest measures and weights VERSES 35–37

35 "'You shall not be unfair when you judge,
or when you measure length, weight, or amount.
36 You shall have honest scales and honest weights,
an honest measure for dry things and an honest measure for liquids.
I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt.
37 "'You shall keep all my rules and all my laws, and do them.
I am the LORD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible names the measures ephah (for grain) and hin (for liquids) here. An ephah is about 6 gallons. A hin is about 1 gallon.

Back then, traders often cheated with false weights and measures. For example, someone who used a slightly lighter weight sold less than the customer paid for. God says: That is wrong. Honesty in business is part of being holy.

The chapter ends the way it began: with God, who set his people free. Because God set Israel free, Israel is to live in a fair and loving way.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 20

Punishments for serious wrongs

Child sacrifice for Molech and calling up the dead VERSES 1–6

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Also tell the people of Israel,
'Someone from the people of Israel,
or one of the foreigners who live in Israel,
might give one of his children to Molech.
Then he must be put to death.
The people of the land shall stone him with stones.
3 And I myself will turn against that person
and cut him off from his people.

For he has given one of his children to Molech.
So he has made my holy place unclean and dishonored my holy name.
4 But the people of the land might close their eyes to that person
when he gives one of his children to Molech,
and not put him to death.
5 Then I will turn against that man and against his family.
I will cut him off from his people.
I will also cut off all who follow him
and are unfaithful to me with Molech, like a prostitute.
6 "'Someone might turn to people who call up the dead,
and to fortune-tellers,
and be unfaithful to me with them, like a prostitute.
I will turn against that person
and cut him off from his people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Chapter 18 many things were forbidden. In Chapter 20 the punishments for them are given. Many of these punishments are very harsh. Often it is the death penalty. That is hard for us to read today.

At the very beginning is the worst crime: burning children as a sacrifice for the god Molech.

Verse 4 is important: Whoever looks away shares the guilt. A community must not stay silent when violence is done to children.

Whoever turns to foreign gods or fortune-tellers is compared to an unfaithful wife. God and his people are like a married couple.

Be holy VERSES 7–8

7 "'So make yourselves holy, and be holy, for I am the LORD your God.
8 You shall keep my rules and do them.
I am the LORD, who makes you holy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"I am the LORD, who makes you holy." Holiness is not only something people achieve. God himself makes his people holy. People answer by living by God's commandments.

The punishments VERSES 9–21

9 "'Everyone who curses his father or his mother must be put to death.
He has cursed his father or his mother.
His blood shall be on himself.
10 "'A man might commit adultery with another man's wife,
with the wife of his neighbor.
Then the man and the woman who committed adultery must be put to death.
11 "'A man might sleep with his father's wife.
Then he has dishonored his father.
Both of them must be put to death.
Their blood shall be on themselves.
12 "'If a man sleeps with his daughter-in-law, both of them must be put to death.
They have committed a perversion.
Their blood shall be on themselves.
13 "'If a man sleeps with a man the way one sleeps with a woman,
both of them have done something disgusting.
They must be put to death.
Their blood shall be on themselves.
14 "'If a man marries a woman and her mother, it is wicked.
They shall be burned with fire, both he and the two women,
so that there is no wickedness among you.
15 "'If a man sleeps with an animal, he must be put to death.
And you shall kill the animal too.
16 "'If a woman goes to an animal to have sex with it,
you shall kill the woman and the animal.
They must be put to death.
Their blood shall be on them.
17 "'A man might take his sister, his father's daughter or his mother's daughter.
He sees her naked, and she sees him naked.
That is a shameful thing.
They shall be cut off in front of the people of their nation.
He has had sex with his sister.
He shall carry his guilt.
18 "'A man might sleep with a woman during her monthly period and have sex with her.
Then he has uncovered the source of her blood,
and she has uncovered the source of her blood.
Both of them shall be cut off from their people.
19 "'You shall not have sex with your mother's sister or your father's sister.
For whoever does that has exposed the body of his close relative.
They shall carry their guilt.
20 "'If a man sleeps with his uncle's wife,
he has dishonored his uncle.
They shall carry their sin. They shall die without children.
21 "'If a man takes his brother's wife, it is something unclean.
He has dishonored his brother.
They shall be without children.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"His blood shall be on himself" means: He himself is to blame for his death. No one else carries the guilt for it.

These punishments are shocking to us today. They must be understood from their own time. Back then there were no prisons. The family was the foundation of the whole society. Whoever destroyed it put the whole people in danger.

In later Judaism, the teachers set up very strict rules before anyone could be sentenced to death: for example, two eyewitnesses and a warning beforehand. So the death penalty was almost never carried out. A court that sentenced one person to death in 70 years was called a "murderous court."

The New Testament tells how a woman is caught in adultery and brought to Jesus. People want to stone her according to this law. Jesus says: "Whoever among you has never sinned may throw the first stone at her." One after another they go away. And Jesus says to her: "I don't condemn you either. You may go. From now on, stop sinning" (John 8:1–11).

For verse 13, the same is true as for Leviticus 18:22: Jews and Christians understand this passage differently today. But it must never justify hatred or violence against people. The large Jewish and Christian communities today reject carrying out such punishments.

"Die without children" is not a punishment that people carry out. It means: God himself will judge this.

God has set you apart from the nations VERSES 22–26

22 "'So you shall keep all my rules and all my laws, and do them.
Then the land where I am bringing you to live will not vomit you out.
23 You shall not live by the customs of the nation that I am driving out ahead of you.
For they did all these things, and that is why I came to hate them.
24 But I have said to you,
"You shall take their land as your own.
I will give it to you to own, a land flowing with milk and honey."
I am the LORD your God, who has set you apart from the nations.
25 "'So you shall tell the difference between clean and unclean animals,
and between unclean and clean birds.
Do not make yourselves disgusting by animals, by birds,
or by anything that swarms on the ground,
which I have set apart for you as unclean.
26 You shall be holy to me, for I, the LORD, am holy.
And I have set you apart from the nations so that you belong to me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A beautiful play on words: Just as Israel tells the difference between clean and unclean animals, God has chosen Israel from all the nations and "set it apart." Israel belongs to God.

That does not mean that Israel is better than other nations. It means: Israel has a special task. It is to show what a life with God looks like.

People who call up the dead VERSE 27

27 "'A man or a woman who calls up the dead or is a fortune-teller must be put to death.
They shall be stoned with stones.
Their blood shall be on themselves.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This punishment is very harsh too. Sadly, in the course of history, passages like this were misused, for example in the witch hunts in Europe. There, many innocent people, mostly women, were tortured and killed. That was a grave injustice and a misuse of the Bible.

The point of this passage is: Israel is not to rely on spirits and the dead, but only on the living God.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 21

Special rules for the priests

Mourning for the dead VERSES 1–6

1 The LORD said to Moses,
"Speak to the priests, the sons of Aaron, and tell them,
'A priest shall not make himself unclean for a dead person among his people.
2 But he may do it for his closest relatives:
for his mother, his father, his son, his daughter, his brother,
3 and for his sister who is still a virgin and close to him, because she has no husband.
For her he may make himself unclean.
4 He is a leader among his people.
So he shall not make himself unclean and dishonor himself.
5 "'The priests shall not shave their heads bald,
or shave off the edges of their beards,
or make any cuts in their skin.
6 They shall be holy to their God
and not dishonor the name of their God.
For they offer the LORD's offerings made by fire, the food of their God.
So they shall be holy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever touches a dead person or is in the same room becomes unclean (Numbers 19:11–14). The priests are to avoid this as much as they can, so that they can do their service. Serving God has to do with life, not with death.

But for his closest relatives a priest may mourn and make himself unclean. God understands grief.

The sister is named separately when she is not married. Then she still belongs to his family. When she is married, her husband takes care of her burial.

"The food of their God" is a picture for the offerings, like a meal you prepare for a guest.

The marriage of the priests VERSES 7–9

7 "'They shall not marry a woman who is a prostitute or who has been dishonored.
And a priest shall not marry a woman who is divorced from her husband.
For he is holy to his God.
8 So you shall treat him as holy, for he offers the food of your God.
He shall be holy to you, for I, the LORD, who make you holy, am holy.
9 "'If a priest's daughter dishonors herself by becoming a prostitute,
she dishonors her father.
She shall be burned with fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Stricter rules apply to priests than to the rest of the people. The closer you serve God, the higher the demands.

These rules say nothing about the worth of divorced women. Other Israelites were allowed to marry divorced women (Deuteronomy 24:2).

The punishment in verse 9 is terribly harsh. It shows how closely the honor of the priest's family was tied to the holy place back then. Here, too: In later Judaism, strict court rules made such punishments almost impossible.

The high priest VERSES 10–15

10 "'The high priest is the one among his brothers
on whose head the anointing oil was poured.
He has been set apart to wear the holy clothes.
He shall not let the hair of his head hang loose, and he shall not tear his clothes.
11 He must not go near any dead body.
He must not make himself unclean even for his father or his mother.
12 He shall not leave the holy place,
and he shall not dishonor the holy place of his God.
For the anointing oil of his God is on him like a crown.
I am the LORD.
13 "'He shall marry a woman who is still a virgin.
14 He shall not marry a widow, a divorced woman, a woman who has been dishonored, or a prostitute.
He shall marry a virgin from his own people.
15 He shall not dishonor his children among his people,
for I am the LORD, who makes him holy.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The strictest rules apply to the high priest. He may not even go to his parents' funeral. He belongs completely to the holy place.

That sounds harsh. But it shows: His service for the whole people is so important that he is not to interrupt it, even when he is grieving. Let us remember Aaron, who was not allowed to mourn after the death of his sons (Leviticus 10:6).

"He shall not leave the holy place" probably means here: He is not to interrupt his service in the holy place to take part in a funeral.

Priests with physical disabilities VERSES 16–24

16 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
17 "Say to Aaron,
'None of your descendants, in all their generations,
who has a physical defect
may come near to offer the food of his God.
18 For no man who has a defect shall come near:
no one who is blind or lame, no one with a flat nose or any other deformity,
19 no man with an injured foot or an injured hand,
20 no one with a hunched back, no one who is very short,
no one with a defect in his eye,
no one with an itching rash or scabs,
and no one with damaged testicles.
21 No man among the descendants of Aaron the priest
who has a defect
shall come near to offer the LORD's offerings made by fire.
Because he has a defect, he shall not come near to offer the food of his God.
22 He may eat the food of his God,
from the most holy offerings and from the holy offerings.
23 But he shall not go near the curtain or come near the altar, because he has a defect.
That way he will not dishonor my holy places.
For I am the LORD, who makes them holy.'"
24 So Moses spoke to Aaron, to his sons, and to all the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a passage that is very hard for us today. People with disabilities may not serve at the altar.

It must be understood from its own time: The animals for the offerings had to be "without defect" (Leviticus 22). The priests who stood at the altar were to be like that too. It was about an outward picture of God's perfection.

But verse 22 is important: A priest with a disability stays a priest. He belongs to the priest family. He may eat from the most holy offerings, which is the holiest food a priest may eat. He is not thrown out. He does not lose his place with God. He only has a different task.

This rule applied only to serving at the altar. It says nothing about the worth of a person before God. Elsewhere the Bible says: "Man looks at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart" (1 Samuel 16:7).

Jesus turned especially to the blind, the lame, and the sick. He healed them and invited them to his table (Luke 14:13, 21).

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 22

The holy gifts and the animals for the offerings

When a priest is unclean VERSES 1–9

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Tell Aaron and his sons to be careful with the holy gifts of the people of Israel,
which they set apart for me.
They shall not dishonor my holy name.
I am the LORD.
3 Tell them,
'One of all your descendants, in all your generations,
might come near the holy gifts that the people of Israel
set apart for the LORD
while he is unclean.
Then that person shall be cut off from my presence.
I am the LORD.
4 "'One of the descendants of Aaron might have leprosy or a discharge from his body.
He shall not eat from the holy gifts until he is clean.
Someone might touch anything that has become unclean through a dead person,
or a man might have an emission of semen,

5 or someone might touch a small creeping animal that
makes him unclean,
or a person who makes him unclean, whatever kind of
uncleanness it is.
6 Whoever touches anything like this is unclean until
the evening.
He shall not eat from the holy gifts unless he has
bathed his body in water.
7 When the sun has gone down, he is clean.
After that he may eat from the holy gifts, because that
is his food.
8 He shall not eat an animal that died by itself or was torn
by wild animals,
and so make himself unclean.
I am the LORD.
9 "'So they shall keep my command.
Otherwise they will carry sin for it and die because of
it, because they dishonored what is holy.
I am the LORD, who makes them holy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The priests lived from the offerings. But this applies to them too: Whoever is unclean may not eat from the holy gifts. He must wait until he is clean again.

"Because that is his food" – the offerings are the daily bread of the priests. God provides for them. But they are to handle the offerings with deep respect.

Who may eat from the holy gifts VERSES 10–16

10 "'No outsider may eat from the holy gifts.
A foreigner who lives with a priest, or a hired worker,
shall not eat from the holy gifts.
11 But if a priest buys a slave with his money, the slave
may eat from them.
And those who are born in his house may eat from his
food.
12 If a priest's daughter marries a man who is not a priest,
she shall not eat from the heave offering of the holy
gifts.
13 But a priest's daughter might become a widow or be
divorced and have no child.
She might return to her father's house, as when she
was young.
Then she may eat from her father's food.
But no outsider shall eat any of it.
14 "'If someone eats something holy by mistake,
he shall add one fifth of its value
and give the holy thing back to the priest.
15 The priests shall not dishonor the holy gifts that the
people of Israel bring to the LORD.
16 Otherwise they will bring guilt on the people when
they eat their holy gifts.
For I am the LORD, who makes them holy.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"An outsider" here means: someone who does not belong to the priest's family.

A slave whom a priest has bought belongs to the family and may eat too. A hired worker or a guest who is there only for a short time may not. In the world back then, slaves were part of the household. There is more about this in the explanation of Exodus 21.

A daughter who marries a man then belongs to his family. But if she becomes a widow and comes back without children, she is provided for again. That way she does not fall into poverty. This protects women who have no one to provide for them.

Only animals without defect VERSES 17–25

17 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
18 "Speak to Aaron, to his sons, and to all the people of
Israel, and tell them,
'Someone from the house of Israel, or one of the
foreigners in Israel, might bring his offering.
It may be because he made a promise to God, or it may
be a free-will gift.
He brings it to the LORD as a burnt offering.
19 So that you are accepted, you shall bring a male animal
without defect,
from the bulls, the sheep, or the goats.
20 But you shall not offer anything that has a defect.
For it will not be accepted for you.
21 "'Someone might bring a peace offering to the LORD to
keep a promise,
or as a free-will gift from the cattle or from the sheep
and goats.
Then it must be perfect to be accepted.
It shall have no defect.
22 You shall not offer to the LORD anything that is blind,
injured, or maimed,
or that has a wart, is festering, or has an open sore.
You shall not put any of these on the altar as an
offering by fire to the LORD.
23 A bull or a lamb that has a deformity or is missing a
body part
you may offer as a free-will gift.
But it will not be accepted to keep a promise.
24 You shall not offer to the LORD an animal whose
testicles are bruised, crushed, torn, or cut.
You shall not do this in your land.
25 You shall also not take any of these animals from a
foreigner and offer them as the food of your God.
For they are spoiled. They have a defect.
They will not be accepted for you.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

You are to give God the best, not what you no longer need yourself. Offering a sick or injured animal would be like a gift from the trash.

Later the prophet Malachi complained that people offered blind and sick animals. He asked: "Try giving it to your governor! Will he be pleased with you?" (Malachi 1:8).

Foreigners may also bring offerings. God's altar is open to everyone.

Care for the animals VERSES 26–28

26 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
27 "When a bull, a sheep, or a goat is born,
it shall stay with its mother for seven days.
From the eighth day on, it will be accepted as an
offering by fire to the LORD.
28 You shall not kill a cow or a ewe on the same day as its
young.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 28: A ewe is a female sheep.

Here the Bible shows compassion for the animals. A newborn animal is to be allowed to stay with its mother for a week. And mother and young are not to be killed on the same day.

Animals are also creatures of God. They are not to be treated cruelly, even when people eat them or offer them.

The thank offering and the end VERSES 29–33

29 "When you bring a thank offering to the LORD, you
shall offer it so that you are accepted.
30 It shall be eaten on the same day.
You shall leave none of it until the morning.
I am the LORD.
31 "So you shall keep my commandments and do them.
I am the LORD.
32 You shall not dishonor my holy name.
But I will be treated as holy among the people of Israel.
I am the LORD, who makes you holy,
33 who brought you out of the land of Egypt to be your
God.
I am the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"But I will be treated as holy among the people of Israel." When people live in a good and fair way, God's name is honored. When they do evil, his name is "dishonored," that is, dragged through the mud.

In Judaism, when someone brings honor to God by the way they act, it is called "Kiddush Hashem," the making holy of the Name. In the Lord's Prayer, Christians pray: "may your name be kept holy" (Matthew 6:9).

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 23

The feasts of the LORD

The Sabbath VERSES 1–3

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them,
'These are the fixed feasts of the LORD, which you
shall announce as holy gatherings.
These are my feasts.
3 "'Work shall be done for six days.
But the seventh day is a Sabbath, a day of complete rest,
a holy gathering.
You shall not do any kind of work.
It is a Sabbath for the LORD, everywhere you live.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is like a calendar of feasts. It names all the feasts that Israel is to celebrate every year.

At the beginning is the Sabbath, the feast of every week. It is the foundation of all the other feasts.

"Holy gathering" means: The people come together to celebrate and worship God.

The feasts are "feasts of the LORD." They belong to God. They are times when God and his people meet.

Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread VERSES 4–8

4 "'These are the fixed feasts of the LORD, the holy
gatherings,
which you shall announce at their fixed times:
5 In the first month, on the fourteenth day of the
month, in the evening, is the LORD's Passover.
6 On the fifteenth day of the same month is the Feast of
Unleavened Bread for the LORD.
For seven days you shall eat bread without yeast.
7 On the first day you shall have a holy gathering.
You shall do no ordinary work.
8 For seven days you shall bring an offering by fire to the
LORD.
On the seventh day is a holy gathering.
You shall do no ordinary work.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: Unleavened bread is bread made without yeast.

Passover is a reminder of the night when Israel was set free from Egypt (Exodus 12). The first month is in the spring, in March or April.

To this day, Jews celebrate the Passover feast, in Hebrew "Pesach," with a special evening meal, the Seder.

Jesus celebrated the Passover meal with his disciples before he died. That became the Lord's Supper. To this day, Easter falls around the time of Passover.

The first bundle of the harvest VERSES 9–14

9 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
10 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them,
'You will come into the land that I am giving you, and
you will bring in its harvest.
Then you shall bring the first bundle of grain from
your harvest to the priest.
11 He shall wave the bundle back and forth before the
LORD, so that you are accepted.
The priest shall wave it on the day after the Sabbath.
12 On the day you wave the bundle,
you shall offer a one-year-old male lamb without
defect as a burnt offering to the LORD.
13 The grain offering with it shall be about 4½ quarts of
fine flour mixed with oil.
It is an offering by fire to the LORD, a pleasant smell.
And the drink offering with it shall be about 1 quart of
wine.
14 You shall not eat bread, roasted grain, or fresh grain
until this very day, until you have brought the
offering for your God.
This is a rule forever, for all your generations,
everywhere you live.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible, the measures are given like this: two tenths of an ephah of flour and a fourth of a hin of wine. An ephah is

about 6 gallons. A hin is about 1 gallon.

A "bundle" of grain (in older English: a sheaf) is a bundle of cut stalks of grain. The very first bundle of the barley harvest belongs to God. Only after that may people eat from the new grain themselves. That is how they say thank you to God for the whole harvest.

Paul calls Jesus "the first fruit of those who are asleep" (1 Corinthians 15:20). Asleep means here: those who have died. Christians see a connection here: Jesus rose from the dead on the day after the Sabbath, exactly on the day of the first bundle.

The Feast of Weeks: 50 days later VERSES 15–22

15 "'You shall count from the day after the Sabbath,
from the day you brought the bundle as a wave offering:
There shall be seven full weeks.
16 You shall count 50 days, up to the day after the seventh Sabbath.
Then you shall bring a new grain offering to the LORD.
17 From your homes you shall bring two loaves of bread as a wave offering.
They shall be made from about four and a half quarts of fine flour.
They shall be baked with yeast, as first fruits for the LORD.
18 With the bread you shall offer seven one-year-old lambs without defect,
one young bull, and two rams.
They shall be a burnt offering to the LORD, with their grain offering and their drink offerings.
It is an offering by fire, a pleasant smell for the LORD.
19 You shall offer one male goat as a sin offering,
and two one-year-old male lambs as a peace offering.
20 The priest shall wave them back and forth before the LORD as a wave offering, with the bread of the first fruits,
together with the two lambs.
They shall be holy to the LORD and belong to the priest.
21 On that same day you shall announce that there is a holy gathering for you.
You shall do no ordinary work.
This is a rule forever, everywhere you live, for all your generations.
22 "'When you bring in the harvest of your land,
you shall not harvest your field all the way to the corners.
And you shall not pick up the grain that is left lying after the harvest.
You shall leave it for the poor and for the foreigner.
I am the LORD your God.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Seven weeks after the first bundle, the wheat harvest is over. Then people celebrate the Feast of Weeks, in Hebrew "Shavuot." At this feast, Jews also remember that God gave the Torah at Mount Sinai.

"Fiftieth" in Greek is "pentekoste." That is where the word "Pentecost" comes from. At this feast, the Holy Spirit came on the disciples of Jesus (Acts 2).

In the middle of the calendar of feasts is the rule for the poor again (as in Leviticus 19:9–10). Whoever celebrates a feast is not to forget the poor.

The Feast of Trumpets VERSES 23–25

23 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
24 "Speak to the people of Israel and say,
'In the seventh month, on the first day of the month, you shall have a day of rest.
It is a day to remember, with the blowing of trumpets, a holy gathering.
25 You shall do no ordinary work.
And you shall bring an offering by fire to the LORD.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The seventh month is in the fall. On the first day of this month, a horn is blown. This is the "shofar," a horn from a ram.

Today Jews celebrate their New Year on this day, "Rosh Hashanah." It is the beginning of 10 days of reflection and turning back to God, up to the Day of Atonement.

The Day of Atonement VERSES 26–32

26 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
27 "But the tenth day of this seventh month is the Day of Atonement.
It shall be a holy gathering for you.
You shall humble yourselves and bring an offering by fire to the LORD.
28 You shall not do any kind of work on that day.
For it is the Day of Atonement, when atonement is made for you before the LORD your God.
29 For whoever does not humble himself on that day shall be cut off from his people.
30 And whoever does any kind of work on that day, I will destroy that person from among his people.
31 You shall not do any kind of work.
This is a rule forever, for all your generations, everywhere you live.
32 It shall be a Sabbath for you, a day of complete rest.
And you shall humble yourselves.
You shall keep your Sabbath from the evening of the ninth day of the month, from evening to evening."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 27: To humble yourself here means: to go without food and comforts.

The Day of Atonement, "Yom Kippur," was already described in detail in Chapter 16.

"From evening to evening" – in the Jewish calendar, every day begins in the evening, when the sun goes down. It is already like this in the story of creation: "There was evening, and there was morning" (Genesis 1:5).

The Feast of Booths VERSES 33–44

33 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
34 "Speak to the people of Israel and say,
'The fifteenth day of this seventh month is the Feast of Booths, for seven days, for the LORD.
35 On the first day there shall be a holy gathering.
You shall do no ordinary work.

36 For seven days you shall bring an offering by fire to the LORD.
On the eighth day you shall have a holy gathering.
You shall bring an offering by fire to the LORD.
It is a solemn gathering. You shall do no ordinary work.
37 "'These are the fixed feasts of the LORD, which you shall announce as holy gatherings,
to bring offerings by fire to the LORD:
burnt offerings, grain offerings, sacrifices, and drink offerings, each on its own day.
38 These are in addition to the Sabbaths of the LORD,
and in addition to your gifts, to all your promises,
and to all your free-will gifts that you give to the LORD.
39 "'So on the fifteenth day of the seventh month,
when you have brought in the crops of the land,
you shall celebrate the feast of the LORD for seven days.
The first day shall be a day of rest, and the eighth day shall be a day of rest.
40 On the first day you shall take fruit from splendid trees,
palm branches, branches from leafy trees, and willows from the brook.
And you shall be joyful before the LORD your God for seven days.
41 You shall celebrate it as a feast for the LORD, seven days in the year.
This is a rule forever, for all your generations.
You shall celebrate it in the seventh month.
42 You shall live in huts for seven days.
Everyone born in Israel shall live in huts.
43 That way your descendants will know
that I had the people of Israel live in huts when I brought them out of the land of Egypt.
I am the LORD your God.'"
44 So Moses told the people of Israel about the fixed feasts of the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 34: Booths are simple huts made of branches.

The Feast of Booths, in Hebrew "Sukkot," is the great harvest festival in the fall. All the crops have been brought in.

For seven days, people live in simple huts made of branches. That way they remember the time in the wilderness, when Israel had no solid houses and had to trust God completely.

"You shall be joyful" – this is even a commandment! God wants his people to celebrate with joy.

To this day, Jews build huts in the garden or on the balcony for this feast. They take a festive bundle made of a palm branch, myrtle, willow, and a citrus fruit, the etrog.

Many Christians celebrate a harvest thanksgiving in the fall. That is also a reminder that everything we have is a gift from God.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 24

The light, the bread, and a man who curses God

The oil for the lampstand VERSES 1–4

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Command the people of Israel to bring you pure olive oil,
made from crushed olives, for the light,
so that a lamp burns all the time.
3 Aaron shall keep it burning in the Tent of Meeting,
outside the curtain in front of the Testimony, from evening to morning, before the LORD, all the time.
This is a rule forever, for all your generations.
4 He shall keep the lamps on the lampstand of pure gold in order before the LORD, all the time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: The Testimony is the tablets with God's covenant written on them.

This was already commanded in Exodus 27:20–21. Now it is repeated.

The light in the holy place is never to go out. It is a sign: God is always there, even at night. And his people are always to think of him.

The 12 loaves of bread VERSES 5–9

5 "Take fine flour and bake 12 loaves from it.
Each loaf shall be made from about 4½ quarts of flour.
6 Set them in two rows, six in each row, on the table of pure gold before the LORD.
7 Put pure frankincense on each row.
It shall be a reminder part for the bread, an offering by fire to the LORD.
8 Every Sabbath day he shall set the bread in order before the LORD, all the time.
It is a covenant forever on behalf of the people of Israel.
9 The bread shall belong to Aaron and his sons.
They shall eat it in a holy place.
For it is most holy for him, from the LORD's offerings by fire, as a rule forever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: Frankincense is a sweet-smelling resin that is burned.

The Bible says: two tenths of an ephah for each loaf. An ephah is about 6 gallons. These were large loaves.

This bread is called the "showbread." There are 12 loaves, for the 12 tribes of Israel. They lie before God all the time. That way the whole people is always present before God.

Every week on the Sabbath, new bread is put there. The priests eat the old bread.

In the New Testament, Jesus reminds people that David once ate from this holy bread when he was in great need (Mark 2:25–26; 1 Samuel 21). With this Jesus says: A person's need matters more to God than a rule.

A man curses God VERSES 10–12

10 There was a son of an Israelite woman. His father was
an Egyptian.
He went out among the people of Israel.
And the son of the Israelite woman got into a fight
with a man of Israel in the camp.
11 The son of the Israelite woman spoke against the Name
and cursed.
So they brought him to Moses.
His mother's name was Shelomith. She was the
daughter of Dibri, from the tribe of Dan.
12 They kept him under guard until the LORD would
make his will clear to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a story interrupts the many laws. It is one of the few stories in the book of Leviticus.

"Speaking against the Name" means: insulting, cursing, or mocking the name of God. The name of God here is "the LORD." In our English source text it is "Yahweh," in Hebrew YHWH.

Moses does not decide by himself. He waits until God says what is to happen. In serious cases, people are not to judge too quickly.

God's judgment and the same law for everyone VERSES 13–22

13 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
14 "Bring the man who cursed outside the camp.
All who heard him shall lay their hands on his head.
And the whole community shall stone him.
15 And tell the people of Israel,
'Whoever curses his God shall carry his sin.
16 Whoever speaks against the name of the LORD must be
put to death.
The whole community shall stone him.
The foreigner as well as the one born in Israel:
whoever speaks against the Name must be put to
death.
17 "'Whoever strikes a person and kills him must be put to
death.
18 Whoever strikes an animal and kills it shall pay for it: a
life for a life.
19 If someone injures his neighbor,
it shall be done to him as he has done:
20 a broken bone for a broken bone, an eye for an eye, a
tooth for a tooth.
It shall be done to him just as he has injured someone.
21 Whoever kills an animal shall pay for it.
And whoever kills a person shall be put to death.
22 You shall have one and the same law, for the foreigner
as well as for the one born in Israel.
For I am the LORD your God.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The punishment for cursing God is very harsh. Back then, the name of God was seen as the holiest thing of all. Whoever cursed it attacked the whole people and its covenant with God.

Out of deep respect, Jews still do not say the name YHWH aloud today. Instead they say "Adonai" (the Lord) or "HaShem" (the Name). That is why many Bibles, this one too, have "the LORD" in capital letters.

"An eye for an eye, a tooth for a tooth" sounds cruel. But back then it was a step forward: The punishment must not be greater than the harm. It was about limiting revenge. In Judaism, it was understood very early as payment in money for the harm: Whoever injures an eye pays as much as an eye is worth.

Jesus went even further. He said: "You have heard that it was said: 'An eye for an eye, and a tooth for a tooth.' But I tell you: Do not resist the person who does evil to you" and "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:38–44).

Verse 22 is very important: The same law applies to foreigners and to those born in the land. No one is to be treated unfairly in court because he is a foreigner.

The punishment is carried out VERSE 23

23 Moses spoke to the people of Israel.
And they brought the man who had cursed outside the
camp and stoned him with stones.
The people of Israel did as the LORD had commanded
Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a sad ending. The Bible tells it without making it look better than it is.

Many people have asked: Why does the Bible tell something like this? It shows how seriously people took God's holiness back then. For us today it is clear: No one may kill people for cursing God. The large Jewish and Christian communities also reject this. Sadly, there are still countries today where people are persecuted for blasphemy. That goes against the dignity that every person has as an image of God.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 25

The Sabbath year and the Year of Jubilee

The land shall rest VERSES 1–7

1 The LORD spoke to Moses on Mount Sinai.
He said,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them,
'You will come into the land that I give you.
Then the land shall keep a Sabbath for the LORD.
3 For six years you shall sow seed in your field.
For six years you shall prune your vineyard and gather
in its fruit.
4 But in the seventh year the land shall have a Sabbath, a
time of complete rest, a Sabbath for the LORD.
You shall not sow your field.
You shall not prune your vineyard.
5 What grows by itself after your harvest, you shall not
harvest.

And you shall not pick the grapes of your vine that you have not pruned.
It shall be a year of complete rest for the land.
6 What the land gives in the Sabbath year shall be food for you:
for yourself, for your servant, for your maid, for your hired worker,
and for the stranger who lives as a foreigner with you.
7 And all that the land gives shall also be food for your livestock
and for the animals that live in your land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: To prune means: to cut back the branches.

People rest every seventh day. In the same way, the land shall rest every seventh year. Nobody sows, and nobody harvests.

This is good for the soil. It can recover. Modern farmers know: If you always use a field, the soil gets worn out.

But it is about even more: The land belongs to God. In this year, what grows by itself belongs to everyone equally. The owner, the servant, the stranger and even the wild animals may eat from it. For one year, everyone is equal.

The Year of Jubilee: freedom in the whole land
VERSES 8–13

8 "'You shall count 7 Sabbath years, 7 times 7 years.
The time of 7 Sabbath years shall be 49 years for you.
9 Then you shall have the loud trumpet sounded on the tenth day of the seventh month.
On the Day of Atonement you shall sound the trumpet throughout all your land.
10 You shall make the fiftieth year holy.
And you shall proclaim liberty throughout the land to all its inhabitants.
It shall be a jubilee for you.
Each of you shall go back to his own property.
And each of you shall go back to his family.
11 That fiftieth year shall be a jubilee for you.
In it you shall not sow.
You shall not harvest what grows by itself.
And you shall not pick the grapes from the vines that were not pruned.
12 For it is a jubilee. It shall be holy to you.
You shall eat what the field gives by itself.
13 In this Year of Jubilee each of you shall go back to his property.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Holy means: It belongs to God in a special way.

Verse 10: "Proclaim liberty throughout the land to all its inhabitants" means: Announce freedom for all the people who live in the land.

After seven times seven years comes the fiftieth year, the "Year of Jubilee." The name comes from the Hebrew word "yobel." That is the ram's horn that is blown on this day.

In the Year of Jubilee, everything goes back to how it was at the beginning. Whoever had to sell his land gets it back. Whoever had to sell himself as a servant becomes free. Every family gets a new beginning.

So a few rich people could not keep getting richer and buy up all the land while others stayed poor forever. Every 50 years, the inequality was balanced out again.

The Year of Jubilee begins on the Day of Atonement. First the guilt before God is forgiven. Then the debts between people are also canceled.

The words "proclaim liberty throughout the land to all its inhabitants" are written on the famous Liberty Bell in America.

Jesus spoke about this year. He said that God had sent him "to tell the prisoners that they will be free ... to announce the year when the Lord shows his favor" (Luke 4:18–19).

In the Catholic Church there is still a "Holy Year" or "Jubilee Year" today. In the year 2000 there was a worldwide movement called "Jubilee 2000." It asked that poor countries have their debts canceled.

Buying and selling fairly VERSES 14–17

14 "'When you sell something to your neighbor, or buy something from your neighbor,
you shall not cheat one another.
15 You shall buy from your neighbor according to the number of years since the Jubilee.
He shall sell to you according to the number of years of harvests.
16 If there are many years, you shall make the price higher.
If there are few years, you shall make the price lower.
For he is only selling you the number of harvests.
17 You shall not cheat one another.
But you shall fear your God.
For I am the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Because the land is given back in the Year of Jubilee, it is not really sold forever. You only sell the harvests until the next Year of Jubilee. It is more like a lease or rent.

That is why the price depends on how many years are left until the Year of Jubilee. So nobody shall be cheated.

God provides for the Sabbath year VERSES 18–22

18 "'So you shall follow my rules.
You shall keep my laws and do them.
Then you will live in the land in safety.
19 The land will give its fruit.
You will eat until you are full and live in it in safety.
20 Maybe you will say:
"What shall we eat in the seventh year?
Look: We will not sow, and we will not gather in our harvest."
21 Then I will send my blessing to you in the sixth year.
The land will give enough fruit for three years.
22 In the eighth year you will sow.
And you will still eat from the old harvest until the ninth year.
Until its new harvest comes in, you will eat from the old harvest.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The question is understandable: What shall we live on if we harvest nothing for a whole year? God answers: Trust me. In the sixth year I will give you so much that it is enough for three years.

This is like the manna in the desert. On the sixth day there was twice as much, so that nobody had to gather it on the Sabbath (Exodus 16:22–30).

The Sabbath year is a practice in trust. Jesus says: "So don't worry, saying, 'What will we eat?' ... Your heavenly Father knows that you need all these things" (Matthew 6:31–32).

The land belongs to God VERSES 23–28

23 "'The land shall not be sold forever.
For the land is mine.
You are only strangers and foreigners living with me.
24 In all the land that you own, you shall allow the land to be bought back.
25 "'Your brother might become poor and sell some of his property.
Then his closest relative shall come and buy back what his brother has sold.
26 But maybe a man has nobody to buy it back.
And then he himself has money again and has enough to buy it back.
27 Then he shall count the years since he sold it.
He shall pay back the rest to the man he sold it to.
Then he goes back to his property.
28 But maybe he is not able to get it back himself.
Then what he sold stays with the man who bought it until the Year of Jubilee.
In the Jubilee it becomes free, and he goes back to his property.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23 is the basis for everything: "For the land is mine. You are only strangers and foreigners living with me." Nobody really owns the land forever. God is the true owner. The people only rent it from him.

If someone in need had to sell his land, there were three ways to get it back:

1. A close relative buys it back. In Hebrew he is called "go'el." That means "redeemer" – someone who buys something back.

2. The seller has money again and buys it back himself.

3. In the Year of Jubilee at the latest, he gets it back for free.

In the book of Ruth, Boaz is such a "redeemer." He buys back the land for Naomi and marries Ruth (Ruth 4).

Houses in cities and villages VERSES 29–34

29 "'If a man sells a house to live in, in a city with walls, then he can buy it back within a whole year after he sold it.
For a full year he has the right to buy it back.
30 If it is not bought back within a full year,
then the house in the walled city shall belong forever to the man who bought it,
and to his descendants after him.
It does not become free in the Jubilee.
31 But the houses in the villages that have no wall around them shall be treated like the fields in the country.
They can be bought back, and they become free in the Jubilee.
32 "'But for the cities of the Levites this is the rule:
The Levites may buy back the houses in the cities that belong to them at any time.
33 If a Levite has sold a house in the city that belongs to him, it can be bought back.
And it becomes free in the Jubilee.
For the houses in the cities of the Levites are their property among the people of Israel.
34 But the pasture land around their cities may not be sold.
For it is their property forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A house in a city is something different from a field. A family lives from its field. That is why the field shall always go back to the family. A house in the city is more like goods that are bought and sold.

But a house in a village is part of the farm. That is why the same rules apply to it as to the field.

The Levites did not get their own land like the other tribes, only some cities with pasture land (Numbers 35). That is why they are especially protected.

Do not take interest from the poor VERSES 35–38

35 "'Your brother might become poor and no longer be able to support himself among you.
Then you shall help him.
He shall live with you like a foreigner and a guest.
36 Take no interest from him and no profit.
But fear your God, so that your brother can live among you.
37 You shall not lend him your money for interest.
And you shall not give him your food for profit.
38 I am the LORD your God.
I brought you out of the land of Egypt
to give you the land of Canaan and to be your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 36: Interest means: extra money that someone has to pay back on top of a loan.

Whoever is poor and needs help shall be helped without anyone making money from it. Whoever lends money to a poor person shall not take any interest.

Back then, people usually did not borrow money to do business. They borrowed because they were in need and had nothing to eat. You shall not make money from someone else's need.

In the Middle Ages, Christians and Jews concluded from this that interest is forbidden. Islam also forbids interest. Today this passage is mainly understood like this: Do not take advantage of other people's need.

An Israelite shall not serve as a slave VERSES 39–43

39 "'Your brother might become poor among you and sell himself to you.
Then you shall not make him work like a slave.
40 He shall be with you like a hired worker and like a guest.
He shall work for you until the Year of Jubilee.
41 Then he shall leave you, he and his children with him.
He shall go back to his own family and to the property of his ancestors.
42 For they are my servants.
I brought them out of the land of Egypt.
They shall not be sold as slaves.
43 You shall not rule over him harshly.
But you shall fear your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Someone could be so poor that he had to sell himself. Then he should not be treated like a slave, but like a worker who gets paid.

The reason: "For they are my servants." God freed Israel from slavery. Israel belongs to God. That is why no Israelite may make another Israelite his slave.

Slaves from other nations VERSES 44–46

44 "'Your male and female slaves may come from the nations that are around you.
From them you may buy male and female slaves.
45 You may also buy from the children of the foreigners who live among you,
and from their families who are with you, who were born in your land.
They will be your property.
46 You may leave them to your children after you as an inheritance, so that they own them.
You may keep them as slaves forever.
But over your brothers, the people of Israel, you shall not rule harshly, one over another.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are very hard for us to read today. They allow people to buy people from other nations as slaves and to pass them on to their children.

We have to say it honestly: Back then there was slavery in all the countries of the world. Here the Bible describes that world. It did not end slavery. But it made rules to limit it. In other places it also protects foreign slaves: Whoever injures his slave must set him free (Exodus 21:26–27). And a slave who runs away may not be sent back (Deuteronomy 23:15–16).

Sadly, people in the 18th and 19th centuries used these verses to defend the slavery of Africans in America. That was a terrible misuse of the Bible.

Other Christians fought against slavery precisely because of the Bible. For the Bible also teaches: Every person is created in God's image (Genesis 1:27). And the New Testament says: "There is neither slave nor free … For you are all one in Christ Jesus" (Galatians 3:28).

Today Jews and Christians agree: Slavery is wrong.

When an Israelite sells himself to a foreigner VERSES 47–55

47 "'A foreigner or a guest living with you might become rich.
And your brother beside him might become poor.
He sells himself to the foreigner or guest living among you,
or to a member of the foreigner's family.
48 After he is sold, he may be bought back.
One of his brothers may buy him back.
49 Or his uncle or his uncle's son may buy him back.
Or any close relative from his family may buy him back.
Or if he himself becomes rich, he may buy himself back.
50 He shall count the time with the man who bought him, from the year he sold himself to him until the Year of Jubilee.
The price of his sale shall depend on the number of years.
His time with him shall be counted like the time of a hired worker.
51 If there are still many years,
then he shall pay back a large part of the money he was bought for.
That is the price to buy him back.
52 If only a few years are left until the Year of Jubilee,
then he shall count with him.
He shall pay the price to buy him back according to his years of service.
53 He shall be with him like a worker who is hired year by year.
The man shall not rule over him harshly while you watch.
54 If he is not bought back in these ways,
then he shall become free in the Year of Jubilee, he and his children with him.
55 For the people of Israel are my servants.
They are my servants whom I brought out of the land of Egypt.
I am the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A foreigner could also become rich in Israel. If a poor Israelite sold himself to him, his family was supposed to buy him free. In the Year of Jubilee at the latest, he became free.

"Buying free" or "redeeming" is a very practical word here: Someone pays the price so that another person becomes free.

Later, Christians applied this word to Jesus. He is the "redeemer" who buys people free (Mark 10:45; 1 Peter 1:18–19).

The whole chapter shows: God does not want people to be trapped in poverty and dependence forever. Everyone shall get a chance for a new beginning.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 26

Blessing and curse – God does not forget his covenant

No idols, keep the Sabbath VERSES 1–2

1 "'You shall not make idols for yourselves.
You shall not set up a carved image or a stone pillar.
And you shall not put any stone with pictures carved on it in your land, to bow down to it.
For I am the LORD your God.
2 "'You shall keep my Sabbaths.
And you shall honor my sanctuary.
I am the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end of the many commandments in Leviticus, the most important things are said once more: serve only the one God and keep the Sabbath.

Verse 2: A sanctuary is a holy place where God is worshiped.

The blessing for obeying VERSES 3–13

3 "'If you live by my statutes, keep my commandments
and do them,
4 then I will give you rain at the right time.
The land will give its harvest.
And the trees of the field will give their fruit.
5 Your threshing will go on until the grape harvest.
And the grape harvest will go on until the time for
sowing.
You will eat your bread until you are full.
And you will live in your land in safety.
6 "'I will give peace in the land.
You will lie down, and nobody will make you afraid.
I will remove dangerous animals from the land.
And no sword will go through your land.
7 You will chase your enemies.
And they will fall before you by the sword.
8 Just 5 of you will chase 100.
And 100 of you will chase 10,000.
And your enemies will fall before you by the sword.
9 "'I will turn to you with kindness.
I will make you fruitful and make you many.
And I will make my covenant with you stand firm.
10 You will eat old supplies that were stored for a long
time.
And you will have to move out the old to make room
for the new.
11 I will set up my tent among you.
And I will not reject you in disgust.
12 I will walk among you.
I will be your God, and you will be my people.
13 I am the LORD your God.
I brought you out of the land of Egypt, so that you
would no longer be their slaves.
I have broken the bars of your yoke.
And I have made you walk upright.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, agreements between kings and nations often ended like this: with a blessing for those who keep the agreement and a curse for those who break it. God's covenant with Israel also ends this way.

The blessing is described beautifully: rain, good harvests, so much that you can never finish it all. Peace, safety, no fear.

But the greatest thing is verse 12: "I will walk among you." This is like the Garden of Eden, where God walked in the garden (Genesis 3:8). God wants to be as close to his people as at the beginning.

Verse 13 is a strong picture: A yoke is a wooden beam that is put on the necks of animals that pull a plow or a cart. Whoever carries a yoke walks bent over. God has broken the yoke. Now Israel can walk upright, as a free people.

Verse 5: Threshing means: beating the grain to get the seeds out.

Verse 9: A covenant is a binding agreement.

What happens if you do not obey VERSES 14–17

14 "'But suppose you do not listen to me and do not do all
these commandments.
15 Suppose you reject my statutes.
Suppose you hate my rules, so that you do not do all my
commandments, but break my covenant.
16 Then I will also do this to you:
I will bring terror on you,
wasting disease and fever that ruin the eyes and make
life fade away.
You will sow your seed for nothing, for your enemies
will eat it.
17 I will turn against you.
You will be beaten by your enemies.
Those who hate you will rule over you.
And you will run away even when nobody is chasing
you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the other side: What happens if Israel breaks the covenant? This part is much longer than the blessing. It sounds very harsh.

What is important: God does not threaten because he enjoys punishing. It is a warning, like a father who warns his child about a danger. He wants Israel to turn back before it is too late.

"And you will run away even when nobody is chasing you" – whoever leaves God loses his inner support and lives in fear.

Worse and worse VERSES 18–26

18 "'If you still do not listen to me after all this,
then I will punish you seven times more for your sins.
19 I will break the pride you have in your power.
I will make your sky like iron and your soil like bronze.
20 Your strength will be used up for nothing.
For your land will not give its harvest.
And the trees of the land will not give their fruit.
21 "'If you go against me and do not want to listen to me,
then I will bring seven times more plagues on you, as
your sins deserve.
22 I will send the wild animals among you.
They will take away your children and destroy your
livestock.
And they will make you few in number.
Your roads will be empty.
23 "'If these things do not bring you back to me,
but you keep going against me,
24 then I will also go against you.
I myself will strike you seven times for your sins.
25 I will bring a sword on you that will carry out the
punishment for breaking the covenant.
You will gather together inside your cities.
And I will send disease among you.
You will be handed over to the enemy.
26 I will break your staff of bread.
Then 10 women will bake your bread in a single oven.
They will weigh out your bread and hand it to you.
You will eat and not be full.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Seven times more" means: worse and worse, until the very end. Each new step is a new chance to turn back. Again and again it says: "If you still do not listen to me ..." God waits patiently for an answer.

"Sky like iron and soil like bronze" is a picture of a drought: The sky gives no rain. The ground is so hard that nothing grows.

"Break your staff of bread" means: take the bread away. Bread was like a staff that you lean on to stay alive.

In verse 26, 10 women bake in a single oven: There is so little flour that a single oven is enough for 10 families.

The worst of all VERSES 27–39

27 "'If you still do not listen to me after all this, but go
against me,
28 then I will go against you in anger.
I will also punish you seven times for your sins.
29 You will eat the flesh of your sons.
And you will eat the flesh of your daughters.
30 I will destroy your high places and cut down your
incense altars.
I will throw your dead bodies on the bodies of your
idols.
And I will reject you in disgust.
31 I will turn your cities into ruins and make your
sanctuaries empty and waste.
And I will not enjoy the sweet smell of your offerings.
32 I will make the land a wasteland.
Your enemies who live in it will be shocked by it.
33 I will scatter you among the nations.
And I will draw the sword and chase you.
Your land will be a wasteland, and your cities will be
ruins.
34 "'Then the land will enjoy its Sabbaths
as long as it lies empty and you are in the land of your
enemies.
Then the land will rest and enjoy its Sabbaths.
35 As long as it lies empty, it will rest.
It gets the rest that it did not have in your Sabbaths
when you lived on it.
36 "'As for those of you who are left, I will make their
hearts weak with fear
in the lands of their enemies.
The sound of a leaf blown by the wind will make them
run away.
They will run as people run from the sword.
And they will fall even when nobody is chasing them.
37 They will trip over one another, as if the sword were
behind them, even when nobody is chasing them.
You will have no power to stand against your enemies.
38 You will die among the nations.
The land of your enemies will eat you up.
39 Those of you who are left will waste away because of
their guilt in the lands of your enemies.
And they will also waste away because of the guilt of
their ancestors, like them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are terrible. Verse 29 describes people in a famine who are so desperate that they eat their own children. That is the most horrible thing anyone can imagine. Sadly, such things really happened later in wars, for example when Jerusalem was under siege (Lamentations 4:10).

Much of this really happened in the history of Israel. In the year 586 BC, the Babylonians conquered Jerusalem. They destroyed the temple and took many people away to Babylon. The prophets saw this as the fulfillment of this warning.

Verses 34–35 are interesting: Because Israel did not keep the Sabbath years, the land makes up for its rest while the people are in exile. Exile means: living far from home in a foreign land. This is exactly what 2 Chronicles 36:21 also says about the exile in Babylon.

These verses must never be used to say that the suffering of the Jewish people in history is a punishment from God. That has happened often, and it has led to terrible hatred of Jews. The Bible itself says something very different in the next section.

Verse 30: High places were places on hills where people worshiped idols.

But God does not forget his covenant VERSES 40–46

40 "'But suppose they confess their guilt and the guilt of
their ancestors,
the unfaithfulness they showed against me,
and also that they went against me,
41 so that I also went against them
and brought them into the land of their enemies.
If then their uncircumcised heart is humbled,
and they accept the punishment for their guilt,
42 then I will remember my covenant with Jacob
and my covenant with Isaac.
And I will also remember my covenant with Abraham.
And I will remember the land.
43 The land will also be left empty by them.
It will enjoy its Sabbaths while it lies empty without
them.
And they will accept the punishment for their guilt,
because they rejected my rules
and hated my statutes.
44 "'But in spite of all that, when they are in the land of
their enemies,
I will not reject them, and I will not turn away from
them in disgust.
I will not destroy them completely or break my
covenant with them.
For I am the LORD their God.
45 But for their sake I will remember the covenant with
their ancestors.
I brought them out of the land of Egypt while the
nations watched, so that I might be their God.
I am the LORD.'"
46 These are the statutes, the rules and the laws
that the LORD made between himself and the people
of Israel on Mount Sinai through Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the most important part of the chapter. After all the harsh words comes hope.

If Israel confesses its guilt and turns back, then God remembers his covenant. He made a promise to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. This promise lasts forever.

Verse 44 is like a light in the darkness: "But in spite of all that ... I will not reject them." Even if Israel breaks the

covenant, God does not break it. God's faithfulness is greater than the unfaithfulness of people.

An "uncircumcised heart" is a heart that is closed to God. When it is "humbled," it opens up again.

In the New Testament, Paul writes about the Jewish people: God has not rejected his people (Romans 11:1–2). And: God's gifts and his calling can never be canceled (Romans 11:29). That means: God does not take them back.

Verse 46 is an ending: Here the great laws that God gave at Sinai come to an end. Chapter 27 is an addition.

LEVITICUS

CHAPTER 27

Promises to God and the tithe

When someone promises a person to God VERSES 1–8

1 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them:
'Suppose someone makes a vow and gives a person to the LORD.
Then the value shall be set according to your valuation.
3 The value for a man from 20 to 60 years old shall be 50 shekels of silver,
by the shekel of the sanctuary.
4 If it is a woman, the value shall be 30 shekels.
5 If the person is from 5 to 20 years old,
the value shall be 20 shekels for a male and 10 shekels for a female.
6 If the person is from a month to 5 years old,
the value shall be 5 shekels of silver for a male and 3 shekels of silver for a female.
7 If the person is 60 years old or older,
the value shall be 15 shekels for a man and 10 shekels for a woman.
8 But suppose someone is too poor to pay that value.
Then he shall be brought before the priest,
and the priest shall set a value for him.
The priest shall set the value according to what the person is able to pay.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A "vow" is a solemn promise to God. For example: "If God saves me from this trouble, then I will belong to him completely." This is how Hannah promised her son Samuel to God (1 Samuel 1:11).

But not everyone can serve in the sanctuary. That is why you can give an amount of money instead of the person.

A shekel is about 0.4 ounces of silver. So 50 shekels are about 1.2 pounds of silver. That was a lot of money back then, about the pay for several years of work.

The amounts are different: Men, women, children and old people have different values. This has nothing to do with how much a person is worth before God. It depended on how much physical work someone could do back then. Before God, every person is endlessly precious.

Verse 8 is important: Whoever is poor pays only what he can. Nobody shall fall into poverty because of a promise to God.

When someone promises an animal VERSES 9–13

9 "'Suppose it is an animal that people can bring to the LORD as an offering.
Then everything of it that someone gives to the LORD becomes holy.
10 He shall not change it or swap it,
not a good one for a bad one, and not a bad one for a good one.
If he does swap one animal for another anyway,
then both shall be holy: the animal and the one it was swapped for.
11 Suppose it is an unclean animal that may not be brought to the LORD as an offering.
Then he shall bring the animal before the priest.
12 The priest shall set its value, whether it is good or bad.
As the priest sets the value, so it shall be.
13 But if he really wants to buy it back,
then he shall add one fifth to its value.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever has promised an animal to God shall not swap it later for a worse one. A promise to God is serious.

An unclean animal, for example a donkey, cannot be sacrificed. Its value is set, and it is sold. The money goes to the sanctuary.

When someone promises a house or a field VERSES 14–25

14 "'Suppose someone dedicates his house to the LORD, so that it is holy.
Then the priest shall set its value, whether it is good or bad.
As the priest sets the value, so it shall stand.
15 If the man who dedicated it wants to buy back his house,
then he shall add one fifth to the money of your valuation.
Then it shall be his again.
16 "'Suppose someone dedicates to the LORD part of the field that he owns.
Then the value shall depend on the seed for it.
The seed for a homer of barley shall be worth 50 shekels of silver.
17 If he dedicates his field from the Year of Jubilee on, the full value of your valuation shall stand.
18 But if he dedicates his field later, after the Jubilee,
then the priest shall count the money for him according to the years that are left until the Year of Jubilee.
And something shall be taken off your valuation.
19 If the man who dedicated the field really wants to buy it back,
then he shall add one fifth to the money of your

valuation.
Then it shall stay his.
20 But if he does not buy back the field,
or if he has sold the field to another man,
then it can never be bought back again.
21 When the field becomes free in the Jubilee, it shall be holy to the LORD,
like a field that is given completely to God.
It shall belong to the priests.
22 "'Suppose someone dedicates to the LORD a field that he has bought,
which is not part of the field he owns as family land.
23 Then the priest shall count for him the value of your valuation up to the Year of Jubilee.
And he shall pay that value on the same day, as a holy gift to the LORD.
24 In the Year of Jubilee the field shall go back to the man he bought it from,
to the man who owns the land as family land.
25 All your valuations shall be by the shekel of the sanctuary: 20 gerahs make a shekel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A "homer" is a large measure for grain, about 58 gallons. It means a field for which you need that much seed.

Here, too, the Year of Jubilee plays a role (Chapter 25). A field is really only passed on until the next Year of Jubilee. That is why its value depends on how many years are left.

A field that was bought really belongs to another family. That is why it goes back to that family in the Year of Jubilee, not to the sanctuary. The family land stays protected.

A gerah is a very small weight, a twentieth of a shekel.

What cannot be dedicated or bought back VERSES 26–29

26 "'But the firstborn of the animals already belongs to the LORD as a firstborn.
Nobody may dedicate it, whether it is an ox or a sheep.
It already belongs to the LORD.
27 If it is an unclean animal,
then he shall buy it back according to your valuation and add one fifth to it.
If it is not bought back, then it shall be sold according to your valuation.
28 "'But nothing that someone devotes to the LORD from everything he has may be sold or bought back,
whether it is a person, an animal or a field that he owns.
Everything that is devoted forever is most holy to the LORD.
29 "'No person who is devoted to destruction may be bought free.
He must be put to death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

You cannot give God something that already belongs to him. The firstborn belongs to God anyway (Exodus 13:2).

"Devoted" is a special word. In Hebrew it is "cherem." It means: to give something to God completely and forever, so that people may no longer use it.

Verse 29 is very hard. It probably means: If a court has sentenced a person to death, he cannot buy himself free with money. Or it is about the "devoting to destruction" in war, which the book of Joshua tells about later. Jews and Christians have thought about this a lot. You can read more about it in the explanations in Deuteronomy and in the book of Joshua.

In no way does this passage mean that a person may "promise" another person to God and then kill him. The Bible strictly forbids human sacrifice (Leviticus 18:21; 20:2).

The tithe VERSES 30–34

30 "'All the tithe of the land belongs to the LORD,
whether from the seed of the land or from the fruit of the trees.
It is holy to the LORD.
31 If someone wants to buy back some of his tithe,
he shall add one fifth to it.
32 All the tithe of the cattle and of the sheep and goats shall be holy to the LORD:
every tenth animal that walks under the shepherd's staff.
33 He shall not check whether it is good or bad.
And he shall not swap it.
If he does swap it anyway, then both shall be holy:
the animal and the one it was swapped for.
It may not be bought back.'"
34 These are the commandments that the LORD gave Moses for the people of Israel on Mount Sinai.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "tithe" means: One tenth of everything you harvest and of all the animals that are born belongs to God. The Levites and priests lived from it, and the poor too (Deuteronomy 14:28–29).

When counting the animals, the shepherd let them walk under his staff one by one. Every tenth animal was marked. Nobody was allowed to secretly pick out the best animals.

Many churches and congregations still encourage people today to give part of their income to God and to others.

Looking back: What have we read in Leviticus?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Leviticus answers a big question: How can a holy God live among people who make mistakes?

1. Through sacrifices that bring forgiveness and peace with God (Chapters 1–7).

2. Through priests who stand between God and the people (Chapters 8–10).

3. Through rules for clean and unclean in everyday life (Chapters 11–15).

4. Through the great Day of Atonement, when all guilt is carried away (Chapter 16).

5. Through a holy life every day: in the family, at work, with the poor and with strangers (Chapters 17–27).

The most important sentence of the book is: "You shall be holy, because I, the LORD your God, am holy" (Leviticus 19:2). And in the middle of the book is the commandment that Jesus called one of the two most important: "You shall love your neighbor as yourself" (Leviticus 19:18).

Many things in this book are strange to us. But its message is still true today: God wants to be close to us. And he shows us a way to live close to him.

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NUMBERS

36 CHAPTERS

NUMBERS

Chapter 1

The first census

Before we begin: What is the book of Numbers?

The book of Numbers is also called "the Fourth Book of Moses." Its name comes from the Latin name "Numeri." That means "numbers." For at the beginning and near the end of the book, the people are counted.

In Hebrew the book is called "Bemidbar." That means "In the wilderness." That name fits even better. For the book tells about Israel's journey through the wilderness, from Mount Sinai to the border of the promised land.

This journey should have taken only a few weeks. But because the people do not trust God, it takes 40 years. A whole generation dies in the wilderness.

It is a book about complaining and doubt, about rebellions and punishments, but also about God's patience and faithfulness. The famous blessing is also found here: "The LORD bless you and keep you" (Numbers 6:24–26).

God commands the census VERSES 1–4

1 The LORD spoke to Moses in the wilderness of Sinai, in the Tent of Meeting.
It was on the first day of the second month, in the second year after they had come out of the land of Egypt.
He said:
2 "Take a census of the whole community of the people of Israel.
Count them by their families and by their fathers' houses,
by the number of the names, every male, one by one,
3 from 20 years old and up, all in Israel who are able to go to war.
You and Aaron shall count them by their army divisions.
4 With you there shall be one man from every tribe.
Each one shall be the head of his fathers' house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A little more than a year has passed since the people left Egypt. At Sinai the people received the commandments and built the sanctuary. Now they shall move on, into the promised land.

For this, they count how many men can fight. Israel is no longer a group of runaway slaves. It is now an orderly people.

"By the number of the names": Everyone is counted with his name. For God, nobody is just a number.

Verse 2: A census means: counting all the people.

The helpers from every tribe VERSES 5–16

5 "These are the names of the men who shall stand with you and help you:
From the tribe of Reuben: Elizur, the son of Shedeur.
6 From the tribe of Simeon: Shelumiel, the son of Zurishaddai.
7 From the tribe of Judah: Nahshon, the son of Amminadab.
8 From the tribe of Issachar: Nethanel, the son of Zuar.
9 From the tribe of Zebulun: Eliab, the son of Helon.
10 From the sons of Joseph:
from the tribe of Ephraim: Elishama, the son of Ammihud;
from the tribe of Manasseh: Gamaliel, the son of Pedahzur.
11 From the tribe of Benjamin: Abidan, the son of Gideoni.
12 From the tribe of Dan: Ahiezer, the son of Ammishaddai.
13 From the tribe of Asher: Pagiel, the son of Ochran.
14 From the tribe of Gad: Eliasaph, the son of Deuel.
15 From the tribe of Naphtali: Ahira, the son of Enan."
16 These were the men who were called from the community.
They were the leaders of the tribes of their ancestors.
They were the heads of the thousands of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Every tribe has a leader. These names come up again and again in the book of Numbers, for example in Chapter 7.

Nahshon from the tribe of Judah is an ancestor of King David, and so also of Jesus (Ruth 4:20–22; Matthew 1:4).

Joseph gets two tribes, Ephraim and Manasseh. These are the names of his sons (Genesis 48). The tribe of Levi is missing from this list. The end of the chapter explains why.

Many names contain names for God, for example "El" (God) or "Shaddai" (the Almighty). "Elizur" means "My God is a rock."

The census begins VERSES 17–19

17 Moses and Aaron took these men who had been named.
18 On the first day of the second month, they gathered the whole community.
And the people stated their ancestry, by their families and by their fathers' houses,
by the number of the names, from 20 years old and up, one by one.
19 Moses counted them in the wilderness of Sinai, just as the LORD had commanded him.

The numbers of the 12 tribes VERSES 20–43

20 The descendants of Reuben, Israel's firstborn, were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names, one by one:
every male from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
21 Those counted from the tribe of Reuben were 46,500.

22 Of the descendants of Simeon: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses. They were counted by the number of the names, one by one:
every male from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
23 Those counted from the tribe of Simeon were 59,300.
24 Of the descendants of Gad: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names:
from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
25 Those counted from the tribe of Gad were 45,650.
26 Of the descendants of Judah: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names:
from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
27 Those counted from the tribe of Judah were 74,600.
28 Of the descendants of Issachar: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names:
from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
29 Those counted from the tribe of Issachar were 54,400.
30 Of the descendants of Zebulun: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names:
from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
31 Those counted from the tribe of Zebulun were 57,400.
32 Of the descendants of Joseph:
Of the descendants of Ephraim: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names:
from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
33 Those counted from the tribe of Ephraim were 40,500.
34 Of the descendants of Manasseh: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names:
from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
35 Those counted from the tribe of Manasseh were 32,200.
36 Of the descendants of Benjamin: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names:
from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
37 Those counted from the tribe of Benjamin were 35,400.
38 Of the descendants of Dan: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names:
from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
39 Those counted from the tribe of Dan were 62,700.
40 Of the descendants of Asher: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names:
from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
41 Those counted from the tribe of Asher were 41,500.
42 Of the descendants of Naphtali: They were listed by their line of descent,
by their families and by their fathers' houses, by the number of the names:
from 20 years old and up, all who were able to go to war.
43 Those counted from the tribe of Naphtali were 53,400.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> The same formula is repeated for every tribe. That can be tiring to read. But it shows: Every tribe is equally important. None is forgotten or cut short.
>
> Judah is the largest tribe. Later, the kings of Israel come from Judah.

The total number VERSES 44–46

44 These were the ones who were counted.
Moses and Aaron counted them,
together with the 12 leaders of Israel, one for each fathers' house.
45 All the people of Israel who were counted by their fathers' houses, from 20 years old and up,
all in Israel who were able to go to war –
46 all who were counted were 603,550.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> 603,550 men, plus women, children and old people. That would be maybe two million people in all. That is a huge number for a journey through the wilderness.
>
> Some scholars think that the Hebrew word for "thousand" ("elef") could also mean "clan" or "troop" here. Then there would have been far fewer people. Others take the numbers literally. Above all, the Bible wants to show: God kept his promise to Abraham. One family has become a great people (Genesis 15:5).
>
> The same number already came up with the offering for the sanctuary (Exodus 38:26).

The Levites are not counted VERSES 47–54

47 But the Levites were not counted with them by the tribe of their ancestors.
48 For the LORD had spoken to Moses.
He had said:
49 "Only the tribe of Levi you shall not count.
You shall not take a census of them among the people of Israel.
50 Instead, put the Levites in charge of the Tabernacle of the Testimony,
over all its equipment and over everything that belongs to it.
They shall carry the Tabernacle and all its equipment.
They shall take care of it and camp all around it.

51 When the Tabernacle is to move on, the Levites shall take it down.
And when the Tabernacle is to be set up, the Levites shall set it up.
A stranger who comes near it shall be put to death.
52 The people of Israel shall set up their tents,
every man in his own camp and every man by his own flag, by their army divisions.
53 But the Levites shall camp all around the Tabernacle of the Testimony,
so that no anger comes on the community of the people of Israel.
The Levites shall be responsible for the Tabernacle of the Testimony."
54 The people of Israel did this.
They did everything just as the LORD had commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Levites do not go to war. They have a different task: They take care of the sanctuary. They set it up and take it down, and they carry it on the journey.

They camp right around the sanctuary, like a protective wall. So nobody comes too close to the holy place who is not called to do so.

"A stranger" here means: someone who does not belong to the tribe of Levi.

The sanctuary stands in the middle of the camp. God is the center of the people.

Verse 50: The Tabernacle is the holy tent where God lives among his people.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 2

The order of the camp

Everyone by his flag VERSES 1–2

1 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron.
He said:
2 "The people of Israel shall set up their tents, every man by his own flag,
with the banners of their fathers' houses.
They shall camp around the Tent of Meeting, at some distance from it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now it is decided what the camp shall look like. The sanctuary stands in the middle. The Levites camp around it. And outside of them, the 12 tribes camp, three on each side.

So there is a big square with God in the middle. Every tribe has its fixed place.

A "banner" is a flag or a sign for an army. By it, everyone could see where his tribe was camping.

In the east: the camp of Judah VERSES 3–9

3 "Those who camp on the east side, toward the sunrise, shall be under the flag of the camp of Judah, by their army divisions.
The leader of the descendants of Judah shall be Nahshon, the son of Amminadab.
4 His division, those who were counted, were 74,600.
5 Next to him the tribe of Issachar shall camp.
The leader of the descendants of Issachar shall be Nethanel, the son of Zuar.
6 His division, those who were counted, were 54,400.
7 Then the tribe of Zebulun.
The leader of the descendants of Zebulun shall be Eliab, the son of Helon.
8 His division, those who were counted, were 57,400.
9 All who were counted in the camp of Judah were 186,400, by their army divisions.
They shall set out first.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The east is the most important side. The entrance of the sanctuary is there too. Judah, the largest tribe, camps here. On the journey, Judah goes first.

Later Judah becomes the tribe of the kings. Jacob's blessing already announced this (Genesis 49:10).

In the south: the camp of Reuben VERSES 10–16

10 "On the south side shall be the flag of the camp of Reuben, by their army divisions.
The leader of the descendants of Reuben shall be Elizur, the son of Shedeur.
11 His division, those who were counted, were 46,500.
12 Next to him the tribe of Simeon shall camp.
The leader of the descendants of Simeon shall be Shelumiel, the son of Zurishaddai.
13 His division, those who were counted, were 59,300.
14 Then the tribe of Gad.
The leader of the descendants of Gad shall be Eliasaph, the son of Reuel.
15 His division, those who were counted, were 45,650.
16 All who were counted in the camp of Reuben were 151,450, by their armies.
They shall set out second.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Numbers 1:14, the father of Eliasaph is called "Deuel." Here he is called "Reuel." In Hebrew, the letters D and R look very similar. It is probably the same man, and a letter was mixed up when the text was copied.

In the middle: the sanctuary and the Levites VERSE 17

17 "Then the Tent of Meeting shall set out, with the camp of the Levites, in the middle of the camps.
As they camp, so they shall also set out, every man in his place, by their flags.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

On the journey, too, the sanctuary is in the middle. Two camps go in front, two camps go behind. God is always at the

center of his people, when they camp and when they travel.

In the west: the camp of Ephraim VERSES 18–24

18 "On the west side shall be the flag of the camp of
Ephraim, by their army divisions.
The leader of the descendants of Ephraim shall be
Elishama, the son of Ammihud.
19 His division, those who were counted, were 40,500.
20 Next to him shall be the tribe of Manasseh.
The leader of the descendants of Manasseh shall be
Gamaliel, the son of Pedahzur.
21 His division, those who were counted, were 32,200.
22 Then the tribe of Benjamin.
The leader of the descendants of Benjamin shall be
Abidan, the son of Gideoni.
23 His army, those who were counted, were 35,400.
24 All who were counted in the camp of Ephraim were
108,100, by their army divisions.
They shall set out third.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the west, the descendants of Rachel camp: Ephraim and Manasseh (the sons of Joseph) and Benjamin. Rachel was the wife Jacob loved most.

In the north: the camp of Dan VERSES 25–31

25 "On the north side shall be the flag of the camp of Dan,
by their army divisions.
The leader of the descendants of Dan shall be Ahiezer,
the son of Ammishaddai.
26 His division, those who were counted, were 62,700.
27 Next to him the tribe of Asher shall camp.
The leader of the descendants of Asher shall be Pagiel,
the son of Ochran.
28 His division, those who were counted, were 41,500.
29 Then the tribe of Naphtali.
The leader of the descendants of Naphtali shall be
Ahira, the son of Enan.
30 His division, those who were counted, were 53,400.
31 All who were counted in the camp of Dan were 157,600.
They shall set out last, by their flags."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The camp of Dan is the rear guard. It goes at the end of the line and protects the people from behind.

Summary VERSES 32–34

32 These were the people of Israel who were counted by
their fathers' houses.
All who were counted in the camps, by their armies,
were 603,550.
33 But the Levites were not counted among the people of
Israel,
just as the LORD had commanded Moses.
34 The people of Israel did this.
They did everything just as the LORD had commanded
Moses.
So they camped by their flags,
and so they set out, everyone with his family, by his
fathers' house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The four camps together: 186,400 + 151,450 + 108,100 + 157,600 = 603,550. The number matches Chapter 1 exactly.

A crowd of refugees has become an orderly people. Order helps everyone to live together well.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 3

The Levites and their tasks

The sons of Aaron VERSES 1–4

1 This is the history of the descendants of Aaron and
Moses,
at the time when the LORD spoke with Moses on
Mount Sinai.
2 These are the names of the sons of Aaron:
Nadab, the firstborn, and Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar.
3 These are the names of the sons of Aaron, the priests
who were anointed.
Anointed means: oil was poured on them to set them
apart for God.
Aaron had made them holy so that they would serve as
priests.
4 Nadab and Abihu died before the LORD
when they brought strange fire before the LORD in
the wilderness of Sinai.
They had no children.
Eleazar and Ithamar served as priests at the side of
their father Aaron.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the death of Nadab and Abihu is remembered (Leviticus 10). They had no children. That is why all later priests come from Eleazar and Ithamar.

The Levites serve the priests VERSES 5–10

5 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
6 "Bring the tribe of Levi here and put them before
Aaron the priest.
They shall serve him.
7 They shall carry out their duties for him and for the
whole community in front of the Tent of Meeting.
They shall do the work of the Tabernacle.
8 They shall take care of all the equipment of the Tent of
Meeting.
They shall carry out the duties for the people of Israel
and do the work of the Tabernacle.
9 You shall give the Levites to Aaron and to his sons.
They are given to him completely, on behalf of the
people of Israel.

10 You shall appoint Aaron and his sons, so that they do
their work as priests.
But a stranger who comes near shall be put to death."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

There are two groups in the tribe of Levi: Only Aaron and his descendants are priests. They bring the sacrifices at the altar. The other Levites help them. They carry the sanctuary, set it up, take it down and guard it.

"A stranger" here means: someone who is not a priest and still wants to do the work of a priest.

The Levites instead of the firstborn VERSES 11–13

11 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
12 "Look: I have taken the Levites from among the people
of Israel
instead of all the firstborn among the people of Israel,
who are the first to come from their mother's womb.
The Levites shall be mine.
13 For all the firstborn are mine.
On the day when I struck down all the firstborn in the
land of Egypt,
I made all the firstborn in Israel holy for myself, both
people and animals.
They shall be mine. I am the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When God freed Israel from Egypt, he spared the firstborn of Israel (Exodus 12). Since then, they belong to God.

Now God takes the Levites in their place. Instead of every family giving its oldest son to serve God, a whole tribe serves for everyone.

The census of the Levites VERSES 14–20

14 The LORD spoke to Moses in the wilderness of Sinai.
He said:
15 "Count the descendants of Levi by their fathers' houses
and by their families.
You shall count every male from a month old and up."
16 Moses counted them by the word of the LORD, as he
had been commanded.
17 These were the sons of Levi by their names: Gershon,
Kohath and Merari.
18 These are the names of the sons of Gershon by their
families: Libni and Shimei.
19 The sons of Kohath by their families: Amram, Izhar,
Hebron and Uzziel.
20 The sons of Merari by their families: Mahli and Mushi.
These are the families of the Levites by their fathers'
houses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Levites are counted differently from the other tribes: not from 20 years old, but already from a month old. For this is not about soldiers. It is about a replacement for all the firstborn.

Moses and Aaron are descendants of Amram, the son of Kohath (Exodus 6:20).

The Gershonites VERSES 21–26

21 From Gershon came the family of the Libnites and the
family of the Shimeites.
These are the families of the Gershonites.
22 Those of them who were counted, by the number of all
the males from a month old and up, were 7,500.
23 The families of the Gershonites shall camp behind the
Tabernacle, on the west side.
24 The leader of the fathers' house of the Gershonites shall
be Eliasaph, the son of Lael.
25 The duty of the sons of Gershon at the Tent of Meeting
shall be:
the Tabernacle, the tent, its covering,
the curtain for the door of the Tent of Meeting,
26 the hangings of the courtyard,
the curtain for the door of the courtyard, which is
around the Tabernacle and the altar,
and its ropes, for all the work on it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Gershonites are responsible for everything made of cloth and leather: the coverings, the curtains and the hangings.

The Kohathites VERSES 27–32

27 From Kohath came the family of the Amramites, the
family of the Izharites,
the family of the Hebronites and the family of the
Uzzielites.
These are the families of the Kohathites.
28 By the number of all the males from a month old and
up, there were 8,600.
They carried out the duties of the sanctuary.
29 The families of the sons of Kohath shall camp on the
south side of the Tabernacle.
30 The leader of the fathers' house of the families of the
Kohathites shall be Elizaphan, the son of Uzziel.
31 Their duty shall be:
the ark, the table, the lampstand, the altars,
the holy objects of the sanctuary that are used for the
service,
the curtain, and all the work on them.
32 Eleazar, the son of Aaron the priest, shall be the chief
leader of the leaders of the Levites.
He shall be in charge of those who carry out the duties
of the sanctuary.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Kohathites have the holiest task: They carry the ark of the covenant and the other holy objects. You can read more about it in Chapter 4.

The Merarites VERSES 33–37

33 From Merari came the family of the Mahlites and the
family of the Mushites.
These are the families of Merari.
34 Those of them who were counted, by the number of all
the males from a month old and up, were 6,200.
35 The leader of the fathers' house of the families of
Merari was Zuriel, the son of Abihail.
They shall camp on the north side of the Tabernacle.
36 The duty of the sons of Merari shall be:
the boards of the Tabernacle, its crossbars, its posts, its
bases, all its equipment and all the work on them,

37 the posts of the courtyard all around, their bases, their
tent pegs and their ropes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Merarites carry the heavy parts: boards, bars, posts and bases. This is the "frame" of the sanctuary.

Every group has its own task. None is unimportant. Without the boards there is no tent. Without the coverings there is no protection. Without the ark there is no sanctuary.

Moses and Aaron in the east VERSES 38–39

38 In front of the Tabernacle, in the east, in front of the
Tent of Meeting toward the sunrise,
Moses, Aaron and his sons shall camp.
They shall carry out the duties of the sanctuary, as a
service for the people of Israel.
An outsider who comes near shall be put to death.
39 All the Levites who were counted, whom Moses and
Aaron counted at the command of the LORD,
by their families, all the males from a month old and
up, were 22,000.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses and the priests camp in the east, right at the entrance of the sanctuary. They guard the most important way in.

If you add up the numbers (7,500 + 8,600 + 6,200), you get 22,300, not 22,000. Probably a mistake happened when the text was copied. Some scholars think that the Kohathites originally had 8,300 instead of 8,600. Then the total would be exactly right. The WEB, our English source text, follows the Hebrew text with 8,600.

The exchange for the firstborn VERSES 40–51

40 The LORD said to Moses:
"Count all the firstborn males of the people of Israel,
from a month old and up,
and find out the number of their names.
41 You shall take the Levites for me – I am the LORD –
instead of all the firstborn among the people of Israel.
And take the livestock of the Levites instead of all the
firstborn among the livestock of the people of Israel."
42 Moses counted all the firstborn among the people of
Israel, as the LORD had commanded him.
43 All the firstborn males, by the number of names, from
a month old and up,
were 22,273.
44 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
45 "Take the Levites instead of all the firstborn among the
people of Israel,
and the livestock of the Levites instead of their
livestock.
The Levites shall be mine. I am the LORD.
46 There are 273 firstborn of the people of Israel who are
more than the number of the Levites.
They must be bought free.
47 For this, you shall take 5 shekels for each one.
You shall take them by the shekel of the sanctuary. A
shekel is 20 gerahs.
48 And you shall give the money with which the rest of
them are bought free to Aaron and to his sons."
49 Moses took the money for buying them free from
those who were more than the ones bought free by the
Levites.
50 He took the money from the firstborn of the people of
Israel: 1,365 shekels, by the shekel of the sanctuary.
51 And Moses gave the money for buying them free to
Aaron and to his sons,
by the word of the LORD, as the LORD had
commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

There are 22,273 firstborn, but only 22,000 Levites. For 273 firstborn there is no Levite to take their place. That is why 5 shekels are paid for each of them, about 2 ounces of silver. Together that is 1,365 shekels (273 × 5).

In Judaism, a firstborn son is still "bought free" today with exactly this amount of 5 shekels. The celebration is called "Pidyon HaBen," the redemption of the son. It takes place one month after the birth.

So every firstborn is represented before God. Nobody is forgotten.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 4

How the sanctuary is carried

The Kohathites and the most holy things VERSES 1–4

1 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron.
He said:
2 "Take a census of the descendants of Kohath among the
Levites, by their families and by their fathers' houses,
3 from 30 years old up to 50 years old,
all who come to serve, to do the work at the Tent of
Meeting.
4 This is the service of the descendants of Kohath at the
Tent of Meeting: They take care of the most holy
things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Chapter 3, all the Levites from one month old were counted. Now only those who really work are counted: the men between 30 and 50 years old. At this age a man is strong enough and has enough experience.

The priests cover the holy things VERSES 5–16

5 "When the camp sets out, Aaron and his sons shall go
in.
They shall take down the curtain that screens off the
Most Holy Place.
And they shall cover the ark of the Testimony with it.
6 They shall put a covering of sealskin over it.
And over that they shall spread a cloth that is all blue.

Then they shall put in its poles.
7 "Over the table of the showbread they shall spread a blue cloth.
On the cloth they shall put the dishes, the spoons, the bowls and the cups for pouring out drink offerings.
And the bread that is always there shall stay on it.
8 Over them they shall spread a scarlet cloth.
And they shall cover it with a covering of sealskin.
Then they shall put in its poles.
9 "They shall take a blue cloth
and cover the lampstand for the light with it,
its lamps, its wick trimmers, its trays
and all its oil jars that are used for the work on it.
10 They shall put it and all its equipment into a covering of sealskin.
And they shall put it on the carrying frame.
11 "Over the golden altar they shall spread a blue cloth.
And they shall cover it with a covering of sealskin.
Then they shall put in its poles.
12 They shall take all the equipment that is used for the service in the sanctuary.
They shall put it in a blue cloth,
cover it with a covering of sealskin,
and put it on the carrying frame.
13 "They shall take away the ashes from the altar.
And they shall spread a purple cloth over it.
14 On it they shall put all the equipment that is used for the work on it:
the fire pans, the meat forks, the shovels and the basins, all the equipment of the altar.
Over it they shall spread a covering of sealskin.
Then they shall put in its poles.
15 "When the camp sets out, Aaron and his sons shall first finish covering the sanctuary and all the furniture of the sanctuary.
After that, the descendants of Kohath shall come to carry it.
But they must not touch the holy things, or they will die.
These are the things of the Tent of Meeting that the descendants of Kohath shall carry.
16 "Eleazar, the son of Aaron the priest, shall be responsible
for the oil for the light, the sweet-smelling incense, the daily grain offering and the anointing oil.
He shall be in charge of the whole Tabernacle and of everything in it,
of the sanctuary and its equipment."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The holy objects may not be carried openly through the wilderness. First the priests cover them carefully with cloths and leather. Only then may the Kohathites carry them.

Here the WEB, our English source text, says "sealskin." In Exodus it said "sea cow hides." It is the same Hebrew word. Nobody knows exactly which animal is meant.

The ark of the covenant is covered with a blue cloth last of all. With all the other objects, the leather is on the outside. Only the ark shines blue. So everyone on the journey could see where the ark was.

Later the ark was once carried on a cart instead of on people's shoulders. Uzzah touched it and died (2 Samuel 6:6–7). So these rules were taken very seriously.

Verse 7: The showbread is the holy bread that always lies before God.

Verse 8: Scarlet is a bright red color.

The Kohathites shall not die VERSES 17–20

17 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron.
He said:
18 "Do not let the tribe of the families of the Kohathites be wiped out from among the Levites.
19 But do this for them, so that they will live and not die when they come near the most holy things:
Aaron and his sons shall go in
and give every man his work and his load.
20 But the Kohathites themselves shall not go in to look at the holy things, not even for a moment.
Otherwise they will die."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God cares about the Kohathites. Their work is dangerous because it is so close to the holy things. That is why they get clear instructions that protect them.

The rules are not there to punish people, but to keep them alive.

The Gershonites VERSES 21–28

21 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
22 "Take a census of the descendants of Gershon too, by their fathers' houses and by their families.
23 You shall count them from 30 years old up to 50 years old,
all who come to serve, to do the work at the Tent of Meeting.
24 This is the service of the families of the Gershonites, in serving and in carrying loads:
25 They shall carry the curtains of the Tabernacle and the Tent of Meeting,
its covering and the covering of sealskin that is on top of it,
the curtain for the door of the Tent of Meeting,
26 the hangings of the courtyard,
the curtain for the door at the gate of the courtyard,
which is around the Tabernacle and the altar,
their ropes and all the equipment for their service,
and everything that has to be done with them. That is their service.
27 All the service of the Gershonites shall be done at the command of Aaron and his sons,
in everything they carry and in everything they do.
You shall tell them exactly what they are responsible for.
28 This is the service of the families of the Gershonites at the Tent of Meeting.
Their duties shall be under the direction of Ithamar, the son of Aaron the priest.

The Merarites VERSES 29–33

29 "You shall count the descendants of Merari by their families and by their fathers' houses.

30 You shall count them from 30 years old up to 50 years old,
everyone who comes to serve, to do the work at the Tent of Meeting.
31 This is the load they shall carry, in all their service at the Tent of Meeting:
the boards of the Tabernacle, its crossbars, its posts and its bases,
32 the posts of the courtyard all around, their bases, their tent pegs and their ropes,
with all their equipment and with everything that belongs to their service.
You shall give them by name the equipment that they shall carry.
33 This is the service of the families of the descendants of Merari, all their service at the Tent of Meeting,
under the direction of Ithamar, the son of Aaron the priest."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Give them by name" means: Everyone knows exactly which part he shall carry. Nothing gets lost. Nothing is forgotten.

Everyone has his task, and every task is important. In the New Testament, Paul compares the church to a body. Every part has its own task, and no part is unimportant (1 Corinthians 12).

The numbers of the working Levites VERSES 34–49

34 Moses, Aaron and the leaders of the community counted the descendants of the Kohathites, by their families and by their fathers' houses,
35 from 30 years old up to 50 years old,
everyone who came to serve, to work at the Tent of Meeting.
36 Those of them who were counted by their families were 2,750.
37 These were the ones counted from the families of the Kohathites, all who served at the Tent of Meeting.
Moses and Aaron counted them at the command of the LORD through Moses.
38 Those counted from the descendants of Gershon, by their families and by their fathers' houses,
39 from 30 years old up to 50 years old,
everyone who came to serve, to work at the Tent of Meeting –
40 those of them who were counted by their families and by their fathers' houses were 2,630.
41 These were the ones counted from the families of the descendants of Gershon, all who served at the Tent of Meeting.
Moses and Aaron counted them at the command of the LORD.
42 Those counted from the families of the descendants of Merari, by their families and by their fathers' houses,
43 from 30 years old up to 50 years old,
everyone who came to serve, to work at the Tent of Meeting –
44 those of them who were counted by their families were 3,200.
45 These were the ones counted from the families of the descendants of Merari.
Moses and Aaron counted them at the command of the LORD through Moses.
46 All the Levites who were counted, whom Moses, Aaron and the leaders of Israel counted,
by their families and by their fathers' houses,
47 from 30 years old up to 50 years old,
everyone who came to do the work of service and the work of carrying loads at the Tent of Meeting –
48 those of them who were counted were 8,580.
49 They were counted through Moses at the command of the LORD,
each one for his service and for his load.
So they were counted by him, as the LORD had commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

2,750 + 2,630 + 3,200 = 8,580. The number is right.

It is interesting: The Merarites have the most workers. After all, they carry the heaviest parts.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 5

Purity in the camp, making things right, suspicion of adultery

The unclean outside the camp VERSES 1–4

1 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
2 "Command the people of Israel to send out of the camp everyone who has leprosy, everyone who has a discharge,
and everyone who has become unclean by touching a dead body.
3 You shall send out both men and women. Send them outside the camp,
so that they do not make their camp unclean. I live in the middle of it."
4 The people of Israel did this and sent them outside the camp.
As the LORD had told Moses, so the people of Israel did.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God lives in the middle of the camp. That is why the camp shall be clean. Whoever is unclean has to stay outside for a while, until he is clean again.

This also protected people from diseases that spread easily. But for those who were affected, it was a hard time. The rules for skin diseases and discharges are in Leviticus 13–15.

Verse 2: Leprosy here means: a serious skin disease.

Confessing and making things right VERSES 5–10

5 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
6 "Speak to the people of Israel:
'Suppose a man or a woman commits any sin that people commit
and so is unfaithful to the LORD.
Then that person is guilty.
7 He shall confess the sin that he has done.
And he shall pay back the damage in full
and add one fifth to it.
He shall give it to the person he has wronged.
8 But suppose the person has no relative to whom the damage can be paid back.
Then the payment for the guilt is made to the LORD.
It belongs to the priest.
This is in addition to the ram of atonement, with which atonement is made for the guilty person.
9 Every offering that is lifted up from all the holy gifts that the people of Israel bring to the priest shall be his.
10 The holy gifts of every person shall belong to the priest.
Whatever anyone gives to the priest shall be his.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This adds to Leviticus 6:1–7. Whoever has harmed someone else shall openly confess his guilt, pay back the damage and add 20 percent.

What is new here: What if the person who was harmed has died and has no relatives? Then the priest gets the money. Making things right does not stop just because the person is no longer there.

Whoever harms a person is also "unfaithful to the LORD." Wrong done to people is also wrong done to God.

Verse 8: Atonement means: the guilt is taken away, and there is peace with God again.

When a man suspects his wife VERSES 11–15

11 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
12 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them:
'Suppose a man's wife goes astray and is unfaithful to him.
13 Another man sleeps with her.
It is hidden from the eyes of her husband and kept secret.
She has made herself unclean,
but there is no witness against her,
and she was not caught in the act.
14 And a spirit of jealousy comes over her husband,
and he is jealous of his wife, and she really has made herself unclean.
Or a spirit of jealousy comes over him,
and he is jealous of his wife, but she has not made herself unclean.
15 Then the man shall bring his wife to the priest.
And he shall bring her offering for her:
about 2 quarts of barley flour.
He shall not pour any oil on it or put any frankincense on it.
For it is a grain offering of jealousy,
a grain offering of remembering that brings guilt to remembrance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says: one tenth of an ephah of barley flour.

This is about a case that is hard for us to read today. A man suspects that his wife has cheated on him. But there is no proof and there are no witnesses.

Verse 14 says clearly: Maybe she really has committed adultery. But maybe the man is only jealous without a reason. Both are possible.

Back then, a jealous man could cause his wife a lot of suffering. He could send her away or even use violence. This procedure takes the matter out of his hands. He may not judge her himself. He must bring the woman to the priest. There, God decides.

Verse 15: Frankincense is a sweet-smelling resin that is burned.

The bitter water VERSES 16–28

16 "'The priest shall bring her near and set her before the LORD.
17 The priest shall take holy water in a clay pot.
And the priest shall take some of the dust that is on the floor of the Tabernacle
and put it into the water.
18 The priest shall set the woman before the LORD
and let the hair of her head hang loose.
He shall put the grain offering of remembering in her hands, the grain offering of jealousy.
And the priest shall hold in his hand the bitter water that brings a curse.
19 "'The priest shall make the woman take an oath and say to her:
"If no man has slept with you,
and if you have not gone astray and made yourself unclean
while you were under your husband's authority,
then may this bitter water that brings a curse not harm you.
20 But if you have gone astray
while you were under your husband's authority,
and if you have made yourself unclean,
and a man other than your husband has slept with you –"
21 then the priest shall make the woman swear the oath with the curse.
And the priest shall say to the woman:
"May the LORD make you a curse and an oath among your people,
when the LORD makes your thigh waste away and your belly swell.
22 May this water that brings a curse go into your body
and make your belly swell and your thigh waste away."
And the woman shall say: "Amen, Amen."
23 "'The priest shall write these curses in a book.
And he shall wash them off into the bitter water.
24 He shall make the woman drink the bitter water that brings the curse.
And the water that brings the curse shall go into her and become bitter.
25 The priest shall take the grain offering of jealousy out of the woman's hand.
He shall wave the grain offering before the LORD and bring it to the altar.

26 The priest shall take a handful of the grain offering as its memorial part
and burn it on the altar.
After that he shall make the woman drink the water.
27 "'When he has made her drink the water, then this will happen:
If she has made herself unclean and has been unfaithful to her husband,
then the water that brings the curse will go into her and become bitter.
Her belly will swell, and her thigh will waste away.
And the woman will become a curse among her people.
28 But if the woman has not made herself unclean, but is clean,
then she shall be free and shall be able to have children.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The water is made of holy water, dust from the floor of the sanctuary and the ink of the curses that was washed off. Of course this water is not poisonous. If something happens, then only through God himself.

Nobody knows for sure what "thigh waste away and belly swell" exactly means. Maybe it means that the woman cannot have children or has a miscarriage. "Thigh" here is probably a polite word for the sexual organs.

"Amen" means: "So be it." The woman herself agrees to the oath.

If the woman is innocent, she is declared innocent in public. Then nobody may blame her for anything anymore. This protected the woman against false suspicion.

Summary VERSES 29–31

29 "'This is the law for jealousy,
when a wife who is under her husband's authority goes astray and makes herself unclean,
30 or when a spirit of jealousy comes over a man and he is jealous of his wife.
Then he shall set the woman before the LORD,
and the priest shall carry out this whole law on her.
31 The man shall be free from guilt.
But that woman shall carry her guilt.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For us today this procedure is very hard to bear. It is one-sided: Only the woman is tested, not the man. There is no such procedure for a man whose wife suspects him. This shows the unequal position of men and women at that time.

The Jewish teachers also saw this procedure critically. They limited it with many conditions. In the first century AD, Rabbi Yohanan ben Zakkai ended it completely. He said: When there were more and more unfaithful men, the water could no longer be used on the women (Mishnah Sotah 9:9).

Jesus took women and men equally seriously. He said that a man who desires another woman also already commits adultery (Matthew 5:28). And he saved a woman who had been caught in adultery from being stoned to death (John 8:1–11).

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 6

The vow of the Nazirites – the blessing of Aaron

Whoever gives himself to God in a special way VERSES 1–8

1 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them:
'Suppose a man or a woman makes a special vow,
the vow of a Nazirite, to set himself apart for the LORD.
3 Then he shall stay away from wine and strong drink.
He shall not drink vinegar made from wine or vinegar made from strong drink.
He shall not drink any grape juice, and he shall not eat fresh or dried grapes.
4 As long as he is set apart, he shall eat nothing that comes from the grapevine,
from the seeds to the skins.
5 "'As long as his vow to be set apart lasts, no razor shall touch his head,
until the days are over in which he sets himself apart for the LORD.
He shall be holy.
He shall let the locks of the hair on his head grow long.
6 "'As long as he sets himself apart for the LORD, he shall not go near a dead body.
7 He shall not make himself unclean, not even for his father, his mother, his brother or his sister when they die.
For the sign that he is set apart for God is on his head.
8 As long as he is set apart, he is holy to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A "Nazirite" is a person who gives himself completely to God for a certain time. The word comes from the Hebrew word "nazir": set apart, dedicated.

Important: This is true for men and for women. Anyone could make this vow, not only priests.

A Nazirite has three signs:

1. No wine and nothing from the grapevine. Wine stands for parties and for an easy life in the land.

2. The hair is not cut. The long hair is a sign that everyone can see: This person belongs completely to God right now.

3. No contact with the dead, not even with his own parents. In this he is even stricter than an ordinary priest, like the high priest (Leviticus 21:11).

Famous Nazirites in the Bible are Samson (Judges 13), Samuel (1 Samuel 1:11) and probably John the Baptist (Luke 1:15). Paul also made such a vow (Acts 18:18; 21:23–26).

Verse 2: A vow is a solemn promise to God.

When someone suddenly dies beside him VERSES 9–12

9 "'Suppose someone dies very suddenly beside him.
And so he makes his head that is set apart unclean.
Then he shall shave his head on the day he is made

clean.
He shall shave it on the seventh day.
10 On the eighth day he shall bring two turtledoves or two
young pigeons to the priest,
to the door of the Tent of Meeting.
11 The priest shall offer one as a sin offering and the other
as a burnt offering.
He shall make atonement for him,
because he became guilty through the dead body.
And the priest shall make his head holy again on that
same day.
12 He shall set himself apart again for the LORD for the
days of his vow.
And he shall bring a male lamb one year old as a guilt
offering.
But the earlier days no longer count,
because his time of being set apart was made unclean.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sometimes something happens that is nobody's fault: Someone suddenly dies beside you. Then the Nazirite has to start over. The time before no longer counts.

This shows how serious the vow is. But it also shows: You can start again.

The end of the time of being set apart VERSES 13–21

13 "'This is the law for the Nazirite:
When the days of his being set apart are over,
he shall be brought to the door of the Tent of Meeting.
14 And he shall bring his offering to the LORD:
a male lamb one year old without any defect as a burnt
offering,
a female lamb one year old without any defect as a sin
offering,
a ram without any defect as a peace offering,
15 a basket of bread made without yeast, cakes of fine flour
mixed with oil,
and thin wafers made without yeast and spread with
oil,
together with their grain offering and their drink
offerings.
16 "'The priest shall bring them before the LORD.
And he shall offer the man's sin offering and his burnt
offering.
17 He shall offer the ram to the LORD as a peace offering,
together with the basket of bread made without yeast.
The priest shall also offer its grain offering and its
drink offering.
18 "'The Nazirite shall shave his head that was set apart at
the door of the Tent of Meeting.
He shall take the hair of his head that was set apart
and put it into the fire that burns under the peace
offering.
19 The priest shall take the boiled shoulder of the ram,
one cake without yeast from the basket and one wafer
without yeast.
He shall put them into the hands of the Nazirite after
he has shaved his head that was set apart.
20 And the priest shall wave them before the LORD as a
wave offering.
They are holy and belong to the priest,
together with the breast that is waved and the thigh
that is offered.
After that, the Nazirite may drink wine again.
21 "'This is the law for the Nazirite who makes a vow,
and for his offering to the LORD for his being set
apart,
in addition to whatever else he can afford.
He must do just as he has promised in his vow, by the
law for his being set apart.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end of the time of being set apart, the Nazirite brings many offerings: burnt offerings, sin offerings, peace offerings. It is a big celebration.

His long hair is cut off and burned. It was the sign that he was set apart. Now it belongs completely to God.

After that he may drink wine again and live a normal life.

Whoever wants to give more may give more. But what you have promised, you must also keep.

The blessing of Aaron VERSES 22–27

22 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
23 "Speak to Aaron and to his sons and tell them:
'This is how you shall bless the people of Israel.'
Tell them:
24 'The LORD bless you and keep you.
25 The LORD make his face shine on you and be gracious
to you.
26 The LORD lift up his face toward you and give you
peace.'
27 So they shall put my name on the people of Israel.
And I will bless them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the best-known and most beautiful texts in the whole Bible. It is called "the Aaronic blessing" or "the priestly blessing."

It is still spoken in synagogues today. And in very many churches, every worship service ends with exactly these words.

The name of the LORD comes three times. Each line gets a little longer, like a blessing that keeps on growing.

"Bless" means: God gives good things, life and success.
"Keep" means: God protects.

"Make his face shine on you" is a picture: God looks at you kindly, the way a father or a mother smiles lovingly at their child.

"Peace" in Hebrew is "shalom." That is more than "no war." It means: Everything is whole and good, with God, with other people and with yourself.

Verse 27 is important: The priests speak the words. But God himself gives the blessing: "And I will bless them."

Archaeologists found two small silver scrolls in Jerusalem with this blessing written on them. They are about 2,600 years old. They are among the oldest known Bible texts in the world.

Chapter 7

The gifts of the 12 tribal leaders

Wagons and oxen for the Levites VERSES 1–9

1 Moses had finished setting up the Tabernacle.
He had anointed it and made it holy, together with all its furniture.
And he had also anointed and made holy the altar with all its equipment.
2 On that day the leaders of Israel brought gifts. They were the heads of their fathers' houses.
They were the leaders of the tribes. They were in charge of those who had been counted.
3 They brought their offering before the LORD:
6 covered wagons and 12 oxen,
a wagon for every 2 leaders and an ox for each leader.
They brought them in front of the Tabernacle.
4 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
5 "Accept these from them.
They shall be used for the work at the Tent of Meeting.
Give them to the Levites, to every man according to his work."
6 Moses took the wagons and the oxen and gave them to the Levites.
7 He gave two wagons and four oxen to the descendants of Gershon, according to their work.
8 He gave four wagons and eight oxen to the descendants of Merari, according to their work,
under the direction of Ithamar, the son of Aaron the priest.
9 But to the descendants of Kohath he gave none.
For their work was with the holy things. They carried them on their shoulders.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The chapter goes back in time a little: to the day when the sanctuary was finished (Exodus 40).

The wagons help with transport. The Merarites get the most wagons, because they carry the heavy boards and posts. The Gershonites get two wagons for the coverings and curtains.

The Kohathites get no wagon. The holy things, like the ark of the covenant, must be carried on the shoulders. Holy things are not simply loaded up like luggage.

12 days, 12 gifts VERSES 10–11

10 The leaders brought gifts for the dedication of the altar on the day it was anointed.
Dedication means: the altar is given to God and used for the first time.
The leaders brought their offerings in front of the altar.
11 The LORD said to Moses:
"They shall bring their offering, each leader on his own day, for the dedication of the altar."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the 12 tribal leaders bring their gifts, on 12 days one after the other. Each one brings exactly the same thing. And the Bible writes down each gift separately and completely.

When you read it, it can seem boring. But it has a purpose: Every tribe is equally important. The small tribe gets just as much room as the big one. None is cut short. God sees every single gift.

The gifts are: a silver plate of 130 shekels, a silver bowl of 70 shekels, both full of flour with oil, and a gold dish of 10 shekels, full of incense. Besides that, many animals for the different offerings. A shekel is about 0.4 ounces. In the text, the weight in pounds and ounces is given in brackets.

The first day: Nahshon from the tribe of Judah VERSES 12–17

12 On the first day, Nahshon, the son of Amminadab, from the tribe of Judah, brought his offering.
13 His offering was:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3 pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a grain offering;
14 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of incense;
15 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year old, as a burnt offering;
16 one male goat as a sin offering;
17 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams, five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Nahshon, the son of Amminadab.

The second day: Nethanel from the tribe of Issachar VERSES 18–23

18 On the second day, Nethanel, the son of Zuar, the leader of Issachar, brought his offering.
19 He brought as his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3 pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a grain offering;
20 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of incense;
21 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year old, as a burnt offering;
22 one male goat as a sin offering;
23 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams, five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Nethanel, the son of Zuar.

The third day: Eliab from the tribe of Zebulun VERSES 24–29

24 On the third day came Eliab, the son of Helon, the leader of the descendants of Zebulun.
25 He brought his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3

pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a grain offering;
26 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of incense;
27 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year old, as a burnt offering;
28 one male goat as a sin offering;
29 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams, five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Eliab, the son of Helon.

The fourth day: Elizur from the tribe of Reuben
VERSES 30–35

30 On the fourth day came Elizur, the son of Shedeur, the leader of the descendants of Reuben.
31 He brought his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3 pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a grain offering;
32 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of incense;
33 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year old, as a burnt offering;
34 one male goat as a sin offering;
35 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams, five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Elizur, the son of Shedeur.

The fifth day: Shelumiel from the tribe of Simeon
VERSES 36–41

36 On the fifth day came Shelumiel, the son of Zurishaddai, the leader of the descendants of Simeon.
37 He brought his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3 pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a grain offering;
38 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of incense;
39 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year old, as a burnt offering;
40 one male goat as a sin offering;
41 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams, five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Shelumiel, the son of Zurishaddai.

The sixth day: Eliasaph from the tribe of Gad VERSES 42–47

42 On the sixth day came Eliasaph, the son of Deuel, the leader of the descendants of Gad.
43 He brought his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3 pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a grain offering;
44 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of incense;
45 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year old, as a burnt offering;
46 one male goat as a sin offering;
47 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams, five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Eliasaph, the son of Deuel.

The seventh day: Elishama from the tribe of Ephraim
VERSES 48–53

48 On the seventh day came Elishama, the son of Ammihud, the leader of the descendants of Ephraim.
49 He brought his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3 pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a grain offering;
50 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of incense;
51 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year old, as a burnt offering;
52 one male goat as a sin offering;
53 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams, five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Elishama, the son of Ammihud.

The eighth day: Gamaliel from the tribe of Manasseh
VERSES 54–59

54 On the eighth day came Gamaliel, the son of Pedahzur, the leader of the descendants of Manasseh.
55 He brought his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3 pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a grain offering;
56 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of incense;
57 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year old, as a burnt offering;
58 one male goat as a sin offering;
59 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams, five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Gamaliel, the son of Pedahzur.

The ninth day: Abidan from the tribe of Benjamin
VERSES 60–65

60 On the ninth day came Abidan, the son of Gideoni, the leader of the descendants of Benjamin.
61 He brought his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3 pounds),

and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by
the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a
grain offering;
62 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of
incense;
63 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year
old, as a burnt offering;
64 one male goat as a sin offering;
65 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams,
five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Abidan, the son of Gideoni.

The tenth day: Ahiezer from the tribe of Dan VERSES 66–71

66 On the tenth day came Ahiezer, the son of
Ammishaddai, the leader of the descendants of Dan.
67 He brought his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3
pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by
the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a
grain offering;
68 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of
incense;
69 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year
old, as a burnt offering;
70 one male goat as a sin offering;
71 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams,
five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Ahiezer, the son of
Ammishaddai.

The eleventh day: Pagiel from the tribe of Asher VERSES 72–77

72 On the eleventh day came Pagiel, the son of Ochran, the
leader of the descendants of Asher.
73 He brought his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3
pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by
the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a
grain offering;
74 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of
incense;
75 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year
old, as a burnt offering;
76 one male goat as a sin offering;
77 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams,
five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Pagiel, the son of Ochran.

The twelfth day: Ahira from the tribe of Naphtali VERSES 78–83

78 On the twelfth day came Ahira, the son of Enan, the
leader of the descendants of Naphtali.
79 He brought his offering:
a silver plate that weighed 130 shekels (about 3
pounds),
and a silver bowl of 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds), by
the shekel of the sanctuary,
both of them full of fine flour mixed with oil, as a
grain offering;
80 a gold dish of 10 shekels (about 4 ounces), full of
incense;
81 one young bull, one ram and one male lamb one year
old, as a burnt offering;
82 one male goat as a sin offering;
83 and as a peace offering: two head of cattle, five rams,
five male goats and five male lambs one year old.
This was the offering of Ahira, the son of Enan.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> The order of the tribes is the same as in the order of the camp in Chapter 2: first Judah, Issachar and Zebulun in the east, then Reuben, Simeon and Gad in the south, then Ephraim, Manasseh and Benjamin in the west, and last Dan, Asher and Naphtali in the north.
>
> On the sixth day, the WEB, our English source text, again calls the father of Eliasaph "Deuel," as in Chapter 1. In Chapter 2 it said "Reuel."

The total of all the gifts VERSES 84–88

84 This was the gift from the leaders of Israel for the
dedication of the altar, on the day when it was
anointed:
12 silver plates, 12 silver bowls, 12 gold dishes.
85 Each silver plate weighed 130 shekels (about 3 pounds),
and each bowl 70 shekels (about 1.7 pounds).
All the silver of the dishes weighed 2,400 shekels
(about 60 pounds), by the shekel of the sanctuary.
86 The 12 gold dishes, full of incense, weighed 10 shekels
(about 4 ounces) each, by the shekel of the sanctuary.
All the gold of the dishes weighed 120 shekels (about 3
pounds).
87 All the cattle for the burnt offering were 12 bulls,
with 12 rams and 12 male lambs a year old, and their
grain offering,
and 12 male goats as a sin offering.
88 And all the cattle for the peace offering were 24 bulls,
with 60 rams, 60 male goats and 60 male lambs a year
old.
This was the gift for the dedication of the altar, after it
had been anointed.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> The Bible gives the weights like this: 130 shekels for each silver plate, 70 shekels for each silver bowl, together 2,400 shekels of silver. 10 shekels for each gold dish, together 120 shekels of gold.
>
> The math is right: $12 \times 130 + 12 \times 70 = 2{,}400$. And $12 \times 10 = 120$.
>
> Altogether there were 252 animals. It was a big dedication celebration. The whole people gave together, tribe by tribe.

God speaks to Moses VERSE 89

89 Moses went into the Tent of Meeting to speak with the
LORD.
Then he heard the voice speaking to him
from above the mercy seat on the ark of the
Testimony, from between the two cherubim.
The mercy seat is the gold lid on top of the ark.
Cherubim are heavenly beings.
And the LORD spoke to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the goal of everything: The sanctuary is finished and dedicated. And now God speaks with Moses there, just as he had promised (Exodus 25:22).

All the gifts, all the offerings, all the effort had this one purpose: that God lives among his people and speaks with them.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 8

The lampstand and the dedication of the Levites

The seven lamps VERSES 1–4

1 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
2 "Speak to Aaron and tell him:
'When you light the lamps, the seven lamps shall give
light to the area in front of the lampstand.'"
3 Aaron did this.
He lit its lamps so that they gave light to the area in
front of the lampstand,
as the LORD had commanded Moses.
4 This is how the lampstand was made: of hammered
gold.
From its base to its flowers it was hammered work.
He made the lampstand by the pattern that the LORD
had shown Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the gifts of the tribal leaders (Chapter 7), the lampstand is lit. Now there is light in the sanctuary.

The lamps shall shine forward, toward the table with the 12 loaves of bread across from it. The light of God shines on the 12 tribes.

The Levites are made clean VERSES 5–14

5 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
6 "Take the Levites from among the people of Israel and
make them clean.
7 This is what you shall do to them to make them clean:
Sprinkle the water of cleansing on them.
They shall shave their whole bodies with a razor,
wash their clothes and make themselves clean.
8 Then they shall take a young bull and its grain offering,
fine flour mixed with oil.
And you shall take another young bull as a sin
offering.
9 You shall bring the Levites in front of the Tent of
Meeting.
And you shall gather the whole community of the
people of Israel.
10 You shall bring the Levites before the LORD.
The people of Israel shall lay their hands on the Levites.
11 And Aaron shall offer the Levites before the LORD as a
wave offering on behalf of the people of Israel.
So they shall do the work of the LORD.
12 "The Levites shall lay their hands on the heads of the
bulls.
You shall offer one as a sin offering and the other as a
burnt offering to the LORD,
to make atonement for the Levites.
13 You shall set the Levites before Aaron and before his
sons,
and offer them to the LORD as a wave offering.
14 So you shall set the Levites apart from among the
people of Israel.
And the Levites shall be mine.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Levites are not anointed like the priests. They are made clean: with water, by shaving and by washing. That is a sign of a new beginning.

Verse 10 is special: All the people lay their hands on the Levites. The Levites stand before God in the place of the whole people. They serve in the place of the firstborn of all the families.

The Levites are "offered as a wave offering." With animals and bread, the gift was waved back and forth in front of the altar. With the Levites, it is probably a solemn gesture by which they are handed over to God. They are like a living gift of the people to God.

Later Paul writes: Give your bodies to God as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God (Romans 12:1). Acceptable means: God is pleased with it.

The Levites belong to God VERSES 15–19

15 "After that, the Levites shall go in to do the work at the
Tent of Meeting.
You shall make them clean and offer them as a wave
offering.
16 For they are given to me completely from among the
people of Israel.
I have taken them for myself instead of all who are the
first to come from the womb,
instead of all the firstborn of the people of Israel.
17 For all the firstborn among the people of Israel are
mine, both people and animals.
On the day when I struck down all the firstborn in the
land of Egypt, I made them holy for myself.
18 I have taken the Levites instead of all the firstborn
among the people of Israel.
19 I have given the Levites as a gift to Aaron and to his
sons, from among the people of Israel.
They shall do the work of the people of Israel at the
Tent of Meeting
and make atonement for the people of Israel,
so that no plague comes on the people of Israel when
the people of Israel come near the sanctuary."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Levites are a "gift" for the priests. They help them with all the work.

And they protect the people. Because they do the work at the sanctuary, nobody else has to come too close to the holy

things and put himself in danger.

The dedication is carried out VERSES 20–22

20 Moses, Aaron and the whole community of the people
of Israel did this to the Levites.
The people of Israel did to them everything the LORD
had commanded Moses about the Levites.
21 The Levites made themselves clean from sin and
washed their clothes.
And Aaron offered them before the LORD as a wave
offering.
And Aaron made atonement for them to make them
clean.
22 After that, the Levites went in to do their work at the
Tent of Meeting, before Aaron and before his sons.
As the LORD had commanded Moses about the
Levites, so they did to them.

The age of service for the Levites VERSES 23–26

23 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
24 "This is the rule for the Levites:
From 25 years old and up they shall come to serve and
work at the Tent of Meeting.
25 And from the age of 50 they shall stop doing the work
and shall serve no more.
26 But they shall help their brothers at the Tent of
Meeting to carry out their duties.
They shall no longer do the work themselves.
This is how you shall arrange the duties of the Levites."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Chapter 4 it said: The Levites work from 30 to 50 years old. Here it says: from 25. Maybe the first five years were a time of training. Jewish teachers have explained it this way.

At 50, the Levites go into a kind of retirement. They no longer have to carry heavy loads. But they are not useless. They help the younger ones and pass on their experience. That is a beautiful picture of old age: You no longer do everything, but you are still needed.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 9

The second Passover and the cloud over the sanctuary

The Passover in the wilderness VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD spoke to Moses in the wilderness of Sinai,
in the first month of the second year after they had
come out of the land of Egypt.
He said:
2 "The people of Israel shall keep the Passover at its
appointed time.
3 On the fourteenth day of this month, in the evening,
you shall keep it at its appointed time.
You shall keep it by all its statutes and by all its rules."
4 Moses told the people of Israel that they should keep
the Passover.
5 And they kept the Passover in the first month, on the
fourteenth day of the month, in the evening, in the
wilderness of Sinai.
The people of Israel did everything just as the LORD
had commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

One year after leaving Egypt, Israel celebrates the Passover again for the first time. They remember the night when they were set free.

In time, this comes before Chapter 1. The book of Numbers does not always tell things in their exact order.

When someone cannot keep the Passover VERSES 6–14

6 But there were some men who were unclean because
they had touched the dead body of a person.
So they could not keep the Passover on that day.
They came to Moses and Aaron on that day.
7 These men said to him:
"We are unclean because we touched the dead body of a
person.
Why should we be kept back?
Why may we not bring the offering of the LORD at its
appointed time with the people of Israel?"
8 Moses answered them:
"Wait. I will hear what the LORD commands about
you."
9 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
10 "Tell the people of Israel:
'Suppose someone among you or your descendants is
unclean because he touched a dead body.
Or suppose he is on a long journey far away.
He shall still keep the Passover for the LORD.
11 They shall keep it in the second month, on the
fourteenth day, in the evening.
They shall eat it with bread made without yeast and
with bitter herbs.
12 They shall leave none of it until the morning.
And they shall not break any of its bones.
They shall keep it by all the statutes of the Passover.
13 But suppose a man is clean and not on a journey,
and he still fails to keep the Passover.
That person shall be cut off from his people.
Because he did not bring the offering of the LORD at
its appointed time,
that man shall carry his sin.
14 "'Suppose a foreigner lives among you and wants to
keep the Passover for the LORD.
Then he shall keep it by the statute of the Passover and
by its rules.
You shall have one and the same statute for the
foreigner and for the one who was born in the land.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Some men could not join the celebration. They had touched a dead body, maybe because they had buried a relative. They are sad to be left out. They ask Moses.

Moses does not know the answer. He says honestly: "Wait. I will hear what the LORD commands about you." Even a great leader does not have to know everything.

And God gives a gracious answer: Whoever cannot keep it may keep the Passover one month later. Nobody shall stay left out just because he was prevented. Judaism still has this "second Passover" (Pesach Sheni) today.

"They shall not break any of its bones" – the Gospel of John remembers this rule when Jesus dies on the cross and none of his bones are broken (John 19:36). Christians see Jesus as the Passover lamb.

Foreigners may also keep the Passover if they hold on to Israel's God. The same law applies to them.

The cloud leads the people VERSES 15–23

15 On the day when the Tabernacle was set up,
the cloud covered the Tabernacle, the Tent of the Testimony.
In the evening, something that looked like fire was over the Tabernacle until the morning.
16 It was always like this:
The cloud covered it, and at night it looked like fire.
17 Whenever the cloud rose up from over the Tent, the people of Israel set out after it.
And in the place where the cloud stopped, there the people of Israel set up their camp.
18 At the command of the LORD the people of Israel set out,
and at the command of the LORD they set up camp.
As long as the cloud stayed over the Tabernacle, they stayed in the camp.
19 When the cloud stayed over the Tabernacle for many days,
the people of Israel kept the LORD's command and did not set out.
20 Sometimes the cloud was over the Tabernacle for only a few days.
Then they stayed in the camp at the command of the LORD,
and they set out at the command of the LORD.
21 Sometimes the cloud was there only from evening until morning.
When the cloud rose up in the morning, they set out.
Or if it stayed a day and a night: When the cloud rose up, they set out.
22 It could be two days, or a month, or a year that the cloud stayed over the Tabernacle –
the people of Israel stayed in the camp and did not set out.
But when it rose up, they set out.
23 At the command of the LORD they set up camp,
and at the command of the LORD they set out.
They kept the LORD's command, at the command of the LORD through Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The cloud over the sanctuary is the visible sign that God is there. In the daytime it is a cloud. At night it shines like fire.

Israel does not make its own travel plans. God decides when they move on and when they stay. Sometimes only one night, sometimes a whole year.

That was surely not always easy. Nobody knew how long they would stay. They had to be ready every day. It is a practice in trust: God knows the way.

Seven times these verses say "at the command of the LORD." The whole life of the people is guided by God.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 10

The silver trumpets and setting out from Sinai

Two trumpets of silver VERSES 1–10

1 The LORD spoke to Moses.
He said:
2 "Make two trumpets of silver.
Make them of hammered silver.
You shall use them to call the community together and to let the camps set out.
3 When they blow both of them, the whole community shall gather to you at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
4 If they blow only one, then the leaders shall gather to you, the heads of the thousands of Israel.
5 "When you blow the alarm, the camps that lie on the east side shall set out.
6 When you blow the alarm a second time, the camps that lie on the south side shall set out.
They shall blow an alarm when they are to set out.
7 But when the assembly is to be called together, you shall blow, but you shall not sound the alarm.
8 "The sons of Aaron, the priests, shall blow the trumpets.
This shall be a statute for you forever, for all your generations.
9 When you go to war in your land against the enemy who oppresses you,
then you shall sound an alarm with the trumpets.
Then you will be remembered before the LORD your God,
and you will be saved from your enemies.
10 Also on your days of joy, at your feasts and at the beginnings of your months,
you shall blow the trumpets over your burnt offerings and over your peace offerings.
They shall be a reminder for you before your God.
I am the LORD your God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With so many people, you need signals that everyone can hear. The trumpets are like a bell or a siren.

There are different signals: a steady sound to gather and a special signal to set out, maybe short, quick notes.

The trumpets sound in hard times, in war, and in happy times, at feasts. Both times they say: God, remember us!

On the Arch of Titus in Rome you can still see today how the Romans carried away such trumpets as loot after they destroyed the temple in AD 70.

Verse 5: The alarm is a special signal to set out.

Setting out from Mount Sinai VERSES 11–13

11 In the second year, in the second month, on the twentieth day of the month,
the cloud rose up from over the Tabernacle of the covenant.
12 And the people of Israel set out from the wilderness of Sinai, one stage after another.
And the cloud stopped in the wilderness of Paran.
13 So they set out for the first time, at the command of the LORD through Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel was at Mount Sinai for almost a whole year. There they received the commandments and built the sanctuary. Now the journey goes on, toward the promised land.

The wilderness of Paran lies north of Sinai, in the south of today's Israel.

The order for setting out VERSES 14–28

14 First the flag of the camp of the descendants of Judah set out, by their armies.
Nahshon, the son of Amminadab, led its army.
15 Nethanel, the son of Zuar, led the army of the tribe of the descendants of Issachar.
16 Eliab, the son of Helon, led the army of the tribe of the descendants of Zebulun.
17 Then the Tabernacle was taken down.
And the descendants of Gershon and the descendants of Merari, who carried the Tabernacle, set out.
18 Then the flag of the camp of Reuben set out, by their armies.
Elizur, the son of Shedeur, led its army.
19 Shelumiel, the son of Zurishaddai, led the army of the tribe of the descendants of Simeon.
20 Eliasaph, the son of Deuel, led the army of the tribe of the descendants of Gad.
21 Then the Kohathites set out, carrying the holy things.
The others set up the Tabernacle before they arrived.
22 Then the flag of the camp of the descendants of Ephraim set out, by their armies.
Elishama, the son of Ammihud, led its army.
23 Gamaliel, the son of Pedahzur, led the army of the tribe of the descendants of Manasseh.
24 Abidan, the son of Gideoni, led the army of the tribe of the descendants of Benjamin.
25 Last of all, the flag of the camp of the descendants of Dan set out, by their armies.
It was the rear guard of all the camps.
Ahiezer, the son of Ammishaddai, led its army.
26 Pagiel, the son of Ochran, led the army of the tribe of the descendants of Asher.
27 Ahira, the son of Enan, led the army of the tribe of the descendants of Naphtali.
28 This was the order in which the people of Israel traveled, by their armies.
And they set out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The order is planned wisely: The Gershonites and the Merarites with the boards and coverings leave early. So they can already set up the tent at the new campsite. Then, when the Kohathites arrive with the holy things, the Tabernacle is already standing ready.

Moses asks Hobab to come along VERSES 29–32

29 Moses spoke to Hobab, the son of Reuel the Midianite, Moses' father-in-law.
He said:
"We are traveling to the place about which the LORD said: 'I will give it to you.'
Come with us, and we will treat you well.
For the LORD has promised good things to Israel."
30 But Hobab answered him:
"I will not go.
I will go back to my own land and to my relatives."
31 Moses said:
"Please do not leave us!
For you know where we can camp in the wilderness.
You can be our eyes.
32 If you go with us – yes, if you do –
then we will do to you all the good that the LORD does to us."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hobab knows the wilderness. He knows where there is water and where it is good to camp. Moses asks him to be their guide.

It is interesting: God leads through the cloud. Still, Moses gladly accepts the help of an experienced person. Trusting God and human wisdom do not exclude each other.

It is not completely clear who Hobab is. The sentence can be understood to mean that Reuel is Moses' father-in-law and Hobab is his son, so Moses' brother-in-law. In Judges 4:11, Hobab himself is called Moses' father-in-law. We also know Moses' father-in-law by the name Jethro (Exodus 3:1).

We are not told here whether Hobab came along. Later his descendants live in Israel (Judges 1:16). So he probably went with them.

The ark goes ahead VERSES 33–36

33 They set out from the mountain of the LORD and traveled for three days.
The ark of the covenant of the LORD went ahead of them for the three days of travel,
to look for a resting place for them.
34 And the cloud of the LORD was over them in the daytime when they set out from the camp.
35 Whenever the ark set out, Moses said:
"Rise up, LORD!
Let your enemies be scattered!
Let those who hate you run away before you!"
36 And whenever it stopped, he said:
"Come back, LORD, to the many thousands upon thousands of Israel!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The ark of the covenant goes ahead. God himself looks for the way and the resting place for his people. It is like a shepherd who walks ahead of his flock.

The two prayers of Moses are very old. They are still spoken today in Jewish worship services when the Torah scroll is taken out of its cabinet and put back again. Psalm 68:1 (in some Bibles 68:2) also begins with these words.

In many Hebrew Bibles there are special marks around verses 35–36: upside-down letters called "nun." They show that these two verses are something very special.

NUMBERS

Chapter 11

The people complain – meat, quails and God's Spirit

Fire at the edge of the camp VERSES 1–3

1 The people complained loudly in the ears of the LORD.
When the LORD heard it, he became angry.
The fire of the LORD burned among them
and burned up some of the edge of the camp.
2 Then the people cried out to Moses.
And Moses prayed to the LORD, and the fire died down.
3 That place was named Taberah,
because the fire of the LORD had burned among them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people have been traveling for only three days, and already they begin to complain. We are not told exactly what about.

Here a sad series of stories begins: Again and again the people grumble against God and against Moses. This "grumbling" goes through the whole book of Numbers.

"Taberah" means "burning."

Moses prays for the people, even though they complain. He speaks up for them before God, as he already did with the golden calf (Exodus 32).

"Who will give us meat?" VERSES 4–9

4 The mixed crowd that was among them was filled with greedy craving.
And the people of Israel also cried again and said:
"Who will give us meat to eat?
5 We remember the fish that we ate in Egypt for free,
the cucumbers, the melons, the leeks, the onions and the garlic.
6 But now we have lost our appetite.
We see nothing at all except this manna."
7 The manna was like coriander seed.
And it looked like bdellium.
8 The people went around and gathered it.
They ground it in hand mills or crushed it in mortars.
They boiled it in pots and made flat cakes from it.
It tasted like fresh oil.
9 When the dew fell on the camp at night, the manna fell on it too.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "mixed crowd" are people who were not Israelites but had left Egypt together with them (Exodus 12:38). They start, and the Israelites join in.

It is amazing: They remember the good food in Egypt that they got "for free." They have forgotten that they were slaves, had to work hard, and that their children were killed. The memory of the past becomes nicer than it really was.

God gives them manna every day, bread from heaven. But they are tired of it. They no longer see the miracle, only the same thing every day.

Bdellium is a clear, yellowish resin.

Moses cannot go on VERSES 10–15

10 Moses heard the people crying, family by family, every man at the door of his tent.
Then the LORD became very angry.
And Moses was upset too.
11 Moses said to the LORD:
"Why have you treated your servant so badly?
Why have I not found favor in your eyes,
that you put the burden of this whole people on me?
12 Did I conceive this whole people?
Did I give birth to them,
that you tell me: 'Carry them in your arms, as a nurse carries a baby,
to the land that you swore to give to their ancestors'?
13 Where can I get meat to give to this whole people?
For they cry to me and say: 'Give us meat to eat!'
14 I cannot carry this whole people alone.
It is too heavy for me.
15 If you treat me like this,
then please kill me right now, if I have found favor in your eyes.
Then I will not have to see my misery anymore."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the Bible shows a great leader at the end of his strength. Moses is exhausted and desperate. He even wishes he were dead.

Moses speaks quite openly with God, even with complaints. And God does not punish him for it. He listens and helps. You may tell God everything, even your despair.

The picture is strong: Moses feels like a mother who has to carry a screaming baby. But he asks: "Did I give birth to them?" In this way he is saying indirectly: You, God, gave birth to this people. You must carry them.

Other great people in the Bible were also so exhausted that they wanted to die, for example Elijah (1 Kings 19:4) and Jonah (Jonah 4:3).

Whoever feels like this today is not alone. It is good to talk to someone about it and to look for help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

God promises help and meat VERSES 16–23

16 The LORD said to Moses:
"Gather for me 70 men from the elders of Israel,
men you know to be elders of the people and officers over them.
Bring them to the Tent of Meeting. Let them stand there with you.
17 I will come down and speak with you there.
I will take some of the Spirit that is on you and put it on them.
Then they shall carry the burden of the people with you,
so that you do not have to carry it alone.
18 "And say to the people:
'Make yourselves holy for tomorrow. Then you will eat meat.
For you have cried in the ears of the LORD and said:
"Who will give us meat to eat? We were well off in Egypt."
So the LORD will give you meat, and you will eat.
19 You will not eat it for only 1 day, or 2 days, or 5 days, or 10 days, or 20 days,
20 but for a whole month,
until it comes out of your nostrils and you are sick of it.
For you have rejected the LORD, who is among you,
and you have cried before him and said: "Why did we ever come out of Egypt?"'"
21 Moses said:
"The people I live among are 600,000 men on foot.
And you say: 'I will give them meat, so that they can eat for a whole month.'
22 Shall flocks and herds be slaughtered for them, so that it is enough for them?
Or shall all the fish in the sea be caught for them, so that it is enough for them?"
23 The LORD said to Moses:
"Has the LORD's hand become too short?
Now you will see whether my word comes true for you or not."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God answers two problems: Moses gets helpers, and the people get meat.

The helpers get some of the Spirit that is on Moses. Moses does not lose anything by it. God's Spirit is shared, but it does not become less. It is like a candle that is used to light other candles.

But the meat is not simply a gift. "Until it comes out of your nostrils" – God gives them what they want, far too much of it. Sometimes what we want so badly is not good for us.

Even Moses doubts whether God can do this. God's answer: "Has the LORD's hand become too short?" That means: Is anything too hard for me?

Verse 16: Elders are older men who lead the people.

The Spirit comes on the 70 elders VERSES 24–30

24 Moses went out and told the people the words of the LORD.
He gathered 70 men from the elders of the people and placed them all around the Tent.
25 The LORD came down in the cloud and spoke to him.
He took some of the Spirit that was on him and put it on the 70 elders.
When the Spirit rested on them, they prophesied.
To prophesy means here: to speak words given by God's Spirit.
But after that they did not do it again.
26 But two men had stayed in the camp.
One was named Eldad, and the other was named Medad.
The Spirit rested on them too.
They were among those whose names had been written down,
but they had not gone out to the Tent.
And they prophesied in the camp.
27 Then a young man ran and told Moses:
"Eldad and Medad are prophesying in the camp!"
28 Joshua, the son of Nun, answered. He was Moses' helper and one of his chosen men.
He said: "My lord Moses, stop them!"
29 Moses said to him:
"Are you jealous for my sake?
I wish that all the LORD's people were prophets,
and that the LORD would put his Spirit on them all!"
30 Then Moses went back into the camp, he and the elders of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Prophesying" here probably means: They were seized by God's Spirit and spoke with great excitement. Maybe they praised God loudly. It was a visible sign that God's Spirit was on them.

Eldad and Medad are not in the right place. Still, God's Spirit comes on them. God cannot be locked in, not even in his own sanctuary.

Joshua wants to protect Moses. He is afraid that Moses will lose respect. But Moses is generous: "I wish that all the LORD's people were prophets!" Moses does not want power for himself alone. He is glad when others receive God's Spirit too.

This wish of Moses comes true later. Through the prophet Joel, God announces: After this I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh (Joel 2:28; in some Bibles 3:1). "All flesh" means: all people. And at Pentecost, Peter says that this has now happened (Acts 2:17).

The quails and the punishment VERSES 31–35

31 Then a wind went out from the LORD
and brought quails from the sea.
Quails are small birds.
It let them fall all around the camp,
about a day's journey on one side and a day's journey on the other side,
and about 3 feet above the ground.
32 The people got up and gathered the quails all that day,
all that night and all the next day.
Whoever gathered the least had about 580 gallons.
And they spread them out for themselves all around the camp.
33 The meat was still between their teeth, before it was even chewed,
when the LORD became angry with the people.

And the LORD struck the people with a very terrible plague.
34 That place was named Kibroth Hattaavah,
because there they buried the people who had been greedy.
35 From Kibroth Hattaavah the people traveled on to Hazeroth.
And they stayed at Hazeroth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says: 2 cubits high and 10 homers. A cubit is about 18 inches. A homer is about 58 gallons.

Quails are small birds that fly over this area in large flocks twice a year. When they are tired, they fly very low, and you can catch them easily. God sends a wind that brings them right to the camp.

The words "2 cubits high" can mean that the birds lay on top of each other that high. Or that they flew so low that people could catch them with their hands.

The people gather as if they were drunk, for two days and a night. Their greed is the problem, not the meat.

"Kibroth Hattaavah" means "graves of craving." The place reminds us that greed can kill.

Psalm 106:15 says about this: God gave them what they asked for, but he sent a wasting disease into their souls. That means: They got what they wanted. But it was not good for them.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 12

Miriam and Aaron speak against Moses

The complaint VERSES 1–3

1 Miriam and Aaron spoke against Moses
because of the Cushite woman he had married.
For he had married a Cushite woman.
2 They said,
"Has the LORD really spoken only with Moses?
Hasn't he also spoken with us?"
And the LORD heard it.
3 But Moses was a very humble man,
more humble than any other person on the face of the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Miriam and Aaron are the older sister and brother of Moses. Miriam saved him when he was a baby (Exodus 2:4–8). After the crossing of the sea, she started the song of victory (Exodus 15:20–21). Aaron is the high priest.

"Cush" is the land south of Egypt, today Sudan or Ethiopia. The people there had dark skin. It is not quite clear who this woman is. Maybe it is Zipporah, the first wife of Moses. Maybe Moses married a second wife.

The complaint about the woman is probably only an excuse. The real reason is jealousy: "We are important too! God speaks with us too!"

Moses does not defend himself. The Bible says: He was the most humble person on earth. Humble does not mean weak. It means: You do not have to make yourself look big. You leave it to God to defend you.

God defends Moses VERSES 4–9

4 Suddenly the LORD said to Moses, to Aaron, and to Miriam,
"You three, come out to the Tent of Meeting!"
So the three of them came out.
5 The LORD came down in a pillar of cloud
and stood at the door of the tent.
He called Aaron and Miriam, and they both stepped forward.
6 He said,
"Listen to my words!
If there is a prophet among you,
I, the LORD, make myself known to him in a vision.
I speak with him in a dream.
7 But it is not like that with my servant Moses.
He is faithful in all my house.
8 With him I speak mouth to mouth,
clearly and not in riddles.
And he sees the form of the LORD.
So why were you not afraid to speak against my servant, against Moses?"
9 The LORD became very angry with them, and he left.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God himself defends Moses. He explains: Yes, I also speak with other prophets, but in dreams and pictures. With Moses I speak directly, "mouth to mouth," like with a friend (Exodus 33:11).

"He is faithful in all my house" – Moses is like a faithful manager who is trusted with the whole house. The Letter to the Hebrews in the New Testament quotes this verse and compares Moses with Jesus (Hebrews 3:2–6).

Miriam gets leprosy VERSES 10–16

10 The cloud moved away from over the tent.
Look! Miriam had leprosy. She was as white as snow.
Aaron turned toward Miriam and saw that she had leprosy.
11 Aaron said to Moses,
"Oh, my lord, please do not hold this sin against us.
We have acted foolishly, and we have sinned.
12 Please do not let her be like a baby born dead,
whose body is already half eaten away when it comes out of its mother's womb."
13 Then Moses cried out to the LORD,
"Heal her, God, I beg you!"
14 The LORD said to Moses,
"If her father had only spit in her face,
wouldn't she be ashamed for seven days?
Let her be shut out of the camp for seven days.
After that she shall be brought back in."
15 So Miriam was shut out of the camp for seven days.
And the people did not travel on until Miriam had been brought back in.

16 After that, the people traveled on from Hazeroth
and set up camp in the wilderness of Paran.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Miriam becomes sick, "as white as snow." This is a kind of skin disease (see Leviticus 13). It is a bitter irony: She complained about a woman with dark skin, and now her own skin becomes white and sick.

Why is only Miriam punished and not Aaron? The Bible does not say. Maybe because Miriam was the driving force. Her name comes first in verse 1. Maybe Aaron is spared because as high priest he could otherwise not do his service. To us today it still seems unequal.

The way Moses reacts is wonderful. He is not offended and does not take revenge. He prays for his sister right away. It is one of the shortest prayers in the Bible: "Heal her, God, I beg you!"

God hears the prayer. Miriam has to stay outside for only seven days. Then she is healed and comes back.

And the whole people waits for her. No one travels on before Miriam is back. She is not forgotten. She belongs.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 13

12 spies explore the land

12 men are chosen VERSES 1–16

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Send out men to explore the land of Canaan, which I
am giving to the people of Israel.
From each tribe of their ancestors you shall send one
man. Each one shall be a leader among them."
3 Moses sent them out from the wilderness of Paran, as
the LORD had commanded.
All of them were men who were heads among the
people of Israel.
4 These were their names:
From the tribe of Reuben: Shammua the son of
Zaccur.
5 From the tribe of Simeon: Shaphat the son of Hori.
6 From the tribe of Judah: Caleb the son of Jephunneh.
7 From the tribe of Issachar: Igal the son of Joseph.
8 From the tribe of Ephraim: Hoshea the son of Nun.
9 From the tribe of Benjamin: Palti the son of Raphu.
10 From the tribe of Zebulun: Gaddiel the son of Sodi.
11 From the tribe of Joseph, from the tribe of Manasseh:
Gaddi the son of Susi.
12 From the tribe of Dan: Ammiel the son of Gemalli.
13 From the tribe of Asher: Sethur the son of Michael.
14 From the tribe of Naphtali: Nahbi the son of Vophsi.
15 From the tribe of Gad: Geuel the son of Machi.
16 These are the names of the men whom Moses sent to
explore the land.
And Moses called Hoshea the son of Nun Joshua.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people are now at the border of the promised land. Before they go in, 12 spies are to explore the land, one from each tribe.

Two names are important: Caleb from Judah and Hoshea from Ephraim.

Moses gives Hoshea a new name: Joshua. "Hoshea" means "rescue." "Joshua" means "The LORD rescues." By the way, the Greek name for Joshua is "Jesus."

The task VERSES 17–20

17 Moses sent them to explore the land of Canaan. He said
to them,
"Go up this way through the South, and go up into the
hill country.
18 Look at the land and see what it is like.
Look at the people who live in it: whether they are
strong or weak, whether they are few or many.
19 See what the land is like that they live in, whether it is
good or bad.
See what the cities are like that they live in, whether
they live in open camps or in strong, walled cities.
20 See what the soil is like, whether it is rich or poor, and
whether there are trees in it or not.
Be brave, and bring back some of the fruit of the land."
It was the time of the first ripe grapes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The South" is called the "Negev" in Hebrew. That is the dry south of the land.

The first grape harvest is in July or August.

Exploring the land VERSES 21–25

21 So they went up and explored the land,
from the wilderness of Zin to Rehob, up to where the
road goes to Hamath.
22 They went up through the South and came to Hebron.
Ahiman, Sheshai, and Talmai, the descendants of
Anak, lived there.
Hebron had been built seven years before Zoan in
Egypt.
23 They came to the valley of Eshcol.
There they cut off a branch with a single cluster of
grapes.
Two men carried it on a pole.
They also brought some pomegranates and figs.
24 That place was called the valley of Eshcol,
because of the cluster of grapes that the people of
Israel cut off there.
25 After 40 days they came back from exploring the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The spies go through the whole land, from the south far up into the north.

Abraham, Sarah, Isaac, and Jacob are buried in Hebron (Genesis 23; 49:29–31).

The "descendants of Anak," or "Anakites," were a people of very tall men.

"Eshcol" means "cluster of grapes." The cluster was so big that two men had to carry it. Today this picture is the logo of Israel's Ministry of Tourism.

The report: a good land, but strong people VERSES 26–29

26 They went and came to Moses, to Aaron, and to the whole community of the people of Israel,
in the wilderness of Paran, at Kadesh.
They gave a report to them and to the whole community.
And they showed them the fruit of the land.
27 They told Moses,
"We came to the land where you sent us.
It really is flowing with milk and honey. And this is its fruit.
28 But the people who live in the land are strong.
And the cities have strong walls and are very large.
We also saw the descendants of Anak there.
29 The Amalekites live in the South.
The Hittites, the Jebusites, and the Amorites live in the hill country.
And the Canaanites live by the sea and along the Jordan River."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The report begins well: The land really is as wonderful as God promised.

But then comes the big "but." The spies only see the problems now.

Caleb against the others VERSES 30–33

30 Caleb calmed the people in front of Moses and said,
"Let's go up right away and take the land!
We can surely do it!"
31 But the men who had gone up with him said,
"We cannot go up against these people.
For they are stronger than we are."
32 And they spread a bad report among the people of Israel about the land they had explored. They said,
"The land we went through to explore is a land that eats up the people who live in it.
And all the people we saw in it are very tall.
33 We also saw the Nephilim there, the descendants of Anak, who come from the Nephilim.
We felt like grasshoppers.
And that is how we looked to them too."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

All 12 saw the same things. But they come to different conclusions.

But 10 of them see only the giants and the walls. They forget that God is with them. They even exaggerate: Before, the land was good. Now it "eats up the people who live in it."

Caleb sees the same giants. But he trusts that God is stronger.

The "Nephilim" are legendary giants from ancient times (Genesis 6:4). The spies want to say: We have no chance against these people.

"We felt like grasshoppers" – that is a sad sentence. Whoever makes himself small also believes that others see him as small. Fear distorts the way we see things.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 14

The people refuse – 40 years in the wilderness

The people want to go back to Egypt VERSES 1–5

1 Then the whole community raised their voices and cried out.
And the people wept that night.
2 All the people of Israel complained against Moses and against Aaron.
The whole community said to them,
"We wish we had died in the land of Egypt!
Or we wish we had died in this wilderness!
3 Why is the LORD bringing us into this land, only to be killed by the sword?
Our wives and our little children will be captured or killed!
Wouldn't it be better for us to go back to Egypt?"
4 And they said to each other,
"Let's choose a leader and go back to Egypt!"
5 Then Moses and Aaron fell on their faces in front of the whole assembly of the community of the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the saddest moments in the history of Israel. They are standing right in front of the goal. God has set them free from Egypt, led them through the sea, and fed them in the wilderness. And now they want to go back into slavery.

They even want to choose a new leader. This is a rebellion against Moses and against God.

Moses and Aaron throw themselves to the ground. Maybe out of horror, maybe to pray to God.

Joshua and Caleb plead with the people VERSES 6–10

6 Joshua the son of Nun and Caleb the son of Jephunneh were among the men who had explored the land.
They tore their clothes.
7 They said to the whole community of the people of Israel,
"The land we went through to explore is a very, very good land.
8 If the LORD is pleased with us, he will bring us into this land and give it to us,
a land flowing with milk and honey.
9 Only do not rebel against the LORD!
And do not be afraid of the people of the land.
For we will eat them up like bread.
Their protection has left them, and the LORD is with us.
Do not be afraid of them!"

10 But the whole community threatened to stone them with stones.
Then the glory of the LORD appeared at the Tent of Meeting to all the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joshua and Caleb tear their clothes. That is a sign of great grief and despair.

Their message is simple: "The LORD is with us. Do not be afraid of them!" What matters is not how strong the enemies are, but how strong God is.

But the people want to stone the two of them. Sometimes people do not want to hear the truth. Instead they silence the person who tells it.

At this moment, God steps in.

God wants to destroy the people – Moses pleads
VERSES 11–19

11 The LORD said to Moses,
"How long will these people treat me with contempt?
How long will they not believe in me,
in spite of all the signs I have done among them?
12 I will strike them with a deadly disease and take away their inheritance.
And I will make you into a nation that is greater and stronger than they are."
13 Moses said to the LORD,
"Then the Egyptians will hear about it.
For with your power you brought these people up out of their country.
14 They will tell it to the people who live in this land.
They have heard that you, LORD, are among these people.
For you, LORD, are seen face to face.
Your cloud stands over them.
And you go ahead of them, in a pillar of cloud by day and in a pillar of fire by night.
15 Now if you kill these people all at once, like one man,
then the nations that have heard how famous you are will say,
16 'The LORD was not able to bring these people into the land he promised them with an oath.
That is why he slaughtered them in the wilderness.'
17 Now please let the power of the Lord be shown to be great,
just as you have said:
18 'The LORD is slow to anger and rich in loving kindness.
He forgives wrongdoing and disobedience.
But he will not simply let the guilty go free.
He brings the wrongdoing of the fathers on the children, on the third and on the fourth generation.'
19 Please forgive the wrongdoing of these people, because your loving kindness is so great,
just as you have forgiven these people from Egypt until now."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

As with the golden calf (Exodus 32), God wants to destroy the people and start again with Moses. And as back then, Moses stands up for the people.

Moses reminds God of his own words: "slow to become angry, and rich in loving kindness and faithfulness ... He forgives wrongdoing" (Exodus 34:6–7). Moses prays with God's own words.

Interesting: God's true strength does not show in punishing, but in forgiving (verse 17).

God forgives – but this generation will not come into the land
VERSES 20–25

20 The LORD said,
"I have forgiven them, as you asked.
21 But as surely as I live, and as surely as the whole earth will be filled with the glory of the LORD:
22 All these men have seen my glory and my signs, which I did in Egypt and in the wilderness.
And yet they have tested me these 10 times and have not listened to my voice.
23 So they will surely not see the land that I promised their ancestors with an oath.
None of those who treated me with contempt will see it.
24 But my servant Caleb has a different spirit in him, and he has followed me completely.
So I will bring him into the land where he went.
And his descendants will own it.
25 The Amalekites and the Canaanites live in the valley.
So tomorrow turn around and go into the wilderness, on the road to the Red Sea."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God forgives. The people are not destroyed. But forgiveness does not mean that there are no consequences. Whoever does not trust God cannot go into a land that can only be won with trust.

The words "10 times" mean: again and again. The number 10 stands for completeness.

Caleb has "a different spirit." He sees the same things as the others, but he has trust instead of fear.

"Red Sea": That is what the WEB, our English source text, says. In Hebrew it says "Sea of Reeds." Here it probably means the Gulf of Aqaba.

The punishment: 40 years in the wilderness
VERSES 26–35

26 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron. He said,
27 "How long must I put up with this evil community that complains against me?
I have heard the complaints that the people of Israel make against me.
28 Tell them,
'As surely as I live, says the LORD:
Just as you have spoken in my ears, so I will do to you.
29 Your dead bodies will fall in this wilderness:
all of you who were counted, your whole number, everyone 20 years old and older who has complained against me.
30 You will surely not come into the land where I promised with an oath to let you live, except Caleb the son of Jephunneh and Joshua the son of Nun.
31 But your little children, who you said would be captured or killed,
I will bring them in.
They will get to know the land that you have rejected.

32 But as for you, your dead bodies will fall in this
wilderness.
33 Your children will wander in the wilderness for 40
years.
They will carry the results of your unfaithfulness,
which was like prostitution,
until your dead bodies have all come to an end in the
wilderness.
34 You explored the land for 40 days.
For each day there will be a year.
So you will carry your guilt for 40 years.
And you will know what it means when I turn away
from you.'
35 I, the LORD, have spoken.
I will surely do this to this whole evil community that
has gathered together against me.
In this wilderness they will come to an end, and there
they will die."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The punishment is bitter. But it is exactly what the people themselves said. They had cried out: "we wish we had died in this wilderness!" (verse 2). Now God says: "Just as you have spoken in my ears, so I will do to you" (verse 28).

And they had said that their children would die. God says: No, your children are the very ones who will receive the land. The ones you were afraid for will be saved.

40 days of exploring, 40 years in the wilderness. A whole generation dies in the wilderness. Only the new generation will go into the land.

"Unfaithfulness, which was like prostitution" – that is often how the Bible describes being unfaithful to God. God and his people are like a married couple.

The New Testament tells this story as a warning: "don't harden your hearts as in the rebellion, on the day of testing in the wilderness" (Hebrews 3:7–19).

The 10 spies die VERSES 36–38

36 Moses had sent men to explore the land.
They came back and made the whole community
complain against him,
because they spread a bad report about the land.
37 These men who spread the bad report about the land
died by a plague before the LORD.
38 But of the men who went to explore the land,
Joshua the son of Nun and Caleb the son of Jephunneh
stayed alive.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The 10 spies carry a special responsibility. They infected the whole people with their fear.

Joshua and Caleb survive. They will be the only ones of their generation to enter the land.

Too late: the failed attack VERSES 39–45

39 Moses told these words to all the people of Israel.
And the people mourned greatly.
40 They got up early in the morning and went up to the
top of the mountain. They said,
"Here we are!
We will go up to the place the LORD has promised.
For we have sinned."
41 Moses said,
"Why are you now disobeying the LORD's command?
It will not succeed.
42 Do not go up, for the LORD is not among you.
Otherwise your enemies will defeat you.
43 For the Amalekites and the Canaanites are there in
front of you.
And you will be killed by the sword.
Because you have turned away from following the
LORD,
the LORD will not be with you."
44 But they dared to go up to the top of the mountain
anyway.
Yet the ark of the LORD's covenant and Moses did not
leave the camp.
45 Then the Amalekites and the Canaanites who lived on
that mountain came down.
They attacked them and beat them, all the way to
Hormah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now that it is too late, they want to go up after all. But this is not real trust in God. It is stubbornness. Yesterday God said, "Go!" and they did not want to. Today God says, "Stay!" and they go anyway.

They set out without God and without the ark of the covenant. And they lose.

The story shows: It is not only about doing the right thing. It is about doing it at the right time and with God.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 15

Rules for life in the land – the fringes on the clothes

Grain offerings and drink offerings with the animal offerings VERSES 1–12

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them,
'You will come into the land where you will live,
which I am giving you.
3 There you will bring an offering by fire to the LORD:
a burnt offering or a sacrifice, to keep a promise,
or as a free-will gift, or at your feasts,
to make a pleasant smell for the LORD,
from the cattle or from the sheep and goats.
4 Then the one who brings his offering shall bring a grain
offering to the LORD:
about 2 quarts of fine flour mixed with about 1 quart of
oil.
5 And you shall prepare about 1 quart of wine as a drink
offering,
with the burnt offering or with the sacrifice, for each
lamb.

6 "'For a ram you shall prepare a grain offering:
about 4½ quarts of fine flour mixed with a little more
than 1 quart of oil.
7 And as a drink offering you shall bring a little more
than 1 quart of wine,
as a pleasant smell for the LORD.
8 When you prepare a young bull as a burnt offering or as
a sacrifice,
to keep a promise, or as a peace offering for the LORD.
9 Then with the bull a grain offering shall be brought:
about 7 quarts of fine flour mixed with about 2 quarts
of oil.
10 And as a drink offering you shall bring about 2 quarts of
wine,
as an offering by fire, a pleasant smell for the LORD.
11 This is how it shall be done for each bull, for each ram,
for each male lamb or young goat.
12 However many animals you prepare,
you shall do this for each one of them, according to
their number.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible, the measures are given like this: one tenth, two tenths, or three tenths of an ephah of flour, and a fourth, a third, or half a hin of oil and wine. An ephah is about 6 gallons. A hin is about 1 gallon.

Right after the story of the spies, God says: "You will come into the land ..." That is a sign of hope. The punishment is not the last word. Israel will come into the land, with fields for flour, olive trees, and vineyards.

Flour, oil, and wine belong with every animal offering. The bigger the animal, the more there is. It is like a complete festive meal.

The same law for foreigners VERSES 13–16

13 "'Everyone born in Israel shall do these things in this
way
when they bring an offering by fire, a pleasant smell
for the LORD.
14 Suppose a foreigner lives with you,
or someone else is among you in your generations.
If he wants to bring an offering by fire, a pleasant smell
for the LORD,
he shall do it just as you do.
15 For the assembly there shall be one rule,
for you and for the foreigner who lives with you.
It is a rule forever, for all your generations.
As you are, so the foreigner shall be before the LORD.
16 One law and one rule shall apply
to you and to the foreigner who lives with you.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Four times it is stressed here: The same applies to the foreigner as to the Israelite. "As you are, so the foreigner shall be before the LORD."

Before God there are no first-class and second-class people. Everyone may come and bring God his gift.

The first bread for God VERSES 17–21

17 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
18 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them,
'You will come into the land where I am bringing you.
19 When you eat from the bread of the land,
you shall give a wave offering to the LORD.
20 From the first of your dough you shall give a flat loaf as
a wave offering.
You shall lift it up just like the wave offering from the
threshing floor.
21 From the first of your dough you shall give a wave
offering to the LORD, for all your generations.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Every time people bake bread, they are to give a piece of the dough to God. That way, even with their daily bread, they think of the one who gives it.

To this day, many Jewish women take off a small piece of dough when they bake bread and burn it. This custom is called "taking challah." That is also where the name "challah" for the Sabbath bread comes from.

In the Lord's Prayer, Christians pray: "Give us today our daily bread" (Matthew 6:11).

Verse 20: A threshing floor is the place where the grain is separated from the stalks.

When the community sins without meaning to VERSES 22–26

22 "'Suppose you make a mistake
and do not keep all these commandments that the
LORD has spoken to Moses,
23 everything the LORD has commanded you through
Moses,
from the day the LORD gave the commandments and
on through all your generations.
24 If it happened without meaning to, without the
community knowing about it,
then the whole community shall offer one young bull
as a burnt offering,
as a pleasant smell for the LORD,
with its grain offering and its drink offering, as the
rule says,
and one male goat as a sin offering.
25 The priest shall make atonement for the whole
community of the people of Israel,
and they will be forgiven.
For it was a mistake.
And they have brought their offering, an offering by
fire to the LORD,
and their sin offering before the LORD, because of
their mistake.
26 The whole community of the people of Israel will be
forgiven,
and also the foreigner who lives among them.
For the whole people did it without meaning to.

When one person sins without meaning to VERSES 27–29

27 "'If one person sins without meaning to,
he shall bring a one-year-old female goat as a sin
offering.
28 The priest shall make atonement before the LORD for
the person who made the mistake,
because he sinned without meaning to.
He shall make atonement for him, and he will be
forgiven.

29 You shall have one and the same law for anyone who
does something without meaning to,
for the one born among the people of Israel and for the
foreigner who lives among them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For mistakes made without meaning to, there is always a way to forgiveness. We already know this from Leviticus 4.

Whoever sins with a raised hand VERSES 30–31

30 "'But suppose someone does something with a raised
hand,
whether he was born in Israel or is a foreigner.
He insults the LORD.
That person shall be cut off from his people.
31 For he has treated the word of the LORD with
contempt and has broken his commandment.
That person shall be completely cut off.
His guilt is on him.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"With a raised hand" means: on purpose, boldly, in defiance. Someone knows exactly that something is wrong and does it anyway, to mock God.

There is no offering for something like this. Offerings only help when a person is sorry. Whoever despises God on purpose and without regret shuts himself out.

But the Bible shows in many places: When a person really turns back and is sorry, God is ready to forgive even then (for example King David in Psalm 51).

A man gathers wood on the Sabbath VERSES 32–36

32 While the people of Israel were in the wilderness,
they found a man gathering sticks on the Sabbath day.
33 Those who found him gathering sticks
brought him to Moses and Aaron and to the whole
community.
34 They kept him under guard,
because it had not yet been made clear what should be
done to him.
35 The LORD said to Moses,
"The man must be put to death.
The whole community shall stone him with stones
outside the camp."
36 So the whole community brought him outside the
camp,
and they stoned him to death with stones, as the LORD
had commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is probably here as an example of a sin "with a raised hand." The man knew that no work was to be done on the Sabbath (Exodus 35:2–3). Still, he did it openly.

To us today, the punishment is shockingly harsh. The Bible tells it without making it look better than it is. It shows how seriously the Sabbath was taken back then. It was the sign of the covenant between God and Israel (Exodus 31:13–17).

Later, Jesus stressed the meaning of the Sabbath in a new way: "The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath" (Mark 2:27). And he healed people on the Sabbath.

Here, too: The large Jewish and Christian communities today reject such punishments.

The fringes on the clothes VERSES 37–41

37 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
38 "Speak to the people of Israel and tell them
that they shall make fringes on the corners of their
clothes, for all their generations.
And on the fringe of each corner they shall put a blue
cord.
39 It shall be a fringe for you.
When you look at it, you shall remember all the
LORD's commandments and do them.
And you shall not follow your own heart and your
own eyes,
which you used to chase after like a prostitute.
40 That way you shall remember all my commandments
and do them,
and be holy to your God.
41 I am the LORD your God,
who brought you out of the land of Egypt to be your
God.
I am the LORD your God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The fringes are called "tzitzit" in Hebrew. They are like a string tied around your finger: When you see them, you remember God's commandments.

The blue color was very expensive. It is a reminder of the sky and of the clothes of the priests. Every Israelite, not only the priest, wears something blue as a sign: I belong to God.

"Not following your own heart and your own eyes" – people are easily led by what they see and want to have. The fringes are meant to help them look to God instead.

To this day, devout Jews wear these fringes on a prayer shawl (tallit) or on an undergarment. Jesus also wore fringes like this. The sick woman touched "the fringe of his garment" (Matthew 9:20).

Verses 37–41 are part of the "Shema Israel," the most important Jewish prayer, which is said in the morning and in the evening.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 16

The rebellion of Korah

Korah and his people rebel VERSES 1–3

1 Korah was the son of Izhar, the son of Kohath, the son
of Levi.
He gathered some men,
together with Dathan and Abiram, the sons of Eliab,
and On, the son of Peleth. They were from the tribe of
Reuben.
2 They rose up against Moses,
together with 250 men from the people of Israel.

They were leaders of the community, men called to the assembly, well-known men.

3 They gathered together against Moses and against Aaron and said to them,
"You go too far!
The whole community is holy, every one of them,
and the LORD is among them.
So why do you put yourselves above the LORD's assembly?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the biggest rebellion against Moses and Aaron.

Korah is a Levite from the family of Kohath, a cousin of Moses and Aaron. He already has an important service at the holy tent. But he wants more: He wants to be a priest like Aaron.

Dathan, Abiram, and On come from the tribe of Reuben. Reuben was Jacob's firstborn son. Maybe they felt pushed aside and wanted to lead.

Their argument sounds good: "The whole community is holy!" That is even true (Exodus 19:6). But they use this sentence to get power for themselves. They do not care about God, only about themselves.

Moses answers Korah VERSES 4–11

4 When Moses heard it, he fell on his face.

5 He said to Korah and to his whole group,
"In the morning the LORD will show who belongs to him and who is holy.
He will let that person come near to him.
Whoever he chooses, he will let come near to him.

6 Do this:
Korah and his whole group shall take fire pans for incense.

7 Tomorrow put fire in them and put incense on them before the LORD.
The man whom the LORD chooses is the one who is holy.
You go too far, you sons of Levi!"

8 Moses said to Korah,
"Listen, you sons of Levi!

9 Is it too small a thing for you that the God of Israel has set you apart from the community of Israel?
He has brought you near to himself,
so that you do the work at the LORD's tabernacle and stand before the community to serve them.

10 He has brought you near, and all your brothers, the sons of Levi, with you.
And now you want to be priests as well?

11 That is why you and your whole group have gathered together against the LORD!
Who is Aaron, that you complain against him?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses does not answer with violence. He leaves the decision to God. God is to show whom he has chosen.

He reminds Korah of what he already has: an honorable service. But Korah is not satisfied. Envy never sees what you have, only what others have.

"Who is Aaron?" – Aaron did not take his office for himself. God gave it to him. Whoever rebels against Aaron is really rebelling against God.

Dathan and Abiram refuse VERSES 12–15

12 Moses sent for Dathan and Abiram, the sons of Eliab.
But they said, "We will not come up!

13 Is it too small a thing that you have brought us up out of a land flowing with milk and honey,
to kill us in the wilderness?
Do you also have to make yourself a ruler over us?

14 You have not brought us into a land flowing with milk and honey.
You have not given us fields and vineyards as our own.
Do you want to put out the eyes of these men?
We will not come up!"

15 Then Moses became very angry and said to the LORD,
"Do not accept their offering!
I have not taken a single donkey from them,
and I have not harmed any of them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Dathan and Abiram turn the truth upside down. They call Egypt, the land of slavery, "a land flowing with milk and honey." And they blame Moses that they are not in the promised land. But it was the people themselves who did not want to go in (Chapter 14).

"Do you want to put out the eyes of these men?" means something like: Do you think we are stupid? We can see what is going on.

Moses is rightly hurt. He never made himself rich at their expense.

The test with the fire pans VERSES 16–22

16 Moses said to Korah,
"You and your whole group, come before the LORD tomorrow:
you, they, and Aaron.

17 Each man shall take his fire pan and put incense on it.
And each man shall bring his fire pan before the LORD, 250 fire pans.
You and Aaron too, each with his fire pan."

18 So each man took his fire pan, put fire in it, and put incense on it.
And they stood at the door of the Tent of Meeting with Moses and Aaron.

19 Korah gathered the whole community against them at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
Then the glory of the LORD appeared to the whole community.

20 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron. He said,

21 "Separate yourselves from this community, so that I can destroy them in a moment!"

22 Then they fell on their faces and said,
"God, the God of the spirits of all people!
One man sins, and you want to be angry with the whole community?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Korah has stirred up the whole community. God wants to destroy them all.

Once again Moses and Aaron plead for the people. They call God "the God of the spirits of all people." That means: God has given every person life, and he knows each one.

Their argument: It is not fair to punish everyone for the guilt of one person. That is a reminder of Abraham, who pleaded for Sodom (Genesis 18:23–25).

The earth opens up VERSES 23–35

23 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
24 "Speak to the community and say,
'Get away from around the tents of Korah, Dathan, and Abiram!'"
25 Moses got up and went to Dathan and Abiram.
And the elders of Israel followed him.
26 He said to the community,
"Please go away from the tents of these wicked men,
and do not touch anything that belongs to them,
so that you are not destroyed because of all their sins!"
27 So they went away from the tents of Korah, Dathan, and Abiram on every side.
Dathan and Abiram came out and stood at the door of their tents
with their wives, their sons, and their little children.
28 Moses said,
"This is how you will know that the LORD has sent me to do all these things,
and that they do not come from my own mind:
29 If these men die the way all people die,
or if what happens to all people happens to them,
then the LORD has not sent me.
30 But suppose the LORD does something new.
The ground opens its mouth and swallows them up with everything that belongs to them,
and they go down alive into Sheol (the world of the dead).
Then you will understand that these men have treated the LORD with contempt."
31 As soon as he had finished saying all these words, the ground under them split apart.
32 The earth opened its mouth and swallowed them up, with their households, all of Korah's men, and all their belongings.
33 They went down alive into Sheol, they and everything that belonged to them.
The earth closed over them.
And they disappeared from the assembly.
34 All Israel around them ran away when they heard them scream.
For they said, "The earth might swallow us up too!"
35 And fire came out from the LORD and burned up the 250 men who had offered the incense.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a terrible story. God shows in a frightening way whom he has chosen.

"Sheol" is the Hebrew word for the world of the dead. In the old way of thinking, it is the place where all the dead go, deep under the earth.

It is especially hard that the women and children die too. To us today this is almost unbearable. Back then, the family was seen as one unit. The Bible tells this honestly, without making it look better than it is.

But not all of Korah's children died. Later it says clearly: "But the sons of Korah did not die" (Numbers 26:11). Their descendants became singers in the temple. In all, 11 psalms have the heading "by the sons of Korah" (Psalm 42; 44–49; 84–85; 87–88). Psalm 42, for example, begins with a deer that longs for streams of water. The child of a rebel became a singer of praise to God.

The fire pans become a warning sign VERSES 36–40

36 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
37 "Tell Eleazar the son of Aaron the priest
to take the fire pans out of the fire.
And he shall scatter the fire far away.
For the pans are holy,
38 the fire pans of these men who sinned and lost their own lives.
Let them be hammered into thin plates as a covering for the altar.
For they brought them before the LORD, so they are holy.
They shall be a sign for the people of Israel."
39 So Eleazar the priest took the bronze fire pans that the men who were burned had offered,
and they hammered them into a covering for the altar.
40 This was to remind the people of Israel
that no outsider who is not a descendant of Aaron may come near to burn incense before the LORD.
Otherwise it will happen to him as it happened to Korah and his group,
just as the LORD had told Eleazar through Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles, Chapter 17 already begins here. There, verses 36–50 are numbered 17:1–15. We follow the numbering of the WEB, our English source text.

The fire pans are not thrown away. They are made into a covering for the altar. Everyone who sees the altar is to remember: Only those whom God calls may do this service.

The people complain again – Aaron stands between the dead and the living VERSES 41–50

41 But on the next day, the whole community of the people of Israel complained against Moses and Aaron.
They said,
"You have killed the LORD's people!"
42 When the community gathered against Moses and Aaron, they looked toward the Tent of Meeting.
Look! The cloud covered it, and the glory of the LORD appeared.
43 Moses and Aaron went to the front of the Tent of Meeting.
44 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
45 "Get away from this community, so that I can destroy them in a moment!"
Then they fell on their faces.
46 Moses said to Aaron,
"Take your fire pan, put fire from the altar in it, and put incense on it.
Take it quickly to the community and make atonement for them!
For anger has gone out from the LORD. The plague has begun."
47 Aaron did what Moses had said and ran into the middle of the assembly.
The plague had already begun among the people.

He put on the incense and made atonement for the people.
48 He stood between the dead and the living.
And the plague was held back.
49 The people who died in the plague were 14,700,
in addition to those who died because of Korah.
50 Aaron went back to Moses at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
And the plague had stopped.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Unbelievable: The very next day, the people complain again. They blame Moses and Aaron for the death of Korah.

But then something wonderful happens. Aaron, the man everyone complained about, runs into the middle of the plague to save his people. He uses the same fire pan that the fight was about.

"He stood between the dead and the living." That is a powerful picture. The priest puts himself in danger to protect others. That is how God shows who the true priest is: not the one who wants power, but the one who risks his life for others.

Christians see this as a picture of Jesus, who stands between God and people to save them.

NUMBERS

Chapter 17

Aaron's staff blossoms

12 staffs before God VERSES 1–7

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and get staffs from them, a staff for each family, from all their leaders, family by family: 12 staffs.
Write each man's name on his staff.
3 You shall write Aaron's name on the staff of Levi.
For there shall be one staff for each head of their families.
4 Put them in the Tent of Meeting in front of the covenant, where I meet with you.
5 The staff of the man I choose will sprout.
That way I will put an end to the complaints of the people of Israel, which they make against you.
Then I will not have to hear them anymore."
6 Moses spoke to the people of Israel.
And all their leaders gave him staffs, a staff for each leader, family by family, 12 staffs in all.
Aaron's staff was among their staffs.
7 Moses put the staffs before the LORD in the Tent of the Testimony.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles this is 17:16–28, because there Chapter 17 already begins at 16:36.

After Korah's rebellion, it is to become clear once and for all whom God has chosen as priest. That is why there is a test in which no one has to die.

A staff was the sign of a leader. It was made of dead, dry wood. Each staff has the name of a tribal leader on it.

The staff blossoms VERSES 8–11

8 On the next day, Moses went into the Tent of the Testimony.
Look! Aaron's staff for the house of Levi had sprouted.
It had grown buds, produced blossoms, and borne ripe almonds.
9 Moses brought all the staffs out from before the LORD to all the people of Israel.
They looked, and each man took his staff.
10 The LORD said to Moses,
"Put Aaron's staff back in front of the covenant.
It shall be kept there as a sign for the people who rebel.
That way you will put an end to their complaints against me, so that they do not die."
11 Moses did it.
He did just as the LORD had commanded him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Overnight a miracle happens: A dead stick produces buds, blossoms, and ripe almonds, all at the same time.

In Israel, the almond tree is the first tree to blossom in the spring. In Hebrew it is called "shaked," the "one that keeps watch." The lampstand in the holy tent also had blossoms like almond blossoms (Exodus 25:33).

God shows: Where he chooses, life grows out of something dead.

The staff was kept in front of the ark of the covenant as a reminder. According to the Letter to the Hebrews, it was even inside the ark (Hebrews 9:4).

The people are afraid VERSES 12–13

12 The people of Israel said to Moses,
"Look, we are dying! We are lost! We are all lost!
13 Everyone who comes near the LORD's tabernacle dies!
Are we all going to die?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After everything that has happened, the people are very afraid now. They ask: How can we live near God at all without dying?

The next chapter answers this. God appointed the priests and Levites for exactly this purpose: so that the people are protected and can still live near God.

NUMBERS

Chapter 18

The duties and the pay of the priests and Levites

The responsibility of the priests and Levites VERSES 1–7

1 The LORD said to Aaron,
"You and your sons and your family with you
shall carry the guilt that has to do with the holy place.
And you and your sons with you shall carry the guilt
that has to do with your priesthood.
2 Also bring your brothers with you, the tribe of Levi,
the tribe of your father.
They shall join you and serve you.
But you and your sons with you shall serve in front of
the Tent of the Testimony.
3 They shall follow your instructions and do the duties
for the whole tent.
But they shall not come near the objects of the holy
place or the altar,
so that they do not die, neither they nor you.
4 They shall join you
and take care of the Tent of Meeting, for all the work at
the tent.
No outsider shall come near you.
5 "You shall do the duties of the holy place and the duties
of the altar,
so that there is no more anger against the people of
Israel.
6 Look, I myself have taken your brothers, the Levites,
from among the people of Israel.
They are a gift to you, given to the LORD,
to do the work at the Tent of Meeting.
7 You and your sons with you shall do your work as
priests
in everything that has to do with the altar and with
what is behind the curtain.
You shall serve.
I give you the work of the priesthood as a gift.
Any outsider who comes near shall be put to death."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is God's answer to the fear of the people (17:12–13). The priests and Levites stand like a protective layer between the holy God and the people.

"Carry the guilt" means: They carry the responsibility. If something goes wrong in the service at the holy tent, they are responsible, not the whole people.

The priesthood is a "gift." It is not a right that someone can take for himself, as Korah wanted. God gives it.

What belongs to the priests VERSES 8–19

8 The LORD spoke to Aaron,
"Look, I myself have put you in charge of my wave
offerings,
all the holy gifts of the people of Israel.
I have given them to you and your sons because you
were anointed, as your share forever.
9 Of the most holy gifts, the parts that are not burned
shall be yours:
every offering they give to me, every grain offering,
every sin offering, and every guilt offering.
They shall be most holy for you and for your sons.
10 You shall eat it as something most holy.
Every male may eat it. It shall be holy to you.
11 "This is yours too: the gifts they give as wave offerings,
all the wave offerings of the people of Israel.
I have given them to you, to your sons, and to your
daughters with you, as your share forever.
Everyone in your house who is clean may eat it.
12 "I have given you all the best of the oil,
all the best of the new wine and of the grain,
the first part of the harvest that they give to the LORD.
13 The first ripe fruit of everything in their land that they
bring to the LORD
shall be yours.
Everyone in your house who is clean may eat it.
14 "Everything in Israel that is completely given over to
God shall be yours.
15 "Every firstborn,
of all living beings that they bring to the LORD, both
people and animals, shall be yours.
But you must surely let the firstborn sons of people be
bought back.
And you shall also let the firstborn of unclean animals
be bought back.
16 Those who must be bought back you shall buy back
from the age of a month,
at the price you set: 5 shekels of silver, by the shekel of
the holy place, which weighs 20 gerahs.
17 "But you shall not let the firstborn of a cow, a sheep, or
a goat be bought back.
They are holy.
You shall sprinkle their blood on the altar
and burn their fat as an offering by fire, a pleasant
smell for the LORD.
18 Their meat shall be yours, just as the breast of the wave
offering and the right thigh are yours.
19 All the wave offerings from the holy gifts that the
people of Israel bring to the LORD,
I have given to you, to your sons, and to your
daughters with you, as your share forever.
It is a covenant of salt forever before the LORD, for
you and for your descendants with you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The priests live from the gifts of the people. They receive parts of the offerings, the best of the oil, wine, and grain, and the first fruits.

Some things only the priests themselves may eat ("most holy"). Other things the whole family may eat, including the daughters.

A "covenant of salt" is a covenant that lasts forever. Salt does not spoil. Back then, people who ate bread and salt together were firmly bound to each other.

The 5 shekels are about 2 ounces of silver.

God is their inheritance VERSES 20–24

20 The LORD said to Aaron,
"You shall have no inheritance in their land,
and you shall have no share among them.
I am your share and your inheritance among the
people of Israel.
21 "Look, I have given the descendants of Levi the whole
tenth part of everything in Israel as their inheritance.

It is their pay for the work they do, the work at the Tent of Meeting.
22 From now on, the people of Israel shall not come near the Tent of Meeting,
so that they do not carry sin and die.
23 But the Levites shall do the work at the Tent of Meeting.
And they shall carry the guilt for it.
This is a rule forever, for all your generations.
They shall have no inheritance among the people of Israel.
24 For I have given the Levites the tithe of the people of Israel as their inheritance,
which the people give to the LORD as a wave offering.
That is why I have said to them, 'They shall have no inheritance among the people of Israel.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

All the other tribes receive their own area in the promised land. The priests and Levites receive no land.

God says: "I am your share and your inheritance." That is a beautiful sentence. They have no land, but they have God himself. And God provides for them through the gifts of the people.

Psalm 16:5 says something similar: The LORD has given me my share and my cup. He keeps my future safe.

Verse 21: The tenth part is called the tithe.

The Levites also give a tithe VERSES 25–32

25 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
26 "Also speak to the Levites and tell them,
'You will receive from the people of Israel the tithe that I have given you from them as your inheritance.
Then you shall give a wave offering from it to the LORD, a tenth of the tithe.
27 Your wave offering will count for you
as if it were grain from the threshing floor and wine from the full winepress.
28 So you too shall give a wave offering to the LORD from all your tithes
that you receive from the people of Israel.
And from it you shall give the LORD's wave offering to Aaron the priest.
29 From all your gifts you shall give every wave offering to the LORD,
from the best of everything, the holy part of it.'
30 "So you shall tell them,
'When you have given the best of it,
it will count for the Levites like the harvest from the threshing floor and the harvest from the winepress.
31 You may eat it anywhere, you and your families.
For it is your pay for your work at the Tent of Meeting.
32 You will not carry any sin because of it when you have given the best of it.
You shall not dishonor the holy gifts of the people of Israel, so that you do not die.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even the Levites, who live from the tithe, are to give a tithe themselves. No one is excused from giving something back to God.

For the Levites, the tithe is like the harvest for a farmer. And just as the farmer gives some of it away, they give some of it away too.

What they keep is their rightful pay. They may eat it anywhere with their families. Whoever serves others may also live from it (1 Corinthians 9:13–14).

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 19

The red cow and the water for cleansing

The ashes of the red cow VERSES 1–10

1 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron. He said,
2 "This is the rule of the law that the LORD has commanded:
Tell the people of Israel to bring you a red young cow, without spot and without defect, which has never worn a yoke.
3 You shall give her to Eleazar the priest.
He shall lead her outside the camp.
And she shall be killed in front of him.
4 Eleazar the priest shall take some of her blood with his finger
and sprinkle her blood seven times toward the front of the Tent of Meeting.
5 The cow shall be burned in front of him:
her skin, her meat, and her blood, together with her dung, shall be burned.
6 The priest shall take cedar wood, hyssop, and red yarn and throw them into the middle of the fire where the cow is burning.
7 "Then the priest shall wash his clothes and bathe his body in water.
After that he may come into the camp.
But the priest is unclean until the evening.
8 The one who burns the cow shall wash his clothes in water and bathe his body in water.
He is unclean until the evening.
9 "A man who is clean shall gather up the ashes of the cow and put them outside the camp in a clean place.
They shall be kept for the community of the people of Israel,
for the water that is used to cleanse people from uncleanness.
It is a sin offering.
10 The one who gathers the ashes of the cow shall wash his clothes and is unclean until the evening.
This shall be a rule forever for the people of Israel and for the foreigner who lives among them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: A yoke is a wooden frame that animals wear on their necks when they pull a plow.

Verse 6: Hyssop is a small plant with many thin branches.

Whoever touches a dead person becomes unclean. That happened all the time in the wilderness, because many people died there. That is why a way of cleansing is needed.

A red young cow without defect is burned. Her ashes are mixed with water. With this water, people who have touched a dead person are cleansed.

Red is the color of blood and of life. The cedar wood and the red yarn also stand for life. The remedy against death is a sign of life.

What is strange: Whoever makes the cleansing ashes becomes unclean himself. The people who help others become clean take uncleanness on themselves. Jewish teachers have said that even wise King Solomon did not understand this riddle.

The Letter to the Hebrews recalls the ashes of the cow. It says: If even they could cleanse, how much more does the blood of Jesus cleanse us (Hebrews 9:13–14).

Whoever touches a dead person VERSES 11–16

11 "Whoever touches the dead body of any person is
unclean for seven days.
12 He shall cleanse himself with the water on the third
day.
Then he will be clean on the seventh day.
But if he does not cleanse himself on the third day, he
will not be clean on the seventh day.
13 Whoever touches a dead person, the body of someone
who has died,
and does not cleanse himself,
makes the LORD's tabernacle unclean.
That person shall be cut off from Israel.
Because the water for cleansing was not sprinkled on
him, he is unclean.
His uncleanness is still on him.
14 "This is the law when a person dies in a tent:
Everyone who comes into the tent and everyone who
is in the tent is unclean for seven days.
15 Every open container that does not have a lid tied on it
is unclean.
16 "Someone out in the open field may touch a person who
was killed with a sword,
or a dead body, or a human bone, or a grave.
He is unclean for seven days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Death is seen as the most unclean thing of all. It is the opposite of God, who is life.

Whoever touches a dead person may not go into the holy tent for a week. That is not a punishment. People buried their dead with love, and that was good and right. But afterward a person needs time and a cleansing before coming before God again.

Even an open container in a tent with a dead person becomes unclean. But one with a lid stays clean. That is also a good rule for health.

How the cleansing happens VERSES 17–22

17 "For the unclean person, they shall take some of the
ashes of the burned sin offering
and pour running water on them in a container.
18 A clean person shall take hyssop, dip it in the water,
and sprinkle it on the tent, on all the containers, on
the people who were there,
and on the one who touched the bone, the person who
was killed, the dead body, or the grave.
19 The clean person shall sprinkle the unclean person on
the third day and on the seventh day.
On the seventh day he shall cleanse him.
Then that person shall wash his clothes and bathe in
water.
In the evening he is clean.
20 "But someone may be unclean and not cleanse himself.
That person shall be cut off from the assembly,
because he has made the LORD's holy place unclean.
The water for cleansing has not been sprinkled on him.
He is unclean.
21 This shall be a rule for them forever.
The one who sprinkles the water for cleansing shall
wash his clothes.
And the one who touches the water for cleansing is
unclean until the evening.
22 "Whatever the unclean person touches becomes
unclean.
And the person who touches it is unclean until the
evening."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The cleansing takes time: on the third and on the seventh day. There is no quick way back, but there is a sure way.

In Psalm 51:7 (in some Bibles 51:9), David prays that God would cleanse him with hyssop, so that he becomes clean. He is probably thinking of this cleansing. But he means his heart, which is to become clean from guilt.

After the temple was destroyed, this law could no longer be carried out. That is why devout Jews today see themselves as "unclean through the dead." They do not step onto the place of the former Most Holy Place in Jerusalem.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 20

Water from the rock – Moses' mistake – Aaron's death

Miriam dies VERSE 1

1 The people of Israel, the whole community, came into
the wilderness of Zin in the first month.
The people stayed in Kadesh.
Miriam died there, and she was buried there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the story makes a big jump. Almost 40 years have passed since Chapter 14. The old generation has almost all died. Now the new generation is standing at the border of the land again.

Miriam, the sister of Moses and Aaron, dies. The Bible reports it very briefly. Miriam saved Moses when he was a baby, and after the crossing of the sea she sang and danced. Jewish teachers tell this story: As long as Miriam was alive, there was a well that traveled along with the people. That is why right after this it says: "The community had no water."

No water VERSES 2–6

2 The community had no water.
So they gathered together against Moses and against Aaron.
3 The people argued with Moses and said,
"We wish we had died when our brothers died before the LORD!
4 Why have you brought the LORD's assembly into this wilderness,
so that we die here, we and our animals?
5 Why did you make us come up out of Egypt,
only to bring us to this terrible place?
There is no grain here, no figs, no grapevines, and no pomegranates.
And there is no water to drink."
6 Moses and Aaron went away from the assembly to the door of the Tent of Meeting
and fell on their faces.
Then the glory of the LORD appeared to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The new generation complains just like their parents. The words sound almost the same as 40 years before.
Moses and Aaron do not answer with words. They go to God.

Moses' mistake at the rock VERSES 7–13

7 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
8 "Take the staff.
Gather the community, you and your brother Aaron.
And in front of their eyes, speak to the rock, so that it gives its water.
That is how you shall bring water out of the rock for them.
That is how you shall give the community and their animals something to drink."
9 Moses took the staff from where it lay before the LORD,
as the LORD had commanded him.
10 Moses and Aaron gathered the assembly in front of the rock.
And Moses said to them,
"Listen, you rebels!
Must we bring water out of this rock for you?"
11 Moses raised his hand and struck the rock twice with his staff.
Then a lot of water came out.
And the community and their animals drank.
12 The LORD said to Moses and to Aaron,
"You did not believe in me,
and you did not show me as holy in front of the eyes of the people of Israel.
So you will not bring this assembly into the land that I have given them."
13 These are the waters of Meribah,
where the people of Israel argued with the LORD,
and where he showed himself holy among them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the saddest passages about Moses. God had said: "Speak to the rock." But Moses strikes it twice with the staff. The water comes anyway, because God does not let his people die of thirst.

What exactly was the mistake? Jews and Christians have thought a lot about this:

Moses did not do exactly what God had said. He struck instead of speaking.

Moses was angry and called the people "rebels."

Moses said: "Must we bring water out of this rock for you?" As if he and Aaron were doing the miracle, not God.

The result is harsh: Moses and Aaron may not enter the promised land. After 40 years of faithful service, that is hard to grasp.

It shows: Whoever carries a great responsibility is also measured by stricter standards. But God does not leave Moses. He stays his friend to the very end.

"Meribah" means "arguing." There was already a place with this name in Exodus 17:7.

Edom does not let Israel pass through VERSES 14–21

14 From Kadesh, Moses sent messengers to the king of Edom to tell him,
"This is what your brother Israel says:
You know all the trouble that has happened to us.
15 Our ancestors went down into Egypt, and we lived in Egypt for a long time.
The Egyptians treated us and our ancestors badly.
16 When we cried out to the LORD, he heard our voice.
He sent an angel and brought us out of Egypt.
Look, now we are in Kadesh, a town at the edge of your land.
17 "Please let us pass through your land.
We will not go through fields or vineyards,
and we will not drink water from the wells.
We will go along the King's Highway.
We will not turn off to the right or to the left until we have passed through your land."
18 But Edom said to him,
"You shall not pass through my land.
Otherwise I will come out against you with the sword."
19 The people of Israel said to him,
"We will go up on the main road.
And if we drink any of your water, I and my animals, I will pay for it.
Just let me pass through on foot, nothing else."
20 He said, "You shall not pass through."
And Edom came out against him with many people and a strong army.
21 So Edom refused to let Israel pass through his land.
That is why Israel turned away from him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Edomites are descendants of Esau, the twin brother of Jacob (Genesis 36). That is why Israel calls itself "your brother."

Israel asks very politely and promises to take nothing and to pay for everything. But Edom says no.

Israel does not fight against Edom. It takes a detour. God had forbidden Israel to fight against Edom, because they are

brothers (Deuteronomy 2:4–5).

The "King's Highway" was an important trade road east of the Jordan, from Egypt all the way to Syria.

Aaron dies VERSES 22–29

22 They set out from Kadesh,
and the people of Israel, the whole community, came to Mount Hor.
23 The LORD spoke to Moses and to Aaron on Mount Hor, at the border of the land of Edom. He said,
24 "Aaron will be gathered to his people.
For he will not enter the land that I have given to the people of Israel,
because you both rebelled against my command at the waters of Meribah.
25 Take Aaron and his son Eleazar and bring them up Mount Hor.
26 Take off Aaron's clothes and put them on his son Eleazar.
Aaron will be gathered to his people and will die there."
27 Moses did as the LORD had commanded.
They went up Mount Hor in front of the whole community.
28 Moses took off Aaron's clothes and put them on his son Eleazar.
And Aaron died there on the top of the mountain.
Then Moses and Eleazar came down from the mountain.
29 When the whole community saw that Aaron had died,
the whole house of Israel wept for Aaron for 30 days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Being gathered to his people" is a beautiful expression for dying. It means: You go to your ancestors who have already died.

Aaron's death is calm and dignified. Before his death, his priestly clothes are taken off him and put on his son Eleazar. That way the office goes on. Aaron can see his son become the one who follows him.

Moses goes with his brother to the very end. The whole people mourns for 30 days, as later for Moses (Deuteronomy 34:8).

Aaron had made mistakes, for example with the golden calf. But he had also served faithfully for many years. The people do not forget him.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 21

The bronze serpent and the first victories

Victory over Arad VERSES 1–3

1 The Canaanite king of Arad, who lived in the South, heard that Israel was coming along the road to Atharim.
He fought against Israel and took some of them as prisoners.
2 Then Israel made a promise to the LORD and said,
"If you really hand these people over to me,
then I will completely destroy their cities."
3 The LORD listened to the voice of Israel and handed the Canaanites over to them.
And they completely destroyed them and their cities.
The place was called Hormah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Completely destroy" is called "cherem" in Hebrew. It means: Everything is handed over completely to God and destroyed. No one may take any loot.

For us today, this is one of the hardest sides of the Bible. In the wars when the land was conquered, whole cities were destroyed and the people who lived in them were killed.

We have to say it honestly: That was terrible. Back then, all nations fought wars like this. Today many Jews and Christians understand these texts like this: They tell how Israel understood its history and war back then. They are not instructions for today. No one may use these passages to justify violence against other people.

Later parts of the Bible show God's love for all nations, for example the book of Jonah. And Jesus says: "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:44).

"Hormah" means "destruction." That is where Israel had been defeated 40 years before (Numbers 14:45). Now the new generation wins at the same place.

The snakes and the bronze serpent VERSES 4–9

4 They set out from Mount Hor on the road to the Red Sea, to go around the land of Edom.
On the way, the people became very discouraged because of the journey.
5 The people spoke against God and against Moses:
"Why have you brought us up out of Egypt to die in the wilderness?
For there is no bread, and there is no water.
And we hate this disgusting food!"
6 Then the LORD sent poisonous snakes among the people.
They bit the people, and many people of Israel died.
7 The people came to Moses and said,
"We have sinned,
because we have spoken against the LORD and against you.
Pray to the LORD, so that he takes the snakes away from us."
And Moses prayed for the people.
8 The LORD said to Moses,
"Make a poisonous snake and put it on a pole.
Everyone who has been bitten and looks at it will live."
9 Moses made a serpent of bronze and put it on the pole.
When a snake had bitten someone and he looked at the bronze serpent,
he lived.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Once again the people complain, this time about the manna, the "disgusting food." Yet it is bread from heaven.

In Hebrew the snakes are called "saraph," which means "burning." Maybe because their bite burns like fire. That is why many Bibles say "fiery serpents."

This time something new happens: The people themselves say: "We have sinned." They ask Moses to pray for them.

God does not simply take the snakes away. But he gives a way to be saved. Whoever has been bitten is to look at the bronze serpent. That was not magic. Whoever looked up showed that he trusted God.

To this day, a snake on a staff is a sign for medicine and pharmacies. People disagree about whether this sign comes from here or from the Greek legend of the staff of Asclepius.

Jesus himself applied this story to himself: "Moses lifted up the snake in the wilderness. In the same way, the Son of Man must be lifted up. Then everyone who believes in him will not be lost. They will have eternal life" (John 3:14–15). Just as the people who were bitten looked at the serpent, people are to look at Jesus on the cross.

Later this bronze serpent itself became an idol. That is why King Hezekiah broke it into pieces (2 Kings 18:4).

The journey to the Arnon VERSES 10–15

10 The people of Israel set out and camped at Oboth.
11 They set out from Oboth and camped at Iyeabarim,
in the wilderness that is in front of Moab, toward the sunrise.
12 From there they set out and camped in the valley of Zered.
13 From there they set out and camped on the other side of the Arnon,
in the wilderness that comes out of the land of the Amorites.
For the Arnon is the border of Moab, between Moab and the Amorites.
14 That is why it says in The Book of the Wars of the LORD,
"Vaheb in Suphah, and the valleys of the Arnon,
15 and the slope of the valleys that goes down toward the town of Ar
and lies along the border of Moab."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The Book of the Wars of the LORD" was an old book of songs and poems. Sadly it has been lost. Here the Bible quotes only a small piece of it.

The Arnon is a deep river valley that flows into the Dead Sea. It was the border between Moab in the south and the land of the Amorites in the north.

The song of the well VERSES 16–20

16 From there they went on to Beer.
That is the well where the LORD said to Moses,
"Gather the people together, and I will give them water."
17 Then Israel sang this song:
"Spring up, well! Sing to it!
18 It is the well that the leaders dug,
that the noble people of the nation dug,
with the scepter and with their staffs."
From the wilderness they traveled on to Mattanah,
19 from Mattanah to Nahaliel, from Nahaliel to Bamoth,
20 and from Bamoth to the valley that is in the land of Moab,
to the top of Pisgah, which looks down on the desert.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What a difference from Chapter 20! There they argued about water. Here they sing a happy song when God gives them water.

"Beer" means "well."

From the top of Pisgah, Moses will later see the promised land before he dies (Deuteronomy 34:1).

Victory over Sihon, the king of the Amorites VERSES 21–32

21 Israel sent messengers to Sihon, the king of the Amorites, to tell him,
22 "Let me pass through your land.
We will not turn off into fields or vineyards.
We will not drink water from the wells.
We will go along the King's Highway until we have passed through your land."
23 But Sihon did not allow Israel to pass through his land.
Instead, Sihon gathered all his people and went out against Israel into the wilderness.
He came to Jahaz and fought against Israel.
24 Israel struck him down with the sword
and took his land, from the Arnon to the Jabbok, as far as the people of Ammon.
For the border of the people of Ammon was strongly defended.
25 Israel took all these cities.
And Israel lived in all the cities of the Amorites, in Heshbon and in all its villages.
26 For Heshbon was the city of Sihon, the king of the Amorites.
He had fought against the former king of Moab
and had taken all his land from him, as far as the Arnon.
27 That is why people who speak in proverbs say,
"Come to Heshbon!
Let the city of Sihon be built and made strong!
28 For a fire has gone out from Heshbon, a flame from the city of Sihon.
It has burned up Ar of Moab, the lords of the high places of the Arnon.
29 How terrible for you, Moab!
You are lost, people of Chemosh!
He has made his sons refugees and his daughters prisoners
of Sihon, the king of the Amorites.
30 We have shot at them.
Heshbon is destroyed, all the way to Dibon.
We have laid waste all the way to Nophah, which reaches to Medeba."
31 So Israel lived in the land of the Amorites.
32 Moses sent men to explore Jazer.
They took its villages and drove out the Amorites who were there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

As with Edom, Israel asks peacefully to pass through. But Sihon attacks. That is why it comes to war.

The land between the rivers Arnon and Jabbok lies east of the Jordan, in today's Jordan. Here Israel settles down in a land for the first time.

The song in verses 27–30 is an old victory song. It mocks Moab: First Sihon defeated Moab. Now Israel has defeated Sihon.

"Chemosh" was the god of the Moabites.

Victory over Og, the king of Bashan VERSES 33–35

33 Then they turned and went up on the road to Bashan.
Og, the king of Bashan, came out against them, he and all his people, to fight at Edrei.
34 The LORD said to Moses,
"Do not be afraid of him!
For I have handed him over to you, with all his people and his land.
You shall do to him as you did to Sihon, the king of the Amorites, who lived in Heshbon."
35 So they struck him down, with his sons and all his people,
until no one was left.
And they took his land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bashan lies in the north, in the area of today's Golan Heights. Og was famous as one of the last giants (Deuteronomy 3:11).

40 years before, the people were afraid of the giants. Now God says: "Do not be afraid of him!" And the new generation trusts God and wins.

Here, too, what was said above about verse 3 applies: It is terrible that a whole people is killed. The Bible tells it from the point of view of that time. For today, God's commandment to love our enemies applies.

The victories over Sihon and Og were sung about again and again later in Israel, for example in Psalm 135:11 and Psalm 136:19–20.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 22

Balak calls Balaam – the talking donkey

Moab is afraid of Israel VERSES 1–4

1 The people of Israel traveled on.
They set up camp in the plains of Moab,
on the other side of the Jordan, at Jericho.
2 Balak, the son of Zippor, saw everything Israel had done to the Amorites.
3 Moab was very afraid of the people, because there were so many of them.
Moab was filled with dread because of the people of Israel.
4 Moab said to the elders of Midian,
"Now this crowd will lick up everything around us, like an ox licks up the grass of the field."
Balak, the son of Zippor, was king of Moab at that time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel is now close to its goal. The people are east of the Jordan, across from the city of Jericho.

The Moabites are descendants of Lot, Abraham's nephew (Genesis 19:37). Israel does not want to fight against them at all (Deuteronomy 2:9). But Balak, the king, is afraid.

Chapters 22 to 24 tell a special story. Israel itself hardly appears in it. The people of Israel do not even know what is being planned against them. But God protects them anyway.

Balak sends for Balaam VERSES 5–14

5 Balak sent messengers to Balaam, the son of Beor, in Pethor, which is by the River,
in the land of the people of his own nation.
They were to call him.
Balak had them say,
"Look, a people has come out of Egypt.
Look, they cover the surface of the earth, and they are camping across from me.
6 So please come now, and curse this people for me.
They are too strong for me.
Then perhaps I will win, so that we can defeat them
and I can drive them out of the land.
For I know: The one you bless is blessed, and the one you curse is cursed."
7 The elders of Moab and the elders of Midian left.
In their hands they had the payment for fortune-telling.
They came to Balaam and told him Balak's words.
8 Balaam said to them,
"Stay here tonight.
Then I will bring you an answer, just as the LORD will speak to me."
So the leaders of Moab stayed with Balaam.
9 God came to Balaam and said, "Who are these men with you?"
10 Balaam said to God,
"Balak, the son of Zippor, king of Moab, has sent me this message:
11 'Look, the people that came out of Egypt covers the surface of the earth.
Now come and curse them for me.
Then perhaps I will be able to fight against them and drive them out.'"
12 God said to Balaam,
"You must not go with them.
You must not curse the people, because they are blessed."
13 Balaam got up in the morning and said to Balak's leaders,
"Go back to your land. The LORD refuses to let me go with you."
14 The leaders of Moab got up and went to Balak.
They said, "Balaam refuses to come with us."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Balaam is a famous seer and fortune-teller from Mesopotamia, by the Euphrates River ("the River"). He is not an Israelite. People back then believed that his curses and blessings really worked.

In Jordan, archaeologists have found an old inscription. It tells about a seer called "Balaam, son of Beor." So he was also known outside the Bible.

God's answer is clear: "You must not curse the people, because they are blessed." God promised Abraham that he would bless his descendants (Genesis 12:2–3). No curse can change that.

Balak sends messengers again VERSES 15–21

15 Then Balak sent leaders again.
There were more of them, and they were more important than the first ones.
16 They came to Balaam and said to him,
"Balak, the son of Zippor, says this:
'Please do not let anything stop you from coming to me.
17 I will give you very great honor.
And I will do whatever you tell me.
So please come, and curse this people for me.'"
18 Balaam answered Balak's servants,
"Even if Balak gave me his house full of silver and gold,
I could not go beyond the word of the LORD my God,
to do less or more.
19 So please stay here tonight as well.
Then I can find out what else the LORD will say to me."
20 God came to Balaam at night and said to him,
"If the men have come to call you, get up and go with them.
But you must do only what I tell you."
21 Balaam got up in the morning and saddled his donkey.
Then he went with the leaders of Moab.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Balaam's words sound very faithful: Even for a house full of gold, he would not go against God's word. But then why does he ask God again, when God has already said no?

Maybe Balaam hopes that God will change his mind, so that he can get the money after all. In the New Testament, Balaam is named as an example. It says that he loved the payment for doing wrong (2 Peter 2:15).

God lets him go, but only on one condition: He may only say what God tells him.

The donkey and the angel VERSES 22–30

22 But God became angry because Balaam went.
The angel of the LORD stood in the road to block him, like an enemy.
Balaam was riding on his donkey, and his two servants were with him.
23 The donkey saw the angel of the LORD standing in the road, with a drawn sword in his hand.
So the donkey turned off the road and went into the field.
Balaam hit the donkey to turn her back onto the road.
24 Then the angel of the LORD stood in a narrow path between the vineyards.
There was a wall on this side and a wall on that side.
25 The donkey saw the angel of the LORD.
She pressed herself against the wall and crushed Balaam's foot against the wall.
So he hit her again.
26 The angel of the LORD went on further.
He stood in a narrow place where there was no room to turn to the right or to the left.
27 The donkey saw the angel of the LORD, and she lay down under Balaam.
Balaam became angry, and he hit the donkey with his stick.
28 Then the LORD opened the donkey's mouth.
She said to Balaam,
"What have I done to you, that you have hit me these three times?"
29 Balaam said to the donkey,
"Because you have made a fool of me!
I wish I had a sword in my hand. Then I would kill you right now!"
30 The donkey said to Balaam,
"Am I not your donkey? You have ridden on me all your life until today.
Have I ever done this to you before?"
He said, "No."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the best-known and also funniest stories in the Bible.

Balaam is a famous seer. People think he can see into the future and into the world of the gods. But he does not see the angel standing right in front of him. His donkey sees him. The animal is wiser than the "great seer."

Three times the donkey saves Balaam's life. And three times he hits her for it.

Then the donkey speaks. And Balaam is so angry that he is not even surprised that an animal is talking to him. He simply argues with her.

The donkey speaks very sensibly: "Have I ever done this to you before?" She has always been loyal to him. This is also a reminder to treat animals well.

Balaam sees the angel VERSES 31–35

31 Then the LORD opened Balaam's eyes.
He saw the angel of the LORD standing in the road, with a drawn sword in his hand.
Balaam bowed his head and fell down with his face to the ground.
32 The angel of the LORD said to him,
"Why have you hit your donkey these three times?
Look, I have come out to block you, like an enemy, because your way is wrong in my eyes.
33 The donkey saw me and turned away from me these three times.
If she had not turned away from me,
I would surely have killed you by now, and I would have let her live."
34 Balaam said to the angel of the LORD,
"I have sinned.
I did not know that you were standing in the road against me.
So now, if this displeases you, I will go back."
35 The angel of the LORD said to Balaam,
"Go with the men.
But you must say only the word that I tell you."
So Balaam went with Balak's leaders.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God had allowed Balaam to go. Then why is God angry? Maybe because Balaam went with the wrong plans. He was still hoping for the money, and for a way to curse Israel after all.

Meeting the angel is a warning: Balaam must understand that he is not the one who decides. God decides what he will say.

Just as God moved the donkey to speak, God will move Balaam to speak.

Balaam comes to Balak VERSES 36–41

36 Balak heard that Balaam was coming.
So he went out to meet him at the City of Moab.
It is on the border at the Arnon, at the very edge of the land.
37 Balak said to Balaam,
"Didn't I send for you urgently to call you?
Why didn't you come to me?
Am I not really able to give you honor?"
38 Balaam said to Balak,
"Look, I have come to you now.
But do I have any power at all to say anything on my own?
I will speak the word that God puts in my mouth."
39 Balaam went with Balak, and they came to Kiriath Huzoth.
40 Balak sacrificed cattle and sheep.
He sent some of the meat to Balaam and to the leaders who were with him.
41 In the morning, Balak took Balaam
and brought him up to the high places of Baal.
From there Balaam saw part of the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Balak thinks he can buy Balaam with money and honor. But Balaam warns him right away: He can only say what God puts in his mouth.

Baal was an important god of the peoples in Canaan. He was a god of the weather and of fertility. From his "high places," Balaam is supposed to see Israel and curse it. High places were places of worship on hills.

The next chapter tells how this turns out.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 23

Balaam is supposed to curse – and he blesses

Seven altars VERSES 1–6

1 Balaam said to Balak,
"Build seven altars for me here.
And get seven bulls and seven rams ready for me here."
2 Balak did what Balaam had said.
Balak and Balaam offered a bull and a ram on every altar.
3 Balaam said to Balak,
"Stay here by your burnt offering, and I will go.
Perhaps the LORD will come to meet me.
I will tell you whatever he shows me."
Then he went to a bare hilltop.
4 God met Balaam.
Balaam said to him,
"I have prepared the seven altars.
And I have offered a bull and a ram on every altar."
5 The LORD put a word in Balaam's mouth and said,
"Go back to Balak, and speak like this."
6 Balaam went back to him.
Balak was standing by his burnt offering, he and all the leaders of Moab.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Balaam tries to win God's favor with many sacrifices. That is what fortune-tellers did back then. But God cannot be bought, and he does not change his mind that way.

The first saying: a people that lives alone VERSES 7–12

7 Then Balaam began his saying.
He said,
"Balak has brought me from Aram,
the king of Moab from the mountains of the East.
He said, 'Come, curse Jacob for me.
Come, speak against Israel.'
8 How can I curse those whom God has not cursed?
How can I speak against those whom the LORD has not spoken against?
9 From the top of the rocks I see them.
From the hills I look at them.
Look, it is a people that lives alone.
It will not be counted among the nations.
10 Who can count the dust of Jacob?
Who can count even a fourth of Israel?
Let me die the death of the righteous!
Let my end be like theirs!"
11 Balak said to Balaam,
"What have you done to me?
I brought you here to curse my enemies.
But look, you have done nothing but bless them!"
12 Balaam answered,
"Must I not be careful to say what the LORD puts in my mouth?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Instead of cursing, Balaam has to bless. No person can curse what God has blessed.

"It is a people that lives alone": Israel is different from the other nations, because it belongs to God.

"The dust of Jacob" is a reminder of God's promise to Abraham: Your descendants will be as many as the dust of the earth (Genesis 13:16).

Balaam even wishes to die like an Israelite, as a righteous person. But strangely, he later dies in a battle against Israel (Numbers 31:8).

The second try VERSES 13–17

13 Balak said to him,
"Please come with me to another place, where you can see them.
You will see only part of them. You will not see all of them.
Curse them for me from there."
14 He took him to the field of Zophim, to the top of Pisgah.
Zophim means: watchmen.
There Balak built seven altars, and he offered a bull and a ram on every altar.
15 Balaam said to Balak,
"Stay here by your burnt offering, while I meet God over there."
16 The LORD met Balaam and put a word in his mouth.
He said, "Go back to Balak, and say this."
17 Balaam came to him.
Balak was standing by his burnt offering, and the leaders of Moab were with him.
Balak asked him, "What has the LORD said?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Balak thinks the curse might work better if Balaam sees only part of the people. He simply tries it at another place. As if God's will depended on where you stand.

The second saying: God does not lie VERSES 18–24

18 Then Balaam began his saying.
He said,
"Get up, Balak, and hear!
Listen to me, you son of Zippor!
19 God is not a man, that he should lie.
He is not a human being, that he should change his mind.
Would he say something and not do it?
Would he promise something and not keep it?
20 Look, I have been given the command to bless.
He has blessed, and I cannot undo it.
21 He has not seen evil in Jacob.
He has not seen wickedness in Israel.
The LORD his God is with him.
The shout of a king is among them.
22 God brings them out of Egypt.
He has strength like a wild ox.
23 There is no magic spell against Jacob.
There is no fortune-telling against Israel.
Now people will say about Jacob and about Israel,
'Look what God has done!'
24 Look, a people rises up like a lioness.
Like a lion it stands up.
It will not lie down until it has eaten its prey
and drunk the blood of those it has killed."
25 Balak said to Balaam,
"Then do not curse them at all, but do not bless them at all either!"
26 But Balaam answered Balak,
"Didn't I tell you, 'I must do everything the LORD says'?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19 is one of the most famous verses about God: "God is not a man, that he should lie." People change their minds, break promises and take bribes. God does not. What he promises, he keeps.

"He has not seen evil in Jacob" – that is amazing. We have seen how often Israel complained and sinned. But God has forgiven. He sees his people with the eyes of love.

The lion is a picture of strength. The picture is warlike. It belongs to the language of that time.

Balak becomes desperate. Now he would rather have Balaam say nothing at all.

The third try VERSES 27–30

27 Balak said to Balaam,
"Come now, I will take you to another place.
Perhaps God will be pleased to let you curse them for me from there."
28 Balak took Balaam to the top of Peor, which looks down on the desert.
29 Balaam said to Balak,
"Build seven altars for me here.
And get seven bulls and seven rams ready for me here."
30 Balak did what Balaam had said.
He offered a bull and a ram on every altar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Balak does not give up. A third place, seven altars again. But God's blessing cannot be turned around.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 24

How beautiful are your tents, Jacob – a star out of Jacob

The third saying: How beautiful are your tents VERSES 1–9

1 Balaam saw that it pleased the LORD to bless Israel.
So he did not go away as he had the other times, to look for signs by fortune-telling.
Instead, he turned his face toward the wilderness.
2 Balaam looked up and saw Israel camping tribe by tribe.
Then the Spirit of God came on him.
3 He began his saying.
He said,
"This is what Balaam, the son of Beor, says.
This is what the man whose eyes are open says.
4 This is what he says who hears the words of God,
who sees the vision of the Almighty,
who falls down and has his eyes open:
5 How beautiful are your tents, Jacob,
your homes, Israel!
6 They are spread out like valleys,
like gardens by the riverside,
like aloe trees that the LORD has planted,
like cedar trees beside the waters.

7 Water will flow from his buckets.
His seed will be in many waters.
His king will be greater than Agag.
His kingdom will be lifted up high.
8 God brings him out of Egypt.
He has strength like a wild ox.
He will swallow up the nations that are his enemies.
He will break their bones to pieces.
He will pierce them with his arrows.
9 He crouched. He lay down like a lion, like a lioness.
Who dares to wake him up?
Everyone who blesses you is blessed.
Everyone who curses you is cursed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: Aloe trees and cedar trees are trees that smell sweet and grow tall.

This time Balaam does not even try to achieve something with magic. He simply looks at Israel. And God's Spirit comes on him.

"How beautiful are your tents, Jacob" – in Hebrew, "Mah tovu." With these words, Jews to this day begin their morning prayer when they enter the synagogue. The words of a foreign seer who wanted to curse have become a prayer.

Israel is compared to a garden in bloom by the water. In the desert, water is the most precious thing. A people that God has blessed is like an oasis.

Agag was later a king of the Amalekites (1 Samuel 15).

Verse 9 repeats God's promise to Abraham: God will bless those who bless him, and he will curse those who curse him (Genesis 12:3).

Balak is angry VERSES 10–14

10 Then Balak became angry with Balaam.
He struck his hands together.
Balak said to Balaam,
"I called you to curse my enemies.
But look, you have blessed them, these three times now!
11 So run away to your home, right now!
I wanted to give you great honor.
But look, the LORD has kept you from honor."
12 Balaam said to Balak,
"Didn't I also tell your messengers whom you sent to me,
13 'Even if Balak gave me his house full of silver and gold,
I could not go beyond the LORD's word,
to do good or bad out of my own mind.
I will say what the LORD says'?
14 And now, look, I am going to my people.
Come, I will tell you what this people will do to your people in the days to come."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Balak strikes his hands together in anger. Three times he wanted a curse. Three times he got a blessing.

Balaam gets no money. But before he leaves, he says something more about the future.

The fourth saying: a star out of Jacob VERSES 15–19

15 He began his saying.
He said,
"This is what Balaam, the son of Beor, says.
This is what the man whose eyes are open says.
16 This is what he says who hears the words of God,
who knows what the Most High knows,
who sees the vision of the Almighty,
who falls down and has his eyes open:
17 I see him, but not now.
I see him, but not near.
A star will come out of Jacob.
A scepter will rise out of Israel.
It will strike through the corners of Moab,
and it will crush all the sons of Sheth.
18 Edom will become his property.
Seir, his enemy, will also become his property,
while Israel acts bravely.
19 Out of Jacob one will rule.
He will destroy those who are left from the city."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: A scepter is the staff of a king.

This is a prophecy about the distant future: "I see him, but not now."

A "star" and a "scepter" are signs of a king. Many people have thought of King David here. Later he defeated Moab and Edom (2 Samuel 8:2, 14).

Later the verse was taken to speak about the Messiah, the Savior people were waiting for. In the year 132 AD, a Jewish leader who fought against the Romans was called "Bar Kokhba." That means "son of the star." The name came from this verse.

Christians think here of the star of Bethlehem, which the wise men from the East followed (Matthew 2:2). Balaam also came "from the mountains of the East" (Numbers 23:7). In the New Testament, Jesus is called the bright morning star (Revelation 22:16).

It is not quite clear who the "sons of Sheth" are. Maybe it means a people in the area of Moab.

Sayings about other nations VERSES 20–25

20 He looked at Amalek. He began his saying and said,
"Amalek was the first of the nations,
but in the end it will be destroyed."
21 He looked at the Kenites. He began his saying and said,
"Your home is strong.
Your nest is set in the rock.
22 But still Kain will be laid waste,
until Asshur carries you away as prisoners."
23 He began his saying and said,
"Oh, who will stay alive when God does this?
24 But ships will come from the coast of Kittim.
They will bring trouble on Asshur, and they will bring trouble on Eber.
He too will be destroyed."
25 Then Balaam got up and went back to his home.
And Balak also went on his way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end, Balaam tells what will happen to other nations. All the powers of the world will fall one day, even the great ones.

Amalek was the first nation that attacked Israel (Exodus 17:8).

The Kenites lived in the rocks. Their name sounds like "nest" (Hebrew "ken"). It is a play on words. Kain is another name for the Kenites.

Asshur is the kingdom of the Assyrians, a later great power in the north.

"Kittim" first meant Cyprus. Later it meant the peoples in the west in general, who came over the sea, for example Greeks or Romans.

It is not certain who "Eber" is. Maybe it means the peoples on the other side of the Euphrates River.

These verses are hard to understand. But their message is clear: God guides history, not the kings.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 25

Israel worships Baal Peor – Phinehas steps in

The people turn to foreign gods VERSES 1–5

1 Israel stayed in Shittim.
There the people began to sleep with the daughters of Moab, like with prostitutes.
2 For the women invited the people to the sacrifices for their gods.
The people ate with them, and they bowed down to their gods.
3 So Israel joined itself to Baal Peor.
Then the LORD became angry with Israel.
4 The LORD said to Moses,
"Take all the leaders of the people, and hang them up before the LORD, in the light of the sun,
so that the burning anger of the LORD will turn away from Israel."
5 Moses said to the judges of Israel,
"Each of you must kill those of his men who have joined themselves to Baal Peor."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What Balaam could not do with curses now happens in another way. The women from Moab invite the Israelites to their sacrifice festivals. There is food and celebration there, and probably also sex as part of the worship of the gods.

Later the Bible says that Balaam thought up this plan (Numbers 31:16; Revelation 2:14). He could not curse Israel, but he could lead it astray.

"Baal Peor" is the god Baal, as he was worshiped at Mount Peor.

This is a terrible step backward. Almost right after God's blessing through Balaam, Israel breaks the covenant. A covenant is a binding agreement.

The punishment is shocking for us today. The Bible tells honestly how harshly people back then dealt with turning away from God. For today, this is true: Nobody may kill people in God's name.

Phinehas steps in VERSES 6–9

6 Then a man from the people of Israel came.
He brought a Midianite woman to his brothers.
He did it in front of Moses and in front of the whole community of Israel,
while they were weeping at the entrance of the Tent of Meeting.
7 Phinehas, the son of Eleazar, the son of Aaron the priest, saw it.
He got up from the middle of the community and took a spear in his hand.
8 He went after the man of Israel into the tent.
He pierced both of them, the man of Israel and the woman, through her body.
Then the plague among the people of Israel stopped.
9 In the plague, 24,000 people died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The whole people is weeping at the holy tent and is sorry. But one man openly brings a woman from Midian into the camp. He does it in front of Moses, as if he wanted to mock God and the people.

Phinehas, Aaron's grandson, kills the two. With that, a plague ends that has already killed many people.

This act is very hard for us to understand today. It is violence. In Judaism, people discussed it a lot. The teachers said: This was a one-time exception. Nobody may point to it as a reason to use violence in God's name themselves. They made strict rules so that nobody would copy it.

Sadly, extremists have pointed to Phinehas again and again in history. That is a misuse of this story.

God's covenant with Phinehas VERSES 10–15

10 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
11 "Phinehas, the son of Eleazar, the son of Aaron the priest,
has turned my anger away from the people of Israel.
He was jealous with my jealousy among them.
So I did not destroy the people of Israel in my jealousy.
12 So say this:
'Look, I give him my covenant of peace.
13 For him and for his descendants after him,
it will be a covenant of a priesthood that lasts forever.
For he was jealous for his God,
and he made atonement for the people of Israel.'"
Atonement means: putting things right again between God and people.
14 The man of Israel who was killed with the Midianite woman
was named Zimri, the son of Salu. He was a leader of a family among the Simeonites.
15 The Midianite woman who was killed was named Cozbi, the daughter of Zur.
He was the head of the people of a family in Midian.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Jealous here means: full of burning zeal for God.

God gives Phinehas a "covenant of peace." After an act of violence, that sounds strange. But it means: Phinehas

stopped the plague. In this way, he brought back peace between God and the people.

His descendants will be the high priests. Zadok, who later was high priest under King Solomon, was one of his descendants.

The names are given because both came from important families. It was not a small matter. It was a public scandal caused by leading people.

War against Midian VERSES 16–18

16 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
17 "Attack the Midianites, and strike them!
18 For they attacked you with their tricks.
They led you astray in the matter of Peor,
and in the matter of Cozbi, the daughter of a leader of Midian, their sister.
She was killed on the day of the plague because of Peor."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Midianites led Israel astray on purpose, to take it away from God. That is why Israel is to fight against them. Chapter 31 tells about this.

Interesting: Moses himself was married to a Midianite woman, Zipporah. And his father-in-law Jethro was a Midianite who helped Israel. Not all Midianites were enemies.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 26

The second census – the new generation

God orders a new count VERSES 1–4

1 After the plague, the LORD spoke to Moses and to Eleazar, the son of Aaron the priest.
He said,
2 "Count the whole community of the people of Israel, everyone 20 years old and older, by their families.
Count everyone in Israel who is able to go to war."
3 Moses and Eleazar the priest spoke with them in the plains of Moab,
by the Jordan, at Jericho.
They said,
4 "Count everyone 20 years old and older,
as the LORD commanded Moses and the people of Israel."
These are the people of Israel who came out of the land of Egypt:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

38 years after the first count (Chapter 1), the people are counted a second time. The old generation has almost completely died. Now the new generation is ready to take the land.

"Who came out of the land of Egypt" here means the whole people of Israel, the descendants of those who came out.

The count is also the basis for dividing the land. Each tribe is to get as much land as it has people.

Reuben VERSES 5–11

5 Reuben was the firstborn of Israel.
The descendants of Reuben:
from Hanoch, the family of the Hanochites;
from Pallu, the family of the Palluites;
6 from Hezron, the family of the Hezronites;
from Carmi, the family of the Carmites.
7 These are the families of the Reubenites.
The number of those counted was 43,730.
8 The son of Pallu was Eliab.
9 The sons of Eliab were Nemuel, Dathan and Abiram.
These are the same Dathan and Abiram who were chosen by the community.
They rebelled against Moses and against Aaron,
together with Korah's group,
when they rebelled against the LORD.
10 Then the earth opened its mouth and swallowed them up together with Korah,
when that group died.
At that time the fire burned up 250 men.
So they became a warning sign.
11 But the sons of Korah did not die.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Reuben, the Bible reminds us of the rebellion of Dathan and Abiram (Chapter 16).

Verse 11 is important: "But the sons of Korah did not die." Their descendants later became singers in the temple and wrote psalms.

Simeon VERSES 12–14

12 The descendants of Simeon by their families:
from Nemuel, the family of the Nemuelites;
from Jamin, the family of the Jaminites;
from Jachin, the family of the Jachinites;
13 from Zerah, the family of the Zerahites;
from Shaul, the family of the Shaulites.
14 These are the families of the Simeonites: 22,200.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The tribe of Simeon has become much smaller: from 59,300 to 22,200. Maybe because many people from Simeon took part in the sin with Baal Peor. Zimri, the man from Chapter 25, was a leader from Simeon.

Gad VERSES 15–18

15 The descendants of Gad by their families:
from Zephon, the family of the Zephonites;
from Haggi, the family of the Haggites;
from Shuni, the family of the Shunites;
16 from Ozni, the family of the Oznites;
from Eri, the family of the Erites;
17 from Arod, the family of the Arodites;
from Areli, the family of the Arelites.

18 These are the families of the descendants of Gad, by the
number of those counted: 40,500.

Judah VERSES 19–22

19 The sons of Judah were Er and Onan.
But Er and Onan died in the land of Canaan.
20 The descendants of Judah by their families were:
from Shelah, the family of the Shelanites;
from Perez, the family of the Perezites;
from Zerah, the family of the Zerahites.
21 The descendants of Perez were:
from Hezron, the family of the Hezronites;
from Hamul, the family of the Hamulites.
22 These are the families of Judah, by the number of those
counted: 76,500.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> The story of Er, Onan, Perez and Zerah is in Genesis 38. Later King David came from the family of Perez.

Issachar VERSES 23–25

23 The descendants of Issachar by their families:
from Tola, the family of the Tolaites;
from Puvah, the family of the Punites;
24 from Jashub, the family of the Jashubites;
from Shimron, the family of the Shimronites.
25 These are the families of Issachar, by the number of
those counted: 64,300.

Zebulun VERSES 26–27

26 The descendants of Zebulun by their families:
from Sered, the family of the Seredites;
from Elon, the family of the Elonites;
from Jahleel, the family of the Jahleelites.
27 These are the families of the Zebulunites, by the
number of those counted: 60,500.

Manasseh VERSES 28–34

28 The descendants of Joseph by their families were
Manasseh and Ephraim.
29 The descendants of Manasseh:
from Machir, the family of the Machirites.
Machir became the father of Gilead.
From Gilead, the family of the Gileadites.
30 These are the descendants of Gilead:
from Iezer, the family of the Iezerites;
from Helek, the family of the Helekites;
31 from Asriel, the family of the Asrielites;
from Shechem, the family of the Shechemites;
32 from Shemida, the family of the Shemidaites;
from Hepher, the family of the Hepherites.
33 Zelophehad, the son of Hepher, had no sons. He had
only daughters.
The names of Zelophehad's daughters were Mahlah,
Noah, Hoglah, Milcah and Tirzah.
34 These are the families of Manasseh.
The number of those counted was 52,700.

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
>
> The five daughters of Zelophehad are named here. That is unusual in a list of men. They play an important part in the next chapter: They bravely stand up for their right to an inheritance.

Ephraim VERSES 35–37

35 These are the descendants of Ephraim by their families:
from Shuthelah, the family of the Shuthelahites;
from Becher, the family of the Becherites;
from Tahan, the family of the Tahanites.
36 And these are the descendants of Shuthelah:
from Eran, the family of the Eranites.
37 These are the families of the descendants of Ephraim,
by the number of those counted: 32,500.
These are the descendants of Joseph by their families.

Benjamin VERSES 38–41

38 The descendants of Benjamin by their families:
from Bela, the family of the Belaites;
from Ashbel, the family of the Ashbelites;
from Ahiram, the family of the Ahiramites;
39 from Shephupham, the family of the Shuphamites;
from Hupham, the family of the Huphamites.
40 The sons of Bela were Ard and Naaman:
from Ard, the family of the Ardites;
from Naaman, the family of the Naamites.
41 These are the descendants of Benjamin by their
families.
The number of those counted was 45,600.

Dan VERSES 42–43

42 These are the descendants of Dan by their families:
from Shuham, the family of the Shuhamites.
These are the families of Dan, by their families.
43 All the families of the Shuhamites, by the number of
those counted, were 64,400.

Asher VERSES 44–47

44 The descendants of Asher by their families:
from Imnah, the family of the Imnites;
from Ishvi, the family of the Ishvites;
from Beriah, the family of the Berites.
45 From the descendants of Beriah:
from Heber, the family of the Heberites;
from Malchiel, the family of the Malchielites.
46 The name of Asher's daughter was Serah.
47 These are the families of the descendants of Asher, by
the number of those counted: 53,400.

Naphtali VERSES 48–50

48 The descendants of Naphtali by their families:
from Jahzeel, the family of the Jahzeelites;
from Guni, the family of the Gunites;
49 from Jezer, the family of the Jezerites;
from Shillem, the family of the Shillemites.
50 These are the families of Naphtali, by their families.
The number of those counted was 45,400.

The total number and the dividing of the land
VERSES 51–56

51 These are those of the people of Israel who were
counted: 601,730.
52 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,

53 "The land is to be divided among these as their
inheritance, by the number of names.
54 To a large tribe you must give a large inheritance.
To a small tribe you must give a small inheritance.
Each tribe is to receive its inheritance by the number
of its people who were counted.
55 But the land is to be divided by lot.
They will inherit by the names of the tribes of their
ancestors.
56 By the lot, their inheritance is to be divided between
the large and the small tribes."
Casting lots was a way to decide something, a little like
drawing straws.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 53: An inheritance is land that a family receives and keeps for its children.

At the first count, there were 603,550 men. Now there are 601,730. After 40 years in the wilderness, the people are almost the same size. God gave them children, even though the old generation died.

If you add up the numbers of the 12 tribes, you get exactly 601,730.

The land is divided in two ways: The size depends on the number of people. The lot decides which area a tribe gets. That way it is fair, and nobody can grab the best piece.

The Levites VERSES 57–62

57 These are the Levites who were counted by their
families:
from Gershon, the family of the Gershonites;
from Kohath, the family of the Kohathites;
from Merari, the family of the Merarites.
58 These are the families of Levi:
the family of the Libnites, the family of the
Hebronites, the family of the Mahlites,
the family of the Mushites and the family of the
Korahites.
Kohath became the father of Amram.
59 The name of Amram's wife was Jochebed.
She was a daughter of Levi, born to Levi in Egypt.
She gave birth to Aaron and Moses for Amram, and to
their sister Miriam.
60 Nadab and Abihu, Eleazar and Ithamar were born to
Aaron.
61 Nadab and Abihu died when they offered strange fire
before the LORD.
Strange fire means: fire that God had not commanded.
62 The number of those counted was 23,000, every male 1
month old and older.
They were not counted among the people of Israel,
because they were not given an inheritance among the
people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Moses' family is named too: his parents Amram and Jochebed, his brother Aaron and his sister Miriam.

The Levites do not get any land. That is why they are counted separately again.

None of the old generation is left VERSES 63–65

63 These are the ones counted by Moses and Eleazar the
priest.
They counted the people of Israel in the plains of
Moab, by the Jordan, at Jericho.
64 But among them there was not a single man of those
whom Moses and Aaron the priest had counted
when they counted the people of Israel in the
wilderness of Sinai.
65 For the LORD had said about them, "They will surely
die in the wilderness."
Not one of them was left,
except Caleb, the son of Jephunneh, and Joshua, the
son of Nun.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's word has come true. The whole generation that had refused to go into the land has died in the wilderness (Numbers 14:29–30). Only Caleb and Joshua, who had trusted God, are still alive.

And Moses too. But he will not enter the land either (Numbers 20:12).

A new generation has grown up. It did not see the miracles in Egypt for itself. But it is ready to trust God and to go into the land.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 27

The daughters of Zelophehad – Joshua becomes Moses' successor

Five sisters ask for their inheritance VERSES 1–4

1 Then the daughters of Zelophehad came forward.
Zelophehad was the son of Hepher, the son of Gilead,
the son of Machir, the son of Manasseh.
He was from the families of Manasseh, the son of
Joseph.
These are the names of his daughters: Mahlah, Noah,
Hoglah, Milcah and Tirzah.
2 They stood before Moses, before Eleazar the priest,
before the leaders and before the whole community, at
the entrance of the Tent of Meeting.
They said,
3 "Our father died in the wilderness.
He was not part of the group that joined together with
Korah against the LORD.
He died because of his own sin.
And he had no sons.
4 Why should our father's name disappear from his
family, just because he had no son?
Give us property among our father's brothers!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, only sons inherited the family's land. If a man had no sons, his land went to other relatives. His name and his family disappeared.

Five sisters do not want to accept that. They bravely step in front of the whole assembly, before Moses, the priest and all the leaders. For women at that time, this was very unusual and brave.

They argue wisely: Our father was not a rebel like Korah. He died like every one of his generation. He does not deserve to have his name wiped out.

God says they are right VERSES 5–11

5 Moses brought their case before the LORD.
6 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
7 "The daughters of Zelophehad are right.
You must surely give them property as an inheritance among their father's brothers.
You must let their father's inheritance pass on to them.
8 And speak to the people of Israel. Say this:
'If a man dies and has no son,
then you must let his inheritance pass on to his daughter.
9 If he has no daughter, then you must give his inheritance to his brothers.
10 If he has no brothers, then you must give his inheritance to his father's brothers.
11 If his father has no brothers,
then you must give his inheritance to his closest relative in his family.
That relative will own it.
This is to be a fixed law and rule for the people of Israel, as the LORD commanded Moses.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses does not know the answer. He asks God.

And God says: "The daughters of Zelophehad are right." God changes the law because of the request of these five women. From now on, daughters may inherit if there are no sons.

This is an important step for the rights of women. It is not yet full equal rights, but it is a beginning. God listens to those who stand up for justice.

The story also shows: Laws are not frozen. If a case is unfair, people may ask and request a better solution.

This story comes up again in Chapter 36.

Moses is to see the land VERSES 12–14

12 The LORD said to Moses,
"Go up into this mountain of Abarim.
Look at the land that I have given to the people of Israel.
13 When you have seen it, you too will be gathered to your people,
just as your brother Aaron was gathered.
14 For when the community argued in the wilderness of Zin,
you rebelled against my word.
You did not honor me as holy at the waters in front of their eyes."
These are the waters of Meribah of Kadesh in the wilderness of Zin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: Being gathered to your people means: to die.

God tells Moses that he will die. Moses may see the land, but not enter it. The reason is Moses' mistake at the waters of Meribah (Chapter 20).

His death is told only at the end of the book of Deuteronomy (Chapter 34).

Moses asks for a successor VERSES 15–17

15 Moses spoke to the LORD. He said,
16 "May the LORD, the God of the spirits of all people, appoint a man over the community.
17 Let him go out before them and come in before them.
Let him lead them out and bring them in.
Then the community of the LORD will not be like sheep that have no shepherd."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses does not think of himself. He does not complain about his death. His biggest worry is the people. Who will lead them when he is gone?

"Like sheep that have no shepherd" – Jesus later uses this picture too, when he feels sorry for the people (Mark 6:34). A good leader is like a good shepherd.

Joshua is appointed VERSES 18–23

18 The LORD said to Moses,
"Take Joshua, the son of Nun. He is a man in whom the Spirit is.
Lay your hand on him.
19 Have him stand before Eleazar the priest and before the whole community.
Give him his task in front of their eyes.
20 Give him authority,
so that the whole community of the people of Israel will obey him.
21 He is to stand before Eleazar the priest.
Eleazar will ask the LORD for him, using the decision of the Urim.
At his word they will go out,
and at his word they will come in,
he and all the people of Israel with him, the whole community."
22 Moses did as the LORD had commanded him.
He took Joshua and had him stand before Eleazar the priest and before the whole community.
23 He laid his hands on him and gave him his task,
just as the LORD had said through Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joshua had been Moses' servant and helper for a long time. He was one of the two faithful spies. Now he becomes Moses' successor.

Moses lays his hands on him. That is a sign: I am passing on my task and my blessing to you. To this day, churches lay hands on people when they make them pastors or priests.

In the Hebrew text, Joshua does not get all of Moses' honor, but only "some of" it. Moses remains unique. Joshua is also to work together with the priest. He does not decide alone.

The "Urim" were holy lots in the breast pocket of the high priest. People used them to ask what God wanted (Exodus 28:30).

CHAPTER 28

The offerings for every day, every Sabbath and the festivals

The daily offering VERSES 1–8

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Command the people of Israel, and tell them,
'Be sure to bring me my offering at the right time,
my food for my offerings made by fire, as a pleasant
smell to me.'
3 And tell them,
'This is the offering made by fire that you must bring
to the LORD:
two male lambs one year old without any defect, every
day, as a regular burnt offering.
4 You must offer one lamb in the morning,
and you must offer the other lamb in the evening.
5 With it, bring about 2 quarts of fine flour as a grain
offering,
mixed with about 1 quart of oil from crushed olives.
6 It is the regular burnt offering that was commanded at
Mount Sinai,
as a pleasant smell, an offering made by fire to the
LORD.
7 Its drink offering is to be about 1 quart for each lamb.
In the holy place, you must pour out a drink offering
of strong drink to the LORD.
8 You must offer the other lamb in the evening.
Offer it like the grain offering of the morning and like
its drink offering,
as an offering made by fire, a pleasant smell to the
LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: A burnt offering is an offering that is burned completely on the altar.

Verse 7: A drink offering is wine or another drink that is poured out for God.

In the Bible the measures are given like this: one tenth of an ephah of flour, and a fourth of a hin of oil and of wine. An ephah is about 6 gallons. A hin is about 1 gallon.

Chapters 28 and 29 are like a calendar for worship. They say exactly which offerings are brought on which day. We already know the festivals from Leviticus 23. Here it is about the offerings for them.

The basis is the daily offering: one lamb in the morning, one lamb in the evening. Every day begins and ends with God. To this day, Jews pray at these times, in the morning and in the afternoon. Since the temple was destroyed, these prayers take the place of the offerings.

On the Sabbath VERSES 9–10

9 "'On the Sabbath day, you must offer two male lambs
one year old without any defect.
With them, bring about 4½ quarts of fine flour as a
grain offering, mixed with oil, and its drink offering.
10 This is the burnt offering for every Sabbath,
in addition to the regular burnt offering and its drink
offering.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says: two tenths of an ephah of flour.

On the Sabbath, the daily offering is doubled. The day of rest is a special day for God.

At the beginning of every month VERSES 11–15

11 "'At the beginning of your months, you must bring a
burnt offering to the LORD:
two young bulls, one ram and seven male lambs one
year old without any defect.
12 With them, bring about 7 quarts of fine flour mixed
with oil as a grain offering for each bull,
and about 4½ quarts of fine flour mixed with oil as a
grain offering for the one ram,
13 and about 2 quarts of fine flour mixed with oil as a grain
offering for each lamb.
This is a burnt offering with a pleasant smell, an
offering made by fire to the LORD.
14 Their drink offerings are to be:
about 2 quarts of wine for a bull, a little more than 1
quart for the ram, and about 1 quart for a lamb.
This is the burnt offering for every month, through
all the months of the year.
15 Also, one male goat is to be offered to the LORD as a sin
offering,
in addition to the regular burnt offering and its drink
offering.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: A sin offering is an offering that takes away guilt.

In the Bible the measures are given like this: three tenths, two tenths and one tenth of an ephah of flour, and a half, a third and a fourth of a hin of wine.

The Jewish calendar follows the moon. Every month begins with the new moon. This day is called "Rosh Chodesh," the head of the month. To this day it is a small holiday.

Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread VERSES 16–25

16 "'In the first month, on the fourteenth day of the
month, is the LORD's Passover.
17 On the fifteenth day of this month there is to be a
festival.
For seven days people must eat bread without yeast.
18 On the first day there is to be a holy assembly.
You must not do any regular work.
19 Instead, you must bring an offering made by fire, a
burnt offering to the LORD:
two young bulls, one ram and seven male lambs one
year old.
They must be without any defect.
20 With them, bring their grain offering, fine flour mixed
with oil.
You must offer about 7 quarts for a bull and about 4½
quarts for the ram.

21 You must offer about 2 quarts for each of the seven lambs.
22 And bring one male goat as a sin offering, to make atonement for you.
23 You must offer these in addition to the burnt offering of the morning, which is the regular burnt offering.
24 In this way you must offer every day, for seven days, the food of the offering made by fire, a pleasant smell to the LORD.
It is to be offered in addition to the regular burnt offering and its drink offering.
25 On the seventh day you must have a holy assembly.
You must not do any regular work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: Atonement means: putting things right again between God and people.

Passover reminds people of how God set them free from Egypt. After it comes the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days, with large offerings every day.

The Feast of Weeks VERSES 26–31

26 "'Also on the day of the first fruits, when you bring a new grain offering to the LORD at your Feast of Weeks,
you must have a holy assembly.
You must not do any regular work.
27 Instead, you must bring a burnt offering as a pleasant smell to the LORD:
two young bulls, one ram and seven male lambs one year old.
28 With them, bring their grain offering, fine flour mixed with oil:
about 7 quarts for each bull, about 4½ quarts for the one ram,
29 about 2 quarts for each of the seven lambs.
30 And bring one male goat, to make atonement for you.
31 You must offer them with their drink offerings, in addition to the regular burnt offering and its grain offering.
Be sure that they are without any defect.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Feast of Weeks, "Shavuot," is the festival of the wheat harvest, seven weeks after Passover. In Christianity it became Pentecost (see Leviticus 23:15–22).

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 29

The offerings for the festivals in the fall

The Feast of Trumpets VERSES 1–6

1 "'In the seventh month, on the first day of the month, you must have a holy assembly.
You must not do any regular work.
It is to be a day of blowing trumpets for you.
2 You must bring a burnt offering as a pleasant smell to the LORD:
one young bull, one ram and seven male lambs one year old without any defect.
3 With them, bring their grain offering, fine flour mixed with oil:
about 7 quarts for the bull, about 4½ quarts for the ram,
4 and about 2 quarts for each of the seven lambs.
5 And bring one male goat as a sin offering, to make atonement for you.
6 All this is in addition to the burnt offering of the new moon with its grain offering,
and the regular burnt offering with its grain offering, and their drink offerings,
as the rule says, as a pleasant smell, an offering made by fire to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible the measures are given like this: three tenths, two tenths and one tenth of an ephah of flour. An ephah is about 6 gallons.

The seventh month, in the fall, is the most festive month of the year. On its first day, the horn is blown. Today this is the Jewish New Year festival, "Rosh Hashanah."

The Day of Atonement VERSES 7–11

7 "'On the tenth day of this seventh month, you must have a holy assembly.
You must humble yourselves.
You must not do any kind of work.
8 Instead, you must bring a burnt offering to the LORD as a pleasant smell:
one young bull, one ram and seven male lambs one year old, all without any defect.
9 With them, bring their grain offering, fine flour mixed with oil:
about 7 quarts for the bull, about 4½ quarts for the one ram,
10 about 2 quarts for each of the seven lambs.
11 And bring one male goat as a sin offering.
This is in addition to the sin offering of atonement, and the regular burnt offering
with its grain offering, and their drink offerings.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Day of Atonement, "Yom Kippur," was described in detail in Leviticus 16. "Humble yourselves" means above all: to fast. To fast means to go without food.

The Feast of Booths: the first seven days VERSES 12–34

12 "'On the fifteenth day of the seventh month, you must have a holy assembly.
You must not do any regular work.
For seven days you must celebrate a festival to the LORD.

13 You must bring a burnt offering, an offering made by
fire, as a pleasant smell to the LORD:
13 young bulls, 2 rams and 14 male lambs 1 year old, all
without any defect.
14 With them, bring their grain offering, fine flour mixed
with oil:
about 7 quarts for each of the 13 bulls, about 4½ quarts
for each of the 2 rams,
15 and about 2 quarts for each of the 14 lambs.
16 And bring one male goat as a sin offering.
This is in addition to the regular burnt offering, its
grain offering and its drink offering.
17 "'On the second day, you must offer 12 young bulls, 2
rams and 14 male lambs 1 year old without any defect.
18 With them, bring their grain offering and their drink
offerings for the bulls, for the rams and for the lambs,
by their number, as the rule says.
19 And bring one male goat as a sin offering.
This is in addition to the regular burnt offering with
its grain offering and their drink offerings.
20 "'On the third day: 11 bulls, 2 rams and 14 male lambs 1
year old without any defect.
21 With them, bring their grain offering and their drink
offerings for the bulls, for the rams and for the lambs,
by their number, as the rule says.
22 And bring one male goat as a sin offering.
This is in addition to the regular burnt offering, its
grain offering and its drink offering.
23 "'On the fourth day: 10 bulls, 2 rams and 14 male lambs 1
year old without any defect.
24 With them, bring their grain offering and their drink
offerings for the bulls, for the rams and for the lambs,
by their number, as the rule says.
25 And bring one male goat as a sin offering.
This is in addition to the regular burnt offering, its
grain offering and its drink offering.
26 "'On the fifth day: 9 bulls, 2 rams and 14 male lambs 1
year old without any defect.
27 With them, bring their grain offering and their drink
offerings for the bulls, for the rams and for the lambs,
by their number, as the rule says.
28 And bring one male goat as a sin offering.
This is in addition to the regular burnt offering, its
grain offering and its drink offering.
29 "'On the sixth day: 8 bulls, 2 rams and 14 male lambs 1
year old without any defect.
30 With them, bring their grain offering and their drink
offerings for the bulls, for the rams and for the lambs,
by their number, as the rule says.
31 And bring one male goat as a sin offering.
This is in addition to the regular burnt offering, its
grain offering and its drink offerings.
32 "'On the seventh day: 7 bulls, 2 rams and 14 male lambs 1
year old without any defect.
33 With them, bring their grain offering and their drink
offerings for the bulls, for the rams and for the lambs,
by their number, as the rule says.
34 And bring one male goat as a sin offering.
This is in addition to the regular burnt offering, its
grain offering and its drink offering.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Feast of Booths is the biggest festival of the year. It is the festival of joy after the harvest. People live in simple huts made of branches during this festival.

The number of bulls gets smaller by 1 every day: 13, 12, 11, 10, 9, 8, 7. Together that makes 70 bulls.

Jewish teachers have said: The 70 bulls stand for the 70 nations of the world that are listed in Genesis 10. So at this festival, Israel also prays for all the other nations. The prophet Zechariah foretells that one day all nations will come to Jerusalem for the Feast of Booths (Zechariah 14:16).

Every day, 14 lambs and 2 rams are offered too. In the 7 days, that makes 98 lambs.

The eighth day VERSES 35–38

35 "'On the eighth day, you must have a solemn assembly.
You must not do any regular work.
36 Instead, you must bring a burnt offering, an offering
made by fire, as a pleasant smell to the LORD:
one bull, one ram and seven male lambs one year old
without any defect.
37 Their grain offering and their drink offerings for the
bull, for the ram and for the lambs
are to be by their number, as the rule says.
38 And bring one male goat as a sin offering.
This is in addition to the regular burnt offering with
its grain offering and its drink offering.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

On the eighth day there is only 1 bull. After the 70 bulls for all nations, there is 1 bull for Israel alone.

To this day, Jews celebrate this day as "Shemini Atzeret," the closing of the festival. After it comes the festival of joy in the Torah, "Simchat Torah." On that day, people dance with the Torah scrolls.

Summary VERSES 39–40

39 "'You must offer these to the LORD at your appointed
festivals,
in addition to your vows and your freewill offerings.
They are for your burnt offerings, your grain
offerings, your drink offerings and your peace
offerings.'"
40 Moses told the people of Israel everything that the
LORD had commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 39: A vow is a solemn promise to God.

In some Bibles, verse 40 is already the first verse of Chapter 30 (30:1). Here we follow the verse numbers of the WEB, our English source text.

If you add everything up, more than 1,000 lambs and more than 100 bulls were offered every year as shared offerings of the people. On top of that came the many offerings of individual people.

The whole year is centered on God: every day, every week, every month, every festival.

Chapter 30

Promises made to God

A man must keep his promise VERSES 1–2

1 Moses spoke to the heads of the tribes of the people of Israel.
He said, "This is what the LORD has commanded:
2 When a man makes a vow to the LORD,
or swears an oath to bind himself to something,
he must not break his word.
He must do everything that has come out of his mouth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles, the verses of this chapter are counted one number higher: Verse 1 here is verse 2 there, and so on up to verse 17. Here we follow the verse numbers of the WEB, our English source text.

A "vow" is a solemn promise to God. For example: "I will bring an offering," or "I will fast for a while."

The rule is clear: What you promise to God, you must keep. Words have weight. Jesus later says: "Let your 'Yes' be 'Yes' and your 'No' be 'No.'" (Matthew 5:37).

A young woman in her father's house VERSES 3–5

3 "Also, when a woman makes a vow to the LORD and binds herself to something,
while she is still young and lives in her father's house,
4 and her father hears her vow and her promise with which she has bound herself,
and her father says nothing to her,
then all her vows will stand.
And every promise with which she has bound herself will stand.
5 But if her father forbids it on the day he hears about it,
then none of her vows and none of her promises with which she has bound herself will stand.
The LORD will forgive her, because her father has forbidden it.

A married woman VERSES 6–8

6 "If she gets married while her vows are on her,
or a hasty word from her lips with which she has bound herself,
7 and her husband hears it and says nothing to her on the day he hears it,
then her vows will stand.
And her promises with which she has bound herself will stand.
8 But if her husband forbids it on the day he hears it,
then he cancels the vow that is on her,
and the hasty word from her lips with which she has bound herself.
The LORD will forgive her.

A widow or a divorced woman VERSE 9

9 "But the vow of a widow or of a divorced woman,
everything with which she has bound herself, will stand for her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Widows and divorced women are independent. They decide about their vows themselves, just like men.

A vow in marriage VERSES 10–16

10 "If she made a vow in her husband's house,
or bound herself to something with an oath,
11 and her husband heard it and said nothing to her and did not forbid it,
then all her vows will stand.
And every promise with which she bound herself will stand.
12 But if her husband completely canceled them on the day he heard them,
then nothing that came from her lips will stand,
not her vows and not her promise.
Her husband has canceled them. The LORD will forgive her.
13 Every vow and every oath that binds her to humble herself,
her husband may confirm it, or her husband may cancel it.
14 But if her husband says nothing to her from one day to the next,
then he confirms all her vows and all her promises that are on her.
He has confirmed them, because he said nothing to her on the day he heard them.
15 But if he cancels them later, after he has heard them,
then he will carry her guilt."
16 These are the rules that the LORD commanded Moses,
between a man and his wife,
and between a father and his daughter, while she is young and lives in her father's house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: Humble herself here means: to fast or to give up something.

These rules show how the family was organized back then. The father or the husband was responsible for the household. That is why he could cancel a vow of his daughter or his wife. For example, if she had promised to offer something valuable from the family's property.

From today's point of view, this is unequal. Men could decide for themselves, women could not always do so. Here the Bible describes the order of its own time. Today men and women have equal rights. That fits the dignity that God gives every person (Genesis 1:27; Galatians 3:28).

But there is also protection for the woman: The man must react right away, on the same day. He cannot cancel a vow later just as he likes. If he does it anyway, he carries the guilt, not the woman.

And when a vow is canceled, God forgives the woman. She is not guilty.

CHAPTER 31

The war against Midian

12,000 men go to war VERSES 1–6

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Take revenge for the people of Israel on the Midianites.
After that you will be gathered to your people."
Being gathered to your people means: to die.
3 Moses spoke to the people. He said,
"Arm men from among you for war.
They are to go against Midian, to carry out the LORD's revenge on Midian.
4 From every tribe, from all the tribes of Israel, you must send 1,000 men to the war."
5 So from the thousands of Israel, 1,000 men were chosen from every tribe,
12,000 men armed for war.
6 Moses sent them to the war, 1,000 from every tribe, together with Phinehas, the son of Eleazar the priest.
Phinehas had the holy objects and the trumpets for the alarm signal in his hand.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is one of the hardest in the whole Bible. It tells about a war with great cruelty.

The reason for the war is told in Chapter 25: The Midianites had led Israel into worshiping idols on purpose. Because of this, 24,000 Israelites died in a plague.

It is Moses' last task before his death.

The victory VERSES 7–12

7 They fought against Midian, as the LORD had commanded Moses.
They killed every male.
8 Together with the others they killed, they also killed the kings of Midian:
Evi, Rekem, Zur, Hur and Reba, the five kings of Midian.
They also killed Balaam, the son of Beor, with the sword.
9 The people of Israel took the women of Midian captive, together with their little children.
They took all their livestock, all their flocks and all their goods as plunder.
10 They burned all their cities where they lived and all their camps with fire.
11 They took all the captives and all the plunder, people and animals.
12 They brought the captives, the plunder and the goods they had taken to Moses,
to Eleazar the priest and to the community of the people of Israel.
They brought them to the camp in the plains of Moab, by the Jordan, at Jericho.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Balaam is also among the dead. He had blessed Israel. But later he had advised the Midianites to lead Israel astray (verse 16). So his life ends in the fight against Israel.

Zur is the father of Cozbi, the woman from Chapter 25.

It is not certain whether all of Midian was really wiped out. Later in the Bible there are many Midianites again (Judges 6). It was probably about one particular group of Midianites in this area.

Moses' terrible order VERSES 13–18

13 Moses, Eleazar the priest and all the leaders of the community went out to meet them outside the camp.
14 Moses was angry with the officers of the army, the commanders of thousands and the commanders of hundreds, who came back from the war.
15 Moses said to them,
"Have you let all the women live?
16 Look, it was these women who, on Balaam's advice, caused the people of Israel
to be unfaithful to the LORD in the matter of Peor.
That is why the plague came on the community of the LORD.
17 So now kill every boy among the children.
And kill every woman who has slept with a man.
18 But keep alive for yourselves all the girls who have not slept with a man.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Something horrible is ordered here: Boys and women are to be killed. Only the young girls stay alive, as captives of the Israelites.

We must say it honestly: This is almost unbearable for us. Children and women are killed. Girls are made captives. By our understanding today, these are serious war crimes.

How can something like this be in the Bible? Jews and Christians have given different answers:

Some say: The Bible honestly tells how people fought wars back then. All the nations of that time did such things. The Bible does not hide this, but it does not make it an example for all times.

Others say: These stories show how seriously turning away from God was taken back then. The people were to be protected from foreign gods.

Many point out: You have to read the whole Bible. Later God forbids that children be punished for the guilt of their parents (Deuteronomy 24:16). The prophets dream of a peace in which swords will be made into plows (Isaiah 2:4). Jesus says: "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:44).

One thing is completely certain: Nobody may use this passage to justify violence against people. That would be a serious misuse of the Bible.

Cleansing after the war VERSES 19–24

19 "Camp outside the camp for seven days.
Everyone who has killed a person, and everyone who has touched someone who was killed,
must purify himself on the third day and on the seventh day, you and your captives.
20 You must purify every piece of clothing,
everything made of leather, everything made of goats'

hair,
and all things made of wood."
21 Eleazar the priest said to the soldiers who had gone into the battle,
"This is the rule of the law that the LORD has commanded Moses:
22 The gold, the silver, the bronze, the iron, the tin and the lead,
23 everything that can stand the fire, you must pass through the fire. Then it will be clean.
But it must also be purified with the water for cleansing.
And everything that cannot stand the fire, you must pass through the water.
24 On the seventh day you must wash your clothes, and then you will be clean.
After that you may come into the camp."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: To purify means: to make clean before God.

Even someone who has killed in war becomes unclean. He may not simply go back into the camp and before God. He needs seven days and a cleansing.

This shows: Even a war that was thought to be necessary is not something that simply passes. Killing leaves marks. Later King David was not allowed to build the temple, because he had shed so much blood (1 Chronicles 22:8).

Metal is cleansed by fire, other things by water.

The plunder is divided VERSES 25–47

25 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
26 "Count the plunder that was taken, people and animals. Do it together with Eleazar the priest and the heads of the families of the community.
27 Divide the plunder into two halves:
one for the soldiers who went into battle,
and one for the whole community.
28 From the soldiers who went into battle, collect a tax for the LORD:
1 out of every 500, from the people, from the cattle, from the donkeys and from the flocks.
29 Take it from their half and give it to Eleazar the priest, as a wave offering for the LORD.
30 From the half of the people of Israel, you must take 1 out of every 50,
from the people, from the cattle, from the donkeys, from the flocks, from all the livestock.
Give them to the Levites, who do the work at the LORD's tabernacle."
The tabernacle is the holy tent where God lives among his people.
31 Moses and Eleazar the priest did as the LORD had commanded Moses.
32 The plunder, not counting what the soldiers had taken for themselves,
was 675,000 sheep,
33 72,000 cattle,
34 61,000 donkeys,
35 and 32,000 people in all, girls who had not slept with a man.
36 The half that was the share of the soldiers was 337,500 sheep.
37 The LORD's tax from the sheep was 675.
38 The cattle were 36,000. The LORD's tax from them was 72.
39 The donkeys were 30,500. The LORD's tax from them was 61.
40 The people were 16,000. The LORD's tax from them was 32 people.
41 Moses gave the tax, the LORD's wave offering, to Eleazar the priest,
as the LORD had commanded Moses.
42 From the half of the people of Israel, which Moses had separated from the half of the soldiers –
43 the half of the community was 337,500 sheep,
44 36,000 cattle,
45 30,500 donkeys
46 and 16,000 people –
47 from the half of the people of Israel, Moses took 1 out of every 50, people and animals.
He gave them to the Levites, who did the work at the LORD's tabernacle,
as the LORD had commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 29: A wave offering is a gift that is lifted up before God.

The plunder is divided fairly: The 12,000 soldiers get half, and the whole people get the other half. That way, those who stayed at home also get something.

From both halves, a part goes to God, that is, to the priests and Levites.

The numbers are very exact. You can check them: 337,500 divided by 500 is exactly 675, and so on. The math works out.

It is especially hard that people are also counted as "plunder," the girls who were taken captive. 32 of them went to the priests, probably as servants at the holy tent. This shows a world in which people were seen as property. Today we know: No person may be the property of another.

Later there were rules to protect the girls. An Israelite could not simply use or sell a woman taken captive. He had to give her time to mourn and treat her like a wife (Deuteronomy 21:10–14). By today's standards, this is still not a just situation.

The officers' thank offering VERSES 48–54

48 The officers over the thousands of the army,
the commanders of thousands and the commanders of hundreds, came to Moses.
49 They said to Moses,
"Your servants have counted the soldiers who are under our command.
Not a single man of us is missing.
50 So we have brought an offering for the LORD, what each man found:
gold jewelry, armbands, bracelets, signet rings, earrings and necklaces.
We bring it to make atonement for ourselves before the LORD."
Atonement means: putting things right again between God and people.

51 Moses and Eleazar the priest took the gold from them,
all of it finely made jewelry.
52 All the gold of the wave offering that they gave to the LORD,
from the commanders of thousands and the commanders of hundreds,
was 16,750 shekels (about 420 pounds).
53 The soldiers had taken plunder, each man for himself.
54 Moses and Eleazar the priest took the gold of the commanders of thousands and of hundreds.
They brought it into the Tent of Meeting,
as a reminder for the people of Israel before the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 50: A signet ring is a ring with a seal that is used like a signature.

A shekel is about 0.4 ounces. So 16,750 shekels of gold weighed about 420 pounds.

Not a single soldier died in the war. The officers see this as a miracle and thank God with a large gift.

"To make atonement for ourselves": Maybe they feel that they have taken guilt on themselves by killing. They want to be made clean again before God.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 32

Reuben and Gad want to stay east of the Jordan

The request of Reuben and Gad VERSES 1–5

1 The people of Reuben and the people of Gad had a very large number of livestock.
They saw the land of Jazer and the land of Gilead.
They saw that the area was a good place for livestock.
2 So the people of Gad and the people of Reuben came.
They spoke to Moses, to Eleazar the priest and to the leaders of the community.
They said,
3 "Ataroth, Dibon, Jazer, Nimrah, Heshbon, Elealeh,
Sebam, Nebo and Beon,
4 the land that the LORD defeated before the community of Israel,
is a land for livestock.
And your servants have livestock."
5 They said,
"If we have found favor in your eyes,
let this land be given to your servants as their property.
Do not take us across the Jordan."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people are still camping east of the Jordan. Israel has just conquered this land from the kings Sihon and Og (Chapter 21).

The tribes of Reuben and Gad raise livestock. They see that the land here has good pastures. They want to stay. They do not want to move into the actual land of Canaan on the other side of the river.

Moses becomes angry VERSES 6–15

6 Moses said to the people of Gad and to the people of Reuben,
"Should your brothers go to war while you sit here?
7 Why are you taking away the courage of the people of Israel,
so that they will not go over into the land that the LORD has given them?
8 That is what your fathers did
when I sent them from Kadesh Barnea to look at the land.
9 They went up to the valley of Eshcol and saw the land.
Then they took away the courage of the people of Israel,
so that they would not go into the land that the LORD had given them.
10 On that day the LORD's anger burned, and he swore,
11 'None of the men who came up out of Egypt,
20 years old and older,
will see the land that I promised with an oath to Abraham, to Isaac and to Jacob.
For they have not followed me with their whole heart.
12 Only Caleb, the son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite, and Joshua, the son of Nun, will see it,
for they have followed the LORD completely.'
13 The LORD's anger burned against Israel.
He made them wander back and forth in the wilderness for 40 years,
until the whole generation that had done evil in the LORD's eyes was gone.
14 Look, now you have taken your fathers' place,
a new crowd of sinful men,
to make the LORD's burning anger against Israel even greater.
15 For if you turn away from following him,
he will leave the people in the wilderness again.
And you will destroy this whole people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses is afraid: It could become like it was 38 years ago. Back then, 10 spies took away the people's courage (Chapters 13 and 14). That is why the people had to stay in the wilderness for 40 years.

If two tribes now say, "We are staying here," then the others might think, "Then why should we fight?" Moses sees the danger: The unity of the people could break apart.

Moses says it very harshly: You are like your fathers. You are putting the whole people in danger.

Reuben and Gad make an offer VERSES 16–19

16 They came up to him and said,
"We will build pens for our livestock here, and cities for our little children.

17 But we ourselves will be armed and ready to go ahead of
the people of Israel,
until we have brought them to their place.
Our little children will live in the cities with walls,
to be safe from the people who live in the land.
18 We will not go back to our homes
until all the people of Israel have received their
inheritance.
19 For we will not inherit with them on the other side of
the Jordan and beyond.
Our inheritance has come to us on this side of the
Jordan, to the east."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Reuben and Gad understand Moses' worry. They make a fair offer: Our families stay here in safe cities. But our men will fight together with the other tribes. They will even go first. Only when everyone has their land will they come home.

They do not leave their brothers alone.

Moses accepts the offer VERSES 20–24

20 Moses said to them,
"If you do this,
if you arm yourselves to go to war before the LORD,
21 and every armed man of yours crosses the Jordan
before the LORD,
until he has driven out his enemies before him,
22 and the land is conquered before the LORD,
then afterward you may go back.
Then you will be free of your duty to the LORD and to
Israel.
And this land will be your property before the LORD.
23 But if you do not do this,
look, then you have sinned against the LORD.
And be sure that your sin will find you out.
24 Build cities for your little children and pens for your
sheep.
And do what you have promised."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Your sin will find you out" has become a well-known saying. It means: You cannot run away from your guilt. Someone who breaks a promise will feel the results sooner or later.

Moses reminds them: Promises must be kept. Chapter 30 was about this too.

The agreement is confirmed VERSES 25–32

25 The people of Gad and the people of Reuben spoke to
Moses. They said,
"Your servants will do what my lord commands.
26 Our little children, our wives, our flocks and all our
livestock
will stay there in the cities of Gilead.
27 But your servants will cross over,
every man who is armed for war, before the LORD into
battle,
just as my lord says."
28 So Moses gave orders about them to Eleazar the priest,
to Joshua, the son of Nun,
and to the heads of the families of the tribes of the
people of Israel.
29 Moses said to them,
"The people of Gad and the people of Reuben may cross
the Jordan with you,
every man armed for battle before the LORD,
and the land may be conquered before you.
If so, you must give them the land of Gilead as their
property.
30 But if they do not cross over with you armed,
they must receive property among you in the land of
Canaan."
31 The people of Gad and the people of Reuben answered,
"We will do what the LORD has said to your servants.
32 We will cross over armed before the LORD into the land
of Canaan.
But the property of our inheritance will stay ours on
the other side of the Jordan."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses knows that he will die soon. That is why he passes on the agreement to Eleazar and Joshua. Later they are to make sure that it is kept.

Reuben and Gad kept their word. In the book of Joshua, their men fight together with the others. Only after that does Joshua send them home, and he praises them for their faithfulness (Joshua 22:1–4).

The land east of the Jordan is divided VERSES 33–42

33 Moses gave them, the people of Gad, the people of
Reuben
and the half-tribe of Manasseh, the son of Joseph,
the kingdom of Sihon, king of the Amorites,
and the kingdom of Og, king of Bashan.
He gave them the land with its cities and borders, the
cities of the land all around.
34 The people of Gad built Dibon, Ataroth, Aroer,
35 Atroth-shophan, Jazer, Jogbehah,
36 Beth Nimrah and Beth Haran: cities with walls, and
pens for sheep.
37 The people of Reuben built Heshbon, Elealeh,
Kiriathaim,
38 Nebo and Baal Meon – their names were changed – and
Sibmah.
They gave other names to the cities that they built.
39 The people of Machir, the son of Manasseh, went to
Gilead.
They took it and drove out the Amorites who lived
there.
40 Moses gave Gilead to Machir, the son of Manasseh.
And he lived there.
41 Jair, the son of Manasseh, went and took its villages.
He called them Havvoth Jair.
42 Nobah went and took Kenath and its villages.
He called it Nobah, after his own name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now, suddenly, the half-tribe of Manasseh appears too. Some of the families of Manasseh also get land east of the Jordan, in the north. The other part later lives west of the Jordan.

So two and a half tribes live east of the Jordan, and nine and a half tribes live in the land of Canaan.

"Havvoth Jair" means "the tent villages of Jair."

Nebo and Baal Meon were names of foreign gods. That is probably why the names were changed.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 33

The stops on the journey through the wilderness

Moses writes down the way VERSES 1–4

1 These are the journeys of the people of Israel
when they went out of the land of Egypt in their armies,
led by Moses and Aaron.
2 At the LORD's command, Moses wrote down the starting points of their journeys.
These are their journeys, by their starting points.
3 They set out from Rameses in the first month, on the fifteenth day of the first month.
On the day after the Passover, the people of Israel went out with a raised hand,
in front of the eyes of all the Egyptians.
4 At that time the Egyptians were burying all their firstborn, whom the LORD had struck down among them.
The LORD had also brought judgment on their gods.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is like a travel diary. It lists all the places where Israel camped on the way from Egypt to the Jordan. Moses himself wrote this list.

"With a raised hand" means: freely, bravely, without hiding. The slaves do not leave in secret. They go out as free people.

"Judgment on their gods": The plagues in Egypt showed that the gods of Egypt have no power against the LORD.

From Egypt to Mount Sinai VERSES 5–15

5 The people of Israel set out from Rameses and camped in Succoth.
6 They set out from Succoth and camped in Etham, which is at the edge of the wilderness.
7 They set out from Etham and turned back to Pihahiroth, which is across from Baal Zephon.
And they camped across from Migdol.
8 They set out from Hahiroth and went through the middle of the sea into the wilderness.
They traveled three days in the wilderness of Etham and camped in Marah.
9 They set out from Marah and came to Elim.
In Elim there were 12 springs of water and 70 palm trees. They camped there.
10 They set out from Elim and camped by the Red Sea.
11 They set out from the Red Sea and camped in the wilderness of Sin.
12 They set out from the wilderness of Sin and camped in Dophkah.
13 They set out from Dophkah and camped in Alush.
14 They set out from Alush and camped in Rephidim.
There was no water there for the people to drink.
15 They set out from Rephidim and camped in the wilderness of Sinai.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

We know many of these places from the book of Exodus: the way through the sea (Chapter 14), the bitter water of Marah (Chapter 15), the oasis of Elim with its palm trees, the water from the rock at Rephidim (Chapter 17), and finally Mount Sinai.

"Red Sea": That is what the WEB, our English source text, says. The Hebrew says "Yam Suf." That literally means "Sea of Reeds."

From Sinai to Kadesh VERSES 16–36

16 They set out from the wilderness of Sinai and camped in Kibroth Hattaavah.
17 They set out from Kibroth Hattaavah and camped in Hazeroth.
18 They set out from Hazeroth and camped in Rithmah.
19 They set out from Rithmah and camped in Rimmon Perez.
20 They set out from Rimmon Perez and camped in Libnah.
21 They set out from Libnah and camped in Rissah.
22 They set out from Rissah and camped in Kehelathah.
23 They set out from Kehelathah and camped at Mount Shepher.
24 They set out from Mount Shepher and camped in Haradah.
25 They set out from Haradah and camped in Makheloth.
26 They set out from Makheloth and camped in Tahath.
27 They set out from Tahath and camped in Terah.
28 They set out from Terah and camped in Mithkah.
29 They set out from Mithkah and camped in Hashmonah.
30 They set out from Hashmonah and camped in Moseroth.
31 They set out from Moseroth and camped in Bene Jaakan.
32 They set out from Bene Jaakan and camped in Hor Haggidgad.
33 They set out from Hor Haggidgad and camped in Jotbathah.
34 They set out from Jotbathah and camped in Abronah.
35 They set out from Abronah and camped in Ezion Geber.
36 They set out from Ezion Geber and camped at Kadesh in the wilderness of Zin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Kibroth Hattaavah means "graves of craving." People died there after they greedily ate quails (Chapter 11). At Hazeroth, Miriam and Aaron spoke against Moses (Chapter 12).

Most places in this list are not mentioned anywhere else. Today people often no longer know where they were. These are the many years in the wilderness that the Bible otherwise tells little about.

Ezion Geber is on the Gulf of Aqaba, on the Red Sea. Later King Solomon had a harbor there (1 Kings 9:26).

Aaron's death and the way to Moab VERSES 37–49

37 They set out from Kadesh and camped at Mount Hor, at
the edge of the land of Edom.
38 At the LORD's command, Aaron the priest went up
Mount Hor and died there.
That was in the fortieth year after the people of Israel
had come out of the land of Egypt,
in the fifth month, on the first day of the month.
39 Aaron was 123 years old when he died on Mount Hor.
40 The Canaanite king of Arad, who lived in the South in
the land of Canaan,
heard that the people of Israel were coming.
41 They set out from Mount Hor and camped in
Zalmonah.
42 They set out from Zalmonah and camped in Punon.
43 They set out from Punon and camped in Oboth.
44 They set out from Oboth and camped in Iye Abarim, at
the border of Moab.
45 They set out from Iyim and camped in Dibon Gad.
46 They set out from Dibon Gad and camped in Almon
Diblathaim.
47 They set out from Almon Diblathaim and camped in
the mountains of Abarim, across from Nebo.
48 They set out from the mountains of Abarim and
camped in the plains of Moab,
by the Jordan, at Jericho.
49 They camped by the Jordan, from Beth Jeshimoth all
the way to Abel Shittim, in the plains of Moab.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only here does the Bible say exactly when Aaron died and how old he was. His death was told in Chapter 20.

The king of Arad is mentioned briefly. He had attacked Israel (Numbers 21:1–3).

"Iyim" is a short form of Iye Abarim. It is the same place.

If you count all the camping places, with Rameses at the beginning, you get 42 stops. Jewish teachers have said: God saw every step of his people. No stop was forgotten. It is the same in the life of every person: God knows every stage, even the hard ones.

The task for the land of Canaan VERSES 50–56

50 The LORD spoke to Moses in the plains of Moab, by the
Jordan, at Jericho.
He said,
51 "Speak to the people of Israel, and tell them,
'When you cross the Jordan into the land of Canaan,
52 you must drive out all the people who live in the land
before you.
Destroy all their idols of stone.
Destroy all their images made of melted metal.
And tear down all their high places.
53 You must take the land as your own and live in it.
For I have given you the land, so that you may own it.
54 You must divide the land by lot as an inheritance, by
your families.
To the larger groups you must give a larger
inheritance,
and to the smaller ones a smaller inheritance.
Wherever the lot falls for someone, that will be his.
You will inherit by the tribes of your ancestors.
55 But if you do not drive out the people who live in the
land before you,
then those of them you let stay will be like splinters in
your eyes
and like thorns in your sides.
They will cause you trouble in the land where you live.
56 And this will happen:
What I planned to do to them, I will do to you.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"High places" were places on hills where people brought offerings to foreign gods.

God commands them to drive out the people who live there and to destroy their idols. The reason is in verse 55: Israel must not be led into worshiping idols. Later in Israel's history, that really did happen again and again.

Verse 56 is a serious warning: If Israel becomes like the nations, then Israel will fare like them. Israel can lose the land again too. Later that happened in the exile in Babylon.

This passage belongs to a certain time and situation. It is not a task for today. Nobody may use it to drive people off their land.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 34

The borders of the land

The southern border VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
2 "Command the people of Israel, and tell them,
'You will come into the land of Canaan.
This is the land that will be given to you as an
inheritance, the land of Canaan with its borders.
3 Your south side will run from the wilderness of Zin
along the side of Edom.
Your southern border will start in the east, at the end
of the Salt Sea.
4 Your border will turn south of the ascent of Akrabbim
and go on to Zin.
It will pass south of Kadesh Barnea.
From there it will go to Hazar Addar and go on to
Azmon.
5 From Azmon the border will turn to the brook of
Egypt,
and it will end at the sea.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God describes the borders of the land that Israel is to receive.

The "Salt Sea" is the Dead Sea. It is so salty that no fish live in it.

"Akrabbim" is Hebrew and means "scorpions." The ascent of Akrabbim, the "Scorpion Pass," is a steep road in the south.

The "brook of Egypt" is probably a river valley in the north of the Sinai Peninsula. It only has water when it rains. The "sea" means the Mediterranean Sea.

The western border and the northern border VERSES 6–9

6 "'For the western border, you will have the great sea and its coast.
This will be your western border.
7 "'This will be your northern border:
From the great sea you must mark out your border to Mount Hor.
8 From Mount Hor you must mark it out to the entrance of Hamath.
And the border will pass by Zedad.
9 Then the border will go to Ziphron, and it will end at Hazar Enan.
This will be your northern border.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "great sea" is the Mediterranean Sea.

Mount Hor here in the north is a different mountain from the Mount Hor where Aaron died. That one was in the south, near Edom.

The WEB, our English source text, says "the entrance of Hamath." Many translate it as a place name: "Lebo Hamath." Hamath was a city in what is today Syria.

The eastern border VERSES 10–12

10 "'You must mark out your eastern border from Hazar Enan to Shepham.
11 The border will go down from Shepham to Riblah, on the east side of Ain.
The border will go on down and reach the shore of the sea of Chinnereth on the east.
12 The border will go down to the Jordan and end at the Salt Sea.
This will be your land, with its borders all around.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "sea of Chinnereth" is the Sea of Galilee. Later Jesus lived and preached by this lake.

The eastern border is the Jordan. So the land of Canaan in the narrow sense lies west of the Jordan.

In its history, Israel only rarely owned all of the land with these borders. It came closest under King David and King Solomon.

These old borders are not a map for politics today. Here the Bible describes what God promised his people back then.

The land for nine and a half tribes VERSES 13–15

13 Moses commanded the people of Israel. He said,
"This is the land that you will inherit by lot.
The LORD has commanded that it be given to the nine tribes and to the half-tribe.
14 For the tribe of the people of Reuben, by their families,
the tribe of the people of Gad, by their families,
and the half-tribe of Manasseh have already received their inheritance.
15 The two tribes and the half-tribe have received their inheritance on the other side of the Jordan,
at Jericho, to the east, toward the sunrise."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This connects to Chapter 32: Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh have already received their land east of the Jordan.

The men who divide the land VERSES 16–29

16 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
17 "These are the names of the men who will divide the land among you as an inheritance:
Eleazar the priest, and Joshua, the son of Nun.
18 You must take one leader from every tribe to divide the land as an inheritance.
19 These are the names of the men:
From the tribe of Judah: Caleb, the son of Jephunneh.
20 From the tribe of the people of Simeon: Shemuel, the son of Ammihud.
21 From the tribe of Benjamin: Elidad, the son of Chislon.
22 From the tribe of the people of Dan, a leader: Bukki, the son of Jogli.
23 From the people of Joseph:
from the tribe of the people of Manasseh, a leader:
Hanniel, the son of Ephod.
24 From the tribe of the people of Ephraim, a leader:
Kemuel, the son of Shiphtan.
25 From the tribe of the people of Zebulun, a leader:
Elizaphan, the son of Parnach.
26 From the tribe of the people of Issachar, a leader:
Paltiel, the son of Azzan.
27 From the tribe of the people of Asher, a leader: Ahihud, the son of Shelomi.
28 From the tribe of the people of Naphtali, a leader:
Pedahel, the son of Ammihud."
29 These are the men whom the LORD commanded to divide the inheritance among the people of Israel in the land of Canaan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The land is to be divided fairly. That is why every tribe gets a representative. No tribe is to be treated unfairly.

Only 10 tribes are named. Reuben and Gad are missing, because they already have their land. Manasseh still gets a representative, because the other half of the tribe will still receive land west of the Jordan.

Caleb is the only well-known name. He was one of the two faithful spies. Now, after 40 years, he may help divide the land that he explored back then.

CHAPTER 35

Cities for the Levites – cities of refuge

48 cities for the Levites VERSES 1–8

1 The LORD spoke to Moses in the plains of Moab, by the Jordan, at Jericho.
He said,
2 "Command the people of Israel to give the Levites cities to live in, from their inheritance.
You must also give the Levites pasture land around the cities.
3 They will have the cities to live in.
And their pasture land will be for their livestock, for their goods and for all their animals.
4 "The pasture land of the cities that you give to the Levites
is to reach out from the city wall about 1,500 feet, all around.
5 Outside the city you must measure
about 3,000 feet on the east side,
about 3,000 feet on the south side,
about 3,000 feet on the west side
and about 3,000 feet on the north side.
The city will be in the middle.
This will be the pasture land of their cities.
6 "Among the cities that you give to the Levites will be the 6 cities of refuge.
You must give them so that someone who has killed a person can flee there.
Besides them, you must give 42 cities.
7 All the cities that you give to the Levites will be 48 cities together, with their pasture land.
8 As for the cities that you give from the property of the people of Israel:
From the large tribes you must take many, and from the small ones you must take few.
Each tribe must give some of its cities to the Levites, according to the inheritance it receives."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: A city of refuge is a city where someone can flee and be safe.

The Bible says: 1,000 cubits and 2,000 cubits. A cubit is about 18 inches.

The numbers in verses 4 and 5 are hard to understand. Bible teachers explain them in different ways. One explanation is: The 1,000 cubits go out from the wall. The 2,000 cubits are the length of each side of the whole pasture land. Another explanation is: The first 1,000 cubits are pasture land, and the next 1,000 cubits are fields and vineyards.

The tribe of Levi does not get its own area. The Levites are there for the worship of God. That is why they live spread out in cities all over the land. That way they are close to the people everywhere and can teach them about faith.

Six cities of refuge VERSES 9–15

9 The LORD spoke to Moses. He said,
10 "Speak to the people of Israel, and tell them,
'When you cross the Jordan into the land of Canaan,
11 you must choose cities for yourselves to be cities of refuge for you.
Someone who has killed a person without meaning to may flee there.
12 The cities will give you refuge from the avenger,
so that the one who has killed does not die
before he has stood trial before the community.
13 The cities that you give will be six cities of refuge for you.
14 You must give three cities on the other side of the Jordan,
and you must give three cities in the land of Canaan.
They will be cities of refuge.
15 These six cities will be a refuge for the people of Israel, for the stranger and for the foreigner living among them.
Everyone who has killed a person without meaning to may flee there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then there was no police. If someone was killed, a close relative had the duty to take revenge. He was called the "avenger of blood."

But what if it was an accident? Then revenge would be unjust. That is why God creates the cities of refuge. Anyone who has killed without meaning to can flee there. There he is safe until a court has decided.

This is a big step forward: Revenge does not decide, but a just court does.

Strangers and foreigners also have this right. The law is the same for everyone.

What is murder? VERSES 16–21

16 "'But if he hit him with an object made of iron, so that he died,
he is a murderer. The murderer must surely be put to death.
17 If he hit him with a stone in his hand that can kill a person,
and he died, he is a murderer.
The murderer must surely be put to death.
18 Or if he hit him with a wooden weapon in his hand that can kill a person,
and he died, he is a murderer.
The murderer must surely be put to death.
19 The avenger of blood himself must put the murderer to death.
When he meets him, he must put him to death.
20 If he pushed him out of hate,
or threw something at him while lying in wait, so that he died,
21 or if he hit him with his hand because he was his enemy, so that he died,
then the one who hit him must surely be put to death.
He is a murderer.
The avenger of blood must put the murderer to death when he meets him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a difference is made: When is it murder, and when is it an accident?

It is murder when someone uses a dangerous weapon. Or when he acts out of hate. Or when he hides and lies in wait for the other person. Then he wanted to kill.

Back then, the punishment for murder was death. Today many countries have ended the death penalty, and many Jews and Christians work for this. But the thought behind it stays important: A human life is endlessly precious. Anyone who takes it on purpose does a very serious wrong.

What is an accident? VERSES 22–29

22 "'But he may have pushed him suddenly, without being his enemy,
or thrown something at him without lying in wait,
23 or dropped a stone on him that can kill a person,
without seeing him, so that he died.
And he was not his enemy and did not want to harm him.
24 Then the community must judge between the one who hit him and the avenger of blood,
by these rules.
25 The community must save the one who killed from the hand of the avenger of blood.
And the community must bring him back to his city of refuge, where he had fled.
He must stay there until the death of the high priest, who was anointed with the holy oil.
26 "'But the one who killed may at some time go outside the border of his city of refuge, where he fled.
27 And the avenger of blood may find him outside the border of his city of refuge
and kill him.
Then the avenger of blood is not guilty of blood.
28 For the one who killed should have stayed in his city of refuge until the death of the high priest.
But after the death of the high priest, he may go back to the land that is his property.
29 "'These things are to be a fixed law and rule for you, for all your generations, everywhere you live.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: Anointed means: Oil was poured on his head as a sign that God chose him.

Someone who has killed another person by accident is not a murderer. But he is not simply free either. He must stay in the city of refuge. He is protected there, but he cannot go home. This shows: Even an accident is something serious. A life has been lost.

He may only go home when the high priest dies. With the death of the high priest, a new time begins. Jewish teachers have said: The death of the high priest brings a kind of atonement.

Christians see in this a picture of Jesus. In the letter to the Hebrews, Jesus is called the great high priest (Hebrews 4:14). Through his death, people become free. And the letter to the Hebrews speaks of people who flee to God for refuge, to hold on to the hope he gives (Hebrews 6:18).

No ransom for murder VERSES 30–34

30 "'Whoever kills a person: The murderer must be put to death based on what witnesses say.
But one witness alone may not speak against a person, so that he dies.
31 "'You must also not take a ransom for the life of a murderer who is guilty and must die.
He must surely be put to death.
32 "'And you must not take a ransom for someone who has fled to his city of refuge,
so that he can come back and live in the land before the death of the priest.
33 "'So you must not pollute the land where you live.
For blood pollutes the land.
No atonement can be made for the land for the blood that was shed in it,
except by the blood of the one who shed it.
34 You must not make the land unclean, the land where you live and where I live.
For I, the LORD, live among the people of Israel.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31: A ransom is money paid to set someone free.

An important protection: Nobody may be condemned because of what only one witness says. There must be at least two. That is meant to prevent false accusations. This rule is still part of many legal systems today.

No ransom: A rich person is not to be able to buy his way free. A human life cannot be paid for with money. Poor and rich are equal before the law.

The last verse explains the deepest reason: God lives among his people. That is why the land is holy. Murder is not only a crime against people, but also against God, who lives there.

NUMBERS

CHAPTER 36

The daughters of Zelophehad once more

A worry of the family VERSES 1–4

1 The heads of the families of the clan of the descendants of Gilead came forward.
Gilead was the son of Machir, the son of Manasseh, from the families of the sons of Joseph.
They spoke before Moses and before the leaders, the heads of the families of the people of Israel.
2 They said,
"The LORD commanded my lord to give the land to the people of Israel as an inheritance by lot.
And my lord was commanded by the LORD
to give the inheritance of Zelophehad, our brother, to his daughters.
3 But they may marry men from one of the other tribes of the people of Israel.
Then their inheritance will be taken away from the

inheritance of our ancestors.
It will be added to the inheritance of the tribe they will then belong to.
So it will be taken away from the share of our inheritance.
4 When the year of jubilee of the people of Israel comes,
their inheritance will be added to the inheritance of the tribe they belong to.
So their inheritance will be taken away from the inheritance of the tribe of our ancestors."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Chapter 27, the five daughters of Zelophehad received the right to inherit their father's land.

Now the men from their clan come with a worry: If the daughters marry men from another tribe, the land will later belong to the families of those men. Then the area of the tribe of Manasseh will become smaller.

The "year of jubilee" came every 50 years. Then land that had been sold was to go back to the family it first belonged to (Leviticus 25). But inherited land like this was not sold. So the year of jubilee would not have changed anything. The loss would be final.

The solution VERSES 5–9

5 Moses commanded the people of Israel by the word of the LORD.
He said,
"The tribe of the sons of Joseph is right.
6 This is what the LORD commands about the daughters of Zelophehad:
'They may marry whom they think best.
But they must marry into a family of their father's tribe.
7 That way no inheritance of the people of Israel will move from tribe to tribe.
For each of the people of Israel is to keep the inheritance of the tribe of his ancestors.
8 Every daughter who owns an inheritance in one of the tribes of the people of Israel
must marry a man from a family of her father's tribe.
That way each of the people of Israel will own the inheritance of his ancestors.
9 So no inheritance will move from one tribe to another tribe.
For each of the tribes of the people of Israel is to keep its own inheritance.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Once again a question is brought to God. And once again a fair solution is found.

The daughters keep their inheritance. They may decide for themselves whom they marry: "whom they think best." That was not a matter of course back then. The only condition is: The man is to be from their own tribe.

In this way both are protected: the right of the women and the land of the tribe.

This rule only applied to daughters who had inherited land. Otherwise Israelites could also marry into other tribes.

The daughters obey VERSES 10–12

10 The daughters of Zelophehad did as the LORD had commanded Moses.
11 Mahlah, Tirzah, Hoglah, Milcah and Noah, the daughters of Zelophehad,
married the sons of their father's brothers.
12 They married into the families of the sons of Manasseh, the son of Joseph.
And their inheritance stayed in the tribe of their father's family.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The five sisters marry their cousins. Back then that was common and allowed.

Their story has a good ending. Later, in the book of Joshua, they really receive their land (Joshua 17:3–6).

The end of the book VERSE 13

13 These are the commandments and the rules
that the LORD commanded the people of Israel through Moses,
in the plains of Moab, by the Jordan, at Jericho.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Numbers ends where the people now stand: by the Jordan, just before the promised land. Across from them is the city of Jericho.

It is remarkable that the book ends with a story about five women who stood up for their rights. Their courage changed the law of Israel.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Numbers?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Numbers tells about the journey through the wilderness. It took almost 40 years. The book has three large parts:

1. At Mount Sinai (Chapters 1–10): The people are counted and put in order. The Levites receive their tasks. Everything is prepared for setting out. In the middle of it is the blessing that priests still speak today: The LORD bless you and keep you (Numbers 6:24).

2. In the wilderness (Chapters 10–21): The people complain again and again. They want to go back to Egypt. They do not believe the two faithful spies. That is why the whole generation must die in the wilderness. Even Moses, Miriam and Aaron may not enter the land. But God still provides for his people every day with manna and water.

3. Before the land (Chapters 22–36): The prophet Balaam is supposed to curse Israel, but he has to bless it. A new generation is counted. Joshua becomes Moses' successor. Everything is prepared for life in the land.

The book shows honestly how hard it is for people to trust God. And it also shows hard and dark sides, like the war against Midian. These sides must not be made to look nice, and they must never be taken as an example for violence.

But the most important message is: God stays faithful, even when his people are unfaithful. He leads them step by step to the goal. One generation fails, but the next one now stands by the Jordan, ready for the new land.

The book of Deuteronomy tells what Moses still says to the people there by the Jordan as a farewell.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 5 OF 66

DEUTERONOMY

34 CHAPTERS

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 1

Moses remembers the way from Horeb

BEFORE WE BEGIN: WHAT IS THE BOOK OF DEUTERONOMY?

The book of Deuteronomy is also called "the Fifth Book of Moses." The name "Deuteronomy" is Greek. It means "second law" or "repeating the law." That is because Moses repeats many commandments here that God gave at Mount Sinai.

In Hebrew, the book is called "Devarim." That means "words." That is because the whole book is made of the speeches of Moses.

The people are standing at the Jordan, shortly before the promised land. Moses knows: I will die soon. I may not go across with them. That is why he gives long farewell speeches. He reminds them of everything God has done. He explains the commandments once more for the new generation. And he begs the people with all his heart: Stay faithful to God!

This book has the most important prayer of Israel: "Hear, Israel: The LORD is our God. The LORD is one. You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your strength" (Deuteronomy 6:4–5). Jesus called it the most important commandment.

At the end of the book, Moses dies.

In this book, Moses usually calls Mount Sinai "Horeb." It is the same mountain.

Where and when Moses speaks VERSES 1–5

1 These are the words that Moses spoke to all Israel
beyond the Jordan, in the wilderness, in the Arabah,
opposite Suf,
between Paran, Tophel, Laban, Hazeroth, and
Dizahab.
2 From Horeb by the way of Mount Seir to Kadesh Barnea
is a journey of 11 days.
3 In the fortieth year, in the eleventh month, on the first
day of the month,
Moses spoke to the people of Israel.
He told them everything that the LORD had
commanded him to tell them.
4 That was after he had struck down Sihon, the king of
the Amorites, who lived in Heshbon,
and Og, the king of Bashan, who lived in Ashtaroth, at
Edrei.
5 Beyond the Jordan, in the land of Moab, Moses began
to explain this law. He said:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Beyond the Jordan" means here: east of the Jordan, where the people are camping right now.

The "Arabah" is the deep valley that reaches from the Sea of Galilee past the Dead Sea down to the Red Sea.

Verse 2 is a quiet complaint: The way from Horeb to Kadesh takes only 11 days. But the people needed 40 years, because they did not trust God.

Moses begins "to explain this law." He does not give a completely new law. He explains it, so that the new generation understands it.

God says: Set out! VERSES 6–8

6 "The LORD our God spoke to us at Horeb. He said,
'You have lived long enough at this mountain.
7 Turn around, set out, and go to the hill country of the
Amorites
and to all the places near there:
to the Arabah, to the hill country, to the lowland, to
the South, to the seashore,
to the land of the Canaanites, and to Lebanon,
as far as the great river, the river Euphrates.
8 Look! I have put the land in front of you.
Go in and take the land as your own.
The LORD swore to your ancestors – to Abraham, to
Isaac, and to Jacob –
that he would give it to them and to their descendants
after them.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel camped at Mount Horeb (Sinai) for almost a year. There they received the commandments. But then God says: It is enough. You should not stand still. Go!

Faith is a journey. You cannot always stay at the holy mountain. You have to go with God into everyday life.

Moses appoints judges VERSES 9–18

9 At that time I said to you,
"I cannot carry you all by myself.
10 The LORD your God has made you many.
Look! Today you are as many as the stars in the sky.
11 May the LORD, the God of your ancestors, make you
1,000 times as many as you are now.
And may he bless you, as he has promised you!
12 How can I alone carry your problems, your burdens,
and your quarrels?
13 Choose wise men who have understanding and who are
respected in your tribes.
I will make them leaders over you."
14 You answered me,
"What you have said is good. We should do it."
15 So I took the leaders of your tribes, wise and respected
men,
and I made them leaders over you:
captains of thousands, captains of hundreds, captains
of fifties, captains of tens,
and officers, for your tribes.
16 At that time I commanded your judges,
"Listen to the cases between your brothers.
Judge fairly between a man and his brother,
and between a man and the foreigner who lives with
him.
17 When you judge, you must not favor anyone.
You must listen to the small person just like the great

person.
You must not be afraid of any person,
because the judgment belongs to God.
If a case is too hard for you, bring it to me. I will listen to it."
18 At that time I commanded you everything that you should do.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses reminds them how he shared out the work (Exodus 18). A leader cannot do everything alone.

The rules for the judges are still the basis of a good court today:

All people are equal before the law: poor and rich, people born in the land and foreigners.

A judge must not let anyone frighten him, not even powerful people.

"The judgment belongs to God": A judge does not judge in his own name. He must answer to God.

The spies VERSES 19–25

19 We set out from Horeb and went through all that great and terrible wilderness, which you saw.
We went on the way to the hill country of the Amorites, as the LORD our God had commanded us.
And we came to Kadesh Barnea.
20 I said to you,
"You have come to the hill country of the Amorites, which the LORD our God is giving us.
21 Look! The LORD your God has put the land in front of you.
Go up and take it as your own,
as the LORD, the God of your ancestors, has told you.
Do not be afraid, and do not lose courage."
22 Then all of you came to me and said,
"Let's send men ahead of us.
They should explore the land for us.
They should tell us which way we should go up,
and which cities we will come to."
23 I liked the idea very much.
I took 12 of your men, one man from each tribe.
24 They turned and went up into the hill country.
They came to the valley of Eshcol and spied it out.
25 They took some of the fruit of the land in their hands and brought it down to us.
They told us,
"It is a good land that the LORD our God is giving us."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story was told in detail in Numbers 13. Here Moses tells it again from his point of view.

Here we learn something new: The idea of the spies came from the people. Numbers 13 tells that God then commanded it. Both fit together: The people asked, and God allowed it.

The people do not want to go VERSES 26–33

26 But you did not want to go up.
You rebelled against the command of the LORD your God.
27 You grumbled in your tents and said,
"Because the LORD hated us, he brought us out of the land of Egypt.
He wants to hand us over to the Amorites, so that they destroy us.
28 Where are we going up to?
Our brothers have made our hearts melt with fear.
They said, 'The people are greater and taller than we are.
The cities are great, with walls up to the sky.
And we even saw the sons of the Anakim there!'"
29 Then I said to you,
"Do not be terrified. Do not be afraid of them.
30 The LORD your God goes ahead of you. He will fight for you,
just as he did everything for you in Egypt before your eyes,
31 and in the wilderness. There you saw
how the LORD your God carried you, as a man carries his son,
on the whole way that you went, until you came to this place."
32 But even so, you did not trust the LORD your God.
33 He went ahead of you on the way, to look for a place for you to set up your tents.
At night he went ahead in fire, to show you the way you should go,
and by day in the cloud.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Because the LORD hated us": That is how far fear can take a person. God freed his people from slavery. But the people think: He only wants to destroy us.

The "Anakim" were thought to be a people of very tall people, like giants.

Verse 31 is one of the most beautiful pictures in the Bible: God carried his people like a father carries his child. When the child is tired, the father picks it up in his arms. That is how God carried Israel through the wilderness.

God's judgment VERSES 34–40

34 The LORD heard what you said.
He became angry and swore:
35 "Surely not one of these men of this evil generation will see the good land that I swore to give to your ancestors,
36 except Caleb, the son of Jephunneh. He will see it.
I will give him and his children the land that he has walked on,
because he has followed the LORD completely."
37 The LORD was also angry with me because of you. He said,
"You also will not go in there.
38 Joshua, the son of Nun, who stands before you, will go in there.
Give him courage, because he will lead Israel to receive the land as their inheritance.
39 And your little ones, who you said would be captured or killed,
your children, who today do not yet know good from evil,
they will go in there.
I will give it to them, and they will own it.

40 But you, turn around and go into the wilderness, on
the way to the Red Sea."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Because of you": Moses says God was angry with him too, because of the people. Numbers 20 tells another reason: At the water of Meribah, Moses did not act as God wanted. Both belong together: The people had made Moses so angry back then that he lost his patience.

"Who stands before you" means: Joshua is your servant and helper.

God's judgment also has a good side: The children the parents were so worried about will receive the land.

The attack without God VERSES 41–46

41 Then you answered me,
"We have sinned against the LORD.
We will go up and fight, just as the LORD our God
commanded us."
Each one of you put on his weapons of war.
And you were so proud and bold that you wanted to go
up into the hill country.
42 The LORD said to me,
"Tell them, 'Do not go up, and do not fight, because I
am not among you.
Otherwise your enemies will strike you down.'"
43 I told you, but you did not listen.
You rebelled against the command of the LORD.
You were proud and bold, and you went up into the
hill country.
44 The Amorites, who lived in that hill country, came out
against you.
They chased you the way bees do.
And they struck you down in Seir, all the way to
Hormah.
45 You came back and wept before the LORD.
But the LORD did not listen to your voice, and he did
not turn his ear to you.
46 So you stayed in Kadesh for many days, for as long as
you stayed there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

First the people do not want to go when God tells them to. Then they want to go no matter what when God forbids it. Both are disobedience.

The most important sentence is: "I am not among you." Without God, even the best weapons do not help.

"The way bees do": Anyone who has ever been chased by a swarm of bees knows what it is like. You can only run away.

Verse 46 sounds strange. It means: You had to stay in Kadesh a long time, exactly as long as it took.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 2

Past Edom, Moab and Ammon – the victory over Sihon

Edom: Leave your brothers in peace VERSES 1–8

1 Then we turned and went into the wilderness, on the
way to the Red Sea,
as the LORD had told me.
And for many days we went around Mount Seir.
2 The LORD spoke to me. He said,
3 "You have gone around this mountain long enough.
Turn toward the north.
4 Command the people:
'You will pass through the land of your brothers, the
people of Esau, who live in Seir.
They will be afraid of you.
So be very careful.
5 Do not start a quarrel with them.
For I will not give you any of their land,
not even enough for the sole of a foot to step on.
For I have given Mount Seir to Esau as his own.
6 You shall buy food from them with money, so that you
can eat.
You shall also buy water from them with money, so
that you can drink.'"
7 For the LORD your God has blessed you in all the work
of your hands.
He has known how you walked through this great
wilderness.
For these 40 years the LORD your God has been with
you.
You have not lacked anything.
8 So we passed by our brothers, the people of Esau, who
live in Seir.
We went away from the road through the Arabah,
from Elath and from Ezion Geber.
We turned and went on along the way of the
wilderness of Moab.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Edomites are descendants of Esau, the brother of Jacob. That is why Moses calls them "your brothers."

God did not give land only to Israel. He also gave other peoples their land. Israel should respect that. It should buy fairly and not rob.

Verse 7 is a beautiful look back: "You have not lacked anything." Even in the wilderness, God took care of everything.

Moab: God gave them their land VERSES 9–12

9 The LORD said to me,
"Do not trouble Moab, and do not start a war with
them.
For I will not give you any of his land as your own.
For I have given Ar to the people of Lot as their own."
10 (The Emim lived there before. They were a great
people, with many people, and as tall as the Anakim.
11 They are also counted as Rephaim, like the Anakim.
But the Moabites call them Emim.
12 The Horites also lived in Seir in the past.
But the people of Esau drove them out.
They destroyed them and lived in their place,

just as Israel did to the land that it owns, which the LORD gave to them.)

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Moabites come from Lot, the nephew of Abraham. So they are relatives too.

"Ar" is a city and an area in Moab.

The verses in parentheses are a kind of explanation that was put into the text. They tell who lived in these lands before. "Rephaim," "Emim" and "Anakim" were names for ancient peoples of very tall people. People told many stories about them.

The thought behind it: Other peoples also received their land from God. God is not only the God of Israel. He guides the history of all peoples.

38 years VERSES 13–15

13 "Now get up and cross over the brook Zered."
And we crossed over the brook Zered.
14 The time from when we left Kadesh Barnea until we crossed the brook Zered
was 38 years.
In that time the whole generation of the men of war had died out from the camp,
as the LORD had sworn to them.
15 And the LORD's hand was against them,
to destroy them from the middle of the camp, until they were all gone.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When they cross the brook Zered, a new part begins. The old generation has died. Now the new generation is here.

38 years: Add the roughly 2 years from leaving Egypt to Kadesh. Together that makes the 40 years in the wilderness.

Ammon: No war here either VERSES 16–23

16 When all the men of war among the people had died out and were dead,
17 the LORD spoke to me. He said,
18 "Today you will pass by Ar, at the border of Moab.
19 When you come near the people of Ammon,
do not trouble them, and do not start a quarrel with them.
For I will not give you any of the land of the people of Ammon as your own.
For I have given it to the people of Lot as their own."
20 (That land is also counted as a land of Rephaim.
Rephaim lived there in the past.
But the Ammonites call them Zamzummim.
21 They were a great people, with many people, and as tall as the Anakim.
But the LORD destroyed them before Israel.
And they drove them out and lived in their place.
22 He had done the same for the people of Esau, who live in Seir,
when he destroyed the Horites before them.
They drove them out and lived in their place, until this day.
23 And the Avvim, who lived in villages as far as Gaza:
The Caphtorim, who came from Caphtor, destroyed them and lived in their place.)

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In verse 21, the WEB says "before Israel." But the Hebrew text says "before them," and it means the Ammonites: They drove out the Zamzummim and live in their place.

The Ammonites are also descendants of Lot. Israel should leave them in peace.

"Caphtor" is probably the island of Crete. The "Caphtorim" are probably the Philistines, who came from there to the coast near Gaza.

God gives Sihon into Israel's hand VERSES 24–25

24 "Get up, set out, and cross the valley of the Arnon.
Look! I have given Sihon the Amorite, the king of Heshbon, and his land into your hand.
Begin to take it as your own, and fight against him.
25 Today I will begin to put terror and fear of you
on the peoples under the whole sky.
They will hear about you. They will tremble and be in great fear because of you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Edom, Moab and Ammon, God said: No war! With Sihon, it is different. His land belongs to the area that Israel is supposed to receive.

The Arnon is a deep river valley that flows into the Dead Sea. It was the border between Moab and the kingdom of Sihon.

Israel asks for peace VERSES 26–30

26 I sent messengers from the wilderness of Kedemoth to Sihon, the king of Heshbon,
with words of peace. I had them say:
27 "Let me pass through your land.
I will stay on the highway.
I will not turn to the right or to the left.
28 Sell me food for money, so that I can eat.
And give me water for money, so that I can drink.
Just let me pass through on foot,
29 as the people of Esau, who live in Seir, did for me,
and the Moabites, who live in Ar,
until I cross the Jordan into the land that the LORD our God is giving us."
30 But Sihon, the king of Heshbon, would not let us pass through his land.
For the LORD your God had made his spirit hard and his heart stubborn,
so that he could give him into your hand, as it is today.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel first offers peace. It only wants to pass through and pay for everything. Only when Sihon refuses and attacks does war come (see also Numbers 21:21–31).

"God made his heart hard": We know this from Pharaoh in Egypt. The Bible says with this: Even Sihon's stubbornness is part of God's plan. This does not mean that Sihon had no choice. Jews and Christians have often said: God makes stronger what a person already wants.

The victory over Sihon VERSES 31–37

31 The LORD said to me,
"Look! I have begun to give Sihon and his land over to you.
Begin to take it, so that you inherit his land."

32 Then Sihon came out against us, he and all his people,
to fight at Jahaz.
33 The LORD our God gave him over to us.
We struck him down, with his sons and all his people.
34 At that time we took all his cities.
And we completely destroyed every city where people
lived, with the women and the little children.
We left no one alive.
35 Only the livestock we took as plunder for ourselves,
together with the plunder from the cities that we had
taken.
36 From Aroer, which is on the edge of the valley of the
Arnon, and from the city in the valley, all the way to
Gilead,
no city was too high for us.
The LORD our God gave them all over to us.
37 Only the land of the people of Ammon you did not
come near:
the whole bank of the river Jabbok, the cities in the
hill country,
and every place that the LORD our God had forbidden
us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Completely destroyed" (in Hebrew: "cherem") means here: All the people in the cities were killed, even women and children. No one was allowed to keep any of it for themselves. It was given over completely to God.

This is one of the hardest passages in the Bible. We must not make it sound nicer than it is. By our understanding today, this is a grave injustice.

Jews and Christians have struggled with texts like this for a long time. Some scholars say: This language is typical of war reports in the ancient Near East, and it often exaggerates. Others say: The Bible shows honestly how brutally people fought wars back then. Many stress: These commands were tied to a one-time situation and do not apply to other times.

One thing is very clear: No one may use this passage to justify violence against people. The Bible itself shows another way: love for the foreigner (Deuteronomy 10:19), the peace of the prophets (Isaiah 2:4), and the commandment of Jesus: "Love your enemies" (Matthew 5:44).

Here too, Israel respects the border of Ammon. It takes only what God has allowed.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 3

The victory over Og – Moses may not enter the land

The victory over Og, the king of Bashan VERSES 1–7

1 Then we turned and went up on the way to Bashan.
Og, the king of Bashan, came out against us, he and all
his people, to fight at Edrei.
2 The LORD said to me,
"Do not be afraid of him.
For I have given him into your hand, with all his
people and his land.
You shall do to him what you did to Sihon, the king of
the Amorites, who lived in Heshbon."
3 So the LORD our God also gave Og, the king of Bashan,
and all his people into our hand.
We struck him down until no one was left to him.
4 At that time we took all his cities.
There was not a single city that we did not take from
them:
60 cities, the whole region of Argob, the kingdom of
Og in Bashan.
5 All these were cities made strong with high walls,
gates, and bars.
And there were also very many villages without walls.
6 We completely destroyed them, as we had done to
Sihon, the king of Heshbon.
We completely destroyed every city where people
lived, with the women and the little children.
7 But all the livestock and the plunder from the cities we
took as plunder for ourselves.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bashan is a fertile high plain in the north, east of the Sea of Galilee. Today the area is called the Golan.

Here too, the cities are "completely destroyed," as with Sihon in Chapter 2. That means: The people who lived there were killed, even women and children. That is terrible, and we must not make it sound nicer than it is. What the explanation in Chapter 2 says is true here too: This passage must never be used to justify violence against people.

The whole land east of the Jordan VERSES 8–11

8 So at that time we took the land out of the hand of the
two kings of the Amorites who lived beyond the
Jordan,
from the valley of the Arnon to Mount Hermon.
9 (The Sidonians call Hermon Sirion, and the Amorites
call it Senir.)
10 We took all the cities of the plain, all Gilead, and all
Bashan,
as far as Salecah and Edrei, the cities of the kingdom of
Og in Bashan.
11 (For only Og, the king of Bashan, was left of the rest of
the Rephaim.
Look! His bed was a bed of iron.
Is it not in Rabbah of the people of Ammon?
It was about 13 and a half feet long and about 6 feet
wide, measured by the ordinary cubit.)

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hermon is the highest mountain in the area, more than 9,200 feet high. There is often snow on its top.

The Bible says: 9 cubits long and 4 cubits wide. A cubit is about 18 inches.

Og was the last of the "Rephaim," an ancient people of very tall people. His huge bed could still be seen in Rabbah long afterward, like a famous sight. Rabbah is today's city of Amman, the capital of Jordan.

Some interpreters think that "bed" means a coffin made of dark stone that looked like iron. That is not certain.

The land is shared out VERSES 12–17

12 At that time we took this land as our own.
From Aroer, which is by the valley of the Arnon,
and half of the hill country of Gilead with its cities,
I gave to the Reubenites and to the Gadites.
13 And the rest of Gilead and all Bashan, the kingdom of Og,
I gave to the half-tribe of Manasseh:
the whole region of Argob, all Bashan.
(This is called the land of Rephaim.
14 Jair, the son of Manasseh, took the whole region of Argob,
as far as the border of the Geshurites and the Maacathites.
And he named them, all Bashan, after his own name:
Havvoth Jair, as it is called to this day.)
15 I gave Gilead to Machir.
16 To the Reubenites and to the Gadites I gave the land
from Gilead to the valley of the Arnon,
with the middle of the valley as the border,
and as far as the river Jabbok, which is the border of the people of Ammon.
17 I also gave them the Arabah, with the Jordan as the border,
from Chinnereth to the sea of the Arabah, the Salt Sea,
below the slopes of Pisgah to the east.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here we hear again what was told in Numbers 32: Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh receive the land east of the Jordan.

The "sea of the Arabah" and the "Salt Sea" are names for the Dead Sea.

"Chinnereth" is an old name for the Sea of Galilee.

"Pisgah" is a mountain peak east of the Dead Sea. From there Moses will later see the land.

The men of Reuben and Gad are to fight too VERSES 18–22

18 At that time I commanded you:
"The LORD your God has given you this land to own it.
All your brave men shall go across armed, ahead of your brothers, the people of Israel.
19 But your wives, your little children, and your livestock
(I know that you have a lot of livestock)
shall stay in your cities that I have given you,
20 until the LORD gives rest to your brothers, as he has to you,
and until they also own the land that the LORD your God is giving them beyond the Jordan.
Then each of you shall return to his own land, which I have given you."
21 At that time I commanded Joshua:
"Your eyes have seen everything that the LORD your God has done to these two kings.
The LORD will do the same to all the kingdoms that you cross over to.
22 You shall not be afraid of them.
For the LORD your God himself fights for you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses reminds them of the agreement with Reuben and Gad from Numbers 32.

And he gives Joshua courage: You have seen with your own eyes what God has done. That is why you do not need to be afraid of the future.

Moses' request is not granted VERSES 23–29

23 At that time I begged the LORD:
24 "Lord GOD,
you have begun to show your servant your greatness and your strong hand.
For what god in heaven or on earth can do works like yours
and mighty deeds like yours?
25 Please let me go across.
Let me see the good land that is beyond the Jordan,
that beautiful hill country, and Lebanon."
26 But the LORD was angry with me because of you, and he did not listen to me.
The LORD said to me,
"That is enough! Do not speak to me about this matter anymore.
27 Go up to the top of Pisgah.
Lift up your eyes to the west, to the north, to the south, and to the east.
Look at it with your eyes.
For you will not cross this Jordan.
28 But appoint Joshua. Give him courage and make him strong.
For he will go across ahead of this people.
And he will lead them to receive as their inheritance the land that you will see."
29 So we stayed in the valley near Beth Peor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Lord GOD": Moses calls God by two names. He uses "Lord" as a title, and God's holy name, which we write as "GOD" or "the LORD."

This is one of the most personal passages in the book. Moses led the people for 40 years. His greatest wish is to enter the land. He asks God for it. But God says no.

Even great people of faith do not get everything they ask for. But God also tells Moses something comforting: You may see the land. And your work goes on, through Joshua.

Christians remember a story in the New Testament: Much later, Moses does stand in the land, on a mountain, together with Jesus (Matthew 17:1–3).

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 4

Listen to God's commandments – do not make an image of God

Listen and do it VERSES 1–8

1 And now, Israel, listen to the rules and the laws that I
am teaching you.
Do them, so that you may live, and go in, and take the
land as your own,
which the LORD, the God of your ancestors, is giving
you.
2 You shall not add anything to the word that I command
you,
and you shall not take anything away from it.
In this way you shall keep the commandments of the
LORD your God, which I command you.
3 Your eyes have seen what the LORD did because of Baal
Peor.
For the LORD your God has destroyed from among
you
all the men who followed Baal Peor.
4 But you who stayed faithful to the LORD your God
are all alive today.
5 Look! I have taught you rules and laws,
just as the LORD my God commanded me.
You shall do them in the land that you are going into
to take as your own.
6 So keep them and do them.
For this is your wisdom and your understanding in the
eyes of the peoples.
They will hear about all these rules and say,
"Truly, this great nation is a wise people with
understanding."
7 For what great nation has a god so near to them
as the LORD our God is near to us whenever we call on
him?
8 And what great nation has rules and laws as just
as all this law that I am putting before you today?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Do not add anything and do not take anything away: You should not change God's word. You should not cut it down to fit your own wishes, and you should not load it down with your own rules. That is why, in this version too, it is so important that no verse is missing.

Baal Peor: That was the story in Numbers 25. Those who followed foreign gods back then died. Those who stayed faithful are alive.

Verse 7 is a wonderful sentence: God is near. You can call on him at any time. You do not need a temple or magic. A simple prayer is enough.

The commandments are not meant to box Israel in. They are wisdom. Other peoples should see: Here people live together well and justly.

Do not forget what you saw at Horeb VERSES 9–14

9 Only be careful, and watch yourself well,
so that you do not forget the things that your eyes
have seen,
and so that they do not leave your heart, all the days of
your life.
Tell them to your children and to your grandchildren:
10 Tell them about the day when you stood before the
LORD your God at Horeb,
when the LORD said to me,
"Gather the people to me. I will let them hear my
words,
so that they learn to fear me all the days that they live
on the earth,
and so that they teach it to their children."
11 You came near and stood at the foot of the mountain.
The mountain burned with fire up into the middle of
the sky,
with darkness, clouds, and thick darkness.
12 The LORD spoke to you out of the middle of the fire.
You heard the sound of words, but you did not see any
form.
You only heard a voice.
13 He told you about his covenant, which he commanded
you to keep: the Ten Commandments.
He wrote them on two stone tablets.
14 At that time the LORD commanded me to teach you
rules and laws,
so that you would do them in the land that you are
crossing over to take as your own.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Faith lives from remembering. Parents should tell their children and grandchildren what God has done. That way faith is passed on from generation to generation.

"To fear God" does not mean to be afraid of him. It means: to have deep respect for him, to take him seriously, to honor him.

Verse 12 is very important: The people heard God's voice. But they did not see any form. God did not show himself as a picture. He showed himself through his word.

Do not make an image VERSES 15–20

15 Be very careful.
For you did not see any kind of form on the day when
the LORD spoke to you at Horeb out of the middle of
the fire.
16 So do not ruin yourselves by making a carved image in
the shape of any figure,
an image of a man or a woman,
17 an image of any animal that lives on the earth,
an image of any bird with wings that flies in the sky,
18 an image of anything that creeps on the ground,
an image of any fish that lives in the water under the
earth.
19 And do not lift up your eyes to the sky
and look at the sun, the moon, and the stars, all the
army of the sky,
and let yourself be led away to worship them and serve
them.
The LORD your God has given them to all the peoples
under the whole sky.
20 But the LORD has taken you
and brought you out of the iron furnace, out of Egypt,
so that you would be his very own people, his
inheritance, as you are today.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Because God did not show any form, people should not show him in an image either. God is greater than anything people can imagine. An image would make him small. People would start to worship the image instead of God himself.

Other peoples worshiped the sun, the moon and the stars. The Bible says: These are not gods. God made them. They are

lamps in the sky, for all people (Genesis 1:14–18).

An "iron furnace": That is how bad the slavery in Egypt was. The Israelites suffered like metal in a glowing fire.

Moses will not come along VERSES 21–24

21 The LORD was angry with me because of you.
He swore that I would not cross the Jordan,
and that I would not go into the good land that the LORD your God is giving you as an inheritance.
22 I must die in this land. I may not cross the Jordan.
But you will cross over and take that good land as your own.
23 Be careful that you do not forget the covenant of the LORD your God, which he made with you.
Do not make yourselves a carved image in the shape of anything,
as the LORD your God has forbidden you.
24 For the LORD your God is a consuming fire, a jealous God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"A jealous God": That sounds strange. It means: God loves his people as much as a husband loves his wife. He does not want to share them with other gods. His love is full of passion.

"A consuming fire": God is holy and mighty. You cannot treat him lightly. The Letter to the Hebrews in the New Testament quotes this sentence (Hebrews 12:29).

A warning and a hope VERSES 25–31

25 You will have children and grandchildren and will have lived in the land for a long time.
If you then ruin yourselves and make a carved image in any shape,
and do what is evil in the eyes of the LORD your God, so that you make him angry,
26 then today I call heaven and earth as witnesses against you:
You will quickly and completely disappear from the land
that you are crossing the Jordan to take as your own.
You will not live long in it. You will be completely destroyed.
27 The LORD will scatter you among the peoples.
And only a few of you will be left among the nations where the LORD will lead you away.
28 There you will serve gods that are made by human hands, out of wood and stone.
They do not see, they do not hear, they do not eat, and they do not smell.
29 But from there you will look for the LORD your God.
And you will find him when you look for him with all your heart and with all your soul.
30 When you are in trouble and all these things have come over you,
then in the later days you will return to the LORD your God and listen to his voice.
31 For the LORD your God is a merciful God.
He will not let you down, and he will not destroy you.
And he will not forget the covenant with your ancestors, which he swore to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses sees ahead: Israel will later be unfaithful. Then it will lose the land and be scattered among the peoples. That really happened later, when the Assyrians and the Babylonians came (about 722 and 586 BC).

But that is not the end! Verse 29 is a promise for all times: Whoever looks for God with all their heart will find him. Even in a foreign land, even after great guilt.

God is merciful. He never forgets his covenant. There is always a way back.

There is no other God VERSES 32–40

32 Just ask about the times past, which were before you, since the day when God created man on the earth, and from one end of the sky to the other:
Has anything as great as this ever happened?
Has anyone ever heard of anything like it?
33 Did a people ever hear the voice of God speaking out of the middle of the fire, as you have heard it, and stay alive?
34 Or has God ever tried to go and take a nation for himself out of another nation,
by trials, by signs, by wonders, by war,
by a mighty hand, by an outstretched arm, and by great terrors,
just like everything that the LORD your God did for you in Egypt before your eyes?
35 It was shown to you so that you would know that the LORD is God.
There is no one else besides him.
36 From heaven he let you hear his voice, to teach you.
And on earth he let you see his great fire.
And you heard his words out of the middle of the fire.
37 Because he loved your ancestors, he chose their descendants after them.
And he brought you out of Egypt with his presence, with his great power,
38 to drive out nations before you that are greater and mightier than you,
to bring you in and to give you their land as an inheritance, as it is today.
39 So know it today, and take it to heart:
The LORD himself is God in heaven above and on the earth below.
There is no one else.
40 You shall keep his rules and his commandments, which I command you today,
so that it may go well with you and with your children after you,
and so that you may live long in the land that the LORD your God is giving you for all time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important passages in the whole Old Testament. Moses says very clearly: There is only one God. There is no other. Back then, almost all peoples believed in many gods.

Why did God choose Israel? Not because Israel was especially great or good. But out of love (verse 37).

"With his presence": The Hebrew says "with his face." God himself went along.

And once more: The commandments are there for good, "so that it may go well with you."

Three cities of refuge in the east VERSES 41–43

41 Then Moses set apart three cities beyond the Jordan, in the east, where the sun rises.
42 Someone who had killed his neighbor without meaning to,
and who had not hated him before, should be able to flee there.
If he fled to one of these cities, he could stay alive.
43 These were the cities: Bezer in the wilderness, on the plain, for the Reubenites,
Ramoth in Gilead for the Gadites,
and Golan in Bashan for the Manassites.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The cities of refuge were explained in Numbers 35. Here Moses chooses the three cities east of the Jordan. Later, Joshua chooses the three cities west of the Jordan (Joshua 20).

The introduction to the law VERSES 44–49

44 This is the law that Moses put before the people of Israel.
45 These are the testimonies, the rules, and the laws that Moses told the people of Israel after they came out of Egypt,
46 beyond the Jordan, in the valley opposite Beth Peor, in the land of Sihon, the king of the Amorites, who lived at Heshbon.
Moses and the people of Israel had struck him down after they came out of Egypt.
47 They took his land as their own, and the land of Og, the king of Bashan.
These were the two kings of the Amorites who lived beyond the Jordan, in the east, where the sun rises.
48 The land reached from Aroer, which is on the edge of the valley of the Arnon, to Mount Siyon (also called Hermon),
49 and all the Arabah beyond the Jordan to the east, as far as the sea of the Arabah, below the slopes of Pisgah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a new, large part of the book begins. Moses has reminded the people of their history. Now come the commandments themselves. First come the Ten Commandments (Chapter 5).

"Mount Siyon" is another name for Hermon. It must not be confused with Mount Zion in Jerusalem.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 5

The Ten Commandments

The covenant is for you today VERSES 1–5

1 Moses called all Israel together and said to them,
"Hear, Israel, the rules and the laws that I am speaking in your ears today.
Learn them, and be careful to do them."
2 The LORD our God made a covenant with us at Horeb.
3 The LORD did not make this covenant with our ancestors,
but with us, with all of us who are alive here today.
4 The LORD spoke with you face to face on the mountain, out of the middle of the fire.
5 (At that time I stood between the LORD and you, to tell you the LORD's word.
For you were afraid because of the fire, and you did not go up onto the mountain.)
He said,

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Actually, most of the people who were at Horeb had already died. Even so, Moses says: The covenant was made with us, with you who are alive today.

That means: God's covenant is not only something from the past. It is for every new generation. To this day, Jews say at the Passover festival: Everyone should see himself as if he himself had come out of Egypt.

"Face to face" means here: directly, personally. The people did not see any form of God (Deuteronomy 4:12), but they heard his voice directly.

I am the LORD your God VERSE 6

6 "I am the LORD your God.
I brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Ten Commandments were already in Exodus 20. Here Moses repeats them for the new generation. The words are almost the same, but there are a few small differences. We point them out in the explanations.

Again, the beginning is not a demand, but a reminder: God has set you free. The commandments are rules for free people.

No other gods, no image VERSES 7–10

7 You shall have no other gods before me.
8 You shall not make a carved image for yourself,
no image at all of anything
that is in heaven above, or on the earth below, or in the water under the earth.
9 You shall not bow down to them, and you shall not serve them.
For I, the LORD your God, am a jealous God.
For those who hate me, I bring the guilt of the fathers on the children, to the third and to the fourth generation.
10 But to those who love me and keep my commandments,
I show my loving kindness to thousands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God alone should be God. And you should not make an image of him, because he is greater than anything we can imagine (see Chapter 4).

The Hebrew says "to thousands." Many understand this as "to 1,000 generations."

The balance is important: The results of guilt reach at most four generations. But God's kindness reaches much further. His love is greater than his anger.

Later God says clearly: Children should not be punished for the guilt of their parents (Deuteronomy 24:16; Ezekiel 18:20). What is meant here is rather: Bad behavior often lives on in families when the children copy it.

Do not misuse God's name VERSE 11

11 You shall not misuse the name of the LORD your God.
For the LORD will not let anyone go unpunished who misuses his name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's name is holy. You should not use it to curse, for false oaths, or to cheat people. The worst thing is to misuse God's name for injustice and violence.

The Sabbath VERSES 12–15

12 Keep the Sabbath day and make it holy,
as the LORD your God has commanded you.
13 For six days you shall work and do all your work.
14 But the seventh day is a Sabbath to the LORD your God.
On it you shall not do any work:
not you, not your son, not your daughter,
not your male servant, not your female servant,
not your ox, not your donkey, none of your livestock,
and not the foreigner who lives within your gates,
so that your male servant and your female servant can rest as well as you.
15 Remember that you yourself were a servant in the land of Egypt.
And the LORD your God brought you out of there by a mighty hand and by an outstretched arm.
That is why the LORD your God has commanded you to keep the Sabbath day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here there is a beautiful difference from Exodus 20:

There it says "Remember the Sabbath day." Here it says "Keep the Sabbath day."

There the reason is: God made the world in six days and rested on the seventh. Here the reason is: You yourself were a slave in Egypt. That is why your male servants and female servants should also be allowed to rest, "as well as you."

So the Sabbath is also a social commandment. No one should have to work without a break. Even the weakest people, and even the animals, have a right to rest. Nothing like that existed anywhere else back then.

The servants mentioned here were often slaves. The WEB, our English source text, uses the word "servant."

Honor your parents VERSE 16

16 Honor your father and your mother,
as the LORD your God has commanded you,
so that your days may be long and so that it may go well with you in the land that the LORD your God is giving you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is meant above all for grown-up children and their old parents. Back then there were no pensions and no nursing homes. The children were supposed to take care of their parents and honor them.

Here there is something extra: "so that it may go well with you" (verse 16). It is missing in Exodus 20:12. A society where old people are respected is good for everyone.

Life, marriage, property, truth VERSES 17–20

17 You shall not murder.
18 You shall not commit adultery.
19 You shall not steal.
20 You shall not tell lies in court against your neighbor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These four short commandments protect how people live together:

The life of every person is holy. No one may murder another person.

Marriage should be protected. Faithfulness is important.

Verse 18: Adultery means: A married person sleeps with someone who is not their husband or wife.

You should not take away what belongs to another person.

In court and everywhere, you should tell the truth. A lie can bring disaster on an innocent person.

Do not covet VERSE 21

21 You shall not covet your neighbor's wife.
And you shall not long for your neighbor's house,
or his field, or his male servant, or his female servant,
or his ox, or his donkey,
or anything that belongs to your neighbor."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: To covet means: to badly want something that belongs to someone else.

The last commandment goes deeper than all the others. It is not about deeds, but about wishes in the heart. Envy and greed are often the beginning of stealing, adultery, and even murder.

A small difference from Exodus 20: There the house comes first, here the wife. And here the field is also named, because the people will soon own fields in the land.

Because of this verse, Catholics and Lutherans count two commandments here: the ninth (the wife) and the tenth (the property). Others count it as one commandment.

The people are afraid VERSES 22–27

22 The LORD spoke these words to your whole assembly
on the mountain,
out of the middle of the fire, out of the cloud, and out of the thick darkness, with a loud voice.
And he added nothing more.
He wrote them on two stone tablets and gave them to me.
23 When you heard the voice out of the middle of the darkness, while the mountain was burning with fire,
you came to me, all the leaders of your tribes and your elders.

24 You said,
"Look! The LORD our God has shown us his glory and his greatness.
And we have heard his voice out of the middle of the fire.
Today we have seen that God speaks with a person, and the person stays alive.
25 But now, why should we die?
For this great fire will burn us up.
If we hear the voice of the LORD our God any longer, we will die.
26 For who of all people has heard the voice of the living God speaking out of the middle of the fire, as we have, and stayed alive?
27 You go near and listen to everything that the LORD our God will say.
And you tell us everything that the LORD our God tells you.
We will listen to it and do it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"He added nothing more": God spoke the Ten Commandments directly to everyone. They are something very special. All the other commandments he gave through Moses.

God's nearness is overwhelming. The people are afraid and ask: Moses, be our go-between.

God answers VERSES 28–33

28 The LORD heard what you said to me.
And the LORD said to me,
"I have heard what this people has said to you.
Everything they have said is good.
29 Oh, if only they would always have such a heart
to fear me and keep all my commandments,
so that it would go well with them and with their children forever!
30 Go and tell them, 'Return to your tents.'
31 But you, stay here and stand by me.
I will tell you all the commandments, the rules, and the laws that you shall teach them,
so that they do them in the land that I am giving them to own."
32 So be careful to do what the LORD your God has commanded you.
Do not turn away from it, not to the right and not to the left.
33 Walk on the whole way that the LORD your God has commanded you,
so that you may live and that it may go well with you,
and so that you may live long in the land that you will own.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 29 shows God's heart. He sighs like a father: "Oh, if only they would always have such a heart to fear me and keep all my commandments!" God wants nothing more than for his people to be well.

The goal of all the commandments is in verse 33: "so that you may live and that it may go well with you." God's commandments are like a path. Whoever stays on it will reach the goal safely.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 6

Hear, Israel!

So that it may go well with you VERSES 1–3

1 These are the commandments, the rules, and the laws that the LORD your God commanded me to teach you, so that you do them in the land that you are crossing over to take as your own.
2 So you shall fear the LORD your God
and keep all his rules and his commandments, which I command you –
you, your son, and your grandson, all the days of your life –
so that you may live long.
3 So hear, Israel, and be careful to do it,
so that it may go well with you and so that you become very many,
as the LORD, the God of your ancestors, has promised you,
in a land flowing with milk and honey.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"A land flowing with milk and honey": That is a picture of a rich, fertile land. There is enough pasture for goats and cows, and many flowers for the bees.

The most important commandment VERSES 4–5

4 Hear, Israel: The LORD is our God. The LORD is one.
5 You shall love the LORD your God
with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your strength.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These may be the most important sentences in the whole Old Testament. In Hebrew they begin with the word "Shema." That means "Hear." That is why this prayer is called the "Shema Israel."

To this day, Jews pray it every morning and every evening. It is the first prayer that Jewish children learn. And it is often the last thing a person says before death.

"The LORD is one" means: There is only one God. And he is whole and undivided. The words can also be translated like this: "The LORD is our God, the LORD alone."

And then comes the commandment: Love God! Not only obey, but love, with everything you are: with the heart (thinking and feeling), with the soul (your whole life), and with all your strength.

When Jesus was asked which commandment is the most important, he quoted exactly these words. And he added the commandment from Leviticus 19:18: Love your neighbor as yourself (Mark 12:29–31).

The words in everyday life VERSES 6–9

6 These words, which I command you today, shall be on
your heart.
7 You shall teach them to your children again and again.
You shall talk about them when you sit in your house
and when you are on the road,
when you lie down and when you get up.
8 You shall tie them as a sign on your hand.
And they shall be as a reminder between your eyes.
9 You shall write them on the doorposts of your house
and on your gates.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's word should not only be found in church or in the synagogue, but everywhere in life: at home, on the road, in the evening and in the morning.

To this day, Jews also take these verses literally:

At morning prayer, Jewish men (and in some communities women too) tie small leather boxes to the arm and to the forehead. They are called "tefillin." Inside are small pieces of paper with these Bible verses.

On the doorposts of Jewish homes hangs a small case, the "mezuzah." It also contains the "Shema Israel." Many people touch it when they go through the door.

The deeper meaning: We act with our hands, we think with our heads, and we go in and out through the door. Everything should be shaped by God's word.

Do not forget God when things go well for you VERSES 10–15

10 The LORD your God will bring you into the land
that he swore to your ancestors, to Abraham, to Isaac,
and to Jacob, to give to you.
There are great and beautiful cities that you did not
build,
11 houses full of good things that you did not fill,
cisterns cut into the rock that you did not dig,
vineyards and olive trees that you did not plant.
And you will eat and be full.
12 Then be careful that you do not forget the LORD,
who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the
house of slavery.
13 You shall fear the LORD your God.
You shall serve him, and you shall swear by his name.
14 You shall not follow other gods,
the gods of the peoples who live around you.
15 For the LORD your God, who is among you, is a jealous
God.
Otherwise the anger of the LORD your God will burn
against you,
and he will destroy you from the face of the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A great danger is not need, but wealth. When things go well for us, we easily forget whom we owe everything to.

Israel will receive many things it did not work for. Everything is a gift. Whoever knows that stays thankful.

A "cistern" is a basin in the rock where people collect rainwater.

Jesus quotes verse 13 when the devil tempts him: You shall worship the Lord your God, and serve only him (Matthew 4:10).

Do not put God to the test VERSES 16–19

16 You shall not test the LORD your God,
as you tested him at Massah.
17 You shall carefully keep the commandments of the
LORD your God,
his testimonies and his rules, which he has
commanded you.
18 You shall do what is right and good in the LORD's eyes,
so that it may go well with you, and so that you may go
in and take as your own the good land
that the LORD swore to your ancestors,
19 and so that he drives out all your enemies before you, as
the LORD has said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At Massah the people had no water. They asked: Is the LORD among us or not? (Exodus 17:7). They wanted to force God to prove himself.

"To test God" means: not to trust him, but to demand proof. Jesus also quotes this verse when he is tempted, when the devil tells him to jump down from the temple (Matthew 4:7).

When your child asks you VERSES 20–25

20 Later, your son may ask you,
"What do the testimonies, the rules, and the laws
mean
that the LORD our God has commanded you?"
21 Then you shall tell your son,
"We were Pharaoh's slaves in Egypt.
And the LORD brought us out of Egypt with a mighty
hand.
22 Before our eyes the LORD did great and frightening
signs and wonders
against Egypt, against Pharaoh, and against all his
household.
23 And he brought us out from there, so that he could
bring us in here
and give us the land that he swore to our ancestors.
24 The LORD commanded us to do all these rules
and to fear the LORD our God,
for our good, for all time,
so that he would keep us alive, as we are today.
25 And it will be righteousness for us
if we are careful to do all these commandments before
the LORD our God,
as he has commanded us."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: Righteousness means: living in the right way before God.

Children ask questions. That is good! The answer should not be a list of rules, but a story: "We were Pharaoh's slaves in Egypt," and God set us free.

Whoever wants to understand God's commandments must first know what God has done. The commandments are the answer to God's love.

This passage has become part of the Jewish Passover celebration. At the Passover meal, the children ask, and the parents tell the story of how they were set free.

"For our good": God's commandments serve life.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 7

A holy people, chosen out of love

No covenants with the peoples of the land VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD your God will bring you into the land that
you are going into to take as your own.
He will drive out many nations before you:
the Hittite, the Girgashite, the Amorite, the
Canaanite,
the Perizzite, the Hivite, and the Jebusite –
seven nations that are greater and mightier than you.
2 When the LORD your God gives them over to you and
you strike them,
then you shall completely destroy them.
You shall make no covenant with them, and you shall
not show them mercy.
3 You shall not marry them.
You shall not give your daughter to his son,
and you shall not take his daughter for your son.
4 For that would turn your sons away from following
me, so that they serve other gods.
Then the LORD's anger would burn against you, and
he would quickly destroy you.
5 But this is how you shall deal with them:
You shall tear down their altars, smash their stone
pillars,
cut down their Asherah poles, and burn their carved
images with fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This passage is very harsh. Again it speaks of "completely destroying" (see Chapters 2 and 3). It means wiping out these peoples completely.

The reason is given in verse 4: Israel should not be led into worshiping idols. It is about faith, not about hatred of other people. Marriages with foreigners were not forbidden as such: Moses himself had a foreign wife, and Ruth from Moab became the great-grandmother of King David.

Something interesting: Right afterward, the text forbids marriages with these peoples. That assumes they will go on living in the land. Many interpreters see this as a hint that "completely destroying" was not meant literally as wiping them out completely, but above all as a radical separation from their idol worship. In the books of Joshua and Judges, these peoples also go on living in the land.

Even so, this text is hard to bear. It is clear: These words belong to a certain time. They must never be used to justify violence or hatred against people of other peoples or religions.

"Stone pillars" and "Asherah poles" were holy signs of the Canaanite religion. Asherah was a goddess.

Why God chose Israel VERSES 6–11

6 For you are a holy people to the LORD your God.
The LORD your God has chosen you to be his very own
people,
out of all the peoples who live on the face of the earth.
7 The LORD did not set his love on you and choose you
because you were more in number than all the other
peoples.
For you were the fewest of all peoples.
8 But it was because the LORD loves you,
and because he wants to keep the oath that he swore to
your ancestors.
That is why the LORD brought you out with a mighty
hand
and set you free from the house of slavery, from the
hand of Pharaoh, the king of Egypt.
9 So know this: The LORD your God himself is God, the
faithful God.
He keeps his covenant and his loving kindness for
1,000 generations
with those who love him and keep his
commandments.
10 But he pays back those who hate him to their face, to
destroy them.
He is not slow to act against the one who hates him.
He pays him back to his face.
11 So keep the commandments, the rules, and the laws
that I command you today, and do them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Holy" means: set apart for God, belonging to him.

Why did God choose Israel of all peoples? Not because it was great, strong or especially good. It was the smallest people. God chose it simply because he loves it. Love needs no reason.

Being chosen does not mean: We are better than others. It means: We have received a gift, and we have a task. Abraham was already told: Through you all peoples will be blessed (Genesis 12:3).

"To pay back to his face" means: directly, personally, not only to his descendants.

The blessing for faithfulness VERSES 12–16

12 If you listen to these laws and keep them and do them,
then the LORD your God will keep the covenant and
the loving kindness with you
that he swore to your ancestors.
13 He will love you, bless you, and make you many.
He will bless the children of your body and the crops of
your ground,
your grain, your new wine, and your oil,
the young of your cattle and the lambs of your flock,
in the land that he swore to your ancestors to give you.
14 You will be blessed more than all peoples.
Among you there will be no man and no woman who
cannot have children,
and not among your livestock either.
15 The LORD will take away all sickness from you.
He will not put on you any of the terrible diseases of
Egypt that you know.
But he will put them on all those who hate you.
16 You shall destroy all the peoples whom the LORD your
God gives over to you.

Your eye shall not pity them.
And you shall not serve their gods, because that would be a trap for you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God promises great blessing: children, good harvests, healthy animals, good health.

This must not be misunderstood: The Bible does not say that everyone who is sick or has no children is being punished by God. The book of Job and Jesus himself speak against that idea (John 9:2–3). Here it is about the blessing for the whole people.

Verse 16 is harsh again. The reason is at the end: The foreign gods would be a "trap."

Do not be afraid VERSES 17–26

17 Maybe you will say in your heart,
"These nations are more than I am. How can I drive them out?"
18 Then you shall not be afraid of them.
Remember well what the LORD your God did to Pharaoh and to all Egypt:
19 the great trials that your eyes saw,
the signs, the wonders, the mighty hand, and the outstretched arm,
with which the LORD your God brought you out.
The LORD your God will do the same to all the peoples you are afraid of.
20 And the LORD your God will send the hornet among them,
until even those who are left and are hiding from you have died.
21 You shall not be frightened of them.
For the LORD your God is among you, a great and awesome God.
22 The LORD your God will drive out those nations before you little by little.
You may not destroy them all at once,
or else the wild animals would become too many for you.
23 But the LORD your God will give them over to you.
He will throw them into great confusion, until they are destroyed.
24 He will give their kings into your hand,
and you shall wipe out their name from under the sky.
No one will be able to stand against you, until you have destroyed them.
25 You shall burn the carved images of their gods with fire.
You shall not covet the silver or the gold on them, and you shall not take it for yourself,
so that you are not caught in a trap by it.
For it is something the LORD your God hates.
26 You shall not bring something hateful like that into your house,
or else you yourself will become a thing devoted to destruction, like it.
You shall hate it completely, and you shall turn away from it completely.
For it is a thing devoted to destruction.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Hornet": Maybe real insects are meant. Maybe it is a picture of fear and terror that makes the enemies run away.

"Little by little": God knows what is good. If the land were suddenly empty, the wild animals would spread out. God has a plan, even when it goes more slowly than we would like.

The gold on the idols is tempting. But whoever takes it brings idol worship into his house. Something the LORD hates is something God rejects with all his heart.

"Devoted to destruction" means here: set apart completely for God, so that it must be destroyed and no one may keep it.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 8

Man does not live by bread alone

Remember the wilderness VERSES 1–6

1 Be careful to do all the commandments that I command you today,
so that you may live and become many,
and go in and take as your own the land that the LORD swore to your ancestors.
2 Remember the whole way that the LORD your God has led you these 40 years in the wilderness.
He wanted to make you humble and to test you.
He wanted to know what was in your heart:
whether you would keep his commandments or not.
3 He made you humble. He let you be hungry.
And he fed you with manna, which you did not know, and which your ancestors did not know either.
With this he wanted to teach you:
Man does not live by bread alone.
Man lives by every word that comes out of the LORD's mouth.
4 Your clothes did not wear out on you,
and your feet did not swell, these 40 years.
5 So understand in your heart:
As a man trains and corrects his son, so the LORD your God trains and corrects you.
6 Keep the commandments of the LORD your God.
Walk in his ways, and fear him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The time in the wilderness was hard. But it had a purpose. Israel was to learn to trust God.

"Man does not live by bread alone" is one of the best-known sentences in the Bible. It means: People need more than food. They need God and his word. Jesus quotes this sentence when the devil tempts him in the wilderness to make bread out of stones (Matthew 4:4).

The manna came new every day. People could not gather it for later. So the people learned: We depend on God every day. That is why Christians pray in the Lord's Prayer: Give us today our daily bread.

God trains his people like a good father. Sometimes it is hard, but it is done out of love.

A good land VERSES 7–10

7 For the LORD your God is bringing you into a good land,
a land with brooks of water, with springs, and with water under the ground
that flows out in the valleys and on the hills,
8 a land of wheat and barley, of grapevines, fig trees, and pomegranates,
a land of olive trees and honey,
9 a land where you will eat bread and never run short,
where you will not lack anything,
a land whose stones are iron,
and out of whose hills you can dig copper.
10 You will eat and be full.
Then you shall praise the LORD your God for the good land that he has given you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the bare wilderness comes a land full of good things. The seven foods in verse 8 (wheat, barley, grapes, figs, pomegranates, olives, honey from dates or bees) are still especially valued in Israel today.

Verse 10 is the basis for the Jewish prayer at the table after the meal. Jews thank God not only before eating, but above all after eating. Whoever is full should not forget to say thank you.

Do not forget God when you are rich VERSES 11–20

11 Be careful that you do not forget the LORD your God
by not keeping his commandments, his laws, and his rules,
which I command you today.
12 Otherwise this could happen: You have eaten and are full.
You have built fine houses and live in them.
13 Your herds and your flocks grow.
Your silver and your gold grow,
and everything you have grows.
14 Then your heart becomes proud,
and you forget the LORD your God,
who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery,
15 who led you through the great and terrible wilderness,
with poisonous snakes and scorpions,
through thirsty ground where there was no water,
who made water pour out for you from the hard rock,
16 who fed you in the wilderness with manna, which your ancestors did not know,
to make you humble and to test you,
so that he could do good to you in the end.
17 And then you might say in your heart,
"My power and the strength of my hand have gotten me this wealth."
18 But you shall remember the LORD your God.
For he is the one who gives you the power to gain wealth.
In this way he wants to confirm his covenant, which he swore to your ancestors, as it is today.
19 But if you forget the LORD your God,
and follow other gods, and serve them, and worship them,
then I warn you today: You will surely die out.
20 Like the nations that the LORD is destroying before you,
so you too will be destroyed,
because you would not listen to the voice of the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is a warning that is true for all times: Whoever is rich and full easily becomes proud. He thinks: I did all this myself.

Moses says: No! Even the strength to work is a gift from God. Health, talents, good circumstances – all of it comes from him.

This does not mean that work is unimportant. But whoever knows that everything is a gift stays thankful and humble. And he finds it easier to share with others.

The last verses are serious: Israel is not better than the other peoples. If it leaves God, the same thing will happen to it as to them.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 9

Not because you are righteous – the golden calf

God goes ahead of you VERSES 1–3

1 Hear, Israel!
Today you are crossing over the Jordan
to drive out nations that are greater and mightier than you,
great cities with walls up to the sky,
2 a great and tall people, the sons of the Anakim.
You know them, and you have heard people say,
"Who can stand against the sons of Anak?"
3 So know this today:
The LORD your God is the one who crosses over ahead of you like a consuming fire.
He will destroy them, and he will bring them down before you.
So you will drive them out and make them die out quickly, as the LORD has told you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

38 years ago the people were afraid of the Anakim, the "giants." That is why they did not want to go into the land (Chapter 1). Now Moses says: Do not be afraid. God himself goes ahead of you.

Not because of your righteousness VERSES 4–6

4 When the LORD your God has driven them out before you,
do not say in your heart,
"The LORD has brought me in to take this land as my own because I am righteous."
For it is because of the wickedness of these nations that the LORD is driving them out before you.
5 It is not because you are righteous, and not because your heart is honest,
that you are going in to take their land as your own.
It is because of the wickedness of these nations that the LORD your God is driving them out before you,
and so that he keeps the word that the LORD swore to your ancestors, to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob.
6 So know this:
It is not because you are righteous that the LORD your God is giving you this good land to own.
For you are a stiff-necked people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses warns against pride. Israel should not think: We are getting the land because we are so good. That is not true.

Moses gives two reasons: First, the wickedness of the peoples in the land. God had already told Abraham that he was waiting until their guilt was full (Genesis 15:16). Second, God's faithfulness to his promise.

"A stiff-necked people" means: a stubborn people. The picture comes from cattle that make their necks stiff and do not want to be led.

It is honest that a holy book speaks this way about its own people. The Bible does not celebrate Israel as heroes. Everything is grace.

Remember: At Horeb VERSES 7–11

7 Remember, and do not forget,
how you made the LORD your God angry in the wilderness.
From the day you left the land of Egypt
until you came to this place,
you have rebelled against the LORD.
8 At Horeb, too, you made the LORD angry.
And the LORD was so angry with you that he wanted to destroy you.
9 I had gone up onto the mountain to receive the stone tablets,
the tablets of the covenant that the LORD had made with you.
Then I stayed on the mountain for 40 days and 40 nights.
I did not eat bread, and I did not drink water.
10 The LORD gave me the two stone tablets, written with God's finger.
On them were all the words that the LORD had spoken with you on the mountain out of the middle of the fire,
on the day of the assembly.
11 At the end of the 40 days and 40 nights,
the LORD gave me the two stone tablets, the tablets of the covenant.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses reminds them of the worst hour at Mount Sinai. The story is in Exodus 32–34.

"Written with God's finger": God himself wrote the Ten Commandments.

The golden calf VERSES 12–17

12 The LORD said to me,
"Get up, and go down from here quickly.
For your people, whom you brought out of Egypt, have ruined themselves.
They have quickly turned away from the way that I commanded them.
They have made themselves an idol out of melted metal!"
13 And the LORD said to me,
"I have seen this people.
Look! They are a stiff-necked people.
14 Leave me alone, so that I can destroy them and wipe out their name from under the sky.
And I will make you into a nation that is mightier and greater than they are."
15 So I turned and came down from the mountain.
The mountain was burning with fire.
The two tablets of the covenant were in my two hands.
16 I looked, and I saw: You had sinned against the LORD your God.
You had made yourselves a calf out of melted metal.
You had quickly turned away from the way that the LORD had commanded you.
17 Then I took hold of the two tablets, threw them out of my two hands,
and broke them before your eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only 40 days after the covenant, the people are already worshiping a golden calf. Moses breaks the tablets. That is a sign: The covenant is broken.

God offers to make a new people out of Moses. But Moses does not accept the offer. He stands up for his people.

Moses prays for the people VERSES 18–21

18 I fell down before the LORD, as the first time, for 40 days and 40 nights.
I did not eat bread, and I did not drink water,
because of all the sin that you had committed by doing what is evil in the LORD's eyes, so that you made him angry.
19 For I was afraid of the anger and the burning rage with which the LORD was angry with you, to destroy you.
But the LORD listened to me that time too.
20 The LORD was also so angry with Aaron that he wanted to destroy him.
And at that time I prayed for Aaron too.
21 Then I took your sin, the calf that you had made, and burned it with fire.
I crushed it and ground it very small, until it was as fine as dust.
And I threw its dust into the brook that flows down from the mountain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses fasts again for 40 days for his people. He prays, and God listens to him.

Here we learn something that is not in Exodus 32: Aaron was in great danger too. Moses also prayed for his brother.

Moses is an example: He stands up for others, even when they are guilty. Praying for others like this is called "intercession."

Rebellion again and again VERSES 22–24

22 At Taberah, at Massah, and at Kibroth Hattaavah you
also made the LORD angry.
23 And when the LORD sent you out from Kadesh Barnea
and said,
"Go up and take as your own the land that I have given
you,"
you rebelled against the command of the LORD your
God.
You did not believe him, and you did not listen to his
voice.
24 You have rebelled against the LORD from the day that I
have known you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses lists more places where the people grumbled against God: Taberah, where fire burned (Numbers 11:1–3); Massah, where it was about water (Exodus 17); Kibroth Hattaavah, where it was about meat (Numbers 11).

That is a hard record. But Moses does not want to shame the people. He wants them to understand: We owe everything only to God's grace.

Moses' prayer VERSES 25–29

25 So I fell down before the LORD for the 40 days and 40
nights that I lay there,
because the LORD had said that he would destroy you.
26 I prayed to the LORD and said,
"Lord GOD, do not destroy your people and your
inheritance,
which you set free through your greatness,
which you brought out of Egypt with a mighty hand.
27 Remember your servants, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.
Do not look at the stubbornness of this people, or at
their wickedness, or at their sin.
28 Otherwise the land you brought us out of will say,
'The LORD was not able to bring them into the land
that he had promised them.
And he hated them. That is why he brought them out,
to kill them in the wilderness.'
29 But they are your people and your inheritance,
which you brought out by your great power and by
your outstretched arm."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses prays very wisely. He does not say: The people are not really that bad. He admits the guilt. But he reminds God of three things:

1. It is your people. You set it free.

2. Remember your promises to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.

3. What will the other peoples think? Your name would be mocked.

Moses does not point to the righteousness of the people, but only to God's faithfulness and grace. People can still pray like this today when they have become guilty.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 10

New tablets – and what God wants from you

The new stone tablets VERSES 1–5

1 At that time the LORD said to me,
"Cut two stone tablets like the first ones,
and come up to me on the mountain.
And make an ark out of wood.
2 I will write on the tablets the words that were on the
first tablets, which you broke.
And you shall put them in the ark."
3 So I made an ark out of acacia wood,
and I cut two stone tablets like the first ones.
And I went up onto the mountain with the two tablets
in my hand.
4 He wrote on the tablets, just as it was written the first
time, the Ten Commandments,
which the LORD had spoken to you on the mountain
out of the middle of the fire, on the day of the
assembly.
And the LORD gave them to me.
5 I turned and came down from the mountain.
I put the tablets in the ark that I had made.
And there they are, as the LORD commanded me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the golden calf, God gives a new beginning. The covenant is renewed. God writes the same words once more.

That is a great message: Even after grave guilt, a new beginning is possible. God does not give up.

The "ark" is a chest. Later it was called the "ark of the covenant," the holiest thing in Israel (Exodus 25:10–22).

An added note: Aaron's death and the Levites VERSES 6–9

6 (The people of Israel traveled from Beeroth Bene
Jaakan to Moserah.
There Aaron died, and there he was buried.
And his son Eleazar served as priest in his place.
7 From there they traveled to Gudgodah, and from
Gudgodah to Jotbathah, a land with brooks of water.
8 At that time the LORD set apart the tribe of Levi
to carry the ark of the LORD's covenant,
to stand before the LORD to serve him,
and to bless in his name, to this day.
9 That is why Levi has no share and no inheritance with
his brothers.

The LORD is his inheritance, as the LORD your God told him.)

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses in parentheses are a short explanation that was put into the speech.

Numbers 20 and 33 say that Aaron died on Mount Hor. Here the place is called Moserah. Many interpreters think: Moserah was the area where Mount Hor is. No one knows for sure.

Why is this here? Maybe because Moses has just told how God listened to his prayer for Aaron (Deuteronomy 9:20). Aaron was allowed to live on and be priest, and after him his son.

The Levites do not get their own land. But they have something better: "The LORD is his inheritance." Their wealth is being close to God.

God listens once more VERSES 10–11

10 I stayed on the mountain as the first time, 40 days and
40 nights.
And the LORD listened to me that time too.
The LORD did not want to destroy you.
11 The LORD said to me,
"Get up, set out, and go ahead of the people.
They shall go in and take as their own the land
that I swore to their ancestors to give them."

What God wants from you VERSES 12–16

12 And now, Israel, what does the LORD your God ask of
you?
Only this: that you fear the LORD your God,
that you walk in all his ways, that you love him,
and that you serve the LORD your God with all your
heart and with all your soul,
13 that you keep the LORD's commandments and rules,
which I command you today,
for your good.
14 Look! Heaven belongs to the LORD your God, and the
highest heaven,
and the earth with everything on it.
15 Even so, the LORD took delight only in your ancestors
and loved them.
And he chose their descendants after them, you, out of
all peoples, as it is today.
16 So circumcise the foreskin of your heart,
and do not be stiff-necked anymore.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12 is a wonderful summary. What does God want? Deep respect, obedience, love, and serving him with all your heart. And all of it "for your good."

Later the prophet Micah sums it up in a similar way: God has shown you, human being, what is good. And what does the LORD ask of you? To do what is just, to love mercy, and to walk humbly with your God (Micah 6:8).

The whole universe belongs to God. And even so, he loves a small people. The great God turns to the small.

"Circumcise the foreskin of your heart": Circumcision was the sign of the covenant on the body (Genesis 17). But Moses says: That is not enough. The heart must also open itself to God. Away with everything that makes the heart hard and closed! Paul takes up this picture (Romans 2:29).

"Stiff-necked" means: stubborn (see Chapter 9).

God loves foreigners – love them too VERSES 17–22

17 For the LORD your God is God of gods and Lord of
lords,
the great, mighty, and awesome God,
who does not favor anyone and does not take bribes.
18 He gets justice for the orphan and the widow.
And he loves the foreigner and gives him food and
clothing.
19 So you too shall love the foreigner.
For you yourselves were foreigners in the land of
Egypt.
20 You shall fear the LORD your God. You shall serve him.
You shall hold on to him, and you shall swear by his
name.
21 He is the one you praise, and he is your God,
who has done for you these great and awesome things
that your eyes have seen.
22 Your ancestors went down into Egypt with 70 people.
And now the LORD your God has made you as many as
the stars in the sky.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The greatest and mightiest God cares for the weakest: for orphans, widows and foreigners. Back then these people had no protection.

God cannot be bribed. With him it does not matter who is rich or powerful.

Verse 19 is one of the most important commandments in the Bible: "So you too shall love the foreigner." The reason: You yourselves were foreigners. You know what it feels like. This commandment is just as important today as it was back then.

"Lord of lords": In the book of Revelation, this title is used for Jesus (Revelation 19:16).

There were 70 people at the beginning (Genesis 46:27). Now there is a great people. God has kept his promise to Abraham.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 11

Blessing and curse

You have seen it yourselves VERSES 1–7

1 So you shall love the LORD your God
and keep his instructions, his rules, his laws, and his
commandments, always.
2 Know it today –
for I am not speaking with your children, who have
not known it and have not seen it –
know the discipline of the LORD your God:
his greatness, his mighty hand, his outstretched arm,

3 his signs and his works, which he did in the middle of Egypt
to Pharaoh, the king of Egypt, and to all his land,
4 and what he did to the army of Egypt, to their horses and to their chariots:
how he made the water of the Red Sea flow over them as they were chasing you,
and how the LORD has destroyed them to this day,
5 and what he did for you in the wilderness until you came to this place,
6 and what he did to Dathan and Abiram, the sons of Eliab, the son of Reuben:
how the earth opened its mouth and swallowed them up,
with their households, their tents, and every living thing that followed them,
in the middle of all Israel.
7 For your eyes have seen all the great work of the LORD that he did.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses is speaking to people who have experienced many things themselves. They were there in Egypt and in the wilderness as children and young people. They can tell their children about it as witnesses.

Dathan and Abiram were the leaders of the rebellion with Korah (Numbers 16).

"Red Sea": That is what the WEB, our English source text, says. The Hebrew says "Sea of Reeds."

A land that lives from the rain VERSES 8–12

8 So you shall keep the whole commandment that I command you today,
so that you are strong, and go in,
and take as your own the land that you are crossing over to take,
9 and so that you live long in the land
that the LORD swore to your ancestors to give to them and to their descendants,
a land flowing with milk and honey.
10 For the land that you are going into to take as your own is not like the land of Egypt, which you came out of.
There you sowed your seed and watered it with your foot, like a vegetable garden.
11 But the land that you are crossing over to take as your own
is a land of hills and valleys that drinks water from the rain of the sky,
12 a land that the LORD your God cares for.
The eyes of the LORD your God are always on it,
from the beginning of the year to the end of the year.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Egypt there is the great river Nile. There people could lead the water onto the fields with canals. "Watering with your foot" probably means: People opened small earth walls with their foot, or they turned a water wheel with their feet.

In the land of Canaan there is no river like that. The land depends completely on the rain. That is why people there must trust God every day.

But the land is not forgotten: God's eyes are on it all year long.

Rain as a blessing VERSES 13–17

13 If you really listen to my commandments, which I command you today,
to love the LORD your God and to serve him with all your heart and with all your soul,
14 then I will give rain to your land at the right time,
the early rain and the late rain,
so that you can gather in your grain, your new wine, and your oil.
15 I will make grass grow in your fields for your livestock.
And you will eat and be full.
16 Be careful that your heart is not fooled,
and that you do not turn away and serve other gods and worship them.
17 Otherwise the LORD's anger will burn against you.
He will shut up the sky, so that no rain falls,
and the land does not give its crops.
And you will quickly disappear from the good land that the LORD is giving you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "early rain" comes in the fall. It makes the hard ground soft, so that people can sow. The "late rain" comes in the spring. It makes the grain ripen.

The Canaanites believed that the god Baal brings the rain. Moses says: No, the LORD gives the rain. Whoever runs to Baal loses exactly what he hopes for.

Jews pray these verses 13–21 as the second part of the "Shema Israel," every morning and every evening.

Put the words into your heart VERSES 18–21

18 So you shall put these words of mine into your heart and into your soul.
You shall tie them as a sign on your hand.
And they shall be as a reminder between your eyes.
19 You shall teach them to your children.
You shall talk about them when you sit in your house and when you are on the road,
when you lie down and when you get up.
20 You shall write them on the doorposts of your house and on your gates,
21 so that you and your children may live long in the land that the LORD swore to your ancestors to give them,
as long as the sky is above the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

We already know these words from Deuteronomy 6:6–9. The repetition shows how important they are. They are also written in the tefillin and in the mezuzah (see Chapter 6).

Every place your foot steps on VERSES 22–25

22 For if you really keep all these commandments that I command you, and do them,
if you love the LORD your God, walk in all his ways, and hold on to him,
23 then the LORD will drive out all these nations before you.
And you will drive out nations that are greater and mightier than you.
24 Every place that the sole of your foot steps on shall be yours.
Your border shall reach from the wilderness and from

Lebanon, from the river, the river Euphrates, to the western sea.

25 No one will be able to stand against you.
The LORD your God will put fear and terror of you
on all the land that you step on, as he has told you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "western sea" is the Mediterranean Sea.

Israel ruled this large area as far as the Euphrates only for a short time, under King Solomon (1 Kings 4:21). The Bible describes a promise here, not a map for politics today.

The choice between blessing and curse VERSES 26–32

26 Look! Today I am putting before you a blessing and a curse:
27 the blessing, if you listen to the commandments of the LORD your God, which I command you today,
28 and the curse, if you do not listen to the commandments of the LORD your God,
but turn away from the way that I command you today,
to follow other gods that you have not known.
29 When the LORD your God brings you into the land that you are going into to take as your own,
then you shall put the blessing on Mount Gerizim and the curse on Mount Ebal.
30 Are they not beyond the Jordan, behind the road to the west, where the sun goes down,
in the land of the Canaanites who live in the Arabah, near Gilgal, beside the oaks of Moreh?
31 For you are crossing over the Jordan to go in
and take as your own the land that the LORD your God is giving you.
You will own it and live in it.
32 So be careful to do all the rules and the laws that I am putting before you today.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses puts a decision before the people. There are two ways: the way of blessing and the way of the curse. Everyone has to choose.

Gerizim and Ebal are two mountains in the middle of the land, near today's city of Nablus. Between them lies the old city of Shechem. Later a great ceremony is to take place there (Chapter 27; Joshua 8:30–35).

Abraham had already camped by the "oaks of Moreh" when he came into the land (Genesis 12:6). Israel returns to the place where everything began.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 12

The one place that God chooses

Destroy the places of the foreign gods VERSES 1–4

1 These are the rules and the laws that you shall be careful to do
in the land that the LORD, the God of your ancestors, has given you to own,
all the days that you live on the earth.
2 You shall completely destroy all the places
where the nations you are driving out served their gods:
on the high mountains, on the hills, and under every green tree.
3 You shall tear down their altars, smash their stone pillars,
and burn their Asherah poles with fire.
You shall cut down the carved images of their gods,
and you shall wipe out their name from that place.
4 You shall not do this to the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With Chapter 12, the large part with the individual commandments begins. It goes on until Chapter 26.

The Canaanites had holy places everywhere: on mountains and under large trees. Israel should destroy these places, so that it is not led away to the foreign gods.

"You shall not do this to the LORD your God" means: You should not worship the LORD the way the other peoples worship their gods, at any place you like.

This is about objects and places of worship, not about people. This text does not allow anyone today to damage the houses of worship of other religions.

The place that God will choose VERSES 5–12

5 But you shall look for the place that the LORD your God will choose out of all your tribes
to put his name there.
You shall look for the place where he lives, and you shall go there.
6 There you shall bring your burnt offerings and your sacrifices,
your tithes and the wave offering of your hand,
your vows and your freewill offerings,
and the firstborn of your herd and of your flock.
7 There you shall eat before the LORD your God.
And you shall be glad about everything you have worked for with your hands,
you and your households, because the LORD your God has blessed you in it.
8 You shall not do what we are doing here today,
where everyone does whatever seems right to him.
9 For you have not yet come to the rest
and to the inheritance that the LORD your God is giving you.
10 But you will cross the Jordan and live in the land that the LORD your God is giving you as an inheritance.
And he will give you rest from all your enemies around you, so that you live in safety.
11 Then you shall bring everything that I command you to the place that the LORD your God will choose to let his name live there:
your burnt offerings, your sacrifices, your tithes, the

wave offering of your hand,
and all your best vows that you promise to the LORD.
12 And you shall be glad before the LORD your God:
you, and your sons and your daughters, your male servants and your female servants,
and the Levite who lives within your gates,
because he has no share and no inheritance with you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: A tithe is a tenth of what you harvest or earn. A vow is a promise to God.

God will choose a place where he "lets his name live." The central holy place is to be there. The place is not named here yet. Later it was first Shiloh and then Jerusalem with the temple.

"To let his name live there": God himself is everywhere and cannot be shut up in a house. But at this place, people can reach him in a special way.

"The wave offering of your hand" is a gift that was waved back and forth before God.

Something stands out: Worship is a festival of joy! People eat together before God. And everyone is there: children, male and female servants, and the Levites who have no land of their own. No one should be left out.

Offer sacrifices only at this one place VERSES 13–19

13 Be careful that you do not offer your burnt offerings at any place you see.
14 But at the place that the LORD chooses in one of your tribes,
there you shall offer your burnt offerings,
and there you shall do everything that I command you.
15 But you may kill animals and eat meat in all your towns,
as much as you like,
according to the blessing that the LORD your God has given you.
The unclean and the clean may eat of it,
as people eat the gazelle and the deer.
16 Only you shall not eat the blood.
You shall pour it out on the ground like water.
17 But in your towns you may not eat
the tithe of your grain, of your new wine, or of your oil,
or the firstborn of your herd or of your flock,
or any of your vows that you promise,
or your freewill offerings, or the wave offering of your hand.
18 You shall eat them before the LORD your God,
at the place that the LORD your God will choose:
you, your son and your daughter, your male servant and your female servant,
and the Levite who lives within your gates.
And you shall be glad before the LORD your God about everything you have worked for with your hands.
19 Be careful that you do not abandon the Levite as long as you live in your land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before this, people were allowed to eat meat almost only as a sacrifice at the holy place (Leviticus 17). But when the people live spread out over the whole land, that is no longer possible. That is why it is now true: For an ordinary meal, people may also kill animals at home.

"As people eat the gazelle and the deer": People were allowed to eat these wild animals, but not to sacrifice them. In the same way, ordinary meat may now be eaten without being a sacrifice. That is why people who are "unclean" at the moment may also eat of it.

But sacrifices and holy gifts belong at the one place that God chooses.

The Levites had no land of their own. That is why the others should take care of them.

The blood is the life VERSES 20–28

20 The LORD your God will make your land larger, as he has promised you.
Then you will say, "I want to eat meat,"
because you would like to eat meat.
Then you may eat meat, as much as you like.
21 Maybe the place that the LORD your God will choose to put his name there is too far away from you.
Then you shall kill animals from your herd and from your flock, which the LORD has given you,
as I have commanded you.
And you may eat in your towns, as much as you like.
22 You shall eat it the way the gazelle and the deer are eaten.
The unclean and the clean may eat of it alike.
23 Only be very sure that you do not eat the blood.
For the blood is the life.
You shall not eat the life with the meat.
24 You shall not eat it.
You shall pour it out on the ground like water.
25 You shall not eat it,
so that it may go well with you and with your children after you,
when you do what is right in the LORD's eyes.
26 Only your holy things that you have, and your vows, you shall take and go with them to the place that the LORD will choose.
27 You shall offer your burnt offerings, the meat and the blood, on the altar of the LORD your God.
The blood of your sacrifices shall be poured out on the altar of the LORD your God,
and you may eat the meat.
28 Pay attention to all these words that I command you, and listen to them,
so that it may go well with you and with your children after you forever,
when you do what is good and right in the eyes of the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The blood is the life": Back then, people understood blood as the place where life is. Life belongs to God. That is why people may not eat the blood. They give it back to him by pouring it out on the ground.

The Jewish way of killing animals for food ("kosher") comes from this commandment: All the blood must run out of the animal. There is a similar rule in Islam too.

The commandment shows deep respect for life, also for the life of animals.

Do not do as the nations do VERSES 29–32

29 The LORD your God will cut off the nations before you
that you are going to drive out.
And you will drive them out and live in their land.
30 Then be careful that you are not caught in the trap of
copying them,
after they have been destroyed before you.
And do not ask about their gods and say,
"How did these nations serve their gods? I will do the
same."
31 You shall not do this to the LORD your God.
For they have done for their gods everything that the
LORD finds disgusting and hates.
They even burn their sons and their daughters in the
fire for their gods.
32 Everything that I command you, you shall be careful
to do.
You shall not add anything to it, and you shall not take
anything away from it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The most disgusting thing of all: Some peoples sacrificed their own children to their gods. God hates that with all his heart. Already with Abraham, God showed that he does not want human sacrifices (Genesis 22).

Being curious about foreign religions is not bad in itself. But Israel should not take over customs that are against God's will, especially customs that harm people.

In some Bibles, verse 32 is already the first verse of Chapter 13 (13:1). We follow the verse numbers of the WEB, our English source text.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 13

A warning against being led away to foreign gods

False prophets VERSES 1–5

1 A prophet or someone who has dreams may appear
among you.
He may announce a sign or a wonder to you.
2 And the sign or the wonder that he told you about may
really happen.
And he says, "Let's follow other gods" – gods you have
not known –
"and let's serve them."
3 Then you shall not listen to the words of that prophet
or of that dreamer.
For the LORD your God is testing you.
He wants to know whether you love the LORD your
God with all your heart and with all your soul.
4 You shall follow the LORD your God, and you shall fear
him.
You shall keep his commandments and listen to his
voice.
You shall serve him and hold on to him.
5 And that prophet or that dreamer shall be put to death.
For he has called for rebellion against the LORD your
God,
who brought you out of the land of Egypt and set you
free from the house of slavery.
He wanted to lead you away from the way that the
LORD your God commanded you to walk in.
In this way you shall remove the evil from among you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles, this chapter is numbered one verse later: Verse 1 here is verse 2 there, and so on up to verse 19. We follow the verse numbers of the WEB, our English source text.

An important lesson: Even if someone does wonders, that does not yet prove that he comes from God. What matters is where he leads. Whoever leads away from God is a false prophet, even if he does impressive things. Jesus gives a very similar warning (Matthew 24:24).

Back then, a false prophet was to be put to death. For us, that is very harsh. We need to understand: Israel back then was a people whose whole order was based on the covenant with God. Turning away from God was seen as betraying the whole people, a bit like high treason.

Today Jews and Christians live in countries with freedom of religion. The large Jewish and Christian communities reject all violence because of faith. No one may use this passage to persecute people of another faith. Sadly, this has happened in history, and it was a grave injustice.

Being led away in your own family VERSES 6–11

6 Maybe your brother, the son of your mother, or your
son, or your daughter,
or the wife you hold in your arms, or your friend who
is as dear to you as your own life,
tries to lead you away in secret and says,
"Let's go and serve other gods" –
gods that you have not known, not you and not your
ancestors,
7 gods of the peoples who live around you, near you or
far from you,
from one end of the earth to the other end of the
earth.
8 Then you shall not give in to him, and you shall not
listen to him.
Your eye shall not pity him.
You shall not spare him, and you shall not hide him.
9 But you shall surely kill him.
Your hand shall be the first against him to put him to
death,
and after that the hands of all the people.
10 You shall stone him with stones until he dies.
For he has tried to lead you away from the LORD your
God,
who brought you out of the land of Egypt, out of the
house of slavery.
11 All Israel shall hear it and be afraid.
And no one shall do such an evil thing among you
anymore.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the harshest texts in the Bible. Not even your own brother, your own child, your own wife, or your best friend is to be spared if he leads you to worship idols.

The text shows how seriously faithfulness to God was taken back then. Love for God was to come before all other bonds.

But it must be said clearly: By our understanding today, it is a grave injustice to kill a person because of their faith. The Jewish teachers of the Talmud already limited the death penalty with so many conditions that it could hardly be used anymore. For Christians, Jesus' example counts: He corrected his disciples when they wanted to call down fire on a village that would not welcome him (Luke 9:54–55).

No one may use this passage to justify violence against family members or other people.

A city that turns away VERSES 12–18

12 Maybe you will hear about one of your cities that the
LORD your God is giving you to live in.
13 You hear that some wicked fellows have gone out from
among you
and have led the people of their city away and said,
"Let's go and serve other gods," gods that you have not
known.
14 Then you shall look into it, examine it, and ask
carefully.
Look! If it is true, and the matter is certain,
that such a disgusting thing has been done among you,
15 then you shall surely strike the people of that city with
the edge of the sword.
You shall completely destroy it, with everything in it,
and also its livestock,
with the edge of the sword.
16 You shall gather all its plunder in the middle of its town
square.
And you shall burn the city with all its plunder with
fire, for the LORD your God.
It shall be a heap of ruins forever.
It shall not be built again.
17 Nothing that is devoted to destruction shall stick to
your hand,
so that the LORD turns away from his burning anger,
shows you mercy, has compassion on you,
and makes you many, as he swore to your ancestors.
18 This will happen when you listen to the voice of the
LORD your God
and keep all his commandments, which I command
you today,
and do what is right in the eyes of the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Wicked fellows": The Hebrew says "sons of Belial." That means something like "good-for-nothings" or "evil people."

An important point: Before anything happens, it must be examined carefully (verse 14). Rumors are not enough. This is a protection against false accusations.

The punishment is terrible: The whole city is to be destroyed. No one may get rich from it. It is not about plunder, but about wiping out idol worship completely.

The Jewish teachers later said: A city like that never existed and never will exist. The commandment is only there to show how serious the sin of idol worship is (Talmud, Sanhedrin 71a).

Here too: This passage must never be used to justify violence against people.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 14

Children of God – clean food – the tithe

You are children of God VERSES 1–2

1 You are the children of the LORD your God.
You shall not cut yourselves for someone who has
died,
and you shall not shave your head bald above your
forehead.
2 For you are a holy people to the LORD your God.
And the LORD has chosen you to be his very own
people,
out of all the peoples who live on the face of the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"You are the children of the LORD": What dignity! God is like a father to his people.

Among other peoples, people cut their skin or shaved off their hair when they were grieving. Israel should not do that. Even in grief you remain God's child. You may grieve, but not in a way that hurts your own body.

Which land animals you may eat VERSES 3–8

3 You shall not eat anything disgusting.
4 These are the animals that you may eat:
the ox, the sheep, the goat,
5 the deer, the gazelle, the roebuck, the wild goat,
the ibex, the antelope, and the chamois.
6 Among the animals, you may eat every animal that has
a split hoof,
split completely in two, and that chews the cud.
7 But among those that chew the cud or have a split hoof,
you shall not eat these:
the camel, the hare, and the rabbit.
For they chew the cud, but they do not have a split
hoof.
They are unclean for you.
8 The pig has a split hoof, but it does not chew the cud.
So it is unclean for you.
You shall not eat their meat, and you shall not touch
their dead bodies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: To chew the cud means: to bring food back up from the stomach and chew it again, like a cow.

We already know these food laws from Leviticus 11. Here they are repeated for the new generation.

"Rabbit": That is what the WEB, our English source text, says. The Hebrew says "shaphan." That is probably the rock hyrax, a small animal that lives among rocks. The hare and the rock hyrax chew all the time, and when they do, it looks as if they are chewing the cud.

Why exactly these rules? The Bible does not say. What is important: Israel should show even in eating that it belongs to God. To this day, many Jews keep these rules. This is called "kosher."

According to the New Testament, these food laws no longer apply to Christians (Mark 7:19; Acts 10).

Animals in the water VERSES 9–10

9 Of everything that lives in the water, you may eat these:
You may eat everything that has fins and scales.
10 But you shall not eat anything that does not have fins and scales.
It is unclean for you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Fish with fins and scales are allowed. Mussels, crabs, squid and, for example, eels are forbidden.

Birds VERSES 11–20

11 You may eat all clean birds.
12 But these are the ones that you shall not eat:
the eagle, the vulture, the osprey,
13 the red kite, the falcon, every kind of kite,
14 every kind of raven,
15 the ostrich, the owl, the seagull, every kind of hawk,
16 the little owl, the great owl, the horned owl,
17 the pelican, the vulture, the cormorant,
18 the stork, every kind of heron, the hoopoe, and the bat.
19 All flying creatures that creep are unclean for you.
They shall not be eaten.
20 You may eat all clean birds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Most of the forbidden birds are birds of prey or birds that eat dead animals. They eat meat with blood in it or animals that have died.

For many Hebrew bird names, we no longer know exactly which bird is meant. That is why Bibles often translate them differently here. We follow the WEB.

The bat is not a bird. But back then, people sorted animals by what they saw: It flies, so it belongs with the flying animals.

"Flying creatures that creep" are insects. According to Leviticus 11:21–22, people were allowed to eat some kinds of locusts.

No animal that died by itself VERSE 21

21 You shall not eat anything that has died by itself.
You may give it to the foreigner who lives within your gates, so that he can eat it,
or you may sell it to a foreigner.
For you are a holy people to the LORD your God.
You shall not boil a young goat in its mother's milk.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When an animal has died by itself, the blood has not run out of it properly. That is why Israelites may not eat it. This rule does not apply to foreigners. They may have it, and so nothing is wasted.

"You shall not boil a young goat in its mother's milk": This commandment is in the Bible three times (also Exodus 23:19 and 34:26). It shows respect for life: The milk that was meant to feed the young animal should not be used for its death. From this, Jews made the rule not to eat meat and milk products together.

The tithe: a feast before God VERSES 22–27

22 You shall surely give a tithe of everything your seed brings in,
of what grows in your field year by year.
23 And you shall eat before the LORD your God,
at the place that he chooses to let his name live there:
the tithe of your grain, of your new wine, and of your oil,
and the firstborn of your herd and of your flock,
so that you learn to fear the LORD your God always.
24 But the LORD your God will bless you.
And maybe the way is too long for you, so that you cannot carry it,
because the place that the LORD your God will choose to put his name there is too far from you.
25 Then you shall exchange it for money.
You shall tie up the money in your hand
and go to the place that the LORD your God will choose.
26 There you shall spend the money on whatever you want:
on cattle or on sheep, on wine or on strong drink,
or on anything you wish for.
And you shall eat there before the LORD your God and be glad, you and your household.
27 And you shall not abandon the Levite who lives within your gates,
for he has no share and no inheritance with you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "tithe" is a tenth of the harvest. Amazing: Here you should not simply hand it over. You should celebrate a big feast with it yourself, before God, with your whole family!

Whoever lives far away may sell the harvest. Then, at the holy place, he may buy with the money anything he wishes for, even wine and strong drink. God wants his people to be glad.

But you should not forget the Levites. They should celebrate too.

The tithe for the poor VERSES 28–29

28 At the end of every three years
you shall bring out the whole tithe of your harvest of that year
and store it within your gates.
29 Then they shall come: the Levite, because he has no share and no inheritance with you,
and the foreigner, the orphan, and the widow who live within your gates.
They shall eat and be full,
so that the LORD your God may bless you in all the work of your hands that you do.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Every third year, the tithe is meant for the poor. It is stored in your own town, and all the people in need may come and eat until they are full.

This is an early form of social help: a fixed supply for those who have no property of their own. The Levites, foreigners, orphans and widows should not have to beg. They have a right to this help.

And God promises: Whoever shares will be blessed.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 15

The year of release – help for the poor

Every seven years debts are canceled VERSES 1–6

1 At the end of every seven years, you shall cancel debts.
2 This is how it shall be done:
Everyone who has lent something shall cancel what he has lent to his neighbor.
He shall not demand payment from his neighbor and his brother,
because a release for the LORD has been announced.
3 From a foreigner you may demand payment.
But whatever your brother owes you, your hand shall let go of it.
4 But there will be no poor among you –
for the LORD will surely bless you in the land that the LORD your God is giving you as an inheritance to own –
5 if only you really listen to the voice of the LORD your God
and are careful to do this whole commandment that I command you today.
6 For the LORD your God will bless you, as he promised you.
You will lend to many nations, but you will not need to borrow.
You will rule over many nations, but they will not rule over you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is an amazing law: Every seven years, debts among Israelites are canceled. No one should stay trapped in debt forever. Everyone gets a new chance.

Back then, people borrowed money mostly when they were in need, for example after a bad harvest. Whoever was poor should not keep getting poorer.

Foreigners were mostly traders who did business. The law did not apply to them. It was about helping the poor in their own people.

Verse 4 is God's great goal: "There will be no poor among you." If everyone lives by God's commandments, there is enough for everyone. The first Christians in Jerusalem took up this verse (Acts 4:34).

Open your hand VERSES 7–11

7 There may be a poor man among you, one of your brothers,
in one of your towns in your land that the LORD your God is giving you.
Then you shall not make your heart hard,
and you shall not close your hand to your poor brother.
8 But you shall open your hand wide to him
and gladly lend him as much as he needs for what he lacks.
9 Be careful that this evil thought does not come up in your heart:
"The seventh year, the year of release, is near."
And be careful that you do not look at your poor brother with an evil eye and give him nothing.
Then he will cry out to the LORD against you, and it will be counted as sin for you.
10 You shall gladly give to him,
and your heart shall not be sorry when you give to him.
For because of this, the LORD your God will bless you in all your work
and in everything you do.
11 For there will always be poor people in the land.
That is why I command you:
You shall open your hand wide to your brother, to the needy, and to the poor in your land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God knows the human heart. Someone could think: Soon it is the year of release. If I lend something now, I will never get it back. Moses says: Do not think like that! Give anyway, and give gladly.

It is not only about giving, but about your attitude: You should not give grudgingly or stingily, but with an open heart. Paul later says: God loves someone who gives with joy (2 Corinthians 9:7).

Verse 4 and verse 11 seem to contradict each other: "There will be no poor among you" and "there will always be poor people in the land." But they belong together: God's goal is that there is no poverty. But because people do not always live by God's will, there will be poor people. That is why we should help. Jesus quotes verse 11 (Mark 14:7).

Hebrew servants VERSES 12–18

12 Your brother, a Hebrew man or a Hebrew woman, may be sold to you
and serve you for six years.
Then in the seventh year you shall let him go free.
13 And when you let him go free,
you shall not let him go away with empty hands.
14 You shall give him plenty from your flock, from your threshing floor, and from your winepress.
As the LORD your God has blessed you, so you shall give to him.
15 Remember that you yourself were a slave in the land of Egypt,

and that the LORD your God set you free.
That is why I am commanding you this today.
16 But he may say to you, "I do not want to leave you,"
because he loves you and your household, because
things go well for him with you.
17 Then you shall take an awl and push it through his ear
into the door.
Then he will be your servant forever.
You shall do the same with your female servant.
18 It should not seem hard to you to let him go free.
For he has served you for six years and was worth twice
as much as a hired worker.
And the LORD your God will bless you in everything
you do.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Someone who had become completely poor could "sell" himself as a servant to work off his debts. That was a kind of slavery for debt. But it was limited: After six years, you were free again.

New compared with Exodus 21: Here the rule clearly applies to women too. And the master should not send the servant away with empty hands. He should give him plenty to take along, so that he can start a new life.

The reason is again remembering: You yourselves were slaves. God set you free. So treat others the way God has treated you.

An "awl" is a pointed tool for making holes. The hole in the ear was a sign: This person has chosen freely to stay.

Even limited slavery does not match what we understand today by human dignity. But compared with other peoples back then, this law was a great protection for the poor.

The firstborn animals VERSES 19–23

19 You shall set apart for the LORD your God all the
firstborn males
that are born in your herd and in your flock.
You shall not work with the firstborn of your herd,
and you shall not shear the firstborn of your flock.
20 You shall eat it before the LORD your God every year,
at the place that the LORD will choose, you and your
household.
21 But if it has a defect, if it is lame or blind,
or has any other defect at all,
you shall not sacrifice it to the LORD your God.
22 You shall eat it in your towns.
The unclean and the clean may eat it alike,
as they eat the gazelle and the deer.
23 Only you shall not eat its blood.
You shall pour it out on the ground like water.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first young animal belongs to God. That is a sign of thanks: All life comes from him.

God gets only the best. You should not sacrifice an animal with a defect. But you may eat it at home in the ordinary way.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 16

The three great feasts – fair judges

The Passover VERSES 1–8

1 Pay attention to the month of Abib.
Keep the Passover for the LORD your God.
For in the month of Abib the LORD your God brought
you out of Egypt by night.
2 You shall kill the Passover sacrifice for the LORD your
God.
It shall come from the flock and from the herd.
You shall do it at the place that the LORD will choose,
to let his name live there.
3 You shall not eat bread made with yeast with it.
For seven days you shall eat bread without yeast with
it.
It is the bread of hardship,
because you left the land of Egypt in a great hurry.
Then you will remember all the days of your life
the day when you came out of the land of Egypt.
4 For seven days no yeast shall be seen with you anywhere
in your land.
And none of the meat that you sacrifice on the evening
of the first day
shall be left over through the night until the morning.
5 You may not kill the Passover sacrifice in just any of
your towns
that the LORD your God gives you.
6 You shall do it only at the place that the LORD your God
will choose,
to let his name live there.
There you shall kill the Passover sacrifice in the
evening, when the sun goes down,
at the same time of day that you came out of Egypt.
7 You shall roast it and eat it at the place that the LORD
your God chooses.
In the morning you shall go back to your tents.
8 For six days you shall eat bread without yeast.
On the seventh day there shall be a special gathering
for the LORD your God.
You shall do no work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Abib" means "young ears of grain." It is the spring month, March or April. Later it was called "Nisan."

The three great feasts of Israel are named here once more: Passover, the Feast of Weeks, and the Feast of Booths (see also Leviticus 23).

What is new: Passover should no longer be celebrated at home as in Egypt, but at the one place that God chooses. Later this was Jerusalem. That is why Jesus also went to Jerusalem for Passover.

"The bread of hardship": The bread without yeast reminds people of the suffering in Egypt and of the hurry when they left. There was no time to let the dough rise.

"Roast": The Hebrew has a word that usually means "cook." According to Exodus 12:9, the Passover lamb was to be roasted over the fire. The WEB, our English source text, translates "roast" here.

The Feast of Weeks VERSES 9–12

9 You shall count seven weeks for yourselves.
Begin to count the seven weeks
from the day you first put the sickle to the grain in the field.
10 Then you shall keep the Feast of Weeks for the LORD your God.
Bring a gift from your hand that you give freely.
Give as much as the LORD your God blesses you.
11 And you shall be glad before the LORD your God:
you, your son and your daughter,
your male servant and your female servant,
the Levite who lives in your town,
and the foreigner, the orphan, and the widow who live among you.
Do this at the place that the LORD your God will choose,
to let his name live there.
12 Remember that you were a slave in Egypt.
Be careful to keep these rules and do them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: A sickle is a curved knife for cutting grain.

The Feast of Weeks is the harvest feast for the wheat, seven weeks after the barley harvest begins. In Hebrew it is called "Shavuot." In Christianity it became Pentecost.

The joy should be shared with everyone. Again and again the laws about the feasts name the same groups: children, male and female servants, Levites, foreigners, orphans, and widows. At God's feast no one should be left alone.

"Remember that you were a slave in Egypt": Whoever knows what it is like to be poor and oppressed should be generous.

The Feast of Booths VERSES 13–17

13 You shall keep the Feast of Booths for seven days,
after you have brought in the harvest from your threshing floor and from your winepress.
14 And you shall be glad at your feast:
you, your son and your daughter,
your male servant and your female servant,
the Levite, the foreigner, the orphan, and the widow who live in your towns.
15 For seven days you shall keep a feast for the LORD your God
at the place that the LORD chooses.
For the LORD your God will bless you in all your harvest
and in all the work of your hands.
And you shall be completely joyful.
16 Three times a year all your men shall come before the LORD your God
at the place that he chooses:
at the Feast of Unleavened Bread, at the Feast of Weeks, and at the Feast of Booths.
They shall not come before the LORD with empty hands.
17 Every man shall give as much as he can,
according to the blessing that the LORD your God has given you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Feast of Booths is in the fall, after the harvest of grapes and olives. People live for seven days in huts made of branches. This reminds them of the time in the wilderness.

"You shall be completely joyful": That is a commandment! God orders his people to be glad.

Everyone gives what he can. No one has to give more than he has. Whoever has received much gives much. Whoever has little gives little.

Fair judges VERSES 18–20

18 You shall appoint judges and officials for each of your tribes
in all your towns that the LORD your God gives you.
They shall judge the people fairly.
19 You shall not twist justice.
You shall not favor anyone.
You shall not take a bribe.
For a bribe makes the eyes of wise people blind,
and it twists the words of people who do right.
20 You shall follow what is completely fair, only what is fair.
Then you will live and take over the land that the LORD your God gives you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"What is completely fair, only what is fair": The Hebrew has the word "justice" twice in a row: "Tsedek, tsedek." This shows how important it is. The WEB, our English source text, says: "that which is altogether just."

A bribe makes people blind. Even wise and good people are influenced by gifts, often without noticing it.

These verses are part of the foundation for independent courts.

No sacred poles and stones VERSES 21–22

21 You shall not plant any kind of tree as an Asherah pole
beside the altar of the LORD your God that you will make for yourself.
22 And you shall not set up a sacred stone pillar for yourself.
The LORD your God hates such things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Canaanites put wooden poles for the goddess Asherah and stone pillars for their gods next to their altars. Israel should not mix the worship of the LORD with these signs.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 17

Court cases – the law for the king

Only sacrifices without defects VERSE 1

1 You shall not sacrifice an ox or a sheep to the LORD your God
if it has a defect or anything bad about it.
For the LORD your God hates that.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

You should not give God the worst, the things you no longer want yourself. He deserves the best.

Two or three witnesses VERSES 2–7

2 A man or a woman may be found among you,
in one of your towns that the LORD your God gives you,
who does what is evil in the eyes of the LORD your God and breaks his covenant.
3 This person has gone and served other gods and worshiped them,
or the sun, or the moon, or any of the stars of the sky.
I have not commanded that.
4 If you are told about it and you hear of it,
then you shall look into it carefully.
If it is true and the matter is certain
that such a terrible thing has been done in Israel,
5 then you shall bring out that man or that woman who has done this evil thing
to the gates of your town, that very man or woman.
And you shall stone them with stones until they die.
6 A person who is to die shall be put to death
only on the word of two witnesses or three witnesses.
He shall not be put to death on the word of only one witness.
7 The hands of the witnesses shall be the first against him to put him to death.
After that, the hands of all the people shall be against him.
So you shall remove the evil from among you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: A covenant is a binding agreement.

Again it is about turning away from God, and again the death penalty applied back then (see Chapter 13). That is very hard for us. Here too: No one may use this passage to persecute people because of their faith.

But the rules of protection are important: The matter must be looked into carefully. One witness alone is not enough. There must be at least two. And the witnesses themselves must act first. So whoever gives false testimony carries a heavy responsibility. This was meant to prevent false accusations.

Jesus took up the rule about two or three witnesses (Matthew 18:16). It is still an important principle of law today.

Difficult court cases VERSES 8–13

8 A case may come up in your towns that is too hard for you to judge.
It may be about blood and blood,
about one claim against another claim,
or about one injury against another injury.
These are matters of quarrel in your towns.
Then you shall get up and go up to the place that the LORD your God chooses.
9 You shall go to the priests, who are Levites,
and to the judge who is there in those days.
You shall ask them, and they will tell you the verdict.
10 You shall act according to the verdict that they tell you from that place that the LORD chooses.
Be careful to do everything they teach you.
11 You shall act according to the law that they teach you
and according to the decision that they tell you.
You shall not turn away from the verdict that they announce to you,
not to the right and not to the left.
12 But a man may act proudly and not listen to the priest who stands there to serve the LORD your God,
or to the judge.
That man shall die.
So you shall remove the evil from Israel.
13 Then all the people will hear it and be afraid,
and they will no longer act proudly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"About blood and blood" means: Was it murder, or a killing by accident? "About one injury against another injury" means: Who hurt whom, and how badly?

For difficult cases there is a highest court at the central holy place. That is something like an early court of appeals.

Whoever deliberately resists the verdict of this highest court is punished harshly. Without respect for the court, a community cannot live in peace.

The law for the king VERSES 14–20

14 You will come into the land that the LORD your God gives you.
You will take it over and live in it.
Then you may say,
"I want to set a king over me, like all the nations around me."
15 Then you shall set over you as king only the one whom the LORD your God chooses.
You shall set one of your brothers as king over you.
You may not put a foreigner over you who is not your brother.
16 But he shall not get many horses for himself.
And he shall not make the people go back to Egypt to get many horses.
For the LORD has said to you,
"You shall never go back that way again."
17 He shall not take many wives for himself,
so that his heart does not turn away.
And he shall not gather very much silver and gold for himself.
18 When he sits on the throne of his kingdom,
he shall write for himself a copy of this law in a book.
He shall copy it from the book that the priests, the Levites, keep.
19 The copy shall be with him,
and he shall read from it all the days of his life.
Then he will learn to fear the LORD his God,
and to keep all the words of this law and these rules and do them.

20 Then his heart will not be lifted up above his brothers,
and he will not turn away from the commandment,
not to the right and not to the left.
Then he will rule for a long time in his kingdom, he
and his children,
in the middle of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel does not have a king yet. But Moses sees ahead that the people will one day want a king. That happened later, at the time of the prophet Samuel (1 Samuel 8).

The king in Israel should be completely different from the kings of other nations:

No great number of horses: Horses were for chariots, so for war and power.

No great number of wives: Back then, kings often had many wives from foreign countries in order to make alliances. These wives brought their gods along.

No great wealth: A king should not make himself rich.

Instead he should read in God's law every day. He does not stand above the law, but under it. And he should not lift himself up above his "brothers." He stays a brother among brothers.

That is a very modern idea: Even the most powerful person must obey the law.

Later, King Solomon did exactly these three things: many horses from Egypt, 700 wives, and countless amounts of gold (1 Kings 10–11). And his heart really did turn away from God.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 18

Priests and Levites – no fortune-telling – a prophet like Moses

What belongs to the priests and Levites VERSES 1–8

1 The priests and the Levites, the whole tribe of Levi,
shall have no share of land and no inheritance with
Israel.
They shall eat from the offerings made by fire to the
LORD,
and from the share that belongs to him.
2 They shall have no inheritance among their brothers.
The LORD is their inheritance, as he has told them.
3 This is what the priests have a right to receive from the
people,
from those who offer a sacrifice, whether it is an ox or
a sheep.
They shall give the priest the shoulder, the two cheeks,
and the inner parts.
4 You shall give him the first part of your grain, of your
new wine, and of your oil,
and the first wool that you shear from your sheep.
5 For the LORD your God has chosen him out of all your
tribes
to stand and serve in the name of the LORD,
him and his sons forever.
6 A Levite may come from one of your towns anywhere
in Israel where he lives.
He may come with all the longing of his heart
to the place that the LORD will choose.
7 Then he shall serve in the name of the LORD his God,
like all his brothers, the Levites, who stand there
before the LORD.
8 They shall get equal shares to eat,
besides what he gets from selling his family's property.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The priests and Levites have no land of their own. They live from the gifts of the people. In this way they are cared for, so that they can serve God.

A Levite from the countryside who would like to serve at the holy place may do so. He should be treated just like the others. No one should see him as "second-class."

"The inner parts": The Hebrew probably means the stomach.

No fortune-telling and no magic VERSES 9–14

9 You will come into the land that the LORD your God
gives you.
Then you shall not learn to copy the terrible practices
of those nations.
10 No one shall be found among you
who makes his son or his daughter pass through the
fire.
No one shall be found among you who tries to see the
future by signs,
who tells fortunes,
who reads omens, or who does magic,
11 who casts spells,
who asks a spirit of the dead for advice,
who is a wizard,
or who tries to speak with the dead.
12 For the LORD hates everyone who does these things.
Because of these terrible practices,
the LORD your God is driving those nations out ahead
of you.
13 You shall be without blame before the LORD your God.
14 For these nations that you will drive out listen to
people who do magic
and to people who tell the future.
But as for you, the LORD your God has not allowed
you to do that.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, many nations tried to learn the future or to gain power: by reading signs, by magic, by asking the dead. Some even sacrificed their children ("make … pass through the fire").

God says: None of this is for you. You do not need magic. You have me. I speak to you through my word and through my prophets.

"Without blame" means: Trust God alone, with your whole heart. Do not hold on to other powers on the side.

Important note: These verses were terribly misused in history. In the witch hunts in Europe, tens of thousands of

innocent people, most of them women, were tortured and killed. That was a grave injustice. Here the Bible forbids Israelites to practice magic. It gives no one the right to accuse other people of being "witches" and to persecute them.

A prophet like Moses VERSES 15–19

15 The LORD your God will raise up for you a prophet like me
from among you, from your brothers.
You shall listen to him.
16 This is just what you asked of the LORD your God at Horeb,
on the day when the people were gathered.
You said,
"Do not let me hear the voice of the LORD my God again.
And do not let me see this great fire anymore,
so that I do not die."
17 The LORD said to me,
"What they have said is good.
18 I will raise up for them a prophet like you
from among their brothers.
I will put my words in his mouth.
And he will tell them everything that I command him.
19 Whoever does not listen to my words that he speaks in my name,
I will hold that person responsible.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Instead of magic and fortune-telling, God promises something better: prophets. Through them God will speak to his people, just as he spoke through Moses.

Jewish people often understand it like this: God will send prophets again and again, like Samuel, Elijah, Isaiah, and Jeremiah.

Christians see this promise above all as pointing to Jesus. In the New Testament this verse is applied to him (Acts 3:22; John 6:14). But at the end of the book of Deuteronomy it also says: "Since then, no prophet like Moses has risen in Israel" (Deuteronomy 34:10). That is why people waited for this one prophet.

How to recognize a false prophet VERSES 20–22

20 But a prophet may proudly speak a word in my name
that I have not commanded him to speak,
or he may speak in the name of other gods.
That prophet shall die."
21 You may say in your heart,
"How shall we know which word the LORD has not spoken?"
22 A prophet may speak in the name of the LORD,
but the thing does not come about and does not happen.
Then it is a word that the LORD has not spoken.
The prophet has spoken it out of pride.
You shall not be afraid of him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An important sign: If a prophet announces something that does not happen, then he does not come from God.

Together with Chapter 13 there are two tests: Does the prophet lead to God or away from him? And: Does what he says come true?

"You shall not be afraid of him": Today too there are people who make others afraid in the name of God, for example with predictions about the end of the world. If their words do not come true, you do not need to fear them.

Back then, the death penalty applied to a false prophet. Today Judaism and Christianity teach: You should not believe false prophets and not follow them. Violence against them is not the way.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 19

Cities of refuge – boundary stones – false witnesses

Three cities of refuge in the land VERSES 1–10

1 The LORD your God will destroy the nations
whose land the LORD your God is giving you.
You will take their place
and live in their cities and in their houses.
2 Then you shall set apart three cities for yourselves
in the middle of your land that the LORD your God is giving you to own.
3 You shall prepare the roads to them.
And you shall divide the land that the LORD your God gives you as your inheritance
into three parts.
Then anyone who has killed a person can flee there.
4 This is the rule for someone who has killed a person and flees there to stay alive:
He killed his neighbor without meaning to,
and he did not hate him before.
5 For example, a man goes into the forest with his neighbor to chop wood.
His hand swings the ax to cut down the tree.
The head of the ax slips off the handle and hits his neighbor, so that he dies.
That man shall flee to one of these cities and stay alive.
6 Otherwise the avenger of blood might chase the man who killed,
while his heart is burning with anger.
He might catch him because the road is long,
and he might kill him,
even though the man did not deserve to die,
because he did not hate his neighbor before.
7 That is why I command you:
Set apart three cities for yourselves.
8 The LORD your God may make your land larger,
as he swore to your ancestors.
He may give you all the land that he promised to give to your ancestors.
9 That will happen if you keep this whole commandment and do it,
which I command you today:

to love the LORD your God and to walk in his ways always.
Then you shall add three more cities for yourselves, besides these three.
10 This is so that innocent blood will not be shed in your land that the LORD your God gives you as an inheritance.
Otherwise you would be guilty of that blood.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: The avenger of blood is the relative who has the duty to punish the killer.

We know the cities of refuge from Numbers 35. Here a clear example of an accident is given: While someone is chopping wood, the head of the ax flies off the handle and kills someone.

The roads to the cities should be good. No one should be caught on the way only because the road is too long or too bad. Jewish teachers say: People even put up signs that said "Refuge."

God also protects the person who has become guilty without being at fault.

No protection for murderers VERSES 11–13

11 But someone may hate his neighbor.
He lies in wait for him, attacks him, and strikes him so that he dies.
Then he flees into one of these cities.
12 Then the elders of his town shall send for him and have him brought back from there.
They shall hand him over to the avenger of blood, so that he dies.
13 You shall not feel sorry for him.
You shall remove the guilt of innocent blood from Israel.
Then things will go well for you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The cities of refuge are not a hiding place for murderers. Whoever killed on purpose is handed over. Back then the death penalty applied to this (see Numbers 35).

Do not move boundary stones VERSE 14

14 You shall not move your neighbor's boundary stone that the people of long ago set up.
This applies to the land that you will receive as your inheritance,
in the land that the LORD your God gives you to own.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, fields were marked with boundary stones. Whoever secretly moved a stone stole land from his neighbor. That was easy to do and hard to prove. That is why it is clearly forbidden here.

Two witnesses – and the punishment for false witnesses VERSES 15–21

15 One witness alone shall not stand up against a man for any wrong or for any sin that he has done.
A matter shall be settled only on the word of two witnesses,
or on the word of three witnesses.
16 A dishonest witness may stand up against someone to accuse him of doing wrong.
17 Then both men who have the quarrel shall stand before the LORD,
before the priests and the judges who are there in those days.
18 The judges shall look into it carefully.
The witness may turn out to be a false witness who has told lies against his brother.
19 Then you shall do to him what he planned to do to his brother.
So you shall remove the evil from among you.
20 The rest of the people will hear about it and be afraid.
They will never again do such an evil thing among you.
21 You shall not feel sorry:
life for life, eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A false witness gets exactly the punishment he wanted to bring on the innocent person. Whoever lies to put someone else in prison goes to prison himself. This keeps people from giving false testimony.

"Eye for eye, tooth for tooth": This sentence is often misunderstood, as if it called for revenge. The opposite is meant! It limits the punishment: The punishment must not be greater than the wrong. Not a life for an eye, but only an eye for an eye. Jewish teaching understood this very early as payment in money.

Jesus goes even further: He says that you should not take revenge at all, but even turn the other cheek (Matthew 5:38–39).

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 20

Rules for war

Do not be afraid VERSES 1–4

1 You may go out to battle against your enemies.
You may see horses and chariots,
and an army that is bigger than yours.
Then you shall not be afraid of them.
For the LORD your God is with you.
He is the one who brought you up out of the land of Egypt.
2 When you come near to the battle,
the priest shall come forward and speak to the people.
3 He shall say to them,
"Listen, Israel!
Today you are going into battle against your enemies.
Do not lose heart!
Do not be afraid, do not tremble,
and do not be terrified of them.

4 For the LORD your God is the one who goes with you.
He fights for you against your enemies, to save you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is about war. Back then, wars between nations were common. The Bible gives rules that are meant to limit war. Some of these rules are surprisingly humane for their time. Others are very hard for us to bear today.

Israel did not have large armies with horses and chariots. That is why it should not trust in its weapons, but in God.

Who may go home VERSES 5–9

5 The officials shall say to the people,
"Has any man built a new house and not yet dedicated it?
He may go back to his house.
Otherwise he might die in the battle,
and another man would dedicate it.
6 Has any man planted a vineyard and not yet enjoyed its fruit?
He may go back to his house.
Otherwise he might die in the battle,
and another man would enjoy its fruit.
7 Has any man promised to marry a woman and not yet married her?
He may go back to his house.
Otherwise he might die in the battle,
and another man would marry her."
8 The officials shall speak further to the people.
They shall say,
"Is any man afraid and has he lost heart?
He may go back to his house.
Otherwise his brothers might lose heart just like him."
9 When the officials have finished speaking to the people,
they shall appoint army commanders to lead the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is surprising: Before the battle begins, many men may go home: whoever has a new house, whoever has just planted a vineyard, whoever is about to get married. The life and the happiness of each person are more important than a large army.

Even whoever is afraid may go. No one is forced. For victory does not depend on the number of soldiers, but on God. Later the story of Gideon shows this. Out of 32,000 men he was allowed to keep only 300 (Judges 7).

First offer peace VERSES 10–15

10 When you come near a city to fight against it,
first offer it peace.
11 If it answers you with peace and opens its gates to you,
then all the people who are found in it shall do forced labor for you.
They shall serve you.
12 But if it does not make peace with you,
and makes war against you instead,
then you shall surround it and lay siege to it.
13 The LORD your God will hand it over to you.
Then you shall kill every male in it with the sword.
14 But you may take for yourself the women, the little children, the livestock,
and everything in the city, all the goods you capture.
You may use the goods of your enemies
that the LORD your God has given you.
15 That is what you shall do to all the cities that are very far away from you,
the cities that do not belong to these nations here.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first rule is good: First you must offer peace. War should not be the first way.

But what comes after that is cruel by today's standards: Whoever surrenders must do forced labor. Whoever fights has his men killed, and women and children are taken as plunder.

We have to say it honestly: That is how almost all nations fought wars back then, and often much more cruelly. The Bible describes this world, but it does not make it a model for all times. Today, thankfully, there are international rules that protect civilians and prisoners. Many of these rules were also fought for by Jews and Christians, who learned from the Bible the dignity of every human being.

The nations in the land VERSES 16–18

16 But in the cities of these nations
that the LORD your God gives you as an inheritance,
you shall not leave alive anything that breathes.
17 You shall completely destroy them:
the Hittite, the Amorite, the Canaanite, the Perizzite,
the Hivite, and the Jebusite,
as the LORD your God has commanded you.
18 Otherwise they would teach you to copy all the terrible things
that they have done for their gods.
Then you would sin against the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is again about "completely destroying" (see Chapter 7). Israel is to act even more harshly against the nations in the land of Canaan itself. The reason is in verse 18: Israel should not be led astray into worshiping idols and into their terrible practices, which also included sacrificing children.

This text is among the hardest in the whole Bible. Jews and Christians have struggled with it for a long time. Many understand it as a one-time command for a very specific time, which no longer applies today and must never apply again. The Jewish scholars said: These nations no longer exist, so the commandment can no longer be applied.

It is very clear: No one may use this passage to justify violence against a people or a group.

Spare the fruit trees VERSES 19–20

19 You may lay siege to a city for a long time,
fighting against it to capture it.
Then you shall not destroy its trees by swinging an ax against them.
For you can eat from them.
You shall not cut them down.
Is the tree of the field a human being, that you should lay siege to it?
20 You may destroy and cut down only the trees
that you know are not trees for food.
You may build siege works against the city that is making war with you,
until it falls.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A very early rule to protect nature: Even in war you may not destroy the fruit trees. The trees are not to blame for the war. And the people need them later in order to live.

From this, Jewish scholars made a general commandment: "Bal tashchit," which means "Do not destroy." You should not waste or ruin anything on purpose.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 21

An unsolved murder – rules for the family

When a dead body is found VERSES 1–9

1 In the land that the LORD your God gives you to own,
someone may be found killed, lying in the field,
and no one knows who struck him down.
2 Then your elders and your judges shall go out.
They shall measure the distance to the towns around
the dead man.
3 The elders of the town that is nearest to the dead man
shall take a young cow from the herd.
It must be a cow that has never been worked
and has never pulled with a yoke.
4 The elders of that town shall lead the young cow down
to a valley with flowing water,
a valley that is not plowed and not sown.
There in the valley they shall break the young cow's
neck.
5 Then the priests, the sons of Levi, shall come forward.
For the LORD your God has chosen them
to serve him and to bless in the name of the LORD.
Every quarrel and every case of violence shall be
decided by what they say.
6 All the elders of the town that is nearest to the dead
man
shall wash their hands over the young cow
whose neck was broken in the valley.
7 They shall say,
"Our hands have not shed this blood,
and our eyes have not seen it.
8 LORD, forgive your people Israel, whom you have set
free.
Do not let the guilt of innocent blood stay among your
people Israel."
Then the guilt for the blood will be forgiven them.
9 So you shall remove the guilt of innocent blood from
among you,
when you do what is right in the eyes of the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: A yoke is a wooden bar that is put on animals so that they can pull a load.

A person was murdered, but no one knows who did it. What now? Such a death must not simply be forgotten. Every human life counts.

The nearest town takes responsibility. Its elders solemnly declare: We did not do it, and we did not see anything. And they ask God to forgive the whole people.

Washing the hands is a sign of innocence. From this comes the saying that someone "washes their hands" of something. Pilate washed his hands when Jesus was sentenced (Matthew 27:24).

Jewish teachers also asked: Did the elders perhaps fail to take care of a stranger, who then traveled without protection? A community shares responsibility for the safety of everyone.

A captive woman VERSES 10–14

10 You may go out to battle against your enemies,
and the LORD your God hands them over to you,
and you take prisoners.
11 Among the prisoners you may see a beautiful woman.
You are attracted to her, and you want to take her as
your wife.
12 Then you shall bring her home to your house.
She shall shave her head and cut her nails.
13 She shall take off the clothes that she wore as a prisoner.
She shall stay in your house
and weep for her father and her mother for a whole
month.
After that you may go in to her and be her husband,
and she shall be your wife.
14 If you are no longer pleased with her,
then you shall let her go wherever she wants.
But you shall never sell her for money.
You shall not treat her as a slave,
because you have humiliated her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This section describes a situation that is terrible for us: A woman is taken prisoner in war and has to marry a foreign man. She has no choice in this. That clearly goes against what we understand today as human rights.

Back then, among almost all nations, women taken prisoner were abused right away and sold as slaves. This law sets limits: The man may not take her right away. She gets a month to mourn for her parents. She becomes his wife with the rights of a wife, not his slave. And if he no longer wants her, he must set her free. He may not sell her.

"Because you have humiliated her": So the Bible itself says that the man should be aware that he has done her wrong.

This rule was a step toward more protection. But it is not a model. Violence against women in war is a serious crime, and no one may use the Bible to defend it.

The right of the firstborn VERSES 15–17

15 A man may have two wives.
He loves one, and he hates the other.
Both the loved wife and the hated wife have borne him
children.
And the firstborn son belongs to the hated wife.
16 On the day when he divides what he owns among his
sons,
he may not give the son of the loved wife the rights of

the firstborn
ahead of the son of the hated wife, who is the firstborn.
17 He shall recognize the firstborn, the son of the hated wife.
He shall give him a double share of everything he has.
For he is the first sign of his father's strength.
The right of the firstborn belongs to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The WEB, our English source text, says "beloved" and "hated." It means: One wife is loved more than the other.

Back then, some men had more than one wife. That often led to jealousy and quarreling, as with Jacob, Leah, and Rachel (Genesis 29–30).

The law protects the wife who is loved less, and her child. The father may not divide the inheritance according to his feelings. What is right stands above what he prefers.

The firstborn got the double share because he had to take care of the family after his father's death.

A rebellious son VERSES 18–21

18 A man may have a stubborn and rebellious son,
who does not listen to the voice of his father or the voice of his mother.
They correct him, but he does not listen to them.
19 Then his father and his mother shall take hold of him
and bring him out to the elders of his town,
to the gate of his town.
20 They shall say to the elders of his town,
"This son of ours is stubborn and rebellious.
He does not listen to us.
He eats too much, and he is a drunkard."
21 Then all the men of his town shall stone him with stones until he dies.
So you shall remove the evil from among you.
And all Israel will hear about it and be afraid.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a very hard text. It does not mean a small child, but probably a grown son who has gone completely wild. He drinks, wastes the family's wealth, and may even become violent.

One thing stands out: The parents may not punish their son themselves. They have to go to the court of the elders. That protected the son from the whims of an angry father. And both parents, father and mother, must agree.

The Jewish scholars added so many conditions to this law that they said: It has never been carried out and never will be (Talmud, Sanhedrin 71a). It only shows how seriously respect for parents was taken.

Jesus tells a very different story about a son who wastes his inheritance: When he comes back, the father runs to meet him and hugs him (Luke 15:11–32).

No one may use this passage to justify violence against children or young people.

A man hanged on a tree VERSES 22–23

22 A man may have done a sin that deserves death.
He is put to death, and you hang him on a tree.
23 Then his body shall not stay on the tree through the night.
You must bury him on the same day.
For whoever is hanged is cursed by God.
You shall not make your land unclean,
the land that the LORD your God gives you as an inheritance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sometimes the body of an executed person was hung on a tree or a pole after his death, as a warning to others. But that must not last long. He must be buried on the same day. Even a criminal has a right to a burial and to dignity.

That is why Jesus too was taken down from the cross on the day he was crucified and buried (John 19:31).

Paul quotes this verse: "Cursed is everyone who hangs on a tree." He says: On the cross Jesus took the curse on himself, to set people free from it (Galatians 3:13).

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 22

Help for your neighbor – rules for marriage and the body

Help your neighbor VERSES 1–4

1 You may see that your brother's ox or his sheep has wandered off.
Then you shall not hide from it and look away.
You must bring it back to your brother.
2 Your brother may not live near you,
or you may not know him.
Then you shall take the animal home to your house.
It shall stay with you until your brother comes looking for it.
Then you shall give it back to him.
3 You shall do the same with his donkey.
You shall do the same with his coat.
You shall do the same with anything that your brother has lost and you have found.
You may not hide and look away.
4 You may see that your brother's donkey or his ox has fallen down on the road.
Then you shall not hide and look away.
You must help him lift them up again.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"You may not hide and look away": You may not look the other way when someone needs help. Whoever finds something must give it back. Whoever sees that someone is in trouble must help.

Exodus 23:4–5 even says: This also applies to the animal of your enemy.

This rule still applies today: Looking away is also a decision.

Various rules VERSES 5–12

5 A woman shall not wear men's clothing,
and a man shall not put on women's clothing.
For the LORD your God hates it when someone does such things.
6 On your way you may find a bird's nest,
in a tree or on the ground,
with young birds or with eggs.
The mother bird is sitting on the young birds or on the eggs.
Then you shall not take the mother together with the young.
7 You must let the mother go.
But you may take the young birds for yourself.
Then things will go well for you, and you will live a long time.
8 When you build a new house,
you shall make a railing around your roof.
Then you will not bring the guilt of blood on your house
if someone falls from it.
9 You shall not sow your vineyard with two kinds of seed.
Otherwise the whole harvest would become unclean:
the seed that you have sown and the harvest of the vineyard.
10 You shall not plow with an ox and a donkey together.
11 You shall not wear clothes in which wool and linen are woven together.
12 You shall make tassels for yourself on the four corners of the coat
that you wrap around yourself.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: Back then, men and women wore very different clothing. Many interpreters think that this was mainly about pagan customs, in which people dressed up in worship for foreign gods. Others see it as a rule for keeping man and woman distinct. Jews and Christians think differently about how to apply this verse today. It is clear: It gives no one the right to look down on other people or to harm them.

Verses 6–7: A small commandment with a great meaning: You should not exploit nature. Whoever takes the mother destroys the future. Whoever lets her fly away can harvest again. For this small commandment God promises the same as for the commandment to honor your parents: a long life.

Verse 8: The roofs were flat. People sat and worked up there. A railing protected against accidents. Whoever does not build a railing shares the guilt if someone dies. That is an early rule for safety in building.

Verses 9–11: Certain things should not be mixed. The exact reason is not given. Maybe it is meant to remind people of the order of creation, in which God made everything "according to its kind." In plowing: An ox and a donkey are not equally strong. Together, the weaker animal would suffer.

"Unclean": That is what the WEB, our English source text, means with "defiled." The Hebrew word actually means "become holy." It means: The harvest goes to the holy place, and you may not keep it for yourself.

Verse 12: The tassels were meant to remind people of God's commandments (Numbers 15:37–41). Jewish people still wear them today on the prayer shawl. Jesus also wore such a coat (Matthew 9:20).

A false accusation against a wife VERSES 13–21

13 A man may marry a woman and sleep with her.
Then he hates her.
14 He accuses her of shameful things,
and he gives her a bad name.
He says, "I married this woman.
But when I came near her,
I did not find the signs that she was a virgin."
15 Then the father and the mother of the young woman shall take the signs that the young woman was a virgin.
They shall bring them to the elders of the town at the gate.
16 The young woman's father shall say to the elders,
"I gave my daughter to this man as his wife,
and now he hates her.
17 Look, he accuses her of shameful things.
He says, 'I did not find the signs that your daughter was a virgin.'
But here are the signs that my daughter was a virgin."
And they shall spread out the cloth in front of the elders of the town.
18 Then the elders of that town shall take the man and punish him.
19 They shall make him pay a fine of 100 shekels of silver.
They shall give it to the young woman's father,
because the man has given a bad name to a virgin of Israel.
She shall stay his wife.
He may never send her away as long as he lives.
20 But the thing may be true.
The signs that the young woman was a virgin may not have been found.
21 Then they shall bring the young woman out to the door of her father's house.
And the men of her town shall stone her with stones until she dies,
because she has done a shameful thing in Israel.
She acted like a prostitute in her father's house.
So you shall remove the evil from among you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: A virgin is a woman who has never slept with a man.

The 100 shekels of silver are about 2.5 pounds of silver. That was a lot of money.

Back then, the "signs that she was a virgin" were a cloth with blood from the wedding night. Today we know: Such "proofs" are not medically reliable. Many women do not bleed the first time.

This section protects the wife from a man who wants to get rid of her and therefore spreads lies about her. He is punished harshly and may never send her away. In this way she was provided for all her life.

But verses 20–21 are shocking for us: A young woman is to be killed because she was no longer a virgin before marriage. By today's understanding that is a grave injustice. Here the Bible describes an old law that placed the honor of the family very high.

Sadly, in some places there are still so-called "honor killings" today. That is a crime. No one may use the Bible to defend it. Jesus protected a woman who was about to be

stoned and said: "Whoever among you has never sinned may throw the first stone at her" (John 8:7).

Adultery and violence against women VERSES 22–29

22 A man may be found sleeping with a woman who is married to a husband.
Then both of them shall die,
the man who slept with the woman, and the woman.
So you shall remove the evil from Israel.
23 A young woman who is a virgin may be promised in marriage to a man.
Another man meets her in the town and sleeps with her.
24 Then you shall bring them both out to the gate of that town,
and you shall stone them with stones until they die:
the young woman, because she did not cry out for help, though she was in the town,
and the man, because he has humiliated his neighbor's wife.
So you shall remove the evil from among you.
25 But the man may meet the young woman who is promised in marriage out in the field.
The man forces her and sleeps with her.
Then only the man who slept with her shall die.
26 But you shall do nothing to the young woman.
The young woman has done no sin that deserves death.
For this case is like when a man attacks his neighbor and kills him.
27 For he met her in the field.
The young woman who was promised in marriage cried out,
but there was no one to save her.
28 A man may meet a young woman who is a virgin and who is not promised in marriage.
He grabs her and sleeps with her, and they are found out.
29 Then the man who slept with her shall give the young woman's father 50 shekels of silver.
And she shall become his wife, because he has humiliated her.
He may never send her away as long as he lives.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The 50 shekels of silver are about 1¼ pounds of silver.

Back then, being promised in marriage counted almost like a marriage.

An important thought is in verses 25–27: If a man uses violence against a woman, she is innocent. The Bible compares rape with murder. And it says: We assume that the woman cried out for help, even if no one heard it. The guilt lies with the attacker alone.

Verses 23–24, on the other hand, are hard to understand today: Back then, people assumed that a woman in the town could have called for help. Today we know that victims of violence often freeze with fear and cannot scream. No one may blame a victim.

Verses 28–29 are especially hard for us: The young woman is to marry the man who used violence against her. Back then, a woman who was no longer a virgin had hardly any chance of marriage and so of being provided for. The law wanted to protect her: The man had to pay and provide for her all her life. But according to Exodus 22:16–17, the father could also refuse the marriage.

Even so: By today's understanding it is a grave injustice to marry a victim to the attacker. Today violence against women is punished as a serious crime. No one may use these verses to justify such a thing.

Not the wife of your father VERSE 30

30 A man shall not take his father's wife.
He shall not uncover the edge of his father's robe.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles this verse is already the first verse of Chapter 23 (23:1). We follow the numbering of the WEB, our English source text.

It means another wife of the father, not one's own mother, for example after the father's death. That was forbidden (Leviticus 18:8).

"Uncovering the edge of the father's robe" is a picture. The robe stands for the protection that a man gives his wife (Ruth 3:9). Whoever sleeps with his father's wife wounds his father's honor.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 23

Who belongs to the assembly – protection for runaways – no interest

Who may not enter the assembly of the LORD VERSES 1–8

1 A man whose private parts have been crushed or cut off shall not enter the assembly of the LORD.
2 A person born from a forbidden union shall not enter the assembly of the LORD.
Even to the tenth generation, none of his descendants shall enter the assembly of the LORD.
3 An Ammonite or a Moabite shall not enter the assembly of the LORD.
Even to the tenth generation, none of their descendants shall ever enter the assembly of the LORD.
4 This is because they did not come to meet you with bread and water
on the way when you came out of Egypt.
And it is because they hired Balaam against you to curse you.
He was the son of Beor, from Pethor in Mesopotamia.
5 But the LORD your God would not listen to Balaam.
The LORD your God turned the curse into a blessing for you,
because the LORD your God loved you.
6 You shall never seek their peace or their well-being, as long as you live, forever.
7 You shall not hate an Edomite, for he is your brother.
You shall not hate an Egyptian,

because you lived as a foreigner in his land.
8 The children who are born to them in the third generation
may enter the assembly of the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles the verses of this chapter are numbered one higher: verse 1 here is verse 2 there, and so on up to verse 26. We follow the numbering of the WEB, our English source text.

The "assembly of the LORD" is the community of Israel when it gathers before God, perhaps especially for worship and important decisions.

Verse 1: Among some nations, men were castrated in the service of foreign gods or as servants at the royal court. That should not happen in Israel.

Verse 2: "From a forbidden union": What exactly is meant is not known for sure. Jewish teachers think of children from incest or adultery.

These rules seem harsh and unfair to us, especially toward people who cannot help it themselves. But the Bible itself later goes a different way:

Ruth was a Moabite woman. She was taken into Israel and became the great-grandmother of King David (Ruth 4:13–17).

The prophet Isaiah clearly promises that castrated men and foreigners who are faithful to God also have a place in God's house, with a name that is better than sons and daughters (Isaiah 56:3–7).

And in the book of Acts, a castrated man from Ethiopia is baptized (Acts 8:26–39).

Verse 7 is also remarkable: Not even the Egyptians, who had made Israel slaves, should be hated. For Israel lived as a foreigner in their land for a long time.

A clean camp VERSES 9–14

9 When you go out against your enemies and set up camp,
you shall keep yourself away from every evil thing.
10 There may be a man among you who is unclean because of something that happened to him at night.
Then he shall go outside the camp.
He shall not come into the camp.
11 When evening comes, he shall wash himself with water.
When the sun has gone down, he may come into the camp.
12 You shall also have a place outside the camp
where you go to relieve yourself.
13 And you shall have a small shovel with your weapons.
When you relieve yourself outside, you shall dig a hole with it.
Then you shall turn and cover up your waste.
14 For the LORD your God walks in the middle of your camp,
to save you and to hand over your enemies to you.
That is why your camp shall be holy.
Then he will not see anything indecent among you and turn away from you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Something that happened to him at night": This means a release of semen during the night (see Leviticus 15:16).

God cares about hygiene too! The rule with the shovel is very practical: It prevented diseases in the camp. In the past, more soldiers in wars often died of disease than in battle.

The reason is beautiful: God walks around in the middle of the camp. That is why it should be clean, just as you tidy up your house when a guest comes.

Protection for a runaway slave VERSES 15–16

15 A servant may run away from his master and come to you.
Then you shall not hand him over to his master.
16 He shall live with you, among you,
in the place that he chooses in one of your towns,
wherever he likes best.
You shall not mistreat him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a truly unusual law! Among other nations back then, runaway slaves had to be given back. Whoever helped a slave was punished harshly.

Israel is to do the opposite: take in the runaway, let him live where he wants, and not mistreat him.

This probably means above all a slave who has fled to Israel from another country. Israel knows what it is like to be a slave, and what it is like to flee.

In history, people who fought against slavery have pointed to this verse.

No prostitution in the name of God VERSES 17–18

17 None of the daughters of Israel shall be a prostitute,
and none of the sons of Israel shall be a male shrine prostitute.
18 You shall not bring the pay of a female prostitute
or the pay of a male prostitute
into the house of the LORD your God for any vow.
For the LORD your God hates both of these.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: A vow is a promise made to God.

"Male shrine prostitute": Here the WEB, our English source text, uses the old word "sodomite." The Hebrew has "kadesh," which literally means "someone set apart." It means a man who worked as a prostitute in the service of a foreign god. For women the Hebrew has the word "kedeshah."

Among the Canaanites there were temples where prostitution was part of worship. That should not happen in Israel. People should not do business with worship and sexuality.

"The pay of a male prostitute": That is what the WEB, our English source text, says. The Hebrew literally says "the pay of a dog." Back then, "dog" was an insult for such a man.

Important: This passage is about prostitution in the temples of foreign gods. It must not be used to look down on people or to persecute them.

No interest from your brother VERSES 19–20

19 You shall not lend anything to your brother for interest:
no interest on money, no interest on food,
no interest on anything that is lent for interest.
20 You may charge interest to a foreigner.
But you shall not charge interest to your brother.
Then the LORD your God will bless you in everything

you do
in the land that you are going into to take over.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: Interest is extra money that the borrower must pay back.

Back then, whoever borrowed money was usually in need. Interest would have pushed him even deeper into misery. That is why you should help a poor Israelite without interest.

Foreigners were mostly traveling traders who borrowed money for business. From them you could take interest, as in a normal business deal.

In the Middle Ages, Christians forbade interest completely. Because Jews were allowed to take interest from Christians, they were pushed into the money trade. Later this gave rise to evil prejudices against Jews. These prejudices are false and have caused endless suffering.

Keeping vows VERSES 21–23

21 When you make a vow to the LORD your God,
you shall not be slow to keep it.
For the LORD your God will surely demand it from you,
and it would be a sin for you.
22 But if you choose not to make a vow,
it will be no sin for you.
23 What has come out of your lips, you shall be careful to do.
You have freely promised something to the LORD your God.
You have promised it with your mouth.
You must do it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

No one has to promise God anything. But whoever does must keep the promise. That is why you should not make promises carelessly (see also Numbers 30 and Ecclesiastes 5:4–5; in some Bibles 5:3–4).

Eating from your neighbor's field VERSES 24–25

24 When you come into your neighbor's vineyard,
you may eat as many grapes as you like, until you are full.
But you shall not put any into your basket.
25 When you come into your neighbor's field of grain,
you may pick the ears of grain with your hand.
But you shall not use a sickle on your neighbor's grain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A law against hunger: Whoever passes by a field hungry may eat until he is full. That is not stealing. But he may not take anything with him and may not harvest.

In this way both are protected: the hungry person and the owner.

The disciples of Jesus did exactly this: They picked ears of grain on the Sabbath because they were hungry (Mark 2:23).

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 24

Divorce – protection for the poor, foreigners, orphans, and widows

Divorce and marrying again VERSES 1–4

1 A man may take a wife and marry her.
Then she may no longer please him,
because he has found something indecent about her.
Then he shall write her a certificate of divorce.
He shall put it in her hand and send her away from his house.
2 When she has left his house,
she may go and become another man's wife.
3 The second husband may also hate her.
He writes her a certificate of divorce,
puts it in her hand, and sends her away from his house.
Or the second husband who took her as his wife may die.
4 Then her first husband, who sent her away,
may not take her back as his wife,
after she has been made unclean.
For the LORD would hate that.
You shall not bring sin on the land
that the LORD your God gives you as an inheritance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This law assumes that there were divorces back then. Above all, it is about protecting the woman:

The man must give her a "certificate of divorce." With this document she could prove that she was free and allowed to marry again. Without this letter, she could later have been accused of adultery.

The first husband may not take her back if she has been married to another man in the meantime. This was meant to keep women from being passed back and forth like property.

What "something indecent" means was already disputed in the time of Jesus. Some teachers said: any small reason. Others said: only adultery.

Jesus said about this: Moses allowed divorce only because your hearts were so hard. But God's original will is that husband and wife stay together (Matthew 19:3–9; Mark 10:2–12).

Today many churches have different ways of dealing with divorce. What matters is this: People whose marriage has broken down deserve mercy, not contempt.

A year for the young marriage VERSE 5

5 When a man has taken a new wife,
he shall not go out with the army,
and he shall not be given any other duties.
He shall be free at home for one year
and make his wife happy, the wife whom he has taken.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A beautiful law: A newly married man gets one year off from military service and from other duties. The young marriage should have time to grow. And the man should

"make his wife happy." The happiness of the wife clearly matters.

No millstone as a pledge VERSE 6

6 No one shall take a hand mill or its upper millstone as a pledge.
For that would be taking a person's life as a pledge.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whoever borrowed money gave the lender something as security, a "pledge." But the hand mill could not be taken. With it the family ground the flour for its bread every day. Without the mill, the family would have gone hungry.

What a person needs to live must not be taken away from him.

Kidnapping VERSE 7

7 A man may be found kidnapping one of his brothers,
one of the people of Israel.
He treats him as a slave or sells him.
Then that thief shall die.
So you shall remove the evil from among you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Kidnapping is one of the worst crimes. A human being is not a thing that can be stolen and sold. The story of Joseph, whom his brothers sold, shows how terrible that is (Genesis 37).

In Exodus 21:16 this ban applies to every human being.

Pay attention to the skin disease VERSES 8–9

8 Be careful when the disease of leprosy breaks out.
Pay close attention and do everything that the priests, the Levites, teach you.
Be careful to do it as I have commanded them.
9 Remember what the LORD your God did to Miriam on the way when you came out of Egypt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Leprosy" was a name for various skin diseases (Leviticus 13–14). The priests were to decide who was sick and who was healthy again. This protected the community from infection.

Miriam, the sister of Moses, got such a disease after she had spoken against Moses (Numbers 12).

The pledge of a poor man VERSES 10–13

10 When you lend your neighbor anything,
you shall not go into his house to take a pledge from him.
11 You shall stay standing outside.
And the man to whom you are lending shall bring the pledge out to you.
12 If he is a poor man,
you shall not go to sleep with his pledge.
13 You must give the pledge back to him when the sun goes down.
Then he can sleep in his coat and bless you.
And it will be counted as right for you before the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A poor person has dignity too. The lender may not simply force his way into his house and take something. The poor person himself decides what he gives as a pledge.

A very poor person often had only his coat as a pledge. At night he needed it as a blanket. That is why it must be given back in the evening. No one should be cold just because he is poor.

Wages on the same day VERSES 14–15

14 You shall not take advantage of a hired worker who is poor and needy,
whether he is one of your brothers
or one of the foreigners who live in your land, in your towns.
15 You shall give him his pay on the same day,
before the sun goes down.
For he is poor, and he is longing for it.
Otherwise he will cry out to the LORD against you,
and it will be counted as sin for you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A day laborer worked for someone else every day and lived from hand to mouth. If he did not get his pay in the evening, his family had nothing to eat.

So: Pay wages right away! And this applies to people from the land and to foreigners alike.

God hears the cry of those who are exploited. The letter of James in the New Testament takes up this thought (James 5:4). To this day, fair wages are a matter of faith.

Each person carries his own guilt VERSE 16

16 Fathers shall not be put to death for their children,
and children shall not be put to death for their fathers.
Each person shall be put to death for his own sin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A very important principle of law: No one may be punished for someone else's guilt. Among other nations, sometimes the whole family of a criminal was punished. Not in Israel.

The prophet Ezekiel stressed this again later (Ezekiel 18:20). And this principle still applies today in every just legal system.

Justice for foreigners, orphans, and widows VERSES 17–18

17 You shall not twist justice for the foreigner or for the orphan.
And you shall not take a widow's clothing as a pledge.
18 Remember that you were a slave in Egypt,
and that the LORD your God set you free from there.
That is why I command you to do this.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, foreigners, orphans, and widows had no husband, no father, and no family to stand up for them. They were easy to cheat. God clearly takes their side.

And again the reason is: Remember that you yourself were a slave.

Leave something for the poor VERSES 19–22

19 When you bring in the harvest from your field
and you have forgotten a bundle of grain in the field,
you shall not go back to get it.
It shall be for the foreigner, for the orphan, and for the widow.
Then the LORD your God will bless you in all the work of your hands.

20 When you beat your olive trees to knock down the olives,
you shall not go over the branches a second time.
What is left shall be for the foreigner, for the orphan, and for the widow.
21 When you pick the grapes in your vineyard,
you shall not go back afterward to gather the last grapes.
What is left shall be for the foreigner, for the orphan, and for the widow.
22 Remember that you were a slave in the land of Egypt.
That is why I command you to do this.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At harvest time you should not gather everything down to the last bit. What is left over belongs to the poor. They may come and pick it up. So they have food to eat, and with dignity, through their own work, without having to beg.

This is exactly how Ruth, the poor widow from Moab, gathered grain in the field of Boaz (Ruth 2). That is how one of the most beautiful stories of the Bible began.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 25

Limited punishments – marriage to a brother-in-law – honest weights

No more than 40 blows VERSES 1–3

1 Suppose there is a quarrel between men,
and they come to court, and the judges judge them.
Then the judges shall declare the righteous person innocent,
and they shall declare the wicked person guilty.
2 If the guilty man deserves to be beaten,
then the judge shall have him lie down,
and he shall have him beaten while the judge watches.
The number of blows shall match his guilt.
3 The judge may sentence him to no more than 40 blows.
He shall not give more.
If he gives him more blows than that,
then your brother will be put to shame in front of you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Physical punishment was common back then. Today we reject it, because it hurts a person's dignity.

But even here the Bible sets a limit: Never more than 40 blows. And the judge must be there, so that no one goes too far. The reason is remarkable: The person who is punished is still "your brother." He must not be put to shame.

Later, to be on the safe side, Jews gave only 39 blows, so that they would never go over the limit. Paul tells that on 5 occasions he was given 40 blows minus 1 (2 Corinthians 11:24).

Do not tie the mouth of the ox while it threshes VERSE 4

4 You shall not tie the mouth of the ox shut when it treads out the grain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At threshing time, an ox walked around in a circle over the grain, so that the kernels came loose from the stalks. The ox should be allowed to eat while it works. Whoever works should also get something from it, even an animal.

Paul applies this verse to people: Whoever works for the church should also be allowed to live from it (1 Corinthians 9:9–10).

Marrying the brother-in-law VERSES 5–10

5 Suppose brothers live together,
and one of them dies and has no son.
Then the wife of the dead man shall not marry a stranger outside the family.
Her husband's brother shall go in to her and take her as his wife.
He shall do the duty of a husband's brother for her.
6 The firstborn son she has shall carry on the name of the brother who died,
so that his name is not wiped out of Israel.
7 But suppose the man does not want to take his brother's wife.
Then his brother's wife shall go up to the gate, to the elders, and say,
"My husband's brother refuses to keep his brother's name alive in Israel.
He will not do the duty of a husband's brother for me."
8 Then the elders of his city shall call him and speak to him.
Suppose he stands firm and says, "I don't want to take her."
9 Then his brother's wife shall come to him in front of the elders.
She shall pull his sandal off his foot and spit in his face.
And she shall answer and say,
"This is what is done to the man who does not build up his brother's house."
10 And his family shall be called in Israel:
"The house of the man whose sandal was pulled off."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When a man died without a son, his widow was in great need. She had no one to provide for her and no share of the land. And the name of the dead man would have died out.

That is why his brother was to marry the widow. The first child then counted as the child of the man who had died. So the widow was cared for, and the family of the dead man lived on.

But the brother was allowed to refuse. Then he had to bear public shame. The widow was allowed to shame him in front of everyone. In this way she at least had a chance to demand her rights.

The Bible tells two stories about this: Tamar (Genesis 38) and Ruth (Ruth 4). In the story of Ruth, the sandal is used in a different way, as a sign that a right is handed on to someone else.

A forbidden grab in a fight VERSES 11–12

11 Suppose men are fighting with each other.
And the wife of one of them comes near to rescue her

husband from the man who is hitting him.
And she reaches out her hand and grabs the other man by his private parts.
12 Then you shall cut off her hand.
Do not have any pity.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This law is hard for us to understand, and it is very harsh. It was probably about the danger that such a grab could make the man unable to father children. Then he would have had no more descendants. That fits the section before it, which is about keeping a family alive.

It is the only place in Israel's law where cutting off a part of the body is a punishment.

The Jewish teachers did not apply this law word for word. They understood it as a fine for the shame that was caused.

Today such a punishment would be a terrible wrong. No one may use this verse to justify anything like it.

Honest weights and measures VERSES 13–16

13 You shall not have two different weights in your bag,
one heavy and one light.
14 You shall not have two different measures in your house,
one large and one small.
15 You shall have a full and honest weight.
You shall have a full and honest measure.
Then you will live a long time in the land that the LORD your God gives you.
16 For everyone who does such things, everyone who does wrong,
is disgusting to the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, people weighed goods with weight stones on a scale. A cheater had two sets: a heavy one for buying and a light one for selling. In this way he cheated his customers.

God wants honesty in business. For him, cheating in trade is "disgusting," just like worshiping idols. This shows: Faith and everyday life belong together. Whoever honors God must also be honest when buying and selling.

Remember Amalek VERSES 17–19

17 Remember what Amalek did to you on the way, when you came out of Egypt.
18 Remember how he met you on the way
and attacked those at the back of your line, all the weak ones who were behind you,
when you were tired and worn out.
And he did not fear God.
19 So when the LORD your God has given you rest from all your enemies around you,
in the land that the LORD your God gives you as an inheritance to take as your own,
then you shall wipe out the memory of Amalek from under the sky.
Do not forget!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Amalekites attacked Israel in the wilderness (Exodus 17:8–16). Here we learn how cowardly this attack was: They did not attack the warriors. They attacked the weakest people at the back of the line: the old, the sick, the tired.

"He did not fear God": Whoever attacks the weakest shows that nothing is holy to him.

The command to wipe out the memory of Amalek is very harsh. In Judaism, "Amalek" has become a picture for every power that attacks weak and defenseless people and has no conscience at all.

Something seems to contradict itself: "Wipe out the memory" and "Do not forget!" What it means is: Never forget what evil is, so that it does not happen again.

This passage must never be used to declare a people or a group today to be enemies and to justify violence against them.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 26

The first fruits – a confession of faith – the covenant

The basket with the first fruits VERSES 1–4

1 You will come into the land that the LORD your God gives you as an inheritance.
You will take it over and live in it.
2 Then you shall take some of the first of all the crops of the ground
that you bring in from your land that the LORD your God gives you.
You shall put them in a basket.
And you shall go to the place that the LORD your God will choose,
to let his name live there.
3 You shall come to the priest who is there in those days and say to him,
"Today I declare to the LORD your God
that I have come into the land
that the LORD swore to our ancestors to give us."
4 The priest shall take the basket from your hand
and set it down in front of the altar of the LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

When the first harvest in the new land is ripe, everyone should bring a basket with the first fruits to the holy place. That is a sign of thanks: The land and everything that grows on it is a gift from God.

"My father was a Syrian who was close to ruin" VERSES 5–11

5 Then you shall speak up before the LORD your God and say,
"My father was a Syrian who was close to ruin.
He went down into Egypt and lived there as a stranger, with only a few people.
There he became a great nation, strong and with many people.

6 The Egyptians treated us badly.
They oppressed us and forced us to do hard work.
7 Then we cried out to the LORD, the God of our ancestors.
The LORD heard our voice.
He saw our misery, our hard work, and how we were oppressed.
8 The LORD brought us out of Egypt
with a strong hand and with an outstretched arm,
with great terror, with signs, and with wonders.
9 He has brought us to this place
and has given us this land,
a land flowing with milk and honey.
10 Now look, I have brought the first of the crops of the ground
that you, LORD, have given me."
Then you shall set it down before the LORD your God,
and bow down in worship before the LORD your God.
11 And you shall be glad about all the good things
that the LORD your God has given to you and to your household,
you, and the Levite, and the foreigner who lives among you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Syrian": That is the word the WEB, our English source text, uses. The Hebrew has "Aramean." The Arameans lived in the region of today's Syria. This means Jacob, who lived for a long time with his uncle Laban in Aram. "Close to ruin" can also be translated as "wandering" or "homeless."

This prayer is like a short confession of faith of Israel. In a few sentences the whole story is told: We were homeless. We were slaves. We cried out. God heard and set us free. He gave us this land.

Something stands out: The farmer who lives centuries later says "us" and "we." He himself was not in Egypt. But the story of his people is his story too.

This text is still a central part of the Jewish Passover celebration today (the Haggadah).

And again: The joy is shared, also with the Levite and the foreigner.

The tithe in the third year VERSES 12–15

12 Every third year is the year of the tithe.
When you have finished setting apart the whole tithe of your harvest in that year,
you shall give it to the Levite, to the foreigner, to the orphan, and to the widow.
Then they can eat in your towns and be full.
13 And you shall say before the LORD your God,
"I have taken the holy share out of my house.
I have given it to the Levite, to the foreigner, to the orphan, and to the widow,
just as you commanded me in all your commandments.
I have not broken any of your commandments,
and I have not forgotten any of them.
14 I have not eaten any of it while I was mourning.
I have not taken any of it away while I was unclean.
And I have not given any of it for the dead.
I have listened to the voice of the LORD my God.
I have done everything that you commanded me.
15 Look down from your holy home, from heaven,
and bless your people Israel
and the land that you have given us,
as you swore to our ancestors,
a land flowing with milk and honey."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: A tithe is a tenth part.

Every third year the tithe belongs to the poor (see Deuteronomy 14:28–29). Afterward, people should declare before God: I really did pass it on.

"For the dead": Among some nations, people put food in the grave with the dead or made sacrifices for them. Israel should not do that with the holy tithe.

At the end there is a beautiful prayer: "Look down … from heaven, and bless your people Israel." Whoever shares with the poor may ask for God's blessing.

God and his people belong together VERSES 16–19

16 Today the LORD your God commands you to do these rules and laws.
So keep them and do them with all your heart and with all your soul.
17 Today you have declared that the LORD is your God.
You have declared that you will walk in his ways,
keep his rules, his commandments, and his laws,
and listen to his voice.
18 And today the LORD has declared that you are his very own people,
as he promised you,
and that you shall keep all his commandments.
19 He will set you high above all the nations that he has made,
to bring praise, fame, and honor.
And you shall be a holy people for the LORD your God,
as he has said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is where the large part with the individual commandments ends (Chapters 12–26).

It is like a wedding: Both sides make a declaration. The people say: The LORD is our God. And God says: You are my people. That is the heart of the covenant.

"High above all the nations": This does not mean that Israel should rule over others. It should be a people in whom you can see God's goodness, "to bring praise, fame, and honor" to God.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 27

The law on stones – 12 curses at Mount Ebal

Large stones with the law VERSES 1–8

1 Moses and the elders of Israel gave the people this command:
"Keep the whole commandment that I command you today.
2 On the day when you cross the Jordan
into the land that the LORD your God gives you,
you shall set up large stones for yourself
and cover them with plaster.
3 When you have crossed over,
you shall write on them all the words of this law.
Then you will go into the land that the LORD your God gives you,
a land flowing with milk and honey,
as the LORD, the God of your ancestors, has promised you.
4 When you have crossed the Jordan,
you shall set up these stones on Mount Ebal,
as I command you today.
And you shall cover them with plaster.
5 There you shall build an altar for the LORD your God,
an altar of stones.
You shall not use any iron tool on them.
6 You shall build the altar of the LORD your God out of stones that are not cut.
And on it you shall offer burnt offerings to the LORD your God.
7 You shall sacrifice peace offerings and eat there.
And you shall be glad before the LORD your God.
8 And you shall write all the words of this law on the stones
very clearly."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Right after entering the land, the law is to be written down in public, on large stones, where everyone can see it. The white layer of plaster made the writing easy to read.

Verse 2: Plaster is a white paste that becomes hard.

"Very clearly": God's word should be understandable for everyone. That is also the goal of this Bible in plain language.

Joshua did this later (Joshua 8:30–35).

The altar is to be made of uncut stones, just as God created them (see Exodus 20:25).

Today you have become God's people VERSES 9–10

9 Moses and the priests, the Levites, spoke to all Israel:
"Be quiet and listen, Israel!
Today you have become the people of the LORD your God.
10 So you shall listen to the voice of the LORD your God,
and do his commandments and his rules
that I command you today."

Blessing and curse on two mountains VERSES 11–14

11 On the same day Moses gave the people this command:
12 "When you have crossed the Jordan,
these tribes shall stand on Mount Gerizim to bless the people:
Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Joseph, and Benjamin.
13 And these tribes shall stand on Mount Ebal for the curse:
Reuben, Gad, Asher, Zebulun, Dan, and Naphtali.
14 The Levites shall speak with a loud voice
and say to all the men of Israel:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The 12 tribes divide up onto two mountains that face each other. Between them lies a valley. You can imagine the voices echoing from one mountain to the other.

The tribes on the mountain of blessing come from Jacob's wives Leah and Rachel. On the mountain of the curse stand mainly the tribes that come from the servant women Zilpah and Bilhah, along with Reuben and Zebulun.

The 12 curses VERSES 15–26

15 'Cursed is the man who makes a carved or a cast idol
and sets it up in secret.
The LORD hates it.
It is only something that a craftsman made with his hands.'
And all the people shall answer and say, 'Amen.'
16 'Cursed is anyone who dishonors his father or his mother.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'
17 'Cursed is anyone who moves his neighbor's boundary stone.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'
18 'Cursed is anyone who leads a blind person the wrong way on the road.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'
19 'Cursed is anyone who denies justice to the foreigner, the orphan, and the widow.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'
20 'Cursed is anyone who sleeps with his father's wife, because he dishonors his father's bed.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'
21 'Cursed is anyone who sleeps with any kind of animal.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'
22 'Cursed is anyone who sleeps with his sister,
his father's daughter or his mother's daughter.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'
23 'Cursed is anyone who sleeps with his mother-in-law.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'
24 'Cursed is anyone who kills his neighbor in secret.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'
25 'Cursed is anyone who takes a bribe to kill an innocent person.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'
26 'Cursed is anyone who does not hold up the words of this law by doing them.'
And all the people shall say, 'Amen.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"He dishonors his father's bed": That is what the WEB, our English source text, says. The Hebrew has the same picture as in Deuteronomy 22:30: "uncover the edge of his father's robe."

"Amen" means "That is so" or "Let it be so." All the people agree. With it, everyone says: I know what is right, and I want to keep to it.

Something stands out: Almost all these sins happen in secret: setting up an idol "in secret," killing "in secret,"

leading a blind person the wrong way, who cannot see it. A human court would often never find out about them. But God sees it.

Again it is about protecting the weak: the blind, foreigners, orphans, and widows.

The last curse sums everything up. Paul quotes it and says: No one can keep the whole law perfectly. That is why all people need God's grace. Christ carried the curse for us (Galatians 3:10–13).

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 28

Blessing and curse

The blessing VERSES 1–14

1 If you really listen to the voice of the LORD your God,
and are careful to do all his commandments that I
command you today,
then the LORD your God will set you high above all the
nations of the earth.
2 All these blessings will come to you and reach you,
if you listen to the voice of the LORD your God:
3 You will be blessed in the city,
and you will be blessed in the field.
4 Your children will be blessed,
and the crops of your ground, and the young of your
animals,
the calves of your cattle and the lambs of your flock.
5 Your basket will be blessed,
and the bowl in which you knead your dough.
6 You will be blessed when you come in,
and you will be blessed when you go out.
7 The LORD will make your enemies who rise up against
you
be defeated in front of you.
They will come out against you on one road,
but they will run away from you on seven roads.
8 The LORD will command his blessing to be with you in
your barns
and in everything you do.
He will bless you in the land that the LORD your God
gives you.
9 The LORD will make you a holy people for himself,
as he has sworn to you,
if you keep the commandments of the LORD your God
and walk in his ways.
10 All the peoples of the earth will see
that you are called by the name of the LORD,
and they will be afraid of you.
11 The LORD will give you great riches:
many children, many young animals, and good crops
from your ground,
in the land that the LORD swore to your ancestors to
give you.
12 The LORD will open his good storehouse in the sky for
you,
to give rain to your land at the right time
and to bless all the work of your hands.
You will lend to many nations,
but you will not need to borrow.
13 The LORD will make you the head and not the tail.
You will always be on top,
and you will not be at the bottom.
This will happen if you listen to the commandments of
the LORD your God
that I command you today,
and if you are careful to do them.
14 Do not turn away from any of the words that I
command you today,
not to the right and not to the left,
to follow other gods and serve them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, a covenant often ended with blessing and curse. It was like that in treaties between kings too. Moses sets it before the people's eyes: What happens if you stay faithful to God? And what happens if you leave him?

The blessing covers all of life: city and countryside, children and animals, food and work, coming and going. "You will be blessed when you come in, and you will be blessed when you go out": These words are also found in Psalm 121:8, and they are still spoken as a blessing today.

The basket is for the harvest, the bowl for the bread dough. God also blesses everyday life in the kitchen.

The curse: Everything becomes hard VERSES 15–26

15 But if you do not listen to the voice of the LORD your
God,
and are not careful to do all his commandments and
his rules
that I command you today,
then all these curses will come on you and reach you:
16 You will be cursed in the city,
and you will be cursed in the field.
17 Your basket will be cursed,
and the bowl in which you knead your dough.
18 Your children will be cursed,
and the crops of your ground,
the calves of your cattle and the lambs of your flock.
19 You will be cursed when you come in,
and you will be cursed when you go out.
20 The LORD will send on you curse, confusion, and
punishment
in everything you try to do,
until you are destroyed and quickly die,
because of the evil things you have done
when you turned away from me.
21 The LORD will make plague cling to you,
until he has wiped you out from the land
that you are going into to take over.
22 The LORD will strike you with wasting disease, with
fever, with swelling,
with burning heat, with the sword,

with blight and with mold in your grain.
They will chase you until you die.
23 The sky over your head will be like bronze,
and the ground under you will be like iron.
24 The LORD will turn the rain of your land into powder
and dust.
It will come down on you from the sky
until you are destroyed.
25 The LORD will let you be defeated in front of your
enemies.
You will go out against them on one road,
but you will run away from them on seven roads.
You will be tossed back and forth among all the
kingdoms of the earth.
26 Your dead bodies will be food for all the birds of the sky
and for the wild animals of the earth.
And there will be no one to scare them away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The curse is the exact opposite of the blessing. The sentences are repeated almost word for word, only with "cursed" instead of "blessed."

"The sky over your head will be like bronze, and the ground under you will be like iron": A strong picture for drought. No rain falls, and the ground becomes hard and produces nothing.

The part with the curse is much longer than the part with the blessing. That is a serious warning. Moses does not want to torment the people. He wants with all his strength to keep them from leaving God.

Sickness, blindness, oppression VERSES 27–37

27 The LORD will strike you with the boils of Egypt,
with tumors, with sores, and with itching,
and you will not be able to be healed from them.
28 The LORD will strike you with madness, with
blindness,
and with confusion of heart.
29 At noon you will feel your way around,
like a blind man feels his way in the dark.
Nothing you do will succeed.
You will always be oppressed and robbed,
and there will be no one to save you.
30 You will be engaged to a woman,
but another man will sleep with her.
You will build a house,
but you will not live in it.
You will plant a vineyard,
but you will not enjoy its fruit.
31 Your ox will be killed in front of your eyes,
but you will not eat any of it.
Your donkey will be taken from you by force right in
front of you,
and it will not be given back to you.
Your sheep will be given to your enemies,
and there will be no one to save you.
32 Your sons and your daughters will be given to another
people.
Your eyes will watch for them all day long
and grow tired with longing,
but you will be powerless to do anything.
33 A nation that you do not know will eat the crops of
your ground
and everything you worked for.
You will always be oppressed and crushed.
34 The things that you see with your eyes
will drive you mad.
35 The LORD will strike you on the knees and on the legs
with painful boils that cannot be healed,
from the soles of your feet to the top of your head.
36 The LORD will bring you and your king, whom you
will set over you,
to a nation that neither you nor your ancestors have
known.
There you will serve other gods made of wood and
stone.
37 You will become a horror, a saying, and a joke
among all the peoples where the LORD will lead you
away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 30 is the opposite of 20:5–7: There, men with a new house, a new vineyard, or a bride-to-be were allowed to go home to enjoy their happiness. Here everything is taken from them.

Verse 36 says ahead of time that the people will be led away with their king into a foreign land. That really happened later: In the year 586 BC, King Zedekiah was taken to Babylon with many people (2 Kings 25).

Work without fruit VERSES 38–48

38 You will carry much seed out into the field,
but you will gather in little,
because the locusts will eat it up.
39 You will plant vineyards and take care of them,
but you will not drink the wine or gather the grapes,
because worms will eat them.
40 You will have olive trees everywhere in your land,
but you will not rub yourself with the oil,
because your olives will drop off.
41 You will have sons and daughters,
but they will not stay yours,
because they will be taken away as prisoners.
42 Locusts will eat up all your trees
and the crops of your ground.
43 The foreigner who lives among you will rise higher and
higher above you,
and you will sink lower and lower.
44 He will lend to you,
but you will not lend to him.
He will be the head,
and you will be the tail.
45 All these curses will come on you.
They will chase you and catch up with you until you
are destroyed,
because you did not listen to the voice of the LORD
your God,
to keep his commandments and his rules that he
commanded you.
46 They will be a sign and a warning
to you and to your descendants forever.
47 You did not serve the LORD your God with joy and with
a glad heart,

even though you had plenty of everything.
48 That is why you will serve your enemies,
whom the LORD will send against you.
You will serve them in hunger, in thirst, in nakedness,
and in need of everything.
He will put an iron yoke on your neck
until he has destroyed you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 38: Locusts are large insects that come in huge swarms.

Verse 47 is especially remarkable: The reason for the disaster is not only disobedience, but that the people did not serve God "with joy," even though they had plenty of everything. God does not only want obedience, but a thankful, joyful heart.

A "yoke" is a wooden bar that is put on the necks of cattle so that they can pull. An "iron yoke" is a picture for very harsh oppression.

A foreign nation and the siege VERSES 49–57

49 The LORD will bring a nation against you from far away,
from the end of the earth,
as fast as an eagle flies.
It will be a nation whose language you will not understand,
50 a nation with a fierce face,
that has no respect for the old
and no mercy for the young.
51 They will eat the young of your animals and the crops of your ground,
until you are destroyed.
They will not leave you any grain, new wine, or oil,
no calves of your cattle and no lambs of your flock,
until they have wiped you out.
52 They will lay siege to you in all your towns,
until your high, strong walls that you trusted in
fall down everywhere in your land.
They will lay siege to you in all your towns
everywhere in the land that the LORD your God has given you.
53 During the siege and the great distress
that your enemies will bring on you,
you will eat your own children,
the flesh of your sons and of your daughters,
whom the LORD your God has given you.
54 The man among you who is most gentle and very sensitive
will turn mean and stingy toward his brother,
toward the wife he loves,
and toward the rest of his children who are still left.
55 He will not give any of them any of the flesh of his children that he is eating,
because he has nothing else left.
That is how bad the siege and the distress will be
that your enemy will bring on you in all your towns.
56 The woman among you who is most gentle and sensitive
would never dare to set the sole of her foot on the ground,
because she is so delicate and sensitive.
But she will turn mean and stingy toward the husband
she loves,
toward her son and toward her daughter,
57 toward her newborn baby
that comes out from between her legs,
and toward the children she gives birth to.
For she will eat them in secret,
because she has nothing at all.
That is how bad the siege and the distress will be
that your enemy will bring on you in your towns.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are almost unbearable. They describe what can happen in a long siege: The hunger becomes so terrible that people lose all humanity and even eat their own children.

This is not a command and not something God wants. It is a warning against the worst misery that can come upon people. Sadly, such things have really happened in sieges in history. The Bible tells of it at the siege of Samaria (2 Kings 6:28–29) and of Jerusalem (Lamentations 4:10).

A nation "from the end of the earth," "as fast as an eagle flies," with a foreign language: Later people thought of the Assyrians, the Babylonians, and the Romans.

Scattered among all nations VERSES 58–68

58 Suppose you are not careful to do all the words of this law
that are written in this book,
so that you fear this glorious and awesome name,
the LORD your God.
59 Then the LORD will send terrible plagues on you and on your descendants,
great plagues that last a long time,
and severe sicknesses that last a long time.
60 He will bring back on you all the diseases of Egypt
that you were afraid of,
and they will cling to you.
61 The LORD will also bring on you every sickness and every plague
that is not written in the book of this law,
until you are destroyed.
62 Only a few of you will be left,
even though you were once as many as the stars in the sky,
because you did not listen to the voice of the LORD your God.
63 Once the LORD was glad to do you good and to make you many.
In the same way the LORD will be glad to wipe you out and destroy you.
You will be pulled out of the land that you are going into to take over.
64 The LORD will scatter you among all peoples,
from one end of the earth to the other end of the earth.
There you will serve other gods
that neither you nor your ancestors have known,
gods of wood and stone.
65 Among these nations you will find no peace,
and there will be no place for the sole of your foot to rest.
There the LORD will give you a trembling heart,
eyes that grow weak, and a soul that wastes away.

66 Your life will hang in doubt before you.
You will be afraid night and day,
and you will never be sure that you will stay alive.
67 In the morning you will say, "If only it were evening!"
And in the evening you will say, "If only it were morning!"
That is because of the fear that will fill your heart,
and because of the things that your eyes will see.
68 The LORD will bring you back to Egypt in ships,
on the road that I told you that you would never see again.
There you will try to sell yourselves to your enemies
as male and female slaves,
but no one will buy you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"This glorious and awesome name, the LORD your God": In the WEB, our English source text, the name here is written all in capital letters: "YAHWEH." That is the holy name of God, which we give as "the LORD."

The end is the opposite of the beginning: God had set Israel free from Egypt. Now a return to slavery threatens, and no one even wants them as slaves. The whole rescue would be undone.

Very important: This chapter was terribly misused in history. For centuries Christians claimed that the suffering of the Jews was a just punishment from God. With this they justified persecution, expulsion, and murder, all the way to the Holocaust. That was a terrible sin. No human being has the right to make himself the one who carries out a curse, or to declare the suffering of others "deserved."

These words were a warning to Moses' own people, spoken out of love, to protect them. And the Bible does not end here. Right in Chapter 30 God promises: If you turn back, I will gather you from wherever you have been scattered. God's last word is not the curse, but mercy.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 29

The covenant in the land of Moab

A second covenant VERSE 1

1 These are the words of the covenant that the LORD commanded Moses
to make with the people of Israel in the land of Moab.
It was in addition to the covenant that he had made with them at Horeb.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles this verse is the last verse of Chapter 28 (28:69). Then the whole of Chapter 29 is shifted by one verse: verse 2 here is verse 1 there, and so on up to verse 28. We follow the numbering of the WEB, our English source text.

At Horeb (Sinai) the covenant was made with the generation that came out of Egypt. Now, 40 years later, it is renewed with the new generation, just before they go into the land.

You have seen everything VERSES 2–9

2 Moses called all Israel together and said to them:
Your eyes have seen everything that the LORD did in the land of Egypt
to Pharaoh, to all his servants, and to his whole land.
3 Your eyes saw the great trials, the signs, and those great wonders.
4 But to this day the LORD has not given you a heart to understand,
eyes to see, and ears to hear.
5 I have led you for 40 years in the wilderness.
Your clothes have not worn out on you,
and your sandals have not worn out on your feet.
6 You have not eaten bread,
and you have not drunk wine or beer.
This was so that you would know that I am the LORD your God.
7 When you came to this place,
Sihon the king of Heshbon and Og the king of Bashan came out to fight against us,
and we defeated them.
8 We took their land
and gave it as an inheritance to the Reubenites, to the Gadites,
and to the half-tribe of the Manassites.
9 So keep the words of this covenant and do them.
Then you will succeed in everything you do.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4 is an honest and painful sentence: The people have seen so many wonders, and still they have not really understood. Deep understanding is a gift from God. You can see everything and still not grasp it. Jesus says something similar about such people: "seeing, they don't see" (Matthew 13:13–15).

In verses 5–6 Moses suddenly speaks as if God himself were speaking: "so that you would know that I am the LORD your God." Moses is God's mouthpiece.

"You have not eaten bread": This means no normal bread made from grain. God fed the people with manna.

Everyone stands before God VERSES 10–15

10 Today all of you are standing before the LORD your God:
your leaders, your tribes, your elders, and your officials,
all the men of Israel,
11 your little children, your wives,
and the foreigners who live in the middle of your camp,
from the one who chops your wood to the one who carries your water.
12 You are standing here to enter into the covenant of the LORD your God
and into his oath,
which the LORD your God is making with you today.
13 So today he will make you his people,
and he will be your God,

as he told you,
and as he swore to your ancestors, to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob.
14 I am not making this covenant and this oath only with you.
15 I am making it with those who are standing here with us today
before the LORD our God,
and also with those who are not here with us today.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: An oath is a solemn promise.

Everyone belongs: leaders and ordinary people, men, women, and children, even the foreigners who do the simplest work, chopping wood and carrying water. Before God everyone is equal.

Verse 15 is especially beautiful: The covenant also applies to "those who are not here with us today." This means the future generations. Jewish teachers say: Every Jewish person who will ever live was there on that day. The covenant still applies today.

Warning against a poisonous root VERSES 16–21

16 (For you know how we lived in the land of Egypt,
and how we passed through the middle of the nations that you went through.
17 And you have seen their terrible things,
and their idols of wood and stone, of silver and gold, that were among them.)
18 There must not be any man or woman, any family or tribe among you
whose heart turns away today from the LORD our God,
to go and serve the gods of those nations.
There must not be a root among you that produces bitter poison.
19 Such a person may hear the words of this curse.
But in his heart he blesses himself and says,
"Things will go well for me,
even though I live by my own stubborn heart."
This would destroy the wet together with the dry.
20 The LORD will not be willing to forgive him.
Instead, the anger of the LORD and his jealousy will smoke against that man.
Every curse that is written in this book will fall on him,
and the LORD will wipe out his name from under the sky.
21 The LORD will single him out from all the tribes of Israel for disaster,
according to all the curses of the covenant
that are written in this book of the law.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"A root … that produces bitter poison": One single person who falls away from God can pull others along, like a poisonous plant that spreads. The letter to the Hebrews takes up this picture (Hebrews 12:15).

The greatest danger is fooling yourself: "Nothing will happen to me." Whoever thinks like that does not take God seriously.

"Destroy the wet together with the dry" is an old saying. It probably means: destroy everything, with no exception. Or: One guilty person drags the innocent down to ruin too.

What the nations will say VERSES 22–28

22 The next generation, your children who grow up after you,
and the foreigner who comes from a faraway land,
will see the plagues of that land
and the sicknesses with which the LORD has made it sick.
23 They will say that its whole land is sulfur, salt, and burning.
Nothing is sown in it, nothing grows, and no grass comes up in it.
It is like the destruction of Sodom, Gomorrah, Admah, and Zeboiim,
which the LORD destroyed in his anger and his fury.
24 All the nations will ask,
"Why has the LORD done this to this land?
Why is his anger so great and so hot?"
25 Then people will say,
"Because they abandoned the covenant of the LORD, the God of their ancestors,
which he made with them when he brought them out of the land of Egypt.
26 They went and served other gods and worshiped them, gods that they did not know and that he had not given them.
27 That is why the anger of the LORD burned against this land,
and he brought on it all the curses that are written in this book.
28 In anger, in fury, and in great rage
the LORD pulled them out of their land by the roots and threw them into another land, as it is today."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sodom and Gomorrah were cities that God destroyed (Genesis 19). Admah and Zeboiim lay in the same region by the Dead Sea. To this day the landscape there is salty and bare.

Moses sees ahead that Israel will one day lose its land. Later the prophets and the people in exile in Babylon read these words and understood: It has happened just as Moses warned.

Here too, what was said about Chapter 28 applies: These words are a warning to Moses' own people. No one may use them to explain the suffering of the Jewish people as a "deserved punishment."

What is hidden and what is shown VERSE 29

29 The hidden things belong to the LORD our God.
But the things that he has shown us belong to us and to our children forever,
so that we may do all the words of this law.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A wise sentence at the end: We humans do not understand everything. Much remains God's secret, for example why something happens or what the future will bring. We may leave that to God.

But what God has shown us, we should do. We do not have to know everything in order to do what is right.

In the Hebrew Bible there are special dots written above some words of this verse. They show how important and mysterious this sentence was to the scribes of old.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 30

Turning back is possible – choose life!

If you turn back, God will gather you again VERSES 1–10

1 All these things will come on you,
the blessing and the curse that I have set before you.
Then you will think about them
among all the nations where the LORD your God has driven you.
2 You will turn back to the LORD your God
and listen to his voice,
just as I command you today,
you and your children,
with all your heart and with all your soul.
3 Then the LORD your God will set you free from captivity
and have mercy on you.
He will turn to you again and gather you
from all the peoples where the LORD your God has scattered you.
4 Even if your people who were driven out are at the very end of the sky,
the LORD your God will gather you from there,
and he will bring you back from there.
5 The LORD your God will bring you into the land that your ancestors owned,
and you will own it.
He will do you good,
and he will make you more in number than your ancestors.
6 The LORD your God will circumcise your heart
and the heart of your descendants.
Then you will love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul,
so that you may live.
7 The LORD your God will put all these curses on your enemies,
and on those who hate you and who persecuted you.
8 But you will turn back and listen to the voice of the LORD,
and do all his commandments that I command you today.
9 The LORD your God will give you success in all the work of your hands,
with many children, many young animals, and good crops from your ground.
For the LORD will again be glad to do you good,
as he was glad over your ancestors.
10 This will happen if you listen to the voice of the LORD your God
and keep his commandments and his rules
that are written in this book of the law,
and if you turn back to the LORD your God
with all your heart and with all your soul.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the heavy curses in Chapters 28 and 29, now comes a great hope: Even if everything seems lost, even if the people are scattered over the whole world, they can turn back. And then God will gather them again.

The word "turn back" (in Hebrew "shuv") comes up again and again in this section. It is one of the most important words of the Bible. Turning back means: turning to God again. And God also "turns" to his people again.

Verse 6 is a great promise: God himself will "circumcise" the heart, that is, open it. In 10:16 the people were supposed to do it themselves. Here God promises: I will do it for you. The prophets Jeremiah and Ezekiel later speak of a "new heart" that God will give (Jeremiah 31:33; Ezekiel 36:26).

God "is glad" to do good to his people. He does not like to punish. He likes to bless.

In all the centuries of being scattered, Jewish people have read these verses as a comfort.

God's word is very near VERSES 11–14

11 For this commandment that I command you today
is not too hard for you, and it is not too far away.
12 It is not in heaven,
so that you would have to say,
"Who will go up to heaven for us, bring it down to us,
and tell it to us, so that we can do it?"
13 It is also not on the other side of the sea,
so that you would have to say,
"Who will go across the sea for us, bring it to us,
and tell it to us, so that we can do it?"
14 No, the word is very near to you.
It is in your mouth and in your heart,
so that you can do it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A wonderful comfort: God's will is not out of reach. You do not have to climb up to heaven or travel to the end of the world to find it. You do not have to be a scholar. God's word is very near: in your mouth when you speak it, and in your heart when you love it.

That is also why it is so important that every person can read and understand the Bible in his or her own language.

Paul quotes these verses and says: The word is near, namely the word about faith in Jesus Christ (Romans 10:6–10).

Choose life! VERSES 15–20

15 Look, today I set before you life and good,
death and evil.
16 For today I command you to love the LORD your God,
to walk in his ways,
and to keep his commandments, his rules, and his laws.
Then you will live and become many,

and the LORD your God will bless you in the land
that you are going into to take over.
17 But your heart may turn away, and you may not listen.
You may let yourself be led away,
and worship other gods and serve them.
18 Then I tell you today: You will surely die.
You will not live long in the land
that you are crossing the Jordan to go into and take over.
19 Today I call heaven and earth as witnesses against you:
I have set before you life and death,
the blessing and the curse.
So choose life, so that you may live,
you and your descendants.
20 Choose to love the LORD your God,
to listen to his voice, and to hold on to him.
For he is your life and gives you a long life.
Then you will live in the land
that the LORD swore to give to your ancestors,
to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the high point of the great speeches of Moses. He sets the people before a decision between two ways: life or death, blessing or curse.

And then he says what he wishes for: "Choose life!" God forces no one. Every person has the freedom to choose. But God wishes with all his heart that we choose life.

What does "choose life" mean? Loving God, listening to him, and holding on to him. For: "He is your life." Whoever holds on to God holds on to the source of life.

This sentence "Choose life" has become a guiding word for many people to this day.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 31

Joshua is appointed – the law is written down

Be strong and brave VERSES 1–6

1 Moses went and spoke these words to all Israel.
2 He said to them,
"Today I am 120 years old.
I can no longer go out and come in.
And the LORD has said to me,
'You will not cross this Jordan.'
3 The LORD your God himself will cross over ahead of you.
He will destroy these nations in front of you,
and you will drive them out.
Joshua will cross over ahead of you,
as the LORD has said.
4 The LORD will do to them what he did to Sihon and Og,
the kings of the Amorites,
and to their land, when he destroyed them.
5 The LORD will hand them over to you.
And you shall do to them everything that I have commanded you.
6 Be strong and brave!
Do not be afraid of them, and do not be terrified of them.
For the LORD your God is the one who goes with you.
He will not let you down, and he will not abandon you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses is 120 years old. "I can no longer go out and come in" means: I can no longer lead the people. His life is coming to an end.

But the people do not need to be afraid. Moses was not the real leader. God was. And God stays.

"He will not let you down, and he will not abandon you": In the letter to the Hebrews this promise is spoken to all who believe (Hebrews 13:5). It is one of the most comforting words in the Bible.

Moses encourages Joshua VERSES 7–8

7 Moses called Joshua.
In front of all Israel he said to him,
"Be strong and brave!
For you will go with this people into the land
that the LORD swore to their ancestors to give them.
And you will give it to them as their inheritance.
8 The LORD himself is the one who goes ahead of you.
He will be with you.
He will not let you down, and he will not abandon you.
Do not be afraid.
Do not lose heart."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In front of all the people, Moses gives his successor courage. So everyone knows: Joshua is the new leader, and Moses stands behind him.

"Be strong and brave" is repeated many times in the book of Joshua (Joshua 1:6–9).

The law is to be read aloud every seven years VERSES 9–13

9 Moses wrote down this law.
He gave it to the priests, the sons of Levi,
who carried the ark of the LORD's covenant,
and to all the elders of Israel.
The ark is a holy chest.
10 Moses commanded them,
"At the end of every seven years,
at the set time of the year of release,
at the Feast of Booths,
11 all Israel will come to appear before the LORD your God
at the place that he will choose.
Then you shall read this law aloud in front of all Israel,
so that they hear it.
12 Gather the people together,
the men, the women, and the little children,
and the foreigners who live in your towns.
Then they will hear and learn,

and they will fear the LORD your God
and be careful to do all the words of this law.
13 And their children, who do not know it yet, will hear it.
They will learn to fear the LORD your God,
as long as you live in the land
that you are crossing the Jordan to take over."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses writes the law down. From now on, God's word is not only in his head, but in a book. That way it can be passed on, even when Moses dies.

Every seven years the whole law is to be read aloud in public. Back then only a few people could read. That is why reading aloud was so important.

And again: Everyone should listen, men, women, children, and foreigners. God's word is for everyone.

From this came the Jewish tradition of reading a section of the Torah aloud in the synagogue every week. In the course of a year, the whole Torah is read in this way.

God says ahead of time that Israel will be unfaithful
VERSES 14–18

14 The LORD said to Moses,
"Look, the days are coming near when you must die.
Call Joshua, and come and stand in the Tent of Meeting,
so that I can appoint him to his task."
So Moses and Joshua went and stood in the Tent of Meeting.
15 The LORD appeared in the Tent in a pillar of cloud.
And the pillar of cloud stood over the entrance of the Tent.
16 The LORD said to Moses,
"Look, you will soon die and join your ancestors.
And this people will get up and be unfaithful to me like a prostitute.
They will chase after the foreign gods of the land
that they are going into, to live among them.
They will leave me and break my covenant that I have made with them.
17 On that day my anger will burn against them.
I will leave them, and I will hide my face from them.
They will be eaten up,
and many disasters and troubles will come on them.
Then on that day they will say,
'Haven't these disasters come on us
because our God is not among us?'
18 On that day I will surely hide my face,
because of all the evil they have done,
because they have turned to other gods.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"You will soon die and join your ancestors": Word for word, the Hebrew says that Moses will "sleep" with his fathers. That is a gentle way of talking about death.

"Like a prostitute": The Bible often uses this harsh picture. God sees himself like a faithful husband. When his people run after other gods, it is like unfaithfulness in a marriage.

"Hide my face": God pulls back. People no longer feel that he is near. That is one of the worst experiences a person can have. Many psalms complain about it: Why do you hide your face from me? (Psalm 88:14; similar Psalm 13:1).

It is sad: God already knows now that the people will be unfaithful. Even so, he leads them into the land. That shows his great patience and love.

A song as a witness
VERSES 19–23

19 "Now write down this song for yourselves
and teach it to the people of Israel.
Put it in their mouths,
so that this song will be my witness against the people of Israel.
20 For I will bring them into the land that I swore to their ancestors,
a land flowing with milk and honey.
They will eat and be full and grow fat.
Then they will turn to other gods and serve them.
They will despise me and break my covenant.
21 Then many disasters and troubles will come on them.
And this song will speak against them as a witness,
for their descendants will not forget it.
For I know what they are planning even today,
before I have brought them into the land that I promised them."
22 So on that day Moses wrote down this song
and taught it to the people of Israel.
23 And he appointed Joshua the son of Nun to his task and said,
"Be strong and brave!
For you will bring the people of Israel into the land that I swore to them.
And I will be with you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

You do not forget a song as quickly as a speech. You sing it, you learn it by heart, you pass it on to your children. That is why Moses is to write a song. It follows in Chapter 32.

Later, when the people are in trouble, they will remember the song and understand: God warned us. But the song also ends with hope.

In verse 23 God himself speaks to Joshua: "And I will be with you."

The book beside the ark of the covenant
VERSES 24–30

24 Moses finished writing the words of this law in a book,
all the way to the end.
25 Then Moses commanded the Levites,
who carried the ark of the LORD's covenant,
26 "Take this book of the law
and put it beside the ark of the covenant of the LORD your God,
so that it will be there as a witness against you.
27 For I know how rebellious and stubborn you are.
Look, even today, while I am still alive with you,
you have rebelled against the LORD.
How much more will you do it after my death!
28 Gather to me all the elders of your tribes and your officials.
Then I will speak these words so that they can hear them,
and I will call heaven and earth as witnesses against them.
29 For I know that after my death you will become completely corrupt
and turn away from the way that I have commanded you.

And in the days to come, disaster will come on you,
because you will do what is evil in the eyes of the LORD
and make him angry by what your hands have made."
30 Then Moses spoke the words of this song from
beginning to end,
so that the whole assembly of Israel heard them:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the ark of the covenant lay the two stone tablets with the Ten Commandments. The whole book of the law is placed beside it. So it is kept in the holiest place.

Moses speaks very honestly, almost sadly. He knows his people well. He knows how often they have rebelled against God.

Later, in the time of King Josiah, a "book of the law" that had long been forgotten was found again in the temple. When it was read aloud, the king was shocked and renewed the covenant with God (2 Kings 22–23).

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 32

The song of Moses

Listen, heaven and earth! VERSES 1–4

1 Listen, you heavens, and I will speak!
Let the earth hear the words of my mouth!
2 Let my teaching fall like rain.
Let my words come down like the dew,
like gentle rain on young grass,
like showers on the plants.
3 For I will announce the name of the LORD.
Tell how great our God is!
4 The Rock: His work is perfect,
for all his ways are just.
He is a faithful God who does no wrong.
He is fair and right.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the song that Moses is to teach the people (31:19). It is a poem with strong pictures. It tells the story between God and his people: God's faithfulness, Israel's unfaithfulness, the punishment, and in the end the rescue.

God's word should be like gentle rain that makes the grass grow. It should not crush, but bring life.

"The Rock": That is the most important picture for God in this song. It comes up again and again. A rock is firm, safe, and cannot be shaken. You can build on it. You can rely on it.

An ungrateful people VERSES 5–6

5 They have acted wickedly against him.
They are not his children, because of their fault.
They are a twisted and crooked generation.
6 Is this how you pay back the LORD,
you foolish people without wisdom?
Is he not your father, who bought you?
He made you, and he set you firmly in place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The contrast is great: God is perfect and faithful. The people are twisted and unfaithful.

Here God is called "father." That is still rare in the Old Testament. He "bought" Israel, that is, he set them free from slavery, like a father who pays to free his child.

How God found his people and carried them VERSES 7–14

7 Remember the days of long ago.
Think about the years of many generations.
Ask your father, and he will show you.
Ask your elders, and they will tell you.
8 When the Most High gave the nations their
inheritance,
when he divided up the human race,
he set the borders of the peoples
according to the number of the people of Israel.
9 For the LORD's share is his people.
Jacob is the part he chose as his own.
10 He found him in a desert land,
in an empty wilderness where the wind howls.
He put his arms around him and took care of him.
He guarded him like the pupil of his eye.
11 Like an eagle that stirs up its nest
and hovers over its young,
he spread out his wings and took them.
He carried them on his feathers.
12 The LORD alone led him.
No foreign god was with him.
13 He let him ride over the heights of the earth.
He ate the crops of the field.
He let him suck honey out of the rock,
and oil out of the hard stone,
14 butter from the cattle and milk from the flock,
with the fat of lambs,
rams of the breed of Bashan, and goats,
with the finest wheat.
And you drank wine from the blood of the grapes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Like the usual Hebrew text, the WEB, our English source text, says "according to the number of the people of Israel." But old manuscripts from the Dead Sea and the Greek translation say: according to the number of the sons of God. Then it would mean: God divided up all the nations, but he kept his own people for himself.

"Like the pupil of his eye": The eye is the most sensitive part we have. We protect it at once when it is in danger. That is how God protects his people. The WEB says "the apple of his eye." People still use this phrase today.

The picture of the eagle (verse 11) is one of the most beautiful in the Bible: An eagle teaches its young to fly. It stirs them out of the nest. When they fall, it flies under them and catches them on its wings. That is how God led Israel through the wilderness: He challenged them, but never let them fall.

"Honey out of the rock": In cracks in the rocks there were sometimes wild bees. God gave his people good things even in barren places.

The people grow fat and forget God VERSES 15–18

15 But Jeshurun grew fat and kicked.
You grew fat, thick, and well fed.
Then he left God, who made him,
and rejected the Rock who saved him.
16 They made him jealous with foreign gods.
They made him angry with things he hates.
17 They sacrificed to demons, not to God,
to gods that they did not know,
to new gods that had come along only recently,
gods that your ancestors did not fear.
18 You forgot the Rock who became your father.
You forgot the God who gave birth to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Jeshurun" is a loving name for Israel. It means something like "the upright one." The very one who should be upright becomes unfaithful. That sounds almost ironic.

The picture: An animal that is fed well becomes wild and kicks with its hooves. In the same way, Israel becomes proud in its wealth and forgets God. We already know this danger from Chapter 8.

Verse 18 is amazing: Here God is compared with a father who fathers a child and with a mother who gives birth. God's love is like the love of a father and a mother at the same time.

God hides his face VERSES 19–27

19 The LORD saw it, and he rejected them,
because his sons and his daughters had made him angry.
20 He said, "I will hide my face from them.
I will see what their end will be.
For they are a very twisted generation,
children who are not faithful.
21 They have made me jealous with what is not a god.
They have made me angry with their worthless idols.
So I will make them jealous with those who are not a people.
I will make them angry with a foolish nation.
22 For a fire has been lit by my anger.
It burns down to the lowest depths of Sheol (the world of the dead).
It eats up the earth and its crops,
and it sets the foundations of the mountains on fire.
23 I will pile disasters on them.
I will shoot all my arrows at them.
24 They will waste away from hunger.
They will be eaten up by burning fever and bitter disease.
I will send the teeth of wild animals against them,
and the poison of snakes that crawl in the dust.
25 Outside, the sword will take their children.
And in the rooms there will be terror
for the young man and the young woman,
for the baby at the breast and for the man with gray hair.
26 I said I would scatter them far away.
I would wipe out the memory of them among people,
27 if I did not fear what the enemy would do to provoke me.
Their enemies might misunderstand it.
They might say, 'Our own power has won.
The LORD has not done all this.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Hebrew the world of the dead is called "Sheol." Back then people imagined that the dead were in a dark place under the earth.

Verse 21: "Those who are not a people": Israel made God jealous with "not-gods." So God will make Israel jealous with a "not-people." Paul later explains it like this: God turns to the other nations, so that Israel becomes jealous and finds its way back to him (Romans 10:19; 11:11).

Verses 26–27: God could destroy his people completely. But he does not do it. Why? Otherwise the enemies would think that they had won by their own strength. God's name and honor are at stake. And behind this stands his faithfulness: He does not give up his people completely.

The enemies do not understand it VERSES 28–35

28 For they are a nation without good sense.
There is no understanding in them.
29 If only they were wise and understood this!
If only they would think about how things will end for them!
30 How could 1 man chase 1,000,
and 2 put 10,000 to flight,
unless their Rock had sold them,
and the LORD had handed them over?
31 For their rock is not like our Rock.
Even our enemies have to admit it.
32 For their vine comes from the vine of Sodom
and from the fields of Gomorrah.
Their grapes are poisonous grapes.
Their bunches are bitter.
33 Their wine is the poison of snakes,
the cruel poison of cobras.
34 "Is this not stored up with me,
sealed up in my treasure rooms?
35 Revenge belongs to me, and paying back,
at the time when their foot slips.
For the day of their disaster is near.
What is coming for them is rushing toward them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

It is not quite clear who is meant in verses 28–33: Israel or the enemies. Many interpreters think: first Israel, who does not understand why it is losing. Then the enemies, whose "rock," that is, their gods, is worthless, and whose wickedness is like poisonous wine.

Verse 30: Israel was not defeated because the enemies were so strong, but because God no longer protected his people.

"Revenge belongs to me": That is a very important sentence. It means: Revenge is God's business, not the business of people. Paul quotes it and says: "Don't seek revenge yourselves, beloved, but leave room for God's anger" (Romans 12:19). So this sentence actually forbids human revenge.

God has mercy VERSES 36–43

36 For the LORD will bring justice to his people
and have mercy on his servants,
when he sees that their strength is gone
and no one is left, neither slave nor free.
37 He will say, "Where are their gods,
the rock in which they looked for safety,
38 the gods who ate the fat of their sacrifices
and drank the wine of their drink offerings?
Let them get up and help you!
Let them protect you!
39 Now see that I, I am he.
There is no god beside me.
I kill, and I make alive.
I wound, and I heal.
And no one can rescue anyone from my hand.
40 For I lift up my hand to heaven and say:
As surely as I live forever,
41 when I sharpen my flashing sword
and my hand takes hold of it to judge,
I will take revenge on my enemies,
and I will pay back those who hate me.
42 I will make my arrows drunk with blood.
My sword will eat flesh,
with the blood of the dead and of the prisoners,
from the heads of the enemy's leaders."
43 Rejoice, you nations, with his people!
For he will avenge the blood of his servants.
He will take revenge on his enemies,
and he will make atonement for his land and for his
people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The turning point: When the people are at the very end, without strength and without hope, God has mercy. The false gods did not help. But the true God helps.

"I kill, and I make alive. I wound, and I heal": Everything lies in God's hand, life and death. But the goal is life and healing.

The pictures in verses 41–42 are very harsh: God as a warrior with sword and arrows. These are pictures from the language of that time. They say: God will not let evil go unpunished. He stands on the side of the oppressed. But these pictures are no call for people to use violence. Revenge remains God's business alone (verse 35).

At the end there is a surprising call: "Rejoice, you nations, with his people!" The other nations too should share in the joy. Paul quotes this verse as a sign that God's rescue is for all nations (Romans 15:10).

The last word of the song is "atonement." Atonement means: God takes away the guilt and makes peace again.

The law is your life VERSES 44–47

44 Moses came and spoke all the words of this song
so that the people heard them,
he and Joshua the son of Nun.
45 When Moses had finished speaking all these words to all
Israel,
46 he said to them,
"Take to heart all the words that I am warning you
with today.
You shall command your children
to be careful to do all the words of this law.
47 For this is not an empty word for you.
It is your life.
And through this word you will live a long time in the
land
that you are crossing the Jordan to take over."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In verse 44 the Hebrew text does not say Joshua, but Hoshea. That was Joshua's original name (Numbers 13:16). The WEB, our English source text, writes "Joshua."

"This is not an empty word for you. It is your life": That is what Moses leaves behind for his people. God's word is not just a collection of rules. It is the foundation of life.

Moses is to climb Mount Nebo VERSES 48–52

48 On that same day the LORD spoke to Moses.
He said,
49 "Go up into these mountains of Abarim, to Mount
Nebo.
It is in the land of Moab, across from Jericho.
Look at the land of Canaan,
which I am giving to the people of Israel to own.
50 Die on the mountain that you climb,
and be gathered to your people,
just as your brother Aaron died on Mount Hor
and was gathered to his people.
51 This is because you were unfaithful to me among the
people of Israel
at the waters of Meribah of Kadesh, in the wilderness
of Zin.
You did not honor me as holy among the people of
Israel.
52 You will see the land from far away.
But you will not go into the land that I am giving to
the people of Israel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the time has come. Moses is to climb a mountain, see the land from above, and then die.

Mount Nebo is in today's Jordan. From its top, in clear weather, you can see far into the land, across the Jordan Valley to Jericho, and, it is said, on good days as far as the mountains of Jerusalem.

"Be gathered to your people": That is how the Bible speaks of death. You do not go into nothingness, but to those who have gone ahead of you.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 33

Moses blesses the tribes of Israel

God came from Sinai VERSES 1–5

1 This is the blessing with which Moses, the man of God,
blessed the people of Israel before his death.
2 He said,
"The LORD came from Sinai,
and he rose like the sun over them from Seir.
He shone out from Mount Paran.
He came from among tens of thousands of holy ones.
At his right hand was a fiery law for them.
3 Yes, he loves the people.
All his holy ones are in your hand.
They sat down at your feet.
Each one receives your words.
4 Moses gave us a law,
an inheritance for the assembly of Jacob.
5 He was king in Jeshurun,
when the leaders of the people gathered,
all the tribes of Israel together.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before Moses dies, he blesses the tribes, just as Jacob blessed his sons before his death (Genesis 49).

"Man of God": That is a title of honor for prophets. Here Moses is called this for the first time.

God is described like the sun that rises over the mountains in the south: Sinai, Seir, Paran. He comes with his angels, the "holy ones."

"He loves the people": That is what the WEB, our English source text, says. The Hebrew has "peoples," in the plural. Perhaps the tribes of Israel are meant.

Verses 2–5 are very hard to understand in Hebrew. That is why Bibles translate these verses in very different ways.

"He was king in Jeshurun": This probably means God himself. He is the real king of Israel.

Reuben, Judah, and Levi VERSES 6–11

6 "Let Reuben live and not die.
And do not let his men be few."
7 And this is for Judah. He said,
"LORD, hear the voice of Judah.
Bring him to his people.
With his own hands he fought for himself.
Be his help against his enemies."
8 About Levi he said,
"Your Thummim and your Urim belong to your faithful man,
whom you tested at Massah,
with whom you quarreled at the waters of Meribah.
9 He said about his father and his mother,
'I have not seen him.'
He did not treat his brothers as his own,
and he did not know his own children.
For they have kept your word,
and they keep your covenant.
10 They will teach Jacob your laws,
and Israel your teaching.
They will put incense before you,
and whole burnt offerings on your altar.
11 LORD, bless his skills.
Accept the work of his hands.
Crush the hips of those who rise up against him,
of those who hate him,
so that they do not rise again."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Reuben was Jacob's firstborn, but he had lost his first place through a serious sin (Genesis 49:3–4). Moses asks: Let him live anyway, and do not let his tribe die out.

Judah: From this tribe later comes King David. And according to the New Testament, Jesus too.

Simeon is not named. This tribe later became part of the tribe of Judah.

Verse 10: Incense is something that gives off a sweet smell when it burns.

Levi: The "Urim and Thummim" were holy lots of the high priest, used to ask what God wanted (Exodus 28:30).

Verse 9 reminds us of the story of the golden calf: The Levites took God's side, even against their own relatives (Exodus 32:26–29). Being faithful to God mattered more to them than family.

The task of the Levites: to teach the people and to lead worship.

Benjamin and Joseph VERSES 12–17

12 About Benjamin he said,
"The one whom the LORD loves will live safely beside him.
He protects him all day long.
He lives between his shoulders."
13 About Joseph he said,
"His land is blessed by the LORD
with the best gifts of heaven, with the dew,
and with the deep water that lies below,
14 with the best things that the sun brings out,
with the best things that the moon makes grow,
15 with the best things of the ancient mountains,
with the best things of the hills that last forever,
16 with the best things of the earth and everything in it,
and with the favor of the one who lived in the bush.
Let all this come on the head of Joseph,
on the top of the head of the one who was set apart from his brothers.
17 He is like a firstborn bull, full of majesty.
His horns are the horns of the wild ox.
With them he will push the peoples,
all of them, to the ends of the earth.
They are the tens of thousands of Ephraim.
They are the thousands of Manasseh."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Benjamin was Jacob's youngest and most beloved son. "He lives between his shoulders": Maybe that is a picture of a child whom the father carries on his shoulders. Or it means: The temple in Jerusalem later lay at the border of the land of Benjamin, "between his hills."

Joseph gets the richest blessing: everything good from heaven, from the earth, from the sun and the moon.

"The one who lived in the bush": That reminds us of the story in which God appeared to Moses in the burning bush (Exodus 3). It is the only place where Moses later mentions it again.

"The one who was set apart from his brothers": Joseph was sold to Egypt by his brothers (Genesis 37).

Ephraim and Manasseh are the two sons of Joseph. They became two large tribes.

Zebulun, Issachar, Gad, Dan, Naphtali, and Asher
VERSES 18–25

18 About Zebulun he said,
"Be glad, Zebulun, when you go out,
and you, Issachar, in your tents.
19 They will call the peoples to the mountain.
There they will offer the right sacrifices.
For they will draw out the riches of the seas
and the hidden treasures in the sand."
20 About Gad he said,
"Blessed is the one who gives Gad more room.
He lives like a lioness
and tears off the arm and the top of the head.
21 He chose the first part for himself,
because the leader's share was kept for him there.
He came with the heads of the people.
He carried out what the LORD said was right,
and his laws together with Israel."
22 About Dan he said,
"Dan is a young lion that leaps out of Bashan."
23 About Naphtali he said,
"Naphtali, filled with favor
and full of the LORD's blessing,
take over the west and the south."
24 About Asher he said,
"Asher is blessed with children.
Let his brothers welcome him.
Let him dip his foot in oil.
25 Your bars on the gates will be iron and bronze.
As your days are, so your strength will be.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zebulun and Issachar later lived in the north, near the sea. "The riches of the seas" and "the hidden treasures in the sand" may mean fishing, trade, and the glass that was made from sand.

Gad received the land east of the Jordan as the "first part" (Numbers 32). Even so, he fought together with the other tribes: "He came with the heads of the people" (Deuteronomy 33:21).

"Let him dip his foot in oil": Asher later received a region with many olive trees. So much oil that you could bathe in it.

"As your days are, so your strength will be": A beautiful blessing that many people take with them as a comfort. It means: God gives you as much strength for each day as you need.

No one is like God VERSES 26–29

26 "No one is like God, Jeshurun.
He rides across the heavens to help you,
and in his majesty across the skies.
27 The eternal God is your home.
Underneath are the everlasting arms.
He drove out the enemy ahead of you
and said, 'Destroy!'
28 Israel lives in safety,
the spring of Jacob by itself,
in a land of grain and new wine.
Yes, his heavens drip with dew.
29 How happy you are, Israel!
Who is like you, a people saved by the LORD?
He is the shield that helps you
and the sword that gives you glory.
Your enemies will bow down to you,
and you will walk on their high places."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end, it is not a tribe but God himself who stands at the center.

Verse 27 is one of the most beautiful words in the whole Bible: "The eternal God is your home. Underneath are the everlasting arms." God is like a house in which you are safe. And when you fall, he catches you with his arms. This verse is often read at funerals and in hard times.

"How happy you are, Israel!": The last words of Moses to his people are not a warning, but a blessing of happiness.

DEUTERONOMY

CHAPTER 34

The death of Moses

Moses sees the land VERSES 1–4

1 Moses went up from the plains of Moab to Mount Nebo,
to the top of Pisgah, which is across from Jericho.
And the LORD showed him the whole land:
Gilead as far as Dan,
2 all of Naphtali, the land of Ephraim and Manasseh,
and the whole land of Judah as far as the Western Sea,
3 the south, and the plain, the valley of Jericho,
the city of palm trees, as far as Zoar.
4 The LORD said to him,
"This is the land that I swore to Abraham, to Isaac, and
to Jacob,
when I said,
'I will give it to your descendants.'
I have let you see it with your own eyes.
But you will not go over there."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God himself shows Moses the whole land, from north to south. It is as if God took him by the hand and said: Look, I promised all this, and now I am keeping my promise. Moses may not go in. But he sees the goal he has been walking toward for 40 years. The promise to Abraham is almost fulfilled.

Moses dies VERSES 5–8

5 So Moses, the servant of the LORD, died there in the
land of Moab,
as the LORD had said.

6 And he buried him in the valley in the land of Moab,
across from Beth Peor.
But to this day no one knows where his grave is.
7 Moses was 120 years old when he died.
His eyes had not grown weak,
and his strength was not gone.
8 The people of Israel wept for Moses in the plains of
Moab for 30 days.
Then the days of weeping and mourning for Moses
came to an end.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The servant of the LORD": That is the highest title of honor for Moses. He served God his whole life.

"As the LORD had said": The Hebrew literally says "according to the mouth of the LORD." Jewish teachers made a beautiful picture from this: Moses died by a kiss from God.

"He buried him": God himself buried Moses. No one knows his grave. Maybe this was so that no one would make a cult of Moses and worship at his grave. Moses always wanted to point to God, not to himself.

At 120 years old, Moses was still healthy and strong. He did not die because he was too weak, but because his time had come according to God's will.

The people mourned for 30 days. To this day, Judaism has a time of mourning of 30 days after the death of someone close.

Joshua takes over VERSE 9

9 Joshua the son of Nun was full of the spirit of wisdom,
because Moses had laid his hands on him.
And the people of Israel listened to him
and did what the LORD had commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Life goes on. God's work does not depend on one single person. Moses appointed a successor in good time, and the people follow him.

No prophet was like Moses VERSES 10–12

10 Since then, no prophet like Moses has risen in Israel.
The LORD knew him face to face.
11 No one else did all the signs and wonders
that the LORD sent him to do in the land of Egypt,
to Pharaoh, to all his servants, and to his whole land.
12 No one else showed such great power
or did such great and awesome deeds
as Moses did in front of all Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

That is the last word about Moses: There was no prophet like him. No one else knew God as closely, "face to face."

Who wrote these last verses? Moses can hardly have described his own death. Jewish scholars already said in the Talmud: Joshua wrote the last eight verses. Others think that Moses wrote them in tears, because God dictated them to him. Many scholars today think that the five books of Moses grew over a longer period of time.

In Chapter 18 Moses had promised: God will send a prophet like me. At the end of the book it says: So far no one has come. That is why Israel waited for this prophet. Christians believe that Jesus is this prophet (Acts 3:22). The Gospel of John says: "The law was given through Moses. Grace and truth came through Jesus Christ" (John 1:17).

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Deuteronomy?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Deuteronomy is the farewell book of Moses. At the Jordan, shortly before his death, he speaks once more to all the people:

1. He reminds them of the journey through the wilderness: of God's faithfulness and of the people's unfaithfulness (Chapters 1–4).

2. He repeats the Ten Commandments and the most important commandment: "Hear, Israel: The LORD is our God. The LORD is one. You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your strength" (Chapters 5–11).

3. He explains the commandments for life in the land: for worship and feasts, for courts and kings, for the family, and above all for protecting the weak: the poor, the foreigners, the orphans, and the widows (Chapters 12–26).

4. He sets before the people the choice between blessing and curse, and he calls out: "Choose life!" (Chapters 27–30).

5. He appoints Joshua, sings his song, blesses the tribes, and dies (Chapters 31–34).

The book also contains hard and dark texts, about war, about punishments, and about how to treat other nations. We have not left them out, but we have explained them honestly. They belong to a distant time, and no one may use them to justify violence or hatred.

The main message of the book is love: God loves his people, not because they are great or good, but simply because he does. And he wishes that his people love him too, and that all people live together with justice and mercy, especially with the weakest. "For you yourselves were foreigners in the land of Egypt."

Looking back: The five books of Moses, the Torah

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With this chapter the five books of Moses come to an end. Jewish people call them together the "Torah," which means "instruction." They are the most important part of the Hebrew Bible. In every synagogue the Torah is kept as a handwritten scroll in the holy ark.

Genesis: God creates the world and human beings. He calls Abraham and promises him a land and many descendants.

Exodus: God sets his people free from slavery in Egypt, makes a covenant with them at Sinai, and gives them the Ten Commandments.

Leviticus: God shows how a holy people can live with a holy God. Right in the middle of it: "You shall love your neighbor as yourself."

Numbers: The people wander through the wilderness for 40 years. They doubt and complain, but God stays faithful.

Deuteronomy: Moses says goodbye and calls out: "Choose life!"

The Torah does not end in the promised land, but just before it. The people are standing at the Jordan. The goal is in sight, but not reached yet. It is often like that with faith too: You are on the way, with God's promise in your hand.

And when Jewish people finish the last verse at the feast of "Simchat Torah," they start again from the beginning right

> away: “In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth.” God’s word is never finished being read.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 6 OF 66

JOSHUA

24 CHAPTERS

JOSHUA

Chapter 1

Be strong and courageous!

Before we begin: What is the book of Joshua?

The book of Joshua is named after its main person: Joshua, who came after Moses as leader. The name "Joshua" means "The LORD saves." It is the same name as "Jesus" in its Hebrew form.

The book tells how Israel finally comes into the promised land. The people cross the Jordan, the walls of Jericho fall, and the land is divided among the 12 tribes. What God promised to Abraham now comes true.

The book also has many reports of war. Some of them are very hard to bear, because women and children are killed too. We do not leave these passages out. We explain them honestly. Many scholars also think that the conquest really happened more slowly and with less violence than the book describes in its language. One thing is clear: No one may use these reports to justify violence or war today.

At the end of the book, Joshua lets the people choose whom they want to serve. And he says the famous sentence: "As for me and my house, we will serve the LORD" (Joshua 24:15).

In the Jewish Bible, the book of Joshua belongs to the "Former Prophets." In Christian Bibles, it stands at the beginning of the "History Books."

God speaks to Joshua VERSES 1–9

1 After the death of Moses, the servant of the LORD,
the LORD spoke to Joshua, the son of Nun, who had
served Moses. He said,
2 "Moses my servant is dead.
So now get up and go across this Jordan, you and all
these people,
into the land that I am giving to them, to the people of
Israel.
3 I have given you every place that the sole of your foot
will step on,
as I told Moses.
4 From the wilderness and this Lebanon to the great
river, the river Euphrates,
all the land of the Hittites,
and to the great sea in the west, where the sun goes
down, will be your border.
5 No one will be able to stand against you all the days of
your life.
As I was with Moses, so I will be with you.
I will not fail you, and I will not leave you.
6 Be strong and courageous!
For you will lead this people to receive the land as their
inheritance,
the land that I swore to their ancestors to give them.
7 Only be strong and very courageous!
Be careful to do everything the law says that Moses my
servant commanded you.
Do not turn from it to the right or to the left,
so that you may have success wherever you go.
8 This book of the law must not leave your mouth.
You must think about it day and night,
so that you are careful to do everything that is written
in it.
For then everything you do will go well,
and then you will have success.
9 Haven't I commanded you? Be strong and courageous!
Don't be afraid. Don't lose heart,
for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses, the great leader, is dead. For the people, this is a great loss. Now Joshua has to fill very big shoes.

God tells him three times: "Be strong and courageous!" Joshua is probably afraid. But God promises: "As I was with Moses, so I will be with you." Joshua does not have to be like Moses. He only has to trust God.

The strength does not come from Joshua himself. It comes from two sources: from God being with him ("the LORD your God is with you") and from God's word ("think about it day and night").

"Think about it" here means: think about God's word again and again, say it quietly to yourself, and keep it in your heart. Psalm 1 says the same about a happy person.

The large area up to the Euphrates is a promise that Israel reached only for a short time, under King Solomon. It is not a map for politics today.

To this day, verse 9 comforts many people, for example before a hard task, a move, or an operation.

Get ready! VERSES 10–11

10 Then Joshua commanded the officers of the people:
11 "Go through the middle of the camp and command the
people:
'Get food ready for the journey.
For in three days you will cross this Jordan,
to go in and take the land
that the LORD your God is giving you to own.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joshua does not wait. He gives the first commands right away. God's word has given him courage.

The tribes east of the Jordan keep their word VERSES 12–18

12 Joshua spoke to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the
half-tribe of Manasseh. He said,
13 "Remember the word that Moses, the servant of the
LORD, commanded you, when he said,
'The LORD your God gives you rest and will give you
this land.
14 Your wives, your little ones, and your livestock will
stay in the land
that Moses gave you beyond the Jordan.

But all of you brave warriors must cross over armed in
front of your brothers and help them,
15 until the LORD has given your brothers rest, as he has
given you,
and until they also have taken the land that the LORD
your God is giving them.
Then you may return to the land that belongs to you
and own it,
the land that Moses, the servant of the LORD, gave you
beyond the Jordan, toward the sunrise.'"
16 They answered Joshua,
"We will do everything you have commanded us,
and we will go wherever you send us.
17 Just as we listened to Moses in everything, so we will
listen to you.
Only may the LORD your God be with you, as he was
with Moses.
18 Whoever rebels against your command
and does not listen to your words in everything you
command him must be put to death.
Only be strong and courageous!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joshua reminds the two and a half tribes of their promise from Numbers 32: They already have their land, but they still fight together with their brothers.

And they keep their word. They stand behind the new leader. At the end, they even tell him what God told him: "Only be strong and courageous!" So Joshua is encouraged not only by God but also by his people.

The harsh threat in verse 18 shows how serious the situation was before a war. Unity was a matter of life and death.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 2

Rahab and the spies

Two spies in Jericho VERSES 1–7

1 Joshua, the son of Nun, secretly sent two men out of
Shittim as spies. He said,
"Go and look at the land, and Jericho too."
They went and came into the house of a prostitute
whose name was Rahab.
They spent the night there.
2 Someone told the king of Jericho,
"Look, men from the people of Israel came here
tonight to spy out the land."
3 So the king of Jericho sent a message to Rahab:
"Bring out the men who came to you, who went into
your house.
For they have come to spy out the whole land."
4 But the woman took the two men and hid them.
Then she said, "Yes, the men came to me,
but I didn't know where they came from.
5 When it was dark, at the time to shut the city gate, the
men went out.
I don't know where the men went.
Chase them quickly. You may still catch them."
6 But she had brought them up to the roof
and hidden them under the stalks of flax that she had
laid out on the roof.
7 The men chased them on the road to the fords of the
Jordan River.
Fords are shallow places where people can walk
through a river.
As soon as the chasers had gone out, the gate was shut.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jericho is one of the oldest cities in the world. It lies in an oasis by the Jordan, right across from Israel's camp.

Rahab was a prostitute. The spies may have gone to her house because strange men often came and went there, so they were not noticed.

Rahab lies to protect the men. Jews and Christians have thought a lot about whether this lie was right. Many say: She risked her life to save people. Later, people did something similar in the time of the Nazis, when they hid Jews and lied to those hunting them.

"Flax" is a plant used to make linen cloth. People laid the stalks on the flat roofs to dry.

Rahab's confession of faith VERSES 8–14

8 Before the men lay down to sleep, she came up to them
on the roof.
9 She said to the men,
"I know that the LORD has given you the land.
Fear of you has fallen on us,
and all the people who live in the land are melting away
with fear because of you.
10 For we have heard how the LORD dried up the water of
the Red Sea in front of you
when you came out of Egypt.
And we heard what you did to the two kings of the
Amorites beyond the Jordan,
to Sihon and to Og, whom you completely destroyed.
11 As soon as we heard it, our hearts melted,
and no one had any courage left because of you.
For the LORD your God is God in heaven above and on
earth below.
12 So now, please swear to me by the LORD:
Because I have been kind to you, you will also be kind
to my father's family.
Give me a sure sign
13 that you will let my father, my mother, my brothers,
and my sisters live,
and everyone who belongs to them,
and that you will save us from death."
14 The men said to her,
"Our lives for yours, if you don't tell anyone about our
business.
And when the LORD gives us the land,
we will be kind and faithful to you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rahab is a woman from a foreign people, and a prostitute. Yet she speaks one of the most beautiful confessions of faith in the Bible: "The LORD your God is God in heaven above and on earth below." These are almost the same words Moses used (Deuteronomy 4:39).

She heard about God's great deeds and drew the right conclusion. All the people of Jericho heard the same thing, but only Rahab trusts it.

She does not think only of herself but of her whole family.

"Kindness" in Hebrew is "chesed." It means faithfulness, love, and kindness that people owe each other. It is a word that is often used for God's faithfulness.

The scarlet cord VERSES 15–21

15 Then she let the men down through the window with a rope.
For her house was built into the city wall, and she lived in the wall.
16 She said to them,
"Go to the hills, so that the chasers don't find you.
Hide there for three days, until the chasers have come back.
After that, you can go on your way."
17 The men said to her,
"We will be free from this oath that you made us swear, unless you do this:
18 Look, when we come into the land,
tie this cord of scarlet thread in the window that you let us down through.
And gather your father, your mother, your brothers, and your father's whole family into your house.
19 If anyone goes out of the door of your house into the street,
his blood will be on his own head, and we will not be guilty.
But if anyone who is with you in the house is harmed, his blood will be on our head.
20 But if you tell anyone about our business,
then we will be free from the oath that you made us swear."
21 She said, "Let it be as you have said."
She sent them away, and they left.
Then she tied the scarlet cord in the window.
Scarlet means bright red.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rahab's house was part of the city wall. That is why she could let the men out directly to the outside.

The scarlet cord in the window is a sign of rescue. Many interpreters think of the Passover in Egypt: There, the red blood on the doorposts was the sign that death would pass over that house (Exodus 12). Whoever stays in the house is safe.

Rahab ties the cord right away, not later. She trusts the promise.

The spies return VERSES 22–24

22 They went into the hills and stayed there three days, until the chasers had gone back.
The chasers searched for them all along the road, but they did not find them.
23 Then the two men turned back, came down from the hills,
crossed the river, and came to Joshua, the son of Nun.
They told him everything that had happened to them.
24 They said to Joshua,
"The LORD has truly given the whole land into our hands.
And all the people who live in the land are melting away with fear because of us."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What a difference from the spies 40 years earlier! Back then, 10 of the 12 came back full of fear (Numbers 13). Now the spies bring a message full of trust.

Rahab is saved later (Chapter 6). She marries an Israelite. In the New Testament, she appears in the family tree of Jesus: She was the mother of Boaz, and so an ancestor of King David (Matthew 1:5). The letter to the Hebrews and the letter of James praise her for her faith (Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25).

God writes history with people whom others look down on.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 3

Crossing the Jordan

Follow the ark of the covenant VERSES 1–6

1 Joshua got up early in the morning.
They set out from Shittim and came to the Jordan, he and all the people of Israel.
They camped there before they crossed over.
2 After three days, the officers went through the middle of the camp
3 and commanded the people:
"When you see the ark of the covenant of the LORD your God,
and the Levitical priests carrying it,
then leave your place and follow it.
4 But keep a space of about 3,000 feet between you and it.
Don't come closer to it.
Then you will know which way to go.
For you have never gone this way before."
5 Joshua said to the people,
"Make yourselves holy, for tomorrow the LORD will do wonders among you."
6 Joshua said to the priests,
"Pick up the ark of the covenant and cross over in front of the people."
So they picked up the ark of the covenant and went in front of the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says: 2,000 cubits. A cubit is about 18 inches.

The ark of the covenant was the sign that God was present. It goes first. The people follow it. Faith is like that too: God goes first, and we follow.

The large space has two reasons: out of deep respect for God's holiness, and so that everyone can see the ark, even those at the very back.

"You have never gone this way before": Before a new stage of life, this sentence can be a real comfort. We do not know the way, but God knows it.

"Make yourselves holy" means: Get ready to meet God, for example by washing and praying.

God is with Joshua VERSES 7–13

7 The LORD said to Joshua,
"Today I will begin to make you great in the eyes of all Israel,
so that they may know that as I was with Moses, so I will be with you.
8 Command the priests who carry the ark of the covenant:
'When you come to the edge of the water of the Jordan,
stand still in the Jordan.'"
9 Joshua said to the people of Israel,
"Come here and listen to the words of the LORD your God."
10 Joshua said,
"This is how you will know that the living God is among you,
and that he will surely drive out the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Hivite, the Perizzite,
the Girgashite, the Amorite, and the Jebusite in front of you:
11 Look, the ark of the covenant of the Lord of all the earth is going ahead of you into the Jordan.
12 So now take 12 men from the tribes of Israel, a man from each tribe.
13 When the soles of the feet of the priests who carry the ark of the LORD, the Lord of all the earth,
rest in the water of the Jordan,
the water of the Jordan will be cut off.
The water that flows down from above will stand up in one heap."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The Lord of all the earth": God is not only the God of Israel. The whole world belongs to him. That is why he can command the river too.

The priests must put their feet into the water first. Only then does the miracle happen. Sometimes faith means: taking the first step before you see how it will end.

The water stands still VERSES 14–17

14 The people set out from their tents to cross the Jordan,
and the priests who carried the ark of the covenant went in front of the people.
15 The men carrying the ark came to the Jordan,
and the feet of the priests who carried the ark dipped into the edge of the water.
(The Jordan overflows all its banks during the whole time of harvest.)
16 Then the water that flowed down from above stood still.
It rose up in one heap very far away, at Adam, the city beside Zarethan.
And the water that flowed down toward the sea of the Arabah, the Salt Sea, was completely cut off.
So the people crossed over near Jericho.
17 The priests who carried the ark of the covenant of the LORD
stood firm on dry ground in the middle of the Jordan.
And all Israel crossed over on dry ground,
until the whole nation had completely crossed the Jordan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In spring, at harvest time, the Jordan carries a lot of water from the snow of Mount Hermon. It overflows its banks. Exactly then it seems impossible to get across.

But God holds the water back. This is like the crossing of the sea when the people left Egypt (Exodus 14). The new generation experiences the same miracle as their parents. At the beginning and at the end of the journey through the wilderness there is a way through the water.

The city of Adam was about 19 miles upstream. There are reports that in later times landslides there blocked the Jordan for hours, for example in the year 1927 during an earthquake. The Bible does not say whether God used such an event here or whether it happened in a completely different way. It says: It happened at exactly the moment the priests stepped into the water, and it was God's deed.

Christians think of baptism when they think of this river: Later, Jesus was baptized in this very river, the Jordan (Mark 1:9).

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 4

12 stones to remember

12 stones from the Jordan VERSES 1–8

1 When the whole nation had completely crossed the Jordan, the LORD spoke to Joshua. He said,
2 "Take 12 men from the people, a man from each tribe,
3 and command them:
'Take 12 stones from the middle of the Jordan, from the place where the priests' feet stood firm.
Carry them over with you
and put them down in the place where you will camp tonight.'"
4 Then Joshua called the 12 men whom he had chosen from the people of Israel, a man from each tribe.
5 Joshua said to them,
"Go ahead of the ark of the LORD your God into the middle of the Jordan.
Each of you, pick up a stone and put it on your

shoulder,
one for each tribe of the people of Israel,
6 so that this may be a sign among you.
In the future, when your children ask you,
'What do these stones mean to you?'
7 then tell them,
'The water of the Jordan was cut off in front of the ark
of the covenant of the LORD.
When it crossed the Jordan, the water of the Jordan
was cut off.
These stones will be a reminder for the people of Israel
forever.'"
8 The people of Israel did as Joshua commanded.
They took 12 stones from the middle of the Jordan, as
the LORD had told Joshua,
a stone for each tribe of the people of Israel.
They carried them over with them to the place where
they camped, and they put them down there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

People quickly forget what God has done. That is why stones are set up as a memorial. When children ask, "What do these stones mean to you?" the parents should tell the story.

Each tribe carries one stone. All 12 tribes belong, including those whose land lies east of the Jordan.

This is often how faith grew: Children ask, and parents tell. We know this from the Passover feast too (Exodus 12:26; Deuteronomy 6:20).

12 stones in the Jordan too VERSES 9–14

9 Joshua also set up 12 stones in the middle of the Jordan,
in the place where the feet of the priests who carried
the ark of the covenant had stood.
They are there to this day.
10 For the priests who carried the ark stood in the middle
of the Jordan
until everything was finished that the LORD had
commanded Joshua to tell the people,
just as Moses had commanded Joshua.
And the people hurried and crossed over.
11 When all the people had completely crossed over,
the ark of the LORD crossed over with the priests,
while the people watched.
12 The people of Reuben, the people of Gad, and the half-
tribe of Manasseh crossed over armed in front of the
people of Israel,
as Moses had told them.
13 About 40,000 men, ready and armed for war,
crossed over in front of the LORD to battle, to the
plains of Jericho.
14 On that day, the LORD made Joshua great in the eyes of
all Israel.
They respected him with awe, as they had respected
Moses, all the days of his life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

So there are two memorials: one in the river, where the priests stood, and one on the bank, in the camp.

The priests stayed in the middle of the riverbed until the last person was across. Those who carried the ark went in first and came out last. Leaders should be like this: first into danger, last into safety.

The warriors of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh keep their promise (Numbers 32).

The water comes back VERSES 15–18

15 The LORD spoke to Joshua. He said,
16 "Command the priests who carry the ark of the
covenant to come up out of the Jordan."
17 So Joshua commanded the priests, "Come up out of the
Jordan!"
18 The priests who carried the ark of the covenant of the
LORD came up out of the middle of the Jordan.
As soon as the soles of the priests' feet touched the dry
ground,
the water of the Jordan went back to its place
and flowed over all its banks again, as before.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In verse 16, the Hebrew text calls it the ark of the testimony. The WEB, our English source text, calls it the ark of the covenant. It is another name for the same ark. The word testimony means the stone tablets with the Ten Commandments that lay inside the ark.

As soon as the ark is out, the river flows again. This shows: It was not chance. The water was gone only as long as God wanted.

The stones of Gilgal VERSES 19–24

19 The people came up out of the Jordan on the tenth day
of the first month.
They camped in Gilgal, on the east border of Jericho.
20 Joshua set up the 12 stones that they had taken out of
the Jordan in Gilgal.
21 He said to the people of Israel,
"In the future, when your children ask their fathers,
'What do these stones mean?'
22 then explain it to your children and say,
'Israel crossed this Jordan on dry land.
23 For the LORD your God dried up the water of the
Jordan in front of you until you had crossed over,
just as the LORD your God did to the Red Sea,
which he dried up in front of us until we had crossed
over,
24 so that all the peoples of the earth may know that the
hand of the LORD is mighty,
and so that you may fear the LORD your God forever.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The tenth day of the first month is exactly the day when the Passover lambs were chosen in Egypt (Exodus 12:3). Four days later, Israel celebrates the first Passover in the land (5:10). 40 years after leaving Egypt, the circle closes.

"Gilgal" became Israel's first permanent camp in the land. The name sounds like the Hebrew word for "circle" or "circle of stones."

In verse 23, the WEB says "Red Sea." The Hebrew says "Sea of Reeds."

The goal comes at the end: "so that all the peoples of the earth may know." God's deeds for Israel are meant to show the whole world who God is.

CHAPTER 5

A new beginning in Gilgal

The kings lose courage VERSE 1

1 All the kings of the Amorites who lived beyond the Jordan to the west,
and all the kings of the Canaanites who lived by the sea,
heard how the LORD had dried up the water of the Jordan in front of the people of Israel until we had crossed over.
Then their hearts melted, and they had no more courage because of the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Until we had crossed over": The narrator says "we." He counts himself among the people who were there at that time.

The circumcision VERSES 2–9

2 At that time, the LORD said to Joshua,
"Make knives out of flint
and circumcise the sons of Israel again, a second time."
3 So Joshua made himself flint knives
and circumcised the sons of Israel at the "hill of the foreskins."
4 This is the reason Joshua circumcised them:
All the people who came out of Egypt, all the males, all the men of war,
had died in the wilderness along the way, after they came out of Egypt.
5 For all the people who came out had been circumcised.
But all the people who were born in the wilderness along the way, after they came out of Egypt,
had not been circumcised.
6 For the people of Israel walked 40 years in the wilderness,
until the whole nation, the men of war who came out of Egypt, had died,
because they did not listen to the voice of the LORD.
The LORD swore to them that he would not let them see the land
that the LORD swore to their ancestors to give us,
a land flowing with milk and honey.
7 Joshua circumcised their sons, whom the LORD raised up in their place.
For they were not circumcised, because no one had circumcised them on the way.
8 When the whole nation was circumcised, they stayed in their places in the camp until they were healed.
9 The LORD said to Joshua,
"Today I have rolled away the shame of Egypt from you."
That is why the name of that place is Gilgal to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Circumcision is the sign of the covenant that God gave to Abraham (Genesis 17). In the wilderness, it was no longer done. Now, at the beginning of life in the land, the covenant is renewed.

Flint knives were common for holy acts at that time, even when people already had metal.

It is amazing: Right in enemy land, shortly before battle, all the men make themselves defenseless for a few days. They trust that God will protect them.

"Gilgal" sounds like the Hebrew word "galal," which means "to roll." God has "rolled away" the shame. The "shame of Egypt" may mean the time of slavery, or the mocking claim that God led his people into the wilderness only to let them die there.

The first Passover in the land VERSES 10–12

10 The people of Israel camped in Gilgal.
They kept the Passover on the fourteenth day of the month, in the evening, in the plains of Jericho.
11 On the day after the Passover, they ate food that grew in the land:
bread without yeast and roasted grain, on that very day.
12 The manna stopped on the next day, after they had eaten food from the land.
The people of Israel had no more manna.
That year they ate the fruit of the land of Canaan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For 40 years, God fed his people with manna every day. Now it stops. Not because God stops caring, but because the people are now in the land, and the land gives enough.

Sometimes God provides through miracles, and sometimes through very normal things: through the harvest. Both are his gift.

The first Passover in the land reminds them of the beginning: of the night of freedom in Egypt. Now the journey is over.

The commander of the LORD's army VERSES 13–15

13 When Joshua was near Jericho, he looked up.
Look! A man stood in front of him with his sword drawn in his hand.
Joshua went to him and asked him,
"Are you for us, or for our enemies?"
14 He said, "No.
But I have come now as commander of the LORD's army."
Joshua fell on his face to the ground, worshiped, and asked him,
"What does my lord say to his servant?"
15 The commander of the LORD's army said to Joshua,
"Take off your sandals,
for the place where you are standing is holy."
And Joshua did so.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joshua asks: Are you for us or against us? And the answer is: "No." The stranger belongs to neither side. He belongs to God. God is not on Joshua's side; Joshua must be on God's side.

This is an important lesson for all times: No one can use God for their own wars and goals. The question is not: "Is God on

our side?" but: "Are we on God's side?"
"Take off your sandals": Moses heard almost the same words at the burning bush (Exodus 3:5). Joshua has a meeting with God much like Moses did.

The Bible does not say who this commander was. Many think of an angel. Some Christian interpreters see Christ himself in him.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 6

The walls of Jericho

God's plan VERSES 1–5

1 Jericho was tightly shut because of the people of Israel.
No one went out, and no one came in.
2 The LORD said to Joshua,
"Look, I have given Jericho into your hand, with its king and its brave warriors.
3 All your men of war must march around the city,
going around the city once.
Do this for six days.
4 Seven priests must carry seven trumpets made of rams' horns in front of the ark.
On the seventh day, you must march around the city seven times,
and the priests must blow the trumpets.
5 When they make a long blast with the ram's horn, and you hear the sound of the trumpet,
all the people must shout with a great shout.
Then the city wall will fall down flat.
And the people must go up, every man straight ahead of him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is an unusual battle plan. No siege, no weapons, but a worship service: priests, the ark, and horns. It should be very clear: Israel does not conquer Jericho. God gives the city.

The ram's horn is called "shofar" in Hebrew. It is still blown in synagogues today, for example at the Jewish New Year.

The number seven comes up again and again: seven priests, seven horns, seven days, seven times around. Seven is the number of completeness, as in the seven days of creation.

Six days around the city VERSES 6–14

6 Joshua, the son of Nun, called the priests and said to them,
"Pick up the ark of the covenant.
Seven priests must carry seven trumpets of rams' horns in front of the ark of the LORD."
7 They said to the people,
"Go forward! March around the city.
The armed men must go ahead of the ark of the LORD."
8 So it happened: When Joshua had spoken to the people,
the seven priests carrying the seven trumpets of rams' horns in front of the LORD went forward and blew the trumpets.
And the ark of the covenant of the LORD followed them.
9 The armed men went ahead of the priests who blew the trumpets,
and the ark went after them.
The trumpets sounded as they went.
10 Joshua had commanded the people,
"Do not shout, and do not let your voice be heard.
Not a word may come out of your mouth until the day I tell you to shout.
Then you must shout."
11 So he had the ark of the LORD go around the city, once around.
Then they came into the camp and stayed the night in the camp.
12 Joshua got up early in the morning, and the priests picked up the ark of the LORD.
13 The seven priests carrying the seven trumpets of rams' horns in front of the ark of the LORD
kept walking and blew the trumpets.
The armed men went ahead of them,
and the rear guard came after the ark of the LORD.
The trumpets sounded as they went.
14 On the second day, they marched around the city once and went back to the camp.
They did this for six days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For six days, nothing seems to happen. The people march silently around the city. Only the horns sound. The people on the wall watch and maybe wonder. This takes a lot of patience and trust.

The silence is important: no boasting, no grumbling. Only waiting for God's time.

On the seventh day the walls fall VERSES 15–21

15 On the seventh day, they got up early, at dawn,
and marched around the city in the same way seven times.
Only on this day did they march around the city seven times.
16 The seventh time, when the priests blew the trumpets,
Joshua said to the people,
"Shout, for the LORD has given you the city!
17 The city and everything in it must be devoted to the LORD.
Only Rahab the prostitute will live,
she and everyone who is with her in the house,
because she hid the messengers that we sent.
18 But as for you, keep away from what is devoted to destruction.
Otherwise, after you have devoted it, you may take some of the devoted things.
Then you would make the camp of Israel cursed and bring trouble on it.

19 But all the silver and gold, and all the things made of
bronze and iron, are holy to the LORD.
They must go into the LORD's treasury."
Devoted to the LORD means: It belongs completely to
God and must be destroyed.
20 So the people shouted, and the priests blew the
trumpets.
When the people heard the sound of the trumpet, the
people shouted with a great shout.
Then the wall fell down flat.
The people went up into the city, every man straight
ahead of him, and they took the city.
21 They completely destroyed everything in the city,
both man and woman, both young and old,
and ox, sheep, and donkey, with the edge of the sword.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The walls do not fall by weapons but by God's power. This is the best-known story in the book of Joshua. There is even a famous song about it ("Joshua fit the battle of Jericho"), which enslaved people in America sang. For them it was a song of hope: Even the strongest walls of oppression can fall.

But verse 21 is terrible: All the people in the city are killed, men, women, children, and old people. This is the "devoting to destruction" that we read about in Deuteronomy (Deuteronomy 7 and 20).

We must not make this sound nice. By our understanding today, this is a grave wrong. Jews and Christians have thought about it for a long time. Many scholars think: The language of such reports is typical of war reports of that time and greatly exaggerates. Other texts of the Bible show that the Canaanites continued to live in the land.

Archaeologists argue about whether Jericho was even a lived-in, walled city at the time of Joshua. Some say no, others say yes. This has still not been settled for sure.

One thing is clear: This story must never be used to justify violence against a people or a city.

Rahab is saved VERSES 22–25

22 Joshua said to the two men who had spied out the land,
"Go into the prostitute's house,
and bring the woman and everything she has out of
there, as you swore to her."
23 So the young men who had been spies went in
and brought out Rahab, her father, her mother, her
brothers, and everything she had.
They also brought out all her relatives.
They put them in a place outside the camp of Israel.
24 They burned the city and everything in it with fire.
Only the silver, the gold, and the things made of
bronze and iron
they put into the treasury of the house of the LORD.
25 But Joshua let Rahab the prostitute live,
together with her father's family and everything she
had.
She lives in the middle of Israel to this day,
because she hid the messengers whom Joshua sent to
spy out Jericho.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the destruction, there is rescue. The promise to Rahab is kept.

At first, Rahab and her family live "outside the camp of Israel." But then it says: "She lives in the middle of Israel to this day." The foreign woman becomes part of God's people.

"House of the LORD": This means the holy tent, which was later replaced by the temple.

A curse on Jericho VERSES 26–27

26 At that time Joshua made the people take an oath. He
said,
"Cursed before the LORD is the man who rises up and
builds this city Jericho again.
With the loss of his firstborn son he will lay its
foundation,
and with the loss of his youngest son he will set up its
gates."
27 So the LORD was with Joshua,
and he became famous in all the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jericho is to stay a ruin, as a reminder of God's deed.

Many centuries later, at the time of King Ahab, a man named Hiel built Jericho again. The Bible reports that two of his sons died as a result, just as Joshua had said (1 Kings 16:34).

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 7

Achan's theft

The defeat at Ai VERSES 1–5

1 But the people of Israel were unfaithful with the
devoted things.
For Achan, the son of Carmi, the son of Zabdi, the son
of Zerah, from the tribe of Judah,
took some of the devoted things.
So the anger of the LORD burned against the people of
Israel.
2 Joshua sent men from Jericho to Ai, which is near
Beth Aven, east of Bethel.
He said to them, "Go up and spy out the land."
The men went up and spied out Ai.
3 They came back to Joshua and said to him,
"Don't let all the people go up.
Let about 2,000 or 3,000 men go up and strike Ai.
Don't make all the people work hard there, for there
are only a few of them."
4 So about 3,000 men from the people went up there.
But they ran away from the men of Ai.
5 The men of Ai killed about 36 of their men.
They chased them from the gate to Shebarim and
struck them on the way down the hill.
Then the hearts of the people melted and became like
water.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The reader already knows what Joshua does not know yet: Someone has secretly taken something that belonged to God.

After the great victory at Jericho, Israel is overconfident. The spies say: "Ai is small. We can do it easily." No one asks God.

"Ai" means "heap of ruins" in Hebrew.

36 men die. For the people, this is a shock. Suddenly their courage is gone.

Joshua cries out to God VERSES 6–9

6 Joshua tore his clothes and fell with his face to the
ground in front of the ark of the LORD until evening,
he and the elders of Israel.
They put dust on their heads.
7 Joshua said,
"Oh, Lord GOD, why did you bring this people across
the Jordan at all?
To give us into the hand of the Amorites, so that they
destroy us?
If only we had been content and stayed beyond the
Jordan!
8 Oh, Lord, what can I say, now that Israel has turned and
run from its enemies?
9 The Canaanites and all the people who live in the land
will hear about it.
They will surround us and wipe our name off the
earth.
And what will you do for your great name?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tearing your clothes and putting dust on your head were signs of deep grief.

Joshua honestly pours out his heart to God. He sounds almost like the people in the wilderness: "If only we had stayed over there!" Even great believers have moments of despair. The Bible does not hide that.

God names the reason VERSES 10–15

10 The LORD said to Joshua,
"Get up! Why are you lying on your face like that?
11 Israel has sinned.
Yes, they have broken my covenant, which I
commanded them.
Yes, they have even taken some of the devoted things,
and they have also stolen and also lied.
They have even put it among their own things.
12 That is why the people of Israel cannot stand against
their enemies.
They turn and run from their enemies, because they
themselves have become devoted to destruction.
I will not be with you anymore
unless you destroy the devoted things from among
you.
13 Get up! Make the people holy and say,
'Make yourselves holy for tomorrow.
For the LORD, the God of Israel, says,
"There is a devoted thing among you, Israel.
You cannot stand against your enemies
until you take away the devoted thing from among
you."
14 So in the morning you must come forward by your
tribes.
The tribe that the LORD chooses must come forward
by clans.
The clan that the LORD chooses must come forward by
families.
And the family that the LORD chooses must come
forward man by man.
15 Whoever is caught with the devoted thing
must be burned with fire, he and everything he has,
because he has broken the covenant of the LORD
and because he has done a shameful thing in Israel.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God says: Stop complaining, get up and act! There is a reason for the defeat.

It is surprising that God says "Israel has sinned," even though only one person took something. The people are a community. What one person does affects everyone. A hidden wrong harms the whole community.

The text does not say exactly how God "chooses" the guilty person. Probably by casting lots, with the Urim and Thummim of the priest.

Achan is found VERSES 16–21

16 Joshua got up early in the morning and had Israel
come forward by tribes.
The tribe of Judah was chosen.
17 He had the clans of Judah come forward, and the clan
of the Zerahites was chosen.
He had the clan of the Zerahites come forward man by
man, and Zabdi was chosen.
18 He had his family come forward man by man,
and Achan was chosen, the son of Carmi, the son of
Zabdi, the son of Zerah, from the tribe of Judah.
19 Joshua said to Achan,
"My son, please give glory to the LORD, the God of
Israel, and confess to him.
Tell me now what you have done. Don't hide it from
me!"
20 Achan answered Joshua,
"It is true. I have sinned against the LORD, the God of
Israel.
This is what I did:
21 Among the things we took, I saw a beautiful robe from
Babylon,
200 shekels of silver (about 5 pounds), and a bar of gold
that weighed 50 shekels (about 1¼ pounds).
I wanted them so much that I took them.
Look, they are hidden in the ground in the middle of
my tent, with the silver underneath."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says 200 shekels of silver and 50 shekels of gold. One shekel is about 0.4 ounces.

Step by step the truth comes to light: from the tribe to the clan to the single man. Achan could have stepped forward the whole time. He did not.

Joshua speaks to him kindly: "My son." He asks him to tell the truth.

Achan's confession shows how sin often happens: He saw something. He wanted it. He took it. He hid it. It was the same with Eve in the Garden of Eden (Genesis 3:6). The

tenth commandment forbids wanting to have something that belongs to someone else (Exodus 20:17). Such greed stands at the beginning of many sins.

Achan's punishment VERSES 22–26

22 So Joshua sent messengers, and they ran to the tent.
Look! It was hidden in his tent, with the silver underneath.
23 They took the things out of the middle of the tent,
brought them to Joshua and to all the people of Israel,
and laid them down in front of the LORD.
24 Then Joshua, and all Israel with him, took Achan the son of Zerah,
the silver, the robe, the bar of gold,
his sons and his daughters, his cattle, his donkeys, and his sheep,
his tent, and everything he had,
and they brought them up to the valley of Achor.
25 Joshua said,
"Why have you brought trouble on us?
The LORD will bring trouble on you today."
All Israel stoned him with stones.
They burned them with fire and stoned them with stones.
26 They piled a great heap of stones over him, which is still there to this day.
And the LORD turned away from his burning anger.
That is why the name of that place is "The valley of Achor" to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Achor" means "trouble." The name sounds almost like "Achan." He brought trouble on Israel, and so his life ends in the "valley of trouble."

This punishment is shockingly harsh. And it is especially hard that, according to verse 24, his sons and daughters are taken too. The text does not say completely clearly whether they were punished as well. If they were, that goes against the commandment in Deuteronomy 24:16: Children must not be punished for the guilt of their parents. Some interpreters think the family knew about the theft and helped hide it, because the hiding place was in the middle of the shared tent.

We have to say it honestly: This story is hard to bear. It shows how seriously the devoting to destruction was taken at that time. But it is not an example of how to deal with guilt. No one may use it to punish people harshly or to make their families suffer.

Later, the prophet Hosea promises something wonderful: God wants to make the valley of Achor, the valley of trouble, into a door of hope (Hosea 2:15; in some Bibles 2:17). Even out of a place of shame, God can make a new beginning.

JOSHUA

Chapter 8

Ai is taken – the altar on Mount Ebal

God encourages Joshua VERSES 1–2

1 The LORD said to Joshua,
"Don't be afraid, and don't lose heart.
Take all the warriors with you. Get up and go up to Ai.
Look, I have given the king of Ai, his people, his city, and his land into your hand.
2 Do to Ai and its king what you did to Jericho and its king.
Only this time, you may take its goods and its livestock for yourselves.
Set an ambush against the city, behind it."
An ambush means: soldiers hide and attack by surprise.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the guilt comes a new beginning. God says again: "Don't be afraid." The matter with Achan is settled. God is with his people again.

This time the Israelites may keep the goods. If Achan had waited, he would have received what he wanted.

The plan with the ambush VERSES 3–13

3 So Joshua got up with all the warriors to go up to Ai.
Joshua chose 30,000 men, brave warriors, and sent them out at night.
4 He commanded them,
"Look, you must lie in ambush against the city, behind the city.
Don't go very far from the city, but all of you be ready.
5 I and all the people with me will come near the city.
When they come out against us, as the first time, we will run away from them.
6 They will come out after us until we have drawn them away from the city.
For they will say, 'They are running away from us, like the first time.'
So we will run away from them,
7 and you must rise up from the ambush and take the city.
For the LORD your God will give it into your hand.
8 When you have taken the city, set the city on fire.
Do this as the LORD has said.
Look, I have commanded you."
9 Joshua sent them out, and they went to the place of the ambush.
They stayed between Bethel and Ai, west of Ai.
But Joshua stayed with the people that night.
10 Joshua got up early in the morning and gathered the people.
He went up to Ai in front of the people, he and the elders of Israel.
11 All the men of war who were with him went up and came near.
They came in front of the city and camped north of Ai.
There was a valley between him and Ai.
12 He took about 5,000 men and set them in ambush between Bethel and Ai, west of the city.

13 So they set up the people: the whole army north of the city,
and the ambush west of the city.
That night Joshua went into the middle of the valley.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The numbers are confusing: In verse 3 there are 30,000 men, in verse 12 only 5,000 in the ambush. Interpreters explain this in different ways. Maybe there were two groups. Maybe the text was changed when it was copied over the centuries. The Hebrew word for "thousand" can also mean a military unit that was much smaller. Then the numbers would have been much smaller.

Joshua uses the defeat from Chapter 7 as a trick: The men of Ai think Israel is running away again.

The victory over Ai VERSES 14–23

14 When the king of Ai saw it,
the men of the city hurried, got up early, and went out to fight against Israel,
he and all his people, at the agreed time, facing the Arabah.
But he did not know that there was an ambush against him behind the city.

15 Joshua and all Israel pretended to be beaten by them and ran away on the road to the wilderness.

16 All the people in the city were called together to chase them.
They chased Joshua and were drawn away from the city.

17 Not one man was left in Ai or Bethel who did not go out after Israel.
They left the city open and chased Israel.

18 The LORD said to Joshua,
"Stretch out the javelin in your hand toward Ai.
For I will give it into your hand."
So Joshua stretched out the javelin in his hand toward the city.
A javelin is a short spear.

19 As soon as he stretched out his hand, the men in the ambush quickly rose up from their place.
They ran, entered the city, and took it.
They quickly set the city on fire.

20 When the men of Ai looked behind them, they saw it.
Look! The smoke of the city was rising up to the sky.
They had no way to run this way or that way.
And the people who had run toward the wilderness turned back against those chasing them.

21 When Joshua and all Israel saw that the ambush had taken the city
and that the smoke of the city was rising,
they turned back and killed the men of Ai.

22 The others came out of the city against them,
so the men of Ai were caught in the middle of Israel,
some on this side and some on that side.
They struck them until not one of them was left or escaped.

23 But they captured the king of Ai alive and brought him to Joshua.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The stretched-out javelin reminds us of Moses, who held up his hands during the battle against the Amalekites (Exodus 17:11). It is a sign: God gives the victory.

Bethel was only a few miles away. Its men also came to help Ai.

Ai is destroyed VERSES 24–29

24 Israel finished killing all the people of Ai in the field, in the wilderness where they had chased them.
They had all fallen by the edge of the sword, until they were all dead.
Then all Israel went back to Ai and struck it with the edge of the sword.

25 All who fell that day, men and women, were 12,000, all the people of Ai.

26 For Joshua did not pull back his hand, with which he stretched out the javelin,
until he had completely destroyed all the people of Ai.

27 Israel took for themselves only the livestock and the goods of that city,
as the LORD had commanded Joshua.

28 So Joshua burned Ai and made it a heap of ruins forever, an empty place, to this day.

29 He hanged the king of Ai on a tree until evening.
At sundown, Joshua gave a command, and they took his body down from the tree
and threw it at the entrance of the city gate.
They piled a great heap of stones on it, which is still there to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again a whole city is destroyed, including the women. For us, this is terrible. What was said about Jericho is true here too: The Bible describes the war of its time. These reports must never be used to justify violence.

For the time of Joshua, archaeologists have found no lived-in city at Ai (today "et-Tell"). There is much discussion about this. Some think the real Ai has not been found yet.

The king's body is taken down that same evening, as the law requires (Deuteronomy 21:22–23).

The altar on Mount Ebal VERSES 30–35

30 Then Joshua built an altar to the LORD, the God of Israel, on Mount Ebal,

31 as Moses, the servant of the LORD, had commanded the people of Israel,
as it is written in the book of the law of Moses:
an altar of uncut stones, on which no one had used an iron tool.
On it they offered burnt offerings to the LORD and sacrificed peace offerings.

32 There he wrote on the stones a copy of the law of Moses, which he wrote while the people of Israel watched.

33 All Israel, with their elders, officers, and judges, stood on both sides of the ark, facing the Levitical priests who carried the ark of the covenant of the LORD,
the foreigner as well as the one born in Israel.
Half of them stood in front of Mount Gerizim, and half of them in front of Mount Ebal,
as Moses, the servant of the LORD, had commanded at the beginning, so that they would bless the people of Israel.

34 After that, he read all the words of the law, the blessing
and the curse,
exactly as it is written in the book of the law.
35 There was not one word of all that Moses had
commanded
that Joshua did not read in front of the whole
assembly of Israel,
including the women, the little ones, and the
foreigners who lived among them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the middle of the time of battles, Joshua stops. He does what Moses had commanded (Deuteronomy 27). The law is written on stones and read aloud to all the people.

"There was not one word ... that Joshua did not read": Joshua reads everything without leaving anything out. That is also the goal of this Bible: to leave out no word.

Again everyone is there: women, children, and foreigners. God's word is for everyone.

On Mount Ebal, archaeologists have found an old stone structure that some think is this altar. Others doubt it.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 9

The trick of the Gibeonites

The kings join together VERSES 1–2

1 All the kings beyond the Jordan heard about it:
the kings in the hill country, in the lowland, and on
the whole coast of the great sea opposite Lebanon,
the Hittite, the Amorite, the Canaanite, the Perizzite,
the Hivite, and the Jebusite.
2 They gathered together to fight with one mind against
Joshua and against Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Beyond the Jordan" here means: west of the Jordan, seen from Joshua's camp. The kings of the land join together against Israel.

The Gibeonites dress up VERSES 3–15

3 But the people of Gibeon heard what Joshua had done
to Jericho and to Ai.
4 So they also used a trick.
They went and pretended to be messengers.
They put old sacks on their donkeys,
and old wineskins that were torn and tied up,
5 and old, patched sandals on their feet,
and they wore old clothes.
All the bread they took with them was dry and moldy.
6 They went to Joshua at the camp at Gilgal and said to
him and to the men of Israel,
"We have come from a far country.
So now make a covenant with us."
7 The men of Israel said to the Hivites,
"What if you live among us? How could we make a
covenant with you?"
8 They said to Joshua, "We are your servants."
Joshua said to them, "Who are you? Where do you
come from?"
9 They said to him,
"Your servants have come from a very far country
because of the name of the LORD your God.
For we have heard about his fame and all that he did in
Egypt,
10 and all that he did to the two kings of the Amorites
beyond the Jordan,
to Sihon, king of Heshbon, and to Og, king of Bashan,
who lived at Ashtaroth.
11 Our elders and all the people of our country said to us,
'Take food for the journey and go to meet them.
Tell them, "We are your servants. So now make a
covenant with us."'
12 This bread of ours was still hot when we took it from
our houses as food for the journey,
on the day we left to come to you.
But now, look, it is dry and has become moldy.
13 These wineskins that we filled were new.
And look, they are torn.
And our clothes and our sandals have worn out
because of the very long journey."
14 The men tasted some of their food.
But they did not ask for advice from the mouth of the
LORD.
15 Joshua made peace with them and made a covenant
with them to let them live.
The leaders of the community swore an oath to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gibeon was a city only about 6 miles northwest of Jerusalem, very close to Ai. The Gibeonites knew: Israel must not make a covenant with the peoples in the land (Deuteronomy 7:2). But Israel may make peace with peoples far away (Deuteronomy 20:10–15). That is why they pretend to come from far away.

They thought up a clever disguise: old bread, torn wineskins, worn-out sandals.

The key sentence is verse 14: "But they did not ask for advice from the mouth of the LORD." They trusted their eyes and not God. That was the mistake.

The trick is discovered VERSES 16–21

16 Three days after they had made a covenant with them,
they heard that they were their neighbors and lived
among them.
17 The people of Israel set out and came to their cities on
the third day.
Their cities were Gibeon, Chephirah, Beeroth, and
Kiriath Jearim.
18 The people of Israel did not kill them,
because the leaders of the community had sworn to
them by the LORD, the God of Israel.
And the whole community grumbled against the
leaders.

19 But all the leaders said to the whole community,
"We have sworn to them by the LORD, the God of Israel.
So now we may not touch them.
20 This is what we will do with them: We will let them live,
so that no anger comes on us because of the oath we swore to them."
21 The leaders said to them, "Let them live."
So they became woodcutters and water carriers for the whole community,
as the leaders had told them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even though Israel was tricked, it keeps its oath. A promise in God's name is holy, even if it was given under false conditions.

Many centuries later, King Saul broke this oath and killed Gibeonites. This was punished severely (2 Samuel 21:1–9). God takes promises seriously.

The result is something good: The Gibeonites stay alive. An oath saved human lives.

Joshua confronts the Gibeonites VERSES 22–27

22 Joshua called for them and said to them,
"Why did you trick us and say, 'We live very far from you,'
when you live among us?
23 So now you are cursed.
Some of you will always be slaves,
woodcutters and water carriers for the house of my God."
24 They answered Joshua,
"Your servants were clearly told what the LORD your God commanded his servant Moses:
to give you the whole land and to destroy all the people of the land in front of you.
So we were very afraid for our lives because of you,
and that is why we did this.
25 Now, look, we are in your hand.
Do with us what seems good and right to you."
26 So he did that with them.
He saved them from the hand of the people of Israel, so that they did not kill them.
27 That day Joshua made them woodcutters and water carriers
for the community and for the altar of the LORD, to this day,
in the place that the LORD would choose.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Gibeonites honestly say why they lied: out of fear of death. They recognized God's power, much like Rahab.

Now they must always do simple work: chopping wood and carrying water. That was a low position. But they serve at God's altar. So they become part of Israel's worship.

Later, Gibeonites continued to live in Israel. After the exile in Babylon, descendants of Gibeon returned to Jerusalem and helped rebuild the city wall (Nehemiah 3:7; 7:25).

Being slaves like this does not fit our understanding of human dignity today. But compared to death, it was rescue.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 10

The sun stands still – the conquest of the south

Five kings attack Gibeon VERSES 1–5

1 Adoni-Zedek, king of Jerusalem, heard that Joshua had taken Ai
and had completely destroyed it.
He heard that Joshua had done to Ai and its king what he had done to Jericho and its king,
and that the people of Gibeon had made peace with Israel and were living among them.
2 Then they were very afraid.
For Gibeon was a great city, like one of the royal cities.
It was greater than Ai, and all its men were brave warriors.
3 So Adoni-Zedek, king of Jerusalem, sent messengers to Hoham king of Hebron, to Piram king of Jarmuth, to Japhia king of Lachish, and to Debir king of Eglon. He said,
4 "Come up to me and help me.
Let's strike Gibeon,
for it has made peace with Joshua and with the people of Israel."
5 So the five kings of the Amorites gathered together:
the king of Jerusalem, the king of Hebron, the king of Jarmuth,
the king of Lachish, and the king of Eglon.
They went up, they and all their armies.
They camped in front of Gibeon and made war against it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Jerusalem is named for the first time in the Bible with this name. At that time, it was a city of the Jebusites. Only later did King David take it.

"Adoni-Zedek" means "My lord is righteousness." This is like Melchizedek, the king of Salem, whom Abraham met (Genesis 14:18).

The five kings do not attack Israel. They attack Gibeon, because it has gone over to Israel's side.

Joshua helps Gibeon VERSES 6–11

6 The men of Gibeon sent a message to Joshua at the camp at Gilgal:
"Don't leave your servants alone!
Come up to us quickly and save us! Help us!
For all the kings of the Amorites who live in the hill country have gathered together against us."
7 So Joshua went up from Gilgal, he and the whole army with him, and all the brave warriors.
8 The LORD said to Joshua,
"Don't be afraid of them, for I have given them into

your hands.
Not one of them will stand against you."
9 Joshua came on them suddenly. He had marched up
from Gilgal all night.
10 The LORD threw them into confusion in front of
Israel.
He struck them down in a great battle at Gibeon.
He chased them on the road up to Beth Horon
and struck them as far as Azekah and Makkedah.
11 As they ran away from Israel, while they were on the
slope going down from Beth Horon,
the LORD threw down great stones from the sky on
them, as far as Azekah, and they died.
More died from the hailstones than the people of Israel
killed with the sword.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel keeps its promise. The Gibeonites had tricked them. Still, Joshua comes to help them right away, even with a night march of about 19 miles uphill. A covenant is a covenant.

God himself fights too: through confusion and through a mighty hailstorm.

Sun, stand still! VERSES 12–15

12 Then Joshua spoke to the LORD, on the day when the
LORD gave the Amorites over to the people of Israel.
He said, while Israel watched,
"Sun, stand still over Gibeon!
And you, moon, stop over the valley of Aijalon!"
13 So the sun stood still, and the moon stopped,
until the nation had taken revenge on its enemies.
Isn't this written in the book of Jashar?
The sun stayed in the middle of the sky
and did not hurry to go down for about a whole day.
14 There was no day like this before it or after it,
when the LORD listened to the voice of a man.
For the LORD fought for Israel.
15 Joshua went back, and all Israel with him, to the camp
at Gilgal.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most famous and most puzzling passages in the Bible. Joshua prays: Sun, stand still! And the day becomes longer, so that Israel can complete the victory.

Joshua's words are a poem. It comes from the "book of Jashar" (in Hebrew: "Sefer ha-Yashar"). That means "book of the upright." It was an old collection of songs that is lost today. David's song of mourning for Saul and Jonathan was in it too (2 Samuel 1:18).

How should we understand this? Jews and Christians have given different answers:

Some believe in a miracle exactly as written: God stopped the movement of the sun and moon.

Others say: It is the language of a victory song. It wants to say: On that day, God helped so mightily that it was as if time stood still.

Still others think: Joshua asked the sun to be "silent," that is, to grow dark, for example through the hailstorm. The Hebrew word can also mean "be silent."

In the year 1633, the Catholic Church pointed to this passage, among others, when it condemned Galileo Galilei for saying that the earth moves around the sun. Today we know: Here the Bible speaks in the language of people who see the sun "rise" and "set." It does not want to teach astronomy. In 1992, the Catholic Church officially admitted that Galileo had been treated wrongly.

The most important thing is in verse 14: "There was no day like this before it or after it, when the LORD listened to the voice of a man." God takes a person's prayer seriously.

Verse 15 briefly tells of the return. But in verse 21, the camp is at Makkedah. Maybe verse 15 tells ahead of time what happened later, and the return to Gilgal happened only at the end of the campaign (verse 43).

The five kings in the cave VERSES 16–27

16 These five kings ran away and hid in the cave at
Makkedah.
17 Joshua was told,
"The five kings have been found. They are hiding in the
cave at Makkedah."
18 Joshua said,
"Roll large stones in front of the entrance of the cave,
and put men there to guard them.
19 But don't stay there yourselves.
Chase your enemies and attack them from behind.
Don't let them get into their cities.
For the LORD your God has given them into your
hand."
20 Joshua and the people of Israel finished striking them
in a very great battle, until they were destroyed.
Those of them who were left escaped into the walled
cities.
21 Then all the people came back safely to Joshua at the
camp at Makkedah.
No one dared even to move his tongue against the
people of Israel.
22 Then Joshua said,
"Open the entrance of the cave, and bring those five
kings out of the cave to me."
23 They did so and brought those five kings out of the cave
to him:
the king of Jerusalem, the king of Hebron, the king of
Jarmuth,
the king of Lachish, and the king of Eglon.
24 When they had brought those kings out to Joshua,
Joshua called all the men of Israel.
He said to the commanders of the men of war who had
gone with him,
"Come here. Put your feet on the necks of these kings."
They came and put their feet on their necks.
25 Joshua said to them,
"Don't be afraid, and don't lose heart.
Be strong and courageous!
For this is what the LORD will do to all your enemies
you fight against."
26 After that, Joshua struck them and put them to death
and hanged them on five trees.
They hung on the trees until evening.
27 At sundown, Joshua gave a command, and they took
them down from the trees
and threw them into the cave where they had hidden.
They put large stones at the entrance of the cave,
which are still there to this very day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Putting your foot on someone's neck" was a sign of victory at that time. You can see it in old pictures from Egypt and Assyria too.

The execution of the kings is harsh. Here too the law is kept: The dead are taken down before sundown (Deuteronomy 21:23).

The cave where the kings looked for safety becomes their grave.

The cities in the south are conquered VERSES 28–39

28 Joshua took Makkedah on that day
and struck it with the edge of the sword, together with its king.
He completely destroyed the city and every person in it.
He left no one alive.
He did to the king of Makkedah what he had done to the king of Jericho.

29 Joshua went on from Makkedah, and all Israel with him, to Libnah, and fought against Libnah.

30 The LORD gave this city too, with its king, into the hand of Israel.
He struck it with the edge of the sword, with every person in it.
He left no one alive in it.
He did to its king what he had done to the king of Jericho.

31 Joshua went on from Libnah, and all Israel with him, to Lachish.
He camped against the city and fought against it.

32 The LORD gave Lachish into the hand of Israel.
He took it on the second day and struck it with the edge of the sword,
with every person in it, just as he had done to Libnah.

33 Then Horam, king of Gezer, came up to help Lachish.
But Joshua struck him and his people until he had left no one alive.

34 Joshua went on from Lachish, and all Israel with him, to Eglon.
They camped against the city and fought against it.

35 They took it on that day and struck it with the edge of the sword.
He completely destroyed every person in it that day, just as he had done to Lachish.

36 Joshua went up from Eglon, and all Israel with him, to Hebron, and they fought against it.

37 They took it and struck it with the edge of the sword, with its king, all its towns, and every person in it.
He left no one alive, just as he had done to Eglon.
He completely destroyed it and every person in it.

38 Then Joshua turned, and all Israel with him, to Debir, and fought against it.

39 He took it with its king and all its towns.
They struck them with the edge of the sword and completely destroyed every person in it.
He left no one alive.
He did to Debir and its king as he had done to Hebron, and as he had done to Libnah and its king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This section repeats the same words again and again: "He left no one alive." It sounds like a fixed form of war report, as we know it from other kings of that time. Such reports often exaggerate to make the victory look great.

One clue for this: Later in this book and in the book of Judges, Hebron and Debir have to be conquered again (Joshua 15:13–17; Judges 1:10–15). So the people who lived there were not all dead.

Still, it remains a report of great violence. It belongs to a distant time and must never serve as an example for war or violence against people.

Summary of the campaign VERSES 40–43

40 So Joshua struck the whole land:
the hill country, the South, the lowland, and the slopes, and all their kings.
He left no one alive.
He completely destroyed everything that breathed, as the LORD, the God of Israel, had commanded.

41 Joshua struck them from Kadesh Barnea to Gaza, and the whole country of Goshen as far as Gibeon.

42 Joshua took all these kings and their land at one time, because the LORD, the God of Israel, fought for Israel.

43 Joshua went back, and all Israel with him, to the camp at Gilgal.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "country of Goshen" here is not the Goshen in Egypt. It is an area in the south of the land of Canaan with the same name.

"At one time" probably means: in a single campaign. But 11:18 says that Joshua made war for a long time. The report sums up many things.

For the narrator, the most important sentence is: "The LORD, the God of Israel, fought for Israel." Not their own strength won, but God. But we know from Chapter 5: God is not simply on one side. People must stand on his side.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 11

The victory in the north

The kings of the north join together VERSES 1–5

1 When Jabin, king of Hazor, heard about it,
he sent messengers to Jobab king of Madon, to the king of Shimron, to the king of Achshaph,

2 and to the kings who lived in the north, in the hill country, in the Arabah south of Chinneroth,
in the lowland, and on the heights of Dor in the west,

3 to the Canaanite in the east and in the west, to the Amorite, the Hittite, the Perizzite,
the Jebusite in the hill country,

and the Hivite below Mount Hermon in the land of Mizpah.

4 They went out, they and all their armies with them,
many people, as many as the sand on the seashore,
with very many horses and chariots.

5 All these kings met together.
They came and camped together at the waters of Merom, to fight against Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the south comes the north. Hazor was the largest city in the land of Canaan. Archaeologists have found huge ruins there.

The enemies have horses and chariots, the most modern weapons of their time. Israel had nothing like that.

"Chinneroth" is the Sea of Galilee.

The victory at the waters of Merom VERSES 6–9

6 The LORD said to Joshua,
"Don't be afraid of them.
For tomorrow at this time I will hand them all over to Israel,
and they will all be killed.
You must hamstring their horses and burn their chariots with fire."
To hamstring means: to cut a tendon in the leg, so that the horse can no longer run.

7 So Joshua came on them suddenly with all the warriors, at the waters of Merom, and attacked them.

8 The LORD gave them into the hand of Israel.
They struck them and chased them as far as great Sidon and Misrephoth Maim,
and as far as the valley of Mizpah in the east.
They struck them until no one of them was left.

9 Joshua did to them as the LORD had told him.
He hamstrung their horses and burned their chariots with fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hamstringing the horses meant they could no longer be used for war. This is cruel to the animals.

Why should Israel not keep the horses and chariots? Israel was meant to trust in God, not in weapons. The law for the king says this too (Deuteronomy 17:16). And Psalm 20:7 (in some Bibles 20:8) says that some trust in chariots and some in horses, but we trust in the name of the LORD our God.

Hazor is destroyed VERSES 10–15

10 At that time Joshua turned back and took Hazor.
He struck its king with the sword.
For Hazor used to be the head of all those kingdoms.

11 They struck every person in it with the edge of the sword
and completely destroyed them.
No one was left who breathed.
And he burned Hazor with fire.

12 Joshua took all the cities of those kings, and all their kings.
He struck them with the edge of the sword and completely destroyed them,
as Moses, the servant of the LORD, had commanded.

13 But Israel did not burn any of the cities that stood on their hills.
Joshua burned only Hazor.

14 The people of Israel took all the goods of these cities and the livestock for themselves.
But they struck every person with the edge of the sword until they had destroyed them.
They left no one who breathed.

15 As the LORD had commanded Moses his servant, so Moses commanded Joshua.
And Joshua did so.
He left nothing undone of all that the LORD had commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Cities on their hills": Old cities were built again and again on the ruins of the earlier cities. This made hills that today are called a "tell."

In Hazor, archaeologists have found a thick layer of ash from the time around 1200 BC. But who destroyed the city at that time is disputed.

Here too: The reports of the destruction of whole cities are hard to bear. They belong to their time and must never justify violence.

The whole land is taken VERSES 16–20

16 So Joshua took this whole land:
the hill country, all the South, all the land of Goshen,
the lowland, the Arabah,
the hill country of Israel and its lowland,

17 from Mount Halak, which goes up toward Seir, to Baal Gad in the valley of Lebanon below Mount Hermon.
He captured all their kings, struck them, and put them to death.

18 Joshua made war with all those kings for a long time.

19 There was not one city that made peace with the people of Israel,
except the Hivites who lived in Gibeon.
They took all the others in battle.

20 For it came from the LORD that their hearts became hard,
so that they came against Israel in battle,
so that he might completely destroy them,
so that they would find no mercy, but that he might destroy them,
as the LORD had commanded Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Halak" means "bare." It is a bare mountain in the south of the land.

"For a long time": The conquest did not take a few days but many years. Jewish interpreters counted about seven years.

Verse 19 is remarkable: Peace would have been possible. The Gibeonites showed it. But no other city chose this way.

"Their hearts became hard" because of God: This is hard to understand. The same was said about Pharaoh. The Bible wants to say: Even the resistance of the peoples was not outside God's plan. This does not mean that the people had no choice. Rahab and the Gibeonites chose differently.

The Anakim VERSES 21–23

21 At that time Joshua came and wiped out the Anakim from the hill country,
from Hebron, from Debir, from Anab, from all the hill country of Judah, and from all the hill country of

Israel.
Joshua completely destroyed them and their cities.
22 No Anakim were left in the land of the people of Israel.
Only in Gaza, in Gath, and in Ashdod did some remain.
23 So Joshua took the whole land,
just as the LORD had said to Moses.
And Joshua gave it to Israel as their inheritance, by
their divisions, by their tribes.
Then the land had rest from war.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Anakim were the "giants" that the spies were so afraid of 40 years earlier (Numbers 13:33). Now they are defeated.

Some remained in Gath. Later, the giant Goliath, whom David defeated, came from Gath (1 Samuel 17:4).

"The whole land": This is a summary. Soon after, in Chapter 13, it says that very much land is still left. The narrator means: The great battles are over, the most important areas belong to Israel.

"The land had rest from war": Peace at last. Now the land can be divided.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 12

The list of defeated kings

The kings east of the Jordan VERSES 1–6

1 Here is a list of the kings of the land.
The people of Israel defeated them and took their land.
This land was on the other side of the Jordan, toward the east.
It went from the valley of the Arnon to Mount Hermon,
and it took in all the Arabah on the east side.
2 The first king was Sihon, king of the Amorites.
He lived in Heshbon.
He ruled from Aroer, at the edge of the valley of the Arnon,
and from the middle of the valley.
He ruled over half of Gilead, as far as the river Jabbok.
The Jabbok is the border of the people of Ammon.
3 He also ruled over the Arabah, as far as the sea of Chinneroth in the east,
and as far as the sea of the Arabah in the east.
The sea of the Arabah is the Salt Sea.
His land went along the road to Beth Jeshimoth,
and in the south it went to the foot of the slopes of Pisgah.
4 Then there was the land of Og, king of Bashan.
He was one of the last of the Rephaim.
He lived at Ashtaroth and at Edrei.
5 He ruled over Mount Hermon, over Salecah, and over all Bashan,
as far as the border of the Geshurites and the Maacathites.
He also ruled over half of Gilead, as far as the border of Sihon, king of Heshbon.
6 Moses, the servant of the LORD, and the people of Israel defeated these kings.
Moses, the servant of the LORD, gave their land to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh.
It became their own land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This chapter is like a list of victories. First come the two kings east of the Jordan who were already defeated at the time of Moses (Numbers 21; Deuteronomy 2–3).

The kings west of the Jordan VERSES 7–24

7 Here is a list of the kings of the land west of the Jordan.
Joshua and the people of Israel defeated them.
This land went from Baal Gad in the valley of Lebanon to Mount Halak, which rises toward Seir.
Joshua gave this land to the tribes of Israel.
Each tribe got its own share.
8 The land was in the hill country, in the lowland, in the Arabah, on the slopes, in the wilderness, and in the South.
It was the land of the Hittites, the Amorites, the Canaanites, the Perizzites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites.
These were the kings:
9 the king of Jericho, one;
the king of Ai, which is beside Bethel, one;
10 the king of Jerusalem, one;
the king of Hebron, one;
11 the king of Jarmuth, one;
the king of Lachish, one;
12 the king of Eglon, one;
the king of Gezer, one;
13 the king of Debir, one;
the king of Geder, one;
14 the king of Hormah, one;
the king of Arad, one;
15 the king of Libnah, one;
the king of Adullam, one;
16 the king of Makkedah, one;
the king of Bethel, one;
17 the king of Tappuah, one;
the king of Hepher, one;
18 the king of Aphek, one;
the king of Lassharon, one;
19 the king of Madon, one;
the king of Hazor, one;
20 the king of Shimron Meron, one;
the king of Achshaph, one;
21 the king of Taanach, one;
the king of Megiddo, one;
22 the king of Kedesh, one;
the king of Jokneam in Carmel, one;

23 the king of Dor on the heights of Dor, one;
the king of Goiim in Gilgal, one;
24 the king of Tirzah, one.
That makes 31 kings in all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The list names 31 kings. At that time, almost every larger city had its own "king," more like a city prince. The land was divided into many small city-states.

Some of these kings are not mentioned in the chapters before, for example Bethel, Megiddo, or Tirzah. So the list sums up more than was told.

Some cities like Jerusalem, Gezer, and Megiddo were really taken by Israel only much later (Judges 1:21, 27–29; 2 Samuel 5:6–9; 1 Kings 9:16). Here their kings were defeated, but the cities themselves stayed in the hands of the Canaanites.

"Goiim" means "nations." It may be a different place from the Gilgal by the Jordan.

The list shows: God has kept his promise. The land he promised to Abraham now belongs to Israel.

JOSHUA

Chapter 13

What is still left – the land east of the Jordan

Much land is still left VERSES 1–7

1 Joshua was old and well along in years.
The LORD said to him,
"You are old and well along in years,
and very much land is still left to be taken.
2 This is the land that is still left:
all the regions of the Philistines and all the land of the Geshurites,
3 from the Shihor, which is east of Egypt, to the border of Ekron in the north,
which is counted as Canaanite land:
the five rulers of the Philistines, those of Gaza, Ashdod, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron,
and also the Avvim
4 in the south.
Also all the land of the Canaanites, and Mearah, which belongs to the Sidonians,
as far as Aphek, to the border of the Amorites,
5 and the land of the Gebalites, and all Lebanon to the east,
from Baal Gad below Mount Hermon to the entrance of Hamath,
6 all the people of the hill country from Lebanon to Misrephoth Maim, all the Sidonians.
I myself will drive them out in front of the people of Israel.
Just give the land to Israel by lot as an inheritance, as I have commanded you.
7 So now divide this land as an inheritance to the nine tribes and the half-tribe of Manasseh."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joshua has grown old. He has done a lot, but not everything. Much land is left, especially on the coast (where the Philistines live) and in the north (in Lebanon).

God says: Divide the land anyway, already now. I myself will take care of the rest. Joshua does not have to finish everything. God takes care of what comes after him.

The Philistines lived in five large cities on the coast. Later, for a long time, they were Israel's most dangerous enemies, at the time of Samson, Saul, and David.

"The entrance of Hamath": Many Bibles translate this as the place name "Lebo Hamath." Hamath was a city in what is now Syria.

The "Gebalites" are the people from Gebal, the city of Byblos in what is now Lebanon.

The inheritance east of the Jordan VERSES 8–14

8 With the other half of Manasseh, the Reubenites and the Gadites had received their inheritance,
which Moses gave them beyond the Jordan to the east,
just as Moses, the servant of the LORD, gave it to them:
9 from Aroer, which is on the edge of the valley of the Arnon,
and the city in the middle of the valley,
and the whole plain of Medeba to Dibon,
10 and all the cities of Sihon, king of the Amorites, who ruled in Heshbon,
as far as the border of the people of Ammon,
11 and Gilead, and the territory of the Geshurites and Maacathites,
all Mount Hermon, and all Bashan as far as Salecah,
12 the whole kingdom of Og in Bashan, who ruled in Ashtaroth and in Edrei.
He was one of the last of the Rephaim who were left.
Moses had attacked them and driven them out.
13 But the people of Israel did not drive out the Geshurites or the Maacathites.
So Geshur and Maacath live in the middle of Israel to this day.
14 Only to the tribe of Levi he gave no inheritance.
The offerings made by fire to the LORD, the God of Israel, are his inheritance, as the LORD told him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"With the other half of Manasseh": The Hebrew says only "with him." It means the other half-tribe of Manasseh, which lived east of the Jordan.

Verse 13 is honest: Not all peoples were driven out. They continued to live in the middle of Israel. Later, King David married a princess from Geshur. Her son was Absalom (2 Samuel 3:3).

The tribe of Levi gets no land. It has God himself as its inheritance. This is said twice in this chapter.

The territory of Reuben VERSES 15–23

15 Moses gave land to the tribe of the people of Reuben by their clans.

16 Their territory went from Aroer, which is on the edge
of the valley of the Arnon,
and the city in the middle of the valley, and the whole
plain by Medeba,
17 Heshbon and all its cities on the plain:
Dibon, Bamoth Baal, Beth Baal Meon,
18 Jahaz, Kedemoth, Mephaath,
19 Kiriathaim, Sibmah, Zereth Shahar on the mountain
in the valley,
20 Beth Peor, the slopes of Pisgah, Beth Jeshimoth,
21 all the cities of the plain, and the whole kingdom of
Sihon, king of the Amorites, who ruled in Heshbon.
Moses had struck him, together with the chiefs of
Midian,
Evi, Rekem, Zur, Hur, and Reba, the princes of Sihon,
who lived in the land.
22 The people of Israel also killed Balaam the son of Beor,
the fortune-teller, with the sword,
together with the others they killed.
23 The border of the people of Reuben was the bank of the
Jordan.
This was the inheritance of the people of Reuben by
their clans, the cities and their villages.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Balaam is called a "fortune-teller" here. He had blessed Israel when he was supposed to curse it (Numbers 22–24). But later he had advised the Midianites to lead Israel into worshiping idols. That is why he died in the war against Midian (Numbers 31:8, 16).

The territory of Gad VERSES 24–28

24 Moses gave land to the tribe of Gad, to the people of
Gad, by their clans.
25 Their territory was Jazer and all the cities of Gilead,
and half the land of the people of Ammon, as far as
Aroer, which is near Rabbah,
26 and from Heshbon to Ramath Mizpeh and Betonim,
and from Mahanaim to the border of Debir,
27 and in the valley: Beth Haram, Beth Nimrah, Succoth,
and Zaphon,
the rest of the kingdom of Sihon, king of Heshbon,
with the bank of the Jordan to the far end of the sea of
Chinnereth, beyond the Jordan to the east.
28 This is the inheritance of the people of Gad by their
clans, the cities and their villages.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mahanaim is the place where Jacob met angels (Genesis 32:2). Succoth is the place where Jacob built shelters for his livestock (Genesis 33:17). The old stories of the ancestors are connected with this land.

The territory of the half-tribe of Manasseh VERSES 29–33

29 Moses gave an inheritance to the half-tribe of
Manasseh.
It was for the half-tribe of the people of Manasseh by
their clans.
30 Their territory went from Mahanaim: all Bashan, the
whole kingdom of Og, king of Bashan,
and all the villages of Jair, which are in Bashan, 60
cities.
31 Half of Gilead, Ashtaroth, and Edrei, the cities of the
kingdom of Og in Bashan,
were for the people of Machir, the son of Manasseh,
for half of the people of Machir by their clans.
32 These are the inheritances that Moses gave out in the
plains of Moab,
beyond the Jordan at Jericho, to the east.
33 But Moses gave no inheritance to the tribe of Levi.
The LORD, the God of Israel, is their inheritance, as he
told them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With this chapter, the second large part of the book of Joshua begins: the dividing of the land (Chapters 13–21). There are many names of places and borders. For us today, this is sometimes hard work to read. But for Israel it was very important: Every tribe and every family knew where their place in the land was. The land was a gift from God, and everyone received their share.

At the end comes the sentence about Levi once more: "The LORD, the God of Israel, is their inheritance." That is the most beautiful inheritance of all.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 14

Caleb receives Hebron

The land is divided by lot VERSES 1–5

1 These are the inheritances that the people of Israel
received in the land of Canaan.
Eleazar the priest, Joshua the son of Nun,
and the heads of the families of the tribes of the people
of Israel gave them out to them,
2 by the lot of their inheritance,
as the LORD had commanded through Moses,
for the nine tribes and for the half-tribe.
3 For Moses had given the inheritance of the two tribes
and the half-tribe beyond the Jordan.
But to the Levites he gave no inheritance among
them.
4 For the people of Joseph were two tribes, Manasseh and
Ephraim.
They gave the Levites no share in the land,
except cities to live in, with their pasture lands for
their livestock and for their property.
5 The people of Israel did as the LORD had commanded
Moses, and they divided the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The land is divided by lot. That way no one could say that they had been treated unfairly. People believed: God himself decides through the lot.

There are still 12 tribes with land: Levi gets no area of its own, but Joseph counts twice, as Ephraim and Manasseh. So the number works out again.

Caleb reminds Joshua of an old promise VERSES 6–12

6 Then the people of Judah came to Joshua in Gilgal.
Caleb, the son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite, said to him,
"You know what the LORD said to Moses, the man of God, in Kadesh Barnea,
about me and about you.
7 I was 40 years old when Moses, the servant of the LORD, sent me from Kadesh Barnea
to spy out the land.
I brought him back a report as it was in my heart.
8 But my brothers who went up with me made the hearts of the people melt with fear.
I, however, followed the LORD my God completely.
9 On that day Moses swore,
'Surely the land where your foot has walked will be an inheritance for you and for your children forever,
because you have followed the LORD my God completely.'
10 Now, look, the LORD has kept me alive, as he said,
these 45 years, since the time the LORD spoke this word to Moses,
while Israel walked in the wilderness.
And now, look, I am 85 years old today.
11 I am still as strong today as I was on the day Moses sent me.
As my strength was then, so is my strength now, for war, and for going out and coming in.
12 So now give me this hill country that the LORD spoke about on that day.
For you heard on that day that the Anakim were there, with great, walled cities.
Maybe the LORD will be with me, and I will drive them out, as the LORD said."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Caleb was one of the two faithful spies (Numbers 13–14). Joshua was the other one. The two old men have known each other for 45 years.

Caleb is 85 years old. But he says: I am still just as strong as back then. And he does not ask for a comfortable, safe piece of land. He wants the hardest area: the hill country where the "giants" live, the ones everyone was afraid of.

"Maybe the LORD will be with me": Caleb is not proud. He trusts God, not himself.

The numbers help us count: Caleb was 40 when he explored the land. After that, the people were in the wilderness for 38 more years. Now he is 85. So the conquest of the land took about seven years.

Caleb was a "Kenizzite." The Kenizzites were originally a people who did not belong to Israel (Genesis 15:19). His family was taken into the tribe of Judah. And it is he who becomes an example of faithfulness.

Joshua gives Hebron to Caleb VERSES 13–15

13 Joshua blessed him
and gave Hebron to Caleb, the son of Jephunneh, as his inheritance.
14 That is why Hebron belongs to Caleb, the son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite, as his inheritance to this day,
because he followed the LORD, the God of Israel, completely.
15 The name of Hebron used to be Kiriath Arba, after the greatest man among the Anakim.
And the land had rest from war.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hebron is a special city. Abraham had lived there, and Abraham, Sarah, Isaac, Rebekah, Jacob, and Leah are buried there (Genesis 23; 49:29–32). This very place becomes the inheritance of faithful Caleb.

"Kiriath Arba" means "city of Arba." Arba was the name of a famous man of the Anakim.

"Followed ... completely": This is said about Caleb again and again. It is the secret of his life.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 15

The territory of the tribe of Judah

The southern border VERSES 1–4

1 The tribe of Judah drew lots for its land.
Each clan got its share.
Their land reached to the border of Edom.
In the south it reached to the wilderness of Zin, at the very end of the south.
2 Their southern border began at the very end of the Salt Sea,
at the bay that faces south.
3 From there it went south of the Akrabbim Pass
and on to Zin.
It went up south of Kadesh Barnea
and on past Hezron.
It went up to Addar and turned toward Karka.
4 It went on to Azmon and came out at the brook of Egypt.
The border ended at the sea.
This will be your southern border.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Judah was the largest tribe. It receives its territory first, in the south of the land.

"Akrabbim" means "scorpions." The Akrabbim Pass is a steep mountain road in the south.

The borders are described much like the southern border of the whole land (Numbers 34:3–5).

The eastern and northern borders VERSES 5–11

5 The eastern border was the Salt Sea,
up to the place where the Jordan flows into it.

The northern border began at the bay of the sea,
where the Jordan flows in.
6 The border went up to Beth Hoglah
and went on north of Beth Arabah.
Then it went up to the Stone of Bohan.
Bohan was the son of Reuben.
7 From the valley of Achor, the border went up to Debir.
Then it turned north toward Gilgal.
Gilgal is across from the Adummim Pass, on the south
side of the stream.
The border went on to the waters of En Shemesh
and ended at En Rogel.
8 Then the border went up through the valley of the son
of Hinnom.
It ran along the south side of the city of the Jebusites.
That city is Jerusalem.
The border went up to the top of the mountain west of
the valley of Hinnom.
This mountain is at the north end of the valley of
Rephaim.
9 From the top of the mountain, the border went to the
spring of the waters of Nephtoah.
It came out at the cities of Mount Ephron.
Then it went to Baalah.
Baalah is also called Kiriath Jearim.
10 From Baalah the border turned west to Mount Seir.
It went on to the north side of Mount Jearim.
Mount Jearim is also called Chesalon.
The border went down to Beth Shemesh and on past
Timnah.
11 Then it came out at the north side of Ekron.
It went to Shikkeron, on to Mount Baalah, and came
out at Jabneel.
The border ended at the sea.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The northern border of Judah runs right along the south of Jerusalem, through the valley of Hinnom. Jerusalem itself still belongs to the Jebusites.

The "valley of Hinnom" later took on a sad meaning. In later times, children were sacrificed there to the idol Molech (2 Kings 23:10). From its Hebrew name "Ge-Hinnom" came the word "Gehenna," which is used in the New Testament for hell.

Mount Seir here is a small mountain near Jerusalem, not the mountains of Seir in Edom.

The western border VERSE 12

12 The western border was the coast of the great sea.
This is the border all around the land of the people of
Judah and their clans.

Caleb takes Hebron and Debir VERSES 13–19

13 Joshua gave Caleb, the son of Jephunneh, a share
among the people of Judah.
The LORD had told Joshua to do this.
Joshua gave him Kiriath Arba.
It was named after the father of Anak.
Kiriath Arba is Hebron.
14 Caleb drove out the three sons of Anak from there.
Their names were Sheshai, Ahiman, and Talmai.
They were descendants of Anak.
15 From there Caleb went up to fight against the people of
Debir.
Debir used to be called Kiriath Sepher.
16 Caleb said,
"I will give my daughter Achsah as a wife to the man
who attacks Kiriath Sepher and takes it."
17 Othniel took the city.
He was the son of Kenaz, Caleb's brother.
So Caleb gave him his daughter Achsah as his wife.
18 When Achsah came to Othniel, she got him to ask her
father for a field.
She got down from her donkey.
Caleb asked her, "What do you want?"
19 She said,
"Give me a blessing.
You have given me land in the South.
So give me springs of water too."
So Caleb gave her the upper springs and the lower
springs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The spies had already seen the three sons of Anak in Hebron 45 years earlier (Numbers 13:22). Now old Caleb drives out exactly these men.

Chapter 10 told that Joshua had already conquered Hebron and Debir. Here it says that Caleb conquers them. Maybe the cities were taken twice, or Joshua's campaign is summed up there and told in detail here.

At that time it was common for Caleb to promise his daughter as a prize. For us, this seems strange: The daughter is not asked.

But Achsah is a confident woman. She asks her father for what she needs: water. Land without water is worthless in the dry South. And her father even gives her more than she asked for.

Othniel later becomes the first judge in Israel (Judges 3:9–11). This story is told again in Judges 1:11–15.

The cities in the South VERSES 20–32

20 This is the land that the tribe of Judah received.
Each clan got its share.
21 These were the cities at the far end of Judah's land,
toward the border of Edom, in the South:
Kabzeel, Eder, Jagur,
22 Kinah, Dimonah, Adadah,
23 Kedesh, Hazor, Ithnan,
24 Ziph, Telem, Bealoth,
25 Hazor Hadattah, Kerioth Hezron (also called Hazor),
26 Amam, Shema, Moladah,
27 Hazar Gaddah, Heshmon, Beth Pelet,
28 Hazar Shual, Beersheba, Biziothiah,
29 Baalah, Iim, Ezem,
30 Eltolad, Chesil, Hormah,
31 Ziklag, Madmannah, Sansannah,
32 Lebaoth, Shilhim, Ain, and Rimmon.
That makes 29 cities in all, with their villages.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

If you count the names, you get more than 29. Maybe some names are two parts of a single place, for example "Ain Rimmon." Or some places were added later. These lists were passed on over a long time.

Beersheba is known from the stories of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob (Genesis 21; 26). Ziklag later became David's town when he fled from Saul (1 Samuel 27:6).

The cities in the lowland VERSES 33–47

33 In the lowland:
Eshtaol, Zorah, Ashnah,
34 Zanoah, En Gannim, Tappuah, Enam,
35 Jarmuth, Adullam, Socoh, Azekah,
36 Shaaraim, Adithaim, and Gederah (or Gederothaim).
14 cities with their villages.
37 Zenan, Hadashah, Migdal Gad,
38 Dilean, Mizpah, Joktheel,
39 Lachish, Bozkath, Eglon,
40 Cabbon, Lahmam, Chitlish,
41 Gederoth, Beth Dagon, Naamah, and Makkedah.
16 cities with their villages.
42 Libnah, Ether, Ashan,
43 Iphtah, Ashnah, Nezib,
44 Keilah, Achzib, and Mareshah.
Nine cities with their villages.
45 Ekron with its towns and its villages.
46 Then everything from Ekron to the sea that lay near Ashdod, with their villages.
47 Ashdod with its towns and its villages,
Gaza with its towns and its villages,
as far as the brook of Egypt and the coast of the great sea.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "towns" of a city were smaller places that belonged to a larger city.

In this lowland lie many places that become important in later stories: Zorah and Eshtaol in the story of Samson (Judges 13). Socoh and Azekah in David's fight against Goliath (1 Samuel 17:1). Adullam, where David hid in a cave (1 Samuel 22:1).

Ekron, Ashdod, and Gaza were cities of the Philistines. They were given to Judah, but for a long time Judah did not really rule them.

The cities in the hill country VERSES 48–60

48 In the hill country:
Shamir, Jattir, Socoh,
49 Dannah, Kiriath Sannah (which is Debir),
50 Anab, Eshtemoh, Anim,
51 Goshen, Holon, and Giloh.
11 cities with their villages.
52 Arab, Dumah, Eshan,
53 Janim, Beth Tappuah, Aphekah,
54 Humtah, Kiriath Arba (also called Hebron), and Zior.
Nine cities with their villages.
55 Maon, Carmel, Ziph, Jutah,
56 Jezreel, Jokdeam, Zanoah,
57 Kain, Gibeah, and Timnah.
10 cities with their villages.
58 Halhul, Beth Zur, Gedor,
59 Maarath, Beth Anoth, and Eltekon.
Six cities with their villages.
60 Kiriath Baal (also called Kiriath Jearim) and Rabbah.
Two cities with their villages.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Debir is called "Kiriath Sannah," in verse 15 "Kiriath Sepher." Both were old names of this city.

The Carmel here is a town in the south, not the well-known Mount Carmel in the north. Nabal and Abigail later lived there (1 Samuel 25:2).

The Jezreel here is also a town in Judah, not the well-known plain in the north.

In the Greek translation of the Bible, there is another list of 11 cities after verse 59, including Bethlehem. This list is missing in the Hebrew text and in the WEB, our English source text.

The cities in the wilderness VERSES 61–62

61 In the wilderness:
Beth Arabah, Middin, Secacah,
62 Nibshan, the City of Salt, and En Gedi.
Six cities with their villages.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "wilderness" here is the wilderness of Judah, which drops steeply down to the Dead Sea. En Gedi is an oasis with a waterfall. Later, David hid there from Saul (1 Samuel 24:1).

Some scholars think the "City of Salt" was near Qumran, where the famous Dead Sea Scrolls were found.

Jerusalem stays Jebusite VERSE 63

63 But the people of Judah could not drive out the Jebusites.
The Jebusites lived in Jerusalem.
So the Jebusites still live with the people of Judah in Jerusalem today.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An honest sentence: Judah could not take Jerusalem. Only King David conquered the city many years later and made it his capital (2 Samuel 5:6–9).

Until then, Jebusites and Israelites lived side by side. This shows: The land was not empty of people. The peoples often went on living side by side.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 16

The territory of Ephraim

The lot for the people of Joseph VERSES 1–4

1 The lot for the people of Joseph came out like this:
from the Jordan at Jericho, at the waters of Jericho on the east,

through the wilderness that goes up from Jericho
through the hill country to Bethel.
2 From Bethel it went out to Luz
and went along to the territory of the Archites, to
Ataroth.
3 It went down west to the territory of the Japhletites,
as far as the territory of Lower Beth Horon and on to
Gezer.
And it ended at the sea.
4 So the people of Joseph, Manasseh and Ephraim,
received their inheritance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After Judah in the south, the people of Joseph now receive their territory in the middle of the land. Joseph had two sons: Manasseh and Ephraim. Jacob had blessed both and put the younger one, Ephraim, ahead of the older one (Genesis 48).

"Bethel" and "Luz": Luz was the old name of Bethel (Genesis 28:19). Here they are named like two places close to each other.

"The Archites": Later, Hushai came from this family. He was the faithful friend and adviser of King David (2 Samuel 15:32).

The borders of Ephraim VERSES 5–9

5 This was the territory of the people of Ephraim by their
clans:
The border of their inheritance on the east was
Ataroth Addar, as far as Upper Beth Horon.
6 The border went out to the west, at Michmethath on
the north.
And the border turned east to Taanath Shiloh
and went along past it, east of Janoah.
7 It went down from Janoah to Ataroth and to Naarah,
reached Jericho, and went out at the Jordan.
8 From Tappuah the border went west to the brook of
Kanah and ended at the sea.
This is the inheritance of the tribe of the people of
Ephraim by their clans,
9 together with the cities that were set apart for the
people of Ephraim in the middle of the inheritance of
the people of Manasseh,
all the cities with their villages.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ephraim received fertile land in the hill country in the middle of the land. Later, Ephraim became one of the most powerful tribes. After the kingdom split, people sometimes called the whole northern kingdom simply "Ephraim" (for example Hosea 11:8).

Some cities of Ephraim lay in the territory of Manasseh. The brother tribes lived closely together.

The Canaanites in Gezer VERSE 10

10 But they did not drive out the Canaanites who lived in
Gezer.
So the Canaanites live in the middle of Ephraim to this
day.
But they became servants who had to do forced labor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Another honest sentence: Ephraim did not drive out the Canaanites in Gezer. They stayed, but they had to do forced labor.

Much later, the Pharaoh of Egypt conquered Gezer and gave the city to his daughter as a wedding gift when she married King Solomon (1 Kings 9:16).

The book of Judges looks critically at this incomplete conquest: The peoples who stayed in the land later led Israel into worshiping idols (Judges 1:29; 2:1–3). Forced labor for people of another nation does not fit our understanding of human dignity today.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 17

The territory of Manasseh

The clans of Manasseh VERSES 1–2

1 This was the lot for the tribe of Manasseh, for he was
the firstborn of Joseph.
Machir, the firstborn of Manasseh, the father of
Gilead, was a man of war.
That is why he received Gilead and Bashan.
2 And this lot was for the rest of the people of Manasseh
by their clans:
for the people of Abiezer, for the people of Helek, for
the people of Asriel,
for the people of Shechem, for the people of Hepher,
and for the people of Shemida.
These were the male descendants of Manasseh the son
of Joseph, by their clans.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Machir had already received land east of the Jordan (Chapter 13). Now the other clans of Manasseh receive land west of the Jordan.

Later, Gideon, one of the best-known judges, came from the clan of Abiezer (Judges 6:11).

The daughters of Zelophehad receive their inheritance VERSES 3–6

3 But Zelophehad, the son of Hepher, the son of Gilead,
the son of Machir, the son of Manasseh,
had no sons, only daughters.
These are the names of his daughters: Mahlah, Noah,
Hoglah, Milcah, and Tirzah.
4 They came to Eleazar the priest, to Joshua the son of
Nun, and to the leaders and said,
"The LORD commanded Moses to give us an
inheritance among our brothers."
So, as the LORD had commanded, he gave them an
inheritance among their father's brothers.
5 So 10 shares fell to Manasseh,
in addition to the land of Gilead and Bashan, which is
beyond the Jordan.

6 For the daughters of Manasseh received an inheritance among his sons.
And the land of Gilead belonged to the rest of the sons of Manasseh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

We know the five sisters from Numbers 27 and 36. Moses had promised them an inheritance. Now, years later, they confidently remind the leaders of it. And the promise is kept.

The 10 shares: 5 for the clans of the sons (without Hepher) and 5 for the daughters of Zelophehad. The women receive land just like the men.

The borders of Manasseh VERSES 7–13

7 The border of Manasseh went from Asher to Michmethath, which is opposite Shechem.
And the border went along to the right, to the people of En Tappuah.
8 The land of Tappuah belonged to Manasseh,
but the town of Tappuah on the border of Manasseh belonged to the people of Ephraim.
9 The border went down to the brook of Kanah, south of the brook.
These cities belonged to Ephraim, among the cities of Manasseh.
The border of Manasseh was on the north side of the brook and ended at the sea.
10 What lay to the south belonged to Ephraim, and what lay to the north belonged to Manasseh.
The sea was its border.
They reached Asher on the north and Issachar on the east.
11 In Issachar and in Asher, Manasseh had three heights:
Beth Shean and its towns, Ibleam and its towns,
the people of Dor and its towns,
the people of Endor and its towns,
the people of Taanach and its towns,
and the people of Megiddo and its towns.
12 But the people of Manasseh could not drive out the people of those cities.
The Canaanites were determined to stay in that land.
13 When the people of Israel grew strong, they put the Canaanites to forced labor.
But they did not drive them out completely.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"To the right" often means "to the south" in the Bible, because people faced east, toward the sunrise, when they named directions.

"The three heights": It is not clear what exactly this means. Maybe it means three cities on hills from this list.

Beth Shean, Megiddo, and Taanach were strong, walled cities in the fertile plain. Manasseh could not take them. Again the Bible honestly says: The conquest was not complete.

Later, the woman who called up the dead, whom King Saul visited, lived in Endor (1 Samuel 28).

Forced labor for people of another nation does not fit our understanding of human dignity today.

The people of Joseph want more land VERSES 14–18

14 The people of Joseph spoke to Joshua. They said,
"Why have you given me only one lot and one share as an inheritance?
We are a large people, because the LORD has blessed us so far."
15 Joshua said to them,
"If you are a large people,
go up to the forest and clear land for yourselves there,
in the land of the Perizzites and of the Rephaim,
since the hill country of Ephraim is too small for you."
16 The people of Joseph said,
"The hill country is not enough for us.
And all the Canaanites who live in the land of the valley have chariots of iron,
both those in Beth Shean and its towns and those in the valley of Jezreel."
17 Joshua spoke to the house of Joseph, to Ephraim and to Manasseh. He said,
"You are a large people and have great power.
You will not have just one lot.
18 The hill country will be yours too.
Even though it is a forest, you will cut it down, and it will be yours to its farthest edges.
For you will drive out the Canaanites, even though they have chariots of iron and are strong."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people of Joseph complain: We are so many, we need more land! Joshua answers wisely: If you are so many and so strong, then work! Clear the forest.

They are afraid of the iron chariots in the plain. But Joshua gives them courage: You are strong enough.

Joshua himself came from the tribe of Ephraim. Still, he does not favor his own tribe. He does not give it land as a gift. He challenges it.

The hill country was still thickly wooded at that time. Archaeologists have found that around 1200 BC many new small villages came into being in the hill country. Many scholars see this as the beginnings of Israel.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 18

The tent in Shiloh – the territory of Benjamin

The Tent of Meeting comes to Shiloh VERSE 1

1 The whole community of the people of Israel gathered at Shiloh,
and they set up the Tent of Meeting there.
The land was under their control.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shiloh lies in the middle of the land, in the territory of Ephraim. The holy tent is set up here. For more than 200

years, Shiloh is the center of worship in Israel. Later, Hannah, the mother of the prophet Samuel, prayed here (1 Samuel 1).

It is an important moment: God now lives in the middle of his land.

Seven tribes still have no land VERSES 2–10

2 Among the people of Israel, there were still seven tribes
that had not yet received their inheritance.
3 Joshua said to the people of Israel,
"How long will you wait to go in and take the land
that the LORD, the God of your ancestors, has given
you?
4 Choose three men from each tribe.
I will send them out.
They will get up, walk through the land,
and describe it by the inheritance each tribe will
receive.
Then they will come back to me.
5 They will divide it into seven parts.
Judah will stay in its territory in the south,
and the house of Joseph will stay in its territory in the
north.
6 Describe the land in seven parts,
and bring the description here to me.
Then I will cast lots for you here in front of the LORD
our God.
7 But the Levites have no share among you,
for the priesthood of the LORD is their inheritance.
And Gad, Reuben, and the half-tribe of Manasseh have
received their inheritance east of the Jordan,
which Moses, the servant of the LORD, gave them."
8 The men got up and went.
Joshua commanded those who went to describe the
land:
"Go, walk through the land, describe it, and come back
to me.
Then I will cast lots for you here in front of the LORD
in Shiloh."
9 The men went and passed through the land.
They described it city by city, in seven parts, in a book.
And they came back to Joshua at the camp at Shiloh.
10 Joshua cast lots for them in Shiloh in front of the
LORD.
There Joshua divided the land among the people of
Israel by their divisions.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Seven tribes are still waiting. Joshua asks them: "How long will you wait to go in and take the land?" God has given them the land as a gift, but they also have to take it.

This is a lesson for today too: God's gifts want to be received. We must not just sit and wait.

The 21 men are like land surveyors. They write everything down in a book. This is one of the first descriptions of a land survey in history.

The borders of Benjamin VERSES 11–20

11 The lot of the tribe of the people of Benjamin came out,
by their clans.
The territory of their lot lay between the people of
Judah and the people of Joseph.
12 Their border on the north side began at the Jordan.
The border went up along the side of Jericho on the
north
and went up through the hill country to the west.
And it ended at the wilderness of Beth Aven.
13 From there the border went along to Luz, to the side of
Luz (that is, Bethel) on the south.
The border went down to Ataroth Addar, by the
mountain south of Lower Beth Horon.
14 The border went on and turned south on the west side,
from the mountain that lies south, in front of Beth
Horon.
And it ended at Kiriath Baal (that is, Kiriath Jearim), a
city of the people of Judah.
This was the west side.
15 The south side began at the far edge of Kiriath Jearim.
The border went out to the west and went out to the
spring of the waters of Nephtoah.
16 The border went down to the far edge of the mountain
that lies in front of the valley of the son of Hinnom,
which is at the north end of the valley of Rephaim.
It went down to the valley of Hinnom, along the south
side of the Jebusite city,
and went down to En Rogel.
17 It stretched north, went out at En Shemesh,
and went out to Geliloth, which is opposite the ascent
of Adummim.
And it went down to the stone of Bohan, the son of
Reuben.
18 It went along to the side opposite the Arabah, on the
north, and went down into the Arabah.
19 The border went along to the side of Beth Hoglah, on
the north.
And the border ended at the north bay of the Salt Sea,
at the south end of the Jordan.
This was the southern border.
20 And the Jordan was its border on the east side.
This was the inheritance of the people of Benjamin, by
its borders all around, by their clans.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Benjamin was a small tribe. It received a small but important area between the two large tribes of Judah and Ephraim.

The southern border of Benjamin is exactly the northern border of Judah (Chapter 15). It runs along the valley of Hinnom, right past Jerusalem.

Later, the first king of Israel, Saul, came from Benjamin (1 Samuel 9:1–2). And in the New Testament, the apostle Paul says of himself that he comes from the tribe of Benjamin (Philippians 3:5).

The cities of Benjamin VERSES 21–28

21 The cities of the tribe of the people of Benjamin by their
clans were:
Jericho, Beth Hoglah, Emek Keziz,
22 Beth Arabah, Zemaraim, Bethel,
23 Avvim, Parah, Ophrah,
24 Chephar Ammoni, Ophni, and Geba.
That makes 12 cities with their villages.
25 Gibeon, Ramah, Beeroth,
26 Mizpeh, Chephirah, Mozah,

27 Rekem, Irpeel, Taralah,
28 Zelah, Eleph, the Jebusite city (that is, Jerusalem),
Gibeath, and Kiriath.
That makes 14 cities with their villages.
This is the inheritance of the people of Benjamin by their clans.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Jerusalem is given to Benjamin. In Joshua 15:63 it was named with Judah. It lay exactly on the border between the two tribes.

"Gibeath" is probably Gibeah, the hometown of King Saul.

Gibeon also belongs to Benjamin. It is the city of the Gibeonites, with whom Israel had made a covenant (Chapter 9).

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 19

The territories of the other tribes

Simeon VERSES 1–9

1 The second lot came out for Simeon.
It was for the tribe of Simeon and its clans.
Their land lay in the middle of the land of the people of Judah.
2 These cities became their land: Beersheba (or Sheba), Moladah,
3 Hazar Shual, Balah, Ezem,
4 Eltolad, Bethul, Hormah,
5 Ziklag, Beth Marcaboth, Hazar Susah,
6 Beth Lebaoth, and Sharuhen.
That makes 13 cities with their villages.
7 Ain, Rimmon, Ether, and Ashan.
That makes 4 cities with their villages.
8 They also got all the villages around these cities, as far as Baalath Beer.
Baalath Beer is Ramah of the South.
This is the land of the tribe of Simeon and its clans.
9 The land of the people of Simeon was taken from the share of the people of Judah.
The share of the people of Judah was too large for them.
So the people of Simeon received their land in the middle of Judah's land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Simeon gets no area of its own, but cities in the middle of Judah. This fulfills what Jacob said before he died: Simeon will be scattered in Israel (Genesis 49:7).

Later, the tribe of Simeon became completely part of the tribe of Judah. That is why it is no longer mentioned in the blessing of Moses in Deuteronomy 33.

Judah had too much land. It shares with its smaller brother tribe.

If you count "Sheba" as its own place, there are 14 names in verses 2–6. But "Beersheba (or Sheba)" probably means the same place. Then the number 13 is right.

Zebulun VERSES 10–16

10 The third lot came up for the people of Zebulun and their clans.
The border of their land went as far as Sarid.
11 From there their border went up west to Maralah and reached Dabbesheth.
It reached the brook across from Jokneam.
12 From Sarid the border turned east, toward the sunrise, to the border of Chisloth Tabor.
It came out at Daberath and went up to Japhia.
13 From there it went on east to Gath Hepher and to Ethkazin.
It came out at Rimmon, which reaches to Neah.
14 On the north, the border turned around to Hannathon.
It ended at the valley of Iphtah El.
15 Kattath, Nahalal, Shimron, Idalah, and Bethlehem also belonged to them.
That makes 12 cities with their villages.
16 This is the land of the people of Zebulun and their clans.
These cities and their villages were theirs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zebulun received an area in Galilee in the north. Later, the town of Nazareth, where Jesus grew up, lay in this area.

Gath Hepher was the home of the prophet Jonah (2 Kings 14:25).

The Bethlehem here is a different town in Galilee, not the Bethlehem in Judah where David and Jesus were born.

Issachar VERSES 17–23

17 The fourth lot came out for Issachar.
It was for the people of Issachar and their clans.
18 Their land reached to Jezreel, Chesulloth, Shunem,
19 Hapharaim, Shion, Anaharath,
20 Rabbith, Kishion, Ebez,
21 Remeth, Engannim, En Haddah, and Beth Pazzez.
22 The border reached Tabor, Shahazumah, and Beth Shemesh.
Their border ended at the Jordan.
That makes 16 cities with their villages.
23 This is the land of the tribe of Issachar and its clans.
These cities and their villages were theirs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Issachar received the fertile plain of Jezreel. Tabor is a striking, round mountain. Many Christians believe that the transfiguration of Jesus took place there (Mark 9:2).

In Shunem lived the woman whose son the prophet Elisha raised from the dead (2 Kings 4).

Asher VERSES 24–31

24 The fifth lot came out for the tribe of Asher and its clans.

25 Their border took in Helkath, Hali, Beten, Achshaph,
26 Allammelech, Amad, and Mishal.
In the west it reached Carmel and Shihorlibnath.
27 Then it turned east, toward the sunrise, to Beth Dagon.
It reached Zebulun and the valley of Iphtah El.
In the north it went to Beth Emek and Neiel.
It came out at Cabul on the left side,
28 and at Ebron, Rehob, Hammon, and Kanah, as far as the great city of Sidon.
29 The border turned to Ramah and to the strong, walled city of Tyre.
Then it turned to Hosah.
It ended at the sea, in the area of Achzib.
30 Ummah, Aphek, and Rehob also belonged to them.
That makes 22 cities with their villages.
31 This is the land of the tribe of Asher and its clans.
These cities and their villages were theirs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Asher received the coast in the north, as far as the great trading cities of Sidon and Tyre in what is now Lebanon. Israel never really ruled these cities.

Carmel is a mountain range by the sea, near the modern city of Haifa. Later, the prophet Elijah had his great contest with the prophets of Baal there (1 Kings 18).

Naphtali VERSES 32–39

32 The sixth lot came out for the people of Naphtali.
It was for the people of Naphtali and their clans.
33 Their border went from Heleph, from the oak tree in Zaanannim,
past Adami-nekeb and Jabneel, to Lakkum.
It ended at the Jordan.
34 Then the border turned west to Aznoth Tabor.
From there it came out at Hukkok.
In the south it reached Zebulun.
In the west it reached Asher.
And in the east, toward the sunrise, it reached Judah at the Jordan.
35 The strong, walled cities were Ziddim, Zer, Hammath, Rakkath, Chinnereth,
36 Adamah, Ramah, Hazor,
37 Kedesh, Edrei, En Hazor,
38 Iron, Migdal El, Horem, Beth Anath, and Beth Shemesh.
That makes 19 cities with their villages.
39 This is the land of the tribe of Naphtali and its clans.
These cities and their villages were theirs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Naphtali received the land by the Sea of Galilee (Chinnereth) and north of it. Later, Jesus preached and did miracles here a lot. Matthew quotes the prophet Isaiah about it: The land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali, the people who sat in darkness, have seen a great light (Matthew 4:13–16).

"Judah at the Jordan" in the east is a puzzle, because Judah lay far to the south. Maybe a place with a similar name is meant. The Greek translation does not have these words.

Dan VERSES 40–48

40 The seventh lot came out for the tribe of Dan and its clans.
41 The border of their land took in Zorah, Eshtaol, Irshemesh,
42 Shaalabbin, Aijalon, Ithlah,
43 Elon, Timnah, Ekron,
44 Eltekeh, Gibbethon, Baalath,
45 Jehud, Bene Berak, Gath Rimmon,
46 Me Jarkon, and Rakkon, with the land across from Joppa.
47 The territory of the people of Dan went out beyond them.
The people of Dan went up and fought against Leshem.
They took the city and killed its people with the sword.
They took it as their own and lived there.
They called Leshem "Dan."
They named it after their ancestor Dan.
48 This is the land of the tribe of Dan and its clans.
These cities and their villages were theirs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The territory of the people of Dan went out beyond them": This is what the WEB says. The Hebrew sentence is hard to understand. Many translate: "The territory was lost to them," because the Amorites pressed them hard (Judges 1:34).

Dan first received an area on the coast, near the modern city of Tel Aviv. "Joppa" is today's Jaffa. "Bene Berak" still exists as a city today.

Because they could not hold on there, they moved far to the north and took the city of Leshem (also called Laish). This story is told in detail in Judges 18. After that, people said for all of Israel: from Dan to Beersheba (Judges 20:1), that is, from the north to the south.

Zorah belonged to Dan. Samson came from there (Judges 13:2).

Joshua's inheritance VERSES 49–51

49 So they finished dividing up the land.
Every tribe got its land with its borders.
Then the people of Israel gave Joshua, the son of Nun, land of his own among them.
50 The LORD had commanded it.
They gave Joshua the city he asked for:
Timnathserah in the hill country of Ephraim.
Joshua built up the city and lived there.
51 Eleazar the priest, Joshua the son of Nun,
and the heads of the families of the tribes of Israel divided up the land.
They did it by lot, in Shiloh, in front of the LORD,
at the door of the Tent of Meeting.
These are the shares they gave out.
So they finished dividing the land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joshua takes his inheritance last. Only when everyone else has been provided for does he receive his piece of land. And he does not take a large, splendid city, but a place that he must first build himself. He is a leader who thinks of others first.

With this chapter, the dividing of the land is complete. The promise to Abraham is fulfilled: His descendants have a

land where they can live.

JOSHUA

Chapter 20

The cities of refuge

God's command VERSES 1–6

1 The LORD spoke to Joshua. He said,
2 "Speak to the people of Israel and say,
'Choose the cities of refuge that I spoke to you about
through Moses.
3 Anyone who kills a person by accident or without
meaning to may run there.
These cities will be a refuge for you from the avenger
of blood.
4 He must run to one of these cities.
He must stand at the entrance of the city gate
and explain his case to the elders of that city.
Then they must take him into the city with them
and give him a place, so that he can live among them.
5 If the avenger of blood chases him,
they must not hand over the killer to him.
For he struck his neighbor without meaning to and
did not hate him before.
6 He must live in that city until he has stood trial in front
of the community,
until the death of the high priest who is serving in
those days.
Then the one who killed may return
and come to his own city and his own house, to the city
he ran away from.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2–3: A refuge is a safe place. The avenger of blood is the relative who wants to take revenge for the dead person.

The cities of refuge were announced in Numbers 35 and Deuteronomy 19. Now, in the land, they are really set up. God's promises are carried out step by step.

What is new here: The person running away must explain his case at the city gate. The elders listen to him and take him in. At that time, the gate was the place where court was held.

This arrangement protects against people taking the law into their own hands. Revenge should not decide, but a fair trial.

Six cities VERSES 7–9

7 So they set apart Kedesh in Galilee in the hill country of
Naphtali,
Shechem in the hill country of Ephraim,
and Kiriath Arba (that is, Hebron) in the hill country
of Judah.
8 And beyond the Jordan at Jericho, to the east, they
chose:
Bezer in the wilderness, on the plain, from the tribe of
Reuben,
Ramoth in Gilead from the tribe of Gad,
and Golan in Bashan from the tribe of Manasseh.
9 These were the chosen cities for all the people of Israel
and for the foreigner who lives among them,
so that anyone who killed a person without meaning to
could run there
and not die by the hand of the avenger of blood
before he had stood trial in front of the community.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The six cities are well spread out over the land: three west and three east of the Jordan, each in the north, in the middle, and in the south. That way everyone could find a city of refuge within reach.

"They set apart" means: They chose these cities for a special task and made them holy.

Again it is said clearly: The right to refuge is for foreigners too. Before God's law, everyone is equal.

All six cities of refuge were also cities of the Levites (Chapter 21). So the servants of God were at the same time the protectors of those who were being hunted.

JOSHUA

Chapter 21

The cities of the Levites – God keeps his word

The Levites ask for their cities VERSES 1–8

1 The heads of the families of the Levites came to Eleazar
the priest
and to Joshua, the son of Nun.
They also came to the heads of the families of the tribes
of Israel.
2 They spoke to them at Shiloh, in the land of Canaan.
They said,
"The LORD gave a command through Moses.
He said that we should get cities to live in.
And we should get the pasture lands around them for
our animals."
3 So the people of Israel gave the Levites these cities and
their pasture lands.
They gave them from their own land, as the LORD had
commanded.
4 The first lot came out for the clans of the Kohathites.
The descendants of Aaron the priest, who were
Levites,
received 13 cities by lot.

The cities came from the tribe of Judah, the tribe of Simeon, and the tribe of Benjamin.

5 The other descendants of Kohath received 10 cities by lot.
The cities came from the clans of the tribe of Ephraim, from the tribe of Dan, and from the half-tribe of Manasseh.

6 The descendants of Gershon received 13 cities by lot.
The cities came from the clans of the tribe of Issachar, from the tribe of Asher, from the tribe of Naphtali, and from the half-tribe of Manasseh in Bashan.

7 The descendants of Merari and their clans received 12 cities.
The cities came from the tribe of Reuben, the tribe of Gad, and the tribe of Zebulun.

8 So the people of Israel gave these cities and their pasture lands to the Levites by lot.
The LORD had commanded this through Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Levites have no territory of their own. But they need a place to live. So all the other tribes give them cities, as Moses had ordered (Numbers 35:1–8).

The Levites were made up of three large families, named after the sons of Levi: Kohath, Gershon, and Merari. The priests, the descendants of Aaron, belonged to the family of Kohath.

The priests received cities near Jerusalem. That fits well, because later the temple stood there.

The cities of the priests VERSES 9–19

9 The tribe of Judah and the tribe of Simeon gave these cities.
Here are their names.

10 The cities were for the descendants of Aaron.
They belonged to the clans of the Kohathites, who were descendants of Levi.
The first lot had come out for them.

11 The tribes gave them Kiriath Arba, with the pasture lands around it.
It was named after the father of Anak.
Kiriath Arba is Hebron, in the hill country of Judah.

12 But the fields of the city and its villages went to Caleb, the son of Jephunneh.
They became his own land.

13 The descendants of Aaron the priest received these cities:
Hebron with its pasture lands.
Hebron was a city of refuge for a person who had killed someone.
They also received Libnah with its pasture lands,

14 Jattir with its pasture lands, Eshtemoa with its pasture lands,

15 Holon with its pasture lands, Debir with its pasture lands,

16 Ain with its pasture lands, Juttah with its pasture lands, and Beth Shemesh with its pasture lands.
That makes 9 cities from those two tribes.

17 From the tribe of Benjamin they received Gibeon with its pasture lands, Geba with its pasture lands,

18 Anathoth with its pasture lands, and Almon with its pasture lands.
That makes 4 cities.

19 So the priests, the descendants of Aaron, received 13 cities in all, with their pasture lands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hebron now belongs to both the priests and Caleb. The priests get the city to live in, and Caleb gets the fields and villages around it. That is how it is shared.

Anathoth later was the hometown of the prophet Jeremiah. He came from a family of priests (Jeremiah 1:1).

9 and 4 make 13. The count is right.

The cities of the other Kohathites VERSES 20–26

20 Then there were the other clans of the descendants of Kohath.
They were Levites too.
By lot, they received cities from the tribe of Ephraim.

21 The tribes gave them Shechem with its pasture lands, in the hill country of Ephraim.
Shechem was a city of refuge for a person who had killed someone.
They also gave them Gezer with its pasture lands,

22 Kibzaim with its pasture lands, and Beth Horon with its pasture lands.
That makes 4 cities.

23 From the tribe of Dan they received Elteke with its pasture lands, Gibbethon with its pasture lands,

24 Aijalon with its pasture lands, and Gath Rimmon with its pasture lands.
That makes 4 cities.

25 From the half-tribe of Manasseh they received Taanach with its pasture lands and Gath Rimmon with its pasture lands.
That makes 2 cities.

26 So the clans of the other descendants of Kohath received 10 cities in all, with their pasture lands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gath Rimmon is named twice, with Dan and with Manasseh. The second time, maybe a different place is meant. In 1 Chronicles 6:70 there is a different name at this place.

4, 4, and 2 make 10.

The cities of the Gershonites VERSES 27–33

27 The descendants of Gershon belonged to the clans of the Levites.
From the half-tribe of Manasseh they received Golan in Bashan with its pasture lands.
Golan was a city of refuge for a person who had killed someone.
They also received Be Eshterah with its pasture lands.
That makes 2 cities.

28 From the tribe of Issachar they received Kishion with its pasture lands, Daberath with its pasture lands,

29 Jarmuth with its pasture lands, and En Gannim with its pasture lands.
That makes 4 cities.

30 From the tribe of Asher they received Mishal with its pasture lands, Abdon with its pasture lands,

31 Helkath with its pasture lands, and Rehob with its pasture lands.

That makes 4 cities.
32 From the tribe of Naphtali they received Kedesh in Galilee with its pasture lands.
Kedesh was a city of refuge for a person who had killed someone.
They also received Hammothdor with its pasture lands, and Kartan with its pasture lands.
That makes 3 cities.
33 So the Gershonites and their clans received 13 cities in all, with their pasture lands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

2, 4, 4, and 3 make 13.

The Gershonites lived in the north, in Galilee and in Bashan.

The cities of the Merarites VERSES 34–40

34 The clans of the descendants of Merari were the rest of the Levites.
From the tribe of Zebulun they received Jokneam with its pasture lands, Kartah with its pasture lands,
35 Dimnah with its pasture lands, and Nahalal with its pasture lands.
That makes 4 cities.
36 From the tribe of Reuben they received Bezer with its pasture lands, Jahaz with its pasture lands,
37 Kedemoth with its pasture lands, and Mephaath with its pasture lands.
That makes 4 cities.
38 From the tribe of Gad they received Ramoth in Gilead with its pasture lands.
Ramoth was a city of refuge for a person who had killed someone.
They also received Mahanaim with its pasture lands,
39 Heshbon with its pasture lands, and Jazer with its pasture lands.
That makes 4 cities in all.
40 These were all the cities of the descendants of Merari and their clans.
They were the rest of the clans of the Levites.
By lot they received 12 cities.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

4, 4, and 4 make 12.

Many Hebrew manuscripts do not have verses 36 and 37 about the cities of Reuben. Other manuscripts and the WEB do have them. Without them, the number 12 would not be right.

48 cities in all VERSES 41–42

41 So the Levites received 48 cities in all, with their pasture lands.
These cities lay in the land that belonged to the people of Israel.
42 Each of these cities had its pasture lands around it.
It was the same with all these cities.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

13 + 10 + 13 + 12 = 48. That is exactly as many as Moses had ordered (Numbers 35:7).

Now the Levites lived spread out over the whole land. So they were close to the people everywhere and could teach them God's law.

God has fulfilled everything VERSES 43–45

43 So the LORD gave Israel all the land.
He had promised with an oath to give it to their ancestors.
The people took the land and lived in it.
44 The LORD gave them peace on every side.
He had promised this to their ancestors with an oath.
None of their enemies could stand against them.
The LORD gave all their enemies into their power.
45 The LORD had promised good things to the people of Israel.
Not one of these good things failed.
Everything came true.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most important sentences in the whole book of Joshua: "The LORD had promised good things to the people of Israel. Not one of these good things failed. Everything came true."

Hundreds of years earlier, God had promised Abraham a land. Now it is fulfilled. God keeps his word.

Of course, we know from the chapters before that not all the peoples had been driven out yet. But the narrator wants to say: On God's side, nothing is missing. If something is still open, it is not because of God.

In hard times, many people have read this verse as a comfort: Even if I cannot see it yet, God keeps his promises.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 22

The altar by the Jordan

The tribes east of the Jordan may go home VERSES 1–9

1 Then Joshua called the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh.
2 He said to them,
"You have kept everything that Moses, the servant of the LORD, commanded you.
And you have listened to my voice in everything I commanded you.
3 You have not left your brothers alone all this long time, to this day.
You have faithfully done what the LORD your God commanded.
4 And now the LORD your God has given rest to your brothers, as he told them.
So now turn back and go to your tents,
to the land that belongs to you,
which Moses, the servant of the LORD, gave you beyond the Jordan.

5 Only be very careful to do the commandment and the law
that Moses, the servant of the LORD, commanded you:
to love the LORD your God, to walk in all his ways,
to keep his commandments, to hold on to him,
and to serve him with all your heart and with all your soul."
6 Then Joshua blessed them and sent them away.
And they went to their tents.
7 To one half-tribe of Manasseh, Moses had given an inheritance in Bashan.
But to the other half, Joshua had given an inheritance among their brothers west of the Jordan.
When Joshua sent them away to their tents, he blessed them
8 and said to them,
"Go back to your tents with great wealth,
with very much livestock, with silver, gold, bronze, and iron, and with very much clothing.
Share the goods you took from your enemies with your brothers."
9 So the people of Reuben, the people of Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh turned back.
They left the people of Israel at Shiloh, which is in the land of Canaan,
to go to the land of Gilead, to the land that belonged to them,
which they had taken as the LORD had commanded through Moses.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The two and a half tribes have kept their promise (Numbers 32). For many years they fought together with their brothers, even though they already had their own land. Joshua praises them for it.

And he gives them the most important thing to take with them: Love God. Hold on to him. With all your heart and all your soul. This is the same message as in the "Shema Israel" (Deuteronomy 6:5).

"Share the goods ... with your brothers": Those who stayed at home should also receive something.

A large altar VERSES 10–12

10 When they came to the region by the Jordan that is in the land of Canaan,
the people of Reuben, the people of Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh built an altar there by the Jordan,
a large altar that could be seen from far away.
11 The people of Israel heard about it:
"Look, the people of Reuben, the people of Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh
have built an altar on the border of the land of Canaan,
in the region by the Jordan,
on the side that belongs to the people of Israel."
12 When the people of Israel heard it,
the whole community of the people of Israel gathered at Shiloh
to go to war against them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

According to the law, there could only be one altar for sacrifices, at the place God chooses (Deuteronomy 12). A second altar looked like turning away from God.

The other tribes are ready right away to go to war against their own brothers. The situation is very dangerous.

Messengers are sent VERSES 13–20

13 The people of Israel sent Phinehas, the son of Eleazar the priest,
to the people of Reuben, the people of Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh, in the land of Gilead.
14 With him were 10 leaders, one leader of a family for each tribe of Israel.
Each of them was the head of his family among the thousands of Israel.
15 They came to the people of Reuben, the people of Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh, in the land of Gilead,
and spoke with them. They said,
16 "The whole community of the LORD says:
'What is this unfaithfulness that you have done against the God of Israel?
Today you are turning away from following the LORD by building yourselves an altar, to rebel against the LORD today!
17 Is the sin of Peor not enough for us?
We have not cleansed ourselves from it to this day,
even though a plague came on the community of the LORD.
18 And today you are turning away from following the LORD?
If you rebel against the LORD today,
then tomorrow he will be angry with the whole community of Israel.
19 But if the land that belongs to you is unclean,
then come over to the land that belongs to the LORD,
where the LORD's tabernacle stands,
and take land among us.
But do not rebel against the LORD, and do not rebel against us,
by building yourselves an altar other than the altar of the LORD our God.
20 Didn't Achan the son of Zerah act unfaithfully with the devoted things,
and anger fell on the whole community of Israel?
And that man was not the only one who died because of his sin.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before they fight, the tribes send messengers. They want to talk first. That is wise. Many wars could have been avoided if people had talked with each other first.

Phinehas was the priest who had acted so firmly against the worship of idols at Baal Peor back then (Numbers 25).

The messengers remind them of Peor and of Achan: When some are unfaithful, the whole people suffers.

Verse 19 is remarkable: They even offer to share their own land if the eastern tribes do not feel at home over there. That is a generous offer.

The answer: an altar as a witness VERSES 21–29

21 Then the people of Reuben, the people of Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh answered.
They said to the heads of the thousands of Israel,

22 "The Mighty One, God, the LORD! The Mighty One,
God, the LORD, he knows!
And Israel shall know:
If it was in rebellion or in unfaithfulness against the
LORD,
then do not save us today!
23 If we have built ourselves an altar to turn away from
following the LORD,
or to offer burnt offerings or grain offerings on it,
or to sacrifice peace offerings on it,
then let the LORD himself punish us for it.
24 No, we did this out of worry, for a reason.
We thought, 'In the future your children might say to
our children,
"What do you have to do with the LORD, the God of
Israel?
25 For the LORD has made the Jordan a border between us
and you,
you people of Reuben and people of Gad.
You have no share in the LORD."'
So your children might make our children stop
fearing the LORD.
26 That is why we said,
'Let's get ready and build ourselves an altar,
not for burnt offerings and not for sacrifices,
27 but to be a witness between us and you,
and between our generations after us,
that we serve the LORD in front of him
with our burnt offerings, our sacrifices, and our peace
offerings.'
Then your children cannot say to our children in the
future,
'You have no share in the LORD.'
28 That is why we said,
'If they say this to us or to our descendants in the
future,
we will answer,
"Look at the copy of the LORD's altar, which our
ancestors made,
not for burnt offerings and not for sacrifices,
but as a witness between us and you."'
29 Far be it from us to rebel against the LORD
and to turn away from following the LORD today
by building an altar for burnt offerings, grain
offerings, or sacrifices,
besides the altar of the LORD our God that stands in
front of his tabernacle!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The Mighty One, God, the LORD": In Hebrew, three names of God stand here one after the other: "El, Elohim, YHWH." They say it twice. It is a solemn oath.

It was a misunderstanding! The eastern tribes did not want to turn away from God. Just the opposite: They were afraid that their children would later be shut out because the Jordan lies between them. The altar was not meant to be an altar for sacrifices but a memorial. A reminder: We belong to God's people too.

This is an important lesson: Before you judge someone, ask and listen. What looks like turning away from the outside can really be a sign of faithfulness.

Peace instead of war VERSES 30–34

30 Phinehas the priest and the leaders of the community,
the heads of the thousands of Israel who were with
him,
heard the words that the people of Reuben, the people
of Gad, and the people of Manasseh spoke.
They were very pleased.
31 Phinehas, the son of Eleazar the priest, said to the
people of Reuben, the people of Gad, and the people of
Manasseh,
"Today we know that the LORD is among us,
because you have not done this unfaithful thing
against the LORD.
Now you have saved the people of Israel from the hand
of the LORD."
32 Then Phinehas, the son of Eleazar the priest, and the
leaders
went back from the people of Reuben and the people of
Gad, from the land of Gilead, to the land of Canaan, to
the people of Israel,
and brought them the report.
33 The people of Israel were pleased with it.
The people of Israel praised God
and spoke no more of going to war against them
to destroy the land where the people of Reuben and the
people of Gad lived.
34 The people of Reuben and the people of Gad named the
altar
"A Witness Between Us that the LORD is God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A war between brothers is avoided because people talked with each other. Phinehas, who used to be so strict, now listens and is glad.

At the end, everyone praises God together. A quarrel becomes a shared confession: "The LORD is God."

This story is an example for dealing with conflicts, in families, in congregations, and between nations: Do not attack right away, but ask, listen, and understand.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 23

Joshua's farewell speech

God has fought for you VERSES 1–5

1 Many days later, when the LORD had given Israel rest
from all their enemies around them,
and Joshua was old and well along in years,
2 Joshua called all Israel together, their elders, their
heads, their judges, and their officers.
He said to them,
"I am old and well along in years.

3 You have seen everything that the LORD your God has
done to all these nations because of you.
For it is the LORD your God who has fought for you.
4 Look, I have given you by lot these nations that are still
left, as an inheritance for your tribes,
from the Jordan, with all the nations that I have
destroyed, to the great sea in the west, where the sun
goes down.
5 The LORD your God will push them out in front of you
and drive them out of your sight.
And you will take their land, as the LORD your God
told you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joshua is old, like Moses at the end of his life. And like Moses, he gives a farewell speech.

He reminds them: You did not win. God fought for you.

Hold on to the LORD VERSES 6–11

6 "So be very courageous. Keep and do everything that is
written in the book of the law of Moses.
Do not turn away from it to the right or to the left.
7 Do not mix with these nations that are still left among
you.
Do not mention the names of their gods, and do not
swear by them.
Do not serve them, and do not bow down to them.
8 But hold on to the LORD your God, as you have done to
this day.
9 For the LORD has driven out great and strong nations
in front of you.
And no one has been able to stand against you to this
day.
10 One man of you will chase 1,000,
for it is the LORD your God who fights for you, as he
told you.
11 So be very careful with yourselves, that you love the
LORD your God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The greatest danger is no longer war but the worship of idols. The nations that still live in the land have other gods. Israel should not even say the names of these gods.

Verse 11 is the heart of the whole speech: "So be very careful with yourselves, that you love the LORD your God." Love for God does not happen by itself. You have to take care of it like a fire that should not go out.

A serious warning VERSES 12–16

12 "But if you turn back
and hold on to the rest of these nations that are still left
among you,
and you marry them, and you go to them and they
come to you,
13 then know for sure:
The LORD your God will no longer drive these nations
out of your sight.
Instead, they will become a snare and a trap for you,
a whip on your sides and thorns in your eyes,
until you disappear from this good land that the LORD
your God has given you.
14 Look, today I am going the way of all the earth.
You know with all your heart and with all your soul
that not one of all the good things has failed
that the LORD your God said about you.
All of them have happened to you.
Not one of them has failed.
15 But just as all the good things that the LORD your God
promised you have come to you,
so the LORD will also bring all the bad things on you,
until he has destroyed you from this good land that
the LORD your God has given you,
16 if you break the covenant of the LORD your God,
which he commanded you,
and go and serve other gods and bow down to them.
Then the anger of the LORD will burn against you,
and you will quickly disappear from the good land that
he has given you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Going the way of all the earth" means: dying. Joshua knows that his life is coming to an end.

Like Moses, Joshua warns them: God's promises can be relied on, the good ones and the warnings too. If Israel worships other gods, it will lose the land.

The warning about marriages is not about hatred of foreigners but about faith. The danger was that through marriage people would also take on the foreign gods. That is exactly what happened later with King Solomon (1 Kings 11:1–8).

The book of Judges then tells how this warning sadly came true.

JOSHUA

CHAPTER 24

The covenant at Shechem – Joshua's death

God tells the story of his people VERSES 1–13

1 Joshua gathered all the tribes of Israel at Shechem.
He called for the elders of Israel, their heads, their
judges, and their officers.
And they stood in front of God.
2 Joshua said to all the people,
"The LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'Long ago your ancestors lived beyond the River:
Terah, the father of Abraham and the father of Nahor.
They served other gods.
3 I took your father Abraham from beyond the River
and led him through the whole land of Canaan.
I gave him many descendants, and I gave him Isaac.
4 To Isaac I gave Jacob and Esau.
To Esau I gave Mount Seir to own.
But Jacob and his children went down into Egypt.

5 Then I sent Moses and Aaron.
I struck Egypt with plagues by what I did among them.
And after that I brought you out.
6 I brought your ancestors out of Egypt, and you came to the sea.
The Egyptians chased your ancestors with chariots and horsemen to the Red Sea.
7 When they cried out to the LORD,
he put darkness between you and the Egyptians
and brought the sea over them, and it covered them.
Your eyes saw what I did in Egypt.
And you lived in the wilderness for a long time.
8 Then I brought you into the land of the Amorites, who lived beyond the Jordan.
They fought against you, and I gave them into your hand.
You took their land, and I destroyed them in front of you.
9 Then Balak the son of Zippor, king of Moab, rose up and fought against Israel.
He sent for Balaam the son of Beor to curse you.
10 But I would not listen to Balaam.
So he had to bless you instead.
That is how I saved you from his hand.
11 Then you crossed the Jordan and came to Jericho.
The men of Jericho fought against you,
and also the Amorite, the Perizzite, the Canaanite, the Hittite, the Girgashite, the Hivite, and the Jebusite.
And I gave them into your hand.
12 I sent the hornet ahead of you.
It drove them out in front of you, even the two kings of the Amorites.
It was not by your sword and not by your bow.
13 I gave you a land you had not worked for,
and cities you did not build, and you live in them.
You eat from vineyards and olive groves that you did not plant.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shechem is a special place. Here God first promised Abraham that he would give him the land (Genesis 12:6–7). Here Jacob told his family to throw away the foreign gods (Genesis 35:2–4). Now the whole people comes back here.

"Beyond the River" means the Euphrates River, in what is now Iraq. Abraham's family came from there.

An honest sentence in verse 2: Abraham's family also served other gods in earlier times. Israel was not better than others from the beginning. God called it.

In this speech, God himself speaks and tells the whole story from Abraham to today. The goal: Everything Israel has is a gift. "It was not by your sword and not by your bow."

"Red Sea": This is what the WEB says. The Hebrew says "Sea of Reeds."

Choose today whom you will serve VERSES 14–15

14 "So now fear the LORD and serve him honestly and faithfully.
Put away the gods that your ancestors served beyond the River and in Egypt,
and serve the LORD.
15 But if you do not like to serve the LORD,
then choose today whom you will serve:
the gods that your ancestors served beyond the River,
or the gods of the Amorites, in whose land you live.
As for me and my house, we will serve the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the most famous sentence in the book of Joshua: "As for me and my house, we will serve the LORD." Many families have hung this sentence over their front door or in their home.

Joshua forces no one. He lets the people make a free choice: Decide! But he also says clearly how he himself has decided.

Faith is a decision. And every generation has to make this decision again, every person for himself or herself.

"Put away the gods": Some of the people obviously still had images of gods from Egypt or from their old homeland. Joshua calls for a clear break.

The people decide VERSES 16–24

16 The people answered,
"Far be it from us to leave the LORD to serve other gods!
17 For it is the LORD our God
who brought us and our ancestors up out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of slavery,
who did those great signs in front of our eyes,
and who protected us on the whole way we went,
and among all the peoples we passed through.
18 The LORD drove out all the peoples in front of us, even the Amorites who lived in the land.
So we too will serve the LORD, for he is our God."
19 Joshua said to the people,
"You cannot serve the LORD.
For he is a holy God.
He is a jealous God.
He will not forgive your disobedience and your sins.
20 If you leave the LORD and serve foreign gods,
then he will turn and do you harm and destroy you,
after he has done you good."
21 The people said to Joshua,
"No! We will serve the LORD!"
22 Joshua said to the people,
"You are witnesses against yourselves
that you yourselves have chosen the LORD, to serve him."
They said, "We are witnesses."
23 "So now put away the foreign gods that are among you,
and turn your heart to the LORD, the God of Israel."
24 The people said to Joshua,
"We will serve the LORD our God, and we will listen to his voice."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people answer with excitement: Yes, we will serve the LORD!

But Joshua says something surprising: "You cannot serve the LORD." Why? He wants them to mean it seriously. A quick "yes" is not enough. God is holy. You cannot believe in him a little on the side and have other gods at the same time.

"He will not forgive your disobedience and your sins": This sounds harsh. It probably means: Whoever knowingly leaves God and serves other gods cannot simply count on forgiveness as if nothing had happened. But the rest of the

Bible also shows: Whoever turns back finds mercy with God (Deuteronomy 30).

Three times the people say yes. And they become witnesses against themselves. That means: You said it freely. Later you cannot say you did not know.

"Turn your heart to the LORD": It is not only about outward things but about the heart.

The covenant is made VERSES 25–28

25 So that day Joshua made a covenant with the people,
and in Shechem he gave them rules and laws.
26 Joshua wrote these words in the book of the law of God.
And he took a large stone and set it up there under the
oak that was by the holy place of the LORD.
27 Joshua said to all the people,
"Look, this stone will be a witness against us,
for it has heard all the words of the LORD that he spoke
to us.
It will be a witness against you, so that you do not deny
your God."
28 Then Joshua sent the people away, each to his own
inheritance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The covenant from Mount Sinai is renewed here. Every generation has to enter into it for itself.

The large stone is like a silent witness. It reminds them again and again of their promise. Archaeologists have found a large standing stone at Shechem. Some connect it with this story. That is not certain.

Joshua's death VERSES 29–31

29 After these things, Joshua the son of Nun, the servant
of the LORD, died.
He was 110 years old.
30 They buried him in the area of his inheritance, in
Timnathserah,
which is in the hill country of Ephraim, north of the
mountain of Gaash.
31 Israel served the LORD as long as Joshua lived,
and as long as the elders lived who outlived Joshua
and who had known all the work that the LORD had
done for Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end, Joshua receives the same title of honor as Moses: "the servant of the LORD." He served faithfully.

110 years: Joseph also lived that long (Genesis 50:26). That was seen as a perfect, blessed age.

Verse 31 is beautiful and sad at the same time: As long as the people lived who had seen God's deeds themselves, Israel stayed faithful. What happens when this generation dies? The book of Judges tells about that (Judges 2:10).

Joseph's bones and Eleazar's death VERSES 32–33

32 They buried the bones of Joseph, which the people of
Israel had brought up from Egypt,
in Shechem, on the piece of land
that Jacob had bought from the sons of Hamor, the
father of Shechem, for 100 pieces of silver.
It became the inheritance of the people of Joseph.
33 Eleazar the son of Aaron also died.
They buried him on the hill of his son Phinehas,
which had been given to him in the hill country of
Ephraim.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before he died, Joseph had asked: Take my bones with you when God leads you out of Egypt (Genesis 50:25). Moses had taken them along (Exodus 13:19). Now, hundreds of years later, they are buried in the promised land. One last promise is fulfilled.

They are buried at Shechem, on the very field that Jacob had bought (Genesis 33:19). Where everything began.

The book ends with three graves: Joshua, Joseph, and Eleazar. A generation comes to an end. But God's story with his people goes on.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Joshua?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Joshua tells how God's promise to Abraham is fulfilled: Israel receives the land.

1. Entering the land (Chapters 1–5): God tells Joshua: "Be strong and courageous!" Rahab saves the spies. The people cross the Jordan.

2. The conquest (Chapters 6–12): The walls of Jericho fall. Achan's guilt brings trouble. The Gibeonites make peace. The sun stands still.

3. The dividing of the land (Chapters 13–21): Every tribe receives its land. Caleb, the daughters of Zelophehad, and the Levites receive their inheritance. God keeps his promises: "Not one of these good things failed. Everything came true."

4. The farewell (Chapters 22–24): A war between brothers is avoided. Joshua calls for a decision: "As for me and my house, we will serve the LORD."

The book has many harsh war reports. We have not left them out, but we have said honestly: They belong to a distant time, they often exaggerate in the language of their time, and they must never be used to justify violence or war.

And the book also shows: People from foreign nations like Rahab and the Gibeonites find a place in God's people. Caleb, whose family came from outside, becomes an example of faithfulness.

The most important message: God keeps his word. And every person has to decide whom they will serve.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 7 OF 66

JUDGES

21 CHAPTERS

JUDGES

Chapter 1

The conquest stays incomplete

Before we begin: What is the book of Judges?

The book of Judges tells about the time after Joshua, before Israel had a king. This time may have lasted 200 to 300 years.

The "judges" were not judges in a court, as we know them today. They were leaders and rescuers whom God called in times of need. They set the people free from enemies. Well-known judges are Deborah, a woman, Gideon, and Samson.

The book has a fixed pattern that repeats again and again: Israel leaves God and serves foreign gods. Then enemies oppress it. The people cry out to God. God sends a rescuer. There is peace. And then everything starts over again.

Each time it gets worse. At the end of the book, the people have sunk into chaos and violence. The last sentence is: "In those days there was no king in Israel. Everyone did what was right in his own eyes" (Judges 21:25).

The book of Judges is honest. It shows the dark sides of God's people, including terrible violence, especially against women. We leave nothing out, but we explain it. The Bible does not tell these stories as examples to follow but as a warning: This is what it looks like when people forget God.

And still the book shows: God does not give up on his people. Again and again he hears the people's cry and sends rescue.

Judah goes into battle first VERSES 1–7

1 After Joshua died, the people of Israel asked the LORD,
"Which of us should go up first against the Canaanites
to fight against them?"
2 The LORD said,
"Judah will go up.
Look, I have given the land into his hand."
3 Judah said to his brother Simeon,
"Come up with me into my territory, so that we can
fight against the Canaanites.
Then I will also go with you into your territory."
So Simeon went with him.
4 Judah went up, and the LORD gave the Canaanites and
the Perizzites into their hand.
They struck 10,000 men at Bezek.
5 At Bezek they found Adoni-Bezek and fought against
him.
They struck the Canaanites and the Perizzites.
6 But Adoni-Bezek ran away.
They chased him, caught him,
and cut off his thumbs and his big toes.
7 Adoni-Bezek said,
"70 kings with their thumbs and big toes cut off
have looked for scraps of food under my table.
As I have done, so God has paid me back."
They brought him to Jerusalem, and he died there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After Joshua's death, there is no single leader anymore. The tribes ask God himself. Judah, the largest tribe, is to begin.

"Adoni-Bezek" means "lord of Bezek."

The punishment is cruel: Without thumbs, you cannot hold a sword. Without big toes, you cannot run well. This was how warriors were made unable to fight. Adoni-Bezek himself had done this to 70 kings. He realizes: What I did to others has now happened to me.

This is not a call to cut off parts of people's bodies. The Bible is telling how cruel the time was.

Jerusalem, Hebron, and Debir VERSES 8–15

8 The people of Judah fought against Jerusalem.
They took it, struck it with the edge of the sword, and
set the city on fire.
9 After that, the people of Judah went down to fight
against the Canaanites
who lived in the hill country, in the South, and in the
lowland.
10 Judah went against the Canaanites who lived in
Hebron.
(The name of Hebron used to be Kiriath Arba.)
They struck Sheshai, Ahiman, and Talmai.
11 From there he went against the people who lived in
Debir.
(The name of Debir used to be Kiriath Sepher.)
12 Caleb said,
"I will give my daughter Achsah as a wife to the man
who strikes Kiriath Sepher and takes it."
13 Othniel the son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother,
took it.
So Caleb gave him his daughter Achsah as his wife.
14 When she came to him, she got him to ask her father
for a field.
She got off her donkey, and Caleb asked her, "What
would you like?"
15 She said to him,
"Give me a blessing.
Since you have given me land in the South, give me
springs of water too."
So Caleb gave her the upper springs and the lower
springs.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Jerusalem is taken and burned. But verse 21 says that the Jebusites went on living there. Maybe only part of the city was destroyed, or the Jebusites came back. Only David took Jerusalem for good (2 Samuel 5).

We already know the story of Caleb, Othniel, and Achsah from Joshua 15:13–19. Here it is told again almost word for word. Othniel will soon become the first judge (Chapter 3).

Successes in the south VERSES 16–20

16 The descendants of the Kenite, Moses' brother-in-law,
went up with the people of Judah from the city of

palm trees into the wilderness of Judah, which is
south of Arad.
They went and lived with the people.
17 Judah went with his brother Simeon.
They struck the Canaanites who lived in Zephath
and completely destroyed the city.
So the city was named Hormah.
18 Judah also took Gaza with its territory,
Ashkelon with its territory, and Ekron with its
territory.
19 The LORD was with Judah, and Judah drove out the
people of the hill country.
But it could not drive out the people of the valley,
because they had chariots of iron.
20 They gave Hebron to Caleb, as Moses had said.
And he drove out the three sons of Anak from there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Brother-in-law": This is what the WEB says. The Hebrew word usually means "father-in-law." The Kenites were the family of Moses' father-in-law Jethro (Exodus 18). They did not belong to Israel, but they lived together with Israel. The city of palm trees (verse 16) is Jericho.

"Hormah" means "devoted to destruction."

Verse 18 says that Judah took the Philistine cities of Gaza, Ashkelon, and Ekron. But later these cities belong to the Philistines again. The Greek translation of the Bible even says the opposite here: Judah did not take them.

Verse 19 is remarkable: "The LORD was with Judah," and still they could not conquer the valley because of the iron chariots. The narrator does not ask why. But the question remains: Was it really the strength of the enemies, or did Judah lack trust?

The other tribes do not drive out the Canaanites

VERSES 21–36

21 The people of Benjamin did not drive out the Jebusites
who lived in Jerusalem.
So the Jebusites live with the people of Benjamin in
Jerusalem to this day.
22 The house of Joseph also went up against Bethel, and
the LORD was with them.
23 The house of Joseph sent men to spy out Bethel.
(The name of the city used to be Luz.)
24 The watchmen saw a man coming out of the city and
said to him,
"Please show us the way into the city, and we will be
kind to you."
25 He showed them the way into the city.
They struck the city with the edge of the sword.
But they let the man and his whole family go.
26 The man went into the land of the Hittites, built a city,
and named it Luz.
That is its name to this day.
27 Manasseh did not drive out the people of Beth Shean
and its towns,
or Taanach and its towns, or the people of Dor and its
towns,
or the people of Ibleam and its towns,
or the people of Megiddo and its towns.
The Canaanites were determined to stay in that land.
28 When Israel grew strong, they put the Canaanites to
forced labor.
But they did not drive them out completely.
29 Ephraim did not drive out the Canaanites who lived in
Gezer.
The Canaanites lived among them in Gezer.
30 Zebulun did not drive out the people of Kitron or the
people of Nahalol.
The Canaanites lived among them and had to do forced
labor.
31 Asher did not drive out the people of Acco,
or the people of Sidon, Ahlab, Achzib, Helbah, Aphik,
or Rehob.
32 The Asherites lived among the Canaanites, the people
of the land,
for they did not drive them out.
33 Naphtali did not drive out the people of Beth Shemesh
or the people of Beth Anath.
He lived among the Canaanites, the people of the land.
But the people of Beth Shemesh and Beth Anath had to
do forced labor.
34 The Amorites forced the people of Dan back into the
hill country.
They did not let them come down into the valley.
35 The Amorites were determined to stay at Mount Heres,
in Aijalon, and in Shaalbim.
But the hand of the house of Joseph grew strong
against them, so that they had to do forced labor.
36 The border of the Amorites went from the ascent of
Akrabbim, from the rock, and on upward.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

It is like a long list of failures: Tribe after tribe does not drive out the Canaanites. With some tribes, the Canaanites live among Israel. With Asher and Naphtali, it is the other way around: Israel lives among the Canaanites. And Dan is even driven out itself.

The problem was not the people themselves, but their gods. As Joshua had warned (Joshua 23:12–13), the nations became a trap for Israel. Chapter 2 tells about this.

Forced labor for people of another nation does not fit our understanding of human dignity today. But the narrator does not criticize it because of human dignity. He criticizes it because Israel did not do what God had said.

A man from Bethel betrays his city and is spared. This is like Rahab. But unlike Rahab, he does not become part of Israel. He goes away and builds a new city.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 2

A new generation that does not know God

The angel of the LORD at Bochim VERSES 1–5

1 The angel of the LORD came up from Gilgal to Bochim
and said,

"I brought you up out of Egypt
and brought you into the land that I swore to give to your ancestors.
I said, 'I will never break my covenant with you.
2 But you must not make a covenant with the people who live in this land.
You must tear down their altars.'
But you have not listened to my voice.
Why have you done this?
3 So I have also said,
'I will not drive them out in front of you.
They will be like a pain in your sides,
and their gods will be a trap for you.'"
4 When the angel of the LORD said these words to all the people of Israel,
the people cried out loud and wept.
5 They named that place Bochim.
And they offered sacrifices there to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Bochim" means "those who weep."

The angel of the LORD speaks as if he were God himself: "I brought you up out of Egypt." In the Bible, the angel of the LORD is often a messenger through whom God himself speaks.

God stays faithful: "I will never break my covenant with you." But Israel has not listened. That is why the nations will stay in the land, with all their temptations.

The people weep. But the question is: Are they weeping because they are truly sorry, or only because they are sad about what is coming now?

Looking back at Joshua's death verses 6–10

6 When Joshua had sent the people away,
the people of Israel each went to his own inheritance to take the land.
7 The people served the LORD as long as Joshua lived,
and as long as the elders lived who outlived Joshua
and who had seen all the great work that the LORD had done for Israel.
8 Joshua, the son of Nun, the servant of the LORD, died at the age of 110.
9 They buried him in the area of his inheritance, in Timnath Heres in the hill country of Ephraim, north of the mountain of Gaash.
10 That whole generation also died and was gathered to their ancestors.
And after them another generation grew up
that did not know the LORD
or the work he had done for Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses repeat almost word for word the end of the book of Joshua (Joshua 24:28–31). They remind us how the new situation came about.

"Timnath Heres": In Joshua 24:30 the place was called "Timnathserah." The letters are switched around. "Heres" means "sun."

Verse 10 is one of the saddest sentences in the Bible: A new generation grows up "that did not know the LORD." The parents saw God's deeds, but they did not pass it on to their children. And yet Moses had said so often: Tell your children! (Deuteronomy 6:7).

Faith is not inherited. Every generation must get to know God for itself.

The cycle of the time of the judges verses 11–19

11 The people of Israel did what was evil in the eyes of the LORD,
and they served the Baals.
12 They left the LORD, the God of their ancestors,
who had brought them out of the land of Egypt,
and they followed other gods, the gods of the peoples who lived around them.
They bowed down to them and made the LORD angry.
13 They left the LORD and served Baal and the Ashtaroth.
14 So the anger of the LORD burned against Israel.
He gave them into the hands of raiders, who robbed them.
He sold them into the hands of their enemies all around,
so that they could no longer stand against their enemies.
15 Wherever they went out, the hand of the LORD was against them, to bring them harm,
as the LORD had said and as the LORD had sworn to them.
And they were in great distress.
16 Then the LORD raised up judges,
who saved them from the hand of those who robbed them.
17 But they did not listen to their judges either.
For they were unfaithful like prostitutes and went after other gods and bowed down to them.
They quickly turned away from the way their ancestors had walked,
who had obeyed the commandments of the LORD.
They did not do so.
18 When the LORD raised up judges for them,
the LORD was with the judge
and saved them from the hand of their enemies as long as the judge lived.
For the LORD felt sorry for them when they groaned because of those who oppressed them and treated them badly.
19 But when the judge died,
they turned back and acted even worse than their ancestors.
They followed other gods, to serve them and bow down to them.
They did not stop what they were doing or give up their stubborn ways.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the pattern of the whole book is explained. It is like a circle that repeats again and again:

1. Israel leaves God and serves foreign gods.
2. God lets enemies oppress Israel.
3. Israel groans and cries out in its need.
4. God has pity and sends a judge who rescues the people.
5. As long as the judge lives, there is peace.
6. After his death, Israel falls away again, even worse than before.

"Baal" was a god of the Canaanites. People believed he brought rain and fertility. "Ashtaroth" is the plural of

Ashtoreth, a goddess of love and fertility. For farmers, the temptation was great: They wanted to be sure that the harvest would be good.

Verse 18 shows God's heart: "The LORD felt sorry for them when they groaned." God suffers with his people when they suffer, even when it is their own fault.

God tests Israel VERSES 20–23

20 So the anger of the LORD burned against Israel, and he said,
"This nation has broken my covenant, which I commanded their ancestors,
and has not listened to my voice.
21 So I too will no longer drive out in front of them any of the nations
that Joshua left when he died.
22 Through them I will test Israel,
to see whether they will keep to the way of the LORD
and walk in it, as their ancestors did, or not."
23 So the LORD let those nations stay and did not drive them out quickly.
He had not given them into Joshua's hand either.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Why did the other nations stay in the land? The Bible gives several answers. Here it says: They are a test. God wants to see whether Israel will stay faithful to him, even when temptation lives right next door.

This is true for us too: Faithfulness to God does not show when everything is easy, but when there are temptations.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 3

The first judges: Othniel, Ehud, and Shamgar

The nations that stayed in the land VERSES 1–6

1 These are the nations that the LORD left, to test Israel by them,
all those who had not been through any of the wars of Canaan.
2 It was only so that the generations of the people of Israel would learn,
so that they would be taught war, at least those who had not known it before:
3 the five lords of the Philistines, all the Canaanites, the Sidonians,
and the Hivites who lived on Mount Lebanon, from Mount Baal Hermon to the entrance of Hamath.
4 They were left to test Israel by them,
to find out whether they would listen to the commandments of the LORD,
which he had commanded their ancestors through Moses.
5 So the people of Israel lived among the Canaanites, the Hittites, the Amorites,
the Perizzites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites.
6 They took their daughters as wives
and gave their own daughters to their sons
and served their gods.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here another reason is given why nations stayed in the land: The new generation was to learn to defend itself and to trust God while doing so.

Verse 6 shows what Joshua had feared: Through the marriages, Israel took on the foreign gods. It was not about where people came from, but about faith.

Othniel, the first judge VERSES 7–11

7 The people of Israel did what was evil in the eyes of the LORD.
They forgot the LORD their God and served the Baals and the Asheroth.
8 So the anger of the LORD burned against Israel,
and he sold them into the hand of Cushan Rishathaim,
the king of Mesopotamia.
And the people of Israel served Cushan Rishathaim for eight years.
9 Then the people of Israel cried out to the LORD.
And the LORD raised up a savior for the people of Israel, who saved them:
Othniel the son of Kenaz, Caleb's younger brother.
10 The Spirit of the LORD came on him, and he judged Israel.
He went out to war, and the LORD gave Cushan Rishathaim, the king of Mesopotamia, into his hand.
His hand grew strong against Cushan Rishathaim.
11 And the land had rest for 40 years.
Then Othniel the son of Kenaz died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here, for the first time, we see the whole cycle from Chapter 2: falling away, oppression, crying out, rescue, rest.

"Cushan Rishathaim" means something like "Cushan, the doubly wicked." It sounds like a mocking name.

We already know Othniel: He took Debir and married Achsah (Chapter 1). He comes from the family of Caleb, the faithful spy.

"The Spirit of the LORD came on him": The judges were not strong by their own power. God's Spirit gave them courage and strength for their task.

In the Bible, "40 years" often means a whole generation, a long time.

Ehud and King Eglon VERSES 12–26

12 The people of Israel again did what was evil in the eyes of the LORD.
So the LORD made Eglon, the king of Moab, strong against Israel,
because they had done what was evil in the eyes of the LORD.
13 He gathered the people of Ammon and Amalek to himself.
He went and struck Israel, and they took the city of palm trees.

14 The people of Israel served Eglon, the king of Moab, for
18 years.
15 Then the people of Israel cried out to the LORD.
And the LORD raised up a savior for them:
Ehud the son of Gera, the Benjamite, a left-handed
man.
The people of Israel sent tribute through him to
Eglon, the king of Moab.
16 Ehud made himself a sword that had two edges and was
about 18 inches long.
He wore it under his clothing on his right thigh.
17 He brought the tribute to Eglon, the king of Moab.
Now Eglon was a very fat man.
18 When Ehud had finished bringing the tribute,
he sent away the people who had carried the tribute.
19 But he himself turned back at the stone idols that were
near Gilgal and said,
"I have a secret message for you, king."
The king said, "Quiet!"
And all who stood by him left him.
20 Ehud came to him.
He was sitting all alone in his cool upper room.
Ehud said, "I have a message from God for you."
Then he got up from his seat.
21 Ehud reached out his left hand,
took the sword from his right thigh,
and thrust it into his belly.
22 The handle also went in after the blade,
and the fat closed over the blade.
For he did not pull the sword out of his belly.
And it came out at the back.
23 Then Ehud went out onto the porch,
shut the doors of the upper room behind him, and
locked them.
24 After he had gone out, the king's servants came.
They saw that the doors of the upper room were
locked.
They said, "Surely he is covering his feet in the upper
room."
25 They waited until they were ashamed.
But he did not open the doors of the upper room.
So they took the key and opened them.
And there was their lord, lying dead on the floor.
26 But Ehud had escaped while they waited.
He had gone past the stone idols and escaped to Seirah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says: a cubit long. A cubit is about 18 inches.

Moab, Ammon, and Amalek attack together. They take Jericho, the "city of palm trees." For 18 years, Israel has to pay tribute, which means payments to the foreign king.

Ehud was left-handed. This is important for the story: The guards probably looked for a sword on the left side, where right-handed men wear it. That is why they did not find it. By the way, the name "Benjamin" means "son of the right hand." A left-handed man from the tribe of the "right hand" is a little joke in the story.

The story is told very vividly, almost like a crime story, and with rough humor: The king is so fat that the fat swallows the sword. The servants think he is sitting on the toilet. "Covering his feet" is a polite way of saying this. That is why they wait so long, "until they were ashamed."

Ehud uses a trick and kills a king. Today we would call this an assassination. The Bible tells it as freedom from oppression. But it is not a call to murder rulers.

Moab is defeated VERSES 27–30

27 When he got there, he blew a trumpet in the hill
country of Ephraim.
Then the people of Israel went down with him from
the hill country, and he led them.
28 He said to them,
"Follow me! For the LORD has given your enemies,
the Moabites, into your hand."
They followed him and took the fords of the Jordan
against the Moabites.
And they did not let anyone cross over.
29 At that time they struck about 10,000 men of Moab, all
strong and brave men.
No one escaped.
30 So that day Moab was brought down under the hand of
Israel.
And the land had rest for 80 years.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Moabites wanted to flee across the Jordan to their home. But Israel took the fords.

Fords are the shallow places where you can walk across a river.

80 years of rest: That is two generations, the longest time of peace in the whole book.

Shamgar VERSE 31

31 After him came Shamgar the son of Anath.
He struck 600 men of the Philistines with an ox goad.
He also saved Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only a single sentence is told about Shamgar. An ox goad was a long stick with a metal point. It was used to drive cattle while plowing. Shamgar had no real weapon, only a farm tool. Still, he saved Israel.

"Anath" was the name of a Canaanite goddess. Maybe Shamgar was not an Israelite at all. Still, God used him.

Shamgar is also mentioned in the song of Deborah (Judges 5:6).

JUDGES

CHAPTER 4

Deborah, Barak, and Jael

Israel is oppressed by Jabin VERSES 1–3

1 After Ehud had died, the people of Israel again did what
was evil in the eyes of the LORD.

2 So the LORD sold them into the hand of Jabin, the king
of Canaan, who ruled in Hazor.
The commander of his army was Sisera, who lived in
Harosheth of the Gentiles.
3 Then the people of Israel cried out to the LORD.
For he had 900 chariots of iron,
and he cruelly oppressed the people of Israel for 20
years.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again the cycle: Ehud dies, Israel falls away, an enemy comes.

900 chariots of iron were a huge army at that time. Israel had no such weapons.

In Hebrew, "Harosheth of the Gentiles" is called "Harosheth Haggoyim." "Gentiles" means peoples who did not belong to Israel.

The prophetess Deborah VERSES 4–10

4 At that time Deborah judged Israel. She was a
prophetess, the wife of Lappidoth.
5 She sat under Deborah's palm tree between Ramah and
Bethel in the hill country of Ephraim.
And the people of Israel came up to her to have their
cases judged.
6 She sent for Barak the son of Abinoam, from Kedesh in
Naphtali,
and said to him,
"Hasn't the LORD, the God of Israel, commanded you:
'Go and lead the way to Mount Tabor,
and take with you 10,000 men from the people of
Naphtali and the people of Zebulun.
7 I will draw Sisera, the commander of Jabin's army,
with his chariots and his crowd of soldiers,
to you at the river Kishon,
and I will give him into your hand'?"
8 Barak said to her,
"If you go with me, then I will go.
But if you don't go with me, I will not go."
9 She said,
"I will surely go with you.
But the honor on this journey you are taking will not
be yours.
For the LORD will sell Sisera into the hand of a
woman."
Then Deborah got up and went with Barak to Kedesh.
10 Barak called Zebulun and Naphtali together to Kedesh.
And 10,000 men followed him.
And Deborah went up with him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Deborah is a very special woman. She is a prophetess, a judge, and the leader of the whole people. At a time when women usually had no public offices, God speaks through her. People come to her to get justice.

She is the only person in the book of Judges who is also described as a judge in today's sense: She judges cases under a palm tree.

Barak does not dare to go alone. He says: Only if you come with me. Deborah comes along, but she says ahead of time: A woman will get the honor. The reader may think: Deborah. But it will be another woman.

"Lappidoth" means "torches." So some Bible teachers translate "a woman of fire" instead of "the wife of Lappidoth."

Heber the Kenite VERSE 11

11 Heber the Kenite had separated himself from the
Kenites, the descendants of Hobab, Moses' brother-in-
law.
He had set up his tent as far away as the oak in
Zaanannim, which is near Kedesh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This verse seems to interrupt the story. But it is important for later: Heber is a Kenite, so he is not an Israelite. He lives near the battlefield. And he is at peace with King Jabin (Verse 17).

"Brother-in-law": This is what the WEB says. The Hebrew word usually means "father-in-law" (see Judges 1:16).

The victory at the river Kishon VERSES 12–16

12 Sisera was told that Barak the son of Abinoam had gone
up to Mount Tabor.
13 So Sisera gathered all his chariots, 900 chariots of iron,
and all the people who were with him, from
Harosheth of the Gentiles to the river Kishon.
14 Deborah said to Barak,
"Go! For this is the day on which the LORD has given
Sisera into your hand.
Hasn't the LORD gone out ahead of you?"
So Barak went down from Mount Tabor, with 10,000
men behind him.
15 And the LORD threw Sisera, all his chariots, and all his
army into confusion
in front of Barak with the edge of the sword.
Sisera left his chariot and ran away on foot.
16 Barak chased the chariots and the army as far as
Harosheth of the Gentiles.
And the whole army of Sisera fell by the edge of the
sword.
Not one man was left.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The chariots were very strong on the plain. But God threw them into confusion. In the song of Deborah (Judges 5:21) we learn more: The river Kishon flooded its banks. The heavy chariots got stuck in the mud.

Deborah gives the signal: This is the day! She tells Barak when to start.

Jael and Sisera VERSES 17–22

17 But Sisera ran away on foot to the tent of Jael, the wife
of Heber the Kenite.
For there was peace between Jabin, the king of Hazor,
and the house of Heber the Kenite.
18 Jael went out to meet Sisera and said to him,
"Come in, my lord, come in to me. Don't be afraid."
He came into the tent with her, and she covered him
with a rug.
19 He said to her,
"Please give me a little water to drink, for I am
thirsty."
She opened a container of milk, gave him a drink, and
covered him.

20 He said to her,
"Stand in the door of the tent.
If anyone comes and asks you, 'Is there a man here?'
you must say, 'No.'"
21 Then Jael, Heber's wife, took a tent peg
and took a hammer in her hand.
She went quietly to him
and drove the peg through his temple, so that it went into the ground.
For he was in a deep sleep and worn out.
And he died.
22 Just then, as Barak was chasing Sisera, Jael came out to meet him and said to him,
"Come, and I will show you the man you are looking for."
He went in with her,
and there lay Sisera, dead, with the tent peg in his temple.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Deborah's word comes true: A woman gets the honor. But it is not Deborah, it is Jael, a woman from a foreign people.

This story is very hard to judge. Jael invites Sisera in as a guest. At that time, hospitality was holy: A guest was protected. Jael breaks this law and kills him in his sleep.

Why does she do it? The Bible does not say. Maybe she was on Israel's side, against her own husband. Maybe she was afraid of what Sisera would do to her. In war, women had hardly any way to protect themselves. Tent peg and hammer were her tools, because at that time women put up the tents.

In the song of Deborah, Jael is praised (Judges 5:24). For Israel she was a hero who defeated a cruel oppressor. But Jews and Christians have also asked again and again whether her betrayal of a guest was right. The Bible tells the story without judging everything.

Sisera asks for water, and Jael gives him milk. Milk makes you sleepy. Maybe she wanted him to fall asleep quickly.

Jabin is defeated VERSES 23–24

23 So on that day God brought down Jabin, the king of Canaan, in front of the people of Israel.
24 And the hand of the people of Israel pressed harder and harder on Jabin, the king of Canaan,
until they had destroyed Jabin, the king of Canaan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the end, it was not Barak, not Deborah, and not Jael who won. "God brought down Jabin." People are tools in God's hand.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 5

The song of Deborah

Praise the LORD! VERSES 1–5

1 On that day Deborah and Barak the son of Abinoam sang:
2 "Because the leaders took the lead in Israel,
because the people offered themselves willingly,
praise the LORD!
3 Listen, you kings! Pay attention, you princes!
I, even I, will sing to the LORD.
I will sing praise to the LORD, the God of Israel.
4 LORD, when you went out from Seir,
when you marched out from the fields of Edom,
the earth shook, and the sky poured,
yes, the clouds poured down water.
5 The mountains shook in front of the LORD,
even Sinai, in front of the LORD, the God of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This song is one of the oldest texts in the whole Bible. Many scholars think it was written soon after the events, maybe in the 12th century BC. The language is old-fashioned and hard to understand in some places.

Deborah and Barak celebrate the victory with a song, just as Moses and Miriam did after crossing the sea (Exodus 15).

God comes from the south, from Sinai and from Edom, with earthquake and thunderstorm. The storm may explain why Sisera's chariots were defeated: The rain turned the plain into a swamp.

The hard times before the victory VERSES 6–11

6 "In the days of Shamgar the son of Anath,
in the days of Jael,
the main roads were empty.
Travelers walked on winding side paths.
7 There were no leaders in Israel.
There were none, until I, Deborah, rose up,
until I rose up as a mother in Israel.
8 They chose new gods.
Then there was war in the city gates.
Was a shield or a spear seen among 40,000 in Israel?
9 My heart is with the leaders of Israel,
who offered themselves willingly among the people.
Praise the LORD!
10 Speak of it, you who ride on white donkeys,
you who sit on rich carpets,
and you who walk along the road!
11 Far from the noise of the archers, at the places where water is drawn,
there they will tell of the right and good deeds of the LORD,
the right and good deeds of his rule in Israel.
Then the people of the LORD went down to the gates.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before the victory, life was dangerous: No one dared to use the main roads. Israel had no weapons.

"A mother in Israel": This is what Deborah calls herself. She cared for her people like a mother cares for her children.

Everyone is to tell about God's deeds: the rich on their white donkeys, the wealthy on carpets, and the ordinary people who walk. Even at the wells, where the women draw water, people are to tell about it.

Who came to the battle, and who did not? VERSES 12–18

12 "'Wake up, wake up, Deborah!
Wake up, wake up, sing a song!
Get up, Barak, and lead away your captives, you son of Abinoam!'
13 Then the rest of the nobles and the people came down.
The LORD came down for me against the mighty.
14 Those whose root is in Amalek came out of Ephraim,
after you, Benjamin, among your peoples.
Leaders came down from Machir,
and from Zebulun came those who carry the commander's staff.
15 The princes of Issachar were with Deborah.
As Issachar was, so was Barak.
They rushed after him into the valley.
By the streams of Reuben there were great decisions of the heart.
16 Why did you stay sitting among the sheepfolds?
To hear the whistling for the flocks?
By the streams of Reuben there was great searching of the heart.
17 Gilead stayed on the other side of the Jordan.
And Dan, why did it stay with the ships?
Asher sat still at the seashore and stayed by its bays.
18 Zebulun was a people that risked their lives to the death,
and Naphtali too, on the high places of the field.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The song praises the tribes that fought: Ephraim, Benjamin, Machir (a part of Manasseh), Zebulun, Issachar, and Naphtali.

And it blames those who stayed at home: Reuben thought and talked for a long time, but did nothing. Gilead stayed beyond the Jordan. Dan and Asher preferred to take care of their ships and their trade.

This is a question for every community: Who gets involved when it really matters, and who stays comfortably at home?

"Whose root is in Amalek": This is hard to understand. Maybe parts of Ephraim lived in an area where Amalekites had lived before.

Judah and Simeon are not mentioned at all. Maybe they were too far away in the south.

The battle VERSES 19–23

19 "The kings came and fought.
Then the kings of Canaan fought at Taanach, by the waters of Megiddo.
But they took no silver as plunder.
20 From the sky the stars fought.
From their paths they fought against Sisera.
21 The river Kishon swept them away,
that ancient river, the river Kishon.
My soul, march on with strength!
22 Then the horses' hoofs pounded
from the galloping, the galloping of their strong ones.
23 'Curse Meroz,' said the angel of the LORD.
'Curse its people bitterly,
because they did not come to help the LORD,
to help the LORD against the mighty.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"From the sky the stars fought": This is a picture in a poem. All of creation, even the sky, was on God's side. Maybe it also means the thunderstorm that came from the sky.

The river Kishon rose because of the rain and swept the enemies away. The horses galloped away in panic.

"Meroz" was a town whose people did not help, even though they could have. Today no one knows where the town was.

Blessed is Jael VERSES 24–27

24 "Jael shall be blessed above women,
the wife of Heber the Kenite.
She shall be blessed above women in the tent!
25 He asked for water, she gave him milk.
In a fine bowl she brought him butter.
26 She reached out her hand for the tent peg
and her right hand for the workmen's hammer.
She struck Sisera, she crushed his head.
Yes, she pierced and struck through his temple.
27 At her feet he bowed, he fell, he lay.
At her feet he bowed, he fell.
Where he bowed, there he fell down dead.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Butter": This is what the WEB says. It probably means thick cream or sour milk.

The song celebrates Jael as a hero. The words repeat like hammer blows: "he bowed, he fell, he lay." In this way, the fall of the mighty enemy is described very powerfully.

"Blessed above women": In the New Testament, Elizabeth says similar words to Mary (Luke 1:42).

As in Chapter 4: Here the Bible tells the story from the point of view of a people who had been oppressed for a long time. It celebrates freedom. This is not general praise for violence.

Sisera's mother waits VERSES 28–30

28 "Through the window she looked out and cried,
Sisera's mother, through the lattice:
'Why is his chariot so long in coming?
Why are the wheels of his chariots so slow?'
29 The wisest of her ladies answered her,
yes, she gave herself the answer:
30 'Haven't they found plunder and are sharing it?
A woman, two women for every man.
For Sisera, colorful cloth as plunder,
colorful, embroidered cloth as plunder,
colorful cloth, embroidered on both sides,
for the necks of those who take the plunder?'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A surprising change of view: The song shows the enemy's mother. She is waiting at the window for her son. He does not come. She is worried. Her ladies calm her down: He is surely still sharing out the plunder.

We readers know: He has been dead for a long time. This moment is bitter. The enemy's mother is also a mother who is afraid for her child.

Verse 30 shows what Sisera and his warriors had planned: to take women as plunder. In Hebrew, there is a very crude, insulting word for women here. This shows the cruelty of

war against women. The irony: Sisera's mother thinks her son is capturing women. But he was defeated by a woman.

Irony means: Something turns out to be the opposite of what someone expected.

The end VERSE 31

31 "So let all your enemies die, LORD!
But let those who love him be like the sun when it rises in its strength."
And the land had rest for 40 years.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The song ends with a beautiful picture: Those who love God are to shine like the rising sun.

After the victory come 40 years of peace.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 6

Gideon is called

The Midianites come like locusts VERSES 1–6

1 The people of Israel did what was evil in the eyes of the LORD.
So the LORD gave them into the hand of Midian for seven years.
2 The hand of Midian pressed hard on Israel.
Because of Midian, the people of Israel made hiding places for themselves in the mountains, caves, and strongholds.
3 Whenever Israel had sown its seed,
the Midianites, the Amalekites, and the people of the east came up against them.
4 They camped against them and destroyed the crops of the land as far as Gaza.
They left nothing to live on in Israel, no sheep, no ox, and no donkey.
5 For they came up with their livestock and their tents.
They came in as many as locusts.
They and their camels could not be counted.
And they came into the land to destroy it.
6 So Israel became very poor because of Midian.
And the people of Israel cried out to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Midianites were nomads from the desert. Every year at harvest time they came with their herds and camels and took everything. The Israelites had nothing left to eat. They had to hide in caves.

At that time, camels were a new and feared "weapon." With them, the robbers could travel long distances through the desert and attack quickly.

A prophet reminds them of God's deeds VERSES 7–10

7 When the people of Israel cried out to the LORD because of Midian,
8 the LORD sent a prophet to the people of Israel.
He said to them,
"This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'I brought you up from Egypt.
I brought you out of the house of slavery.
9 I rescued you from the hand of the Egyptians
and from the hand of all who oppressed you.
I drove them out in front of you and gave you their land.
10 And I said to you,
"I am the LORD your God.
Do not fear the gods of the Amorites, in whose land you live."
But you have not listened to my voice.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before God helps, he sends a prophet. The people are to understand why they are in trouble. It is not only about being set free from the enemies, but about turning back to God.

The angel visits Gideon VERSES 11–16

11 The angel of the LORD came and sat under the oak in Ophrah, which belonged to Joash the Abiezrite.
His son Gideon was threshing wheat in the winepress, to hide it from the Midianites.
12 The angel of the LORD appeared to him and said to him,
"The LORD is with you, you mighty hero!"
13 Gideon said to him,
"Oh, my lord, if the LORD is with us, why has all this happened to us?
Where are all his wonderful works that our ancestors told us about, when they said,
'Didn't the LORD bring us up from Egypt?'
But now the LORD has thrown us away and given us into the hand of Midian."
14 The LORD looked at him and said,
"Go in this strength of yours and save Israel from the hand of Midian.
Haven't I sent you?"
15 He said to him,
"Oh, Lord, how can I save Israel?
My family is the poorest in Manasseh,
and I am the least in my father's house."
16 The LORD said to him,
"I will be with you.
And you will strike the Midianites as if they were one man."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Normally, grain is threshed in an open place in the wind. Gideon threshes in secret in a winepress, a pit in the rock. He is afraid.

To thresh means: to beat the grain so that the seeds come loose.

And it is to this frightened man that the angel says: "You mighty hero!" It sounds almost like a joke. But God sees in Gideon what he can become.

Gideon asks an honest question that many people know: If God is with us, why are things so bad for us? God does not

answer the question directly. But he sends Gideon to change something.

Gideon refuses: I am the least, from the poorest family. This reminds us of Moses, who did not want to go either (Exodus 3–4). God gives him the same promise as he gave Moses then: I will be with you. It does not depend on Gideon's strength, but on God being with him.

Here, the angel of the LORD is also simply called "the LORD." God himself speaks through the angel.

A sign: fire from the rock VERSES 17–24

17 He said to him,
"If I have found favor in your eyes,
then give me a sign that it is really you who are talking with me.
18 Please don't go away from here until I come to you
and bring out my gift and set it in front of you."
He said, "I will wait until you come back."
19 Gideon went in and prepared a young goat
and bread without yeast from about 6 gallons of flour.
He put the meat in a basket and poured the broth into a pot.
He brought it out to him under the oak and offered it to him.
20 The angel of God said to him,
"Take the meat and the bread without yeast, lay them on this rock,
and pour out the broth."
And he did so.
21 Then the angel of the LORD reached out the tip of the staff that was in his hand
and touched the meat and the bread without yeast.
Fire went up out of the rock and burned up the meat and the bread without yeast.
And the angel of the LORD disappeared from his sight.
22 Then Gideon realized that it was the angel of the LORD.
And Gideon said,
"Oh no, Lord GOD!
For I have seen the angel of the LORD face to face!"
23 The LORD said to him,
"Peace be with you! Don't be afraid. You will not die."
24 Then Gideon built an altar there to the LORD and called it "The LORD is Peace."
To this day it is still in Ophrah of the Abiezrites.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible says: an ephah of flour. An ephah is about 6 gallons. That was a lot, a generous gift at a time of hunger.

Gideon asks for a sign. He wants to be sure. God is patient with him.

At that time, people believed: Whoever sees God must die. That is why Gideon is frightened. But God says: "Peace be with you!" In Hebrew: "Shalom."

The altar is called "The LORD is Peace" (in Hebrew: "Yahweh Shalom"). In the middle of trouble, in the middle of war, Gideon learns: God is peace.

Gideon tears down the altar of Baal VERSES 25–32

25 That same night the LORD said to him,
"Take your father's bull, the second bull, which is seven years old.
Tear down the altar of Baal that belongs to your father,
and cut down the Asherah pole that is next to it.
26 Then build an altar to the LORD your God on top of this stronghold, carefully laid out.
And take the second bull and offer it as a burnt offering,
with the wood of the Asherah pole that you cut down."
27 So Gideon took 10 men from his servants
and did as the LORD had told him.
Because he was afraid of his father's family and of the men of the city,
he could not do it by day, so he did it at night.
28 When the men of the city got up early in the morning,
the altar of Baal was torn down,
the Asherah pole next to it was cut down,
and the second bull had been offered on the newly built altar.
29 They said to one another, "Who has done this?"
They searched and asked around.
Then they said, "Gideon the son of Joash has done this."
30 Then the men of the city said to Joash,
"Bring out your son so that he may die!
For he has torn down the altar of Baal
and cut down the Asherah pole next to it."
31 Joash said to all who stood against him,
"Will you fight for Baal? Or will you save him?
Whoever fights for him shall be put to death by morning!
If he is a god, let him fight for himself,
because someone has torn down his altar!"
32 So on that day Gideon was named Jerub-Baal,
because people said, "Let Baal fight against him,
because he has torn down his altar."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An Asherah pole was a wooden pole that stood for the goddess Asherah.

Before Gideon fights against the Midianites, he has to clean up at home. His own father had an altar for Baal. The worship of idols was right in the middle of Israel, even in Gideon's family.

Gideon obeys, but at night, because he is afraid. God accepts him anyway. You do not have to be fearless to obey God.

The men of the city want to kill Gideon because he has insulted Baal. This shows how far Israel had moved away from God. But Gideon's father defends him with a wise sentence: If Baal is a god, let him defend himself. A god who has to be protected is not a god.

"Jerub-Baal" means "let Baal fight." The name becomes a way of mocking Baal, because Baal did nothing.

The army gathers VERSES 33–35

33 Then all Midian, Amalek, and the people of the east gathered together.
They crossed over and camped in the valley of Jezreel.
34 But the Spirit of the LORD came on Gideon, and he blew a trumpet.
The Abiezrites were called together to follow him.
35 He sent messengers throughout all Manasseh,
and they too were called together to follow him.
He sent messengers to Asher, to Zebulun, and to Naphtali.
And they came up to meet them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The Spirit of the LORD came on Gideon": The Hebrew literally says that the Spirit of the LORD put on Gideon like a piece of clothing. God wraps him up completely. The frightened farmer becomes a leader.

The sign with the fleece VERSES 36–40

36 Gideon said to God,
"If you will save Israel by my hand, as you have said,
37 then I will put a fleece of wool on the threshing floor.
If there is dew only on the fleece and all the ground stays dry,
then I will know that you will save Israel by my hand, as you have said."
38 And that is what happened.
When he got up early the next morning, he squeezed the fleece
and wrung the dew out of the fleece, a whole bowl full of water.
39 Gideon said to God,
"Don't let your anger burn against me, and I will speak just this once more.
Please let me make a test with the fleece just this once more:
Let only the fleece be dry now, and let there be dew on all the ground."
40 And God did so that night.
Only the fleece was dry, and there was dew on all the ground.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A fleece is the wool of a sheep in one piece.

Gideon has already received a sign (Verse 21). Still, he doubts. He asks twice for a sign with the fleece. And God is patient with him and gives him both signs.

This is comforting: God does not look down on those who doubt. He meets them in their weakness.

This story gave us the saying "to put out a fleece": to ask God for a sign. But many Bible teachers also say: Gideon did not really need it. God had already spoken clearly. The story is not a model for testing God all the time (Deuteronomy 6:16).

JUDGES

CHAPTER 7

Gideon's 300 men

Too many warriors VERSES 1–8

1 Jerubbaal, who is Gideon, and all the people who were with him got up early
and camped beside the spring of Harod.
The camp of Midian was north of them, by the hill of Moreh, in the valley.
2 The LORD said to Gideon,
"There are too many people with you for me to give Midian into their hand.
Otherwise Israel will brag against me and say, 'My own hand has saved me.'
3 So now announce so that all the people can hear:
'Whoever is afraid and trembling, let him turn back and leave Mount Gilead.'"
So 22,000 of the people turned back, and 10,000 remained.
4 The LORD said to Gideon,
"There are still too many people.
Bring them down to the water, and I will test them for you there.
When I tell you, 'This one shall go with you,' he shall go with you.
And when I tell you, 'This one shall not go with you,' he shall not go."
5 So he brought the people down to the water.
And the LORD said to Gideon,
"Everyone who laps the water with his tongue, as a dog laps, put him by himself.
Do the same with everyone who gets down on his knees to drink."
6 The number of those who lapped, putting their hand to their mouth, was 300 men.
But all the rest of the people got down on their knees to drink water.
7 The LORD said to Gideon,
"With the 300 men who lapped I will save you
and give Midian into your hand.
Let all the other people go, each to his own place."
8 So the people took food in their hands, and their trumpets.
And he sent all the other men of Israel to their tents.
He kept only the 300 men with him.
And the camp of Midian lay below him in the valley.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Normally, before a war, you want as many soldiers as possible. God does the opposite: He sends almost everyone home. Of 32,000, only 300 remain. Why? So that Israel cannot say: We won by our own strength. It should be clear: God has given the victory.

Whoever is afraid may go home. This was also written in the law for war (Deuteronomy 20:8).

It is not completely clear how the test at the water worked. Probably the 300 scooped up water with their hand and lapped it from their hand. The others knelt down and drank straight from the water. Many Bible teachers think the choice had nothing to do with who could fight better. God simply wanted a small number.

Later Paul writes what the Lord said to him: God's power is made perfect in weakness (2 Corinthians 12:9). This story shows that very clearly.

A dream in the enemy camp VERSES 9–15

9 That same night the LORD said to him,
"Get up, go down into the camp, for I have given it into your hand.

10 But if you are afraid to go down,
go down to the camp with your servant Purah.
11 You will hear what they are saying.
After that your hands will be strong enough to go down into the camp."
So he went down with his servant Purah to the edge of the armed men in the camp.
12 The Midianites, the Amalekites, and all the people of the east lay in the valley,
as many as locusts.
And their camels could not be counted. They were as many as the sand on the seashore.
13 When Gideon got there,
a man was just telling his friend a dream.
He said, "I had a dream.
A loaf of barley bread came rolling into the camp of Midian.
It came to the tent and hit it so that it fell over.
It turned it upside down, so that the tent lay flat."
14 His friend answered,
"This is nothing else than the sword of Gideon the son of Joash, a man of Israel.
God has given Midian and the whole army into his hand."
15 When Gideon heard the dream and what it meant, he worshiped God.
Then he went back to the camp of Israel and said,
"Get up! For the LORD has given the army of Midian into your hand!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God knows Gideon's fear. He does not say: Don't be afraid! Instead he says: If you are afraid, take your servant with you. God lovingly meets Gideon in his weakness.

Barley bread was the bread of poor people. Small, poor Israel is like a loaf of bread that knocks over the big tent of the enemies.

The enemies themselves are already afraid of Gideon. This gives Gideon courage. Before he does anything else, he worships God.

Jars, torches, and trumpets VERSES 16–22

16 He divided the 300 men into 3 groups.
He put trumpets into all their hands, and empty jars with torches inside the jars.
17 He said to them,
"Watch me and do the same.
When I come to the edge of the camp, do just as I do.
18 When I blow the trumpet, I and all who are with me, then you also blow the trumpets all around the camp and shout,
'For the LORD and for Gideon!'"
19 So Gideon and the 100 men who were with him came to the edge of the camp
at the beginning of the middle watch of the night, just after the guards had been changed.
They blew the trumpets and smashed the jars that were in their hands.
20 The three groups blew the trumpets and broke the jars.
They held the torches in their left hands and the trumpets in their right hands to blow them.
And they shouted, "The sword of the LORD and of Gideon!"
21 Each man stood in his place around the camp.
Then the whole army ran around in confusion.
They cried out and fled.
22 The 300 blew their trumpets.
And the LORD turned every man's sword against his friend, throughout the whole army.
And the army fled as far as Beth Shittah toward Zererah, as far as the border of Abel Meholah, near Tabbath.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What strange weapons: trumpets, jars, and torches. Not a single sword is mentioned!

The plan: In the middle of the night, just as the guards had changed, the men smash the jars. Suddenly 300 torches light up all around. 300 trumpets sound. Normally only one leader had a trumpet, for 100 soldiers. So the enemies thought: There is a huge army!

In the darkness and panic, the enemies fight against each other. God confuses them, and they flee.

The "middle watch" was around midnight. At that time, the night was divided into three watches.

Many Christians see a beautiful picture in this: Only when the jar breaks can the light shine (see also 2 Corinthians 4:6–7).

The chase VERSES 23–25

23 The men of Israel from Naphtali, from Asher, and from all Manasseh were called together,
and they chased Midian.
24 Gideon sent messengers throughout the whole hill country of Ephraim and said,
"Come down against Midian,
and take the waters ahead of them as far as Beth Barah, and also the Jordan!"
So all the men of Ephraim were called together,
and they took the waters as far as Beth Barah and the Jordan.
25 They captured the two princes of Midian, Oreb and Zeeb.
They killed Oreb at Oreb's rock, and they killed Zeeb at Zeeb's winepress,
while they chased Midian.
And they brought the heads of Oreb and Zeeb to Gideon on the other side of the Jordan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now many men do join in after all, to chase the fleeing enemies. But the real victory had already been given.

"Oreb" means "raven," and "Zeeb" means "wolf." Later the places were named after them.

Cutting off the heads is cruel. At that time it was proof of victory. Later the prophet Isaiah remembers this day as a great example of God's rescue (Isaiah 9:4; 10:26).

JUDGES

CHAPTER 8

Gideon's victory and his end

Gideon calms Ephraim down VERSES 1–3

1 The men of Ephraim said to him,
"Why have you treated us like this? Why didn't you
call us when you went to fight against Midian?"
And they argued with him sharply.
2 He said to them,
"What have I done now compared to you?
Aren't the grapes left over in Ephraim better than the
whole grape harvest of Abiezer?
3 God has given the princes of Midian, Oreb and Zeeb,
into your hand!
What was I able to do compared to you?"
When he had said this, their anger against him calmed
down.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ephraim was a large, proud tribe. It feels left out. Gideon answers wisely and humbly: You have achieved much more than I have! Even your leftover grapes, the little that is left after the harvest, are worth more than our whole harvest.

A proverb says that a gentle answer turns away anger (Proverbs 15:1). In this way, Gideon prevents a fight between brothers.

Succoth and Penuel refuse to help VERSES 4–9

4 Gideon came to the Jordan and crossed over,
he and the 300 men who were with him.
They were worn out, but they kept chasing the
enemies.
5 He said to the men of Succoth,
"Please give loaves of bread to the people who follow
me.
For they are worn out, and I am chasing Zebah and
Zalmunna, the kings of Midian."
6 The leaders of Succoth said,
"Are the hands of Zebah and Zalmunna already in your
hand,
that we should give bread to your army?"
7 Gideon said,
"Because of this, when the LORD has given Zebah and
Zalmunna into my hand,
I will tear your flesh with the thorns of the wilderness
and with briers."
8 From there he went up to Penuel and spoke to them in
the same way.
And the men of Penuel answered him just as the men
of Succoth had answered.
9 So he also said to the men of Penuel,
"When I come back in peace, I will tear down this
tower."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Succoth and Penuel were Israelite cities east of the Jordan. Still, they refuse to give bread to their worn-out brothers. They are afraid: If Gideon loses, the Midianites will take revenge on them.

"Are the hands ... already in your hand": At that time, people sometimes cut off the hands of defeated enemies as proof.

So the leaders of Succoth are mocking him: Have you already defeated them?

Gideon becomes angry. The humble Gideon from before is changing.

The kings of Midian are captured VERSES 10–12

10 Zebah and Zalmunna were in Karkor, and their armies
with them,
about 15,000 men, all who were left of the whole army
of the people of the east.
For 120,000 men who carried swords had fallen.
11 Gideon went up by the road of the people who lived in
tents, east of Nobah and Jogbehah,
and struck the army while it felt safe.
12 Zebah and Zalmunna fled, and he chased them.
He captured the two kings of Midian, Zebah and
Zalmunna,
and threw the whole army into panic.

Gideon's revenge VERSES 13–21

13 Gideon the son of Joash came back from the battle by
the ascent of Heres.
14 He caught a young man from the men of Succoth and
questioned him.
The young man wrote down for him the names of the
leaders of Succoth and its elders, 77 men.
15 He came to the men of Succoth and said,
"Here are Zebah and Zalmunna. You mocked me
because of them and said,
'Are the hands of Zebah and Zalmunna already in your
hand,
that we should give bread to your worn-out men?'"
16 He took the elders of the city, and thorns of the
wilderness and briers,
and with them he taught the men of Succoth a lesson.
17 And he tore down the tower of Penuel and killed the
men of the city.
18 Then he said to Zebah and Zalmunna,
"What kind of men were they whom you killed at
Tabor?"
They answered,
"They were like you. Each one looked like a king's son."
19 He said,
"They were my brothers, the sons of my mother.
As surely as the LORD lives: If you had let them live, I
would not kill you."
20 He said to Jether, his firstborn son,
"Get up and kill them!"
But the boy did not draw his sword.
For he was afraid, because he was still young.
21 Then Zebah and Zalmunna said,
"Get up yourself and strike us down.
For as the man is, so is his strength."
So Gideon got up and killed Zebah and Zalmunna.
And he took the crescents that hung on the necks of
their camels.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An interesting detail: An ordinary young man was able to write down the names. So even at that time, not only priests and scholars could write.

"He taught them a lesson": This is close to what the WEB says. Other old manuscripts say: "he threshed them." It means: He punished them harshly with thorns.

Now it becomes clear: Gideon is no longer fighting only for Israel, but also out of personal revenge. The kings had killed his brothers. And he uses great violence against his own countrymen in Succoth and Penuel. The hero of Chapter 7 shows a dark side here. The Bible does not hide this.

Gideon wants to make his young son kill. But the boy is afraid. This shows: Violence is not something we should teach children.

The "crescents" were jewelry in the shape of a crescent moon. They often had a religious meaning, because the moon was worshiped as a god.

Gideon refuses the crown VERSES 22–23

22 Then the men of Israel said to Gideon,
"Rule over us, you and your son and your grandson too.
For you have saved us from the hand of Midian."
23 Gideon said to them,
"I will not rule over you,
and my son will not rule over you either.
The LORD shall rule over you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people want to make Gideon king, with his whole family. But Gideon says a wonderful sentence: "The LORD shall rule over you."

He has understood: It was not he who saved the people, but God. God alone is the true king of Israel.

Sadly, right after this, his actions do not match his words.

The golden ephod VERSES 24–28

24 Gideon said to them,
"I have a request for you:
Each of you, give me the earrings from his plunder."
(For the enemies had golden earrings, because they were Ishmaelites.)
25 They answered, "We will gladly give them."
They spread out a garment,
and each man threw the earrings from his plunder onto it.
26 The weight of the golden earrings that he asked for was 1,700 shekels of gold (about 42 pounds).
Besides this, there were the crescents, the pendants, and the purple clothes that the kings of Midian had worn,
and also the chains on the necks of their camels.
27 Gideon made an ephod out of it and set it up in his city, Ophrah.
And all Israel was unfaithful to God with it there, like a prostitute.
And it became a trap for Gideon and his family.
28 So Midian was brought down in front of the people of Israel,
and they did not lift up their heads anymore.
And the land had rest for 40 years in the days of Gideon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A shekel is a little under half an ounce. So 1,700 shekels are about 42 pounds.

Here the Midianites are called "Ishmaelites." Both peoples were nomads from the desert. Sometimes the Bible uses both names for the same people (see Genesis 37:25–28).

An "ephod" was a piece of clothing worn by the high priest. It was used to ask for God's will (Exodus 28). Gideon made himself his own ephod out of gold. Maybe he wanted to honor God. But it became an idol. People worshiped it instead of God.

This is Gideon's tragedy: He said, "The LORD shall rule over you," but he himself made something that led people away from God. Meaning well is not always the same as doing well.

Still: 40 years of peace. God really did save Israel through Gideon.

Gideon's death VERSES 29–35

29 Jerubbaal the son of Joash went and lived in his own house.
30 Gideon had 70 sons of his own, for he had many wives.
31 His concubine, who lived in Shechem, also had a son by him.
And he named him Abimelech.
32 Gideon the son of Joash died at a good old age.
He was buried in the tomb of his father Joash, in Ophrah of the Abiezrites.
33 As soon as Gideon was dead, the people of Israel turned away again.
They were unfaithful like prostitutes and followed the Baals,
and they made Baal Berith their god.
34 The people of Israel no longer remembered the LORD their God,
who had rescued them from the hand of all their enemies around them.
35 And they did not show kindness to the family of Jerubbaal, that is, Gideon,
for all the good he had done for Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gideon refused the crown, but he lived like a king: many wives, 70 sons, great wealth. And he named a son "Abimelech," which means "my father is king." What a name!

A "concubine" was a woman who lived with a man but had fewer rights than a wife.

As soon as Gideon is dead, the cycle starts all over again. "Baal Berith" means "lord of the covenant." The people make a covenant with a false god instead of with the true God.

The next chapter tells what becomes of Abimelech.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 9

Abimelech, the false king

Abimelech murders his brothers VERSES 1–6

1 Abimelech the son of Jerubbaal went to Shechem, to
his mother's brothers.
He spoke with them and with the whole family of his
mother's father and said,
2 "Please say to all the men of Shechem:
'Which is better for you:
that 70 men, all the sons of Jerubbaal, rule over you,
or that one man rules over you?'
Remember also that I am your own flesh and blood."
3 His mother's brothers said all these words about him to
all the men of Shechem.
Their hearts turned toward Abimelech,
for they said, "He is our brother."
4 They gave him 70 pieces of silver from the temple of
Baal Berith.
With it Abimelech hired worthless and reckless men,
who followed him.
5 He went to his father's house at Ophrah
and killed his brothers, the sons of Jerubbaal, 70 men,
on one stone.
Only Jotham, the youngest son of Jerubbaal, was left,
because he had hidden himself.
6 Then all the men of Shechem and all the house of Millo
gathered together.
They went and made Abimelech king by the oak of the
pillar in Shechem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abimelech was the son of Gideon's concubine from Shechem. He wants to become king, even though his father had refused the crown.

He plays with where he comes from: I am one of you. The people in Shechem support him because he is "our brother."

The money comes from the temple of a false god. And with it he pays a gang of thugs.

Then a terrible crime happens: He murders 70 of his own brothers "on one stone," as at an execution. Only the youngest, Jotham, is able to hide.

The Bible tells this story as a warning: This is what power looks like when it does not come from God but is built on violence and lies.

"The house of Millo" was probably a fortress or a part of the city of Shechem.

Jotham's fable of the trees VERSES 7–21

7 When Jotham was told about it, he went and stood on
the top of Mount Gerizim.
He raised his voice, called out, and said to them,
"Listen to me, you men of Shechem, so that God may
listen to you!
8 Once the trees set out to anoint a king over themselves.
They said to the olive tree, 'Be king over us!'
9 But the olive tree said to them,
'Should I stop making my oil, with which God and
people are honored through me,
and go to sway back and forth over the trees?'
10 Then the trees said to the fig tree, 'You come and be
king over us!'
11 But the fig tree said to them,
'Should I give up my sweetness and my good fruit
and go to sway back and forth over the trees?'
12 Then the trees said to the vine, 'You come and be king
over us!'
13 But the vine said to them,
'Should I give up my new wine, which makes God and
people happy,
and go to sway back and forth over the trees?'
14 Then all the trees said to the bramble, 'You come and be
king over us!'
15 The bramble said to the trees,
'If you really want to anoint me king over you,
then come and find shelter in my shade.
If not, let fire come out of the bramble
and burn up the cedars of Lebanon.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a fable, a story in which plants talk. It is one of the oldest fables in the world.

A bramble is a thorn bush.

The good trees, the olive tree, the fig tree, and the vine, do not want to be king. They have more important things to do: They produce oil, figs, and wine. They make life good. Only the useless bramble wants to be king.

The bramble offers shade. But a bramble has no shade at all! And it threatens: Whoever does not obey, I will burn. Thorns catch fire easily and can set a whole forest on fire.

The message: Good people often do not want power. It is the useless and dangerous ones who push their way to the top. And whoever follows them gets burned. This fable is one of the earliest criticisms of false power in world literature.

16 "So now: Have you acted honestly and sincerely in
making Abimelech king?
Have you treated Jerubbaal and his family well,
and have you done to him what his deeds deserved?
17 (For my father fought for you, he risked his life,
and he rescued you from the hand of Midian.
18 But today you have risen up against my father's family
and killed his sons, 70 men, on one stone.
And you have made Abimelech, the son of his female
servant, king over the men of Shechem,
because he is your brother.)
19 If you have acted honestly and sincerely with
Jerubbaal and his family today,
then be happy with Abimelech, and let him also be
happy with you.
20 But if not, let fire come out from Abimelech
and burn up the men of Shechem and the house of
Millo.
And let fire come out from the men of Shechem and
from the house of Millo
and burn up Abimelech."
21 Then Jotham ran away and fled.
He went to Beer and lived there, because he was afraid
of his brother Abimelech.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jotham explains the fable: You have betrayed my father, who risked his life for you. If that was right, then good luck with your king! But if not, you will destroy each other, like fire.

It is like a curse. And it will come true, as the rest of the chapter shows.

Conflict between Abimelech and Shechem VERSES 22–29

22 Abimelech ruled over Israel for three years.
23 Then God sent an evil spirit between Abimelech and the men of Shechem.
And the men of Shechem betrayed Abimelech.
24 This happened so that the violence done to the 70 sons of Jerubbaal would be paid back,
and their blood would come on their brother Abimelech, who had killed them,
and on the men of Shechem, who had helped him kill his brothers.
25 The men of Shechem set an ambush for him on the tops of the mountains.
They robbed everyone who came past them on the road.
And Abimelech was told about it.
26 Then Gaal the son of Ebed came with his brothers and moved to Shechem.
And the men of Shechem trusted him.
27 They went out into the fields, harvested their vineyards, pressed the grapes, and held a feast.
They went into the house of their god, ate and drank, and cursed Abimelech.
28 Gaal the son of Ebed said,
"Who is Abimelech, and who is Shechem, that we should serve him?
Isn't he the son of Jerubbaal? And isn't Zebul his officer?
Serve the men of Hamor, the father of Shechem!
But why should we serve him?
29 If only this people were under my command!
Then I would get rid of Abimelech."
And he said to Abimelech, "Make your army bigger and come out!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"God sent an evil spirit": This means God let quarrels and distrust grow between them. Whoever builds on betrayal and murder will reap betrayal. That is God's justice.

Shechem and Abimelech had joined together against Gideon's family. Now they turn against each other. Gaal is a show-off who makes big speeches at a feast with a lot of wine.

"Hamor, the father of Shechem": Hamor was the old Canaanite ruler of Shechem (Genesis 34). Gaal means: We are real Shechemites. What do we have to do with this half-Israelite?

Abimelech defeats Gaal VERSES 30–41

30 When Zebul, the ruler of the city, heard the words of Gaal the son of Ebed, he became angry.
31 He secretly sent messengers to Abimelech, saying,
"Gaal the son of Ebed and his brothers have come to Shechem.
And they are stirring up the city against you.
32 So now get up at night, you and the people who are with you,
and lie in wait in the field.
33 In the morning, as soon as the sun comes up, get up early and rush against the city.
When he and the people with him come out against you,
then do to him whatever you can."
34 So Abimelech got up at night, with all the people who were with him,
and they lay in wait against Shechem in four groups.
35 Gaal the son of Ebed went out and stood at the entrance of the city gate.
Then Abimelech and the people with him got up from their hiding place.
36 When Gaal saw the people, he said to Zebul,
"Look, people are coming down from the tops of the mountains."
Zebul said to him,
"You see the shadows of the mountains as if they were men."
37 Gaal spoke again and said,
"Look, people are coming down from the middle of the land,
and one group is coming by the road from the oak of Meonenim."
38 Then Zebul said to him,
"Now where is your big mouth, with which you said,
'Who is Abimelech, that we should serve him?'
Isn't this the people you looked down on?
Go out now and fight against them!"
39 So Gaal went out at the head of the men of Shechem and fought against Abimelech.
40 Abimelech chased him, and he fled from him.
And many fell wounded, all the way to the entrance of the gate.
41 Abimelech stayed at Arumah.
And Zebul drove out Gaal and his brothers, so that they could no longer live in Shechem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zebul plays a double game. He keeps Gaal waiting until it is too late. First he says: "You see the shadows of the mountains as if they were men." Then he mocks him: "Now where is your big mouth"?

"Meonenim" means "fortune-tellers." So it was an "oak of the fortune-tellers," maybe a holy tree of a foreign religion.

Abimelech destroys Shechem VERSES 42–49

42 On the next day the people went out into the fields.
And Abimelech was told about it.
43 He took the people, divided them into three groups, and lay in wait in the field.
He looked, and the people were coming out of the city.
Then he rose up against them and struck them.
44 Abimelech and the groups that were with him rushed forward
and stood at the entrance of the city gate.
And the two other groups rushed at everyone who was in the field and struck them.

45 Abimelech fought against the city all that day.
He took the city and killed the people who were in it.
He tore down the city and scattered salt over it.
46 When all the men of the tower of Shechem heard this,
they went into the stronghold of the temple of
Elberith.
47 Abimelech was told that all the men of the tower of
Shechem had gathered there.
48 So Abimelech went up Mount Zalmon, he and all the
people who were with him.
Abimelech took an ax in his hand, cut a branch from
the trees,
lifted it up, and put it on his shoulder.
And he said to the people who were with him,
"What you have seen me do, hurry and do just as I have
done!"
49 So all the people each cut down a branch and followed
Abimelech.
They put the branches against the stronghold and set
the stronghold on fire over them.
So all the people of the tower of Shechem died too,
about 1,000 men and women.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abimelech destroys the city that made him king. He scatters salt over the ruins so that nothing will grow there anymore. This was a sign: This city is to be cursed forever.

Then he burns 1,000 people, men and women, who had hidden in the temple. This is a terrible massacre.

Jotham's curse comes true: Fire has come out from Abimelech and burned up the men of Shechem. Just like the bramble in the fable.

"Elberith" means "god of the covenant," probably the same god as "Baal Berith" (Verse 4). Of all places, the temple that gave the money for the murder of the brothers becomes a death trap.

Abimelech's death VERSES 50–57

50 Then Abimelech went to Thebez, camped against
Thebez, and took it.
51 But in the middle of the city there was a strong tower.
All the men and women, all the people of the city, fled
there.
They shut themselves in and went up onto the roof of
the tower.
52 Abimelech came to the tower and fought against it.
He came close to the door of the tower to burn it with
fire.
53 Then a woman threw an upper millstone onto
Abimelech's head
and cracked his skull.
54 He quickly called the young man who carried his
weapons and said to him,
"Draw your sword and kill me,
so that people will not say about me, 'A woman killed
him.'"
So his young man stabbed him, and he died.
55 When the men of Israel saw that Abimelech was dead,
they all went home, each to his own place.
56 So God paid Abimelech back for the evil he had done to
his father
by killing his 70 brothers.
57 And God made all the evil of the men of Shechem fall
back on their own heads.
And the curse of Jotham the son of Jerubbaal came on
them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abimelech wants to do the same thing in Thebez as in Shechem: burn a tower full of people. But this time he is stopped, by a woman without a name, with a millstone.

A millstone was a heavy, round stone that women used every day to grind grain. A tool from the kitchen defeats the tyrant.

Even while dying, Abimelech is still proud: No one is to say that a woman killed him. But the Bible tells it anyway, and many years later people still remember it exactly (2 Samuel 11:21).

In the end it is clear: God has set justice right again. Abimelech, who murdered his brothers on one stone, is himself killed by a stone. Whoever sows violence will reap violence.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 10

Tola, Jair, and Israel's repentance

Tola and Jair VERSES 1–5

1 After Abimelech, Tola came forward to save Israel.
He was the son of Puah and the grandson of Dodo.
He was a man from the tribe of Issachar.
He lived in Shamir in the hill country of Ephraim.
2 Tola was judge over Israel for 23 years.
Then he died and was buried in Shamir.
3 After him came Jair from Gilead.
He was judge over Israel for 22 years.
4 Jair had 30 sons.
They rode on 30 young donkeys.
They had 30 cities in the land of Gilead.
These cities are still called Havvoth Jair today.
5 Jair died and was buried in Kamon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only a little is told about Tola and Jair. They are called the "minor judges." They led Israel in calmer times.

30 sons on 30 donkeys: This shows that Jair was rich and powerful. Whoever rode on a donkey was an important man.

"Havvoth Jair" means "tent villages of Jair" (see also Numbers 32:41).

Israel serves many gods VERSES 6–9

6 Once again the people of Israel did what was evil in the
eyes of the LORD.

They served the Baals and the Ashtaroth.
They served the gods of Syria, the gods of Sidon, and the gods of Moab.
They served the gods of the people of Ammon and the gods of the Philistines.
They turned away from the LORD and did not serve him.
7 So the LORD became very angry with Israel.
He handed them over to the Philistines and to the people of Ammon.
8 That year these enemies crushed the people of Israel and treated them harshly.
For 18 years they oppressed all the people of Israel on the other side of the Jordan.
That was in the land of the Amorites, in Gilead.
9 The people of Ammon even crossed the Jordan.
They fought against Judah, against Benjamin, and against the tribe of Ephraim.
So Israel was in great trouble.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now it gets worse than ever before: Israel serves not just one foreign god, but the gods of seven different peoples. And they leave the LORD completely.

Two enemies come at the same time: the Philistines in the west and the people of Ammon in the east. The story of Samson later tells about the Philistines. The story of Jephthah tells about the people of Ammon.

God is tired of it VERSES 10–16

10 Then the people of Israel cried out to the LORD.
They said,
"We have sinned against you.
We have turned away from our God and served the Baals."
11 The LORD said to the people of Israel,
"I saved you from the Egyptians and from the Amorites.
I saved you from the people of Ammon and from the Philistines.
Didn't I?
12 The Sidonians, the Amalekites, and the Maonites also oppressed you.
You cried out to me, and I saved you from their power.
13 But you have turned away from me and served other gods.
So I will not save you anymore.
14 Go and cry out to the gods you have chosen.
Let them save you when you are in trouble!"
15 The people of Israel said to the LORD,
"We have sinned!
Do to us whatever you think is good.
Only please save us today!"
16 They got rid of the foreign gods among them,
and they served the LORD.
Then the LORD was deeply grieved by Israel's misery.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This time, God first says no. The people have begged so often and then fallen away again anyway. God says: Go and call on your other gods! This is bitter mockery, but also pain. God is like a father who is disappointed by his children again and again.

But then the people do something they had not done before: They really put away the foreign gods. They do not only ask, they turn back.

And then comes one of the most beautiful sentences in the book: "The LORD was deeply grieved by Israel's misery." God cannot just watch his people suffer. His love is stronger than his anger.

"Maonites": It is not certain who is meant. The Greek translation has "Midianites" here.

Who will lead us? VERSES 17–18

17 Then the people of Ammon gathered their army.
They set up camp in Gilead.
The people of Israel also came together.
They set up camp in Mizpah.
18 The people, the leaders of Gilead, said to one another,
"Who will be the first to fight against the people of Ammon?
That man will be the head over everyone who lives in Gilead."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The armies stand facing each other. But Israel has no leader. No one wants to make the first move. The next chapter tells who this man will be.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 11

Jephthah and his vow

The son who was driven out VERSES 1–3

1 Jephthah the Gileadite was a mighty warrior.
He was the son of a prostitute.
Gilead was Jephthah's father.
2 Gilead's wife also had sons by him.
When his wife's sons grew up, they drove Jephthah out and said to him,
"You will not inherit anything in our father's house, because you are the son of another woman."
3 So Jephthah fled from his brothers and lived in the land of Tob.
Outlaws gathered around Jephthah, and they went out with him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jephthah has a hard start in life: He is the child of a prostitute. His half-brothers drive him away so that he does not inherit anything. He becomes an outsider and lives together with other outcasts.

God often uses exactly the people whom others look down on.

The elders bring Jephthah back VERSES 4–11

4 After a while, the people of Ammon made war against
Israel.
5 When the people of Ammon made war against Israel,
the elders of Gilead went to bring Jephthah back from
the land of Tob.
6 They said to Jephthah,
"Come and be our commander, so that we can fight
against the people of Ammon."
7 Jephthah said to the elders of Gilead,
"Didn't you hate me and drive me out of my father's
house?
Why have you come to me now, when you are in
trouble?"
8 The elders of Gilead said to Jephthah,
"That is why we have come back to you now.
Go with us and fight against the people of Ammon.
Then you will be our head over all the people of
Gilead."
9 Jephthah said to the elders of Gilead,
"If you bring me back home to fight against the people
of Ammon,
and the LORD gives them to me, will I be your head?"
10 The elders of Gilead said to Jephthah,
"The LORD will be witness between us.
We will surely do what you say."
11 So Jephthah went with the elders of Gilead.
And the people made him head and commander over
them.
And Jephthah spoke all his words in front of the LORD
in Mizpah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now, in their need, they need the outcast. Jephthah says honestly: You drove me away, and now you come crawling back?

He bargains wisely and has the promise confirmed in front of God. He knows how quickly people change their minds.

Jephthah negotiates with the king of Ammon VERSES 12–28

12 Jephthah sent messengers to the king of the people of
Ammon, saying,
"What do you have against me, that you have come to
me to fight against my land?"
13 The king of the people of Ammon answered Jephthah's
messengers,
"Because Israel took away my land when he came up
out of Egypt,
from the Arnon to the Jabbok and to the Jordan.
So now give it back peacefully."
14 Jephthah sent messengers again to the king of the
people of Ammon
15 and said to him,
"This is what Jephthah says:
Israel did not take away the land of Moab or the land of
the people of Ammon.
16 But when they came up from Egypt,
Israel went through the wilderness to the Red Sea and
came to Kadesh.
17 Then Israel sent messengers to the king of Edom,
saying,
'Please let me pass through your land.'
But the king of Edom did not listen.
In the same way, Israel sent to the king of Moab, but he
refused.
So Israel stayed in Kadesh.
18 Then they went through the wilderness and went
around the land of Edom and the land of Moab.
They came to the east side of the land of Moab and
camped on the other side of the Arnon.
But they did not go into the territory of Moab, for the
Arnon was the border of Moab.
19 Then Israel sent messengers to Sihon, the king of the
Amorites, the king of Heshbon.
And Israel said to him,
'Please let us pass through your land to our place.'
20 But Sihon did not trust Israel to only pass through his
territory.
Instead, Sihon gathered all his people, camped in
Jahaz, and fought against Israel.
21 And the LORD, the God of Israel, gave Sihon and all his
people into the hand of Israel,
and they struck them.
So Israel took all the land of the Amorites who lived in
that country.
22 They took the whole territory of the Amorites,
from the Arnon to the Jabbok, and from the
wilderness to the Jordan.
23 So now the LORD, the God of Israel, has driven out the
Amorites in front of his people Israel.
And now you want to take it?
24 Don't you take what Chemosh your god gives you to
own?
So we also will take everything that the LORD our God
has driven out in front of us.
25 Now are you any better than Balak the son of Zippor,
the king of Moab?
Did he ever quarrel with Israel, or did he ever fight
against them?
26 Israel has lived in Heshbon and its towns,
in Aroer and its towns,
and in all the cities along the Arnon for 300 years!
Why didn't you take them back during that time?
27 I have not sinned against you.
But you are doing me wrong by making war against
me.
May the LORD, the Judge, judge today between the
people of Israel and the people of Ammon."
28 But the king of the people of Ammon did not listen to
the words that Jephthah sent him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before Jephthah fights, he tries with words. He sends messengers twice and explains the history in detail, just as it is told in Numbers 20–21. This is one of the first diplomatic negotiations recorded in the Bible.

His arguments: Israel did not take the land from the people of Ammon, but from King Sihon, who had attacked Israel. And Israel has lived there for 300 years. Why do you come only now?

"Chemosh" was actually the god of the Moabites. Maybe Jephthah mixes up the peoples here, or Ammon and Moab were closely connected at that time. Jephthah speaks in the language of his opponent here, without saying that Chemosh is a real god.

"The LORD, the Judge": In the end, Jephthah leaves the decision to God. He is the real judge.

"Red Sea": This is what the WEB says. The Hebrew says "Sea of Reeds."

The terrible vow VERSES 29–33

29 Then the Spirit of the LORD came on Jephthah.
He passed through Gilead and Manasseh, he passed through Mizpah of Gilead,
and from Mizpah of Gilead he went on to the people of Ammon.
30 And Jephthah made a vow to the LORD and said,
"If you will really give the people of Ammon into my hand,
31 then whatever comes out of the doors of my house to meet me
when I come back in peace from the people of Ammon
shall belong to the LORD,
and I will offer it up as a burnt offering."
32 So Jephthah went over to the people of Ammon to fight against them.
And the LORD gave them into his hand.
33 He struck them from Aroer to Minnith, 20 cities, and as far as Abelcheramim,
with a very great slaughter.
So the people of Ammon were brought down in front of the people of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A vow is a solemn promise made to God.

Even though the Spirit of the LORD has already come on Jephthah, he makes a vow. He wants to promise God something so that he will win. This was not necessary. God had already equipped him.

The vow is careless and terrible: "whatever comes out of the doors of my house to meet me." At that time, animals often lived on the ground floor of houses. Maybe he was thinking of an animal. But he also had to expect that a person might come out.

God had clearly forbidden human sacrifice (Leviticus 18:21; Deuteronomy 12:31). Jephthah obviously did not know God's commandments well. He thought like the peoples around him, who sacrificed people to their gods.

Jephthah's daughter VERSES 34–40

34 When Jephthah came to his house in Mizpah,
his daughter came out to meet him, with tambourines and dancing.
She was his only child.
Besides her, he had no son or daughter.
35 When he saw her, he tore his clothes and said,
"Oh, my daughter! You have brought me very low,
and you are one of those who trouble me.
For I have opened my mouth to the LORD, and I cannot take it back."
36 She said to him,
"My father, you have opened your mouth to the LORD.
Do to me what has come out of your mouth,
since the LORD has taken revenge for you on your enemies, the people of Ammon."
37 And she said to her father,
"Let just this one thing be done for me:
Leave me alone for two months,
so that I may go away and go down to the mountains and weep over my virginity, I and my friends."
38 He said, "Go."
And he sent her away for two months.
She went with her friends and mourned her virginity on the mountains.
39 At the end of the two months, she came back to her father.
And he did with her according to his vow that he had made.
She had never been with a man.
And it became a custom in Israel
40 that the daughters of Israel went every year to celebrate the daughter of Jephthah the Gileadite, four days a year.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the saddest and most terrible stories in the Bible.

His daughter, his only child, comes out happily to meet him, with music and dancing, to celebrate the victory. And Jephthah says: "You are one of those who trouble me." He thinks of himself first, not of her.

The daughter is braver and has more dignity than her father. She does not even have a name in the story. She only asks for two months to mourn with her friends that she will never marry and never have children.

What exactly happened then? The Bible only says: "He did with her according to his vow." There are two ways to understand it:

Many, including most of the old Jewish and Christian Bible teachers, understand that Jephthah really sacrificed his daughter. That was a horrible crime against God's commandment.

Others think he dedicated her to God, so that she was never allowed to marry and lived her whole life in God's service. One hint for this could be that she weeps over her "virginity," not over her death.

Jewish scholars have said: Jephthah should not have kept his vow. A vow that goes against God's commandment does not count. He could have gone to the priest and had it released (Leviticus 27).

The Bible does not praise Jephthah for this vow. God is silent in this story. It is a warning: against careless promises and against treating God like a business partner. And it shows how far Israel was from God at this time.

The women of Israel did not forget Jephthah's daughter. Every year they remembered her. In this way, the victim without a name at least gets a memorial.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 12

Shibboleth – and three minor judges

Conflict with Ephraim VERSES 1–4

1 The men of Ephraim gathered their army.
They crossed the river toward the north.
They said to Jephthah,
"You crossed over to fight against the people of Ammon.
Why didn't you call us to go with you?
We will burn down your house with you inside!"
2 Jephthah answered them,
"My people and I had a hard fight with the people of Ammon.
I called you, but you did not save me from them.
3 I saw that you would not save me.
So I risked my life and went over to fight the people of Ammon.
And the LORD handed them over to me.
So why have you come here today to fight against me?"
4 Then Jephthah gathered all the men of Gilead.
They fought against Ephraim.
The men of Gilead defeated Ephraim.
They did this because the men of Ephraim had said,
"You Gileadites are only runaways from Ephraim.
You live in the middle of Ephraim and in the middle of Manasseh."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"To the north": The Hebrew word "Zaphon" can mean "north," but it can also be a city with this name east of the Jordan (Joshua 13:27).

Ephraim complains again, as it did with Gideon (Judges 8:1). But Jephthah does not answer as gently as Gideon. He becomes angry.

The men of Ephraim insult the Gileadites: You are only runaways, people without a real home! Mocking like this can start wars.

It comes to a war between brothers, Israelites against Israelites. This is a sign of how deeply Israel has fallen.

The word "Shibboleth" VERSES 5–7

5 The Gileadites took control of the places where people could cross the Jordan.
These places are called fords.
They kept the Ephraimites from getting across.
Sometimes a runaway from Ephraim said, "Let me cross over."
Then the men of Gilead asked him, "Are you an Ephraimite?"
If he said, "No,"
6 they said to him, "Then say 'Shibboleth.'"
But he said "Sibboleth."
He could not say the word the right way.
Then they grabbed him and killed him at the fords of the Jordan.
At that time 42,000 men of Ephraim were killed.
7 Jephthah was judge over Israel for 6 years.
Then Jephthah the Gileadite died.
He was buried in the cities of Gilead.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Shibboleth" means "ear of grain" or "stream." The Ephraimites spoke a different dialect. They could not say the "sh" sound and said "s" instead. So people could recognize them by the way they spoke.

This story gave us the word "shibboleth," which exists in many languages to this day, also in English. It means: a sign by which you can tell whether someone belongs to a group or not.

The story is shocking: People are killed only because they speak differently. Sadly, things like this have happened again and again in history. The Bible tells it as a sign that the people were falling apart, not as an example to follow.

The number 42,000 is very high. The Hebrew word for "thousand" can also mean a smaller military unit (see Joshua 8).

Ibzan, Elon, and Abdon VERSES 8–15

8 After Jephthah, Ibzan from Bethlehem was judge over Israel.
9 He had 30 sons.
He sent his 30 daughters to marry outside his clan.
And he brought in 30 young women from outside his clan as wives for his sons.
He was judge over Israel for 7 years.
10 Ibzan died and was buried in Bethlehem.
11 After him, Elon from the tribe of Zebulun was judge over Israel.
He was judge over Israel for 10 years.
12 Elon from Zebulun died.
He was buried in Aijalon in the land of Zebulun.
13 After him, Abdon was judge over Israel.
He was the son of Hillel, from Pirathon.
14 He had 40 sons and 30 grandsons.
They rode on 70 young donkeys.
He was judge over Israel for 8 years.
15 Abdon, the son of Hillel, from Pirathon, died.
He was buried in Pirathon in the land of Ephraim, in the hill country of the Amalekites.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again, three "minor judges," about whom little is told. They had big families and a lot of influence.

Ibzan married his children to people outside his clan. In this way, he made connections and friendships with other families. This made peace stronger.

It is not certain whether this Bethlehem is the Bethlehem in Judah or the one in Zebulun (Joshua 19:15).

After these calmer times comes the best-known judge: Samson.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 13

An angel announces Samson's birth

The Philistines rule over Israel VERSE 1

1 The people of Israel again did what was evil in the eyes
of the LORD.
And the LORD gave them into the hand of the
Philistines for 40 years.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again the story begins as it so often does in the book of Judges: Israel turns away from God, and a foreign people rules over the land.

The Philistines lived on the coast in the southwest, by the Mediterranean Sea. They were a strong people with weapons made of iron. Later the land got the name "Palestine" from them.

This time nothing is said about the people crying out to God. Still, God sends a rescuer. God acts before the people even ask him.

The angel appears to the woman VERSES 2–7

2 There was a man from Zorah, from the family of the
Danites.
His name was Manoah.
His wife could not have children and was childless.
3 The angel of the LORD appeared to the woman and said
to her,
"You cannot have children and are childless.
But you will become pregnant and have a son.
4 So now please be careful:
Do not drink wine or strong drink,
and do not eat anything unclean.
5 For you will become pregnant and have a son.
No razor shall come on his head.
For the child shall be a Nazirite to God from the womb.
He will begin to save Israel from the hand of the
Philistines."
6 Then the woman went to her husband and told him,
"A man of God came to me.
His face was like the face of the angel of God, very
awesome.
I did not ask him where he came from,
and he did not tell me his name.
7 But he said to me,
'You will become pregnant and have a son.
And now do not drink wine or strong drink.
Do not eat anything unclean.
For the child shall be a Nazirite to God
from the womb to the day of his death.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Zorah was in the hill country west of Jerusalem, close to the land of the Philistines.

A woman who cannot have children does have a son because God steps in. This happens more often in the Bible: with Sarah, the mother of Isaac, with Rebekah, with Rachel, later with Hannah, the mother of Samuel, and in the New Testament with Elizabeth, the mother of John the Baptist. It shows: This child is a gift from God and has a special task.

The woman has no name in the story. But she is the one to whom the angel appears first.

A "Nazirite" is a person who is set apart completely for God. He drinks no wine, does not cut his hair, and does not touch dead bodies (Numbers 6). Normally people made such a vow for a certain time. But Samson is to be a Nazirite his whole life. Even his mother is not to drink wine while she is pregnant.

"He will begin to save Israel": Samson will not defeat the Philistines completely. He only makes a beginning. Only much later, under King David, will Israel be completely free from the Philistines.

Manoah asks for a second visit VERSES 8–14

8 Then Manoah prayed to the LORD and said,
"Oh, Lord, please let the man of God whom you sent
come to us again.
Let him teach us what we should do with the child who
will be born."
9 God listened to Manoah's voice.
The angel of God came again to the woman while she
was sitting in the field.
But Manoah, her husband, was not with her.
10 The woman quickly ran and told her husband.
She said to him,
"The man who came to me the other day has appeared
to me."
11 Manoah got up and followed his wife.
He came to the man and said to him,
"Are you the man who spoke to my wife?"
He said, "I am."
12 Manoah said,
"Now let what you have said happen.
How shall the child live, and what shall his task be?"
13 The angel of the LORD said to Manoah,
"The woman must be careful about everything I told
her.
14 She must not eat anything that comes from the vine.
She must not drink wine or strong drink,
and she must not eat anything unclean.
She must keep everything I commanded her."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Manoah wants to do everything right. He prays, and God hears him. But again the angel comes first to the woman, not to him.

Manoah asks for rules for the child. The angel does not answer with new rules. He only says: What I told the woman, that counts. The woman had already understood everything correctly.

"Strong drink" means other drinks that make you drunk, for example beer.

The offering and the angel's name VERSES 15–23

15 Manoah said to the angel of the LORD,
"Please stay with us.
Then we will prepare a young goat for you."
16 The angel of the LORD said to Manoah,
"Even if you keep me here, I will not eat your bread.
If you want to prepare a burnt offering, you must
offer it to the LORD."
For Manoah did not know that he was the angel of the
LORD.
17 Manoah said to the angel of the LORD,
"What is your name?
When your words come true, we want to honor you."

18 The angel of the LORD said to him,
"Why do you ask about my name? It is
incomprehensible."
19 So Manoah took the young goat with the grain offering
and offered it on the rock to the LORD.
Then the angel did an amazing thing while Manoah
and his wife watched.
20 For when the flame went up from the altar toward the
sky,
the angel of the LORD went up in the flame of the
altar.
Manoah and his wife saw it,
and they fell on their faces to the ground.
21 But the angel of the LORD did not appear to Manoah
and his wife again.
Then Manoah knew that he was the angel of the LORD.
22 Manoah said to his wife,
"We will surely die, because we have seen God."
23 But his wife said to him,
"If the LORD had wanted to kill us,
he would not have accepted a burnt offering and a
grain offering from our hands.
He would not have shown us all these things.
And he would not have told us such things now."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Manoah wants to serve the guest a meal, as hospitality requires. He thinks he is a human being, a prophet. The angel turns him away from himself: If you want to give something, give it to God.

"Incomprehensible" means: too great to understand. This is what the WEB says. The Hebrew word means "wonderful." The angel's name is too great for human beings. Later the prophet Isaiah uses the same word about the promised child: He will be called "Wonderful" (Isaiah 9:6). In verse 19 there is a related word: The angel does "an amazing thing."

Manoah becomes afraid. At that time, people believed: Whoever sees God must die. But his wife thinks clearly and calmly: God has accepted our offering. He has promised us a child. He does not want to kill us, he wants to bless us. In this story, the woman is the wiser one.

Samson is born VERSES 24–25

24 The woman had a son and named him Samson.
The child grew up, and the LORD blessed him.
25 The Spirit of the LORD began to stir him in Mahaneh
Dan,
between Zorah and Eshtaol.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The name Samson (in Hebrew "Shimshon") is probably connected with the Hebrew word for "sun."

"Mahaneh Dan" means "camp of Dan." At that time, the tribe of Dan still lived in this area, before part of it moved north (Chapter 18).

The Spirit of God comes on Samson. That is the source of his strength, not his muscles. The next chapters tell about this.

JUDGES

Chapter 14

The lion, the riddle, and the wedding

Samson wants to marry a Philistine woman VERSES 1–4

1 Samson went down to Timnah.
In Timnah he saw a woman, one of the daughters of
the Philistines.
2 He came back up and told his father and his mother.
He said,
"I have seen a woman in Timnah, one of the daughters
of the Philistines.
Now get her for me as my wife."
3 Then his father and his mother said to him,
"Isn't there a woman among the daughters of your
relatives
or among all my people,
that you have to go and take a wife from the
uncircumcised Philistines?"
Samson said to his father,
"Get her for me, for she pleases me well."
4 But his father and his mother did not know that this
came from the LORD.
For he was looking for a reason to act against the
Philistines.
At that time the Philistines ruled over Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At that time, parents chose the husbands and wives for their children. But Samson decides for himself. He wants a woman from the people who are oppressing Israel.

"Uncircumcised": Circumcision was the sign of the covenant with God. The Philistines did not have this sign. The parents are worried: A marriage with a woman who does not know the LORD can lead away from faith (Deuteronomy 7:3–4).

"She pleases me well" literally means in Hebrew: "She is right in my eyes." This fits the big theme at the end of the book: "Everyone did what was right in his own eyes" (Judges 17:6; 21:25).

Verse 4 is hard: God uses even Samson's stubborn wish for his plan. This does not mean that God likes everything Samson does. But God can also act through people who make mistakes.

Samson and the lion VERSES 5–9

5 Then Samson went down to Timnah with his father
and his mother.
They came to the vineyards of Timnah.
Suddenly a young lion roared at him.
6 Then the Spirit of the LORD came on him with power.
He tore the lion apart with his bare hands,
as you would tear apart a young goat.
But he did not tell his father or his mother what he had
done.
7 He went down and talked with the woman.
And Samson liked her very much.

8 After a while he came back to take her as his wife.
He turned off the road to look at the dead body of the lion.
And there was a swarm of bees in the body of the lion, and honey.
9 He took the honey into his hands
and went on, eating as he walked.
He came to his father and mother and gave them some, and they ate.
But he did not tell them that he had taken the honey out of the lion's body.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At that time there were still lions in Israel. Samson kills one without a weapon. He does not do this by his own strength: The Spirit of the LORD comes on him.

Samson is in the vineyards. For a Nazirite this is a dangerous place, because he is not allowed to eat anything from the vine.

Then Samson takes honey out of the dead lion. A Nazirite was not allowed to touch dead bodies (Numbers 6:6). There the law speaks about dead people. But a dead animal made every Israelite unclean (Leviticus 11:27). Samson does not take the rules seriously. That is probably why he keeps it secret from his parents. He even gives them some of the honey without telling them.

The wedding feast and the riddle VERSES 10–14

10 His father went down to the woman.
And Samson held a feast there,
for that is what young men used to do.
11 When the people saw him, they brought 30 companions to be with him.
12 Samson said to them,
"Let me tell you a riddle now.
If you can tell me the answer within the 7 days of the feast and find it out,
then I will give you 30 linen shirts and 30 changes of clothing.
13 But if you cannot tell me the answer,
then you must give me 30 linen shirts and 30 changes of clothing."
They said to him,
"Tell us your riddle, so that we can hear it."
14 He said to them,
"Out of the eater came food.
Out of the strong came sweetness."
For three days they could not solve the riddle.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At that time, a wedding was celebrated for seven days. In Hebrew, the word for "feast" actually means "drinking party." The text does not say whether Samson, as a Nazirite, drank wine there.

The 30 companions are Philistines. They are supposed to keep Samson company, but maybe also to watch him.

A "change of clothing" (the words in the WEB, our English source text) was a set of fine festive clothes. Clothing was very expensive at that time. So the bet was about a lot.

The riddle is actually unfair. No one could know the answer, because no one had seen what happened with the lion.

The woman gives away the riddle VERSES 15–18

15 On the seventh day they said to Samson's wife,
"Talk your husband into telling us the riddle.
Otherwise we will burn you and your father's house with fire.
Did you invite us here to make us poor? Isn't that so?"
16 Samson's wife cried in front of him and said,
"You just hate me and don't love me.
You have told a riddle to the people of my nation,
and you haven't told me the answer."
He said to her,
"I haven't even told my father or my mother.
Why should I tell you?"
17 She cried in front of him for the seven days while their feast lasted.
On the seventh day he told her, because she pressed him so hard.
And she told the riddle to the people of her nation.
18 On the seventh day, before the sun went down, the men of the city said to him,
"What is sweeter than honey?
What is stronger than a lion?"
He said to them,
"If you had not plowed with my heifer,
you would not have found out my riddle."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Philistines threaten the young woman with death. She is in a terrible situation: She is caught between her husband and her people.

Verse 15 says "on the seventh day," but verse 17 says she cried "for the seven days." This does not fit together completely. The old Greek translation has "on the fourth day" in verse 15. Maybe the woman had already been crying the whole week, and on the seventh day the threat was added.

A heifer is a young cow. "Plowed with my heifer" is a crude picture. Samson means: You used my wife to get the secret. This is not a respectful way to talk about your own wife.

This scene will happen again later: Once again a woman will press Samson until he gives away his secret (Chapter 16).

Samson takes revenge in Ashkelon VERSES 19–20

19 Then the Spirit of the LORD came on him with power.
He went down to Ashkelon and struck down 30 of their men.
He took what he could from them as plunder
and gave the changes of clothing to those who had solved the riddle.
His anger burned, and he went up to his father's house.
20 But Samson's wife was given to his companion,
who had been his friend.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ashkelon was one of the five great cities of the Philistines, by the sea.

Samson kills 30 innocent men just to pay what he owes from the bet. This is a horrible deed. The Bible says that the Spirit of the LORD came on him. This means: Through Samson, God begins the fight against Israel's oppressors. But the Bible does not say that Samson's anger and revenge are good. Samson is a hero with great weaknesses.

Jewish and Christian Bible teachers have often seen Samson critically: He was gifted by God, but he lived by his own wishes. This story must never be used as an example to justify revenge or violence.

In the end, Samson loses his wife. Her father gives her to another man. The wedding ends in disaster.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 15

The foxes and the donkey's jawbone

Samson wants to see his wife VERSES 1–3

1 But after a while, at the time of the wheat harvest,
Samson visited his wife and brought a young goat with him.
He said, "I will go in to my wife in her room."
But her father would not let him go in.
2 Her father said,
"I was sure that you completely hated her.
So I gave her to your companion.
Isn't her younger sister more beautiful than she is?
Please take her instead."
3 Samson said to them,
"This time I will be without blame toward the Philistines
when I do them harm."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The wheat harvest was in early summer, around May or June.

Samson comes back as if nothing had happened. At that time, a young goat was a gift that people brought to make peace.

Meanwhile the father has given his daughter to another man. Now he offers Samson the younger sister, as if women were goods that can be traded. That is how it often was at that time. The Bible tells it, but it does not praise it.

The foxes with the torches VERSES 4–6

4 Samson went and caught 300 foxes.
He took torches and tied the foxes together by their tails, two by two.
Between each pair of tails he put a torch.
5 He set the torches on fire
and let the foxes run into the standing grain of the Philistines.
So he burned up the bundles of grain and the standing grain,
and also the olive groves.
6 Then the Philistines asked, "Who has done this?"
People said, "Samson, the son-in-law of the man from Timnah.
For he took his wife away and gave her to his companion."
So the Philistines went up
and burned her and her father with fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The word for "foxes" can also mean jackals. Jackals live in packs and are easier to catch in large numbers.

At harvest time the grain was dry. A fire destroyed the food for a whole year. This was a heavy blow for the Philistines.

Then something terrible happens: The Philistines burn the woman and her father. This is exactly what they had threatened her with (Judges 14:15). The woman had given away Samson's secret so that she would not be burned. Now she is burned anyway. She is the innocent victim of the violence between the men.

Revenge and more revenge VERSES 7–8

7 Samson said to them,
"If you act like this,
I will surely take revenge on you,
and after that I will stop."
8 He struck them hip and thigh, with a great slaughter.
And he went down and lived in the cave in the rock of Etam.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"To strike hip and thigh" is an old saying. It means: He beat them completely.

Here you can see how revenge always creates new revenge: Samson burns the fields, the Philistines burn the woman, Samson kills many Philistines, and the Philistines march against Judah. Samson says: "After that I will stop." But the violence does not stop.

Here the Bible shows honestly where revenge leads. Later the Bible teaches another way: You shall not take revenge (Leviticus 19:18), and Jesus says: Love your enemies (Matthew 5:44).

The men of Judah hand Samson over VERSES 9–13

9 Then the Philistines went up,
camped in Judah, and spread out in Lehi.
10 The men of Judah asked, "Why have you come up against us?"
They said,
"We have come up to tie up Samson.
We want to do to him as he has done to us."
11 Then 3,000 men of Judah went down to the cave in the rock of Etam.
They said to Samson,
"Don't you know that the Philistines rule over us?
What is this that you have done to us?"
He said to them,
"As they did to me, so I have done to them."
12 They said to him,
"We have come down to tie you up
and hand you over to the Philistines."
Samson said to them,
"Swear to me that you will not attack me yourselves."
13 They said to him,
"No, we will only tie you up tightly and hand you over to them.
But we will surely not kill you."

They tied him up with two new ropes
and brought him up from the rock.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a sad scene: The men of Judah do not fight against the oppressors. They have accepted the rule of the Philistines. They would rather hand over their own countryman than get into trouble. 3,000 men come to tie up one single man.

Earlier, Judah had been the first tribe to fight against the Canaanites (Chapter 1). Now Judah only wants peace and quiet.

Samson does not fight back against his own people. He lets himself be tied up.

In Hebrew, "Lehi" means "jawbone." This fits what comes next.

The donkey's jawbone VERSES 14–17

14 When he came to Lehi, the Philistines came shouting
to meet him.
Then the Spirit of the LORD came on him with power.
The ropes on his arms became like flax that has been
burned in the fire.
And the ropes fell off his hands.
15 He found a fresh jawbone of a donkey.
He reached out his hand, took it, and struck down
1,000 men with it.
16 Samson said,
"With the jawbone of a donkey, heaps on heaps.
With the jawbone of a donkey I have struck 1,000
men."
17 When he had finished speaking, he threw the jawbone
out of his hand.
And that place was called Ramath Lehi.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Flax is a plant from which linen thread is made. When it burns, it falls apart easily.

A "fresh" jawbone was not yet dried out and brittle, but hard and heavy.

Once again Samson touches something dead. For a Nazirite this is actually forbidden.

Samson's saying is a play on words: In Hebrew, "donkey" and "heap" sound the same: "chamor." It is like a little victory song.

"Ramath Lehi" means "hill of the jawbone."

Samson says: "I have struck." He only speaks about himself, not about God. But the Bible makes clear: The strength came from the Spirit of the LORD.

God gives water VERSES 18–20

18 He was very thirsty.
He called on the LORD and said,
"You have given this great rescue through the hand of
your servant.
And now shall I die of thirst
and fall into the hands of the uncircumcised?"
19 But God split open the hollow place that is in Lehi,
and water came out of it.
When he had drunk, his strength came back, and he
came back to life.
That is why the spring was named En Hakkore.
It is in Lehi to this day.
20 He judged Israel for 20 years, in the days of the
Philistines.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For the first time, Samson prays. He realizes: Without God he is only a weak human being who can die of thirst. The strong hero needs help.

God answers right away. He lets water come out of the ground, just as he did for Israel in the wilderness long ago.

"En Hakkore" means "spring of the one who called." The name reminds us: Samson called to God, and God answered.

Verse 20 says that Samson judged Israel for 20 years. He did not drive out the Philistines. They stayed in power. But he was a constant danger for them. This sentence stands here like an ending, and it is repeated once more at the end of Chapter 16.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 16

Samson and Delilah

Samson in Gaza VERSES 1–3

1 Samson went to Gaza.
There he saw a prostitute and went in to her.
2 The people of Gaza were told, "Samson is here!"
They surrounded him and lay in wait for him all night
in the city gate.
They kept quiet all night and said,
"Wait until morning light. Then we will kill him."
3 Samson lay there until midnight.
At midnight he got up.
He took hold of the doors of the city gate with the two
posts
and pulled them up, bar and all.
He put them on his shoulders
and carried them up to the top of the mountain that
faces Hebron.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gaza was one of the five great cities of the Philistines, by the sea in the south. Samson goes right into the land of his enemies.

The Bible tells openly that Samson goes to a prostitute. Again he follows what his eyes see. God's law rejected this.

A city gate was the most important part of a city wall. It was heavy and strong. Samson carries it away. For the Philistines this is a great humiliation: Their city stands open, without protection.

Hebron is about 37 miles from Gaza, in the mountains of Judah. Maybe a mountain in the direction of Hebron is meant.

The Philistines bribe Delilah VERSES 4–5

4 After this, he loved a woman in the valley of Sorek.
Her name was Delilah.
5 The lords of the Philistines came up to her and said to her,
"Talk him into it and find out where his great strength comes from
and how we can overpower him.
Then we will tie him up and torment him.
And each of us will give you 1,100 pieces of silver."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The valley of Sorek is near Samson's home town of Zorah, at the border of the land of the Philistines. The Bible does not say whether Delilah was a Philistine or an Israelite.

Here, for the first time, it says that Samson "loves" a woman. But nowhere does it say that Delilah loves him.

The "lords of the Philistines" were the rulers of the five Philistine cities. If each paid 1,100 pieces of silver, that came to 5,500 altogether. A piece of silver was probably a shekel, a little under half an ounce. So 1,100 pieces of silver were about 27 pounds of silver. That was a huge fortune.

Three false answers VERSES 6–14

6 Delilah said to Samson,
"Please tell me where your great strength comes from and what you could be tied up with, so that someone could torment you."
7 Samson said to her,
"If they tie me up with seven green cords that have never been dried,
then I will become weak and be like any other man."
8 So the lords of the Philistines brought her seven green cords
that had not been dried.
And she tied him up with them.
9 She had men lying in wait in the inner room.
She said to him, "The Philistines are on you, Samson!"
Then he broke the cords, as a flax thread breaks when it comes too close to the fire.
So the secret of his strength was not found out.
10 Delilah said to Samson,
"You have made a fool of me and told me lies.
Now please tell me how you could be tied up."
11 He said to her,
"If they just tie me up with new ropes that have never been used for work,
then I will become weak and be like any other man."
12 So Delilah took new ropes and tied him up with them.
Then she said to him, "The Philistines are on you, Samson!"
The men lying in wait were in the inner room.
He snapped the ropes off his arms like a thread.
13 Delilah said to Samson,
"Until now you have made a fool of me and told me lies.
Tell me what you could be tied up with."
He said to her,
"If you weave the seven braids of my head into the cloth on the loom."
14 She fastened it with the pin
and said to him, "The Philistines are on you, Samson!"
He woke up from his sleep
and pulled out the pin of the loom and the cloth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The WEB, our English source text, says "green cords." This probably means fresh, damp cords, for example made from animal gut. When they dry, they become hard.

A loom is a frame for weaving cloth.

Delilah asks quite openly: What can you be tied up with, so that someone can torment you? Each time, Samson notices that she wants to betray him. Still, he stays with her. He is playing with danger.

With each answer he comes closer to his real secret: The third answer is already about his hair.

Verses 13 and 14 are short in the Hebrew text. The old Greek translation tells in a little more detail how Delilah weaves his hair while Samson sleeps. The WEB follows the Hebrew text.

Samson gives away his secret VERSES 15–20

15 She said to him,
"How can you say, 'I love you,'
when your heart is not with me?
You have made a fool of me three times now
and have not told me where your great strength comes from."
16 She pressed him with her words every day and kept urging him.
Then his soul was troubled to death.
17 He opened his whole heart to her and said to her,
"No razor has ever come on my head.
For I have been a Nazirite to God from my mother's womb.
If I am shaved, my strength will leave me.
Then I will become weak and be like any other man."
18 When Delilah saw that he had opened his whole heart to her,
she sent for the lords of the Philistines and said,
"Come up this one more time.
For he has opened his whole heart to me."
Then the lords of the Philistines came up to her
and brought the money in their hands.
19 She made him fall asleep on her knees.
She called for a man and had him shave off the seven braids of his head.
She began to torment him,
and his strength left him.
20 She said, "The Philistines are on you, Samson!"
He woke up from his sleep and said,
"I will go out as at other times and shake myself free."
But he did not know that the LORD had left him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Delilah uses the same trick as the woman from Timnah did then (Chapter 14): If you love me, then tell me. And again Samson gives in.

It is important to know: The strength was not in the hair itself. The hair was the sign that Samson belonged completely to God. Samson had already broken many rules. Now he also gives up the last sign of his Nazirite vow.

Verse 20 is one of the saddest sentences in the Bible: "He did not know that the LORD had left him." Samson had become so used to his strength that he had forgotten where it came from.

Samson in prison VERSES 21–22

21 The Philistines grabbed him and gouged out his eyes.
They brought him down to Gaza and tied him up with chains of bronze.
And he had to grind grain at the mill in the prison.
22 But the hair on his head began to grow again
after it had been shaved.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samson had always done what pleased his eyes. Now he loses his eyes. The strong hero becomes a slave. Grinding grain at a hand mill was work for slaves and women at that time, and often a donkey was used for it. It was a great humiliation.

He is brought to Gaza, the city whose gate he had carried away.

Verse 22 is a small sign of hope: The hair grows back. God is not finished with Samson yet.

The feast for the god Dagon VERSES 23–27

23 The lords of the Philistines gathered together
to offer a great sacrifice to their god Dagon and to celebrate.
For they said,
"Our god has given Samson, our enemy, into our hand."
24 When the people saw him, they praised their god.
For they said,
"Our god has given our enemy into our hand,
the one who destroyed our land and killed many of us."
25 When their hearts were happy, they said,
"Call Samson, so that he can entertain us."
They called Samson out of the prison,
and he had to perform in front of them.
They made him stand between the pillars.
26 Samson said to the boy who was holding him by the hand,
"Let me feel the pillars that hold up the house,
so that I can lean on them."
27 The house was full of men and women.
All the lords of the Philistines were there.
And on the roof there were about 3,000 men and women
who were watching Samson perform.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Dagon was a god who was worshiped in that whole region, probably a god of grain. The Philistines believe: Our god is stronger than the God of Israel. So now it is no longer only about Samson. It is about the question: Who is the true God?

The blind Samson has to entertain the crowd. He is mocked and put on show.

Archaeologists have dug up temples of the Philistines whose roofs rested on two wooden pillars that stood close together. This fits this story.

Samson's death VERSES 28–31

28 Samson called to the LORD and said,
"Lord GOD, please remember me.
Please give me strength just this one more time, O God,
so that I can take revenge on the Philistines with one blow for my two eyes."
29 Samson took hold of the two middle pillars that held up the house
and leaned against them,
one with his right hand and the other with his left.
30 Samson said, "Let me die with the Philistines!"
He pushed with all his strength.
Then the house fell on the lords and on all the people who were in it.
So the dead whom he killed at his death were more than those he had killed in his life.
31 Then his brothers and his father's whole family came down.
They took him, brought him up,
and buried him between Zorah and Eshtaol, in the tomb of his father Manoah.
He had judged Israel for 20 years.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samson prays for the second time in his life. Blind and imprisoned, he asks God for help, and God answers. Even after great failure, a person can come back to God.

But his prayer is not holy and unselfish. He asks for revenge for his eyes. Right to the end, Samson remains a person with great faults.

Samson's death took thousands of people with him, women too. This is a terrible story from a violent time. The Bible tells it as the LORD's victory over the god Dagon. It must never be used as an example for killing yourself and others. Whoever uses violence in God's name today misuses the Bible.

In the New Testament, Samson is counted among the people who had faith (Hebrews 11:32). This does not mean that everything he did was good. It means: God can do something even with weak people who make mistakes, if in the end they trust him.

Samson is the last judge the book tells about. The remaining chapters show how bad things became in Israel without good leadership.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 17

Micah and his idol

The stolen silver VERSES 1–6

1 There was a man from the hill country of Ephraim.
His name was Micah.
2 He said to his mother,
"The 1,100 pieces of silver that were taken from you –
you spoke a curse about it, and you said it so that I heard it too –
look, the silver is with me. I took it."
His mother said, "May the LORD bless my son!"
3 He gave the 1,100 pieces of silver back to his mother.
Then his mother said,

"I truly dedicate the silver to the LORD, from my hand
for my son,
to make a carved image and a cast metal image.
So now I will give it back to you."
4 When he gave the money back to his mother,
his mother took 200 pieces of silver and gave them to a
silversmith.
He made a carved image and a cast metal image out of
it.
It was in Micah's house.
5 The man Micah had a house of gods.
He made an ephod and teraphim
and dedicated one of his sons, who became his priest.
6 In those days there was no king in Israel.
Everyone did what was right in his own eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

With this chapter, the last part of the book begins. It no longer tells about judges, but about how Israel falls apart on the inside.

Micah steals from his own mother. Only when she curses the thief does he become afraid and give the money back. The mother blesses him right away to cancel the curse.

1,100 pieces of silver are about 27 pounds of silver, and 200 pieces of silver are about 5 pounds. A piece of silver was probably a shekel, a little under half an ounce. Interesting: In Chapter 16, Delilah got exactly this much from each of the lords.

The mother wants to dedicate the silver "to the LORD," and then she makes idols out of it. This is exactly what God had forbidden: You shall not make an idol for yourself (Exodus 20:4). She means well, but she does the opposite of God's will. Besides, out of 1,100 pieces of silver, she gives only 200 for it.

An "ephod" here was probably an object used to ask God questions. "Teraphim" were household gods, small figures (see Genesis 31:19).

Micah makes his own son a priest. But only the descendants of Aaron were allowed to be priests.

Verse 6 is the key to the last chapters of the book: Everyone makes his own religion and his own rules. At the end of the book, this sentence comes again.

A Levite becomes Micah's priest VERSES 7–13

7 There was a young man from Bethlehem in Judah,
from the family of Judah.
He was a Levite, and he lived there.
8 The man left the city, Bethlehem in Judah,
to live wherever he could find a place.
On his journey he came to the hill country of
Ephraim, to Micah's house.
9 Micah asked him, "Where do you come from?"
He said to him,
"I am a Levite from Bethlehem in Judah.
I am looking for a place to live."
10 Micah said to him,
"Live with me.
Be a father and a priest to me.
I will give you 10 pieces of silver a year, a set of clothes,
and your food."
So the Levite went in.
11 The Levite was happy to live with the man.
And the young man was like one of his sons to him.
12 Micah dedicated the Levite.
The young man became his priest and lived in Micah's
house.
13 Then Micah said,
"Now I know that the LORD will do good to me,
because I have a Levite as my priest."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Levites had no land of their own. They were to live in the Levite cities and live from the tithes of the people (Joshua 21). That this Levite is wandering around looking for work shows: The people no longer took care of the Levites.

A tithe is a tenth of what someone earns or harvests.

10 pieces of silver a year are about 4 ounces of silver.

Micah thinks: Now I have a "real" priest, so God has to bless me. He thinks that you could buy God's blessing with the right things and the right people. But he has idols in his house. God does not let himself be used like that.

"Father" was a title of honor for a spiritual teacher.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 18

The tribe of Dan looks for new land

The spies at Micah's house VERSES 1–6

1 In those days there was no king in Israel.
In those days the tribe of the Danites was looking for
an inheritance to live in.
For until that day, no inheritance had fallen to them
among the tribes of Israel.
2 The people of Dan sent five men from their family,
from their whole number,
brave men, from Zorah and from Eshtaol,
to spy out the land and explore it.
They said to them, "Go, explore the land!"
They came to the hill country of Ephraim, to Micah's
house, and spent the night there.
3 When they were near Micah's house,
they recognized the voice of the young man, the
Levite.
They went over there and said to him,
"Who brought you here?
What are you doing in this place?
What do you have here?"
4 He said to them,
"Micah has done this and that for me.
He has hired me, and I have become his priest."
5 They said to him,
"Please ask God for advice, so that we may know
whether the journey we are on will be successful."
6 The priest said to them,
"Go in peace.

The journey you are on is in front of the LORD."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The tribe of Dan had actually been given a territory (Joshua 19:40–48). But it could not conquer it. The Amorites forced the Danites back into the hill country (Judges 1:34). That is why the tribe is now looking for land somewhere else.

"No inheritance had fallen to them" means: They had not yet really taken their land.

The spies recognize the voice of the Levite, maybe by his southern accent.

The priest's answer sounds good, but it can mean two things. It can mean: God protects your journey. But it can also simply mean: God sees what you are doing.

The land of Laish VERSES 7–10

7 Then the five men went on and came to Laish.
They saw the people who lived there:
They lived in safety, in the way of the Sidonians, quiet and carefree.
For there was no one in the land with power who could put them to shame in anything.
And they were far away from the Sidonians
and had nothing to do with anyone else.
8 They came back to their brothers at Zorah and Eshtaol.
Their brothers asked them, "What do you say?"
9 They said,
"Come on, let's go up against them.
For we have seen the land, and it is very good.
And you are just sitting still?
Don't be too lazy to go and enter and take the land.
10 When you go, you will come to a people who feel safe.
And the land is large.
For God has given it into your hand.
It is a place where nothing on earth is lacking."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Laish was in the far north, at the foot of Mount Hermon, by the springs of the Jordan. It is green there and has lots of water.

The Sidonians were a people of traders on the coast, in what is Lebanon today. The people of Laish lived peacefully like them. They had no army and no allies.

The spies say: "God has given it into your hand." But God had not said that. Laish was not part of the land that God had given to the Danites. They use God's name for their own plans.

This story reminds us of Moses' spies (Numbers 13). But that was God's command. Here it is only the plan of one tribe.

The Danites steal Micah's idols VERSES 11–20

11 Then 600 men from the family of the Danites set out from there, from Zorah and Eshtaol,
armed with weapons of war.
12 They went up and camped at Kiriath Jearim in Judah.
That is why that place is called Mahaneh Dan to this day.
It is behind Kiriath Jearim.
13 From there they went on to the hill country of Ephraim
and came to Micah's house.
14 Then the five men spoke up
who had gone to spy out the land of Laish.
They said to their brothers,
"Do you know that in these houses there is an ephod, and teraphim,
and a carved image, and a cast metal image?
So now think about what you want to do."
15 They went over there and came to the house of the young Levite, to Micah's house,
and asked him how he was doing.
16 The 600 men of the people of Dan, armed with their weapons of war,
stood at the entrance of the gate.
17 The 5 men who had gone to spy out the land went up.
They went in there and took the carved image, the ephod, the teraphim, and the cast metal image.
And the priest stood at the entrance of the gate with the 600 men armed with weapons of war.
18 When these men went into Micah's house
and took the carved image, the ephod, the teraphim, and the cast metal image,
the priest said to them, "What are you doing?"
19 They said to him,
"Be quiet, put your hand over your mouth, and come with us.
Be a father and a priest to us.
Is it better for you to be priest for the house of one man,
or priest for a tribe and a family in Israel?"
20 Then the priest's heart was glad.
He took the ephod, the teraphim, and the carved image
and went with the people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

600 warriors set out with their families. This was probably only a part of the tribe of Dan.

"Mahaneh Dan" means "camp of Dan." This place was already mentioned in the story of Samson (Judges 13:25).

The Danites steal the idols. Micah had paid for them with stolen silver, and now they themselves are stolen. No one asks: Does God even want such images?

The Levite is not loyal. For a better job, he leaves Micah right away, who had taken him in like a son. He is even "glad." He cares about honor and advantage, not about God.

Micah is left with empty hands VERSES 21–26

21 So they turned and went away.
They put the little children, the livestock, and their belongings in front of them.
22 When they were already a good distance from Micah's house,
the men from the houses near Micah's house gathered together
and caught up with the people of Dan.
23 They called out after the people of Dan.
They turned around and said to Micah,
"What is wrong with you, that you come with such a crowd?"
24 He said,
"You have taken away my gods that I made, and the priest,
and you have gone away!

What do I have left?
How can you ask me, 'What is wrong with you?'"
25 The people of Dan said to him,
"Don't let us hear your voice.
Otherwise angry men will attack you,
and you will lose your life and the lives of your family."
26 The people of Dan went on their way.
When Micah saw that they were too strong for him,
he turned and went back to his house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Micah's complaint is sad and at the same time almost funny: "You have taken away my gods that I made." A god that you have made yourself and that others can simply carry away cannot help. Later the prophets often mocked such gods (for example Isaiah 44:9–20).

Here only the law of the stronger counts. No one protects Micah. There is no king and no judge.

The Danites conquer Laish VERSES 27–31

27 They took what Micah had made, and the priest he had.
They came to Laish, to a people who lived quietly and carefree.
They struck them with the edge of the sword
and burned the city with fire.
28 There was no one to rescue them, because the city was far from Sidon,
and they had nothing to do with anyone else.
It was in the valley near Beth Rehob.
The Danites rebuilt the city and lived in it.
29 They named the city Dan,
after the name of their ancestor Dan, who was born to Israel.
But the city used to be called Laish.
30 The people of Dan set up the carved image for themselves.
And Jonathan, the son of Gershom, the son of Moses,
he and his sons were priests for the tribe of the Danites
until the day the land was taken into captivity.
31 So they set up for themselves the carved image that Micah had made.
It stayed there the whole time that the house of God was in Shiloh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Danites attack a peaceful people without defense, who had done nothing to anyone. The Bible tells this without praise. God had not given them this task. This story shows how deeply Israel had sunk. It is not an example to follow, but a warning.

"Israel" in verse 29 is another name for Jacob. Dan was one of his 12 sons.

The city of Dan later became the northernmost city of Israel. People spoke of the land from Dan to Beersheba and meant the whole land from north to south. Later King Jeroboam set up a golden calf there (1 Kings 12:29). Dan remained a place of false worship.

Now we learn the Levite's name: Jonathan, a grandson of Moses. It is shocking: Even the grandson of the great Moses serves idols.

In the Hebrew text, a small letter "n" is written above the line here. This turns the name "Moses" into "Manasseh." Jewish Bible teachers have said: This was done to protect the honor of Moses. The WEB, our English source text, has "Moses."

"The captivity of the land" probably means the time when the Assyrians conquered the north of Israel and took people away (2 Kings 15:29; 17:6).

Shiloh was the place where God's tent stood, the proper place of worship (Joshua 18:1). So the Danites had their own worship, separate from the house of God.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 19

The crime in Gibeah

A Levite brings back his concubine VERSES 1–3

1 In those days, when there was no king in Israel,
a Levite lived at the far end of the hill country of Ephraim.
He took a concubine for himself from Bethlehem in Judah.
2 His concubine was unfaithful to him like a prostitute
and went away from him to her father's house in Bethlehem in Judah.
She was there for four months.
3 Her husband got up and went after her,
to speak kindly to her and bring her back.
He had his servant with him and two donkeys.
She brought him into her father's house.
When the young woman's father saw him, he was glad to meet him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now the darkest story in the whole book of Judges begins. It tells of terrible violence against a woman and of a civil war in Israel. It is hard to read. The Bible does not tell it so that people will copy it, but so that people see how deeply human beings can fall when they forget God.

A "concubine" was a woman who was married to a man but had fewer rights than a main wife.

Verse 2: This is what the WEB, our English source text, and the Hebrew text say. But the old Greek translation says instead: She became angry with him. Many Bible teachers think this fits better: A woman who had broken her marriage would hardly have gone to her father. She probably left her husband after a quarrel.

The man wants to "speak kindly to her," literally "speak to her heart." At first, this sounds good.

The father-in-law keeps him there VERSES 4–10

4 His father-in-law, the young woman's father, kept him there.
He stayed with him for three days.
They ate and drank and spent the nights there.
5 On the fourth day they got up early in the morning,
and he got ready to leave.

The young woman's father said to his son-in-law,
"Strengthen your heart with a bite of bread.
After that you can go."
6 So the two of them sat down and ate and drank together.
Then the young woman's father said to the man,
"Please be willing to stay overnight. Let your heart be happy."
7 The man got up to leave.
But his father-in-law urged him, and so he stayed there again that night.
8 On the fifth day he got up early in the morning to leave.
The young woman's father said,
"Please strengthen your heart and stay until the afternoon."
And the two of them ate.
9 When the man got up to leave, with his concubine and his servant,
his father-in-law, the young woman's father, said to him,
"Look, it is already getting toward evening. Please stay overnight.
The day is coming to an end.
Stay here so that your heart may be happy.
Tomorrow you can start out early and go home."
10 But the man did not want to stay that night.
He got up and left and came near Jebus, that is, Jerusalem.
He had two saddled donkeys with him.
His concubine was with him too.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hospitality was very important at that time. The father serves his son-in-law meals day after day. Maybe he also wants to delay his daughter's leaving.

Something stands out: The men eat and drink and talk with each other. The woman is not asked. No one talks with her.

Because the man leaves too late, they have to spend the night on the way. This will have terrible results.

Jebus was the old name of Jerusalem. At that time, the Jebusites still lived there. Only King David conquered the city (2 Samuel 5).

The night in Gibeah VERSES 11–21

11 When they were near Jebus, the day was almost over.
The servant said to his master,
"Please come, let's go into this city of the Jebusites and spend the night there."
12 His master said to him,
"We will not go into the city of foreigners who are not people of Israel.
We will go on to Gibeah."
13 He said to his servant,
"Come, let's go to one of these places.
We will spend the night in Gibeah or in Ramah."
14 So they went on their way.
The sun went down as they were near Gibeah, which belongs to Benjamin.
15 They turned off there to spend the night in Gibeah.
He went in and sat down in the town square.
For no one took them into his house for the night.
16 Then an old man came in the evening from his work in the field.
The man was from the hill country of Ephraim and he lived in Gibeah.
But the men of the place were Benjamites.
17 He looked up and saw the traveler in the town square.
The old man said, "Where are you going? Where do you come from?"
18 He said to him,
"We are on our way from Bethlehem in Judah to the far end of the hill country of Ephraim.
I am from there, and I went to Bethlehem in Judah.
I am going to the house of the LORD.
But no one has taken me into his house.
19 And yet we have straw and feed for our donkeys.
And we also have bread and wine for me, for your servant woman,
and for the young man who is with your servants.
We have everything we need."
20 The old man said,
"Peace be with you!
Just let me take care of everything you need.
But don't spend the night in the square."
21 So he brought him into his house and gave the donkeys feed.
They washed their feet, ate, and drank.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Levite does not want to spend the night with foreigners. He thinks: We will be safe with our own people in Israel. But it turns out exactly the opposite.

Gibeah was a city of the tribe of Benjamin, about 3 miles north of Jerusalem. Later it was the home town of King Saul.

In the whole city, no one takes in the travelers. Only an old man, who is a foreigner himself, helps them. At that time, this was a great disgrace for a city.

"I am going to the house of the LORD": This is what the Hebrew text says. The old Greek translation has: "I am going to my house."

With "your servant woman" the Levite politely means his own concubine.

The men of the city VERSES 22–26

22 While they were enjoying themselves,
the men of the city, some wicked men, surrounded the house.
They pounded on the door
and said to the owner of the house, the old man,
"Bring out the man who came into your house.
We want to have sex with him!"
23 The man, the owner of the house, went out to them and said to them,
"No, my brothers, please don't do something so evil.
This man has come into my house.
Don't do this shameful thing.
24 Look, here is my daughter, who is a virgin, and his concubine.
I will bring them out now.
Humble them and do with them whatever you like.
But don't do such a shameful thing to this man."
25 But the men would not listen to him.
So the man grabbed his concubine and brought her

out to them.
They had sex with her and abused her all night until the morning.
When the dawn came, they let her go.
26 Then, as the morning was dawning, the woman came and fell down at the door of the house where her master was.
She lay there until it was light.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A horrible crime happens here. The men want to rape the guest. This is not a story about love or sexuality. It is about violence, humiliation, and power over a stranger.

This scene is told almost exactly like the story of Sodom (Genesis 19). This is on purpose. In this way the Bible is saying: Israel has become as bad as Sodom.

But here no angel comes to rescue them. The old man offers his own daughter and the concubine. And the Levite pushes his own wife outside to save himself. "Humble them" here means: rape them.

All night long, the woman is raped and abused. In the morning she drags herself to the door with the last of her strength. No one opens it for her.

The Bible does not praise a single man here. What the men of Gibeah, the old man, and the Levite do is a grave wrong. This woman has no name. But God has seen her suffering. The Bible has written it down so that it will not be forgotten.

Today many Christians and Jews read this story as a call: Violence against women must never be kept silent or accepted.

The 12 pieces VERSES 27–30

27 Her master got up in the morning,
opened the door of the house, and went out to go on his way.
And there was the woman, his concubine, lying at the door of the house,
with her hands on the doorstep.
28 He said to her,
"Get up, let's go!"
But there was no answer.
Then he put her on the donkey.
And the man got up and went to his home.
29 When he had come into his house,
he took a knife and cut up his concubine.
He divided her, limb by limb, into 12 pieces
and sent them throughout the whole territory of Israel.
30 And everyone who saw it said,
"Such a thing has not been done or seen
since the day the people of Israel came up out of the land of Egypt
until this day!
Think about it, talk it over, and speak!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the morning, the Levite goes out "to go on his way." He is not looking for his wife. He finds her by chance. His words are cold: "Get up, let's go!" Not a word of pity.

"There was no answer": The text does not say exactly whether she was already dead then. The old Greek translation says clearly: "for she was dead."

Then the man cuts her body into 12 pieces, for the 12 tribes of Israel. In this way he wants to shake up all of Israel. This is a cruel deed. Even after her death, the woman is still used as a tool.

Later King Saul, who comes from Gibeah, cuts up two oxen and sends the pieces throughout Israel to call the people to battle (1 Samuel 11:7).

All of Israel is horrified. And rightly so. But the way the people react now makes everything even worse.

JUDGES

CHAPTER 20

The war against Benjamin

Israel gathers at Mizpah VERSES 1–7

1 Then all the people of Israel went out.
The congregation gathered together as one man,
from Dan to Beersheba, with the land of Gilead,
to the LORD at Mizpah.
2 The leaders of all the people, of all the tribes of Israel,
took their places in the assembly of the people of God:
400,000 foot soldiers who fought with the sword.
3 (The people of Benjamin heard that the people of Israel had gone up to Mizpah.)
The people of Israel said,
"Tell us, how did this evil thing happen?"
4 The Levite, the husband of the woman who had been murdered, answered,
"I came to Gibeah, which belongs to Benjamin, I and my concubine,
to spend the night there.
5 The men of Gibeah rose up against me
and surrounded the house at night.
They intended to kill me.
And they raped my concubine, and she is dead.
6 So I took my concubine, cut her into pieces,
and sent her throughout the whole land of Israel's inheritance.
For they have done a shameful and foolish thing in Israel.
7 Now, you people of Israel, all of you:
Give your advice and your opinion here."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"From Dan to Beersheba" means: from the whole land, from the far north to the far south. For the first time in the book of Judges, all of Israel acts together. But not against a foreign enemy, but against one of its own tribes.

Mizpah was in the territory of Benjamin, north of Jerusalem.

400,000 men is a very large number. Some Bible teachers think that the Hebrew word for "thousand" could also mean "troop" or "unit" here. Then there would have been far fewer men.

The Levite tells the story in a way that makes him look good. He does not say that he himself pushed his wife outside. He says: "They intended to kill me," but in Chapter 19 the men wanted to rape him. He keeps quiet about his own guilt.

The Benjamites do not hand over the criminals
VERSES 8–17

8 All the people stood up as one man and said,
"None of us will go to his tent,
and none of us will go back to his house.
9 But this is what we will do to Gibeah now:
We will go up against it as the lot decides.
10 From all the tribes of Israel we will take 10 men out of 100,
100 out of 1,000, and 1,000 out of 10,000,
to get food for the people.
Then, when they come to Gibeah in Benjamin,
they will do what is right for all the shameful things
the men of Gibeah have done in Israel."
11 So all the men of Israel gathered against the city,
joined together as one man.
12 The tribes of Israel sent men through the whole tribe of Benjamin, saying,
"What is this evil thing that has happened among you?
13 Now hand over the men, the wicked men who are in Gibeah.
Then we will put them to death and remove the evil from Israel."
But the people of Benjamin would not listen to the voice of their brothers, the people of Israel.
14 The people of Benjamin gathered from the cities to Gibeah,
to go out to battle against the people of Israel.
15 On that day the people of Benjamin were counted:
from the cities, 26,000 men who fought with the sword,
besides the people of Gibeah. Of them, 700 chosen men were counted.
16 Among all these soldiers there were 700 chosen men who were left-handed.
Each one of them could sling a stone at a hair and not miss.
17 The men of Israel, not counting Benjamin, were counted:
400,000 men who fought with the sword.
All of them were men of war.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At first Israel acts rightly: It only demands that the criminals be handed over. Only the guilty are to be punished, not a whole tribe.

But Benjamin refuses. The tribe sides with the criminals only because they belong to their own family. In this way, the whole tribe shares in the guilt. This is a warning: Whoever covers for criminals because they are "our people" becomes guilty too.

The left-handed men remind us of Ehud, the judge from the tribe of Benjamin, who was also left-handed (Chapter 3). The sling was a dangerous weapon. Well-trained slingers could hit things very exactly.

In verse 15, some old manuscripts of the Greek translation have 25,000 instead of 26,000.

Two defeats for Israel VERSES 18–28

18 The people of Israel got up, went up to Bethel, and asked God for advice.
They asked,
"Which of us shall go up first to battle against the people of Benjamin?"
The LORD said, "Judah first."
19 The people of Israel got up in the morning and camped across from Gibeah.
20 The men of Israel went out to battle against Benjamin.
The men of Israel lined up for battle against them at Gibeah.
21 The people of Benjamin came out of Gibeah
and on that day struck down 22,000 men of Israel.
22 The people, the men of Israel, took courage
and lined up for battle again in the same place where they had lined up on the first day.
23 The people of Israel went up and wept in front of the LORD until evening.
They asked the LORD,
"Shall I go into battle again against my brother Benjamin?"
The LORD said, "Go up against him."
24 On the second day the people of Israel came near to the people of Benjamin.
25 On the second day Benjamin went out against them from Gibeah
and struck down another 18,000 men of the people of Israel.
All of them fought with the sword.
26 Then all the people of Israel and all the people went up and came to Bethel.
They wept and sat there in front of the LORD.
They fasted that day until evening.
Then they offered burnt offerings and peace offerings in front of the LORD.
27 The people of Israel asked the LORD
– for the ark of the covenant of God was there in those days,
28 and Phinehas, the son of Eleazar, the son of Aaron, served before it in those days –
and they asked,
"Shall I go out again to battle against my brother Benjamin,
or shall I stop?"
The LORD said,
"Go up. For tomorrow I will give him into your hand."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The question in verse 18 reminds us of the beginning of the book. There, Israel asked: Who should fight first against the Canaanites? And God said: Judah (Judges 1:1–2). Now Judah does not fight against foreign enemies, but against its brother tribe. The book ends where it began, but everything is turned upside down.

Israel first asks God who should fight first, not whether they should fight at all. They have already made up their minds.

Twice Israel loses, even though God says: Go up. This is hard to understand. Many Bible teachers think: In this way God was also making Israel humble. Only the third time do they weep, fast, and offer sacrifices. Only now do they ask: Or shall I stop? And only now does God promise victory.

At that time, the ark of the covenant was in Bethel. Phinehas, Aaron's grandson, was priest. He was already alive in the time of Moses (Numbers 25). This shows: This story takes place at the beginning of the time of the judges, not at the end, even though it is told last in the book.

Losses in verses 21 and 25: 22,000 and 18,000 men, together 40,000.

The ambush VERSES 29–36

29 Israel set men in ambush all around Gibeah.
30 On the third day the people of Israel went up against the people of Benjamin
and lined up against Gibeah as at the other times.
31 The people of Benjamin went out against the people and were drawn away from the city.
They began to strike down and kill some of the people as at the other times,
on the highways, one of which goes up to Bethel and the other to Gibeah,
in the open field, about 30 men of Israel.
32 The people of Benjamin said,
"They are being struck down in front of us, as at the first."
But the people of Israel said,
"Let's run away and draw them away from the city onto the highways."
33 All the men of Israel got up from their place
and lined up at Baal Tamar.
And the men of Israel who were lying in ambush broke out of their hiding place,
out of Maareh Geba.
34 10,000 chosen men from all Israel came against Gibeah.
The battle was hard.
But the Benjamites did not know that disaster was close to them.
35 The LORD struck Benjamin in front of Israel.
And on that day the people of Israel killed 25,100 men of Benjamin.
All of them fought with the sword.
36 So the people of Benjamin saw that they were beaten.
For the men of Israel had given ground to Benjamin, because they were relying on the men in ambush whom they had set against Gibeah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Israel uses the same trick that Joshua used at the city of Ai (Joshua 8): Part of the army pretends to run away. The defenders chase it and leave their city without protection. Then the men from the hiding place attack the city.

Verse 35 sums up the end of the battle ahead of time. From verse 36 on, it is told in more detail how it came to that.

"The LORD struck Benjamin": The Bible says that here God is judging a tribe that covered up a serious crime.

Gibeah burns VERSES 37–48

37 The men in ambush hurried and rushed at Gibeah.
The men in ambush spread out
and struck the whole city with the edge of the sword.
38 The men of Israel and the men in ambush had agreed on a sign:
They were to make a great cloud of smoke rise up out of the city.
39 The men of Israel turned around in the battle.
And Benjamin began to strike down and kill about 30 of the men of Israel.
For they said,
"They are surely being struck down in front of us, as in the first battle."
40 But when the cloud began to rise out of the city like a pillar of smoke,
the Benjamites looked behind them.
And the whole city was going up in smoke to the sky.
41 The men of Israel turned around,
and the men of Benjamin were terrified.
For they saw that disaster had come on them.
42 So they turned their backs to the men of Israel
and fled toward the wilderness.
But the battle stayed close behind them.
And those who came out of the cities killed them in the middle of it.
43 They surrounded the Benjamites, chased them,
and trampled them down at their resting place,
as far as near Gibeah, toward the east.
44 18,000 men of Benjamin fell.
All of them were brave men.
45 They turned and fled toward the wilderness, to the rock of Rimmon.
On the highways the Israelites gleaned 5,000 men from them.
They chased them as far as Gidom and killed 2,000 more men of them.
46 So all of Benjamin who fell that day were 25,000 men who fought with the sword.
All of them were brave men.
47 But 600 men turned and fled toward the wilderness, to the rock of Rimmon.
They stayed at the rock of Rimmon for 4 months.
48 The men of Israel turned against the people of Benjamin again
and struck them with the edge of the sword,
the whole city, the livestock, and everything they found.
They also set on fire all the cities they found.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"To glean" is a picture from the harvest: You gather up what is still left. Here it is a cruel picture for killing those who were running away.

The numbers: 18,000 + 5,000 + 2,000 = 25,000. Verse 35 is more exact: 25,100. Verse 46 gives a round number.

According to verse 15, Benjamin had 26,700 men. If 25,100 fall and 600 survive, about 1,000 are still missing. Maybe they had already fallen in the first two battles. The Bible does not say.

What happens in verse 48 is horrible: Israel kills not only the soldiers, but also women, children, and animals in the cities of Benjamin. A just punishment for a crime turns into revenge without limits. A whole tribe is almost wiped out.

The Bible does not tell this as an example to follow. In these chapters, the book of Judges shows step by step: This is where it leads when everyone does what is right in his own eyes. No one may use this story to justify violence against a whole group.

JUDGES

Chapter 21

Wives for Benjamin

A tribe is about to disappear VERSES 1–7

1 The men of Israel had sworn at Mizpah,
"None of us will give his daughter as a wife to a Benjamite."
2 The people came to Bethel and sat there in front of God until evening.
They cried out loud and wept bitterly.
3 They said,
"LORD, God of Israel, why has this happened in Israel, that today one tribe is missing in Israel?"
4 The next day the people got up early and built an altar there.
They offered burnt offerings and peace offerings.
5 The people of Israel said,
"Who from all the tribes of Israel did not come up to the assembly to the LORD?"
For they had sworn a great oath about anyone who did not come up to the LORD at Mizpah:
"He shall surely be put to death."
6 The people of Israel felt sorry for their brother Benjamin.
They said,
"Today one tribe has been cut off from Israel.
7 How can we find wives for those who are left?
For we have sworn by the LORD
that we will not give them any of our daughters as wives."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only now does Israel realize what it has done. Only 600 men of Benjamin are left, and no women anymore. One of the 12 tribes is going to die out.

The people weep and ask God: Why has this happened? But Israel did it itself. The question sounds as if God were to blame.

Israel has sworn two thoughtless oaths: No one will give his daughter to Benjamin. And: Whoever does not come to the assembly must die. Now they are caught in the trap of their own oaths. This reminds us of Jephthah and his terrible vow (Chapter 11).

Jabesh in Gilead VERSES 8–14

8 They said,
"Which of the tribes of Israel did not come up to the LORD at Mizpah?"
And it turned out that no one from Jabesh Gilead had come to the camp, to the assembly.
9 For when the people were counted,
none of the people of Jabesh Gilead were there.
10 The congregation sent 12,000 of the bravest men there.
It commanded them,
"Go and strike the people of Jabesh Gilead with the edge of the sword,
including the women and the little children.
11 This is what you shall do:
You shall completely destroy every male
and every woman who has slept with a man."
12 Among the people of Jabesh Gilead they found 400 young women,
virgins who had never slept with a man.
They brought them to the camp at Shiloh, which is in the land of Canaan.
13 The whole congregation sent messengers
and spoke to the people of Benjamin who were at the rock of Rimmon,
and offered them peace.
14 So Benjamin came back at that time.
And they gave them the women whom they had kept alive from the women of Jabesh Gilead.
But there still were not enough for them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is another horrifying chapter. To solve the problem with Benjamin, Israel destroys yet another city. Men, women, and children are killed. Only 400 young girls are left alive, and they are taken away against their will and given to the Benjamites.

The Bible does not praise this. It shows: One wrong leads to the next. To punish a crime against one woman, hundreds of women are now killed or carried off.

Jabesh was east of the Jordan, in the land of Gilead. Later this city is remembered again: King Saul from the tribe of Benjamin rescues Jabesh from the people of Ammon (1 Samuel 11). Maybe there was an old connection between Jabesh and Benjamin.

600 men, but only 400 women: 200 are still missing.

The kidnapping of the girls of Shiloh VERSES 15–24

15 The people felt sorry for Benjamin,
because the LORD had made a gap in the tribes of Israel.
16 Then the elders of the congregation said,
"How can we find wives for those who are left?
For the women of Benjamin have been destroyed."
17 They said,
"There must be an inheritance for those of Benjamin who have escaped,
so that a tribe is not wiped out from Israel.
18 But we cannot give them any of our daughters as wives.
For the people of Israel have sworn,
'Cursed is anyone who gives a wife to Benjamin.'"
19 They said,
"Look, every year there is a feast of the LORD in Shiloh.
Shiloh is north of Bethel,
east of the highway that goes up from Bethel to Shechem,
and south of Lebonah."
20 They commanded the people of Benjamin,
"Go and lie in wait in the vineyards.

21 Watch carefully:
When the daughters of Shiloh come out to dance in the dances,
then come out of the vineyards.
Each of you catch a wife for himself from the daughters of Shiloh.
Then go to the land of Benjamin.
22 When their fathers or their brothers come to complain to us,
we will say to them,
'Be kind and let them have them.
For we did not take a wife for each man in battle.
And you did not give them to them either.
Otherwise you would now be guilty.'"
23 The people of Benjamin did so.
They took wives for themselves, as many as there were men,
from the girls who were dancing, whom they carried off.
Then they went away and returned to their inheritance.
They rebuilt the cities and lived in them.
24 At that time the people of Israel left that place,
each man to his tribe and his family.
Each one went from there to his own inheritance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The elders find a trick: They do not give their daughters, but they allow them to be kidnapped. In this way they do not break their oath, at least not by the letter of it.

For the young women it is a crime: They are dancing at a feast in honor of God and are taken by force and married. No one asks them.

Verse 22: The elders want to tell the fathers: You did not give your daughters yourselves, so you have not broken the oath.

Here you can see how far Israel has gone: People keep exactly to the words of an oath and at the same time hurt the dignity of human beings. This is the opposite of what God wants.

"The LORD had made a gap": This is how the people explain the downfall of Benjamin. But the chapters show clearly that people caused this gap.

In the end, the tribe of Benjamin survives. Later the first king of Israel, Saul, comes from it. And much later the apostle Paul, who says that he too is an Israelite, a descendant of Abraham, from the tribe of Benjamin (Romans 11:1). God can let something new grow again even out of great guilt.

The last sentence VERSE 25

25 In those days there was no king in Israel.
Everyone did what was right in his own eyes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Judges ends with this sentence. It is like a heading over everything that was told in the last chapters: idols, robbery, rape, murder, and civil war.

"No king" means: There was no order, no justice, no one who made sure that things were fair. But in a deeper sense it also means: No one asked about God anymore, the true King of Israel.

The book makes us curious about what comes next. The books of Samuel tell how Israel gets a king. But before that comes a small, very different story from the same time: the book of Ruth.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Judges?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Judges tells about the time between Joshua and the kings. Israel lives in the land, but it forgets God again and again.

The book has three parts:

1. The beginning (Judges 1:1–3:6): The tribes do not conquer the land completely. The peoples who stay lead Israel to their gods.

2. The judges (Judges 3:7–16:31): Again and again the same pattern: Israel does evil, is oppressed, cries out to God, and God sends a rescuer. We have met Othniel, Ehud, Shamgar, Deborah and Barak, Gideon, Jephthah, Samson, and some minor judges. At the beginning, the judges are still good examples, like Othniel and Deborah. Later they themselves become more and more questionable: Gideon makes an ephod that becomes a trap, Jephthah sacrifices his daughter, Samson lives by his own wishes.

3. The chaos (Chapters 17–21): Without a judge and without a king, the people fall apart. There are idols, robbery, a terrible crime in Gibeah, and a war in which Israel almost wipes out one of its own tribes.

The book of Judges is one of the darkest books in the Bible. It tells of a lot of violence, especially against women: Jephthah's daughter, the woman from Timnah, the concubine in Gibeah, the women of Jabesh and Shiloh. The Bible does not hide anything. It does not tell these stories as examples to follow, but as a mirror and a warning. No one may ever use these texts to justify violence or hatred.

And yet there is light: God does not give up on his people. Again and again he listens when they cry out to him. He uses weak people who make mistakes to rescue. And there are brave women like Deborah, Jael, and the woman from Thebez who threw a millstone.

The big question of the book is: Who leads Israel? The answer that the book hints at in the end is: Israel needs a good king who obeys God. Jews and Christians believe: In the end it is God himself who can truly lead his people. Christians see in Jesus this king, who comes from the tribe of Judah and from Bethlehem.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 8 OF 66

RUTH

4 CHAPTERS

RUTH

Chapter 1

Where you go, I will go

Before we begin: What is the book of Ruth?

The book of Ruth is a short story with only four chapters. It takes place at the same time as the book of Judges.

But it is very different. In the book of Judges we read a lot of violence and chaos. The book of Ruth, on the other hand, tells about ordinary people who are faithful and kind to each other.

The main characters are two women: Naomi, an Israelite woman who has lost everything, and Ruth, her daughter-in-law. Ruth is a foreigner from the people of Moab. And yet she becomes an example of faithfulness for all Israel.

An important word in the book is the Hebrew word "chesed." It means: kindness, faithfulness, love that does more than it has to. Ruth, Boaz, and in the end God himself show this kindness.

God does no great miracles in this book. He does not speak from heaven. But he works quietly in the background, through everyday things and through good people.

At the end, we learn a surprise: Ruth, the foreigner, becomes the great-grandmother of King David. Christians remember that Ruth is also named in the family tree of Jesus (Matthew 1:5).

In Judaism, the book of Ruth is read every year at the Feast of Weeks (Shavuot). That is the feast of the harvest, and the story also takes place at that time of year.

A family loses everything VERSES 1–5

1 In the days when the judges judged, there was a famine
in the land.
A famine is a time when there is not enough food.
A man from Bethlehem in Judah went away
to live in the country of Moab,
he, his wife, and his two sons.
2 The name of the man was Elimelech,
and the name of his wife was Naomi.
The names of his two sons were Mahlon and Chilion.
They were Ephrathites from Bethlehem in Judah.
They came into the country of Moab and stayed there.
3 Elimelech, Naomi's husband, died.
And she was left with her two sons.
4 The sons married women from Moab.
The name of one was Orpah,
and the name of the other was Ruth.
They lived there about 10 years.
5 Then Mahlon and Chilion both died too.
And the woman was left alone, without her two
children and without her husband.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Hebrew, Bethlehem means "house of bread." Of all places, there is no more bread there. That is why the family moves away.

Moab lay east of the Dead Sea, in what is now Jordan. The Moabites were Israel's neighbors, but often also its enemies. The law even says that Moabites should not come into the assembly of the LORD (Deuteronomy 23:3; in some Bibles 23:4). That is why it is especially remarkable that the heroine of this book is a woman from Moab.

"Ephrathites": Ephrathah was an old name for the area around Bethlehem.

The names have a meaning: Elimelech means "My God is king." Naomi means "pleasant" or "my joy."

At that time, it was very hard for a woman to be without a husband and without sons. There was no pension and no insurance. Widows without family were often very poor and without protection. Naomi has lost not only her loved ones but also all her security.

Naomi sends her daughters-in-law back VERSES 6–14

6 Then she got up with her daughters-in-law
to return from the country of Moab.
For she had heard in the country of Moab
that the LORD had visited his people and given them
bread.
7 She left the place where she had been,
and her two daughters-in-law went with her.
They set out on the road to return to the land of Judah.
8 Naomi said to her two daughters-in-law,
"Go, each of you, go back to your mother's house.
May the LORD be kind to you,
as you have been kind to the dead and to me.
9 May the LORD let you find rest,
each of you in the house of her husband."
Then she kissed them.
And they cried out loud and wept.
10 They said to her,
"No, we will go back with you to your people."
11 Naomi said,
"Go back, my daughters.
Why do you want to go with me?
Do I still have sons in my womb who could become
your husbands?
12 Go back, my daughters, go your way.
For I am too old to have a husband.
Even if I said, 'I have hope,'
even if I had a husband tonight and also had sons,
13 would you then wait until they were grown up?
Would you stay without husbands because of that?
No, my daughters.
I am very sad for your sakes,
for the hand of the LORD has turned against me."
14 They cried out loud and wept again.
Then Orpah kissed her mother-in-law goodbye.
But Ruth stayed with her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The LORD had visited his people" means: God had taken care of his people again. The famine is over.

Here the important word "kindness" (Hebrew "chesed") appears for the first time. Naomi says: You have been good to

my sons and to me. May God be good to you too.

Naomi thinks of her daughters-in-law, not of herself. She knows: In Israel, the young women from Moab will be foreigners. There they have little hope of finding a husband again. In Moab they have a family and a future.

"Finding rest in the house of a husband" means: having safety and a home.

Orpah goes back. The Bible does not blame her for it. She does what is sensible. But Ruth does more than anyone could expect of her.

Ruth's promise VERSES 15–18

15 Naomi said,
"Look, your sister-in-law has gone back to her people
and to her god.
Follow your sister-in-law."
16 Ruth said,
"Don't push me to leave you and to turn back from
following you.
For where you go, I will go.
And where you stay, I will stay.
Your people will be my people, and your God will be my
God.
17 Where you die, I will die,
and there I will be buried.
May the LORD do this to me, and even more,
if anything but death separates you and me."
18 When Naomi saw that Ruth was determined to go with
her,
she stopped trying to talk her out of it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These words of Ruth are among the best-known sentences in the Bible. Many couples today choose them as their wedding verse. But here, a young woman is really speaking to her mother-in-law. It is a promise of faithfulness between two women, across the borders of people, age, and background.

Ruth chooses not only Naomi but also Naomi's people and Naomi's God. She even swears by the name of the LORD, the God of Israel. That is why, in Judaism, Ruth is an example for all people who become Jewish.

"May the LORD do this to me, and even more" is an old form of oath. It means: May God punish me hard if I break this promise.

Ruth leaves her homeland, her family, and everything she knows. Just like Abraham long before (Genesis 12:1). And she does it without a promise from God, only out of love and faithfulness.

"Don't call me Naomi" VERSES 19–22

19 So the two of them walked on until they came to
Bethlehem.
When they came to Bethlehem, the whole town was
excited about them.
And they asked, "Is this Naomi?"
20 She said to them,
"Don't call me Naomi.
Call me Mara.
For the Almighty has made my life very bitter.
21 I went away full,
and the LORD has brought me home again empty.
Why do you call me Naomi,
since the LORD has spoken against me
and the Almighty has brought trouble on me?"
22 So Naomi came back,
and Ruth the Moabite woman, her daughter-in-law,
with her,
who came back from the country of Moab.
They came to Bethlehem at the beginning of the barley
harvest.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In verse 19, the WEB, our English source text, only says "they asked." In Hebrew it is clearly a form for women: The women of the town ask.

"Naomi" means "pleasant," "Mara" means "bitter." Naomi says: My name no longer fits my life.

Naomi accuses God quite openly. The Bible allows this. Whoever suffers may tell God about their pain and their anger. People speak to God like this in the Psalms and in the book of Job too.

"Empty" I have come back, says Naomi. But that is not quite true: Ruth is standing next to her. Naomi does not see it yet, but in Ruth she has already received a gift.

"The Almighty" is "Shaddai" in Hebrew. That is an old name for God.

The barley harvest was in spring, around April. The chapter ends with a small sign of hope: There is bread in Bethlehem again.

RUTH

CHAPTER 2

Ruth gathers grain in the field of Boaz

Ruth goes to the field VERSES 1–3

1 Naomi had a relative of her husband's,
a very respected and rich man from the family of
Elimelech.
His name was Boaz.
2 Ruth the Moabite woman said to Naomi,
"Please let me go to the field and glean grain
behind anyone who is kind to me."
To glean means: to pick up the grain that the harvest
workers leave behind.
Naomi said to her, "Go, my daughter."
3 She went and gleaned in the field behind the harvest
workers.
And it happened that she came to the part of the field
that belonged to Boaz,
who was from the family of Elimelech.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Right at the beginning, we learn what Ruth does not know yet: There is a rich relative. That makes the story exciting.

"Gleaning grain": In God's law there was a rule to protect the poor. At harvest time, people were not to harvest everything down to the last stalk. Whatever was left lying could be picked up by the poor, foreigners, widows, and orphans (Leviticus 19:9–10; Deuteronomy 24:19). Ruth is all of these at once: poor, a foreigner, and a widow.

"It happened," says the text, as if it were chance. But the reader notices: God is leading in secret. This is how God works in the whole book of Ruth: quietly, through what seems like chance.

Boaz notices Ruth VERSES 4–7

4 Look! Boaz came from Bethlehem
and said to the harvest workers, "May the LORD be with you."
They answered him, "May the LORD bless you."
5 Then Boaz said to his servant who was in charge of the harvest workers,
"Who does this young woman belong to?"
6 The servant who was in charge of the harvest workers answered,
"She is the young Moabite woman who came back with Naomi from the country of Moab.
7 She said,
'Please let me glean and gather among the bundles behind the harvest workers.'
So she came and has kept working from the morning until now.
She only rested a little in the house."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Boaz greets his workers with the name of God, and they bless him back. This shows: Boaz is a man of faith and a friendly employer. He and his workers get along well.

The man in charge praises Ruth: She works hard and keeps going all day. But he does not call her by name, only "the Moabite woman." For the people, she is first of all a foreigner.

"Came back with Naomi": Ruth had really never been in Bethlehem before. But she belongs to Naomi now.

Boaz is kind to Ruth VERSES 8–13

8 Then Boaz said to Ruth,
"Listen, my daughter.
Don't go to glean in another field.
Don't go away from here, but stay here close to my young women.
9 Keep your eyes on the field they are harvesting, and follow them.
Haven't I commanded the young men not to touch you?
When you are thirsty, go to the jars
and drink from the water the young men have drawn."
10 Then she fell on her face and bowed down to the ground.
She said to him,
"Why are you so kind to me
that you notice me, even though I am a foreigner?"
11 Boaz answered her,
"I have been told everything
you have done for your mother-in-law since the death of your husband.
And how you left your father, your mother, and the land where you were born,
and came to a people you did not know before.
12 May the LORD repay you for what you have done.
May you receive a full reward from the LORD, the God of Israel,
under whose wings you have come to take refuge."
13 Then she said,
"May you be kind to me, my lord.
For you have comforted me
and spoken kindly to your servant,
even though I am not even like one of your servants."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Boaz protects Ruth. A young foreign woman alone in the field was in danger of being harassed. Boaz makes sure that no one harms her. After the terrible stories at the end of the book of Judges, this is like fresh air: Here is a man who protects a woman.

Normally, foreigners and women drew water for the Israelites and the men. Here it is the other way around: The young men have drawn the water, and Ruth may drink from it.

Ruth is surprised: Why is he so kind to a foreigner? Boaz answers: Because of your faithfulness to Naomi. Word of Ruth's kindness has gotten around.

"Taking refuge under God's wings" is a beautiful picture: like a chick that runs under its mother's wings. This picture appears in the Psalms too (Psalm 91:4). It becomes important again in Chapter 3.

The meal with the harvest workers VERSES 14–17

14 At mealtime Boaz said to her,
"Come here and eat some bread,
and dip your piece in the vinegar."
She sat down beside the harvest workers,
and they passed her roasted grain.
She ate until she was full, and she had some left over.
15 When she got up to glean again,
Boaz commanded his young men,
"Let her glean even among the bundles,
and don't shame her.
16 Also pull out some stalks from the bundles for her on purpose
and leave them for her.
Let her glean them, and don't scold her."
17 So she gleaned in the field until evening.
Then she beat out the grain she had gleaned.
It was about 6 gallons of barley.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Vinegar" was a sour drink made from wine, mixed with water. People dipped their bread into it. It was refreshing when working in the heat.

In verse 14, the Hebrew says more exactly: "he passed her." So Boaz handed her the grain himself.

Boaz invites the foreigner to his table. She eats with the workers as if she belonged. She receives so much that she has some left over. Later she brings it to Naomi.

Boaz does more than the law requires. The law says: Leave what is left lying. Boaz says: Drop something for her on purpose. And in such a way that she does not have to feel ashamed. That is real kindness: helping without making the other person feel ashamed.

The Bible says "an ephah." An ephah is about 6 gallons. That is a lot for one day of gleaning, enough bread for several weeks.

Naomi finds new hope VERSES 18–23

18 She picked it up and went into the town.
Her mother-in-law saw what she had gleaned.
And Ruth took out and gave her what she had left over
after she had eaten enough.
19 Her mother-in-law said to her,
"Where did you glean today? Where did you work?
Blessed be the man who noticed you."
She told her mother-in-law whom she had worked
with:
"The name of the man I worked with today is Boaz."
20 Naomi said to her daughter-in-law,
"May he be blessed by the LORD,
who has not stopped showing his kindness to the living
and to the dead."
And Naomi said to her,
"The man is a close relative of ours.
He is one of our family redeemers."
21 Ruth the Moabite woman said,
"Yes, he also said to me,
'Stay close to my young men
until they have finished my whole harvest.'"
22 Naomi said to Ruth her daughter-in-law,
"It is good, my daughter, that you go out with his
young women.
Then no one will harm you in another field."
23 So she stayed close to the young women of Boaz,
to glean until the end of the barley harvest and the
wheat harvest.
And she lived with her mother-in-law.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Naomi changes. She had said: God has made me empty. Now she says: God has not stopped showing his kindness. For the first time, hope comes back into her life.

"To the living and to the dead": The sentence can be about God or about Boaz. Both fit. God shows his kindness through Boaz.

"Family redeemer" is "go'el" in Hebrew. A redeemer was an important family member. He had to help a poor relative: He bought back family land that had been sold (Leviticus 25:25). He bought the freedom of relatives who had to sell themselves as slaves. He made sure that the family did not die out. Boaz is such a redeemer. That is the key to the rest of the story.

Later, the prophets call God himself the "Redeemer" of Israel (Isaiah 41:14). Christians see in Jesus the Redeemer who sets people free.

Boaz had spoken about his "young men." In verse 22, Naomi advises her rather to stay with the young women. That is safer for a young woman.

The barley and wheat harvests together lasted about seven weeks, from April to June. That is the time until the Feast of Weeks.

RUTH

CHAPTER 3

Ruth at night on the threshing floor

Naomi's plan VERSES 1–5

1 Naomi, her mother-in-law, said to her,
"My daughter, shouldn't I look for rest for you,
so that things will go well for you?
2 Isn't Boaz our relative, whose young women you were
with?
Look, tonight he is winnowing barley on the
threshing floor.
3 So wash yourself, put on perfumed oil, get dressed,
and go down to the threshing floor.
But don't let the man know you are there
until he has finished eating and drinking.
4 When he lies down, notice the place where he is lying.
Then go in, uncover his feet, and lie down.
Then he will tell you what to do."
5 She said to her,
"I will do everything you say."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Chapter 1, Naomi had wished that her daughters-in-law would find "rest" in the house of a husband. Now she herself wants to make sure that Ruth gets a safe home.

"Winnowing": After threshing, people threw the grain into the air with a fork. The evening wind carried away the light chaff, and the heavy grains fell back down. The "threshing floor" was a hard, flat place where this was done. At harvest time, the men slept there to guard the grain.

Naomi's plan is brave and also risky. A young woman goes to a man at night. That could easily have been misunderstood. "Uncovering his feet" was probably a sign: Ruth lies down at his feet and in this way silently asks him for protection. Some interpreters think the expression also has a hidden double meaning. But the text clearly shows: Nothing dishonorable happens that night.

Ruth asks Boaz VERSES 6–9

6 She went down to the threshing floor
and did everything her mother-in-law had told her.
7 When Boaz had eaten and drunk and his heart was
happy,
he went to lie down at the end of the heap of grain.
She came quietly, uncovered his feet, and lay down.
8 At midnight the man woke up with a start and turned
over.
Look! A woman was lying at his feet.
9 He said, "Who are you?"
She answered,
"I am Ruth, your servant.
Spread the corner of your garment over your servant,
for you are a family redeemer."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ruth does what Naomi said. But then she herself says something that Naomi had not said: She asks Boaz quite directly.

"Spread the corner of your garment over me" was a request for marriage. It means: Take me under your protection. Take me as your wife (compare Ezekiel 16:8).

The Hebrew word for "corner" is the same word as "wing." In Ruth 2:12, Boaz had said: You have come to take refuge under the wings of the LORD. Now Ruth says: Then you be the answer to your own prayer. Spread your wings over me. God often helps through people.

"You are a family redeemer": The Hebrew word here is "go'el." Ruth reminds Boaz of his responsibility for the family of Elimelech.

Boaz promises to help VERSES 10–13

10 He said,
"May the LORD bless you, my daughter.
You have shown even more kindness now at the end
than at the beginning.
For you have not gone after young men, whether poor
or rich.
11 And now, my daughter, don't be afraid.
I will do for you everything you say.
For the whole town of my people knows that you are a
woman of noble character.
12 It is true that I am a family redeemer.
But there is another redeemer who is a closer relative
than I am.
13 Stay here tonight.
In the morning, if he will do the duty of a redeemer
for you, good.
Let him do the redeemer's duty.
But if he does not want to do the duty of a redeemer for
you,
then I will do the duty of a redeemer for you,
as surely as the LORD lives.
Lie down until morning."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Boaz is probably much older than Ruth. He praises her: You could have married a young man. But you are thinking of the family of your dead husband and of Naomi. That is even greater kindness (chesed) than your faithfulness at the beginning.

"A woman of noble character" is the same expression in Hebrew as in Proverbs 31:10, which asks who can find such a woman. In the Hebrew Bible, the book of Ruth often comes right after the book of Proverbs. Ruth is like a living example of this woman. And in Ruth 2:1, Boaz was described with a similar word. The two are a good match.

Boaz is honest: There is another man who has the first right. Boaz does not want to do anything behind his back. He wants to settle everything properly and openly.

Ruth returns to Naomi VERSES 14–18

14 She lay at his feet until morning.
Then she got up before anyone could recognize
another person.
For he said,
"No one must know that the woman came to the
threshing floor."
15 He said,
"Bring the shawl you are wearing and hold it out."
She held it out.
He measured out six measures of barley and put it on
her back.
Then he went into the town.
16 When she came to her mother-in-law, Naomi said,
"How did it go, my daughter?"
She told her everything the man had done for her.
17 She said,
"He gave me these six measures of barley.
For he said,
'Don't go back to your mother-in-law empty-
handed.'"
18 Then Naomi said,
"Wait, my daughter, until you know how things will
turn out.
For the man will not rest until he has settled this
today."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ruth leaves in the dark, so that no false gossip about her arises. Boaz protects her good name.

The text does not say how big a "measure" was. It was probably an amount that a woman could still carry.

"Don't go back … empty-handed": In Ruth 1:21, Naomi had said: "The LORD has brought me home again empty." Now the emptiness is being filled step by step. The barley is like a promise: Soon more will come.

At the end, Ruth has to wait. Sometimes you yourself cannot do anything more, only trust.

RUTH

CHAPTER 4

Boaz marries Ruth

At the town gate VERSES 1–6

1 Boaz went up to the town gate and sat down there.
Look! The family redeemer Boaz had spoken about
came by.
Boaz said to him,
"Come over here, friend, and sit down!"
He came over and sat down.
2 Boaz took 10 men from the elders of the town
and said, "Sit down here."
And they sat down.
3 He said to the family redeemer,
"Naomi, who has come back from the country of
Moab,
is selling the piece of land that belonged to our brother
Elimelech.

4 I thought I should tell you:
'Buy it in front of those who are sitting here, and in front of the elders of my people.'
If you will redeem it, redeem it.
But if you will not redeem it, tell me, so that I know.
For there is no one besides you who can redeem it, and I come after you."
To redeem means here: to buy the land back, so that it stays in the family.
He said, "I will redeem it."
5 Then Boaz said,
"On the day you buy the field from Naomi,
you must also buy it from Ruth the Moabite woman,
the wife of the dead man,
to keep the name of the dead man alive on his land."
6 The family redeemer said,
"I cannot redeem it for myself,
or I would put my own inheritance in danger.
You take my right to redeem it for yourself.
For I cannot redeem it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At that time, the town gate was like a town hall and a court. The elders met there and settled important matters in front of witnesses.

The other relative is not given a name. In Hebrew, Boaz calls him something like "Mr. So-and-So." Maybe because he does not earn any honor in this story.

At first it is only about a piece of land. The relative would gladly buy it. Then Boaz says: Ruth comes with the land. Whoever redeems the land should also marry Ruth. A son of Ruth would then count as a descendant of the dead Mahlon and would inherit the land.

Behind this is an old law: If a man dies without children, his brother should marry the widow. The first son should carry on the name of the dead man (Deuteronomy 25:5–10). Boaz and the relative are not brothers of Mahlon, but the idea is applied to close relatives.

Now the relative does the math: I pay for the land, but later it does not belong to my own children. It is not worth it for me. He thinks of his own advantage. Boaz thinks of the family.

In the Hebrew text, there is a small uncertainty about how to read verse 5. The sentence can also be read like this: Boaz says that he himself is taking Ruth as his wife. Most translations read it as the WEB, our English source text, does.

The sandal as a sign VERSES 7–10

7 In earlier times in Israel, this was the custom for redeeming and for exchanging,
to make any matter official:
A man took off his sandal and gave it to the other man.
This was how business deals were made official in Israel.
8 So the family redeemer said to Boaz, "Buy it for yourself."
And he took off his sandal.
9 Boaz said to the elders and to all the people,
"You are witnesses today
that I have bought everything that belonged to Elimelech,
and everything that belonged to Chilion and Mahlon,
from Naomi.
10 I have also acquired Ruth the Moabite woman, the wife of Mahlon,
to be my wife,
to keep the name of the dead man alive on his land,
so that the name of the dead man will not disappear from among his brothers and from the gate of his hometown.
You are witnesses today."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Handing over the sandal was like a signature. The sandal stands for the right to step on a piece of land and own it. Whoever gives away his sandal gives away his right.

The narrator has to explain the custom. This shows: When the book was written down, people no longer knew it.

"Acquired": That is how people spoke about a marriage at that time. We should not imagine it like buying a thing. Boaz takes responsibility for Ruth and for Naomi. Ruth herself had asked him to.

Boaz does everything openly and in front of witnesses. Nothing is secret. So Ruth has a secure position, and no one can challenge it later.

The blessing of the people VERSES 11–12

11 All the people who were at the gate, and the elders, said,
"We are witnesses.
May the LORD make the woman who is coming into your house like Rachel and like Leah,
who together built up the house of Israel.
May you do well in Ephrathah
and be famous in Bethlehem.
12 May your family be like the family of Perez,
whom Tamar bore to Judah,
through the children the LORD will give you by this young woman."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rachel and Leah were the wives of Jacob. The 12 tribes of Israel came from them and their servants. The people wish: May Ruth, the foreigner, become a mother of Israel like them.

Perez was a son of Judah and Tamar (Genesis 38). Tamar was also a foreigner, and her story too was about carrying on the name of a dead man. The clan that Boaz belonged to came from Perez.

A son for Naomi VERSES 13–17

13 So Boaz took Ruth, and she became his wife.
He slept with her,
and the LORD let her become pregnant.
And she had a son.
14 The women said to Naomi,
"Praise the LORD,
who has not left you without a family redeemer today.
May his name become famous in Israel.
15 He will give you new life
and take care of you in your old age.
For your daughter-in-law, who loves you,
who is better to you than seven sons,
has given birth to him."
16 Naomi took the child, held him in her lap,
and took care of him.

17 The women, her neighbors, gave him a name.
They said, "A son has been born to Naomi."
They named him Obed.
He is the father of Jesse, the father of David.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In 10 years of marriage to Mahlon, Ruth had not become pregnant. Now it says clearly: The LORD let her become pregnant. It is one of the few times in the book when God himself acts directly.

At the end, it is not Ruth who stands at the center, but Naomi. The women of Bethlehem, who had asked at the beginning, "Is this Naomi?" now share her joy. The woman who came back "empty" now holds a child in her arms. "Mara," the bitter one, has become "Naomi," the pleasant one, again.

"Better than seven sons": Seven sons were seen as the greatest happiness. The women say: Ruth is worth even more than that. Great praise for a foreigner.

"Obed" means "servant" or "one who serves."

And then the big surprise: This child is the grandfather of David, the most famous king of Israel. The faithful foreign woman from Moab becomes the great-grandmother of the king.

The family tree from Perez to David VERSES 18–22

18 This is the history of the descendants of Perez:
Perez became the father of Hezron,
19 Hezron became the father of Ram,
Ram became the father of Amminadab,
20 Amminadab became the father of Nahshon,
Nahshon became the father of Salmon,
21 Salmon became the father of Boaz,
Boaz became the father of Obed,
22 Obed became the father of Jesse,
and Jesse became the father of David.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book ends with a list of 10 names, from Perez to David. Boaz is in seventh place, David in tenth. In Israel, 7 and 10 were special numbers that stood for completeness.

Nahshon was a leader of the tribe of Judah at the time of Moses (Numbers 1:7). The Gospel of Matthew says that Salmon was married to Rahab from Jericho (Matthew 1:5). Then Boaz himself would have had a foreign mother.

The list probably does not name every single generation, only important names. That was common in old family trees.

With the name David, the book of Ruth opens the door to the next books, the books of Samuel. They tell how David becomes king.

Christians read this family tree further: In the Gospel of Matthew, it goes from David to Jesus (Matthew 1:1–16). Tamar, Rahab, and Ruth are named there too. In this way the Bible shows: God's way also leads through foreign women and people on the edge.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of Ruth?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of Ruth tells a story from empty to full. At the beginning, Naomi loses everything: her homeland, her husband, her sons. She comes back to Bethlehem bitter and empty. At the end, she holds a grandchild in her arms, and her family has land and a future again.

This does not happen through great miracles but through kindness (chesed): Ruth stays faithful to Naomi, even though she could leave. Boaz does more than the law requires. And behind everything is God, who leads quietly and in secret.

The book has an important message about foreigners: Ruth is a Moabite, from a people that was not well thought of in Israel. And yet she becomes an example of faithfulness and the great-grandmother of the great King David. God does not ask where someone comes from but looks at the heart. The book invites us to welcome strangers with kindness.

After the dark book of Judges, the book of Ruth shows: Even in hard times, there are people who do good. And God builds his future through them.

The next books, 1 and 2 Samuel, tell how Ruth's great-grandson becomes King David.

OLD TESTAMENT · BOOK 9 OF 66

1 SAMUEL

31 CHAPTERS

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 1

Hannah prays for a child

BEFORE WE BEGIN: WHAT IS THE BOOK OF 1 SAMUEL?

The books of Samuel tell how Israel becomes a kingdom. At the beginning, judges and priests are still ruling. At the end, David is king.

Originally, 1 Samuel and 2 Samuel were one single book. Only later was it divided into two parts.

The book of 1 Samuel tells about three great people:

Samuel is the last judge and a great prophet. He anoints the first two kings.

Saul is the first king of Israel. He starts well, but he does not obey God and fails.

David is a young shepherd whom God chooses. He defeats Goliath. Saul chases him for a long time, but in the end David becomes king.

The book is full of exciting and very human stories: friendship, jealousy, war, prayer, and betrayal. It shows honestly the strengths and weaknesses of people.

An important question in the book is: What makes a good leader? The answer is in a famous sentence: "Man looks at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart" (1 Samuel 16:7).

But the book does not begin with a king. It begins with a woman who weeps and prays: Hannah.

Elkanah and his two wives VERSES 1–8

1 There was a man from Ramathaim Zophim in the hill country of Ephraim.
His name was Elkanah.
He was the son of Jeroham, the son of Elihu, the son of Tohu, the son of Zuph, an Ephraimite.

2 He had two wives.
The name of one was Hannah, and the name of the other was Peninnah.
Peninnah had children, but Hannah had no children.

3 Year after year this man went up from his city
to worship the LORD of Armies in Shiloh and to offer sacrifices to him.
The two sons of Eli, Hophni and Phinehas, were priests of the LORD there.

4 When the day came for Elkanah to offer his sacrifice,
he gave portions of the sacrifice to his wife Peninnah and to all her sons and daughters.

5 But he gave Hannah a double portion,
because he loved Hannah.
But the LORD had closed her womb.

6 Her rival hurt her badly to upset her,
because the LORD had closed her womb.

7 This happened year after year:
Whenever she went up to the house of the LORD, her rival hurt her.
So she wept and did not eat.

8 Her husband Elkanah said to her,
"Hannah, why are you weeping?
Why don't you eat?
Why is your heart so sad?
Am I not better to you than 10 sons?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ramathaim Zophim is called "Ramah" for short in verse 19. It was in the hill country north of Jerusalem.

Elkanah has two wives. This was allowed at that time, but the Bible often shows how much quarreling and pain it brought, as with Sarah and Hagar or with Rachel and Leah.

"The LORD of Armies" is in Hebrew "YHWH Tsebaoth." This name for God appears here for the first time in the Bible. It means: God is the Lord over all powers in heaven and on earth. The WEB, our English source text, says "Yahweh of Armies."

At that time, the holy tent with the ark of the covenant stood in Shiloh. People went there once a year for the great feast.

Being childless was a great sorrow and a disgrace at that time. Many people thought God had punished the woman. Peninnah takes advantage of this and hurts Hannah, especially at the feasts.

Elkanah loves Hannah. But he does not fully understand her pain. He means well, but his question "Am I not better to you than 10 sons?" does not comfort her.

Hannah's prayer VERSES 9–18

9 After they had eaten and drunk in Shiloh, Hannah got up.
Eli the priest was sitting on his seat by the doorpost of the temple of the LORD.

10 She was deeply bitter in her soul.
She prayed to the LORD and wept bitterly.

11 She made a vow and said,
"LORD of Armies,
if you will really look at the misery of your servant
and remember me and not forget your servant,
but give your servant a son,
then I will give him to the LORD for all the days of his life.
And no razor shall come on his head."

12 While she kept on praying in front of the LORD,
Eli watched her mouth.

13 For Hannah was speaking in her heart.
Only her lips moved, but her voice could not be heard.
So Eli thought she was drunk.

14 Eli said to her,
"How long will you stay drunk?
Get rid of your wine!"

15 Hannah answered,
"No, my lord.
I am a woman with a troubled spirit.
I have not been drinking wine or strong drink.
But I have poured out my soul before the LORD.

16 Don't think of your servant as a wicked woman.
For I have been speaking out of my great sorrow and

my hurt."
17 Then Eli answered,
"Go in peace.
May the God of Israel give you what you have asked of him."
18 She said,
"Let your servant find favor in your eyes."
Then the woman went her way and ate.
And her face was no longer sad.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "temple" in Shiloh was not yet a big building like the later temple in Jerusalem, but probably a solid holy place with doors (1 Samuel 3:15).

Hannah takes her pain straight to God. She promises: If you give me a son, I will give him back to you. He is to serve God his whole life. "No razor" means: He is to be a Nazirite, like Samson (Judges 13:5).

At that time, people usually prayed out loud. Hannah prays quietly, only in her heart. Eli does not understand this and thinks she is drunk. The priest who should have helped her accuses her.

But Hannah stays polite and explains herself. "I have poured out my soul before the LORD" is a beautiful picture for honest prayer: You tell God everything that is in your heart.

After this, Hannah is changed. She does not yet know whether she will have a child. But she has handed her burden over to God. She can eat again.

Samuel is born VERSES 19–20

19 They got up early in the morning and worshiped the LORD.
Then they went back home to Ramah.
Elkanah knew his wife Hannah,
and the LORD remembered her.
20 When the time had come, Hannah became pregnant and had a son.
She named him Samuel.
For she said, "I have asked the LORD for him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible, "to know" is a word for the love between a man and a woman.

"The LORD remembered her": God did not forget Hannah. That is what she had asked for in her prayer (verse 11).

In Hebrew, the name "Samuel" sounds a bit like the word for "asked for" (sha'al). The name itself probably means "name of God" or "God has heard." Every time Hannah calls her son, she is reminded: God has answered my prayer.

Hannah brings Samuel to Shiloh VERSES 21–28

21 The man Elkanah and his whole family went up to offer the yearly sacrifice to the LORD and to keep his vow.
22 But Hannah did not go up.
For she said to her husband,
"Not until the child is weaned.
Then I will bring him, so that he may appear before the LORD and stay there forever."
23 Her husband Elkanah said to her,
"Do what seems good to you.
Stay until you have weaned him.
Only may the LORD make his word come true."
So the woman stayed and nursed her son until she had weaned him.
24 When she had weaned him, she took him up with her, with 3 bulls, about 6 gallons of flour, and a container of wine.
She brought him to the house of the LORD in Shiloh.
The child was still young.
25 They killed the bull
and brought the child to Eli.
26 She said,
"Oh, my lord, as surely as you live, my lord:
I am the woman who stood here beside you, praying to the LORD.
27 I prayed for this child.
And the LORD has given me what I asked of him.
28 So I also give him to the LORD.
As long as he lives, he is given to the LORD."
And he worshiped the LORD there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

To wean a child means: to stop feeding it at the breast.

At that time, a child was often breastfed for two to three years. Only then does Hannah bring Samuel to Shiloh. This is a great sacrifice for a mother who has waited so long for a child. But she keeps her promise.

The Bible says "an ephah of flour." An ephah is about 6 gallons.

Verse 24 says "3 bulls," verse 25 says "the bull." An old manuscript from the Dead Sea and the old Greek translation have in verse 24: "a three-year-old bull." This fits verse 25 better.

In verses 27 and 28, Hannah plays with the Hebrew word "sha'al": I "asked" for him, so I "give him back" (literally: "I lend him") to the LORD.

"He worshiped": This probably means Elkanah or little Samuel. Some manuscripts have "they worshiped."

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 2

Hannah's song and Eli's wicked sons

Hannah's song of praise VERSES 1–10

1 Hannah prayed and said,
"My heart rejoices in the LORD!
My horn is exalted by the LORD.
My mouth laughs at my enemies,
because I rejoice in your salvation.
2 No one is as holy as the LORD.
For there is no one besides you.
And there is no rock like our God.

3 Don't keep talking so proudly.
Don't let arrogant words come out of your mouth.
For the LORD is a God who knows everything.
By him all actions are weighed.
4 The bows of the mighty men are broken.
Those who stumbled are given strength.
5 Those who were full have hired themselves out for bread.
Those who were hungry are satisfied.
Yes, the barren woman has had seven children.
And she who has many children wastes away.
6 The LORD kills and makes alive.
He brings down to Sheol (the world of the dead) and brings up again.
7 The LORD makes poor and makes rich.
He brings low, and he also lifts up.
8 He raises up the poor from the dust.
He lifts up the needy from the garbage heap,
to make them sit with princes
and give them a throne of honor.
For the pillars of the earth belong to the LORD.
He has set the world on them.
9 He will guard the feet of his holy ones.
But the wicked will be silenced in darkness.
For no one wins by his own strength.
10 Those who fight against the LORD will be broken to pieces.
He will thunder against them in the sky.
The LORD will judge the ends of the earth.
He will give strength to his king
and exalt the horn of his anointed one."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hannah sings a song of thanks. But it is much more than a personal thank-you for a child. It is a song about God, who turns the world upside down: The strong become weak, the weak become strong. Those who were full go hungry, and the hungry are satisfied. The poor sit with princes.

The "horn" is a picture for strength and dignity, like the horn of a strong bull. "My horn is exalted" means: I am no longer put to shame, I can hold my head up again.

"Rock" is a picture for God: He is firm and reliable, a safe place to hold on to.

"Sheol" is the Hebrew word for the world of the dead. Hannah says: God has power over life and death.

"The barren woman has had seven children": Seven is a number for fullness. Later Hannah has six children in all (verse 21).

At the end, Hannah speaks of a "king" and an "anointed one." But Israel does not even have a king yet. The song looks ahead to the time of the kings, to David. The Hebrew word for "anointed one" is "Mashiach," Messiah. Christians see in this a pointer to Jesus, the "Christ," which is the Greek word for "anointed one."

In the New Testament, Mary, the mother of Jesus, sings a song that is very much like this song (Luke 1:46–55).

Eli's wicked sons VERSES 11–17

11 Elkanah went home to Ramah.
And the boy served the LORD under Eli the priest.
12 But the sons of Eli were wicked men.
They did not know the LORD.
13 This was the custom of the priests with the people:
When anyone offered a sacrifice, the priest's servant came
while the meat was boiling,
with a fork with three prongs in his hand.
14 He stabbed it into the pan, or kettle, or cauldron, or pot.
Everything the fork brought up, the priest took for himself.
They did this to all the Israelites who came there to Shiloh.
15 Even before the fat was burned,
the priest's servant came and said to the man who was offering the sacrifice,
"Give meat to roast for the priest.
For he will not accept boiled meat from you, only raw."
16 If the man said to him,
"Let the fat be burned first, and then take as much as you want,"
then he would say,
"No, you must give it to me now.
If not, I will take it by force."
17 The sin of the young men was very great in front of the LORD.
For the men treated the LORD's offering with contempt.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the beautiful story of Hannah comes a hard contrast: The priests in Shiloh are wicked.

"They did not know the LORD": They were priests, they worked in the holy place every day, but they had no real relationship with God.

The law said exactly which part of a sacrifice the priests were to get (Leviticus 7:31–34). And the fat belonged first to God. It had to be burned on the altar (Leviticus 3:16). But Eli's sons take whatever they want, even before God gets his part, and even by force.

They misuse their holy office to make themselves rich. And they drive away the people who want to honor God. This is especially bad.

Samuel grows up VERSES 18–21

18 But Samuel served in front of the LORD, while still a child,
dressed in a linen ephod.
19 His mother also made him a little robe.
She brought it to him year after year,
when she came up with her husband to offer the yearly sacrifice.
20 Eli blessed Elkanah and his wife and said,
"May the LORD give you children from this woman,
in place of the one she asked for and gave to the LORD."
Then they went to their home.
21 The LORD visited Hannah,
and she became pregnant and had three sons and two daughters.
And the boy Samuel grew up in front of the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An "ephod" here was a simple priest's garment made of linen. Little Samuel already wears the clothes of a servant

in the holy place.

Every year Hannah brings him a new, slightly bigger robe. In it is all the love of a mother who can see her child only once a year.

Eli wishes Hannah more children, because she has given her request, the son she asked for, to the LORD.

God blesses Hannah richly: She has five more children. Whoever gives to God does not become poorer.

The storyteller keeps switching back and forth: Eli's wicked sons, then good Samuel. In this way, the difference is easy to see.

Eli warns his sons VERSES 22–26

22 Eli was very old.
He heard about everything his sons were doing to all Israel,
and that they slept with the women
who served at the entrance of the Tent of Meeting.
23 He said to them,
"Why do you do such things?
For I hear from all these people about your evil deeds.
24 No, my sons.
What I hear is not a good report.
You are making the LORD's people disobey.
25 If one person sins against another, God will judge him.
But if a person sins against the LORD, who will speak up for him?"
But they did not listen to their father's voice.
For the LORD intended to kill them.
26 The boy Samuel kept on growing
and gained favor with the LORD and also with people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eli's sons also abuse the women who serve at the holy place. They take advantage of their power as priests. This is a serious crime.

An old manuscript from the Dead Sea and the old Greek translation do not have the sentence about the women. But it is in the Hebrew text, which the WEB, our English source text, follows.

Eli warns his sons. But he does nothing more. He is the high priest. He could have removed them from office, and he should have. He does not do it.

Verse 25 is hard: "The LORD intended to kill them." This does not mean that God forced them to do evil. They had decided against God for a long time. Now the time was up, and the judgment was fixed. The Bible often shows: Whoever keeps hardening himself against God may at some point no longer be able to turn back.

Verse 26 sounds almost exactly like a sentence about Jesus as a child (Luke 2:52).

A prophet announces judgment VERSES 27–36

27 A man of God came to Eli and said to him,
"This is what the LORD says:
'Didn't I clearly show myself to your father's family
when they were slaves in Egypt in Pharaoh's house?
28 Didn't I choose him out of all the tribes of Israel to be my priest,
to go up to my altar, to burn incense,
and to wear an ephod in front of me?
Didn't I give your father's family all the offerings of the people of Israel made by fire?
29 Why do you kick at my sacrifice and my offering,
which I commanded in my dwelling place?
And why do you honor your sons more than me,
so that you make yourselves fat with the best of all the offerings of my people Israel?'
30 So the LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'I did say that your family and your father's family would walk in front of me forever.'
But now the LORD says:
'Far be it from me!
For those who honor me I will honor.
And those who despise me will be cursed.
31 The days are coming when I will cut off your strength
and the strength of your father's family,
so that there will be no old man in your family.
32 You will see trouble in my dwelling place,
in spite of all the good things I will give Israel.
There will never be an old man in your family.
33 The man of yours whom I do not cut off from my altar
will make your eyes weak with weeping and fill your heart with grief.
And all the descendants of your family will die in the prime of life.
34 And this will be the sign for you, which will come on your two sons,
on Hophni and Phinehas:
They will both die on the same day.
35 I will raise up a faithful priest for myself,
who will do what is in my heart and in my mind.
I will build him a lasting family.
He will walk in front of my anointed one forever.
36 And this is what will happen:
Everyone who is left in your family
will come and bow down to him for a piece of silver and a loaf of bread.
And he will say,
"Please give me a job with the priests,
so that I may have a bite of bread to eat."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A prophet without a name comes to Eli. He reminds him: God made your family, the family of Aaron, priests out of grace.

"Why do you honor your sons more than me?" Eli did not stop his sons, because they were his sons. And he probably ate some of the meat himself. The text says: "you make yourselves fat."

Verse 30 is an important sentence: "Those who honor me I will honor." God's promises are not a free pass. Whoever despises God cannot rely on where he comes from.

What is announced here comes true step by step later: Hophni and Phinehas die on the same day (Chapter 4). Later almost all the priests from Eli's family are killed in the city of Nob (Chapter 22). Only one, Abiathar, survives. Later King Solomon removes him from office (1 Kings 2:27).

The "faithful priest" is probably first Samuel and later Zadok, who becomes high priest under Solomon. Christians also see in this a pointer to Jesus, the faithful high priest (Hebrews 2:17).

CHAPTER 3

God calls Samuel

A voice in the night VERSES 1–10

1 The boy Samuel served the LORD under Eli.
The word of the LORD was rare in those days.
There were not many visions at that time.
2 At that time Eli was lying down in his place.
His eyes had grown weak, so that he could no longer see.
3 The lamp of God had not yet gone out.
And Samuel was lying down in the temple of the LORD, where the ark of God was.
4 Then the LORD called Samuel.
He said, "Here I am."
5 He ran to Eli and said,
"Here I am. You called me."
He said, "I didn't call. Lie down again."
So he went and lay down.
6 The LORD called once more, "Samuel!"
Samuel got up, went to Eli, and said,
"Here I am. You called me."
He answered, "I didn't call, my son. Lie down again."
7 Samuel did not yet know the LORD,
and the word of the LORD had not yet been shown to him.
8 The LORD called Samuel again, for the third time.
He got up, went to Eli, and said,
"Here I am. You called me."
Then Eli understood that the LORD was calling the boy.
9 So Eli said to Samuel,
"Go, lie down.
And if he calls you, say,
'Speak, LORD, for your servant is listening.'"
So Samuel went and lay down in his place.
10 The LORD came and stood there and called as at the other times,
"Samuel! Samuel!"
Then Samuel said,
"Speak, for your servant is listening."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The word of the LORD was rare": At this time, God hardly spoke to people. The priests were corrupt, and Eli was old and almost blind. Eli's weak eyes are like a picture: Israel no longer sees clearly in spiritual things either.

"The lamp of God had not yet gone out": In the holy place, a lampstand burned all night until the morning (Exodus 27:20–21). So it was shortly before sunrise. You can also read it as a picture: The light of God in Israel had almost gone out, but not quite.

Samuel does not yet know God's voice. He thinks it is Eli. Three times he runs to him. Only then does Eli understand what is happening.

Here Eli is a good teacher: He shows the boy how to listen to God. The sentence "Speak, LORD, for your servant is listening" is still a prayer today for many people who want to know what God wants from them.

Interesting: The fourth time, Samuel only says "Speak," without the word "LORD." Maybe he does not yet dare to say God's name.

A hard message VERSES 11–14

11 The LORD said to Samuel,
"I am going to do something in Israel
that will make both ears of everyone who hears it ring.
12 On that day I will carry out against Eli everything
I have said about his family, from beginning to end.
13 For I have told him
that I will judge his family forever because of the sin he knew about.
For his sons brought a curse on themselves,
and he did not stop them.
14 So I have sworn to the family of Eli:
The sin of Eli's family will never be taken away,
not by sacrifice and not by offering."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first message that young Samuel receives from God is a hard message. And it is about Eli, of all people, his teacher, who is like a father to him.

"Make both ears of everyone who hears it ring" means: It will be so terrible that people will be shocked when they hear about it.

God says why Eli is guilty: He knew what his sons were doing, and he did not stop them. Whoever has responsibility and lets wrong happen shares in the guilt.

"His sons brought a curse on themselves": This is what the Hebrew text says. The old Greek translation and many Bible teachers read: "His sons cursed God." Jewish scribes sometimes changed such places, so that it would not be written that someone cursed God.

The sons misused the sacrifices. That is why no sacrifice can help them anymore.

Samuel tells Eli the truth VERSES 15–18

15 Samuel lay there until the morning.
Then he opened the doors of the house of the LORD.
Samuel was afraid to tell Eli about the vision.
16 Then Eli called Samuel and said,
"Samuel, my son!"
He said, "Here I am."
17 He said,
"What did he say to you?
Please don't hide it from me.
May God punish you, and even more,
if you hide from me anything of all that he said to you."
18 So Samuel told him everything
and hid nothing from him.
He said,
"It is the LORD.
Let him do what seems good to him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the morning Samuel does his usual work: He opens the doors. But he is afraid. How can he tell Eli something like this?

Eli insists on hearing the truth. And Samuel is honest, even though it is hard. This is the first task of a prophet: to pass on God's word without leaving anything out.

Eli accepts the judgment: "It is the LORD." There is humility in this. But you can also ask: Why doesn't he change anything? He could still have acted now.

Samuel becomes a prophet VERSES 19–21

19 Samuel grew up, and the LORD was with him.
He let none of his words fall to the ground.
20 All Israel, from Dan to Beersheba, knew
that Samuel was confirmed as a prophet of the LORD.
21 And the LORD appeared again in Shiloh.
For the LORD showed himself to Samuel in Shiloh
through the word of the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"He let none of his words fall to the ground": Everything that Samuel said in God's name came true. This is how people recognized a true prophet (Deuteronomy 18:22).

"From Dan to Beersheba" means: in the whole land, from the north to the south.

At the beginning of the chapter, the word of the LORD was rare. At the end, God speaks again. Through a boy who has learned to listen, a new time begins for Israel.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 4

The ark of the covenant is lost

Israel loses the first battle VERSES 1–4

1 The word of Samuel came to all Israel.
Israel went out to battle against the Philistines
and camped near Ebenezer.
The Philistines camped at Aphek.
2 The Philistines lined up for battle against Israel.
When the battle began, Israel was beaten by the Philistines.
They killed about 4,000 men of the army on the battlefield.
3 When the people came back to the camp, the elders of Israel said,
"Why has the LORD let us be beaten by the Philistines today?
Let's bring the ark of the covenant of the LORD here from Shiloh.
Then it will come among us
and save us from the hand of our enemies."
4 So the people sent messengers to Shiloh.
From there they brought the ark of the covenant of the LORD of Armies,
who sits enthroned above the cherubim.
And the two sons of Eli, Hophni and Phinehas, were there with the ark of the covenant of God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Aphek was in the coastal plain, at the border of the land of the Philistines. Ebenezer was nearby. The name "Ebenezer" means "stone of help." How the place got this name is told only in Chapter 7.

The ark of the covenant was a wooden chest covered with gold. Inside it were the stone tablets with the Ten Commandments. On top of the lid were two cherubim, angel figures with wings. The ark was the sign that God is right among his people. People said: God sits enthroned above the cherubim, like a king on his throne.

The elders ask: Why has the LORD let us be beaten? That is a good question. But they do not wait for an answer. They do not ask God or Samuel. They think: If we have the ark with us, God has to help us.

In this way they treat the ark like a lucky charm, like a magic object. They want to use God, but not listen to him. And of all people, the wicked priests Hophni and Phinehas go along with the ark.

The Philistines become afraid VERSES 5–9

5 When the ark of the covenant of the LORD came into the camp,
all Israel shouted so loudly that the earth shook.
6 When the Philistines heard the noise of the shouting, they said,
"What does the noise of this great shouting in the camp of the Hebrews mean?"
They found out that the ark of the LORD had come into the camp.
7 The Philistines became afraid.
For they said, "God has come into the camp."
They said,
"How terrible for us!
For nothing like this has ever happened before.
8 How terrible for us!
Who will save us from the hand of these mighty gods?
These are the gods who struck the Egyptians with all kinds of plagues in the wilderness.
9 Be strong and act like men, you Philistines,
so that you will not become slaves of the Hebrews, as they have been your slaves.
Be men and fight!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Hebrews" was a name that other peoples used for the Israelites.

The Philistines know the story of the exodus from Egypt. But they think that Israel has many gods, just as they do. And they mix up the story a little: The plagues happened in Egypt, not in the wilderness.

Instead of giving up, the Philistines encourage each other. Their fear makes them determined.

The great defeat VERSES 10–11

10 The Philistines fought, and Israel was beaten.
Each man fled to his tent.
It was a very great slaughter.
For 30,000 foot soldiers of Israel fell.
11 The ark of God was captured.
And the two sons of Eli, Hophni and Phinehas, were killed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is a disaster. The ark, the holiest thing in Israel, falls into the hands of the enemies.

The message is clear: God cannot be forced. The ark is not a magic tool. Without obedience and without real trust, even the holiest object does not help.

Hophni and Phinehas die on the same day, just as the prophet had announced (1 Samuel 2:34).

Later the Psalms and the prophets remember this day: God left his dwelling place in Shiloh (Psalm 78:60–61; Jeremiah 7:12).

Eli's death VERSES 12–18

12 A man from Benjamin ran away from the army
and came to Shiloh the same day.
His clothes were torn, and he had dirt on his head.
13 When he arrived, Eli was sitting on his seat by the road, watching.
For his heart was trembling for the ark of God.
When the man came into the city and told about it,
the whole city cried out.
14 When Eli heard the noise of the crying, he said,
"What does the noise of this uproar mean?"
The man hurried over, came, and told Eli.
15 Eli was 98 years old.
His eyes were fixed, so that he could not see.
16 The man said to Eli,
"I am the one who came from the army.
I fled from the army today."
He said, "How did it go, my son?"
17 The one who brought the news answered,
"Israel has fled from the Philistines.
There has also been a great slaughter among the people.
Your two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, are dead too.
And the ark of God has been captured."
18 When he mentioned the ark of God,
Eli fell backward off his seat, by the side of the gate.
His neck broke, and he died.
For he was an old man and heavy.
He had judged Israel for 40 years.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Torn clothes and dirt on the head were signs of mourning at that time. Everyone saw right away: This man is bringing bad news.

Eli is more worried about the ark than about his sons. When he hears that his sons are dead, he is still alive. Only when he hears that the ark is lost does he fall over. This shows: With all his faults, Eli loved God and his holy place.

"He was heavy": The Hebrew word for "heavy" is related to the word for "glory" or "honor" ("kavod"). In 1 Samuel 2:29 God had said: "you make yourselves fat with the best of all the offerings." And verses 21 and 22 play with the same word: The "glory" is gone.

The old Greek translation says that Eli judged Israel for 20 years.

Ichabod: "Where is the glory?" VERSES 19–22

19 His daughter-in-law, the wife of Phinehas, was pregnant and about to give birth.
When she heard the news that the ark of God had been captured
and that her father-in-law and her husband were dead,
she bent over and gave birth.
For her labor pains came on her suddenly.
20 As she was dying, the women standing beside her said to her,
"Don't be afraid, for you have given birth to a son."
But she did not answer or pay attention to it.
21 She named the child Ichabod and said,
"The glory has departed from Israel!"
She said this because the ark of God had been captured,
and because of her father-in-law and her husband.
22 She said,
"The glory has departed from Israel,
for the ark of God has been captured."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Again a sad story about a woman who suffers because of what the men have done. The news is so terrible that the birth starts too early. The woman dies.

The women want to comfort her: You have a son! At that time, that was the greatest joy. But she cannot be happy.

The name "Ichabod" means: "Where is the glory?" or "No glory." God's "glory" was his presence. With the ark, she thinks, God himself has left Israel.

This woman understands more than the elders: The worst thing is not the lost battle. The worst thing is when God is no longer with his people.

But the story goes on. The next chapters show: God is not defeated. He can help himself even in the land of the enemies.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 5

The ark among the Philistines

Dagon falls over VERSES 1–5

1 The Philistines had captured the ark of God.
They brought it from Ebenezer to Ashdod.
2 The Philistines took the ark of God,
brought it into the house of Dagon,
and set it up next to Dagon.
3 When the people of Ashdod got up early the next morning,

Dagon had fallen on his face to the ground in front of
the ark of the LORD.
They took Dagon and put him back in his place.
4 When they got up early the following morning,
Dagon had again fallen on his face to the ground in
front of the ark of the LORD.
Dagon's head and both his hands were broken off and
lay on the threshold.
Only Dagon's body was still in one piece.
5 That is why the priests of Dagon and all who go into
Dagon's house
in Ashdod do not step on the threshold of Dagon, to
this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ashdod was one of the five great cities of the Philistines. Dagon was their most important god. We already heard about him in the story of Samson (Judges 16:23).

The threshold is the stone or board at the bottom of a doorway.

The Philistines set the ark next to Dagon, like the spoils of war. They want to show: Our god has defeated the God of Israel.

But in the morning Dagon lies on his face in front of the ark, as if he were bowing down before the LORD. The people have to set their god up again. A god who needs help to get up is not a god.

On the second morning, the head and hands are broken off. The head stands for understanding, the hands for power. Dagon has neither. This is also a bit of mockery of idols.

Israel had thought: God has been defeated. But God fights alone, without Israel, right in the temple of the enemies.

The plague in Ashdod VERSES 6–7

6 But the hand of the LORD was heavy on the people of
Ashdod.
He destroyed them and struck them with tumors,
Ashdod and its territory.
7 When the men of Ashdod saw what was happening,
they said,
"The ark of the God of Israel must not stay with us.
For his hand is hard on us and on our god Dagon."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Tumors" were probably sores or swellings. Many Bible teachers think of a disease, maybe the plague. With the plague, people get big swellings, and it is spread by mice and rats. This fits the golden mice in Chapter 6.

The old Greek translation also tells here that mice overran the land.

"The hand of the LORD" is a picture for God's power. The people of Ashdod realize: This is not chance.

The ark moves from city to city VERSES 8–12

8 So they sent messengers and gathered all the lords of
the Philistines.
They said,
"What shall we do with the ark of the God of Israel?"
They answered,
"Let the ark of the God of Israel be taken over to Gath."
And they took the ark of the God of Israel there.
9 After they had taken it there,
the hand of the LORD was against the city, with a very
great panic.
He struck the men of the city, young and old,
so that tumors broke out on them.
10 So they sent the ark of God to Ekron.
When the ark of God came to Ekron, the people of
Ekron cried out,
"They have brought the ark of the God of Israel here to
us,
to kill us and our people!"
11 So they sent messengers and gathered all the lords of
the Philistines.
They said,
"Send the ark of the God of Israel away.
Let it go back to its own place,
so that it will not kill us and our people."
For there was a deadly panic in the whole city.
The hand of God was very heavy on it.
12 The men who did not die were struck with the tumors.
And the cry of the city went up to heaven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gath and Ekron were other cities of the Philistines. No city wants to have the ark. Wherever it goes, the disease breaks out.

This is almost like a repeat of the plagues in Egypt. The Philistines had reminded themselves of them (1 Samuel 4:8). Now they experience it themselves.

The ark, which the Israelites had lost like spoils of war, becomes a burden for the Philistines that no one can bear. God does not need an army to defend himself.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 6

The ark comes back

The Philistines ask their priests VERSES 1–6

1 The ark of the LORD was in the land of the Philistines
for seven months.
2 The Philistines called for the priests and the fortune-
tellers and said,
"What shall we do with the ark of the LORD?
Show us how we should send it back to its place."
3 They said,
"If you send away the ark of the God of Israel,
don't send it away empty.
You must surely give him back a guilt offering.
Then you will be healed.
And you will find out why his hand has not turned
away from you."
4 Then they asked,
"What should the guilt offering be that we give back to

him?"
They said,
"Five golden tumors and five golden mice,
for the number of the lords of the Philistines.
For one plague was on all of you and on your lords.
5 So you shall make images of your tumors
and images of your mice that are ruining the land.
And you shall give glory to the God of Israel.
Maybe then he will take his hand off you,
off your gods and off your land.
6 Why do you want to harden your hearts,
as the Egyptians and Pharaoh hardened their hearts?
When he had done wonders among them,
didn't they let the people go, and they left?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The priests of the Philistines advise: Give the God of Israel a gift to make up for what you did. This is what people did at that time when they had offended a god.

Golden images of the disease and of the mice: People believed that if you make an image of the evil and send it away, the evil itself goes away too. This is not a custom of Israel, but a custom of the Philistines. Here God accepts their way of wanting to honor him.

The priests of the Philistines are wiser than their people. They say: Learn from the story of Pharaoh. Whoever hardens himself against the God of Israel loses in the end.

"Give glory to the God of Israel": Of all people, foreign priests say this. The word for "glory" is again "kavod," the same word as in 1 Samuel 4:21. The glory was not lost. Now even the enemies have to admit it.

The test with the cows VERSES 7–12

7 "Now take and get ready a new cart
and two milk cows that have never worn a yoke.
Hitch the cows to the cart,
and take their calves away from them and bring them home.
8 Take the ark of the LORD and put it on the cart.
And put the gold objects that you are giving back to him as a guilt offering
in a box beside it.
Then send it away and let it go.
9 And watch:
If it goes up the road to its own territory, to Beth Shemesh,
then he has done this great evil to us.
But if not, then we will know that it was not his hand that struck us.
It was just chance that happened to us."
10 The men did so.
They took two milk cows and hitched them to the cart.
They shut up their calves at home.
11 They put the ark of the LORD on the cart,
and the box with the golden mice and the images of their tumors.
12 The cows went straight along the road to Beth Shemesh.
They walked along the highway, mooing as they went.
They did not turn to the right or to the left.
And the lords of the Philistines followed them as far as the border of Beth Shemesh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A yoke is a wooden bar that is put over the necks of animals so that they can pull a cart or a plow.

This is a clever test. Cows that have never pulled a cart do not usually walk straight ahead. And cows whose calves have just been taken away want to go back to their calves. If they still pull the cart into the land of Israel, then God must be guiding them.

The cows are mooing because they are calling for their calves. But they keep going anyway, straight ahead, without turning off. God is guiding them.

Beth Shemesh was a city of Israel at the border of the land of the Philistines. The name means "house of the sun." It was a city of the Levites (Joshua 21:16).

Joy in Beth Shemesh VERSES 13–18

13 The people of Beth Shemesh were harvesting their wheat in the valley.
They looked up and saw the ark,
and they were happy to see it.
14 The cart came into the field of Joshua of Beth Shemesh
and stopped there, where there was a large stone.
They split up the wood of the cart
and offered the cows to the LORD as a burnt offering.
15 The Levites took down the ark of the LORD
and the box that was with it, in which the gold objects were.
They put them on the large stone.
And on that day the men of Beth Shemesh offered burnt offerings and sacrifices to the LORD.
16 When the five lords of the Philistines had seen it,
they went back to Ekron the same day.
17 These are the golden tumors
that the Philistines gave back to the LORD as a guilt offering:
one for Ashdod, one for Gaza, one for Ashkelon, one for Gath, one for Ekron.
18 And the golden mice,
for the number of all the cities of the Philistines that belonged to the five lords,
both the walled cities and the villages in the country,
as far as the large stone on which they set down the ark of the LORD.
That stone is still in the field of Joshua of Beth Shemesh to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The wheat harvest was in early summer. In the middle of their work, the people see the ark coming. What joy!

Joshua of Beth Shemesh is not the famous Joshua, who came after Moses. He is a farmer with the same name.

The Levites were the right people to carry the ark (Numbers 4:15). The large stone serves as an altar.

The five cities of the Philistines are named: Ashdod, Gaza, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron. Together these five cities made up the land of the Philistines.

In verse 4 there were five golden mice. In verse 18 it says: as many mice as all the cities and villages. Maybe there were more in addition to the five mice. The Bible does not explain it in more detail.

The disaster in Beth Shemesh VERSES 19–21

19 He struck some of the men of Beth Shemesh,
because they had looked into the ark of the LORD.
He struck 50,070 of the men.
Then the people mourned, because the LORD had
struck the people with a great slaughter.
20 The men of Beth Shemesh said,
"Who is able to stand before the LORD, this holy God?
To whom shall he go up from us?"
21 They sent messengers to the people of Kiriath Jearim,
saying,
"The Philistines have brought back the ark of the
LORD.
Come down and take it up to your town."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The joy ends with terror. The men of Beth Shemesh look into the ark. This was strictly forbidden. Not even the Levites were allowed to look at the holy things, or they would die (Numbers 4:20).

The number in verse 19 is difficult. In the Hebrew text there are literally two numbers one after the other: 70 men and 50,000 men. Such a way of giving a number is very unusual in Hebrew. Beth Shemesh was a small town. 50,000 men would not have lived there. The Jewish historian Josephus and some Hebrew manuscripts give only 70 men. Many Bible teachers think this is the original number. The WEB, our English source text, has "fifty thousand seventy."

The old Greek translation tells verse 19 differently: The sons of a man named Jeconiah did not rejoice with the others when they saw the ark. That is why they were struck.

This story is hard to understand. It wants to show: God is holy. You must not deal with him out of curiosity or without respect. He is not an object that you examine.

The question "Who is able to stand before the LORD, this holy God?" is an important question of the whole Bible. The Bible's answer is: No one by his own strength. Only because God himself is gracious can people come near him.

Kiriath Jearim was about 9 miles west of Jerusalem. The story continues in the next chapter.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 7

The stone of help

The ark in Kiriath Jearim VERSES 1–2

1 The men of Kiriath Jearim came and took the ark of the
LORD.
They brought it into the house of Abinadab on the hill.
And they dedicated his son Eleazar to guard the ark of
the LORD.
2 From the day the ark stayed in Kiriath Jearim, a long
time went by.
It was 20 years.
And the whole house of Israel mourned and longed for
the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The ark does not go back to Shiloh. Shiloh had probably been destroyed by the Philistines (Jeremiah 7:12). The ark stays in a private house for many years. Only King David later brings it to Jerusalem (2 Samuel 6).

"Longed for the LORD" means: The people miss God. They long for him. This is the beginning of turning back.

Samuel calls the people to turn back VERSES 3–6

3 Samuel spoke to the whole house of Israel:
"If you are returning to the LORD with all your heart,
then put away the foreign gods and the Ashtaroth
from among you.
Turn your hearts to the LORD and serve him only.
Then he will save you from the hand of the
Philistines."
4 So the people of Israel put away the Baals and the
Ashtaroth
and served the LORD only.
5 Samuel said,
"Gather all Israel at Mizpah.
Then I will pray to the LORD for you."
6 They gathered at Mizpah.
They drew water and poured it out in front of the
LORD.
They fasted on that day and said there,
"We have sinned against the LORD."
And Samuel judged the people of Israel at Mizpah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For 20 years we hear nothing about Samuel. Now he steps forward and says clearly: Real turning back does not only mean mourning. Real turning back means: putting away everything that stands between you and God.

Baal was a god of rain and fertility. Ashtoreth was a goddess of love and war. The plural forms "Baals" and "Ashtaroth" mean their many images and places of worship.

Pouring out water is a sign that does not appear like this anywhere else in the Bible. Maybe it means: We pour out our hearts before God, as Hannah did (1 Samuel 1:15). Or: Our life is before you like water poured out.

The people say honestly: "We have sinned." That is the most important sentence when people turn back.

God thunders against the Philistines VERSES 7–11

7 When the Philistines heard that the people of Israel had
gathered at Mizpah,
the lords of the Philistines went up against Israel.
When the people of Israel heard it, they were afraid of
the Philistines.
8 The people of Israel said to Samuel,
"Don't stop crying out to the LORD our God for us,
so that he will save us from the hand of the
Philistines."
9 Samuel took a young lamb that was still nursing
and offered it to the LORD as a whole burnt offering.
Samuel cried out to the LORD for Israel, and the LORD
answered him.

10 While Samuel was offering the burnt offering,
the Philistines came near to fight against Israel.
But on that day the LORD thundered with a mighty
thunder against the Philistines
and threw them into confusion.
And they were beaten in front of Israel.
11 The men of Israel went out from Mizpah,
chased the Philistines,
and struck them down as far as below Beth Kar.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This time everything is different from Chapter 4. Then Israel brought the ark like a lucky charm. Now it prays. Then it relied on a thing. Now it relies on God.

The people are afraid, but they do not run away. They ask Samuel to pray for them.

God answers with thunder. In her song Hannah had said: "He will thunder against them in the sky" (1 Samuel 2:10). This comes true here.

Today no one knows exactly where Beth Kar was.

Ebenezer: Until now the LORD has helped VERSES 12–14

12 Then Samuel took a stone
and set it up between Mizpah and Shen.
He named it Ebenezer and said,
"Until now the LORD has helped us."
13 So the Philistines were brought down.
They did not come into the territory of Israel
anymore.
The hand of the LORD was against the Philistines as
long as Samuel lived.
14 The cities that the Philistines had taken from Israel
were given back to Israel, from Ekron to Gath.
Israel freed its territory from the hand of the
Philistines.
And there was peace between Israel and the Amorites.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Ebenezer" means "stone of help." It was at a place with this very name that Israel had lost the ark in Chapter 4. Now the name gets a new meaning: God has helped.

In Hebrew, "until now" can be understood in two ways: Up to this place God has helped us. And: Up to this time God has helped us. Both are true. The stone is meant to remind them: God has not left us until today. So we can trust him for tomorrow too.

To this day, many Christians say "Ebenezer" or "Until now the LORD has helped us" when they look back on their lives. A well-known English hymn says: "Here I raise my Ebenezer."

"Amorites" here stands for the peoples of Canaan who still lived in the land.

Samuel as judge VERSES 15–17

15 Samuel judged Israel all the days of his life.
16 Year after year he went around in a circle to Bethel,
Gilgal, and Mizpah.
And in all these places he judged cases for Israel.
17 Then he went back to Ramah, because his home was
there.
And there he judged cases for Israel.
And he built an altar to the LORD there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samuel is like a judge who travels through the land. He comes to the people, so that they do not have to go far to get justice.

Bethel, Gilgal, and Mizpah were all in the territory of the tribes of Benjamin and Ephraim, not far from each other. Ramah was his home town.

Samuel is the last and maybe the best of the judges. He leads the people not mainly with the sword, but with prayer and with God's word.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 8

The people want a king

Samuel's sons VERSES 1–3

1 When Samuel was old, he made his sons judges over
Israel.
2 The name of his firstborn son was Joel,
and the name of the second was Abijah.
They were judges in Beersheba.
3 But his sons did not walk in his ways.
They went after dishonest gain,
took bribes,
and twisted justice.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A bribe is money or a gift that someone gives secretly, so that a judge or an official will decide in his favor.

Once again it is the same problem as with Eli: A good father has sons who are not good. Samuel's sons take bribes. Whoever gives them money gets a decision in his favor.

God's law strictly forbids bribes. It says that a bribe makes even wise people blind (Deuteronomy 16:19).

Beersheba was far in the south, a long way from Samuel in Ramah. Maybe Samuel did not know for a long time what they were doing.

"Give us a king!" VERSES 4–9

4 Then all the elders of Israel gathered
and came to Samuel at Ramah.
5 They said to him,
"Look, you have grown old,
and your sons don't walk in your ways.
Now give us a king to judge us,
like all the nations have."
6 But this displeased Samuel when they said,
"Give us a king to judge us."
Samuel prayed to the LORD.
7 The LORD said to Samuel,
"Listen to the voice of the people in all that they tell
you.
For they have not rejected you,
but they have rejected me as king over them.

8 They are doing what they have always done,
from the day I brought them up out of Egypt until this day:
They have left me and served other gods.
Now they are doing the same to you.
9 So listen to their voice now.
But warn them seriously
and show them the way of the king who will rule over them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The elders have a good reason: Samuel is old, and his sons are bad. Who will lead the people after him?

But then they say: "like all the nations have." That is the real problem. Israel was supposed to be different from the other nations. God himself was supposed to be its king.

Samuel is hurt. But God comforts him: They are not rejecting you, but me.

So is a king a bad thing? The Bible does not see it in a simple way. Already in the law of Moses it says that one day Israel may have a king, if he obeys God (Deuteronomy 17:14–20). The problem is not the king himself. The problem is the heart of the people: They want safety through a human being instead of trust in God.

God gives the people what they want. But he has them warned. God does not force anyone. He lets people make their own decisions, even when they are wrong.

What a king will do VERSES 10–18

10 Samuel told all the words of the LORD
to the people who were asking him for a king.
11 He said,
"This will be the way of the king who will rule over you:
He will take your sons and make them his servants,
for his chariots and to be his horsemen.
And they will run in front of his chariots.
12 He will make them captains over thousands and captains over fifties.
He will assign some to plow his ground and to bring in his harvest,
and to make his weapons of war and the equipment for his chariots.
13 He will take your daughters to make perfume, to cook, and to bake.
14 He will take your fields, your vineyards, and your olive groves, the best ones,
and give them to his servants.
15 He will take a tenth of your grain and of your vineyards
and give it to his officials and to his servants.
16 He will take your male servants and your female servants, your best young men, and your donkeys,
and put them to work for himself.
17 He will take a tenth of your flocks.
And you yourselves will be his servants.
18 On that day you will cry out because of your king,
whom you have chosen for yourselves.
But the LORD will not answer you on that day."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samuel describes honestly what kings were like at that time. The word "take" comes up again and again: He takes your sons, your daughters, your fields, your animals. A king needs soldiers, workers, taxes, and land. And in the end you are his servants.

That is exactly what really happened later. King Solomon in particular put heavy taxes and forced labor on the people (1 Kings 12:4).

This is also a warning for today: Whoever has a lot of power is in danger of misusing it. That is why all power needs limits.

"The LORD will not answer you": Whoever knowingly rejects God cannot complain later when he has to bear the results.

The people insist VERSES 19–22

19 But the people refused to listen to the voice of Samuel.
They said,
"No, we want a king over us.
20 Then we will also be like all the nations.
Our king will judge us,
go out in front of us, and fight our battles."
21 Samuel heard all the words of the people
and told them to the LORD.
22 The LORD said to Samuel,
"Listen to their voice and give them a king."
Then Samuel said to the men of Israel,
"Everyone go back to your own city."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people want a king at any price. "Then we will also be like all the nations." And: "Fight our battles." But until now God had fought their battles, just as he did with the thunder in Chapter 7.

Samuel brings the words of the people to God. He stands between the two and speaks for each side.

For the third time God says: "Listen to their voice." Israel gets its king. The next chapter tells how this happens.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 9

Saul looks for donkeys and finds a kingdom

Saul, the son of Kish VERSES 1–4

1 There was a man from the tribe of Benjamin.
His name was Kish.
He was the son of Abiel, the son of Zeror, the son of Becorath,
the son of Aphiah, the son of a man from Benjamin.
Kish was a strong and brave man.
2 He had a son named Saul.
Saul was an impressive young man.
No one among the people of Israel was more handsome

than he was.
He was a head taller than everyone else.
3 One day the donkeys of Saul's father Kish were lost.
Kish said to his son Saul,
"Take one of the servants with you.
Go and look for the donkeys."
4 Saul went through the hill country of Ephraim
and through the land of Shalishah.
But they did not find the donkeys.
Then they went through the land of Shaalim,
but the donkeys were not there.
Then Saul went through the land of Benjamin,
but they did not find them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Saul comes from the tribe of Benjamin, the tribe that had almost been wiped out at the end of the book of Judges (Judges 20–21). God chooses the first king from this very small tribe.

Saul looks like a king: tall, handsome, and strong. He is exactly what people wish for. Later God will say: "Man looks at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart" (1 Samuel 16:7).

The Hebrew says more exactly: female donkeys. At that time donkeys were valuable, like a car or a tractor today.

Today no one knows exactly where Shalishah and Shaalim were.

The servant's advice VERSES 5–10

5 They came to the land of Zuph.
Saul said to the servant who was with him,
"Come on! Let's go back home.
Otherwise my father will stop worrying about the donkeys
and start worrying about us."
6 But the servant said,
"Listen, there is a man of God in this city.
People respect him very much.
Everything he says really happens.
Let's go there now.
Maybe he can tell us which way to go."
7 Saul said to his servant,
"But if we go, what can we bring the man?
The bread in our bags is all gone.
We have no gift to bring to the man of God.
What do we have?"
8 The servant answered Saul,
"Look, I have a quarter of a shekel of silver here.
I will give it to the man of God.
Then he will tell us which way to go."
9 (In earlier times in Israel, people went to ask God for advice.
Then they said, "Come! Let's go to the seer."
The person we call a prophet today used to be called a seer.)
10 Saul said to his servant,
"Good idea. Come on, let's go."
So they went to the city where the man of God was.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The land of Zuph was the area that Samuel's family came from (1 Samuel 1:1). The city is probably Ramah.

Saul does not know Samuel. He does not know the great prophet whom all Israel, from Dan to Beersheba, knew (1 Samuel 3:20). The servant knows more than Saul. This says something about Saul: He probably did not care much about God.

A quarter of a shekel is about a tenth of an ounce of silver. A shekel was a weight used at that time. It was usual to bring a prophet a small gift.

Verse 9 is an explanation by the storyteller for later readers: A "seer" is someone who sees what others do not see. Later people called this a "prophet."

The girls at the well VERSES 11–14

11 They went up the hill to the city.
On the way they met some young women.
The women were coming out to get water.
Saul and his servant asked them, "Is the seer here?"
12 The women answered,
"Yes, he is. He is just ahead of you.
Hurry!
He has just come to the city today,
because the people are offering a sacrifice today at the high place.
13 As soon as you go into the city, you will find him.
He has not yet gone up to the high place to eat.
The people will not eat until he comes,
because he blesses the sacrifice.
After that, the guests eat.
So go up now.
At this time you will find him."
14 So they went up to the city.
As they were going into the city,
Samuel came out toward them.
He was on his way up to the high place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A "high place" was a place on a hill where people offered sacrifices to God. Later such places were often used for foreign gods and were forbidden. But at that time, when there was no temple, people also offered sacrifices to the LORD there.

After the sacrifice there was a shared feast. Samuel, as the prophet, first said the prayer of blessing.

Everything fits together exactly: The donkeys run away, Saul searches for three days, he comes to this city on exactly this day, and Samuel comes toward him at exactly this moment. For the reader it is clear: This is no accident.

God had announced Saul VERSES 15–21

15 The day before Saul came, the LORD had told Samuel this:
16 "Tomorrow at about this time I will send you a man from the land of Benjamin.
Anoint him to be the leader of my people Israel.
He will save my people from the power of the Philistines.
I have seen my people.
I have heard them cry out to me."
To anoint means: to pour oil on someone's head as a sign that God has chosen this person.
17 When Samuel saw Saul, the LORD said to him,
"This is the man I told you about!
He will rule over my people."

18 Saul came up to Samuel in the city gate.
He said, "Please tell me where the seer's house is."
19 Samuel answered Saul,
"I am the seer.
Go up ahead of me to the high place.
Today you will eat with me.
In the morning I will let you go.
And I will tell you everything that is on your mind.
20 Your donkeys were lost three days ago.
Don't worry about them.
They have been found.
And who is it that all Israel longs for?
Isn't it you and your father's whole family?"
21 Saul answered,
"But I am from Benjamin.
That is the smallest of the tribes of Israel.
And my family is the least important of all the families in the tribe of Benjamin.
So why do you speak to me like this?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Hebrew, "told" literally says: "He had uncovered Samuel's ear." God had trusted Samuel with a secret.

God does not say "king," but "leader" (Hebrew "nagid"; the WEB, our English source text, says "prince"). This means: Saul is to be a leader who is under God. God himself remains the real king.

God says: I have heard the cry of my people. Even though the people have rejected him as king, God keeps caring for them.

Saul is humble: I am only from the smallest tribe and from an unimportant family. That sounds good. Gideon had answered in a similar way (Judges 6:15). But later we will see that Saul often feels small and unsure, and that is why he makes wrong decisions.

The feast VERSES 22–27

22 Samuel took Saul and his servant into the guest hall.
He had them sit in the best place among the guests.
There were about 30 guests.
23 Samuel said to the cook,
"Bring the piece of meat I gave you.
I told you to set it aside."
24 So the cook brought the thigh and what was on it.
He set it in front of Saul.
Samuel said,
"Here is what was kept for you!
Eat it.
It was saved for you for this special time.
I said, 'I have invited the people.'"
So Saul ate with Samuel that day.
25 Then they came down from the high place into the city.
Samuel talked with Saul on the roof of the house.
26 Early the next morning, at about sunrise,
Samuel called to Saul on the roof.
He said, "Get up. I will send you on your way."
Saul got up.
Then he and Samuel went outside together.
27 They were walking down to the edge of the city.
Samuel said to Saul,
"Tell the servant to go on ahead of us."
So the servant went ahead.
Then Samuel said,
"But you stay here for a moment.
I will tell you God's message."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Saul gets the place of honor and the best piece of meat. Samuel had already had it set aside for him the day before. All the guests see: This young man is someone special.

The thigh, the leg, was a piece of honor. At a sacrifice it actually belonged to the priests (Leviticus 7:32). Samuel gives it to Saul.

Verse 24 is hard to understand in Hebrew. Bible translators translate the last part in different ways.

In the flat-roofed houses of that time, the roof was a place to talk and to sleep. The old Greek translation says in verse 25: They made a bed for Saul on the roof, and he lay down to sleep.

At the end Samuel sends the servant away. What comes now is meant to stay secret: Saul is anointed king. The next chapter tells about it.

1 SAMUEL

Chapter 10

Saul is anointed and chosen as king

Samuel anoints Saul VERSES 1–8

1 Then Samuel took the little bottle of oil
and poured it on his head.
Then he kissed him and said,
"Hasn't the LORD anointed you to be prince over his inheritance?
2 When you leave me today,
you will find two men by Rachel's tomb,
on the border of Benjamin at Zelzah.
They will tell you,
'The donkeys you went to look for have been found.
And look, your father has stopped worrying about the donkeys
and is worried about you.
He is saying, "What shall I do for my son?"'
3 "Then you will go on from there
and come to the oak of Tabor.
Three men will meet you there
who are going up to God at Bethel.
One is carrying three young goats,
one is carrying three loaves of bread,
and one is carrying a container of wine.
4 They will greet you
and give you two loaves of bread.
You shall take them from their hand.
5 "After that you will come to the hill of God,
where the Philistine outpost is.

And this will happen:
When you come there to the city,
you will meet a group of prophets
coming down from the high place.
They will have a lute, a tambourine, a flute, and a harp
in front of them,
and they will be prophesying.
6 Then the Spirit of the LORD will come on you with
power.
Then you will prophesy with them
and will be turned into a different man.
7 When these signs happen to you,
then do what the moment calls for.
For God is with you.
8 Go down ahead of me to Gilgal.
And look, I will come down to you
to offer burnt offerings and to sacrifice peace
offerings.
You shall wait seven days until I come to you
and show you what you are to do."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

To "anoint" means: to pour oil on someone's head. This was a sign that God chooses a person for a special task. Priests were anointed, later kings, and sometimes prophets. The Hebrew word for "anointed one" is "mashiach," Messiah.

The anointing happens in secret. Only Samuel and Saul know about it.

"His inheritance" means the people of Israel. It belongs to God. Saul is to lead it for God, not for himself.

Samuel gives Saul three signs. When they happen, Saul knows: All this really comes from God.

The old Greek translation has a longer text in verse 1: Samuel tells Saul clearly that he is to save the people from the hand of their enemies, and that the signs will confirm this.

"The hill of God" was probably Gibeah, Saul's hometown. The Philistines had a military outpost there. This shows how much the Philistines ruled the land.

The prophets make music and speak about God with great excitement. This was a special kind of worship, in which people were completely taken hold of by the Spirit of God.

Verse 8 is important for later: Saul is to wait seven days for Samuel in Gilgal. In Chapter 13 this becomes the great test for Saul.

The signs happen VERSES 9–13

9 And this is what happened:
When he turned to leave Samuel,
God gave him another heart.
And all these signs happened on that day.
10 When they came there to the hill,
a group of prophets came to meet him.
The Spirit of God came on him with power,
and he prophesied among them.
11 All who had known him before saw
that he was prophesying with the prophets.
Then the people said to one another,
"What has happened to the son of Kish?
Is Saul also among the prophets?"
12 One man from there answered,
"And who is their father?"
So it became a saying:
"Is Saul also among the prophets?"
13 When he had finished prophesying,
he came to the high place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"God gave him another heart": Saul is changed on the inside. God prepares him for his task.

The people are amazed: Saul, the son of a rich farmer, suddenly speaks like a prophet? That does not fit him.

"Who is their father?" is a difficult question. Maybe it means: You do not become a prophet because of your family. The Spirit comes from God, not from your father. So Saul can be a prophet too.

"Is Saul also among the prophets?" became a saying. People said it when someone did something completely unexpected. 1 Samuel 19:24 tells how the saying is used once more.

Saul keeps quiet about the kingdom VERSES 14–16

14 Saul's uncle said to him and to his servant,
"Where did you go?"
He said,
"To look for the donkeys.
When we saw that they could not be found, we went to
Samuel."
15 Saul's uncle said,
"Please tell me what Samuel said to you."
16 Saul said to his uncle,
"He told us plainly that the donkeys had been found."
But about the matter of the kingdom, which Samuel
had spoken about,
he told him nothing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Saul keeps the great secret to himself. Is that humility? Or fear? Or wisdom, because the Philistines are still in the land? The text does not say.

Saul is chosen by lot VERSES 17–24

17 Samuel called the people together to the LORD at
Mizpah.
18 He said to the people of Israel,
"This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says:
'I brought Israel up out of Egypt.
I saved you from the hand of the Egyptians
and from the hand of all the kingdoms that oppressed
you.'
19 But today you have rejected your God,
who himself saves you from all your troubles and your
distress.
And you have said to him,
'No! Set a king over us!'
So now stand before the LORD
by your tribes and by your clans."
20 So Samuel had all the tribes of Israel come forward,
and the tribe of Benjamin was chosen.
21 He had the tribe of Benjamin come forward by its
families,
and the family of the Matrites was chosen.
Then Saul the son of Kish was chosen.
But when they looked for him, he could not be found.

22 So they asked the LORD again,
"Has the man come here yet?"
The LORD answered,
"Look, he has hidden himself among the baggage."
23 They ran and brought him from there.
When he stood among the people,
he was taller than any of the people from his shoulders up.
24 Samuel said to all the people,
"Do you see the one the LORD has chosen?
There is no one like him among all the people."
Then all the people shouted,
"Long live the king!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samuel reminds the people once more: God has always saved you. And still you want a king. He says it clearly before he gives them what they wish for.

Now what Samuel had already done in secret is shown in public. By lot the choice falls on Saul. So all the people see: God himself chose him, not Samuel.

Casting lots was a way of finding out God's will. "Chosen" here means: The lot fell on him. This is also how the guilty man, Achan, was found back then (Joshua 7).

But then comes the surprise: The new king has hidden himself among the baggage! Maybe out of humility, maybe out of fear. Saul has already been anointed and has seen the signs. Still he hides. This shows an unsureness that will stay with him all his life.

"Long live the king!" The people cheer. They see a tall, handsome man. This is exactly the kind of king they wanted.

The rules of the kingdom VERSES 25–27

25 Then Samuel explained to the people the rules of the kingdom.
He wrote them in a book and laid it before the LORD.
Then Samuel sent all the people away, each one to his house.
26 Saul also went to his house in Gibeah.
The army went with him,
the men whose hearts God had touched.
27 But some worthless fellows said,
"How can this man save us?"
They looked down on him and brought him no gift.
But he kept quiet about it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samuel writes down the rules for the king. This is to make it clear: The king, too, is under God's law. He cannot do whatever he wants. This is a very early form of what today we call a constitution.

Not everyone is excited. Some look down on Saul. Saul reacts wisely: He keeps quiet and does not let himself be provoked.

In an old manuscript from the Dead Sea there is an extra section after verse 27: Nahash, the king of the Ammonites, had already badly oppressed the tribes of Gad and Reuben and had gouged out the right eye of many men. The Jewish historian Josephus also knows this story. The WEB, our English source text, does not have this section.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 11

Saul rescues the city of Jabesh

The Ammonite's threat VERSES 1–5

1 Then Nahash the Ammonite came up
and surrounded Jabesh Gilead.
All the men of Jabesh said to Nahash,
"Make a covenant with us, and we will serve you."
2 Nahash the Ammonite said to them,
"I will make a covenant with you on this condition:
that the right eye of every one of you is gouged out.
That is how I will bring shame on all Israel."
3 The elders of Jabesh said to him,
"Give us seven days.
Then we can send messengers through the whole territory of Israel.
If there is no one to save us,
then we will come out to you."
4 Then the messengers came to Gibeah, Saul's town,
and spoke these words in the hearing of the people.
Then all the people cried out loud and wept.
5 Just then Saul was coming in from the field behind the oxen.
Saul said,
"What is wrong with the people? Why are they weeping?"
They told him the words of the men of Jabesh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Ammonites lived east of the Jordan. Jabesh Gilead was an Israelite city there, near the border.

Nahash does not only want to defeat the men of Jabesh, but to humiliate them cruelly. In battle a man held his shield in front of his left eye. Without his right eye he could not see anything anymore. He was useless as a soldier. And the injury was meant to be a shame for all Israel.

Nahash is so sure of himself that he even gives them seven days to look for help. He does not believe that Israel will help them.

Why do the men of Jabesh send messengers to Gibeah of all places? Maybe because of an old connection: At the end of the book of Judges the men of Benjamin got wives from Jabesh (Judges 21:12–14). Many people in Gibeah may have had ancestors from Jabesh.

Saul has been chosen king, but he still works as a farmer in the field. There is no palace and no army yet.

Saul calls Israel together VERSES 6–11

6 The Spirit of God came on Saul with power when he heard these words,
and he became very angry.
7 He took a pair of oxen,
cut them into pieces,
and sent the pieces by messengers through the whole

territory of Israel with the message:
"Whoever doesn't come out after Saul and after Samuel,
this is what will be done to his oxen."
Then the fear of the LORD fell on the people,
and they came out as one man.
8 He counted them at Bezek.
The people of Israel were 300,000 men,
and the men of Judah 30,000.
9 They said to the messengers who had come,
"Tell the men of Jabesh Gilead:
'Tomorrow, by the time the sun is hot, you will be rescued.'"
The messengers came and told the men of Jabesh,
and they were glad.
10 So the men of Jabesh said,
"Tomorrow we will come out to you.
Then you can do with us whatever seems good to you."
11 The next day Saul divided the people into three groups.
In the morning watch they broke into the middle of the camp
and struck down the Ammonites until the heat of the day.
Those who were left were scattered,
so that not even two of them were left together.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Once again the Spirit of God comes on Saul, as with the judges Othniel, Gideon, Jephthah, and Samson. Now Saul shows that he can be a rescuer.

His anger is a just anger: He cannot stand by and watch people being tortured.

Saul cuts oxen into pieces and sends the pieces through Israel. This strongly reminds us of Judges 19:29. Back then a man in Gibeah had cut up a woman's body. Now a man from Gibeah takes oxen. He does not threaten the people, but their oxen.

Saul also names Samuel. He does not act alone, but together with the prophet.

The numbers are very large. Some Bible teachers think that the Hebrew word for "thousand" here rather means "unit" or "troop." The old Greek translation has 600,000 and 70,000.

The "morning watch" was the last watch of the night, shortly before sunrise. An attack at this time was a surprise.

The men of Jabesh chose the words of their promise "Tomorrow we will come out to you" on purpose, so that it could mean two things. They came out, but not to surrender.

No revenge on the day of rescue VERSES 12–15

12 The people said to Samuel,
"Who was it who said, 'Shall Saul rule over us?'
Bring those men here, so that we can put them to death!"
13 Saul said,
"No one shall be put to death today.
For today the LORD has rescued Israel."
14 Then Samuel said to the people,
"Come! Let's go to Gilgal
and renew the kingdom there."
15 So all the people went to Gilgal.
And there they made Saul king before the LORD in Gilgal.
There they offered peace offerings before the LORD.
And there Saul and all the men of Israel rejoiced greatly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the victory some people want revenge on those who had looked down on Saul (1 Samuel 10:27). But Saul says: No. Today is a day of joy, because God has rescued us. This is a great moment for Saul. He is merciful and gives the glory to God, not to himself.

This scene shows: Saul had good qualities. At the beginning he was humble, brave, and generous. That makes it all the sadder how he changes later.

Gilgal was an important place. There Israel had its first camp in the land after crossing the Jordan (Joshua 4:19).

The men of Jabesh never forgot that Saul rescued them. Many years later, when Saul was dead, they risked their lives to take his body back from the Philistines and gave him an honorable burial (1 Samuel 31:11–13).

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 12

Samuel's farewell speech

"Whom have I cheated?" VERSES 1–5

1 Samuel said to all the people of Israel,
"I have listened to you.
I have done everything you asked me to do.
I have given you a king.
2 Now you have a king to lead you.
I am old, and my hair is gray.
My sons are here with you.
I have led you since I was young until today.
3 Here I am.
If I have done wrong, speak up now in front of the LORD and in front of his anointed king.
Whose ox have I taken?
Whose donkey have I taken?
Whom have I cheated?
Whom have I treated harshly?
Have I ever taken a bribe from anyone
to look the other way?
If I have, I will give it back to you."
4 They answered,
"You have not cheated us.
You have not treated us harshly.
You have not taken anything from anyone."
5 Samuel said to them,
"Today the LORD is a witness against you.
And his anointed king is a witness too.
You have not found that I took anything."
They said, "He is a witness."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samuel is giving up his office. But first he wants to make it clear in public: Have I done wrong to anyone in my life?

His questions remind us of Samuel's warning in Chapter 8: The king will "take." But Samuel never took anything. He was an honest leader. The people confirm it in front of everyone.

This is an example for everyone who has responsibility: At the end you should be able to say: I have not made myself rich, I have not cheated anyone.

"His anointed" here is King Saul.

God has always saved VERSES 6–13

6 Samuel said to the people,
"The LORD chose Moses and Aaron.
He brought your ancestors out of the land of Egypt.
7 So now stand still.
I will argue my case with you in front of the LORD.
I will remind you of all the good and right things the LORD has done
for you and for your ancestors.
8 Jacob went to Egypt.
Later your ancestors cried out to the LORD for help.
Then the LORD sent Moses and Aaron.
They brought your ancestors out of Egypt
and let them live in this place.
9 But your ancestors forgot the LORD their God.
So the LORD handed them over to Sisera, the commander of the army of Hazor.
He handed them over to the Philistines
and to the king of Moab.
These enemies fought against them.
10 Then your ancestors cried out to the LORD.
They said,
'We have sinned.
We have turned away from the LORD.
We have served the Baals and the Ashtaroth.
But now save us from our enemies,
and we will serve you.'
11 So the LORD sent Jerubbaal, Bedan, Jephthah, and Samuel.
He saved you from the enemies all around you.
And you lived in safety.
12 Then you saw that Nahash, the king of the people of Ammon, was coming to attack you.
So you said to me,
'No, we want a king to rule over us.'
But the LORD your God was already your king.
13 So now, here is the king you chose.
You asked for him.
Now the LORD has given you a king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samuel tells the whole history of Israel once more in short: Egypt, the time of the judges, always the same pattern. The people forget God, get into trouble, cry out to God, and God saves them.

The message is: You never needed a human king. God was your king, and he always saved you.

Jerubbaal is another name for Gideon (Judges 6:32).

"Bedan" does not appear as a judge anywhere else. The old Greek translation and other old translations have "Barak" here. That fits well, because Barak fought together with Deborah against Sisera (Judges 4), and Sisera is named in verse 9.

It is unusual that Samuel names himself. Some old translations have "Samson" here.

Verse 12 shows: The attack by Nahash was one of the reasons why the people wanted a king.

If you obey God VERSES 14–15

14 "If you have respect for the LORD and serve him,
if you listen to what he says
and do not go against the LORD's commands,
then both you and the king who rules over you
will follow the LORD your God.
15 But maybe you will not listen to what the LORD says.
Maybe you will go against the LORD's commands.
Then the LORD will turn against you,
just as he turned against your ancestors.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now comes the good news: Even with a king, everything can turn out well. The condition is the same as always: Listen to God. And that means the people and the king together.

The king does not stand above God. He is bound by God's commandments just like every other person.

Thunder at the wheat harvest VERSES 16–19

16 "So now stand still and watch.
The LORD will do a great thing right in front of you.
17 It is time for the wheat harvest now, isn't it?
I will call to the LORD.
He will send thunder and rain.
Then you will see and understand
that you did a very wicked thing in the eyes of the LORD
when you asked for a king."
18 So Samuel called to the LORD.
And that same day the LORD sent thunder and rain.
Then all the people were very afraid of the LORD and of Samuel.
19 All the people said to Samuel,
"Pray for your servants to the LORD your God.
Pray that we will not die.
We have added this evil to all our sins:
we have asked for a king."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The wheat harvest was in May and June. In Israel it almost never rains at this time. A thunderstorm in the middle of the harvest was unusual and could ruin the harvest. That is why the people realize: This is a sign from God.

The people become afraid and finally admit: It was wrong to ask for a king. They say to Samuel: "Pray for your servants to the LORD your God." It almost sounds as if the LORD were no longer their own God.

Don't be afraid VERSES 20–25

20 Samuel said to the people,
"Don't be afraid.
It is true that you have done all this evil.
But don't stop following the LORD.
Serve the LORD with all your heart.

21 Don't turn away and run after empty things.
They cannot help you or save you,
because they are empty.
22 The LORD will not abandon his people,
for his great name's sake.
It has pleased the LORD to make you his own people.
23 And I will never sin against the LORD
by no longer praying for you.
I will go on teaching you the way that is good and
right.
24 Only have respect for the LORD.
Serve him faithfully with all your heart.
Think about the great things he has done for you.
25 But if you keep on doing evil,
you will be destroyed, both you and your king."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the most beautiful passages about God's grace. Samuel says: Yes, you have sinned. But don't give up now. Don't turn away. God does not abandon his people.

Why not? Not because the people are so good. But "for his great name's sake," and because "it has pleased the LORD" to make them his people. God's love does not depend on whether we deserve it.

"Empty things" are the idols. They are empty, they cannot help.

Verse 23 is a special sentence: Samuel says it would be a sin if he stopped praying for the people. Even though the people rejected him as leader, he keeps praying for them. That is real love.

Samuel steps down as judge, but he remains a prophet and teacher. The king rules, but the prophet tells him God's word. This division of tasks runs through the whole time of the kings.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 13

Saul does not wait

Saul and Jonathan against the Philistines VERSES 1–7

1 Saul was 30 years old when he became king,
and he ruled over Israel for 42 years.
2 Saul chose 3,000 men of Israel for himself.
Of them, 2,000 were with Saul in Michmash and in the
hill country of Bethel,
and 1,000 were with Jonathan in Gibeah of Benjamin.
He sent the rest of the people home, each one to his
own tent.
3 Jonathan struck down the Philistine outpost that was
in Geba.
And the Philistines heard about it.
Saul had the trumpet blown throughout the whole
land and said,
"Let the Hebrews hear!"
4 All Israel heard:
"Saul has struck down the Philistine outpost."
And they also heard that Israel had become hated by
the Philistines.
The people were called together to follow Saul to
Gilgal.
5 The Philistines gathered to fight against Israel:
30,000 chariots, 6,000 horsemen,
and soldiers as many as the sand on the seashore.
They came up and camped in Michmash, east of Beth
Aven.
6 The men of Israel saw that they were in trouble,
for the people were hard pressed.
So the people hid in caves, in bushes, in rocks, in
tombs, and in pits.
7 Some of the Hebrews even went over the Jordan to the
land of Gad and Gilead.
But Saul was still in Gilgal,
and all the people followed him trembling.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1 is damaged in the Hebrew text. According to the Hebrew text, Saul was one year old when he became king. And he ruled for two years. Numbers are obviously missing. The WEB, our English source text, has put in the numbers 30 and 42, like some other translations. The New Testament says that Saul ruled for 40 years (Acts 13:21). We do not know for sure how old he really was and exactly how long he ruled.

Jonathan is Saul's son. He is named here for the first time. He is brave and attacks a Philistine outpost. But Saul has it announced: "Saul has struck down." He takes the honor for himself.

Now the Philistines come with a huge army. The number 30,000 chariots is very high. Some old translations have 3,000. That fits better with the 6,000 horsemen.

The Israelites panic. They hide everywhere or flee over the Jordan.

Saul offers the sacrifice himself VERSES 8–14

8 He waited seven days, until the time that Samuel had
set.
But Samuel did not come to Gilgal,
and the people were running away from him.
9 So Saul said,
"Bring the burnt offering and the peace offerings here
to me."
And he offered the burnt offering.
10 And this is what happened:
Just as he finished offering the burnt offering,
Samuel came.
Saul went out to meet him and greet him.
11 Samuel said, "What have you done?"
Saul said,
"I saw that the people were running away from me,
and you did not come at the set time,
and the Philistines had gathered at Michmash.

12 So I thought,
'Now the Philistines will come down against me at Gilgal,
and I have not yet asked the LORD for his favor.'
So I forced myself and offered the burnt offering."
13 Samuel said to Saul,
"You have acted foolishly.
You have not kept the commandment of the LORD your God
that he commanded you.
For now the LORD would have made your kingdom over Israel firm forever.
14 But now your kingdom will not last.
The LORD has looked for a man after his own heart.
And the LORD has appointed him to be prince over his people,
because you have not kept what the LORD commanded you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samuel had told Saul: Wait seven days in Gilgal until I come (1 Samuel 10:8). Saul waits. But on the seventh day Samuel is still not there. The soldiers run away. The Philistines come closer. Saul gets nervous and acts on his own.

We can understand Saul. His situation really was difficult. Why is the judgment so harsh?

Saul did not wait until the end. He did not trust God's instruction. He wanted to force God's help with a sacrifice instead of waiting for God's word through the prophet. The king was supposed to be under God's word. But when things get tight, Saul puts himself above it.

And Saul does not admit that he did something wrong. He blames others: the people, who ran away, and Samuel, who came too late.

"A man after his own heart": This means David. He is named only in Chapter 16. In the New Testament this sentence about David is quoted (Acts 13:22). This does not mean that David made no mistakes. It means: He was a man whose heart turned back to God again and again.

Without weapons against the Philistines VERSES 15–23

15 Samuel got up and went from Gilgal to Gibeah of Benjamin.
Saul counted the people who were with him, about 600 men.
16 Saul and his son Jonathan and the people who were with them
stayed in Geba of Benjamin.
But the Philistines camped in Michmash.
17 The raiders came out of the Philistine camp in three groups.
One group turned onto the road to Ophrah, to the land of Shual.
18 Another group turned onto the road to Beth Horon.
And another group turned onto the road to the border that looks down on the valley of Zeboim, toward the wilderness.
19 There was no blacksmith in the whole land of Israel.
For the Philistines said,
"Otherwise the Hebrews will make themselves swords or spears."
20 So all the Israelites went down to the Philistines,
each one to have his plowshare, his hoe, his ax, and his sickle sharpened.
21 The price was one payim each for sharpening hoes, plowshares, pitchforks, axes, and goads.
22 So on the day of battle this is what happened:
Not one sword or spear was found in the hand of any of the people
who were with Saul and Jonathan.
Only Saul and his son Jonathan had them.
23 The Philistine outpost went out to the pass of Michmash.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Of the many soldiers, only 600 are left. The Philistines send out groups that rob the land.

The Philistines have full control over iron. They do not let the Israelites have any blacksmiths, so that they cannot make weapons. Whoever wants to have a tool sharpened has to go to the Philistines and pay.

A "payim" was a small weight. Archaeologists have found small stone weights with the word "pim" on them. A pim was about two-thirds of a shekel, around a quarter of an ounce of silver. Before these finds, no one knew what this word meant.

Verse 21 is hard to understand in Hebrew. "Goads" were sticks with a point that people used to drive cattle.

Israel's situation is hopeless: few soldiers, no weapons, a huge army against them. If rescue comes now, it can only come from God.

1 SAMUEL

Chapter 14

Jonathan's brave deed and Saul's oath

Jonathan and his armor bearer VERSES 1–15

1 One day Jonathan the son of Saul said to the young man who carried his armor,
"Come! Let's go over to the Philistine outpost on the other side."
But he did not tell his father.
2 Saul was staying at the edge of Gibeah under the pomegranate tree that is in Migron.
And the people who were with him were about 600 men.
3 Ahijah was also there, the son of Ahitub, the brother of Ichabod,
the son of Phinehas, the son of Eli, the priest of the LORD in Shiloh.
He was wearing an ephod.
The people did not know that Jonathan had gone.
4 Between the passes by which Jonathan wanted to go over to the Philistine outpost,

there was a rocky cliff on one side and a rocky cliff on the other side.
The name of the one was Bozez, and the name of the other was Seneh.
5 One cliff rose up on the north, facing Michmash,
and the other on the south, facing Geba.
6 Jonathan said to the young man who carried his armor,
"Come! Let's go over to the outpost of these uncircumcised men.
Maybe the LORD will act for us.
For nothing can stop the LORD from saving, whether by many or by few."
7 His armor bearer said to him,
"Do all that is in your heart.
Go, and look, I am with you, whatever you decide."
8 Then Jonathan said,
"Look, we will cross over to the men and let them see us.
9 If they say to us,
'Wait until we come to you!'
then we will stay where we are and not go up to them.
10 But if they say,
'Come up to us!'
then we will go up.
For then the LORD has given them into our hand.
This will be the sign for us."
11 The two of them let the Philistine outpost see them.
The Philistines said,
"Look, the Hebrews are coming out of the holes where they have been hiding!"
12 The men of the outpost called to Jonathan and his armor bearer,
"Come up to us, and we will show you something!"
Jonathan said to his armor bearer,
"Climb up after me,
for the LORD has given them into the hand of Israel."
13 Jonathan climbed up on his hands and feet, and his armor bearer after him.
The Philistines fell in front of Jonathan,
and his armor bearer killed them behind him.
14 In that first attack, Jonathan and his armor bearer killed about 20 men,
in an area of about half a furrow's length in a field.
15 Then there was terror in the camp, in the field, and among all the people.
The outpost and the raiders also trembled.
And the earth shook.
So there was a very great terror.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

While Saul sits under a tree doing nothing, his son Jonathan acts. He trusts in God. His sentence is famous: "Nothing can stop the LORD from saving, whether by many or by few." For God, numbers do not matter.

Ahijah is a great-grandson of Eli. So Eli's family is still serving as priests. Here the "ephod" is an object that people used to ask God for answers.

Jonathan asks God for a sign. He does not go carelessly, but wants to know whether God is with him.

The rocks had names: "Bozez" may mean "the shining one," "Seneh" means "the thorny one." You can still see this narrow pass in the land today.

The Philistines make fun of the Israelites: They come out of their holes like mice. But then everything happens very quickly. God sends an earthquake, and panic breaks out.

In Hebrew, "a very great terror" literally says: "a terror of God." This means: a terror that God sent, or also: an enormous terror.

The Philistines flee VERSES 16–23

16 Saul's watchmen in Gibeah of Benjamin looked over.
And they saw the crowd melting away and running here and there.
17 Then Saul said to the people who were with him,
"Count now, and see who is missing from us."
When they had counted, Jonathan and his armor bearer were not there.
18 Saul said to Ahijah,
"Bring the ark of God here."
For the ark of God was with the people of Israel at that time.
19 While Saul was still talking to the priest,
the noise in the Philistine camp kept getting louder.
So Saul said to the priest,
"Withdraw your hand!"
20 Saul and all the people who were with him gathered and went into the battle.
And they saw that every man was striking the other with his sword,
in very great confusion.
21 The Hebrews who had been with the Philistines before and had gone up with them into the camp from all around
also changed sides and joined the Israelites who were with Saul and Jonathan.
22 All the men of Israel who had hidden in the hill country of Ephraim
also heard that the Philistines were fleeing.
And they too chased after them in the battle.
23 So the LORD saved Israel that day.
And the battle moved on beyond Beth Aven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Saul wants to ask God. But when the situation becomes urgent, he says to the priest: "Withdraw your hand!" That means: Stop, I have no more time. Once again Saul has no patience to wait for God's answer.

In verse 18 the old Greek translation has "ephod" instead of "ark." That fits better, because people asked God with the ephod, and the ark was in Kiriath Jearim (1 Samuel 7:1–2).

The Philistines panic so much that they kill each other. This is like the story of Gideon (Judges 7:22).

"So the LORD saved Israel": Not Saul, not even Jonathan, but God. That is the main point.

Saul's rash oath VERSES 24–30

24 The men of Israel were very worn out that day.
For Saul had made the people take an oath and had said,
"Cursed is the man who eats any food before evening,
until I am avenged of my enemies."
So none of the people ate anything.
25 All the people came into the forest.
There was honey on the ground.

26 When the people came into the forest,
the honey was dripping.
But no one put his hand to his mouth,
because the people were afraid of the oath.
27 But Jonathan had not heard his father make the people take the oath.
So he stretched out the end of the stick that was in his hand,
dipped it into the honeycomb,
and put his hand to his mouth.
And his eyes brightened.
28 Then one of the people said,
"Your father strictly made the people take an oath and said,
'Cursed is the man who eats food today.'"
And the people were worn out.
29 Then Jonathan said,
"My father has brought trouble on the land.
Look how my eyes have brightened
because I tasted a little of this honey.
30 How much better it would have been
if the people had eaten freely today
from the plunder they found from their enemies!
For now the defeat of the Philistines has not been great."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Saul wants to look especially devoted to God and forbids all soldiers to eat. But this is not sensible. Whoever has to fight needs strength. And he says: "until I am avenged of my enemies." It is about himself.

Jonathan knew nothing about the oath. He eats a little honey and gets new strength. "His eyes brightened" means: He is awake and fresh again.

Jonathan says openly: My father has harmed the people. He is right.

Once again there is a rash oath, as with Jephthah (Judges 11) and with the oath against Benjamin (Judges 21). The Bible warns again and again: Think carefully before you swear something.

The people eat meat with the blood VERSES 31–35

31 That day they struck down the Philistines from Michmash to Aijalon.
The people were very worn out.
32 So the people rushed at the plunder.
They took sheep, cattle, and calves,
killed them on the ground,
and the people ate them with the blood.
33 Then someone told Saul,
"Look, the people are sinning against the LORD
by eating the meat with the blood."
He said,
"You have been unfaithful.
Roll a large stone over to me today!"
34 Saul said,
"Spread out among the people and tell them,
'Each of you bring his ox and each his sheep to me,
and kill it here and eat.
And don't sin against the LORD by eating the meat with the blood.'"
So that night all the people each brought his ox with him
and killed it there.
35 Saul built an altar to the LORD.
This was the first altar that he built to the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The results of Saul's oath: In the evening the soldiers are so starving that they kill the animals and eat them right away, without letting the blood drain out. This was strictly forbidden. The blood stands for life and belongs to God (Leviticus 17:10–14; Genesis 9:4).

Saul's oath, which was meant to be devoted to God, drove the people into sin.

Saul makes sure that the animals are killed on a large stone, so that the blood can drain out. Here he acts rightly.

The sentence "This was the first altar that he built" sounds almost like a quiet criticism: Saul has been king for a while, but only now does he build an altar to God for the first time.

Jonathan is to die VERSES 36–46

36 Saul said,
"Let's go down after the Philistines by night
and plunder them until the morning light.
Let's not leave a single man of them."
They said, "Do whatever seems good to you."
Then the priest said,
"Let's come near to God here."
37 Saul asked God,
"Shall I go down after the Philistines?
Will you give them into the hand of Israel?"
But he did not answer him that day.
38 Saul said,
"Come here, all you leaders of the people,
and find out and see who has committed this sin today.
39 For as the LORD lives, who saves Israel:
even if it is my son Jonathan, he must surely die."
But not one man among all the people answered him.
40 Then he said to all Israel,
"You stand on one side,
and I and my son Jonathan will stand on the other side."
The people said to Saul, "Do what seems good to you."
41 So Saul said to the LORD, the God of Israel,
"Show what is right."
Jonathan and Saul were chosen, and the people went free.
42 Saul said,
"Cast lots between me and my son Jonathan."
And Jonathan was chosen.
43 Then Saul said to Jonathan,
"Tell me what you have done!"
Jonathan told him and said,
"I did taste a little honey with the end of the stick that was in my hand.
And look, I must die."
44 Saul said,
"May God do so to me and even more:
You must surely die, Jonathan."
45 But the people said to Saul,
"Shall Jonathan die, who has brought about this great rescue in Israel?
Far from it!

As the LORD lives,
not one hair of his head shall fall to the ground.
For he has worked with God today."
So the people rescued Jonathan, and he did not die.
46 Then Saul stopped chasing the Philistines.
And the Philistines went back to their own place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God does not answer Saul. Saul thinks: Someone has sinned. And right away he swears another hasty oath: Whoever it is must die, even my son.

The lot falls on Jonathan. He honestly admits what he has done. After all, he knew nothing about the oath.

In verse 41 the old Greek translation has a longer text. There Saul asks God to answer with "Urim" or "Thummim." These were holy lots with which the priest asked God for answers (Exodus 28:30).

Saul wants to kill his own son, just so that he does not lose face. He holds on to his oath, even though the oath was wrong.

The people take Jonathan's side. They say: God was with Jonathan, not against him. Here the people have more sense than the king. Jewish Bible teachers say about this: A wrong oath must not lead to the death of an innocent person.

Because of all the confusion, the Philistines are able to escape. Saul's oath made the victory smaller.

Saul's wars and his family VERSES 47–52

47 When Saul had taken over the kingdom of Israel,
he fought against all his enemies on every side:
against Moab, against the Ammonites, against Edom,
against the kings of Zobah, and against the Philistines.
Wherever he turned, he defeated them.
48 He acted bravely and struck down the Amalekites.
And he rescued Israel from the hands of those who robbed them.
49 The sons of Saul were Jonathan, Ishvi, and Malchishua.
And the names of his two daughters were:
the older one was named Merab, and the younger one was named Michal.
50 The name of Saul's wife was Ahinoam, the daughter of Ahimaaz.
The name of the commander of his army was Abner, the son of Ner, Saul's uncle.
51 Kish was the father of Saul,
and Ner, the father of Abner, was the son of Abiel.
52 There was fierce war against the Philistines as long as Saul lived.
And whenever Saul saw a strong man or a brave man, he took him into his service.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here is a short summary of Saul's rule. Saul was a successful military leader. He protected Israel against many enemies. We have to give him credit for that.

Zobah was a kingdom of the Arameans in the north, in what is Syria today.

Ishvi may be the same person as Ish-bosheth, who later becomes king for a short time after Saul (2 Samuel 2:8). Merab and Michal will become important in the story of David.

Abner was Saul's cousin and his top general. He too plays a big role later.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 15

To obey is better than sacrifice

The order against Amalek VERSES 1–3

1 Samuel said to Saul,
"The LORD sent me to anoint you as king over his people Israel.
So now listen to what the LORD says.
2 This is what the LORD of Armies says:
'I remember what Amalek did to Israel.
The people of Amalek stood in Israel's way
when Israel came up out of Egypt.
3 Now go and attack Amalek.
Completely destroy everything they have.
Do not spare them.
Kill men and women, children and nursing babies,
oxen and sheep, camels and donkeys.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is one of the hardest texts in the whole Bible. We do not leave it out, but we want to explain it honestly.

The Amalekites were a people in the south who moved around with their herds. They had attacked Israel after it left Egypt. They attacked the weak and tired people at the end of the line (Exodus 17:8–16; Deuteronomy 25:17–19). Later, too, they attacked Israel again and again (1 Samuel 14:48).

In Hebrew, "completely destroy" means "to carry out the ban" (cherem). In war this meant: Nothing could be taken as plunder. Everything was handed over to God and destroyed, even people and animals. We have already read about this in the book of Joshua.

That God commands to kill women, children, and babies too frightens every reader. Jews and Christians have struggled with this for a long time. Some understand the text like this: It was a one-time judgment of God on a people that had acted cruelly against the weak again and again (verse 33). Others understand it as an expression of the language of war and the ideas of that time. Many Jewish Bible teachers say: "Amalek" today is not a people that anyone may fight, but a picture of the evil in the world and in your own heart.

Very important: This text must never be used to justify violence against people or nations. No one today may appeal to this command. Jesus taught that we should love our enemies (Matthew 5:44).

Saul spares the best VERSES 4–9

4 Saul called the soldiers together.
He counted them at Telaim.
There were 200,000 foot soldiers and 10,000 men from Judah.

5 Saul came to the city of Amalek.
He hid soldiers in the valley, ready to attack.
6 Saul said to the Kenites,
"Go away! Leave the Amalekites.
Otherwise I will destroy you along with them.
You were kind to all the people of Israel
when they came up out of Egypt."
So the Kenites moved away from the Amalekites.
7 Saul defeated the Amalekites.
He fought them from Havilah all the way to Shur,
which is east of Egypt.
8 He captured Agag, the king of the Amalekites, alive.
And he completely destroyed all the people with the sword.
9 But Saul and the soldiers spared Agag.
They also kept the best of the sheep and the cattle,
the fat calves and the lambs, and everything that was good.
They did not want to destroy these things.
They destroyed only what was worthless and of no use.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Kenites were the people that Moses' father-in-law belonged to (Judges 1:16). They had helped Israel in the wilderness. Saul warns them and lets them go. This shows: It was not about killing all people. Whoever had done good was spared.

Saul obeys only halfway. He spares the king, probably to show him off as a trophy. And he keeps the best animals. Only what is worthless is destroyed.

This shows what really drives Saul: not obedience to God, but his own advantage and his reputation.

"He completely destroyed all the people": Still, later there are Amalekites again (1 Samuel 27:8; 30:1). This probably means the people in this area, not every single Amalekite.

God is sorry he made Saul king VERSES 10–16

10 Then the LORD spoke to Samuel.
He said,
11 "I am sorry that I made Saul king.
He has turned away from following me.
He has not done what I commanded."
Samuel was angry.
He cried out to the LORD all night long.
12 Early in the morning Samuel got up to go and meet Saul.
Someone told Samuel,
"Saul went to Carmel.
There he set up a monument for himself.
Then he left and went on down to Gilgal."
13 Samuel came to Saul.
Saul said to him,
"May the LORD bless you!
I have done what the LORD commanded."
14 Samuel said,
"Then why do I hear sheep bleating?
Why do I hear cattle mooing?"
15 Saul answered,
"The soldiers brought them from the Amalekites.
The people spared the best of the sheep and cattle.
They want to sacrifice them to the LORD your God.
We have completely destroyed the rest."
16 Then Samuel said to Saul,
"Stop! I will tell you what the LORD said to me last night."
Saul said, "Tell me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"I am sorry": God is sad about Saul. Here the Bible describes God with human feelings. God is not a cold God. It hurts him when a person turns away from him.

Samuel is angry and prays all night. He loves Saul and is deeply disappointed.

Here Carmel is not the mountain in the north, but a town in the south of Judah. Saul sets up a monument there, for himself, not for God. This shows how proud he has become.

Saul greets Samuel happily: I have done everything! But the bleating of the sheep gives him away. You cannot hide the truth.

And once again Saul blames others: "The people" spared the animals. And he says "your God," not "my God" or "our God."

"To obey is better than sacrifice" VERSES 17–23

17 Samuel said,
"Once you thought you were not important.
But you became the head of the tribes of Israel.
The LORD anointed you as king over Israel.
18 The LORD sent you on a mission.
He said,
'Go and completely destroy those sinners, the Amalekites.
Fight against them until they are all gone.'
19 So why didn't you obey the LORD?
Why did you take the plunder?
You did what is evil in the eyes of the LORD!"
20 Saul said to Samuel,
"But I have obeyed!
I obeyed the LORD.
I went where the LORD sent me.
I brought back Agag, the king of Amalek.
And I completely destroyed the Amalekites.
21 But the people took sheep and cattle from the plunder.
They took the best of the things that should have been destroyed.
They want to sacrifice them to the LORD your God in Gilgal."
22 Samuel said,
"What does the LORD enjoy more:
burnt offerings and sacrifices,
or people who obey him?
Listen: to obey is better than sacrifice.
To listen to God is better than offering the fat of rams.
23 Rebellion is as bad as the sin of witchcraft.
Stubbornness is as bad as serving idols and teraphim.
You have rejected the word of the LORD.
So he has rejected you as king."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samuel reminds Saul of his beginning: You were small and humble. God made you great. But now you want to decide for yourself.

Saul still does not admit that he acted wrongly. He says: "But I have obeyed!" And he blames the people. And he even gives a devout reason: We wanted to sacrifice it to God.

Samuel's answer is one of the most important sentences in the Bible: "To obey is better than sacrifice." God does not want devout rituals when the heart does not obey. The prophets later repeated this often (Hosea 6:6; Micah 6:6–8). And Jesus quoted Hosea: God wants mercy, not sacrifice (Matthew 9:13).

"Witchcraft" and "teraphim" (household idols) were terrible sins. Samuel says: Whoever knowingly does not listen to God is just as far away from God as someone who serves idols. This verse speaks about disobedience. It must never be used to hunt down people as "witches."

The torn robe VERSES 24–31

24 Saul said to Samuel,
"I have sinned.
I have broken the LORD's command and gone against your words.
I was afraid of the people.
So I did what they wanted.
25 Now please forgive my sin.
Come back with me, so that I can worship the LORD."
26 Samuel said to Saul,
"I will not go back with you.
You have rejected the word of the LORD.
So the LORD has rejected you as king over Israel."
27 Samuel turned around to leave.
But Saul grabbed the edge of his robe,
and it tore.
28 Samuel said to him,
"Today the LORD has torn the kingdom of Israel away from you.
He has given it to a neighbor of yours who is better than you.
29 The Strength of Israel does not lie.
He does not change his mind.
He is not a human being who changes his mind."
30 Saul said again,
"I have sinned.
But please honor me now before the elders of my people and before Israel.
Come back with me, so that I can worship the LORD your God."
31 So Samuel went back with Saul.
And Saul worshiped the LORD.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At last Saul says: "I have sinned." But then right away he says why: I was afraid of the people. A king who is more afraid of people than of God cannot lead his people well.

The second time we see what Saul really cares about: "Please honor me now before the elders." He wants to look good to others.

The torn-off edge of the robe becomes a sign: Just as the robe is torn, the kingdom is torn away from Saul. The "neighbor" who is better is David. Later David will cut off an edge of Saul's robe (1 Samuel 24:4).

"The Strength of Israel" is a name for God. The Hebrew word can also mean "glory" or "faithfulness."

In verses 11 and 35 it says that God was "sorry." In verse 29 it says that God does not "change his mind." In Hebrew it is the same word. Is that a contradiction? It is about two different things: God has feelings. He is sad about Saul (verses 11 and 35). But God does not change his just judgment like a person who can easily be talked into something else (verse 29). God is both caring and reliable.

In the end Samuel does go with Saul, probably so that the people are not divided.

The end of Agag VERSES 32–35

32 Then Samuel said,
"Bring Agag the king of the Amalekites here to me!"
Agag came to him cheerfully.
He said,
"Surely the bitter danger of death is over."
33 But Samuel said,
"Your sword has taken children away from many women.
So now your mother will lose her child too!"
Then Samuel cut Agag to pieces before the LORD in Gilgal.
34 After that, Samuel went to Ramah.
And Saul went up to his house in Gibeah of Saul.
35 Samuel never went to see Saul again for the rest of his life.
But Samuel was sad and mourned for Saul.
And the LORD was sorry that he had made Saul king over Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Agag thinks he has been saved. But Samuel gives the reason for his death: Agag himself was a cruel warrior who had taken children from many mothers. The judgment strikes him for his own deeds.

That the prophet himself kills a person is shocking for readers today. It belongs to a violent time. It is not an example for today.

Later, in the book of Esther, a man named Haman is called "the Agagite," a descendant of Agag (Esther 3:1). He wants to kill all the Jews. That is why in Jewish tradition Amalek is a picture of all who want to destroy the Jewish people.

The chapter ends sadly: Samuel never visits Saul again. But Samuel mourns for Saul. And God is sad too. The first king of Israel has failed, not because he was too weak, but because he did not want to obey.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 16

Samuel anoints David

Samuel goes to Bethlehem VERSES 1–5

1 The LORD said to Samuel,
"How long will you mourn for Saul?
I have rejected him from being king over Israel.
Fill your horn with oil and go.
I am sending you to Jesse of Bethlehem.
For I have chosen a king for myself among his sons."

2 Samuel said,
"How can I go?
If Saul hears about it, he will kill me."
The LORD said,
"Take a heifer with you and say,
'I have come to sacrifice to the LORD.'
3 Invite Jesse to the sacrifice.
Then I will show you what you are to do.
You shall anoint for me the one I name to you."
4 Samuel did what the LORD had said and came to Bethlehem.
The elders of the town came to meet him trembling and said,
"Do you come in peace?"
5 He said,
"In peace.
I have come to sacrifice to the LORD.
Make yourselves holy and come with me to the sacrifice."
He made Jesse and his sons holy
and invited them to the sacrifice.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Samuel is still mourning for Saul. But God says: It is time to look ahead. I already have a new king.

Jesse is the grandson of Ruth and Boaz (Ruth 4:17). Here the story connects to the book of Ruth.

Samuel is afraid of Saul. By now Saul is so dangerous that even the prophet fears for his life. God gives him a way: He is really to offer a sacrifice. That is not a lie, but he does not say everything.

A heifer is a young cow.

The elders of Bethlehem tremble. When the great prophet comes without warning, it can mean judgment. "Make yourselves holy" means: Get ready through washing and prayer to meet God.

God looks at the heart VERSES 6–13

6 When they came, he saw Eliab and said,
"Surely the LORD's anointed is standing here before him."
7 But the LORD said to Samuel,
"Don't look at his appearance or at how tall he is,
for I have rejected him.
I don't see as man sees.
Man looks at the outward appearance,
but the LORD looks at the heart."
8 Then Jesse called Abinadab
and had him walk past Samuel.
He said, "The LORD has not chosen this one either."
9 Then Jesse had Shammah walk past.
He said, "The LORD has not chosen this one either."
10 So Jesse had seven of his sons walk past Samuel.
Samuel said to Jesse,
"The LORD has not chosen these."
11 Samuel said to Jesse,
"Are these all your children?"
He said,
"There is still the youngest.
Look, he is taking care of the sheep."
Samuel said to Jesse,
"Send for him and have him brought here.
For we will not sit down to eat until he comes here."
12 He sent for him and had him brought in.
He was ruddy, with a handsome face and a good appearance.
The LORD said,
"Get up! Anoint him, for he is the one."
13 Then Samuel took the horn of oil
and anointed him in the middle of his brothers.
And the Spirit of the LORD came on David with power from that day on.
Then Samuel got up and went to Ramah.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eliab is the oldest son, tall and impressive, like Saul. Even Samuel thinks: It must be him. But God says one of the most important sentences in the Bible: "Man looks at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart."

This means: God does not judge people by their looks, their height, their wealth, or their position. He sees what a person is like inside.

The youngest son was not even invited. He has to take care of the sheep. No one thought of him. But God chooses exactly him. God often chooses the small and the overlooked.

"Ruddy" may mean reddish hair or a healthy, fresh skin color. In Hebrew, "with a handsome face" literally means "with beautiful eyes."

Only now, at the end, is his name given: David. The name probably means "beloved."

With Saul, the Spirit of God came only at certain moments. With David he stays "from that day on."

An evil spirit troubles Saul VERSES 14–23

14 The Spirit of the LORD left Saul,
and an evil spirit from the LORD troubled him.
15 Saul's servants said to him,
"Look, an evil spirit from God is troubling you.
16 Let our lord command your servants who stand before you
to look for a man who can play the harp well.
Then when the evil spirit from God comes on you,
he will play with his hand.
And you will feel better."
17 Saul said to his servants,
"Find me a man who can play well
and bring him to me."
18 Then one of the young men answered,
"Look, I have seen a son of Jesse of Bethlehem
who plays well.
He is a brave man, a warrior,
wise in speech, and handsome.
And the LORD is with him."
19 So Saul sent messengers to Jesse and said,
"Send me your son David, who is with the sheep."
20 Jesse took a donkey loaded with bread,
a container of wine, and a young goat,
and sent them to Saul with his son David.
21 David came to Saul and entered his service.
Saul loved him very much,
and David became his armor bearer.
22 Saul sent word to Jesse:
"Please let David stay in my service,

for he has found favor in my eyes."
23 Whenever the spirit from God came on Saul,
David took the harp and played with his hand.
Then Saul was refreshed and felt better,
and the evil spirit left him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"An evil spirit from the LORD" is a difficult expression. The people at that time believed: Everything, even the hard things, is in the end under God's power. God allows Saul to be troubled, because Saul has turned away from him. It does not mean that God enjoys evil.

Today we might say that Saul had severe depression, anxiety, or delusions. He is suspicious, moody, and has fits of rage. The Bible describes this honestly.

Music helps Saul. People still know this today: Music can calm and comfort the soul. Today music therapy is used in medicine.

The "harp" was actually a lyre, a small string instrument that people held in their arms.

Here we see how God guides the paths: The future king comes to the court of the present king. At first Saul loves David. He does not know that Samuel has anointed him.

David is not only a shepherd, but also a musician and poet. Later many psalms were said to be by him.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 17

David and Goliath

The giant Goliath VERSES 1–11

1 The Philistines gathered their armies for battle.
They gathered at Socoh, which belongs to Judah,
and camped between Socoh and Azekah, at
Ephesdammim.
2 Saul and the men of Israel gathered,
camped in the valley of Elah,
and lined up for battle against the Philistines.
3 The Philistines stood on the mountain on one side,
and Israel stood on the mountain on the other side.
And the valley was between them.
4 Then a champion came out of the Philistine camp.
His name was Goliath of Gath.
He was about nine and a half feet tall.
5 He had a bronze helmet on his head
and wore a coat of armor made of scales.
The coat weighed 5,000 shekels of bronze (about 125
pounds).
6 He had bronze armor on his shins
and a bronze javelin between his shoulders.
7 The shaft of his spear was like a weaver's beam.
And the head of his spear weighed 600 shekels of iron
(about 15 pounds).
His shield bearer went in front of him.
8 He stood and shouted to the ranks of Israel,
"Why have you come out to line up for battle?
Am I not a Philistine, and you servants of Saul?
Choose a man for yourselves, and let him come down
to me.
9 If he is able to fight with me and kill me,
then we will be your servants.
But if I defeat him and kill him,
then you will be our servants and serve us."
10 The Philistine said,
"I defy the ranks of Israel today!
Give me a man, so that we can fight each other!"
11 When Saul and all Israel heard these words of the
Philistine,
they were shocked and very afraid.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Elah" means "terebinth," which is a kind of tree. The valley of Elah is about 15 miles southwest of Jerusalem. You can still visit it today.

The Bible says: "six cubits and a span." A cubit is about 18 inches, a span about 9 inches. That is about nine and a half feet. An old manuscript from the Dead Sea, the old Greek translation, and Josephus have "four cubits and a span," which is about six and a half feet. Even that was a giant at that time, because most men were much shorter.

The coat of armor weighed 5,000 shekels, the spearhead 600 shekels. A shekel is a little under half an ounce.

A "weaver's beam" was a thick wooden bar on a loom, a machine for weaving cloth.

Goliath suggests a duel: One man against one man decides the whole war. This was sometimes done at that time.

And Saul? He is the tallest man in Israel (1 Samuel 9:2). Really, he should have fought against Goliath. But he too is afraid.

David comes to the camp VERSES 12–24

12 David was the son of that Ephrathite of Bethlehem in
Judah whose name was Jesse.
He had eight sons.
In the days of Saul the man was already very old.
13 The three oldest sons of Jesse had followed Saul to the
war.
The names of his three sons who had gone to the war
were:
Eliab the firstborn,
Abinadab the second,
and Shammah the third.
14 David was the youngest.
And the three oldest had followed Saul.
15 But David went back and forth from Saul
to take care of his father's sheep at Bethlehem.
16 The Philistine came forward morning and evening
and took his stand, for 40 days.
17 Jesse said to his son David,
"Take for your brothers about 6 gallons of this roasted
grain
and these 10 loaves of bread,
and bring them quickly to the camp to your brothers.

18 And bring these 10 cheeses to the commander of their thousand.
See how your brothers are doing,
and bring back news from them."
19 Saul and they and all the men of Israel were in the valley of Elah,
fighting against the Philistines.
20 David got up early in the morning,
left the sheep with someone to watch them,
took the food, and went, as Jesse had commanded him.
He came to the camp with the wagons
just as the army was going out to the battle line,
shouting the war cry.
21 Israel and the Philistines lined up, army against army.
22 David left his things with the man who guarded the baggage,
ran to the battle line,
came, and greeted his brothers.
23 While he was talking with them,
the champion came up,
the Philistine of Gath, named Goliath,
out of the ranks of the Philistines.
He said the same words, and David heard them.
24 When all the men of Israel saw the man,
they fled from him and were terrified.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here David is introduced once more, as if we had not heard of him yet. This is probably because different stories about David were put together here. The old Greek translation has a shorter text: Verses 12–31 and 55–58 are missing there.

Here Jesse has eight sons. In 1 Chronicles 2:13–15 only seven are named, and there David is the seventh. Maybe one son died young.

For 40 days Goliath mocks Israel, and no one dares to fight. In the Bible, the number 40 often stands for a time of testing.

The Bible says "an ephah." An ephah is about 6 gallons.

David does not come as a fighter, but as a messenger with food. He is the little brother who brings bread and cheese to his big brothers.

David wants to fight VERSES 25–30

25 The men of Israel said,
"Have you seen this man who comes up?
He comes up to defy Israel.
The king will give great riches to the man who kills him.
He will give him his daughter
and free his father's family in Israel from taxes."
26 David said to the men who were standing near him,
"What will be done for the man who kills this Philistine
and takes away the shame from Israel?
For who is this uncircumcised Philistine,
that he should defy the armies of the living God?"
27 The people answered him in the same way and said,
"This is what will be done for the man who kills him."
28 Eliab, his oldest brother, heard him talking with the men.
Then Eliab became angry with David and said,
"Why have you come down here?
And with whom have you left those few sheep in the wilderness?
I know your pride and the evil of your heart.
For you have only come down to watch the battle."
29 David said,
"What have I done now?
Is there not a cause?"
30 He turned away from him to someone else
and said the same thing again.
And the people answered him again as before.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The soldiers only talk about the reward. But David talks about God: Goliath is not only mocking Israel, but "the living God." For David, that is the real outrage.

"Uncircumcised" here means: He does not belong to the covenant with God.

Eliab is furious. Maybe he is jealous because Samuel anointed David and not him. He accuses David of pride. But really Eliab is the one who does not dare to fight.

"Is there not a cause?": The Hebrew can also mean: "It was only a word" or "only a question."

David before Saul VERSES 31–40

31 When the words that David had spoken were heard,
they were told to Saul.
And he sent for him.
32 David said to Saul,
"Let no one lose heart because of him.
Your servant will go and fight with this Philistine."
33 Saul said to David,
"You are not able to go against this Philistine to fight with him.
For you are only a young man,
and he has been a warrior since his youth."
34 David said to Saul,
"Your servant used to take care of his father's sheep.
When a lion or a bear came
and took a lamb out of the flock,
35 I went after it, struck it,
and rescued the lamb from its mouth.
When it rose up against me,
I grabbed it by its beard, struck it, and killed it.
36 Your servant has struck down both the lion and the bear.
And this uncircumcised Philistine will be like one of them,
because he has defied the armies of the living God."
37 David said,
"The LORD, who rescued me from the paw of the lion
and from the paw of the bear,
will rescue me from the hand of this Philistine."
Saul said to David,
"Go! The LORD will be with you."
38 Saul dressed David in his own clothes.
He put a bronze helmet on his head
and dressed him in a coat of armor.
39 David strapped his sword over his clothes
and tried to walk, for he had never tried it before.
David said to Saul,
"I can't walk in these,
for I have never tried them."
So David took them off again.

40 He took his staff in his hand,
chose five smooth stones from the stream,
and put them in his shepherd's bag.
His sling was in his hand.
And he went toward the Philistine.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David tells about his work as a shepherd: He defended the sheep against lions and bears. At that time this was really dangerous in Israel.

But David does not brag about his strength. He says: The LORD rescued me. He will rescue me again. His courage comes from trusting God.

Saul wants to give David his own armor. But it does not suit David. He cannot move in it. David does not fight with someone else's weapons, but with what he knows: staff, stones, and sling.

A sling was a leather strap with a small pouch. You put a stone in it, swung it around in a circle, and let go of one end. A trained slinger could hit very exactly and with great force. It was a real weapon (Judges 20:16).

"I come to you in the name of the LORD" VERSES 41–47

41 The Philistine came closer and closer to David,
and the man who carried the shield went in front of him.

42 When the Philistine looked around and saw David, he looked down on him.
For he was only a young man, ruddy and good-looking.

43 The Philistine said to David,
"Am I a dog, that you come to me with sticks?"
And the Philistine cursed David by his gods.

44 The Philistine said to David,
"Come here to me,
and I will give your flesh to the birds of the sky and to the animals of the field."

45 Then David said to the Philistine,
"You come to me with a sword, with a spear, and with a javelin.
But I come to you in the name of the LORD of Armies,
the God of the armies of Israel, whom you have defied.

46 Today the LORD will give you into my hand.
I will strike you down and cut off your head.
And today I will give the dead bodies of the Philistine army
to the birds of the sky and to the wild animals of the earth.
Then all the earth will know that there is a God in Israel.

47 And everyone gathered here will know
that the LORD does not save with sword and spear.
For the battle is the LORD's,
and he will give you into our hand."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Goliath feels insulted: A young shepherd with a stick? He threatens David cruelly.

David's answer is the heart of this story. It is not about strength against weakness. It is about trusting in weapons against trusting in God: "You come to me with a sword, with a spear, and with a javelin. But I come to you in the name of the LORD of Armies."

David is not fighting for his own fame. He says: The whole world is to know that there is a God. And Israel is to learn: God does not save by weapons.

"The battle is the LORD's": This thought is found often in the Bible. People should do their best, but God gives the victory.

The stone hits VERSES 48–54

48 When the Philistine got up
and came closer to meet David,
David hurried and ran toward the battle line to meet the Philistine.

49 David put his hand into his bag,
took out a stone,
slung it,
and struck the Philistine on his forehead.
The stone sank into his forehead,
and he fell on his face to the ground.

50 So David defeated the Philistine with a sling and a stone.
He struck the Philistine and killed him,
even though David had no sword in his hand.

51 Then David ran,
stood over the Philistine,
took his sword, drew it out of its sheath,
killed him, and cut off his head with it.
When the Philistines saw that their champion was dead, they fled.

52 The men of Israel and Judah got up,
shouted the war cry,
and chased the Philistines as far as Gai and to the gates of Ekron.
The wounded Philistines fell along the road to Shaaraim,
as far as Gath and Ekron.

53 The people of Israel came back from chasing the Philistines
and plundered their camp.

54 David took the head of the Philistine and brought it to Jerusalem.
But he put Goliath's armor in his tent.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A single stone decides the fight. Goliath had heavy armor, but his forehead was uncovered.

David had no sword. He uses Goliath's own sword to cut off his head. Later this sword will play a part once more (1 Samuel 21:9).

This story has become famous all over the world. To this day people say "David against Goliath" when someone small goes up against an opponent who seems far too strong.

Here the Bible tells about a war with a lot of violence. The message is not: Violence is good. The message is: Whoever trusts God does not need to be afraid of enemies who seem far too strong.

At that time Jerusalem still belonged to the Jebusites. David conquers the city only later (2 Samuel 5). Maybe he brought the head there later, or the storyteller is already naming the later capital.

The Hebrew text of 2 Samuel 21:19 says that a man named Elhanan killed Goliath of Gath. The WEB, our English source text, has "the brother of Goliath the Gittite" there. 1 Chronicles 20:5 says that Elhanan killed a brother of

Goliath. Bible teachers explain these passages in different ways.

"Whose son is this young man?" VERSES 55–58

55 When Saul saw David going out against the Philistine,
he said to Abner, the commander of the army,
"Abner, whose son is this young man?"
Abner said,
"As surely as you live, O king, I don't know."
56 The king said,
"Find out whose son this young man is!"
57 When David came back from killing the Philistine,
Abner took him and brought him before Saul,
with the head of the Philistine in his hand.
58 Saul said to him,
"Whose son are you, young man?"
David answered,
"I am the son of your servant Jesse of Bethlehem."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is surprising: In Chapter 16 David was already Saul's harp player and armor bearer. Why does Saul not know him now?

Some Bible teachers say: Here two different stories about how David came to the court have been put together. The old Greek translation does not have these verses. Others say: Saul is not asking about David himself, but about his family, because he had promised the winner his daughter and freedom from taxes for his family (verse 25). Or Saul was so confused because of his illness that he did not recognize David.

We leave the text as it is and say honestly: Here there is a tension that cannot be fully resolved.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 18

Jonathan's friendship and Saul's jealousy

Jonathan and David make a covenant VERSES 1–5

1 When he had finished speaking with Saul,
the soul of Jonathan was bound to the soul of David.
And Jonathan loved him as his own soul.
2 Saul took him into his service that day
and did not let him go back home to his father's house anymore.
3 Then Jonathan and David made a covenant,
because he loved him as his own soul.
4 Jonathan took off the robe he was wearing
and gave it to David, with his clothes,
even his sword, his bow, and his belt.
5 David went out wherever Saul sent him,
and he acted wisely.
Saul put him in charge of the soldiers.
This pleased all the people and also Saul's servants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jonathan is the king's son and really the next in line to be king. David is a shepherd from Bethlehem. Still they become best friends. Their friendship is one of the best-known friendships in the literature of the world.

"He loved him as his own soul" means: as himself. Jonathan is ready to do anything for David.

The "covenant" is a solemn promise of loyalty, made before God.

Jonathan gives David his robe and his weapons. This is more than a gift. It is a sign: Jonathan accepts that one day David will be king, not he himself (compare 1 Samuel 23:17). Jonathan is free of envy. That is very rare.

Some readers today ask whether the love between Jonathan and David was more than friendship. The text speaks of covenant, loyalty, and a deep bond. At that time the word "love" was also used for faithfulness and loyalty between allies. Most Jewish and Christian Bible teachers see here the model of a deep friendship.

The women's song VERSES 6–9

6 When they came home, when David returned from killing the Philistine,
the women came out of all the cities of Israel,
singing and dancing,
to meet King Saul,
with tambourines, with joy, and with musical instruments.
7 As they played, the women sang to one another:
"Saul has killed his thousands,
and David his ten thousands."
8 Saul became very angry,
and this song displeased him.
He said,
"They have given David ten thousands,
and they have only given me thousands.
What more can he have but the kingdom?"
9 From that day on Saul kept a suspicious eye on David.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The women celebrate the victory with a song. In the poetry of the Bible people often say the same thing twice, and the second half goes further than the first. The women probably did not want to insult Saul. But Saul only hears: David is better than me.

Now Saul's jealousy begins. It will torment him for the rest of his life. Envy can eat a person up from the inside.

"What more can he have but the kingdom?" Saul suspects that David will one day be king. And that is exactly God's plan.

Saul throws the spear VERSES 10–16

10 The next day an evil spirit from God came on Saul with power,
and he prophesied in the middle of the house.
David was playing with his hand, as he did every day.
Saul had his spear in his hand.
11 And Saul threw the spear,
for he said, "I will pin David to the wall!"

But David got out of his way twice.
12 Saul was afraid of David,
because the LORD was with him
but had left Saul.
13 So Saul sent him away from him
and made him commander over a thousand.
And he went out and came in before the people.
14 David acted wisely in all his ways,
and the LORD was with him.
15 When Saul saw that he acted very wisely,
he was afraid of him.
16 But all Israel and Judah loved David,
because he went out and came in before them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"He prophesied": It is the same word as with the excited prophets in Chapter 10. But here it is an eerie, wild state.

While David makes music to calm Saul, Saul tries to kill him. The man who helps him becomes his enemy.

Saul is afraid of David because God is with him. Saul senses: God has left him and is with David.

Saul sends David to war, maybe hoping that he will be killed there. But the opposite happens: David becomes more and more popular.

"He went out and came in" means: He led the soldiers into battle and back again. He was a leader whom people saw and knew.

Merab and Michal VERSES 17–27

17 Saul said to David,
"Here is my older daughter Merab.
I will give her to you as your wife.
Only be brave for me and fight the LORD's battles."
For Saul said to himself,
"I will not raise my hand against him,
but let the hand of the Philistines be against him."
18 David said to Saul,
"Who am I, and what is my life
or my father's family in Israel,
that I should become the king's son-in-law?"
19 But when the time came for Merab, Saul's daughter, to be given to David,
she was given as wife to Adriel the Meholathite.
20 Michal, Saul's daughter, loved David.
They told Saul, and this pleased him.
21 Saul said,
"I will give her to him,
so that she may be a trap for him
and the hand of the Philistines may be against him."
So Saul said to David a second time,
"Today you shall become my son-in-law."
22 Saul commanded his servants,
"Talk with David secretly and say,
'Look, the king is pleased with you,
and all his servants love you.
So now become the king's son-in-law.'"
23 Saul's servants spoke these words in David's hearing.
David said,
"Does it seem to you a small thing to become the king's son-in-law,
since I am a poor man and not well known?"
24 Saul's servants told him,
"This is what David said."
25 Saul said,
"Tell David this:
'The king wants no bride price
except 100 foreskins of Philistines,
to take revenge on the king's enemies.'"
For Saul planned to have David fall by the hand of the Philistines.
26 When his servants told David these words,
David was glad to become the king's son-in-law.
Before the time was up,
27 David got up and went, he and his men,
and killed 200 Philistine men.
David brought their foreskins,
and they gave the full number to the king,
so that he could become the king's son-in-law.
Then Saul gave him his daughter Michal as wife.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Saul had promised to give his daughter to the man who defeated Goliath (1 Samuel 17:25). But he does not keep his promise. He adds new conditions, hoping that David will die in battle.

Merab is given to another man. Once again women are treated like objects that men use for politics.

It is very rare that the Bible says clearly that a woman loves a man. With Michal it says so twice (verses 20 and 28). But her father uses her love as a trap.

David is humble: I am poor, I cannot pay a bride price for a king's daughter. At that time the bridegroom had to pay a bride price to the bride's family.

Saul asks for a cruel bride price: foreskins of killed Philistines. The foreskin is the skin that is removed at circumcision. This was proof that someone had really killed Philistines, because the Philistines were not circumcised. It is a custom from a brutal time of war. The Bible tells it, but it does not praise it.

David even brings twice as many. The old Greek translation has 100 in verse 27. In 2 Samuel 3:14 David also speaks of 100.

Saul becomes David's enemy VERSES 28–30

28 Saul saw and knew that the LORD was with David.
And Michal, Saul's daughter, loved him.
29 Then Saul was even more afraid of David.
And Saul was David's enemy from then on.
30 Then the princes of the Philistines went out to battle.
And every time they went out,
David acted more wisely than all of Saul's servants,
so that his name was highly respected.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Everything Saul plans against David only makes David stronger. The spear misses him. The war makes him famous. The wedding makes him part of the king's family. Even Saul's own children, Jonathan and Michal, love David.

Saul realizes: God is with David. But instead of being glad about it or turning back to God, he becomes David's enemy. In this way he is really fighting against God himself.

This chapter shows the difference between two people: Jonathan has every reason to be jealous, but he loves David. Saul has every reason to be thankful, but he hates David.

1 SAMUEL

Chapter 19

David has to flee

Jonathan stands up for David VERSES 1–7

1 Saul spoke to his son Jonathan and to all his servants.
He told them to kill David.
But Saul's son Jonathan liked David very much.
2 Jonathan told David,
"My father Saul wants to kill you.
So please be careful tomorrow morning.
Go to a secret place and hide there.
3 I will go out and stand beside my father
in the field where you are hiding.
I will talk with my father about you.
If I find out anything, I will tell you."
4 Jonathan spoke well of David to his father Saul.
He said to him,
"The king should not sin against his servant David.
David has not sinned against you.
Everything he has done has been very good for you.
5 He risked his life and killed the Philistine.
And the LORD gave a great victory to all Israel.
You saw it, and you were glad.
So why do you want to sin against an innocent man?
Why do you want to kill David for no reason?"
6 Saul listened to Jonathan.
Saul swore an oath.
He said, "As surely as the LORD lives, David will not be
put to death."
7 Then Jonathan called David
and told him everything.
Jonathan brought David to Saul,
and David served Saul as before.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now Saul openly orders that David be killed. He even gives this order to his own son.

Jonathan stands between his father and his friend. He chooses the way of justice: He talks with his father and reminds him of the truth. David is innocent. He has saved Israel.

Jonathan is brave. It was dangerous to disagree with an angry king.

For a moment Saul listens to him and even swears by God. But will he keep his word?

The spear and the window VERSES 8–17

8 There was war again.
David went out and fought against the Philistines.
He killed many of them, and the rest ran away from
him.
9 Then an evil spirit from the LORD came on Saul.
Saul was sitting in his house with his spear in his hand.
David was playing music with his hands.
10 Saul tried to pin David to the wall with the spear.
But David slipped away from Saul.
So the spear stuck in the wall.
That night David ran away and escaped.
11 Saul sent men to David's house.
They were to watch the house and kill David in the
morning.
But Michal, David's wife, warned him.
She said,
"If you don't run for your life tonight,
you will be killed tomorrow."
12 So Michal let David down through the window.
He went away, fled, and escaped.
13 Then Michal took the teraphim and laid it in the bed.
Teraphim are idols that people kept in their homes.
She put a pillow of goats' hair at its head
and covered it with clothes.
14 Saul sent men to take David away.
But Michal said, "He is sick."
15 Then Saul sent the men back to see David.
He told them,
"Bring him to me in his bed, so that I can kill him."
16 The men went into the room.
But there was only the teraphim in the bed,
with the pillow of goats' hair at its head.
17 Saul said to Michal,
"Why have you tricked me like this?
You let my enemy go, and he has escaped!"
Michal answered Saul,
"He said to me,
'Let me go! Why should I kill you?'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Saul breaks his oath. Once again he throws the spear. Now David has to flee. From here on David is on the run for many years.

Michal loves David and saves him. She lets him down through the window, as Rahab did with the spies in Jericho (Joshua 2:15).

"Teraphim" were household gods, figures that some families had at that time, even though it was forbidden. That Michal has such a thing in the house shows how common such customs were. Here the figure was probably big enough to look like a person under the blanket.

Michal lies to save David. And in the end she also lies to her father to protect herself: He threatened me. The Bible tells this without judging it.

Saul even wants to have a sick man killed in his bed. His hatred has no limits anymore.

According to its title, Psalm 59 is a prayer of David from this night.

The Spirit of God stops Saul VERSES 18–24

18 So David ran away and escaped.
He came to Samuel at Ramah.
He told Samuel everything Saul had done to him.
Then David and Samuel went to Naioth and stayed
there.
19 Someone told Saul,
"David is at Naioth in Ramah."

20 So Saul sent men to capture David.
The men saw a group of prophets who were prophesying.
Samuel stood there as their leader.
Then the Spirit of God came on Saul's men,
and they began to prophesy too.
21 Saul heard about it.
So he sent other men,
and they also began to prophesy.
Saul sent men a third time,
and they also began to prophesy.
22 Then Saul went to Ramah himself.
He came to the big well in Secu.
He asked,
"Where are Samuel and David?"
Someone said,
"They are at Naioth in Ramah."
23 So Saul went to Naioth in Ramah.
Then the Spirit of God came on him too.
He kept on prophesying as he walked, until he came to Naioth in Ramah.
24 He also took off his clothes.
He also prophesied in front of Samuel.
He lay there naked all that day and all that night.
That is why people say,
"Is Saul also among the prophets?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David flees to Samuel, the man who anointed him. "Naioth" was probably a place where the prophets lived together, something like a community.

Three times Saul sends soldiers to catch David. But every time the Spirit of God comes on them, and they begin to prophesy instead of arresting David. God protects David in a very unusual way.

Then Saul comes himself. And he too is taken hold of by the Spirit of God. He tears off his clothes and lies there for a day and a night. "Naked" can also mean here: only in his underclothes, without his outer robe and his royal clothes.

This is a deep picture: The king who fights against God's will is made helpless by God. He lies on the ground before Samuel, the prophet whom he had not seen since Chapter 15.

We already know the saying "Is Saul also among the prophets?" from 1 Samuel 10:11–12. Back then it was a sign of Saul's new beginning. Now it is a sign of his helplessness.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 20

Jonathan and the arrows

"Only a step between me and death" VERSES 1–11

1 David fled from Naioth in Ramah.
He came and said to Jonathan,
"What have I done?
What is my guilt?
What is my sin against your father, that he is trying to kill me?"
2 He said to him,
"Far from it! You will not die.
Look, my father does nothing, big or small,
without telling me.
Why would my father hide this from me?
It is not so."
3 David also swore and said,
"Your father knows very well that I have found favor in your eyes.
And he says to himself,
'Don't let Jonathan know this, or he will be upset.'
But truly, as the LORD lives and as you live,
there is only a step between me and death."
4 Then Jonathan said to David,
"Whatever you want, I will do it for you."
5 David said to Jonathan,
"Look, tomorrow is the new moon.
I am supposed to sit and eat with the king.
But let me go.
Then I will hide in the field until the evening of the third day.
6 If your father misses me,
then say,
'David begged me to let him hurry to Bethlehem, his town.
For the yearly sacrifice for the whole family is there.'
7 If he says, 'Good,'
then your servant is safe.
But if he gets angry,
then you will know that he has decided to do evil.
8 So show kindness to your servant.
For you have brought your servant into a covenant of the LORD with you.
But if I am guilty, then kill me yourself.
Why should you bring me to your father?"
9 Jonathan said,
"Far be it from you!
If I knew for sure that my father had decided to harm you,
wouldn't I tell you?"
10 Then David said to Jonathan,
"Who will tell me if your father gives you a harsh answer?"
11 Jonathan said to David,
"Come! Let's go out into the field."
And the two of them went out into the field.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David does not understand why Saul hates him. He asks: What have I done wrong? Many people who are persecuted for no reason ask this question.

Jonathan does not want to believe that his father is really so evil. It is hard to think such a thing about your own father.

"Only a step between me and death": That is how David feels. Any day could be the end.

At the "new moon," the beginning of each month, there was a festival with a special meal (Numbers 10:10; 28:11). As the

king's son-in-law, David was supposed to be there.

David suggests a test: How will Saul react when David is missing?

"Covenant of the LORD": The friendship between David and Jonathan is a covenant before God (1 Samuel 18:3). That is a holy promise.

Jonathan's covenant with David's house VERSES 12–17

12 Jonathan said to David,
"By the LORD, the God of Israel:
When I have found out what my father thinks, about this time tomorrow or the day after,
if things look good for David,
won't I send word to you and tell you?
13 May the LORD do so to Jonathan and even more,
if my father wants to harm you
and I don't tell you and send you away,
so that you can go in peace.
May the LORD be with you as he has been with my father.
14 And not only while I am still alive
shall you show me the kindness of the LORD, so that I do not die.
15 But you shall also never take your kindness away from my house,
not even when the LORD has cut off every one of David's enemies
from the face of the earth."
16 So Jonathan made a covenant with the house of David and said,
"The LORD will hold David's enemies responsible."
17 Jonathan had David swear again,
because of his love for him.
For he loved him as he loved his own soul.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jonathan says: "May the LORD be with you as he has been with my father." Jonathan knows that David will be the next king, not he himself. And he wishes it for him.

At that time new kings often killed the whole family of the old king, so that no one could fight them for the throne. That is why Jonathan asks: When you are king, spare my family.

David kept this promise. Many years later he takes Jonathan's lame son Mephibosheth to eat at his table (2 Samuel 9).

Once again we find the word "kindness" (chesed), which we know from the book of Ruth. It is faithfulness that goes beyond this life.

The sign with the arrows VERSES 18–23

18 Then Jonathan said to him,
"Tomorrow is the new moon.
You will be missed, because your seat will be empty.
19 When you have waited three days,
go down quickly to the place where you hid when this matter began,
and stay by the stone Ezel.
20 I will shoot three arrows to the side of it,
as if I were shooting at a target.
21 And look, then I will send the boy and say,
'Go, find the arrows!'
If I say to the boy,
'Look, the arrows are on this side of you, take them,'
then come.
For then you are safe, and there is no danger, as the LORD lives.
22 But if I say to the boy,
'Look, the arrows are beyond you,'
then go your way.
For the LORD has sent you away.
23 And as for the matter we have talked about, you and I:
Look, the LORD is between you and me forever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jonathan thinks up a secret sign. No one is to notice that he is warning David. A boy who fetches arrows does not attract attention at all.

"The LORD is between you and me" means: God is the witness of our promise. He watches over it.

Saul's anger at the feast VERSES 24–34

24 So David hid in the field.
When the new moon came, the king sat down to eat.
25 The king sat on his seat as usual,
on the seat by the wall.
Jonathan stood up, and Abner sat at Saul's side.
But David's place was empty.
26 Still, Saul said nothing that day.
For he thought,
"Something has happened to him. He is not clean.
Surely he is not clean."
27 On the day after the new moon, the second day, David's place was empty again.
Saul said to his son Jonathan,
"Why hasn't the son of Jesse come to eat, either yesterday or today?"
28 Jonathan answered Saul,
"David begged me for permission to go to Bethlehem.
29 He said,
'Please let me go,
for our family has a sacrifice in the town.
My brother has ordered me to be there.
Now, if I have found favor in your eyes,
please let me go away and see my brothers.'
That is why he has not come to the king's table."
30 Then Saul became very angry with Jonathan and said to him,
"You son of a twisted, rebellious woman!
Don't I know that you have chosen the son of Jesse,
to your own shame and to the shame of your mother's nakedness?
31 For as long as the son of Jesse lives on the earth,
you will not be secure, neither you nor your kingdom.
So now send for him and bring him to me,
for he must surely die!"
32 Jonathan answered his father Saul and said to him,
"Why should he be put to death?
What has he done?"
33 Then Saul threw his spear at him to strike him.
From this Jonathan knew that his father was determined to kill David.
34 So Jonathan got up from the table in fierce anger
and ate no food on the second day of the month.

For he was grieved for David,
because his father had treated him so shamefully.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

On the first day Saul thinks: Maybe David is unclean, for example because he touched something dead. Then a person was not allowed to take part in the holy meal (Leviticus 7:20–21).

On the second day Saul explodes. He insults Jonathan and his own wife. "To the shame of your mother's nakedness" is a crude insult.

Saul gives away his real fear: If David lives, you will not become king. For Saul it is about power for his family. For Jonathan it is about justice and faithfulness.

Jonathan asks: "What has he done?" That is the right question. And Saul answers with the spear. He even attacks his own son.

Jonathan is angry and sad, not because of himself, but because of David.

The farewell VERSES 35–42

35 In the morning Jonathan went out into the field
at the time he had agreed on with David,
and a little boy was with him.
36 He said to his boy,
"Run, find the arrows that I shoot."
As the boy ran, he shot an arrow beyond him.
37 When the boy came to the place of the arrow that
Jonathan had shot,
Jonathan called after the boy,
"Isn't the arrow beyond you?"
38 Jonathan called after the boy,
"Quick! Hurry! Don't stop!"
Jonathan's boy picked up the arrows and came back to
his master.
39 But the boy knew nothing.
Only Jonathan and David knew about the matter.
40 Jonathan gave his weapons to his boy
and said to him,
"Go, carry them to the town."
41 As soon as the boy was gone,
David got up from the south side.
He fell on his face to the ground
and bowed three times.
They kissed each other and wept together,
and David wept the most.
42 Jonathan said to David,
"Go in peace.
For we have both sworn in the name of the LORD and
said,
'The LORD is between me and you,
and between my descendants and your descendants
forever.'"
He got up and left.
And Jonathan went into the town.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The arrow flies beyond the boy. That means: Go away, you are in danger. Jonathan calls to the boy, "Quick! Hurry!" but really he is speaking to David.

Really Jonathan would not have needed the sign. But the two want to see each other at least one more time.

They kiss and weep. At that time it was normal for men to show their friendship and their pain at saying goodbye in this way.

This is one of the saddest farewells in the Bible. The two see each other only one more time (1 Samuel 23:16–18).

In the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles the numbering is different here: The last sentence ("He got up and left. And Jonathan went into the town.") is Chapter 21, verse 1 there.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 21

David in Nob and in Gath

The holy bread VERSES 1–6

1 Then David came to Nob, to Ahimelech the priest.
Ahimelech came trembling to meet David and said to
him,
"Why are you alone, and no one is with you?"
2 David said to Ahimelech the priest,
"The king has given me a task and said to me,
'Let no one know anything about the matter I am
sending you on,
or about what I have commanded you.'
I have told the young men to meet me at a certain
place.
3 Now what do you have on hand?
Please give me five loaves of bread,
or whatever is there."
4 The priest answered David,
"I have no ordinary bread on hand,
but there is holy bread,
if only the young men have kept away from women."
5 David answered the priest,
"Truly, women have been kept away from us as usual
these three days.
When I set out, the bodies of the young men were
holy,
even though it was only an ordinary journey.
How much more will they be holy today?"
6 So the priest gave him holy bread.
For there was no bread there except the show bread
that had been taken from before the LORD,
to be replaced with warm bread on the day it was taken
away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles this chapter is shifted by one verse. Verse 1 here is verse 2 there, and so on up to verse 16.

Nob was a town of the priests, near Jerusalem. After Shiloh was destroyed, the priests from Eli's family lived there. Ahimelech was a great-grandson of Eli.

Ahimelech trembles. Why does Saul's famous army commander come all alone? That is strange.

David lies to the priest. He says he is on a mission for the king. This lie will have terrible results (Chapter 22).

The "show bread" was 12 loaves of bread that were set out fresh before God in the sanctuary every week. Only the priests were allowed to eat the old loaves (Leviticus 24:5–9).

The priest makes an exception because David and his men are in need. He only asks whether they are clean. At that time the rule was: Whoever had recently slept with a woman was unclean for holy things for a while (Exodus 19:15). The Hebrew literally says "vessels." This probably means their bodies or their equipment.

Later Jesus referred to this story: A person's need is more important than a religious rule (Mark 2:25–27).

Doeg the Edomite VERSE 7

7 Now one of Saul's servants was there that day,
held back before the LORD.
His name was Doeg the Edomite,
the chief of Saul's herdsmen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This short sentence is like a dark cloud. A servant of Saul sees everything that happens here. Later he will betray it (1 Samuel 22:9).

"Held back before the LORD": Maybe he had to stay at the sanctuary for a while because of a vow or a cleansing.

According to its title, Psalm 52 is a prayer of David about Doeg.

Goliath's sword VERSES 8–9

8 David said to Ahimelech,
"Don't you have a spear or a sword here on hand?
For I have not brought my sword or my weapons with me,
because the king's business was urgent."
9 The priest said,
"Look, the sword of Goliath the Philistine,
whom you killed in the valley of Elah,
is here, wrapped in a cloth behind the ephod.
If you want to take it, take it,
for there is no other here except this one."
David said,
"There is none like it. Give it to me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Goliath's sword had been kept in the sanctuary as a sign of victory. Now David gets it back.

It is a sign of remembering: Back then God helped David against the giant. He will help him now too.

David pretends to be insane VERSES 10–15

10 David got up and fled from Saul that day.
He went to Achish, the king of Gath.
11 The servants of Achish said to him,
"Isn't this David, the king of the land?
Didn't they sing about him in their dances:
'Saul has killed his thousands,
and David his ten thousands'?"
12 David took these words to heart
and was very afraid of Achish, the king of Gath.
13 He changed his behavior in front of them
and pretended to be insane while they held him.
He scribbled on the doors of the gate
and let his spit run down his beard.
14 Then Achish said to his servants,
"Look, you can see the man is insane.
Why have you brought him to me?
15 Do I lack madmen,
that you have brought this fellow to act like a madman in front of me?
Should this fellow come into my house?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is so desperate that he flees to the Philistines, of all people. And to Gath of all places, the hometown of Goliath. And he has Goliath's sword with him!

The Philistines recognize him right away. They even call him "the king of the land." They know more than Saul suspects.

David becomes afraid and saves himself with a trick: He acts crazy. At that time people were afraid to harm someone who was insane.

Achish makes fun of it: I already have enough madmen around me.

The great hero who defeated Goliath now has to drool and scribble to survive. That is how low David has fallen. But God does not let him fall.

According to its title, Psalm 34 is a song of David from this time. It says that the LORD is near to those who have a broken heart (Psalm 34:18; in some Bibles 34:19). In the title of the psalm the king is called "Abimelech." This was probably a title of the Philistine kings.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 22

The cave of Adullam and the massacre at Nob

David's people VERSES 1–5

1 So David left there and escaped to the cave of Adullam.
When his brothers and his father's whole family heard about it,
they went down there to him.
2 Everyone who was in trouble,
everyone who was in debt,
and everyone who was bitter gathered around him.
And he became their leader.
There were about 400 men with him.
3 From there David went to Mizpeh in Moab.
He said to the king of Moab,
"Please let my father and my mother stay with you
until I know what God will do for me."
4 He brought them to the king of Moab.
And they stayed with him the whole time that David was in the stronghold.

5 The prophet Gad said to David,
"Don't stay in the stronghold.
Leave and go into the land of Judah."
So David left and came into the forest of Hereth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The cave of Adullam was in the hill country of Judah, about 15 miles southwest of Bethlehem. There are many caves there.

David's family has to flee too. Saul could take revenge on them.

No heroes or nobles come to David, but people on the edge: the poor, people in debt, the unhappy. From them David makes a troop. Here Christians remember Jesus, to whom outcasts and despised people came too.

David brings his parents to Moab. That is no accident: David's great-grandmother Ruth was a Moabite (Ruth 4:17).

Gad is a prophet who goes with David from now on. David too listens to the word of God through a prophet. That makes him different from Saul.

According to their titles, Psalm 57 and Psalm 142 are prayers of David "in the cave."

Saul's suspicion VERSES 6–10

6 Saul heard that David and the men with him had been found.
Saul was sitting in Gibeah, under the tamarisk tree in Ramah,
with his spear in his hand,
and all his servants were standing around him.
7 Saul said to his servants who were standing around him,
"Listen, you Benjamites!
Will the son of Jesse give every one of you fields and vineyards?
Will he make you all captains of thousands and captains of hundreds?
8 Is that why all of you have plotted against me?
No one tells me when my son makes a covenant with the son of Jesse.
None of you is sorry for me
or tells me that my son has stirred up my servant against me
to lie in wait for me, as he is doing today."
9 Then Doeg the Edomite, who was standing with Saul's servants, answered,
"I saw the son of Jesse coming to Nob,
to Ahimelech the son of Ahitub.
10 He asked the LORD for him,
gave him food,
and gave him the sword of Goliath the Philistine."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A tamarisk is a tree with small leaves that grows in dry places.

Saul sits under a tree with his spear in his hand. He is suspicious of everyone. He believes that everyone has plotted against him, even his own son.

He appeals to his own people from the tribe of Benjamin: David is from Judah. He will give you nothing. Only I can reward you. In this way Saul divides the people by tribes.

He feels sorry for himself: "None of you is sorry for me." Saul sees himself as the victim, even though he is the one who is persecuting.

Doeg uses the chance to make the king like him. He tells only half the truth: He does not say that Ahimelech knew nothing about David's escape.

Saul has the priests killed VERSES 11–19

11 Then the king sent for Ahimelech the priest, the son of Ahitub,
and his father's whole family, the priests who were in Nob.
And they all came to the king.
12 Saul said, "Listen now, you son of Ahitub!"
He answered, "Here I am, my lord."
13 Saul said to him,
"Why have you plotted against me, you and the son of Jesse?
You gave him bread and a sword
and asked God for him,
so that he could rise up against me and lie in wait for me, as he is doing today."
14 Then Ahimelech answered the king,
"Who among all your servants is as faithful as David?
He is the king's son-in-law,
the captain of your bodyguard,
and honored in your house.
15 Is today the first time I have asked God for him?
Far be it from me!
Don't let the king blame his servant or my father's whole family for anything.
For your servant knew nothing about all this, little or much."
16 The king said,
"You shall surely die, Ahimelech, you and your father's whole family."
17 The king said to the guards who were standing around him,
"Turn and kill the priests of the LORD.
For their hand also is with David,
and they knew that he was fleeing and did not tell me."
But the king's servants would not raise their hand
to attack the priests of the LORD.
18 Then the king said to Doeg,
"You turn and attack the priests!"
So Doeg the Edomite turned and attacked the priests.
That day he killed 85 men who wore a linen ephod.
19 And he struck Nob, the town of the priests, with the sword:
men and women, children and nursing babies,
cattle, donkeys, and sheep, with the sword.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ahimelech defends himself honestly and bravely: David was your most faithful servant! I have done nothing evil. He is completely innocent.

But Saul does not want to listen. He sentences the whole family of priests to death.

Saul's soldiers refuse. They do not want to kill priests of the LORD. This is brave disobedience. There are orders that must not be followed. Whoever is told to kill innocent people must refuse.

Doeg, a foreigner with no respect for God, carries out the cruel order. He kills 85 priests. The old Greek translation has 305.

Then Saul destroys the whole town of Nob, with women, children, and animals. This is shocking: Against the Amalekites Saul had not fully carried out God's command (Chapter 15). But against God's own priests he carries out a complete destruction out of hatred. That is how far Saul has fallen.

Here the dark announcement about the house of Eli also comes true (1 Samuel 2:31–33).

Abiathar escapes VERSES 20–23

20 One of the sons of Ahimelech the son of Ahitub
escaped.
His name was Abiathar.
He fled to David.
21 Abiathar told David that Saul had killed the priests of
the LORD.
22 David said to Abiathar,
"I knew on that day, when Doeg the Edomite was
there,
that he would surely tell Saul.
I am responsible for the death of all the people of your
father's family.
23 Stay with me.
Don't be afraid.
For whoever wants to kill me also wants to kill you.
You will be safe with me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David takes responsibility. He says: It is my fault. I lied to the priest, and I saw Doeg. That makes him different from Saul, who always blames others.

David takes Abiathar under his protection. From now on David has a priest with him. Abiathar brings the ephod with him, with which people can ask God for answers (1 Samuel 23:6).

Saul has killed the priests, and with them the possibility of asking God. But David now has a priest and a prophet with him.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 23

On the run in the wilderness

David rescues Keilah VERSES 1–6

1 David was told,
"Look, the Philistines are fighting against Keilah
and are robbing the threshing floors."
2 So David asked the LORD,
"Shall I go and strike down these Philistines?"
The LORD said to David,
"Go, strike down the Philistines, and save Keilah."
3 David's men said to him,
"Look, we are afraid here in Judah already.
How much more if we go to Keilah against the armies
of the Philistines!"
4 Then David asked the LORD once more.
And the LORD answered him,
"Get up, go down to Keilah.
For I will give the Philistines into your hand."
5 David and his men went to Keilah
and fought against the Philistines.
They drove away their livestock
and defeated them badly.
So David saved the people of Keilah.
6 When Abiathar the son of Ahimelech fled to David at
Keilah,
he came down with an ephod in his hand.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Keilah was a town in Judah, near the border with the Philistines. The "threshing floors" were the places where the harvested grain was beaten to separate the grain from the stalks. The Philistines are stealing the harvest, the food for a whole year.

David himself is on the run. Still he helps others. Really, that would have been the king's job. But Saul is busy hunting David.

David asks God before he acts. And when his men are afraid, he asks once more. This is very different from Saul, who often did not wait for God.

With the ephod the priest could ask God and get an answer of yes or no.

The ungratefulness of Keilah VERSES 7–14

7 Saul was told that David had come to Keilah.
Saul said,
"God has given him into my hand.
For he has shut himself in
by going into a town with gates and bars."
8 Saul called all the people together for war,
to go down to Keilah and surround David and his men.
9 David found out that Saul was planning evil against
him.
He said to Abiathar the priest,
"Bring the ephod here."
10 Then David said,
"LORD, God of Israel,
your servant has surely heard
that Saul wants to come to Keilah
to destroy the town because of me.
11 Will the men of Keilah hand me over to him?
Will Saul come down, as your servant has heard?
LORD, God of Israel, please tell your servant."
The LORD said,
"He will come down."
12 Then David said,
"Will the men of Keilah hand me and my men over to
Saul?"
The LORD said,
"They will hand you over."
13 So David and his men got up, about 600 men,
left Keilah,
and went wherever they could go.
Saul was told that David had escaped from Keilah.
So he gave up going there.

14 David stayed in the wilderness, in the strongholds,
and remained in the hill country in the wilderness of Ziph.
Saul looked for him every day,
but God did not give him into his hand.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Saul thinks: God has handed David over to me! He uses God's name for his evil plans. But God is not on his side.

The people of Keilah would betray David, even though he has just saved them. They would do it out of fear of Saul. They had seen what happened to Nob.

David does not want a whole town to suffer because of him. So he leaves.

"God did not give him into his hand": That is the key sentence. Saul searches every day, with a whole army. But he does not find David. God protects him.

The wilderness of Ziph is southeast of Hebron, a dry, rocky area at the edge of the wilderness of Judah.

Jonathan strengthens David VERSES 15–18

15 David saw that Saul had come out to take his life.
David was in the wilderness of Ziph, in the woods.
16 Then Jonathan, Saul's son, got up
and went to David in the woods.
He gave David new courage in God.
17 He said to him,
"Don't be afraid.
For the hand of my father Saul will not find you.
And you will be king over Israel,
and I will be second to you.
And my father Saul knows this too."
18 The two of them made a covenant before the LORD.
Then David stayed in the woods,
and Jonathan went home.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"In the woods": The Hebrew word is probably a place name: "Horesh." That is why many other Bibles write "at Horesh."

Jonathan comes to David secretly, even though it is dangerous for him. He does exactly what a true friend does: He gives David courage, not by his own strength, but "in God." He reminds David of God's promise.

Jonathan says openly: You will be king, not I. And I gladly want to be second. That is true greatness.

This is the last time the two friends see each other. Jonathan will die in battle together with Saul (Chapter 31). His wish to be second to David does not come true.

The Ziphites betray David VERSES 19–29

19 Then the Ziphites went up to Saul at Gibeah and said,
"Isn't David hiding among us in the strongholds in the woods,
on the hill of Hachilah, which is south of the desert?
20 So now, O king, come down,
just as you wish.
And our part will be to hand him over to the king."
21 Saul said,
"You are blessed by the LORD,
for you have had compassion on me.
22 Please go and make even more sure.
Find out and see the place where he stays,
and who has seen him there.
For I have been told that he is very cunning.
23 Look and find out all the hiding places where he hides.
Then come back to me with sure news,
and I will go with you.
And if he is in the land,
I will search him out among all the thousands of Judah."
24 They got up and went to Ziph ahead of Saul.
But David and his men were in the wilderness of Maon,
in the Arabah, south of the desert.
25 Saul and his men went to look for him.
When David was told,
he went down to the rock and stayed in the wilderness of Maon.
When Saul heard that, he chased David into the wilderness of Maon.
26 Saul went on this side of the mountain,
and David and his men on the other side of the mountain.
David hurried to get away from Saul out of fear.
For Saul and his men were surrounding David and his men to capture them.
27 But a messenger came to Saul and said,
"Hurry and come,
for the Philistines have attacked the land!"
28 So Saul turned back from chasing David
and went against the Philistines.
That is why that place was called Sela Hammahlekoth.
29 David went up from there
and lived in the strongholds of En Gedi.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Ziphites belonged to the tribe of Judah, like David himself. Still they betray him. According to its title, Psalm 54 is a prayer of David from the time when the Ziphites betrayed him.

Saul blesses the traitors in the name of the LORD. And again he says: "You have had compassion on me." He still sees himself as the victim.

At the mountain it gets very tight. Only a mountain separates Saul from David. He has almost surrounded him. And at exactly this moment a messenger comes: The Philistines are attacking! Saul has to turn back.

Was that an accident? Not for the storyteller. God rescues David at the last moment, even through Israel's enemies.

"Sela Hammahlekoth" probably means "rock of separation," because Saul and David separated here.

En Gedi is an oasis by the Dead Sea, with a spring and caves in the rocks. Wild mountain goats still live there today.

In the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles, verse 29 is already Chapter 24, verse 1.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 24

David spares Saul in the cave

In the cave VERSES 1–7

1 When Saul came back from chasing the Philistines,
he was told,
"Look, David is in the wilderness of En Gedi."
2 Then Saul took 3,000 chosen men from all Israel
and went to look for David and his men on the rocks of
the wild goats.
3 He came to the sheep pens by the road, where there was
a cave.
And Saul went in to relieve himself.
David and his men were sitting far back in the cave.
4 David's men said to him,
"Look, this is the day the LORD told you about:
'Look, I will give your enemy into your hand,
and you can do to him whatever seems good to you.'"
Then David got up
and secretly cut off the edge of Saul's robe.
5 Afterward David's heart troubled him,
because he had cut off the edge of Saul's robe.
6 He said to his men,
"The LORD forbid that I should do this to my lord,
the LORD's anointed,
to stretch out my hand against him.
For he is the LORD's anointed."
7 So David held his men back with these words
and did not let them attack Saul.
Saul got up, left the cave, and went on his way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles the numbering in this chapter is shifted by one verse. Verse 1 here is verse 2 there, and so on up to verse 23.

Saul is hunting David with 3,000 elite soldiers. And then he goes into the very cave where David is hiding. He is alone, defenseless, with his back to them.

David's men say: This is your chance! God has given him into your hand! A word from God like the one they quote does not appear anywhere earlier. Maybe they are simply explaining the situation this way.

David sneaks up to Saul. But he does not kill him. He only cuts off an edge of his robe. And even that makes him feel sorry afterward. His conscience troubles him.

Why? The edge of the robe was a sign of dignity and power. Let us remember: Saul once tore off the edge of Samuel's robe, and Samuel said that the kingdom would be torn from him in the same way (1 Samuel 15:27–28). David does not want to take the kingdom away from Saul himself. He wants to wait until God gives it to him.

"The LORD's anointed": Saul is still appointed by God. David respects that, even though Saul is persecuting him. He leaves the judgment to God.

David speaks to Saul VERSES 8–15

8 After that David also got up,
went out of the cave,
and called after Saul,
"My lord the king!"
When Saul looked behind him,
David bowed with his face to the ground and showed
him respect.
9 David said to Saul,
"Why do you listen to people who say,
'Look, David wants to harm you'?
10 Look, today your eyes have seen
how the LORD gave you into my hand today in the
cave.
Some urged me to kill you.
But I spared you.
I said,
'I will not stretch out my hand against my lord,
for he is the LORD's anointed.'
11 And look, my father,
see the edge of your robe in my hand.
I cut off the edge of your robe
and did not kill you.
From this you can know and see
that there is no evil or rebellion in my hand.
I have not sinned against you,
even though you are hunting me to take my life.
12 May the LORD judge between me and you,
and may the LORD avenge me on you.
But my hand will not be on you.
13 As the old saying goes,
'Out of the wicked comes wickedness.'
But my hand will not be on you.
14 Whom has the king of Israel come out against?
Whom are you chasing?
A dead dog? A flea?
15 So may the LORD be judge
and decide between me and you.
May he see and plead my cause
and rescue me from your hand."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David shows great courage. He goes out and shows himself to the man who wants to kill him. He bows before him and calls him "my father."

He holds out the edge of the robe to him: Look, I could have killed you. I did not do it. I am not your enemy.

David says it again and again: "My hand will not be on you." He leaves the judgment to God. That is the heart of this story: Do not take revenge yourself, but let God judge. Paul later writes that we should not take revenge ourselves, but overcome evil with good (Romans 12:19–21).

"A dead dog? A flea?": David makes himself small. Why does the mighty king chase after such an unimportant person? That is ridiculous.

Saul weeps VERSES 16–22

16 When David had finished saying these words to Saul,
Saul said,
"Is that your voice, my son David?"
And Saul cried out loud and wept.
17 He said to David,
"You are more righteous than I.
For you have done good to me,
but I have done evil to you.
18 Today you have shown how well you have treated me.
For the LORD had given me into your hand,
and you did not kill me.

19 For if a man finds his enemy,
will he let him go away unharmed?
So may the LORD reward you with good for what you
have done for me today.
20 And now, look, I know that you will surely be king
and that the kingdom of Israel will be made firm in
your hand.
21 So now swear to me by the LORD
that you will not wipe out my descendants after me
and that you will not destroy my name from my
father's family."
22 David swore it to Saul.
Saul went home.
But David and his men went up to the stronghold.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For a moment Saul's hard heart opens up. He weeps. He calls David "my son." And he tells the truth: "You are more righteous than I." Righteous means: living right before God.

For the first time Saul says it openly: I know that you will be king. He asks for the same thing as Jonathan: Spare my family. David swears it.

But David stays careful. He does not go home with Saul, but back to the stronghold. He knows: Saul's mood can change quickly again. And that is exactly what will happen (Chapter 26).

This story is a great lesson: You can answer evil with good. Love for your enemy can even touch the heart of a persecutor, at least for a moment.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 25

David, Nabal, and wise Abigail

Samuel dies VERSE 1

1 Samuel died.
All Israel gathered and mourned for him.
They buried him at his house in Ramah.
Then David got up and went down to the wilderness of
Paran.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The great prophet Samuel dies. He was the last judge and anointed the first two kings. All Israel mourns for him.

With Samuel's death David has lost an important supporter.

The wilderness of Paran is far to the south. The old Greek translation has "the wilderness of Maon" here. That fits better with the rest of the story.

Rich Nabal VERSES 2–13

2 There was a man in Maon whose property was in
Carmel.
The man was very rich.
He had 3,000 sheep and 1,000 goats.
And he was shearing his sheep in Carmel.
3 The name of the man was Nabal,
and the name of his wife was Abigail.
The woman was wise and had a beautiful face.
But the man was rude and evil in what he did.
He was from the family of Caleb.
4 In the wilderness David heard that Nabal was shearing
his sheep.
5 So David sent 10 young men.
David said to the young men,
"Go up to Carmel, go to Nabal,
and greet him in my name.
6 Say to him,
'Long life to you!
Peace to you! Peace to your house!
Peace to all that you have!
7 I have heard that you have shearers.
Your shepherds have been with us,
and we did not harm them.
Nothing of theirs was missing the whole time they
were in Carmel.
8 Ask your young men, and they will tell you.
So let these young men find favor in your eyes,
for we have come on a good day.
Please give your servants and your son David
whatever you have on hand.'"
9 When David's young men arrived,
they told Nabal all these words in David's name and
waited.
10 Nabal answered David's servants,
"Who is David?
Who is the son of Jesse?
These days there are many servants who run away
from their masters.
11 Shall I take my bread and my water
and my meat that I have killed for my shearers,
and give it to men when I don't know where they come
from?"
12 So David's young men turned around and went back.
They came and told him all these words.
13 David said to his men,
"Every man put on his sword!"
And every man put on his sword.
David also put on his sword.
About 400 men went up after David,
and 200 stayed with the baggage.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Maon and Carmel are towns in Judah, south of Hebron. This Carmel is not Mount Carmel in the north.

The name "Nabal" means "fool" in Hebrew. His wife Abigail is the exact opposite: wise and beautiful.

Shearing the sheep, that is, cutting off their wool, was a big celebration, like a harvest festival. At that time people usually were generous and shared.

David and his men had protected Nabal's shepherds in the wilderness, from robbers and wild animals. Now David politely asks for a share. At that time this was not rude, but normal.

Nabal insults David: "Who is David?" He calls him a runaway servant. And he keeps saying "my": my bread, my

water, my meat. He thinks only of himself.

David becomes very angry. He wants revenge. This is a very different David from the one in Chapter 24, who spared Saul.

A servant warns Abigail VERSES 14–22

14 But one of the young men told Abigail, Nabal's wife,
"Look, David sent messengers from the wilderness to greet our master.
And he insulted them.
15 But the men were very good to us.
Nothing happened to us,
and we did not miss anything as long as we went around with them,
when we were in the fields.
16 They were a wall around us, by night and by day,
the whole time we were with them taking care of the sheep.
17 So now think about it and see what you will do.
For disaster has been decided against our master and against his whole house.
And he is such a worthless fellow that no one can talk to him."
18 Then Abigail hurried.
She took 200 loaves of bread, 2 containers of wine,
5 sheep ready to cook,
about 10 gallons of roasted grain,
100 clusters of raisins, and 200 cakes of figs,
and loaded them on donkeys.
19 She said to her young men,
"Go on ahead of me.
Look, I am coming after you."
But she did not tell her husband Nabal.
20 As she was riding on her donkey
and coming down under cover of the mountain,
David and his men were coming down toward her,
and she met them.
21 Now David had said,
"It was for nothing that I guarded everything this fellow has in the wilderness,
so that nothing of all that belonged to him was missing.
He has paid me back evil for good.
22 May God do so to the enemies of David, and even more,
if by morning light I leave alive of all that belongs to him
even one who urinates on a wall."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The servant confirms: David and his men were like a protective wall. The servant knows that no one can talk to Nabal. That is why he goes to Abigail.

Abigail acts right away and wisely. She prepares a big gift. The Bible says "five seahs." A seah is about 2 gallons.

David swears revenge. "One who urinates on a wall" is a crude expression for "man" or "boy." David wants to kill all the men in Nabal's house.

"May God do so to the enemies of David": That is what the Hebrew text says. Usually this kind of oath says "May God do so to me." The old Greek translation has "May God do so to David." Maybe the scribes changed the sentence so that the curse would not fall on David, because David did not carry out his oath.

Abigail's wise speech VERSES 23–31

23 When Abigail saw David,
she quickly got off her donkey,
fell on her face before David,
and bowed to the ground.
24 She fell at his feet and said,
"On me, my lord, on me be the blame!
Please let your servant speak to you.
Hear the words of your servant.
25 Please don't let my lord pay attention to this worthless fellow, Nabal.
For as his name is, so is he.
Nabal is his name, and foolishness is with him.
But I, your servant, did not see my lord's young men whom you sent.
26 And now, my lord, as the LORD lives and as you live:
The LORD has kept you from bringing blood guilt on yourself
and from taking revenge with your own hand.
So now let your enemies and all who want to harm my lord be like Nabal.
27 And let this gift that your servant has brought to my lord
be given to the young men who follow my lord.
28 Please forgive the wrong of your servant.
For the LORD will certainly make my lord a lasting house,
because my lord fights the LORD's battles.
And no evil will be found in you all your life.
29 Even if people rise up to chase you and to take your life,
the life of my lord will be bound in the bundle of life with the LORD your God.
But the lives of your enemies he will sling away as from the pocket of a sling.
30 And this is what will happen:
When the LORD has done for my lord all the good he has promised you
and has made you prince over Israel,
31 then this will not be a grief to you or a burden on your heart,
that you shed blood without cause
or that my lord took revenge himself.
And when the LORD has been good to my lord,
then remember your servant."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Abigail's speech is one of the longest speeches by a woman in the Bible. And it is a masterpiece.

She takes the blame on herself, even though she is innocent. In this way she makes it easy for David to give in.

She reminds David of what God has promised him: You will be king. A king should not start out as someone who shed blood out of revenge. That would weigh on you later.

She is really saying: You did not kill Saul to help yourself. Don't do it with Nabal now either. Leave revenge to God.

"The bundle of life" is a beautiful picture: God keeps your life safe, the way you tie something precious into a bundle. To this day many Jewish gravestones have five Hebrew letters that stand for the sentence: "May his soul be bound in the bundle of life."

The picture of the sling reminds us of David and Goliath.

Abigail is a prophet without being called one. She tells David's future.

David thanks God for Abigail VERSES 32–35

32 David said to Abigail,
"Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel,
who sent you to meet me today!
33 Blessed is your good sense,
and blessed are you,
who have kept me today from bringing blood guilt on myself
and from taking revenge with my own hand.
34 For truly, as the LORD, the God of Israel, lives,
who has kept me from harming you:
If you had not hurried and come to meet me,
then by morning light not even one who urinates on a wall
would have been left to Nabal."
35 So David accepted from her hand what she had brought him.
Then he said to her,
"Go up to your house in peace.
Look, I have listened to your voice and granted your request."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David listens to a woman who disagrees with him. That is a sign of greatness. Saul never listened to advice. David can let himself be corrected.

He realizes: God sent Abigail. Through her God kept me from a great sin.

This is an important lesson: Sometimes God sends us people who stop us when we want to do something wrong in our anger.

Nabal's death VERSES 36–38

36 Abigail came to Nabal.
He was holding a feast in his house, like the feast of a king.
Nabal's heart was merry, for he was very drunk.
So she told him nothing until morning light.
37 In the morning, when the wine had gone out of Nabal, his wife told him these things.
Then his heart died within him, and he became like a stone.
38 About 10 days later the LORD struck Nabal, so that he died.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nabal celebrates "like the feast of a king." He acts as if he were the king, while the true future king lives in the wilderness.

When he is sober in the morning and hears how close he came to death, he is so shocked that "his heart died within him." Maybe it was a stroke or a heart attack.

After 10 days he dies. The Bible says: The LORD struck him. David did not have to take revenge. God judged him himself.

David marries Abigail VERSES 39–44

39 When David heard that Nabal was dead, he said,
"Blessed be the LORD,
who has pleaded my cause against the insult from Nabal
and has kept his servant from evil.
The LORD has turned Nabal's evil back on his own head."
Then David sent messengers to speak with Abigail about taking her as his wife.
40 When David's servants came to Abigail at Carmel, they spoke to her and said,
"David has sent us to you
to take you to him as his wife."
41 She got up, bowed with her face to the ground, and said,
"Look, your servant is ready to be a servant who washes the feet of my lord's servants."
42 Abigail quickly got up
and rode on a donkey, with her five maids following her.
She went after David's messengers
and became his wife.
43 David had also taken Ahinoam of Jezreel.
And they both became his wives.
44 But Saul had given his daughter Michal, David's wife, to Palti the son of Laish, who was from Gallim.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David is thankful that God kept him from taking revenge himself.

David marries Abigail. At that time it was often a matter of life and death for a widow without a son to have a husband again. Abigail says yes. She joins herself to the man she knows will be king.

Now David has several wives: Ahinoam and Abigail. Saul has given David's first wife Michal to another man, probably to hurt David and to take away his claim to the royal family.

At that time it was common for kings to have several wives. But the law contains a warning: A king should not have many wives, so that his heart does not turn away (Deuteronomy 17:17). David's many marriages will later lead to great misery in his family.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 26

David spares Saul a second time

Spear and water jar VERSES 1–12

1 The Ziphites came to Saul at Gibeah and said,
"Isn't David hiding on the hill of Hachilah, facing the desert?"
2 So Saul got up and went down to the wilderness of Ziph,

with 3,000 chosen men of Israel,
to look for David in the wilderness of Ziph.
3 Saul camped on the hill of Hachilah, facing the desert,
by the road.
But David stayed in the wilderness.
He saw that Saul came after him into the wilderness.
4 So David sent out spies
and found out that Saul had really come.
5 Then David got up and came to the place where Saul had
camped.
David saw the place where Saul lay,
with Abner the son of Ner, the commander of his
army.
Saul lay in the middle of the camp with the wagons,
and the people were camped all around him.
6 Then David said to Ahimelech the Hittite
and to Abishai the son of Zeruiah, the brother of Joab,
"Who will go down with me to Saul in the camp?"
Abishai said, "I will go down with you."
7 So David and Abishai came to the people by night.
And there was Saul, lying asleep in the middle of the
camp with the wagons,
with his spear stuck in the ground at his head.
And Abner and the people were lying all around him.
8 Then Abishai said to David,
"God has given your enemy into your hand today.
Now please let me pin him to the ground with the
spear, with one single stroke.
I won't need a second."
9 David said to Abishai,
"Don't kill him.
For who can stretch out his hand against the LORD's
anointed
and be guiltless?"
10 David said,
"As the LORD lives:
The LORD will strike him.
Or his day will come and he will die.
Or he will go down into battle and die there.
11 The LORD forbid
that I should stretch out my hand against the LORD's
anointed.
But now please take the spear that is at his head
and the jar of water, and let's go."
12 So David took the spear and the jar of water from Saul's
head,
and they went away.
No one saw it, no one knew it, and no one woke up.
For they were all asleep,
because a deep sleep from the LORD had fallen on
them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Once again the Ziphites betray David (as in 1 Samuel 23:19). Once again Saul hunts him with 3,000 men, even though in Chapter 24 he had promised to stop.

This time David himself goes into the enemy's camp, in the middle of the night. Abishai is David's nephew. His mother Zeruiah was David's sister (1 Chronicles 2:16). Abishai and his brother Joab will later be David's most important army commanders.

Abishai says the same thing as David's men in the cave: God has given him to you! Let me kill him. And David answers again: No. God will act himself, when and how he wants.

The spear was Saul's sign of power. With this spear Saul had tried several times to kill David. Now David takes it away without using it.

"A deep sleep from the LORD": God himself protects David on this dangerous walk.

David calls to Abner VERSES 13–16

13 Then David went over to the other side
and stood far away on the top of the mountain,
so that there was a great distance between them.
14 David called to the people and to Abner the son of Ner,
"Won't you answer, Abner?"
Then Abner answered,
"Who are you, calling to the king?"
15 David said to Abner,
"Aren't you a man?
And who is like you in Israel?
Why then have you not guarded your lord the king?
For one of the people came in to kill your lord the king.
16 What you have done is not good.
As the LORD lives,
you deserve to die,
because you have not guarded your lord, the LORD's
anointed.
And now see where the king's spear is,
and the jar of water that was at his head."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David mocks Abner, the great army commander: You are the king's bodyguard, and you were asleep! If I had been a murderer, the king would be dead now.

This is proof: David could have killed Saul. He did not do it.

David's last request to Saul VERSES 17–25

17 Saul recognized David's voice and said,
"Is this your voice, my son David?"
David said,
"It is my voice, my lord the king."
18 He said,
"Why is my lord chasing his servant?
For what have I done?
What evil is in my hand?
19 So now please let my lord the king hear the words of his
servant:
If it is the LORD who has stirred you up against me,
then may he accept an offering.
But if it is people,
then they are cursed before the LORD.
For they have driven me out today,
so that I no longer have a share in the LORD's
inheritance.
They say, 'Go, serve other gods!'
20 So now don't let my blood fall to the ground far away
from the presence of the LORD.
For the king of Israel has come out to look for a flea,
as someone hunts a partridge in the mountains."
21 Then Saul said,
"I have sinned.
Come back, my son David.
For I will not harm you anymore,
because my life was precious in your eyes today.

Look, I have played the fool and have been very
wrong."
22 David answered,
"Here is the spear, O king!
Let one of the young men come over and get it.
23 The LORD will reward everyone for his righteousness
and his faithfulness.
For the LORD gave you into my hand today,
but I would not stretch out my hand against the
LORD's anointed.
24 And look:
As your life was valued in my eyes today,
so may my life be valued in the eyes of the LORD.
And may he rescue me from all trouble."
25 Then Saul said to David,
"You are blessed, my son David.
You will do great things and will surely prevail."

Then David went his way,
and Saul went back to his place.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David says: If God has stirred you up against me, then let us bring an offering and make peace with God. But if people are stirring you up, then they are cursed.

David suffers because he is being driven out of Israel. At that time people thought: Whoever lives in a foreign land is far from God's presence and has to serve foreign gods there. David does not want to die far from God.

"A partridge in the mountains": A partridge is a bird that would rather run than fly. People hunt it until it is worn out. That is how David feels.

Saul says again: "I have sinned" and "I have played the fool." But David no longer believes him. He gives back the spear, but he does not go with Saul.

This is the last time Saul and David meet. Saul's last words to David are a blessing: "You will do great things and will surely prevail."

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 27

David among the Philistines

David flees to Gath VERSES 1–4

1 David said in his heart,
"One day I will surely die by the hand of Saul.
There is nothing better for me than to escape into the
land of the Philistines.
Then Saul will give up looking for me anywhere in the
territory of Israel.
So I will escape from his hand."
2 So David got up and went over,
he and the 600 men who were with him,
to Achish the son of Maoch, the king of Gath.
3 David lived with Achish at Gath,
he and his men, each with his family,
and David with his two wives,
Ahinoam of Jezreel and Abigail of Carmel, Nabal's
widow.
4 Saul was told that David had fled to Gath.
So he stopped looking for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David loses heart. He has spared Saul twice, but Saul keeps hunting him. He thinks: Sooner or later he will catch me.

It is striking: This time David does not ask God before he acts. He "said in his heart," which means he decides alone. And he goes to Israel's enemies, of all people.

The first time, David came to Gath alone and had to pretend to be insane (Chapter 21). Now he comes with 600 warriors. For Achish he is a valuable ally against Saul.

David's plan works: Saul stops hunting him.

The town of Ziklag VERSES 5–7

5 David said to Achish,
"If I have found favor in your eyes,
let them give me a place in one of the towns in the
country,
so that I can live there.
For why should your servant live with you in the royal
city?"
6 So that day Achish gave him Ziklag.
That is why Ziklag belongs to the kings of Judah to this
day.
7 The time that David lived in the land of the Philistines
was a year and four months.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David does not want to live in the capital, under the eyes of the king. In a town of his own he can act more freely.

Ziklag was in the south, on the border between the land of the Philistines and Judah.

"To this day": When the book was written, Ziklag belonged to the kingdom of Judah. The town was a gift from the Philistines to David.

David's double game VERSES 8–12

8 David and his men went up
and raided the Geshurites, the Girzites, and the
Amalekites.
For these peoples had lived in the land from long ago,
toward Shur and as far as the land of Egypt.
9 David struck the land
and left no man or woman alive.
He took the sheep, the cattle, the donkeys, the camels,
and the clothing.
Then he came back to Achish.
10 Achish asked,
"Whom did you raid today?"
David said,
"The south of Judah,
the south of the Jerahmeelites,
and the south of the Kenites."
11 David left neither man nor woman alive to bring to
Gath.
For he said,

"Otherwise they will tell about us and say,
'This is what David did.
And this has been his way the whole time
he has lived in the land of the Philistines.'"
12 Achish believed David and said,
"He has made his people Israel hate him completely.
So he will be my servant forever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This passage shows a dark side of David. He raids peoples in the south who were enemies of Israel, like the Amalekites. And he leaves no one alive, not even women.

Then he lies to Achish: He says he raided places in Judah. And so that no one can tell the truth, he kills all the witnesses.

The Bible tells this without praise. It does not hide that even David, the man after God's own heart, could act cruelly and dishonestly. David is a great hero of faith, but not a person without faults.

We read this text as an honest report about a violent time, not as an example. No one may appeal to it to justify violence or lies.

Achish falls for the lie. He thinks: Now Israel hates him, he can never go back. He belongs to me. But in his heart David stays with his people.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 28

Saul and the medium at Endor

David in a difficult position VERSES 1–2

1 In those days the Philistines gathered their armies for war
to fight against Israel.
Achish said to David,
"You must know for sure that you will go out with me in the army,
you and your men."
2 David said to Achish,
"Then you will know what your servant can do."
Achish said to David,
"Then I will make you my bodyguard forever."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now David's double game comes back on him. Achish demands that David fight with the Philistines against Israel, against his own people.

David's answer is meant to have two meanings: "You will know what your servant can do." Achish understands: He will fight well for me. But David leaves open on which side.

Chapter 29 tells what happens next.

God no longer answers Saul VERSES 3–7

3 Samuel had died,
and all Israel had mourned for him and buried him in Ramah, his own town.
And Saul had driven out of the land the people who talked with spirits of the dead and the fortune-tellers.
4 The Philistines gathered, came, and camped at Shunem.
And Saul gathered all Israel, and they camped on Gilboa.
5 When Saul saw the army of the Philistines, he was afraid,
and his heart trembled greatly.
6 Saul asked the LORD.
But the LORD did not answer him,
not by dreams, not by Urim, and not by prophets.
7 Then Saul said to his servants,
"Find me a woman who has a familiar spirit.
Then I will go to her and ask her."
His servants said to him,
"Look, there is a woman at Endor who has a familiar spirit."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The storyteller reminds us: Samuel is dead. And Saul himself had driven out of the land the people who called up the dead, as God's law required (Leviticus 19:31; Deuteronomy 18:10–12).

The Philistines camp at Shunem, in the fertile Jezreel Valley in the north. Saul camps across from them on the mountains of Gilboa.

Saul becomes afraid, very afraid. He asks God, but God is silent. No dreams, no answer through the holy lots (Urim), no prophets. Saul had had the priests killed (Chapter 22) and had not listened to the prophets.

In his despair Saul does exactly what he himself had forbidden. He looks for a woman who calls up the dead. This shows how far he has fallen.

"A woman who has a familiar spirit" means: a woman who claims that she can talk with the dead. Such a woman is called a medium.

Saul goes to Endor in disguise VERSES 8–14

8 Saul disguised himself and put on other clothes.
He went, he and two men with him,
and they came to the woman by night.
He said,
"Please ask the spirit for me
and bring up for me the one I name to you."
9 The woman said to him,
"Look, you know what Saul has done,
how he has cut off from the land the people who talk with spirits and the fortune-tellers.
Why are you setting a trap for my life, to get me killed?"
10 Saul swore to her by the LORD and said,
"As the LORD lives,
no punishment will come to you for this."
11 Then the woman said,
"Whom shall I bring up for you?"
He said,
"Bring up Samuel for me."
12 When the woman saw Samuel, she screamed loudly.
And the woman said to Saul,

"Why have you deceived me?
You are Saul!"
13 The king said to her,
"Don't be afraid!
What do you see?"
The woman said to Saul,
"I see a god coming up out of the earth."
14 He said to her,
"What does he look like?"
She said,
"An old man is coming up.
He is wrapped in a robe."
Then Saul knew that it was Samuel.
He bowed with his face to the ground and showed him respect.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Endor was north of the Philistine camp. In the night Saul has to go close past the enemy camp. He disguises himself so that no one will recognize him.

It is bitter: Saul swears by the LORD in order to do something the LORD has forbidden.

The woman screams when Samuel appears. Maybe she herself did not expect that someone would really come. And suddenly she recognizes Saul.

"A god" here means: a ghostly being, more than human.

The robe was Samuel's mark. Let us remember: Saul once tore Samuel's robe (1 Samuel 15:27).

Was it really Samuel? Jews and Christians have thought about this a lot. Many say: Yes, in this one case God himself sent Samuel to tell Saul his judgment. That is why the woman is so frightened. Others say: It was a deception. The Bible tells it as if it was Samuel. The book of Sirach says that Samuel still prophesied even after his death (Sirach 46:20).

What is clear: The Bible forbids calling up the dead (Deuteronomy 18:10–12). This story is not a permission, but shows where despair without God leads. But the Bible also gives no one the right to accuse or hunt down people as "witches."

Samuel's last message VERSES 15–19

15 Samuel said to Saul,
"Why have you disturbed me by bringing me up?"
Saul answered,
"I am in great distress.
For the Philistines are making war against me,
and God has left me
and no longer answers me, either by prophets or by dreams.
That is why I have called you,
so that you can tell me what I should do."
16 Samuel said,
"Why then do you ask me,
since the LORD has left you and has become your enemy?
17 The LORD has done to you just as he said through me.
The LORD has torn the kingdom out of your hand
and given it to your neighbor, David.
18 Because you did not obey the voice of the LORD
and did not carry out his fierce anger against Amalek,
the LORD has done this to you today.
19 And the LORD will also give Israel with you into the hand of the Philistines.
Tomorrow you and your sons will be with me.
The LORD will also give the army of Israel into the hand of the Philistines."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Saul hopes for advice. But Samuel says nothing new. He only repeats what he had already said while he was alive (Chapter 15). Whoever does not listen to God while he is alive will not find a different answer among the dead either.

For the first time it is said clearly who the "neighbor" is to whom God gives the kingdom: David.

"Tomorrow you and your sons will be with me" means: Tomorrow you will be dead, you and your sons. At that time people imagined that all the dead are in one place, the place of the dead.

It is a shattering message. On the evening before the battle Saul learns that he will die.

The woman takes care of Saul VERSES 20–25

20 Then Saul immediately fell full length on the ground.
He was terrified because of Samuel's words.
And he had no strength left,
because he had not eaten any bread all day and all night.
21 The woman came to Saul and saw that he was very frightened.
She said to him,
"Look, your servant has listened to your voice.
I have risked my life
and have listened to the words you spoke to me.
22 So now please listen to the voice of your servant too.
Let me set a piece of bread in front of you.
Eat, so that you have strength when you go on your way."
23 But he refused and said,
"I will not eat."
But his servants and the woman too urged him.
So he listened to their voice.
He got up from the ground and sat on the bed.
24 The woman had a fattened calf in the house.
She hurried and killed it.
She took flour, kneaded it, and baked bread without yeast from it.
25 She brought it to Saul and his servants, and they ate.
Then they got up and went away that same night.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Saul collapses. The great king lies on the ground, weak from hunger and fear.

The woman, whom he really should have punished, feels sorry for him. She kills her only fattened calf, a great sacrifice for a poor woman. She gives him one last meal.

This is a surprisingly human moment. Of all people, this woman shows Saul kindness on his last night.

Then they go out into the night. The night fits Saul's situation: He is going into the darkness, toward his death.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 29

The Philistines send David back

The lords do not trust David VERSES 1–5

1 The Philistines gathered all their armies at Aphek.
And the Israelites camped by the spring that is in Jezreel.
2 The lords of the Philistines marched past by hundreds and by thousands.
And David and his men marched past at the back with Achish.
3 Then the commanders of the Philistines said,
"What are these Hebrews doing here?"
Achish said to the commanders of the Philistines,
"Isn't this David, the servant of Saul the king of Israel?
He has been with me for days, even years now.
I have found no fault in him
from the day he came over to me until today."
4 But the commanders of the Philistines were angry with him.
The commanders of the Philistines said to him,
"Send the man back.
Let him go back to the place you gave him.
Don't let him go down with us into battle,
so that he does not turn against us in the battle.
For how could this fellow win back the favor of his lord any better
than with the heads of these men?
5 Isn't this David, about whom they sang in their dances:
'Saul has killed his thousands,
and David his ten thousands'?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the storyteller jumps back a little: The Philistines first gather at Aphek, before they march north to Shunem (1 Samuel 28:4).

The other lords of the Philistines are more suspicious than Achish. They say: In battle David could change sides and attack us from behind. In this way he could make peace with Saul again.

Once again the famous song is quoted. David's fame follows him even among his enemies.

Achish sends David away VERSES 6–11

6 Then Achish called David and said to him,
"As the LORD lives:
You have been honest,
and I am pleased with your going out and coming in with me in the army.
For I have found no evil in you
from the day you came to me until today.
But the lords do not like you.
7 So now turn back and go in peace,
so that you do nothing that displeases the lords of the Philistines."
8 David said to Achish,
"But what have I done?
What have you found in your servant from the time I came to you until today,
that I may not go and fight against the enemies of my lord the king?"
9 Achish answered David,
"I know that you are good in my eyes, like an angel of God.
But the commanders of the Philistines have said,
'He shall not go up with us into battle.'
10 So get up early in the morning, with the servants of your lord who came with you.
As soon as you are up early in the morning and it is light, leave."
11 So David got up early, he and his men,
to leave in the morning and go back to the land of the Philistines.
And the Philistines went up to Jezreel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Achish, a Philistine, swears by the LORD, the God of Israel. Maybe he wants to convince David especially well in this way.

David acts as if he were disappointed. "Against the enemies of my lord the king" again has two meanings: Does he mean Achish as his lord, or Saul? We do not find out what David really would have done.

In this way God has freed David from an impossible situation. He did not have to fight against his own people. And he has no part in it when Saul and Jonathan die.

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 30

David gets everything back

Ziklag is burned VERSES 1–6

1 When David and his men came to Ziklag on the third day,
the Amalekites had made a raid on the South and on Ziklag.
They had struck Ziklag and burned it with fire.
2 And they had taken the women captive and everyone who was in it, young and old.
They had not killed anyone,
but had carried them off and gone their way.
3 When David and his men came to the town,
it was burned with fire.
And their wives, their sons, and their daughters had been taken captive.
4 Then David and the people who were with him cried out loud and wept
until they had no more strength to weep.

5 David's two wives had also been taken captive,
Ahinoam of Jezreel and Abigail, the widow of Nabal of Carmel.
6 David was in great distress.
For the people talked about stoning him,
because all the people were bitter, each one because of his sons and daughters.
But David strengthened himself in the LORD his God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David was away for three days. During this time the Amalekites raided his town. This is bitter irony: David himself had raided the Amalekites (1 Samuel 27:8). Now they take revenge.

But unlike David, the Amalekites did not kill anyone. They took the people away as slaves.

David's men weep until they cannot weep anymore. Then their sorrow turns into rage. They want to stone David. This is the lowest point in David's life so far.

And exactly here comes the important sentence: "But David strengthened himself in the LORD his God." When everyone is against him and everything seems lost, David turns to God. He does not find his strength in himself, but in God.

David asks God and chases the raiders VERSES 7–10

7 David said to Abiathar the priest, the son of Ahimelech,
"Please bring the ephod here to me."
And Abiathar brought the ephod to David.
8 David asked the LORD,
"If I chase after this band of raiders, will I catch up with them?"
He answered him,
"Chase them.
For you will surely catch up with them
and will surely rescue everything."
9 So David went, he and the 600 men who were with him.
They came to the brook Besor,
where those who were left behind stayed.
10 But David kept chasing, he and 400 men.
For 200 men stayed behind,
because they were too worn out to cross the brook Besor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Chapter 27 David had not asked before he went to the Philistines. Now he asks God again. He is back on the right path.

God does not only answer with yes, but with a promise: You will get everything back.

The men are worn out. They had been on the road for three days from Aphek to Ziklag, and now they go on chasing right away. Of them, 200 cannot go any farther.

The Egyptian VERSES 11–15

11 They found an Egyptian in the field
and brought him to David.
They gave him bread, and he ate.
And they gave him water to drink.
12 They gave him a piece of a fig cake and two clusters of raisins.
When he had eaten, his strength came back.
For he had not eaten any bread or drunk any water for three days and three nights.
13 David asked him,
"To whom do you belong? And where are you from?"
He said,
"I am a young man from Egypt, the servant of an Amalekite.
My master left me behind because I got sick three days ago.
14 We made a raid on the South of the Cherethites,
on the land that belongs to Judah,
and on the South of Caleb.
And we burned Ziklag with fire."
15 David said to him,
"Will you take me down to this band of raiders?"
He said,
"Swear to me by God that you will not kill me
and not hand me over to my master.
Then I will take you down to this band of raiders."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A sick slave is simply left behind by his master in the wilderness to die. David's men find him and give him food and drink, even though they are in a hurry.

This kindness is rewarded: The Egyptian leads them to the raiders. In this way the story shows: Whoever helps someone who is weak is often helped himself.

The "Cherethites" were a group related to the Philistines who lived in the south. Later Cherethites were part of David's bodyguard (2 Samuel 8:18).

The victory over the Amalekites VERSES 16–20

16 When he had brought him down,
they were spread out over the whole area.
They were eating, drinking, and dancing
because of all the great plunder they had taken from the land of the Philistines and from the land of Judah.
17 David struck them down from twilight until the evening of the next day.
Not one of them escaped,
except 400 young men who got on camels and fled.
18 David rescued everything that the Amalekites had taken.
And David also rescued his two wives.
19 Nothing of theirs was missing, young or old,
sons or daughters, or any of the plunder,
nothing of all that had been taken from them.
David brought everything back.
20 David also took all the flocks and herds.
They drove them in front of the other livestock and said,
"This is David's plunder."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Amalekites feel safe and celebrate. That is how they are taken by surprise.

God's promise comes true exactly: Nothing was missing. All the women and children come back. David even gets more than he had lost.

Equal rights for all VERSES 21–25

21 David came to the 200 men
who had been too worn out to follow David
and who had been left at the brook Besor.

They went out to meet David and the people with him.
When David came near the people, he greeted them.
22 Then all the wicked and worthless men among those
who had gone with David said,
"Because they did not go with us,
we will not give them any of the plunder we have
rescued.
Each man may only take his wife and his children
and leave with them."
23 Then David said,
"Don't do that, my brothers,
with what the LORD has given us.
He has kept us safe
and given into our hand the band of raiders that came
against us.
24 Who will listen to you in this matter?
For the share of the one who goes down into the battle
shall be the same as the share of the one who stays with
the baggage.
They shall share alike."
25 And so it was from that day on:
He made it a law and a rule for Israel to this day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Some men want to send away the worn-out men with nothing. But David says: No. The victory comes from God, not from us. So the plunder belongs to everyone.

David makes it a law: Whoever fights and whoever stays behind to guard the baggage gets the same amount. The weak belong too.

This is a principle of justice and of standing together: Everyone contributes what he can, and everyone shares. No one is to be treated unfairly because he is not as strong.

Gifts to the elders of Judah VERSES 26–31

26 When David came to Ziklag,
he sent some of the plunder to the elders of Judah, his
friends, and said,
"Here is a gift for you from the plunder of the LORD's
enemies."
27 He sent it to those in Bethel,
to those in Ramoth of the South,
to those in Jattir,
28 to those in Aroer,
to those in Siphmoth,
to those in Eshtemoa,
29 to those in Racal,
to those in the towns of the Jerahmeelites,
to those in the towns of the Kenites,
30 to those in Hormah,
to those in Borashan,
to those in Athach,
31 to those in Hebron,
and to all the places where David himself and his men
used to stay.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

David shares his plunder with the towns in Judah that had helped him while he was on the run. That is thankfulness. And it is also wise: In this way he wins the hearts of the elders of Judah.

"Bethel" here is probably a town in the south, not the well-known Bethel north of Jerusalem. Some manuscripts of the old Greek translation have "Beth Zur" here.

The last town in the list is Hebron. There David will soon be anointed king over Judah (2 Samuel 2:4).

1 SAMUEL

CHAPTER 31

The death of Saul and Jonathan

The battle on Gilboa VERSES 1–6

1 The Philistines fought against Israel.
The men of Israel ran away from the Philistines.
Many of them were killed on Mount Gilboa.
2 The Philistines caught up with Saul and his sons.
They killed Saul's sons Jonathan, Abinadab, and
Malchishua.
3 The fighting around Saul was very hard.
The archers found him.
Saul was in great distress because of the archers.
4 Saul said to the young man who carried his weapons,
"Pull out your sword and stab me with it.
Otherwise these uncircumcised men will come.
They will stab me and treat me cruelly!"
Uncircumcised means: They do not belong to God's
people.
But the young man did not want to do it.
He was terribly afraid.
So Saul took his own sword and fell on it.
5 The young man saw that Saul was dead.
Then he also fell on his sword and died with him.
6 So Saul died on that same day.
His three sons died with him,
and the young man who carried his weapons,
and all his men.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

What Samuel had announced in Endor happens: Israel is defeated, and Saul dies with his sons.

Jonathan dies too, David's faithful friend. He was a good man, but he stays at his father's side to the end. He does not die for any guilt of his own.

Saul is in great distress because of the archers. He is afraid that the Philistines will catch him alive, torture him, and mock him, as they had done with Samson (Judges 16). So he asks his armor bearer to kill him. When he refuses, Saul takes his own life.

The Bible tells this without comment, honestly and sadly. It does not condemn Saul here, and it does not praise what he did either. It is the end of a man who had lost God and knew only fear.

In 2 Samuel 1 an Amalekite tells a different version of Saul's death. We will read there what is true about it.

Important note: If you yourself are in great distress or are thinking about taking your own life, you are not alone.

Please talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

The Philistines dishonor Saul's body VERSES 7–10

7 Other men of Israel lived on the other side of the valley
and on the other side of the Jordan.
They saw that the army of Israel had run away.
They saw that Saul and his sons were dead.
So they left their cities and ran away.
Then the Philistines came and lived in those cities.
8 The next day the Philistines came to take everything
from the dead bodies.
They found Saul and his three sons lying dead on
Mount Gilboa.
9 They cut off Saul's head
and took off his armor.
They sent messengers all over the land of the
Philistines.
The messengers told the news in the temples of their
idols and to the people.
10 They put Saul's armor in the temple of the Ashtaroth.
And they hung his body on the wall of Beth Shan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The defeat is complete. The Philistines conquer many towns in the north of Israel. The land is now weaker than at the beginning of Saul's rule.

The Philistines cut off Saul's head, just as David had once cut off Goliath's head.

They celebrate the victory in the temples of their gods. For them it is a victory of their gods over the God of Israel.

Beth Shan was a town in the Jordan Valley. To hang the body on the wall was a great shame. The dead were not even supposed to get a grave.

The faithfulness of the men of Jabesh VERSES 11–13

11 The people of Jabesh Gilead heard
what the Philistines had done to Saul.
12 So all their brave men set out.
They walked all night long.
They took the body of Saul and the bodies of his sons
down from the wall of Beth Shan.
They brought them to Jabesh and burned them there.
13 Then they took their bones
and buried them under the tamarisk tree in Jabesh.
And they fasted for seven days.
That means: They did not eat, to show their sadness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book ends with a sign of faithfulness. The men of Jabesh remember: Saul had rescued them when Nahash wanted to gouge out their eyes. That was Saul's first great deed as king (Chapter 11).

Now, many years later, they risk their lives. They march all night, take the dead down from the wall, and give them an honorable burial.

Usually people in Israel did not burn the dead. Maybe they did it because the bodies had already been dishonored. But they buried the bones.

Fasting for seven days was a sign of great mourning.

So the story of Saul does not end only with shame, but also with thankfulness. The good he once did was not forgotten.

Looking back: What have we read in the book of 1 Samuel?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book of 1 Samuel tells how Israel goes from the time of the judges to the time of the kings. Three people are at the center:

1. Samuel (Chapters 1–7): He is the child Hannah prayed for. As a boy he hears God's voice: "Speak, LORD, for your servant is listening." He becomes a prophet and the last judge. He leads the people to turn back to God. Under him God helps Israel: "Until now the LORD has helped us."

2. Saul (Chapters 8–15): The people want a king "like all the nations." God gives them Saul, tall and handsome. He starts out humble and brave. But he has no patience to wait for God, and he obeys only halfway. Samuel tells him: "To obey is better than sacrifice." God rejects Saul as king.

3. David (Chapters 16–31): God chooses Jesse's youngest son, a shepherd: "Man looks at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart." David defeats Goliath in the name of the LORD. Jonathan becomes his faithful friend. Saul becomes jealous and hunts David for years. Twice David could kill Saul, but he does not do it. He waits until God himself acts.

The book also honestly shows the dark sides: Eli's wicked sons, Saul's hatred and his violence against the priests at Nob, but also David's lies and his cruel raids. The Bible does not make anything look better than it was. It is not a book about heroes, but an honest book about people and God.

Important messages of the book:

God hears prayers, like the prayer of Hannah.

God looks at the heart, not at the outside.

God wants obedience and trust, not only devout rituals.

True friendship is faithful and free of envy, as with Jonathan.

Revenge belongs to God. David spares his enemy and leaves the judgment to God.

In the end Saul is dead. The way is open for David. The book of 2 Samuel tells how David becomes king.

Help is available

You are not alone.

If you are not doing well, it is okay to ask for help.

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (USA)
Call or text 988
free, 24 hours a day

Childhelp National Child Abuse Hotline (USA)
1-800-422-4453
free, 24 hours a day

National Domestic Violence Hotline (USA)
1-800-799-7233
free, 24 hours a day

RAINN Sexual Assault Hotline (USA)
1-800-656-4673
free, 24 hours a day

Samaritans (UK and Ireland)
116 123
free, 24 hours a day

Childline (UK, for children and young people)
0800 1111
free

Other countries
findahelpline.com
free help lines worldwide

Emergency
911 (USA) · 999 (UK) · 112 (Europe)
police, ambulance, fire